

READING EDITION

Journey to the West: Volume One

Chapter 1: The Stone Egg of Flower-Fruit Mountain and the Magical Monkey King

A poem says:

Before the chaos split, the heavens and the earth
were one, A vast and formless blur that no eye ever
looked upon. But once Pangu had shattered through
that primal murky shell, The pure and the impure
were parted, and creation's order fell. All living
things look up in awe to that supreme benevolence,
Which brought forth every thing that is, and made
each thing turn toward the good. Would you know
the work of making, the turning of the great world's
age? Then read this tale of *Journey to the West*, the
chronicle that frees from woe.

It is said that the reckoning of heaven and earth runs in great cycles, each cycle lasting one hundred twenty-nine thousand six hundred years. Each such cycle is divided into twelve epochs, named for the twelve earthly branches — Zi, Chou, Yin, Mao, Chen, Si, Wu, Wei, Shen, You, Xu, and Hai — and each epoch endures for ten thousand eight hundred years.

Consider it by the measure of a single day. At the hour of Zi the vital force of yang first stirs; at Chou the cocks begin to crow. At Yin the light has not yet broken through; at Mao the sun comes up. At Chen breakfast is past; at Si all is set in order. At Wu the sun stands at heaven's center; at Wei it begins to slip westward. At Shen comes the late afternoon, and the sun sets at You. At Xu falls the yellow dusk, and at Hai the world lies down to rest.

By analogy with the great reckoning: when the epoch of Xu draws to its close, heaven and earth grow dark and dim, and all things wither. Five thousand four hundred years onward, at the opening of the epoch of Hai, there is utter blackness, and between the two realms neither man nor thing remains. This is what is called chaos — the undivided murk. After another five thousand four hundred years, as the epoch of Hai nears its end, the constant turns once more toward the source, and as the epoch of Zi approaches, light gradually begins to return. Master Shao Kangjie said: "At the winter solstice, the midpoint of Zi, the heart of heaven does not shift. Where the single yang first quickens — that is the moment before the myriad things are born." At this point, heaven first has its root.

After another five thousand four hundred years, in the very midst of the epoch of Zi, the light and the pure rise upward, and there come to be sun, moon, stars, and constellations. Sun, moon, stars, and constellations are called the Four Images. Hence it is said: heaven opened in Zi. After another five thousand four hundred years pass, as the epoch of Zi draws toward its close and the epoch of Chou approaches, things gradually grow firm and solid. The *Book of Changes* says: "Great is the creative principle of Qian! Supreme is the receptive principle of Kun! The myriad things draw their life from it, obediently following heaven." At this point, the earth first congeals.

After another five thousand four hundred years, in the very midst of the epoch of Chou, the heavy and impure settle downward, and there come to be water, fire, mountains, stone, and soil. Water, fire, mountains, stone, and soil are called the Five Forms. Hence it is said: earth was opened in Chou. After another five thousand four hundred years, as the epoch of Chou ends and the epoch of Yin begins, the myriad things spring into being. The almanac says: "The breath of heaven descends; the breath of earth ascends. Heaven and earth join in union, and all the host of things is born." At this point heaven is clear and earth is fresh, and yin and yang join together. After another five thousand four hundred years, in the very midst of the epoch of Yin, there are born human beings, beasts, and birds — and so the three powers, heaven, earth, and humankind, take their fixed places. Hence it is said: humankind was born in Yin.

After Pangu opened the world, the Three Sovereigns ruled the age, and the Five Emperors set in order the human bonds. The world was then divided into four great continents: the Eastern Continent of Spiritual Excellence, the Western Continent of Cattle-Offering, the Southern Continent of Jambu, and the Northern Continent of Kuru. This book concerns the Eastern Continent of Spiritual Excellence alone.

Beyond its seas there lay a country called Aolai. The country bordered the great ocean, and out in that ocean there rose a famous mountain called Flower-Fruit Mountain. This mountain was the ancestral vein of the Ten Continents, the source-dragon of the Three Isles. It had stood since the very parting of the pure and the impure, and taken its shape when the primal murk was first cleft asunder. Truly it was a splendid mountain! There is a rhapsody to prove it:

Its power overawes the boundless deep; its might brings peace to the jade-green sea. Its power overawes the boundless deep — the tide surges up in silver hills and the fish flee to their dens; its might brings peace to the jade-green sea — the waves roll over in drifts of snow and the sea-monsters quit their abyss. Where water and fire heap high at the corners, it lifts a soaring summit over the Eastern Sea. Cinnabar cliffs and grotesque stones, sheer escarpments and wondrous peaks. Upon the cinnabar cliffs, paired phoenixes call together; before the sheer escarpments, a lone unicorn lies at rest. On the peaks one hears in season the crowing of golden pheasants; in the stone caverns one ever watches dragons coming and going. In the forest dwell long-lived deer and fairy foxes; in the trees roost numinous birds and dark cranes. The fairy grasses and rare blossoms never fade; the green pines and emerald cypress keep eternal spring. The immortal peaches forever bear

their fruit; the slender bamboo perpetually holds the clouds. A single ravine runs thick with vines and creepers, and on every side the embankments wear fresh new green. This is indeed the heaven-bracing pillar where the hundred rivers meet, the unmoving root of the earth that ten thousand ages cannot stir.

Now upon the very summit of that mountain there sat a magic stone. The stone measured three zhang six chi and five cun in height, and two zhang four chi around. Its height of three zhang six chi and five cun corresponded to the three hundred sixty-five degrees of the heavens; its girth of two zhang four chi corresponded to the twenty-four solar terms of the calendar. Upon it were nine apertures and eight holes, corresponding to the Nine Palaces and the Eight Trigrams. On all four sides there were no trees to shade it, but to left and right there grew sprigs of magic fungus and orchid for company.

Ever since the world's beginning, the stone had received the true essence of heaven and the fine flower of earth, the seed of the sun and the splendor of the moon. Having been so quickened through long ages, it conceived at last a numinous purpose, and nurtured within itself a magic womb. One day it burst open and gave birth to a stone egg, round and large as a ball. Touched by the wind, the egg transformed into a stone monkey, complete in all five senses and whole in all four limbs. At once it learned to crawl and to walk, and bowed toward the four quarters. From

its eyes shot forth two beams of golden light that pierced upward to the Palace of the Dipper.

The light startled the August One on high — the supremely compassionate and benevolent Jade Emperor, the Most High Lord of the Mysterious Vault — who sat enthroned upon his Spirit-Mist Treasure Hall within the Cloud Palace of the Golden Gate. He had gathered his immortal ministers about him, and seeing the blazing golden light, he straightway commanded Thousand-Mile Eye and Down-the-Wind Ear to open the Southern Gate of Heaven and look out. The two generals received the order, went out beyond the gate, looked clearly and listened plainly, and after a moment returned to report: "Your servants, obeying the command, observed and listened at the source of the golden light. It comes from the border of the little country of Aolai, east across the sea of the Eastern Continent of Spiritual Excellence. There is a mountain there called Flower-Fruit Mountain, and on the mountain a magic stone, and the stone has given birth to an egg. Touched by the wind, it became a stone monkey, which now bows toward the four quarters; from its eyes shot the golden light that pierced the Palace of the Dipper. But now that it has begun to take food and drink, the golden light is fading away." The Jade Emperor in his gracious mercy declared: "These creatures of the world below are born of the very essence of heaven and earth. It is nothing to wonder at."

The monkey in the mountains could already walk and leap and run about. It ate the grasses and the trees, drank from the brook and the spring, gathered the mountain flowers and sought out the fruits of the trees. It made companions of the wolves and the insects, ran in packs with the tigers and leopards, made friends of the river-deer and the stags, and counted the gibbons and apes as its kin. By night it slept beneath the stone cliffs; by day it roamed among the peaks and caves. Truly, as the

saying goes: "In the mountains there is no calendar; when the cold is gone, one does not know the year."

One day the weather turned scorching hot, and the monkey, together with the whole troop, took refuge from the heat beneath the shade of the pines. Just look at every one of them:

Leaping the trees and clambering the branches,
plucking the blossoms and seeking the fruit; tossing
pellets and playing with marbles; racing through the
sand-pits, building little pagodas; chasing
dragonflies, pouncing on lizards; bowing to old
Heaven, worshipping the Bodhisattva; pulling at the
kudzu vines, plaiting the grasses; catching their
fleas, biting and pinching them; grooming their fur,
picking at their nails. The pressing pressed and the
rubbing rubbed, the shoving shoved and the
squashing squashed, the dragging dragged and the
hauling hauled — beneath the green pine forest
they romped at will, beside the clear brook they
bathed as they pleased.

When the troop had played a while, they went to bathe in the mountain brook. They saw how the water came rushing down, churning like a

boiling cauldron. The old saying goes: "Birds have the speech of birds, and beasts the words of beasts." All the monkeys said: "We do not know where this water comes from. Today, having nothing better to do, let us follow the brook up to its head and trace it to its source — that will be sport!" With a shout they all came running, tugging the males and leading the females, calling to younger brother and elder brother, scrambling up the mountain along the brook until they reached the very source: a leaping waterfall and a flying spring. They saw there:

A sheet of white rainbow rises; a thousand fathoms of snowy waves take flight. The sea-wind cannot break it; the river-moon still shines upon it. Its cold breath divides the blue cliffs; its overflow waters the emerald slopes. Murmuring, it is named a waterfall — truly like a hanging curtain of pearls.

The monkeys clapped their hands and cried in praise: "Fine water! Fine water! So it reaches far down beneath the mountain's foot and joins straight to the waves of the great ocean." Then they said: "If any one of us has the ability to bore inside, find the source-head, and come out again unhurt, we will honor him as our king." Three times they raised the cry, and suddenly out from the throng leaped the stone monkey, answering with a loud shout: "I'll go in! I'll go in!" Ah, what a monkey! For him it was:

Today his fair name is made plain; his hour has come, his great fortune flows. By destiny he dwells in this place; his king will send him into the immortal palace.

Just watch him: he shut his eyes, crouched low, and with one bound sprang straight into the waterfall. Then he opened his eyes, lifted his head, and looked — and there inside was neither water nor wave, but a bright and shining bridge of iron. He steadied himself and calmed his spirit, and looking more carefully, he saw that it was indeed a bridge of wrought iron plates. The water beneath it poured through the gaps among the rocks and gushed outward, hanging downward to screen the bridge's mouth. He stepped up onto the bridgehead and walked forward, gazing about him, and saw that the place seemed a very dwelling where folk might live — truly a fine spot. He saw there:

Green mosses heaped like blue, white clouds
floating like jade, the light shimmering in shred
upon shred of rosy mist. Empty windows and quiet
chambers; smooth benches where flowers seem to
bloom upon the boards. Stalactites hang like
dragon-pearls; rare blossoms wind in profusion over
all the ground. Beside the cliff a stove still bears the
trace of fire; against the table the wine-jars show
the dregs of a feast. Stone seats and stone beds,
truly lovable; stone basins and stone bowls, more to
be praised still. And there too one or two stalks of
slender bamboo, three or five sprays of plum
blossom. A few green pines that ever wear the rain
— altogether, just like a human household.

After he had looked a good while, he leaped to the middle of the bridge and gazed left and right. There in the very center stood a stone tablet, and upon the tablet a line of large regular characters was carved: "The Blessed Land of Flower-Fruit Mountain, the Cave-Heaven of the Water-Curtain Cave."

The stone monkey was beside himself with joy. He hastily turned and made his way back out, shut his eyes, crouched low, and leaped clear of

the water. With two great chuckles he cried: "Great fortune! Great fortune!" The monkeys crowded round him and asked: "How is it inside? How deep is the water?" The stone monkey said: "There's no water! No water at all! It turns out there's a bridge of wrought iron, and beyond the bridge a household ready-made by heaven and earth." The monkeys said: "How can it be a household?" The stone monkey laughed and said: "This water pours through beneath the stone bridge and hangs down to screen the gateway. Beside the bridge there are flowers and trees, and there is a stone house. Within the house are a stone hearth, a stone stove, stone bowls, stone basins, a stone bed, and stone benches. In the center, on a stone tablet, are carved the words: 'The Blessed Land of Flower-Fruit Mountain, the Cave-Heaven of the Water-Curtain Cave.' Truly it is a place for us to settle. Inside it is broad and wide, with room for a thousand of us or more, old and young alike. Let us all go in and dwell there, and so spare ourselves the buffets of old Heaven. In here:

When the wind blows there's a place to hide; when
the rain falls a good shelter for the body. Frost and
snow we need not fear at all; the thunder's voice is
never heard. Mist and rosy clouds forever glow;
auspicious vapors ever steam and warm. The pines
and bamboo year by year stay fair; the rare flowers
grow fresh day after day."

When the monkeys heard this, every one rejoiced. They all said: "You go first and lead us in! In, in!" Again the stone monkey shut his eyes, crouched low, and leaped inside, calling: "Follow me in, all of you! In, in!"

Those monkeys with bold hearts all leaped in at once; the timid ones, one by one, craned their necks and drew them back, scratched their ears and rubbed their cheeks, shrieked aloud, and after fussing a good while, in they went too. They leaped over the bridgehead, and one and all began snatching basins and seizing bowls, claiming the stove and fighting over the bed, hauling things this way and shifting them that way — for monkeys by nature are restless and unruly, and not a one would keep still until they had worn themselves out and their spirits flagged. Only then did they stop.

The stone monkey took his seat at the head and said: "Gentlemen — 'a man without good faith, one does not know what he can be good for.' You yourselves just now said that whoever had the ability to get in and out again unhurt should be honored as king. Now I have gone in and come out, come out and gone in, and have found you this cave-heaven where you may sleep soundly and rest at ease, and where each may enjoy the blessing of a household ready-made. Why then do you not honor me as king?" When the monkeys heard this, they all folded their hands and bowed in submission without dissent. One by one they arranged themselves in order of age, drew up in ranks, and bowed in homage, all hailing him "Great King of a Thousand Years." From that time the stone monkey ascended to the throne. He set aside the word "stone" and styled himself the Handsome Monkey King. There is a poem to prove it:

The three yang join in harmony to bring forth the living host; the magic stone, its womb enwrapping the essence of sun and moon. Borrowing the egg to become a monkey, he fulfills the Great Way; taking on a name and a surname, he matches the cinnabar's completion. Looked at within, there is no knowing — for it is without form; joined with the outer world, one clearly sees it takes on shape. Through all the ages every man belongs to this same kind: calling himself king, calling himself sage, free to roam as he will.

The Handsome Monkey King led his troop of gibbons, macaques, and horse-monkeys, and assigned to each the rank of minister, lord, aide, or officer. By day they roamed Flower-Fruit Mountain; by night they lodged in the Water-Curtain Cave. United in fellowship and of one mind, they joined neither the flocks of flying birds nor the ranks of running beasts. He was king all by himself, and his delight was boundless. And so:

In spring they gathered the hundred flowers for food and drink; in summer they sought all manner of fruits to make their living. In autumn they harvested chestnuts and taro to mark the season; in winter they hunted out the yellow-essence herb to pass the year.

The Handsome Monkey King enjoyed his innocent pleasures, and so it went — who could have foreseen it? — for three or four hundred years. One day, in the midst of a merry feast with the troop of monkeys, he suddenly grew downcast and troubled, and let fall tears. The monkeys hurriedly gathered around him, bowing, and asked: "Great King, what is the cause of your grief?" The Monkey King said: "Though I am now in my time of joy, I have one small but far-reaching worry, and that is why I grieve." The monkeys laughed and said: "Great King, how easily you are dissatisfied! Day after day we hold merry gatherings in fairy mountains and blessed lands, in ancient caves and spirit continents. We are not subject to the rule of the unicorn, nor governed by the phoenix, nor bound by any earthly king's authority. We are free and at ease, and ours is a blessing beyond measure. Why then this far-reaching worry that makes you grieve?" The Monkey King said: "Today, though we are not bound by the laws of any human king, nor in dread of the majesty of birds and beasts, yet in years to come, when we grow old and our blood runs thin, there is old King Yama working in secret who has us in his charge. Once the body perishes, shall we not have lived in this world in vain, unable to abide forever among the ranks of the gods?"

When the monkeys heard these words, every one of them covered his face and wept, all troubled by the thought of impermanence. Just then, out from the ranks leaped a Common-Backed Gibbon, who cried in a loud, stern voice: "If the Great King has thoughts so far-reaching as these, it is truly what is called the awakening of the heart that seeks the Way! Now among all the Five Kinds of living creatures, there are just three sorts that are not subject to old King Yama." The Monkey King said: "Do you know which three sorts?" The gibbon said: "They are the Buddhas, the Immortals, and the Holy Sages — these three. They escape the wheel of rebirth; they are neither born nor extinguished, and they live as long as heaven and earth, the mountains and the rivers." The Monkey King said: "Where do these three dwell?" The gibbon said: "They dwell only within the world of Jambudvipa, in ancient caves and on fairy mountains." When the Monkey King heard this, his heart was filled with joy, and he said: "Tomorrow I shall take leave of you all and go down from the mountain. I shall roam the corners of the sea on cloud, journey far to the ends of heaven, and seek out these three without fail, that I may learn the secret of deathless long life and forever escape the woe of King Yama." Ah! This one saying caused him to leap clear of the net of the wheel of rebirth, and led at last to the making of the Great Sage Equal to Heaven.

The monkeys clapped and cheered in praise, all saying: "Excellent! Excellent! Tomorrow we will cross the ridges and climb the heights and gather a wide store of fruits, and set out a great banquet to see the Great King off." The next day the monkeys went indeed to pluck the immortal peaches and pick the rare fruits, to dig up the mountain yams and grub out the yellow-essence herb. Magic fungus and fragrant orchid, fairy grasses and rare blossoms — every sort and every kind, neatly arranged in good order, they laid out on the stone benches and stone tables, and

set forth the immortal wine and immortal viands. You should have seen them:

Golden pellets and pearly bullets, ones split red and ones grown yellow-ripe. Golden pellets and pearly bullets — the winter cherries, their color true and their taste sweet; split red and grown yellow-ripe — the ripened plums, their flavor fragrant and tart. Fresh dragon-eyes, sweet of flesh and thin of skin; fire-lychees, small of stone and red of pulp. Crab-apples in jade-green fruit, offered still on the branch; loquats in pale-yellow husk, held up with the leaves. Hare-headed pears and chicken-heart dates, that slake the thirst, dispel vexation, and sober a drunken head. Fragrant peaches and softened apricots, sweet as the jade-broth and jasper nectar of the gods; crisp plums and bayberries, tart and cool as cream and curds and clarified butter. Ripe watermelons with red rind and black seeds; great persimmons of four lobes and yellow skin. Pomegranates split open, their cinnabar grains glowing like fiery crystal beads; chestnuts cracked apart, their hard kernels round as golden agate.

Walnuts and ginkgo nuts to go with the tea;
coconuts and grapes that can be made into wine.
Hazelnuts, pine-nuts, torreyia and quince heaped
full on the platters; oranges, sugarcane, tangerines
and bitter-oranges piled high upon the boards.
Mountain yams roasted soft, yellow-essence herb
stewed tender; poria and Job's-tears pounded fine,
simmered to a broth over a low fire in the stone pot.
Though the world of men may have its rarest
delicacies, how can they match the calm
contentment of the mountain monkeys?

The troop set the Handsome Monkey King in the seat of honor, and each ranged himself below according to his age. One by one they came up in turn to offer wine, to offer flowers, to offer fruit, and they drank deep all that day.

The next day the Handsome Monkey King rose early and gave the order: "Little ones, break me some dry pine boughs and weave them into a raft, cut a bamboo pole for punting, gather some fruits and the like — I am going now." He boarded the raft alone, pushed off with all his strength, and went drifting and tossing straight out into the waves of the great ocean. With a heaven-sent wind behind him, he made his crossing toward the borders of the Southern Continent of Jambu. This voyage was truly:

The heaven-born fairy monkey, deep in his cultivation of the Way, leaves the mountain, rides the raft, and takes the wind of heaven. Across the ocean, over the sea, he seeks the immortal Way; firm in will, with hidden heart, to build a great achievement. Having his share and his destiny, he sets aside worldly desires; free of sorrow, free of care, he meets the Origin-Dragon. Surely he must encounter one who knows the music of his heart, who will lay bare the source and stream, and all the myriad ways flow clear.

Indeed his fortune had come and his hour had ripened. From the day he boarded his wooden raft, the southeast wind blew strong for days on end and carried him to the northwest shore, which was the border of the Southern Continent of Jambu. He tested the depth with his pole, chanced upon a shallow, abandoned the raft, and leaped up onto the bank. There along the shore were people fishing, catching wild geese, digging clams, and panning for salt. He went up close, played a trick, and made himself out to be a tiger to frighten them — so that those folk threw down their baskets and abandoned their nets and scattered in all directions, fleeing. The one who could not run he seized, stripped off his clothes, and learned, like a man, to put them on his own body. Swaggering and strutting, he passed through districts and crossed

prefectures, and in the marketplaces learned the manners of men and the speech of men. By morning he ate and by night he lodged, his whole heart set on inquiring after the Way of the Buddhas, the Immortals, and the Holy Sages, and on finding some recipe for deathless long life. Yet he saw that the people of the world were all men bent on fame and gain, and not one among them cared for his own life and destiny. It was indeed:

Striving for fame and snatching at gain — when will it ever cease? Up early and to bed late, never their own masters. Riding the donkey and the mule, they dream of fine steeds; holding the office of prime minister, they hope for the rank of king. They worry only over food and clothing and steep themselves in toil, never fearing that King Yama will come to hook them away. Sons after them and grandsons in their shade, they scheme for wealth and rank, and not a single one is willing to turn his head and look back.

The Monkey King sought everywhere after the Way of the immortals, but found no destined meeting. Through the Southern Continent of Jambu he wandered, threading the great cities and roaming the little counties, until before he knew it eight or nine years had passed. Then suddenly he came to the great Western Ocean, and he thought to himself that beyond the sea there must surely be immortals. As before, he built himself a raft

alone and drifted across the Western Sea until he reached the borders of the Western Continent of Cattle-Offering. He went ashore and searched about for a long while, until suddenly he saw a tall mountain, fair and lovely, its forests and foothills deep and secluded. Fearing neither wolves nor insects, neither tigers nor leopards, he climbed to the very summit to look about. Truly it was a fine mountain:

A thousand peaks ranged like halberds, ten thousand fathoms spread like a screen. The sun lights the mountain mist and lightly locks the green; the rain clears and the dark hue coldly holds the blue. Withered vines twine the old trees; an ancient ford marks off the secret path. Rare flowers and auspicious grasses, slender bamboo and towering pine. Slender bamboo and towering pine — for ten thousand years ever green, putting the blessed land to shame; rare flowers and auspicious grasses — never fading through the four seasons, outdoing fairy Penglai. The secret birds call near at hand; the spring at the source murmurs clear. Fold upon fold of valleys, ringed about with fungus and orchid; everywhere the steep cliffs grow with moss and lichen. The rolling crests are dragon-veins of good fortune — surely here some lofty man hides his name and dwells.

As he was gazing about, he suddenly heard from the depths of the forest the sound of someone speaking. Hurriedly he quickened his step, pressed

into the wood, cocked his ear, and listened — and found it was the sound of singing. The song went:

"Watching the chess, the axe-handle rots; chopping wood, the strokes ring out — *ding, ding*. By the cloud's edge, at the valley's mouth, I stroll at ease. Selling firewood to buy my wine, I laugh wild and delight in myself. The green path, the high autumn — facing the moon, I pillow my head on a pine-root, and sleep a sleep till the sky grows light. I know the old wood, climb the cliffs and cross the ridges, and with my axe cut the withered vines. When I have gathered a full load, I go singing along the market street and trade it for three measures of rice. No haggling, no contention — the price of the day is fair and even. I know no cunning schemes or clever reckonings; without glory or disgrace, in calm and plainness I lengthen out my life. Those I meet upon the way are immortals, or else followers of the Way, who sit in stillness and expound the *Yellow Court*."

When the Handsome Monkey King heard these words, his heart was full of joy, and he said: "So the immortals are hidden away in here!" At once he sprang inside, and looking carefully about, he saw it was only a woodcutter, raising his axe to chop firewood. But look how strangely the man was dressed:

On his head a broad bamboo hat, made of the sheath that a fresh bamboo-shoot has just cast off. On his body a cloth gown, made of the yarn that cotton has been twisted into. Round his waist a knotted girdle, made of the silk that the old silkworm's mouth has spun. On his feet straw sandals, woven of the stripped and dried sedge. In his hand a polished steel axe, and a hempen rope coiled at his side. For prying loose the pines and splitting the dead trees — what could be better than such a woodcutter?

The Monkey King drew near and called out: "Old immortal, your disciple makes his bow!" The woodcutter hastily threw down his axe and turned to return the courtesy, saying: "Not fitting, not fitting! I am a poor, clumsy fellow who lacks even enough to eat and wear — how should I dare bear the two words 'immortal'?" The Monkey King said: "If you are no immortal, how is it you speak the words of immortals?" The woodcutter said: "What words of immortals did I speak?" The Monkey

King said: "Just now, as I came to the forest's edge, I heard you singing: 'Those I meet upon the way are immortals, or else followers of the Way, who sit in stillness and expound the *Yellow Court*.' The *Yellow Court* is a true scripture of the Way and its Power — if that is not an immortal, what is it?"

The woodcutter laughed and said: "I will tell you truly and hide nothing. This song is called *Fragrance Fills the Courtyard*, and it was an immortal who taught it to me. That immortal lives next door to my poor cottage. Seeing how I am worn down by household toil and daily vexations, he taught me that whenever I meet with troubles I should chant this song to myself — first to ease my mind, and second to dispel my weariness. Just now I had some hardships weighing on my thoughts, and so I was chanting it, never expecting that you would hear me." The Monkey King said: "Since your house is next door to an immortal's, why do you not follow him in his cultivation and learn some recipe for not growing old? Would that not be well?" The woodcutter said: "My whole life has been bitter and hard. From my infancy I was raised and reared by my parents, and by the time I was eight or nine and had come to know the ways of men, my father, alas, died, and my mother lived on as a widow. I have neither brothers nor sisters — only myself, and no help for it but to wait upon her morning and evening. Now my mother is old, and all the more I dare not leave her side. Besides, my fields and garden lie fallow, and we lack enough food and clothing. So I can do nothing but cut a couple of bundles of firewood, carry them to the marketplace, sell them for a few coins, buy a few measures of rice, and cook it myself to set out some plain food and tea and provide for my old mother. That is why I cannot cultivate the Way."

The Monkey King said: "By what you say, you are a gentleman who practices filial piety, and in time to come good things will surely come of

it. But I beg you to point me to that immortal's dwelling, that I may go and pay him a visit." The woodcutter said: "It is not far at all. This mountain is called the Mountain of the Spirit-Terrace and the Square-Inch; within the mountain there is a cave called the Cave of the Slanting Moon and Three Stars. In that cave there dwells an immortal called the Patriarch Subodhi. Of his disciples who have gone forth there is no counting the number, and even now some thirty or forty are cultivating the Way under him. You have only to follow that little path southward for seven or eight li, and you will come to his house."

The Monkey King took hold of the woodcutter by the arm and said: "Elder brother, come along with me. If I gain some benefit from it, I will surely not forget your kindness in showing me the way." The woodcutter said: "What a thick-headed fellow you are! I have just now told you everything, and still you do not understand. If I were to go with you, would I not be neglecting my livelihood? And who then would provide for my old mother? I have my firewood to cut — you go on by yourself, go on!"

Hearing this, the Monkey King had no choice but to take his leave. He came out of the deep forest, found the path, passed over a hillside, and after some seven or eight li, sure enough, he caught sight of a cave-dwelling. He stood up straight and gazed at it — truly a splendid place! He saw:

Mists and rosy clouds scatter their colors; sun and moon shake their light. A thousand ancient cypresses, ten thousand joints of slender bamboo. A thousand ancient cypresses, bearing the rain, blue-green and soft against the empty sky; ten thousand joints of slender bamboo, wrapped in mist, filling a whole ravine with their somber hue. Outside the gate, rare flowers spread like brocade; beside the bridge, fairy grasses breathe out their fragrance. The stone cliffs jut up, their green moss moist; the hanging walls stretch high, their emerald lichen long. Now and again one hears the cry of fairy cranes; ever one sees the soaring of phoenixes. When the fairy crane cries, its voice shakes the ninefold marsh and reaches the far heavens; when the phoenix soars up, its plumage of five colors glows like a rainbow cloud. Dark gibbons and white deer come and go half-hidden; golden lions and jade elephants roam or hide at will. Look closely on this blessed spirit-land — truly it rivals heaven itself.

He saw too that the cave-gate was tightly shut, all hushed and still, with no trace of anyone. Suddenly turning his head, he spotted at the edge of the cliff a stone tablet standing some three zhang and more in height and eight chi and more in breadth, on which a single line of ten great characters was carved: "The Mountain of the Spirit-Terrace and the Square-Inch; the Cave of the Slanting Moon and Three Stars." The Handsome Monkey King was greatly delighted and said: "The people here are honest folk indeed — there truly is such a mountain and such a cave." He gazed at it for a long while but did not dare to knock at the gate. Instead he leaped up to the tips of the pine boughs, plucked pine-seeds, and ate them as he played.

After a little while, he heard the cave-gate creak open, and out from within came a fairy lad, truly of fair and noble bearing, of pure and uncommon looks, quite unlike the common run of worldly folk. Just look at him:

His twin tufts of hair bound with cords of silk; his wide robe with the wind filling both its sleeves. His features and his form set him apart; his heart and his appearance both were void. A long-lived guest beyond the things of this world, an ever-youthful lad of the mountains. No speck of dust could stain him at all; let the years and calendars wheel as they would.

The lad came out the gate and called aloud: "Who is it making a disturbance here?" The Monkey King leaped down from the tree with a flop, came forward, and bowed low. "Fairy lad," he said, "I am a disciple come to seek the Way and to learn to be an immortal. I would never dare make a disturbance here." The fairy lad laughed and said: "You are one seeking the Way?" The Monkey King said: "I am." The lad said: "My master has just now risen from his couch and mounted the dais to expound the Way. Before he had even named his reason, he sent me out to open the gate, saying: 'There is one cultivating the Way come outside — go and receive him.' It must surely be you?" The Monkey King laughed and said: "It is I, it is I." The lad said: "Come in with me, then."

The Monkey King straightened his clothes, composed himself with reverence, and followed the lad straight into the deep recesses of the cave-heaven. Tier upon tier of deep towers and jasper pavilions, court within court of pearl palaces and conch-shell gateways — there was no telling the number of those quiet chambers and secluded dwellings. They came at last to the foot of a jasper terrace, where he saw the Patriarch Subodhi seated upright upon the dais, with thirty lesser immortals standing in attendance on either side below. Truly he was:

The Great Enlightened Golden Immortal, of a form without stain, the Patriarch Bodhi of the wondrous likeness of the West. Unborn, undying, in the threefold-threefold practice; whole in vital force, whole in spirit, in his myriad-fold compassion.

Empty and still, of himself he follows transformation; in true suchness, his original nature acts as it will. Of a majestic body that lives as long as heaven; a great Dharma-master whose heart shines clear through aeon upon aeon.

The moment the Handsome Monkey King saw him, he flung himself down and kowtowed without ceasing, his mouth saying only: "Master, master! Your disciple pays homage with his whole heart, pays homage with his whole heart!" The Patriarch said: "From what region do you come? First state your native place and your name clearly, and then bow again." The Monkey King said: "Your disciple is a native of the Water-Curtain Cave on Flower-Fruit Mountain, in the country of Aolai, in the Eastern Continent of Spiritual Excellence." The Patriarch shouted his command: "Drive him out! He is nothing but a fellow who deals in lies and deceit — how should such a one cultivate any fruit of the Way?" The Monkey King hastily knocked his head against the ground without ceasing and said: "Your disciple's words are honest; there is surely no falsehood or deceit." The Patriarch said: "If you are honest, how is it you speak of the Eastern Continent of Spiritual Excellence? Between that

place and here lie two great oceans and the whole Southern Continent of Jambu — how could you ever have come here?" The Monkey King kowtowed and said: "Your disciple drifted across the oceans and over the seas, made landfall and roamed about for some ten years and more, before at last I found my way to this place."

The Patriarch said: "Well, if you came gradually, step by step, that may pass. What is your surname?" The Monkey King said: "I have no temper. If men curse me, I am not vexed; if they strike me, I am not angered. I merely make my apology and let it go. All my life I have had no temper." The Patriarch said: "I do not mean that kind of temper. I mean — what was your father's and mother's surname?" The Monkey King said: "I have no father or mother either." The Patriarch said: "If you have no father or mother, then you must have grown on a tree." The Monkey King said: "Though I did not grow on a tree, I grew out of a stone. I remember only that on Flower-Fruit Mountain there was a magic stone, and that in that year the stone burst open, and so I was born."

When the Patriarch heard this, he was secretly pleased, and said: "Then you are a being formed by heaven and earth. Get up and walk about, and let me see you." The Monkey King sprang up and went hobbling and rolling about twice. The Patriarch laughed and said: "Though your body is coarse and mean, you are like nothing so much as a pine-nut-eating macaque. I will take a surname for you from your own body. My thought is to give you the surname *Hu*. But if you take the beast-radical from the character *hu*, what remains is *gu* and *yue* — 'ancient' and 'moon.' Yet 'ancient' means old, and 'moon' belongs to the yin; and what is old and yin cannot transform and bring forth life. Better that I give you the surname *Sun*. If you take the beast-radical from the character *sun*, what remains is *zi* and *xi* — 'child' and 'small.' 'Child' means a young boy, and

'small' means an infant — which fits exactly the root meaning of the newborn babe. Let your surname be *Sun*."

When the Monkey King heard this, his heart was filled with joy, and he kowtowed up toward the dais and said: "Splendid! Splendid! Splendid! Today at last I know I have a surname! I beg the master in his mercy — since now I have a surname, grant me also a personal name, so that it will be convenient to call me." The Patriarch said: "Within my school there are twelve characters by which names are assigned in order, and you fall in the tenth generation of little disciples." The Monkey King said: "Which twelve characters?" The Patriarch said: "They are *Guang, Da, Zhi, Hui, Zhen, Ru, Xing, Hai, Ying, Wu, Yuan, Jue* — twelve characters. Counting down to you, it falls upon the character *Wu*, 'Awakened.' I will give you the Dharma-name Sun Wukong — 'Monkey Awakened to Emptiness.' How is that?" The Monkey King laughed and said: "Splendid! Splendid! Splendid! From this day on I am called Sun Wukong!" It was indeed:

When the primal murk was first cleft, there was no surname at all; to shatter stubborn emptiness, one must awaken to emptiness.

And after all, there is no knowing what fruit of the Way he was to cultivate from this point on — so listen to the next chapter for the explanation.

Chapter 2: The Secret Word at the Third Watch

Now the Handsome Monkey King, having at last received both surname and religious name, was so overjoyed that he leapt and capered with delight, then bowed before the Patriarch Subodhi to give his thanks. The master at once ordered the assembled disciples to lead Sun Wukong out beyond the second gate, where they were to teach him how to sprinkle and sweep, how to answer when spoken to, and the proper manners of coming and going, advancing and withdrawing. The immortals obeyed and led him out. Once outside the gate, Wukong bowed again to all his elder brothers in the faith and arranged himself a sleeping place within the corridors of the cloister. Early the next morning he set about learning speech and courtesy from his elder brethren, discussing the scriptures and debating the Way, practicing his brushwork and burning incense. So passed each day. In his idle hours he swept the grounds and hoed the garden, tended the flowers and pruned the trees, gathered firewood and tended the flames, drew water and carried it in buckets. Of all the chores that wanted doing, there was none he left undone. And so, scarcely noticing the passage of time, he dwelt in that cave for six or seven years.

One day the Patriarch mounted his lecture platform, took his lofty seat, and summoned all the immortals to hear him expound the Great Way. Truly it was a marvel:

Heaven's blossoms came tumbling down, golden lotuses welled up from the earth. Subtle, he laid out the teaching of the Three Vehicles, in fine detail, the ten thousand methods complete. A slow wave of the whisk, and pearls and jade came spraying; the sound rolled like thunder, shaking the Ninefold Sky. A while he spoke of the Way, a while he discoursed on Chan — the three traditions joined as one, as is their nature. Open but a single word, and you grasp the principle of return and faith; follow his pointing finger, and you fathom the mystery of the deathless, deep nature.

Sun Wukong, listening from the side, was so delighted that he scratched his ears and rubbed his cheeks, his brows fairly blooming and his eyes laughing; he could not keep his hands from waving nor his feet from stamping in a dance. All at once the Patriarch caught sight of him and called out: "Sun Wukong! There you stand among the ranks — why do you leap and dance like a madman instead of listening to my lecture?"

"Your disciple was listening with all his heart," said Wukong, "and when he reached the place where the old master's wondrous voice grew most marvelous, he was so beside himself with joy that, before he knew it, he fell into this capering. I beg the master's pardon."

"Since you can recognize the wondrous voice," said the Patriarch, "let me ask you this: how long have you been in this cave?"

"Your disciple was always a dull-witted creature," said Wukong, "and cannot reckon how many seasons it has been. I only remember that whenever there was no fire under the stove, I would go off behind the mountain to gather kindling. There I found a fine hill of peach trees, and there I have eaten my fill of peaches seven times over."

"That hill is called Ripe Peach Mountain," said the Patriarch. "If you have eaten there seven times, then it must be seven years. And now what manner of the Way do you wish to learn from me?"

"That rests with my honored teacher's instruction," said Wukong. "If there is but a breath of the Way's true essence in it, your disciple will learn it gladly."

The Patriarch said: "Within the gate of this one word, 'Tao,' there are three hundred and sixty side-doors, and every side-door can lead to a proper fruition. I wonder — which of them would you study?"

"That is as my honored teacher pleases," said Wukong. "Your disciple will listen and obey with his whole heart."

"Suppose I teach you the Way that lies within the gate of the word 'Arts,'" said the Patriarch. "How would that suit you?"

"And what does the Way of the Arts gate mean?" asked Wukong.

"Within the gate of the Arts," said the Patriarch, "are such things as summoning immortals and consulting the planchette, casting fortunes and divining with yarrow stalks — the lore by which one may know how to seek good luck and shun misfortune."

"And by such means," asked Wukong, "can one win eternal life?"

"No, no," said the Patriarch.

"Then I won't learn it, I won't learn it," said Wukong.

The Patriarch went on: "Suppose I teach you the Way within the gate of the word 'Schools.' How would that be?"

"And what is the principle within the Schools gate?" Wukong asked again.

"Within the gate of the Schools," said the Patriarch, "are the Confucians and the Buddhists, the Taoists, the Yin-Yang masters, the Mohists and the Physicians — some who pore over the scriptures, some who chant the Buddha's name, and others who summon the true and call down the holy."

"And by such means," asked Wukong, "can one win eternal life?"

"If it's eternal life you want," said the Patriarch, "then this is like setting a pillar inside a wall."

"Master," said Wukong, "I am a plain, honest fellow, and I don't follow the cant of the marketplace. What do you mean, 'setting a pillar inside a wall'?"

"When folk build a house," said the Patriarch, "and want it to stand firm, they set an upright pillar in among the walls. But the day the great hall begins to topple, that pillar is sure to have rotted away."

"By that account," said Wukong, "it does not last long. I won't learn it, I won't learn it."

The Patriarch said: "Suppose I teach you the Way within the gate of the word 'Stillness.' How about that?"

"And what proper fruition lies within the Stillness gate?" asked Wukong.

"This," said the Patriarch, "is fasting from grain and guarding the body's emptiness, pure quietude and non-action, sitting in Chan meditation, holding silence and keeping abstinence; some practice their merit lying down, some standing up, along with entering trance and sealing oneself in retreat."

"And can such practices win eternal life as well?" asked Wukong.

"They are like an unfired brick of clay on a kiln," said the Patriarch.

Wukong laughed: "The master is full of riddles! Just now I told you I can't follow the marketplace cant, and here you go again. What do you mean, 'an unfired brick of clay on a kiln'?"

"It is just like a brick or tile of clay shaped upon the kiln," said the Patriarch. "Though it has already taken its form, it has not yet been tempered by water and fire; and when one day the rain comes pouring down in torrents, it is sure to dissolve back into mud."

"That does not last long either," said Wukong. "I won't learn it, I won't learn it."

The Patriarch said: "Suppose I teach you the Way within the gate of the word 'Action.' How about that?"

"And what then is the Way of the Action gate?" asked Wukong.

"This is the path of doing and contriving," said the Patriarch: "drawing on the yin to nourish the yang, drawing the bow and treading the crossbow's lever, massaging the navel and circulating the breath, compounding elixirs by formula, firing the cauldron over a grass blaze, ingesting red lead and refining autumn stone, and such things as drinking a woman's milk."

"And by such means can one win eternal life?" asked Wukong.

"To seek long life this way," said the Patriarch, "is like fishing for the moon in the water."

"There the master goes again," said Wukong. "What do you mean, 'fishing for the moon in the water'?"

"The moon hangs in the vast sky," said the Patriarch, "and its reflection lies in the water below. Though you can see it plainly, there is nothing there to grasp or seize; in the end it comes to nothing at all."

"Then I won't learn that either, I won't learn it," said Wukong.

When the Patriarch heard this, he gave a sharp cry—"Tcha!"—and sprang down from the high platform. Grasping his ruler-rod, he leveled it at Wukong and said: "You ape! This you won't learn and that you won't learn—what is it you're waiting for, then?" He strode forward and struck Wukong three times upon the head. Then, clasping his hands behind his back, he walked off into the inner quarters, shut the middle gate, and left the whole assembly standing there. This so startled all those who had come to hear the lecture that every one of them was seized with fear, and they fell to scolding Wukong: "You wretched monkey! You have no manners at all. The master would have handed you the methods of the Way—why wouldn't you learn them? Why must you talk back to him? Now that you've provoked him, there's no telling when he'll come out again!" One and all they reviled him, heaping reproach upon him and despising him utterly. But Wukong was not the least bit vexed; his whole face was wreathed in smiles. For the truth was that the Monkey King had already cracked the riddle hidden in the master's words and kept it secret in his heart—and that was why he would not quarrel with the others, but held his peace in silence. The Patriarch's three blows upon his head meant: be mindful at the hour of the third watch; and the clasping of his hands behind his back as he walked into the inner rooms and shut the

middle gate meant: enter by the back door, where in secret the Way would be passed to him.

That day Wukong made merry with the rest before the Cave of the Three Stars, watching the sky and impatient for the dark, which seemed as though it would never come. When dusk at last fell he went to bed with the others, but only feigned to close his eyes, steadying his breath and gathering his spirit. In the mountains there was no watchman's drum or water-clock to mark the hours, so he could not tell the time by any instrument; he only regulated the breath that passed in and out through his own nostrils. When it drew near the hour of the Rat, he rose ever so softly, put on his clothes, stealthily opened the front door, slipped away from the sleepers, and went out. He lifted his head and looked about, and this is what he saw:

The moon shone bright, the clear dew cold, and to the eight far quarters, no speck of dust. Deep in the trees the hidden birds were roosting, and at its source the water purled and flowed. The flitting fireflies scattered their drifting glow, and passing wild geese ranged in script across the clouds. Just at the moment of the third watch's depth—the very hour to seek the truth of the Way.

Watch him now, following the old familiar path to the place behind the rear gate, where he found the door standing half open and half closed. Wukong rejoiced: "So the old master truly means to pass me the Way—

that is why he has left the door ajar." With long, quiet strides he drew near, turned himself sideways, and slipped inside, going straight on until he stood beneath the Patriarch's sleeping couch. There he saw the master lying curled up, asleep with his face to the wall. Wukong dared not disturb him, but knelt down before the couch and waited. Before long the Patriarch awoke, stretched out both his legs, and murmured to himself:

"Hard! Hard! Hard! The Way is most profound— do not treat the Golden Elixir as a trifling thing. Unless you meet a perfected man to pass the wondrous secret, you weary your mouth with empty words and dry your tongue!"

At this Wukong answered aloud: "Master, your disciple has been kneeling here in waiting a long while." The Patriarch, hearing that the voice was Wukong's, at once rose and pulled on his robe, sat cross-legged, and barked: "You ape! Why aren't you sleeping out in front? What are you doing here behind?"

"Master," said Wukong, "yesterday at the lecture platform, before all the others, you promised your disciple that at the hour of the third watch you would pass me the Way by the back door. That is why I have made so bold as to come straight here and kneel beneath your couch."

When the Patriarch heard this he was greatly pleased, and thought secretly to himself: "This creature is indeed something engendered by Heaven and Earth—how else could he have cracked the dark riddle hidden in my words?"

"Here there are no other ears to hear," said Wukong, "none but your disciple alone. I beg the master in his great mercy to grant me the Way of eternal life, and I shall never forget the kindness."

"You have an affinity now," said the Patriarch, "and I too am glad to speak. Since you have read the hidden riddle, come closer and listen carefully, and I shall pass to you the wondrous Way of eternal life." Wukong kowtowed his thanks, washed out his ears, fixed his whole mind upon it, and knelt beneath the couch. The Patriarch chanted:

The true and wondrous secret, manifest and hidden, perfect and all-pervading, guards nature and life—there is nothing else to say. It all comes down to essence, breath, and spirit: hold them firm, lock them deep, let nothing leak away. Let nothing leak away, but store it in the body, and the Way I pass to you will of itself grow great. Keep the oral formula in mind—much good it brings; banish lewd desire, and win the cool serenity. Win the cool serenity, the light pure and bright, and turn toward the elixir-terrace to savor the shining moon. The moon hides the jade hare, the sun hides the crow; of themselves the tortoise and serpent coil and entwine. Coiled and entwined, nature and life stand firm— and you can plant the golden lotus within the very fire. Gather and reverse the Five Phases in their working, and when the work is done, become a Buddha or an immortal as you will.

In that moment the very root and source were laid bare. Wukong, his spirit quickened and his good fortune arrived, fixed the formula firmly in

his heart. He bowed to the Patriarch in deep gratitude, then went out by the back door and looked about him. The east was just beginning to pale with white, and along the western road a great golden light shone forth bright. Following the old path, he came round to the front door, pushed it softly open, went in, and sat down in his usual sleeping place. Then he deliberately shook the bedstead so that it rattled and called out: "It's light! It's light! Time to get up!" The rest were still fast asleep, never knowing that Wukong had won this fine thing. That day he went about and mingled with the others as usual, secretly nurturing his attainment, regulating his own breath morning and evening, before noon and after.

In no time three more years had slipped by, and the Patriarch once again ascended his treasure-seat to expound the Dharma to the assembly. He spoke of the public cases and parables, and discoursed on the outer forms and the husks that wrap them. Suddenly he asked: "Where is Wukong?" Wukong came forward and knelt down: "Your disciple is here."

"What sort of Way have you been cultivating all this while?" asked the Patriarch.

"Of late your disciple's spiritual nature has grown fairly clear," said Wukong, "and the root and source are gradually growing firm."

"Since you have penetrated the nature of the Dharma and grasped the root and source," said the Patriarch, "and have already settled your spirit-body, you must now guard yourself against the perils of the Three Calamities."

Hearing this, Wukong brooded for a long while, then said: "Master, surely your words are mistaken. I have always heard that one of lofty Way and abundant virtue is coeval with Heaven itself; that when water and fire are brought into harmony, no illness can arise. How then can there be these perils of the Three Calamities?"

"This," said the Patriarch, "is no ordinary Way. It robs Heaven and Earth of their very work of creation; it usurps the hidden workings of the sun and moon. Once the elixir is achieved, ghosts and spirits cannot abide it. Though it keeps your youth and lengthens your years, yet after five hundred years Heaven will send down a thunder-calamity to strike you. You must see your nature and make your mind clear, and dodge it beforehand. If you can dodge it, your life span will equal Heaven's; if you cannot, there your life is cut off. After another five hundred years Heaven will send down a fire-calamity to burn you. This is no fire of Heaven, nor any common fire; it is called the yin-fire. It kindles up from the Bubbling Spring point beneath the soles of your own feet, drives straight up to the Niwan Palace in the crown of the head, reduces the five viscera to ashes and the four limbs to rot, so that a thousand years of bitter cultivation are all turned to illusion. After yet another five hundred years a wind-calamity will be sent down to blow upon you. This is no wind of east or south or west or north, no mild or scorching wind off the metal autumn, nor any wind through flowers and willows, pines and bamboo; it is called the Mighty Wind. It blows in through the crown of the head into the six bowels, passes the elixir-field and pierces the nine apertures; flesh and bone melt and disperse, and the body of itself comes undone. All of these, therefore, must be dodged."

When Wukong heard this his hair stood on end and a shudder ran through him; he kowtowed and bowed, saying: "I beg the old master to take pity and pass me the method for dodging the Three Calamities. To the very end I shall never dare forget the kindness."

"This is not so hard," said the Patriarch. "Only, you are different from other men, and so it cannot be passed to you in the usual way."

"But I too have a round head reaching up to Heaven and square feet treading the Earth," said Wukong. "I have the same nine apertures and

four limbs, the five viscera and six bowels. How am I different from other men?"

"Though you have the likeness of a man," said the Patriarch, "you are short in the cheeks compared with others." For the truth was that this monkey had a hollow-cheeked, pointed-jawed face, a sunken visage and a sharp snout. Wukong put up his hand, felt about his face, and laughed: "The master hasn't reckoned right. True, I'm short in the cheeks—but I have more than other men in this gullet-pouch of mine, and that may serve to make up the difference."

"Very well, then," said the Patriarch. "Which sort would you learn? There is one set after the number of the Heavenly Ladle, which comprises thirty-six transformations; and there is one set after the number of the Earthly Fiends, which comprises seventy-two transformations."

"Your disciple would rather cast a wider net," said Wukong. "Let me learn the Earthly Fiends' transformations."

"In that case," said the Patriarch, "come forward and I shall pass you the oral formula." Then he put his mouth to Wukong's ear and murmured low—who knows what wondrous method he spoke? But this Monkey King was one in whom, once a single aperture opened, all hundred apertures opened together; and there and then he learned the formula, cultivated and refined it himself, and mastered all seventy-two transformations entire.

Then one day the Patriarch and his disciples were amusing themselves before the Cave of the Three Stars, enjoying the cool of the evening. The Patriarch said: "Wukong, have you accomplished it yet or not?"

"By the master's boundless grace," said Wukong, "your disciple's labor and fruit are complete, and I can already rise on the rosy mists and soar

aloft."

"Try flying up for me to see," said the Patriarch.

Wukong displayed his skill: he hunched his body, gave a tumbling somersault, sprang up some fifty or sixty feet from the ground, trod the clouds and mists for about the time it takes to eat a meal, came and went, and covered not quite three miles before dropping down again before them. He folded his hands and said: "Master, that is what they call soaring on the clouds!"

The Patriarch laughed: "That can't be counted as cloud-soaring—it can only be called cloud-crawling. As the old saying goes: 'An immortal roams the Northern Sea at dawn and reaches Cangwu by dusk.' But you, in half a day, have gone not even three miles; that can't even be reckoned as cloud-crawling."

"What does it mean," asked Wukong, "to 'roam the Northern Sea at dawn and reach Cangwu by dusk'?"

"Those who soar upon the clouds," said the Patriarch, "rise in the early morning from the Northern Sea, roam across the Eastern Sea, the Western Sea, and the Southern Sea, and come round again to Cangwu. Now Cangwu is the common name for Lingling on the Northern Sea. To traverse the whole expanse beyond the Four Seas in a single day—that may be reckoned as true cloud-soaring."

"This is hard indeed, hard indeed," said Wukong.

"In all the world there is no thing too hard," said the Patriarch; "only fear a man of resolve."

When Wukong heard these words he kowtowed and bowed, and said: "Master, when one does a thing for another, one should see it through to

the end. Of your great mercy, be generous and pass me this method of cloud-soaring as well, and I shall surely never dare forget the kindness."

"When all the immortals soar upon the clouds," said the Patriarch, "they rise by stamping off their feet—but you are not like that. Just now I watched you go: you had to scramble up by tumbling somersaults. Working from this very posture of yours, I shall pass you the Somersault Cloud." Wukong bowed again and begged earnestly, and the Patriarch passed him this further formula: "For this cloud, make the secret hand-sign, recite the true words, clench your fists tight, give your body a shake, and leap up—and with one somersault you'll cover a hundred and eight thousand miles."

When the assembly heard this, every one of them tittered and laughed: "What luck for Wukong! If he can work this trick, he could hire himself out as a courier-runner, carrying documents and delivering dispatches—wherever he went, he'd never want for a meal." Master and disciples then dispersed, each to his own quarters, as the sky grew dark.

That night Wukong worked his spirit and refined the method, and mastered the Somersault Cloud. From then on, day by day, he was free of all restraint, at ease and roaming as he pleased—and this too was one of the joys of eternal life.

One day, when spring was passing into summer, the assembly had been gathered a long while beneath the pine trees, discoursing together. They said to him: "Wukong, what affinity from a former life had you cultivated to deserve this? The other day the old master put his mouth to your ear and whispered low, and passed you the methods for dodging the Three Calamities and the transformations. Have you really mastered them all?"

Wukong laughed: "I'll not deceive you, elder brothers. For one thing it was the master's teaching, and for another it was my own diligence night

and day—and I have mastered every one of those several skills."

"Now is a fine time," said the assembly. "Try giving us a demonstration—let us have a look."

Hearing this, Wukong roused his spirit and prepared to show off his arts: "Elder brothers, set me a subject. What would you have me change into?"

"Change into a pine tree, then," they said. Wukong made the secret sign, recited the spell, gave his body a shake, and changed into a pine tree. Truly it was:

Lush and dense, breathing mist through all four seasons, rising straight above the clouds in a fine, upright form. Not the least trace of the goblin-monkey about it— nothing but boughs that have braved the frost and borne the snow.

When the assembly saw it they clapped their hands and roared with laughter, all crying out: "What a fine monkey! What a fine monkey!" Their clamor and uproar, before they knew it, disturbed the Patriarch. He came hurrying out of his door, dragging his staff, and demanded: "Who is making this racket here?" At his call the assembly hastily checked themselves, straightened their robes, and stepped forward. Wukong too resumed his true form and, lost among the crowd, said: "May it please the honored master: we were gathered here in discourse, and there were no outsiders making any noise."

The Patriarch shouted in anger: "Bawling and shouting like this—you do not in the least resemble men of cultivation! A man who cultivates the

Way, when he opens his mouth, lets his spirit-breath disperse, and when he stirs his tongue, breeds right and wrong. How is it you are roaring with laughter here?"

"We dare not deceive the master," said the assembly. "Just now Sun Wukong was performing his transformations for sport. We told him to change into a pine tree, and a real pine tree it was. Your disciples were all praising and applauding him, and so our loud voices startled and offended the honored master. We beg your pardon."

"Off with you, all of you," said the Patriarch. Then he called: "Wukong, come here! What sort of spirit were you working? What manner of pine tree were you changing into? Is this a feat to be showing off in front of others? Suppose you saw someone else with such a skill—wouldn't you beg him for it? And when others see that you have it, they will surely beg it of you. If you fear the harm that would follow, you will have to teach them; and if you do not teach them, they will surely do you injury—and then you cannot keep your own life safe."

Wukong kowtowed and said: "I only beg the master to pardon me."

"I lay no blame on you," said the Patriarch, "but you must simply go."

When Wukong heard these words, his eyes brimmed with tears. "Master, where would you have me go?"

"Wherever you came from," said the Patriarch, "back there you must go."

All at once Wukong understood, and said: "I came from the Water Curtain Cave on the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit, in the Aolai Country, in the Eastern Continent of Superior Body."

"Hurry back there," said the Patriarch, "and preserve your life. To remain here is by no means to be permitted."

Wukong accepted his fault and pleaded with the honored master: "I have been away from home a full twenty years now. Though I long indeed to look upon my children and grandchildren of old, yet when I think how I have not yet repaid the master's deep kindness, I dare not go."

"What kindness or obligation is there to speak of?" said the Patriarch. "Only see that you stir up no trouble and do not drag my name into it—that is all I ask."

Seeing there was no help for it, Wukong could only bow his farewell and take his leave of the assembly. The Patriarch said: "On this going of yours, you are bound to come to no good. Whatever trouble you stir up or evil you commit, you are forbidden to say that you are my disciple. Let half a word of it out, and I shall know it at once—and I will flay this ape's hide and grind his bones, and banish his spirit-soul to the Nine Hells, so that through ten thousand ages he shall never turn over again!"

"I will never dare to breathe a word of the master," said Wukong. "I'll only say that I learned it all by myself, and there's an end of it."

Wukong gave his thanks and then drew himself together, made the secret sign, gave a tumbling spring, mounted the Somersault Cloud, and headed straight back to the Eastern Continent. In less than an hour he could already see the Water Curtain Cave on the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit. The Handsome Monkey King, glad in his own heart, said to himself in secret:

When I set out, my mortal bones and frame were heavy; now that I've won the Way, my body's light, my whole self light. In all the world there's none who'll set his will to it— set your will to cultivate the mystery, and the mystery clears of itself. When I went out, the waves were hard to press across; today, returning, how easy the journey is! The parting words of admonition still ring in my ears—who would have thought I'd see the Eastern Sea in a single breath?

Wukong pressed down his cloud-head and came straight to the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit, picking his way along. Suddenly he heard the cry of cranes and the wail of apes—the cranes' cries piercing beyond the clouds of heaven, the apes' wailing mournful and full of grief. At once he called out: "Children, I have come home!" From beneath the cliffs and rock-clefts, out of the flowers and grasses and the trees, monkeys great and small came leaping out by the thousands and tens of thousands, surrounding the Handsome Monkey King in their midst. They kowtowed and cried: "Great King! How carefree you must have been! How could you stay away so long? You left us stranded here, longing for you as for food and drink. Lately we have been bullied and oppressed by a fiend who insists on seizing our Water Curtain Cave for his own dwelling. We have fought him to the death, heedless of our lives. All this while that wretch has plundered our household goods and carried off many of our

young, so that day and night we cannot sleep but must keep watch over our home. Happily the Great King has come! Had the Great King stayed away another year or two, we and the whole mountain cave would have fallen into another's hands!"

When Wukong heard this his heart blazed with rage. "What fiend is this, that dares behave so outrageously? Tell me the whole of it, and I'll go and hunt him down to avenge you."

The monkeys kowtowed. "We report to the Great King: the wretch calls himself the Monstrous King of Havoc, and dwells away to the due north."

"How far is it from here to his place?" asked Wukong.

"When he comes, it's on cloud," said the monkeys; "when he goes, it's on mist—now wind, now rain, now lightning, now thunder. We have no idea how far it is."

"If that's so," said Wukong, "then never fear; just go on with your play, and let me go and hunt him out."

Splendid Monkey King! He drew his body together, leapt up and away, and went tumbling somersault after somersault straight to the north to look about him. There he saw a high mountain, truly steep and perilous in the extreme. A fine mountain:

Brush-tip peaks standing sheer, winding ravines
sunk deep. The brush-tip peaks stand sheer,
piercing the empty sky; the winding ravines sink
deep, leading down to Earth's own gate. On the two
cliffs, flowers and trees vie in their splendor; in
many a place, pine and bamboo contend in their
green. On the left, the dragons—tame and docile;
on the right, the tigers—crouching low and still.
Here one often sees the iron ox at plough, and there
are ever golden coins for the planting. The hidden
birds sing sweet and clear; the cinnabar phoenix
stands facing the sun. The rocks lie jagged, the
waters lie clear— strange and uncanny, fierce and
forbidding indeed. Famous mountains in the world
are past all counting, where the flowers bloom and
fade and crowd again in throngs; but how can they
match this scene that endures forever, through the
eight festivals and four seasons utterly unmoved?
Truly it is the Source-Pit Mountain of the Three

Realms, the nourishing Water-Viscera Cave of the Five Phases.

The Handsome Monkey King was silently taking in the scenery when he heard the sound of someone speaking, and went straight down the mountain to seek it out. There, before the sheer cliff, was the Water-Viscera Cave. Outside its gate several little imps were dancing about; the moment they saw Wukong they took to their heels. "Stop!" said Wukong. "Lend me the speech of your mouths, that I may carry word of what's in my heart. I am the Lord of the Water Curtain Cave on the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit, in the due south. What is this Monstrous King of Havoc of yours, who has so many times bullied my children and grandchildren? I have come on purpose to seek him out and settle accounts with him face to face."

When the little imps heard this they rushed pell-mell into the cave to report: "Great King! Disaster!"

"What disaster?" asked the Fiend King.

"Outside the cave," said the imps, "there's a monkey-head who calls himself the Lord of the Water Curtain Cave on the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit. He says you have bullied his children and grandchildren time and again, and he's come on purpose to seek you out and have it out with you face to face."

The Fiend King laughed. "I've often heard those monkey-spirits say they had a Great King who'd gone off to leave home and cultivate the Way. So he's come back at last. How is he got up? What weapons does he carry?"

"He has no weapon at all," said the imps. "His head is bare; he wears a single robe of red, with a yellow sash bound about him, and on his feet a

pair of black boots. Neither monk nor layman, and not like a Taoist or an immortal either—bare-handed and empty-fisted, he's shouting outside the gate."

When the Fiend King heard this he said: "Fetch me my armor and weapons." The little imps brought them out at once.

The Fiend King donned his armor and helmet, grasped his saber in his hand, and came out the gate with his horde of imps. At once he cried out in a loud voice: "Which of you is the Lord of the Water Curtain Cave?" Wukong opened his eyes wide and looked, and beheld the Fiend King:

On his head an iron-black helmet, gleaming in the sun; over his body a black gauze robe, fluttering in the wind. Below he wore black iron armor, bound tight with leather thongs; on his feet, patterned pleated boots—mighty as a great commander. Round the waist, ten spans broad; in stature, three rods tall. In his hand he gripped a saber, its edge most keen and bright. Styled the Monster of Havoc—a bold and savage figure.

The Monkey King roared: "You wretched fiend, with eyes so big—and yet you can't see Old Monkey!"

The Fiend King looked at him and laughed: "You're not four feet tall, you're not thirty years old, and you've not so much as a weapon in your

hand. How dare you be so wild and reckless as to come seeking me out to have it out?"

Wukong cursed him: "You wretched fiend, so you're blind after all! You reckon me small, but to make myself big is no hard thing. You reckon me without a weapon, but these two hands of mine can hook down the moon at the sky's edge! Never fear—just take a punch from Old Monkey!" With a spring he leapt up and struck straight at the fiend's face. The Fiend King put up his hand to ward it off and said: "You're such a runt, and I'm so big and tall; if you mean to use your fists while I mean to use my saber, cutting you down with my blade would only set folk laughing. Let me lay down the saber and try a round of fists with you."

"Well said," replied Wukong. "Now there's a brave fellow—come on, then!" The Fiend King let go his guard and struck out, and Wukong bored straight in, grappling and trading blows. The two of them punched and kicked, charging and ramming. A long reach is hollow and unwieldy, but short clinching blows are firm and sure. The Fiend King found Wukong digging at his short ribs and ramming into his groin, and after a few cracks at his joints he was badly battered. He dodged aside, snatched up his broad steel saber, and slashed straight down at Wukong's head. Wukong whipped his body away, and the stroke cut empty air. Seeing how fierce the fiend was, Wukong now used the Body-Outside-the-Body method: he plucked a fistful of hairs, threw them into his mouth and chewed them to bits, then spat them out into the air with a cry of "Change!" At once they became two or three hundred little monkeys, clustering all around.

For when one attains the immortal body, his spirit issues forth in transformations without measure. Now since this Monkey King had won the Way, there were upon his body eighty-four thousand hairs, and every single one of them could transform, answering to the need at the bidding

of his mind. Those little monkeys, sharp-eyed and nimble at leaping, dodged the saber when it came and could not be wounded by the spear when it thrust. Watch them now, springing forward and leaping back, boring in and swarming up, surrounding the Fiend King: some hugged him, some hauled at him, some ducked into his groin, some grabbed at his legs, kicking and pummeling, plucking his hairs, gouging at his eyes, pinching his nose, hoisting him up and tumbling him about, beating him into one writhing heap. In that moment Wukong managed to wrest away the fiend's saber, parted his little monkeys, and brought it down full on the crown of the fiend's head, cleaving him into two halves. Then he led his band charging into the cave and wiped out every last fiend, great and small. He shook his hairs and gathered them back onto his body—and then he saw that some could not be gathered back, and these were the little monkeys the Fiend King had carried off from the Water Curtain Cave.

"How did you come to be here?" asked Wukong. There were some thirty to fifty of them, and they all said through their tears: "After the Great King went off to cultivate immortality, that wretch made trouble these past two years and snatched us all away here. And aren't these the household goods from our own cave? Our stone basins and stone bowls were all carried off by him."

"If they are our household goods," said Wukong, "then move them all out." Then he set a fire blazing in the cave and burned the Water-Viscera Cave dry to a cinder, reducing it all to ruin. He said to them: "All of you, follow me home."

"Great King," said the monkeys, "when we came, we only heard the wind whistling in our ears, and we drifted hazily to this place; we never learned the road. How are we to get home again?"

"That's just a magic art he worked," said Wukong. "What's hard about it? Now that one aperture in me is open, all hundred apertures are open, and I too can work it. Close your eyes, all of you, and don't be afraid."

Splendid Monkey King! He recited the words of a spell, summoned a wild gale, and brought his cloud-head down to earth. "Children, open your eyes," he called. The monkeys set their feet on solid ground, recognized it for their own homeland, and every one of them rejoiced, all racing for the old path to the cave-mouth. The monkeys that had stayed in the cave came crowding out together to meet them, and they all went in, ranked themselves in order of age, and bowed in homage to the Monkey King. They set out wine and fruit to welcome him back and offer congratulations, and asked about the matter of subduing the fiend and rescuing their young. Wukong told them the whole of it in full detail, and the monkeys praised him without end, saying: "Great King, who would have thought that, going off to that far place, you would return with such powers!"

Then Wukong said: "When I parted from you in those days, I followed the waves and drifted with the current, blown across the great Eastern Ocean to the borders of the Southern Continent of Jambu. There I learned to take on human form, put on these clothes and wore these boots, and swaggered and roamed about the clouds for eight or nine years and more, yet never found the Way. Then I crossed the great Western Ocean to the borders of the Western Continent of Cattle-Gift, and after long inquiry I had the good fortune to meet an old patriarch, who passed me the true and fruitful art of being coeval with Heaven, the great gateway of deathless eternal life."

The monkeys offered their congratulations, all saying: "Such fortune is not to be met with in ten thousand ages!"

Wukong laughed again: "Little ones, here's another happy thing—every one of this clan of ours now has a surname."

"What is the Great King's surname?" asked the monkeys.

"My surname now is Sun," said Wukong, "and my religious name is Wukong."

When the monkeys heard this they clapped their hands in delight, crying: "The Great King is the Elder Sun, and we are all the second Suns, the third Suns, the little Suns, the small Suns — a whole family of Suns, a whole nation of Suns, a whole nest of Suns!" And they all came forward to wait upon the Elder Sun, with great basins and little bowls of coconut wine and grape wine, immortal flowers and immortal fruits — truly the whole household made merry together. Ah!

Threaded through into a single surname, the self returns to its root, awaiting only the glorious rise — a name on the immortal rolls.

But after all, there is no knowing how it will all turn out, nor how his sojourn in this realm will end from first to last. Listen to the explanation in the next chapter.

Chapter 3: The Four Seas and a Thousand Mountains Bow in Submission

Now, the Handsome Monkey King had returned in glory to his native mountain. Having destroyed the Demon of Havoc and carried off a great

broadsword, he spent his days drilling his followers in the arts of war. He set the little monkeys to cutting bamboo for spears and whittling wood for blades; they fashioned banners and pennants, blew whistles for signals, advanced and retreated on command, pitched camp and raised stockades, and amused themselves at this for a long while.

Then one day, sitting quietly, the King fell to brooding. "Here we are at our games," he said to himself, "but I fear that play may turn to earnest. We may yet disturb some human king, or some Lord of Birds or Lord of Beasts may take offense and say that we are mustering troops in rebellion. They would raise an army and come to slay us — and with your bamboo poles and wooden swords, how could you meet such a foe? We must have keen swords and sharp halberds before we are safe. What is to be done?"

When the monkeys heard this, every one of them was alarmed. "Your Majesty sees far ahead," they said, "but there is nowhere we can obtain such weapons." As they spoke, four old monkeys stepped forward — two bare-rumped roan-apes and two long-armed gibbons — and came before him. "Your Majesty," they said, "to procure sharp weapons is not so difficult a thing." "How is it not difficult?" asked Wukong.

"East of our mountain," answered the four, "across two hundred miles of water, lies the kingdom of Aolai. In that land there is a throne, and within its walls are soldiers and citizens beyond counting — surely there must be smiths who work in gold and silver, copper and iron. If Your Majesty were to go there, you might buy or commission whatever weapons you please; then you could train us properly and guard our mountain stronghold. Truly that would be the way to lasting peace and security." Wukong was filled with delight. "You stay here at your sport," he said, "while I go and return."

Good Monkey King! He leapt at once onto his somersault cloud and in an instant had crossed two hundred miles of water. There indeed he saw a walled city, with six avenues and three markets, ten thousand households and a thousand gates, the people coming and going freely beneath the open sky. Wukong thought to himself, "There must be ready-made weapons here. I could go down and buy a few — but it would be better still to use a little magic and simply help myself."

So he made the magic sign and recited a spell, drew in a breath toward the southeast quarter, and blew it out in one great puff. At once a wind arose, flinging sand and rolling stones — a fearsome thing indeed:

Where the cannon-clouds rise, heaven and earth are shaken; Black mists and gloomy fogs darken all the land. Waves churn the rivers and seas till fish and crabs cower; Trees snap in the mountain woods, and tigers and wolves take flight. In every trade no merchant or traveler stirs; In every walk of life not a soul is seen. The king upon his hall withdraws to his inner court; Before the steps, civil and martial officers scatter to their offices. The age-old treasure-thrones are all blown over, And the lofty Five-Phoenix Tower rocks to its very roots.

Where the wind blew, it scattered the king of Aolai in terror; through the three streets and six markets, every household slammed its gates and barred its doors, and no one dared walk abroad. Only then did Wukong bring down his cloud and stride straight in through the palace gates, making his way directly to the armory and weapons-stores. He threw open the doors and looked inside — arms beyond number met his eyes: sabers and spears, swords and halberds, axes and battle-axes, pikes and sickles, whips and rakes, bludgeons and maces, bows and crossbows, forks and lances — every kind complete.

Delighted at the sight, he said, "How many can one man carry? Better to use my body-dividing magic and move the lot." Good Monkey King! He plucked out a handful of his hairs, chewed them to bits in his mouth, and spat them out, reciting a spell and crying, "Change!" At once they became hundreds upon hundreds of little monkeys, all snatching and grabbing in a great tumult — the strong ones taking five or seven pieces, the weaker ones two or three — until they had cleared the place out entirely. Then he mounted his cloud, worked a summoning spell, called up the wild wind, and led his little monkeys back to their home.

Now the monkeys great and small of the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit were just then sporting outside the cave entrance when suddenly they heard the wind howling and saw the air filled with a dense, boundless swarm of monkey-spirits swooping and tumbling overhead. Frightened, they all scattered helter-skelter and hid. In a moment the Handsome Monkey King set down his cloud, gathered up the mists, shook his body, and recovered his hairs. The weapons he heaped in a great pile before the mountain and called out, "Little ones, come and take your arms!"

When the monkeys looked and saw Wukong standing alone on the open ground, they all came running to kowtow and ask what had happened. Wukong told them the whole story of how he had raised the wild wind

and carried off the weapons. When the monkeys had finished thanking him, they all rushed to grab sabers and seize swords, to snatch axes and fight over spears, to draw bows and bend crossbows — shouting and bawling, they made sport of it the whole day long.

The next day they formed up the camp as before. Wukong assembled the whole host of monkeys, and they numbered more than forty-seven thousand. This roused all the monstrous beasts of the mountain — wolves and serpents, tigers and leopards, river-deer and roe-deer, muntjac and elk, foxes and wildcats, badgers and raccoon-dogs, lions and elephants, lion-mastiffs and orangutans, bears and stags, wild boars and mountain oxen, antelopes and blue rhinoceros, cunning hares and divine hounds — every sort of monster-king. There were seventy-two caves of them in all, and they came one and all to pay homage to the Monkey King as their sovereign. Year by year they offered tribute, and four times a season they reported for muster. Some drilled with the ranks; some levied grain by the seasons. Trim and orderly, they made of the whole Mountain of Flowers and Fruit something like an iron cauldron — a fortress of gold. The monster-kings of every quarter, moreover, brought gongs and drums, bright banners, helmets and armor; in a busy bustle they practiced their drills and mustered their forces day after day.

The Handsome Monkey King was rejoicing in all this when he suddenly said to the assembly, "You are now well-versed in bow and crossbow and skilled with your weapons. But this saber of mine is truly clumsy and ill-suited to my hand. What is to be done?" The four old monkeys came forward and addressed him: "Your Majesty is an immortal sage, and common weapons are not fit for your use. We wonder, though — can Your Majesty travel beneath the water?"

"Since I came to know the Way," said Wukong, "I have mastered the seventy-two earthly transformations, and my somersault cloud has

boundless power. I am skilled in the arts of vanishing and concealment, in raising spells and summoning spells. To Heaven there is a road for me, and into the Earth there is a gate; I walk under sun and moon and cast no shadow; I pass through metal and stone without hindrance; water cannot drown me, fire cannot burn me. Is there anywhere I cannot go?"

"If Your Majesty has such powers," said the four monkeys, "then beneath this iron-plank bridge of ours the water flows clear through to the Dragon Palace of the Eastern Sea. If Your Majesty would go down there, seek out the old Dragon King, and ask him for a proper weapon — would that not be just what you wish?" Wukong was overjoyed to hear it. "Wait here while I go and return," he said.

Good Monkey King! He sprang to the head of the bridge, worked a water-parting spell, made the magic sign, and with a splash plunged into the waves. Cleaving a path through the water, he went straight down to the floor of the Eastern Ocean. As he traveled along, he suddenly came upon a sea-patrolling yaksha who barred his way and demanded, "What divine being is this, pushing the waters aside? Speak plainly, that I may go and announce you."

"I am Sun Wukong," said Wukong, "the Heaven-born Sage of the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit — your old Dragon King's near neighbor. How is it you do not know me?" When the yaksha heard this, he hurried back to the Crystal Palace and reported: "Your Majesty, outside there is one Sun Wukong, the Heaven-born Sage of the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit. He calls himself Your Majesty's near neighbor and is even now arriving at the palace."

Aoguang, Dragon King of the Eastern Sea, rose at once and came out with his dragon sons and dragon grandsons, his shrimp soldiers and crab generals, to receive him. "Come in, honored Immortal, come in!" They

went straight into the palace, and when Wukong had been seated in the place of honor and served tea, the Dragon King asked, "When did the honored Immortal attain the Way? What magic arts did you receive?"

"From the very time of my birth," said Wukong, "I left my home to practice cultivation, and I have won a body that is neither born nor perishing. Lately, because I have been training my children and grandchildren and guarding our mountain caves, I find I have no proper weapon. I have long heard that my worthy neighbor enjoys jeweled halls and coral palaces, and must surely have some divine arms to spare; so I have come expressly to beg one of you."

Hearing this, the Dragon King could hardly refuse. He ordered the perch marshal to fetch a great long-handled saber and present it. "Old Sun does not know how to wield a saber," said Wukong. "I beg you, give me something else." The Dragon King then bade the eel commandant lead the cuttlefish strongmen to carry out a nine-pronged fork. Wukong leapt down, took it in his hands, ran through a few passes, and set it aside. "Light, light — far too light! And it doesn't suit my hand either. I beg you, give me something else."

The Dragon King laughed and said, "Honored Immortal, take a closer look — that fork weighs three thousand six hundred catties!" "It doesn't suit my hand," said Wukong. "It simply doesn't suit my hand." Now the Dragon King grew uneasy, and ordered the carp inspector-general and the bream commander-in-chief to carry out a painted-handle Square-Heaven halberd weighing seven thousand two hundred catties. When Wukong saw it he ran up, took it in his hands, struck a few stances, made a couple of flourishes, then planted it upright in the ground. "Still too light, too light!"

The old Dragon King was thoroughly alarmed by now. "Honored Immortal, this halberd is the heaviest weapon in my entire palace — there is truly nothing else." Wukong laughed: "As the ancients say, 'Never fear that the Dragon King lacks treasures.' Go and search again. If you have anything to my liking, I will pay whatever price you name." "Truly there is nothing more," said the Dragon King.

As they were speaking, the Dragon Mother and the Dragon Daughter slipped out from behind a curtain and said, "Your Majesty, to judge by his appearance this sage is plainly no ordinary being. In our sea treasury there is that piece of divine iron that anchors the bed of the Heavenly River. These last few days it has glowed with brilliant rosy light and given off auspicious vapors — could it be that the thing is destined to come forth now, and has at last met its sage?"

"That," said the Dragon King, "is the rod that the Great Yu used in taming the floods, to measure the depths of rivers and seas — a piece of divine iron. What use could it be to him?" "Never mind whether he can use it," said the Dragon Mother. "Simply give it to him; let him do with it as he likes, so long as we send him out of the palace gate." The old Dragon King agreed, and told Wukong the whole story. "Bring it out and let me see it," said Wukong. The Dragon King waved his hands: "It cannot be lifted or carried — the honored Immortal must come and look at it himself." "Where is it?" asked Wukong. "Lead me to it."

The Dragon King duly guided him into the depths of the sea treasury, and suddenly ten thousand shafts of golden light blazed forth. The Dragon King pointed: "That glowing thing is it." Wukong hitched up his robe and stepped forward, gave it a feel, and found it to be an iron pillar, about as thick as a peck-measure and more than twenty feet long. He grasped it with both hands and heaved with all his might. "Too thick and too long," he said. "It should be a bit shorter and thinner to be of any

use." No sooner had he spoken than the treasure shortened by several feet and grew thinner by a full span. Wukong hefted it again. "Thinner still would be better." And the treasure truly grew thinner by several more degrees.

Wukong was overjoyed. He carried it out of the sea treasury to examine it in full, and found that the two ends were bound with rings of gold while the middle was wrought of solid black iron. Close against one golden band a row of words was engraved, reading: "The As-You-Will Gold-Banded Cudgel — weight, thirteen thousand five hundred catties." His heart rejoiced in secret: "No doubt this treasure does exactly as one wishes." And as he walked along, thinking in his heart and speaking with his mouth and hefting it in his hand, he said, "Shorter and thinner still would be more wonderful yet." By the time he carried it outside, it had shrunk to barely twelve feet long and was no thicker around than a rice bowl.

Just watch him work his magic! Making his flourishes, he came whirling through the Crystal Palace until the old Dragon King quaked with terror, the young dragon sons lost their wits, and the turtles and tortoises, the soft-shells and alligators, all drew in their necks, while the fish and shrimp, the sea-bream and crabs, all hid their heads. Wukong held the treasure in his hand, settled himself upon the dais of the Crystal Palace, and said to the Dragon King with a laugh, "Many thanks, worthy neighbor, for your generosity." "Don't mention it, don't mention it," said the Dragon King.

"This piece of iron is good to use," said Wukong, "but there is one thing more." "What more has the honored Immortal to say?" asked the Dragon King. "If there had been no such iron to begin with, then so be it," said Wukong. "But now that I hold it in my hand and have no fitting clothes upon my body, what's to be done? If you have any armor here, why not

give me a suit as well? I'll thank you for everything together." "That," said the Dragon King, "I truly do not have." "A guest cannot trouble two hosts," said Wukong. "If you haven't any, I certainly won't go out this door." "I beg the honored Immortal to try another sea," said the Dragon King. "Perhaps there it may be found." "Better to sit at one house than trudge round three," said Wukong. "I implore you — find me a suit, by all means." "Truly there is none," said the Dragon King. "If there were, I would certainly present it." "Truly none?" said Wukong. "Then let me try this iron out on you!"

The Dragon King panicked. "Honored Immortal, don't raise your hand, don't raise your hand! Let me see whether my brothers have any, and I'll send you a suit." "Where are your brothers?" asked Wukong. "My brothers," said the Dragon King, "are Aoqin, Dragon King of the Southern Sea; Aoshun, Dragon King of the Northern Sea; and Aorun, Dragon King of the Western Sea." "Old Sun won't go running to them," said Wukong. "As the saying goes, 'Three on credit are no match for two in hand.' I only ask that you make do, high or low, and send me a suit — and that's that."

"There is no need for the honored Immortal to go," said the old Dragon. "I have here an iron drum and a golden bell. Whenever some urgent matter arises, we beat the drum till it thunders and strike the bell till it rings, and my brothers come in an instant." "Then quick — go and beat the drum and strike the bell," said Wukong. And indeed the alligator general went to strike the bell, and the soft-shelled marshal came to beat the drum.

In a little while, roused by the sounding of bell and drum, the three other Dragon Kings arrived in a moment and gathered outside. Said Aoqin, "Elder brother, what urgent matter has come, that you beat the drum and strike the bell?" "Worthy brother," said the old Dragon, "it's hard to say.

There is a Heaven-born Sage of the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit who came this morning and claimed me for a neighbor. He demanded a weapon. I offered him a steel fork — he scorned it as too small; I presented a painted halberd — he scorned it as too light. He took up with his own hands that divine iron that anchors the bed of the Heavenly River and made a few flourishes with it. Now he sits in my palace and demands a suit of armor besides. I have none, so I sounded the bell and beat the drum to summon you, worthy brothers. Have you any armor? Give him a suit and send him out the door, and have done with it."

When Aoqin heard this, he was furious. "Let us brothers call out our troops and seize him — wouldn't that settle it?" "Do not speak of seizing him," said the old Dragon. "Just brush against that iron and you're dead; just graze it and you're done for; touch it and your skin splits; rub against it and your sinews are torn." Said Aorun, Dragon King of the Western Sea, "Second brother must not come to blows with him. Let us simply put together a suit of armor and send him out the door — then we shall draw up a memorial to lay before Heaven, and Heaven itself will execute him." "Well said," agreed Aoshun, Dragon King of the Northern Sea. "I have here a pair of cloud-walking shoes of lotus thread." "And I," said Aorun of the West, "have brought a suit of chain-link golden armor." "And I," said Aoqin of the South, "have a phoenix-winged cap of purple gold."

The old Dragon was delighted, and led them all into the Crystal Palace to present these gifts to Wukong. Wukong put on the golden cap, buckled on the golden armor, and stepped into the cloud-walking shoes, then set his As-You-Will cudgel swinging and fought his way back out, calling to the assembled dragons as he went, "Sorry to trouble you! Sorry to trouble you!" The four Dragon Kings of the Four Seas were greatly

aggrieved, and withdrew to confer about presenting a memorial to Heaven — but of that we shall say no more for now.

Just look at the Monkey King! He parted the waters and came straight back to the head of the iron-plank bridge, bounding up out of the river. There stood the four old monkeys leading the host, all waiting at the bridgeside. Suddenly they saw Wukong leap from the waves without a single drop of water on his body, gleaming golden as he mounted onto the bridge. The monkeys all fell to their knees in awe. "Your Majesty, what splendor! What splendor!" Wukong, his face wreathed in springtime smiles, mounted high upon his throne and stood the iron cudgel upright in the midst of them.

Those foolish monkeys, knowing no better, all came forward to lay hold of the treasure — but it was like dragonflies trying to shake an iron tree; not a hair's breadth could they stir it. One after another they bit their fingers and stuck out their tongues in amazement. "Grandfather! So heavy as this — however did you carry it back?" Wukong stepped up, reached out his hand, and snatched it up in a single grip. He said to them with a laugh, "Everything has its master. This treasure has lain hidden in the sea treasury for who knows how many thousands of years, and it just happened to shine forth in this very year. The Dragon King took it for nothing but a lump of black iron, and called it the divine iron that anchors the bed of the Heavenly River. None of those fellows could so much as lift or carry it, and in the end they had to ask me to go and fetch it myself. At that time the treasure was more than twenty feet long and as thick as a peck-measure. When I gripped it and wished it smaller, it shrank by a good deal; when I told it to be smaller still, it shrank again; and when I commanded it smaller once more, it shrank again. Holding it up to the light to read it, I found a row of words engraved upon it: 'The As-You-Will Gold-Banded Cudgel, thirteen thousand five hundred

catties.' Now all of you stand aside, and watch me make it change once more."

He hefted the treasure in his hand and cried, "Small! Small! Small!" — and at once it dwindled to the size of an embroidery needle, small enough to be tucked away inside his ear. The monkeys cried out in astonishment, "Your Majesty, bring it out again and play with it some more!" The Monkey King took it from his ear and held it on his palm, calling, "Big! Big! Big!" — and at once it grew again to a peck-measure's thickness and twenty feet in length. Carried away with delight, he leapt onto the bridge and strode out of the cave, gripped the treasure in his hand, and worked the magic of taking Heaven for his pattern and Earth for his model. He bent his waist and cried, "Grow!" — and he grew ten thousand fathoms tall, his head like Mount Tai, his waist like a towering ridge, his eyes like flashing lightning, his mouth like a basin of blood, his teeth like swords and halberds; and the cudgel in his hand reached up to the Thirty-Third Heaven above and down to the Eighteenth Hell below. The tigers and leopards, the wolves and serpents, all the monster-throngs of the mountain, and the monster-kings of the seventy-two caves were so terrified that they kowtowed and prostrated themselves in worship, trembling till their wits scattered and their souls flew away. In an instant he withdrew the magic form, turned the treasure back into an embroidery needle, hid it in his ear, and returned to his cave dwelling. The monster-kings of every cave all came rushing in great alarm to pay their respects and offer congratulations.

Then they flung wide the banners and struck up the drums, set the brass gongs ringing, spread out a lavish feast of rare delicacies, and filled the cups brimming with coconut wine and grape liquor. They drank and feasted with the whole host for a long while, and afterward took up their drilling as before. The Monkey King appointed the four old monkeys as

his stalwart commanders: the two bare-rumped roan-apes he named Marshal Ma and Marshal Liu, and the two long-armed gibbons he named General Beng and General Ba. All matters of pitching camp and raising stockades, of rewards and punishments, he handed over to the four stalwart commanders to manage.

His mind at ease, he passed his days riding the clouds and mounting the mists, roaming the Four Seas and disporting himself among a thousand mountains. He displayed his martial arts and sought out heroes far and wide; he worked his magic and made worthy friends in plenty. At this time he became sworn brothers with six others — the Bull Demon King, the Serpent Demon King, the Roc Demon King, the Lion-Camel King, the Macaque King, and the Marmoset King — making seven in all, counting himself, the Handsome Monkey King. Day after day they discoursed on letters and debated the arts of war, passed the wine-cups and the goblets round, played the strings and sang, piped and danced; off in the morning and back at evening, there was no kind of joy they did not taste. Ten thousand miles of distance they reckoned as no more than the path across a courtyard — as the saying goes, a nod of the head and three thousand miles are crossed, a twist of the waist and eight hundred more are spanned.

One day, in his own cave, he ordered the four stalwart commanders to lay out a banquet and invited the six kings to come and drink. They slaughtered oxen and butchered horses, made sacrifice to Heaven and offerings to Earth, set the monster-throng to dancing and singing, and all drank themselves blind drunk. After seeing the six kings off, he rewarded his officers great and small. Then he reclined in the shade of the pines beside the iron-plank bridge and in a moment fell asleep. The four stalwart commanders led the host in keeping watch around him, not daring to raise their voices.

But in his sleep the Handsome Monkey King saw two men approach carrying a warrant, on which were written the three characters "Sun Wukong." Coming up to his side, they allowed him not a word of protest, slipped a noose about him, and led his very soul away. Stumbling and reeling, he was dragged along until they came to the wall of a great city. The Monkey King gradually felt the wine wearing off, and lifting his head he saw upon the wall an iron placard bearing three great characters: "Region of Darkness." At once the Handsome Monkey King came to himself. "The Region of Darkness is where Yama dwells," he said. "Why have I come here?" The two men replied, "Your span of earthly life is at an end this day; we two have received the warrant and come to summon you."

When the Monkey King heard this, he said, "Old Sun has risen above the Three Realms and stands no longer within the Five Elements. I am no longer subject to his authority — how dare you, blindly and confusedly, come to summon me?" But the two soul-takers only kept tugging and hauling, determined to drag him inside. At this the Monkey King's temper flared. He plucked the treasure from his ear, gave it a shake until it was as thick as a rice bowl, and with one easy lift of his hand beat the two soul-takers to a pulp. He undid his own noose, shook his hands free, and wielding the cudgel came smashing his way into the city. The ox-headed demons fled and dodged east and west; the horse-faced demons ran north and south. The demon underlings rushed up to the Hall of Judgment and reported, "Your Majesties, disaster! Disaster! Outside there is some hairy-faced thunder-god come smashing his way in!"

In a fluster, the Ten Kings of the Underworld hurriedly straightened their robes and came out to look. When they saw how fierce his features were, they at once arranged themselves in their ranks and called out together in loud voices, "Honored Immortal, your name! What is your honored

name?" Said the Monkey King, "Since you do not even know who I am, how is it you sent men to summon me?" The Ten Kings said, "We dare not presume — surely the men we sent were mistaken." Said the Monkey King, "I am Sun Wukong, the Heaven-born Sage of the Water-Curtain Cave on the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit. What official ranks are yours?" The Ten Kings bowed and replied, "We are the Ten Kings of the Underworld, the sovereigns of the world of shades." "Quick, tell me your names," said Wukong, "and spare yourselves a beating." Said the Ten Kings, "We are King Qinguang, King of First Rivers, King of the Song Emperor, King of Revolting Officials, King Yama, King of Equality, King of Mount Tai, King of the Capital City, King of Biancheng, and King of the Turning Wheel."

"Since you have all attained the rank of king," said Wukong, "and are counted among the order of bright and responsive spirits, how is it you do not know good from ill? Old Sun has perfected the way of the immortals; my life-span equals Heaven's; I have risen above the Three Realms and leapt clean out of the Five Elements. Why did you send men to lay hold of me?" "Let not the honored Immortal be wroth," said the Ten Kings. "There are many in all the world who share the same name and surname. Perhaps the soul-taker went astray." "Nonsense! Nonsense!" said Wukong. "As the common saying goes, 'Officials may err and clerks may err, but the man sent on the errand does not err.' Quick, fetch me the Registers of Life and Death, and let me see them!"

The Ten Kings at once invited him up into the hall to examine the records. Wukong, gripping his As-You-Will cudgel, mounted straight up onto the Hall of Judgment and sat himself down in the very center, facing south. The Ten Kings ordered the recording judge in charge of the files to bring out the documents for examination. The judge dared not delay; he went to the records office and brought out five or six bundles of

documents along with the registers of the ten kinds of beings, and went through them one by one. Among the bare-skinned creatures, the hairy creatures, the feathered creatures, the insects, and the scaled and shelled kinds, his name was nowhere to be found. Then they came to the category of monkeys: now this monkey was like a man, yet was not entered among the names of men; like a bare-skinned creature, yet did not dwell within any kingdom; like a running beast, yet was not under the rule of the qilin; like a flying bird, yet was not subject to the phoenix. There was a separate register, and this Wukong examined for himself, until at the number one thousand three hundred and fifty under the character "Soul," he found at last the name of Sun Wukong, set down as follows: "Heaven-born stone monkey; allotted life-span, three hundred and forty-two years; a good and natural death."

"I don't trouble myself to remember how many years my span is," said Wukong. "I'll simply strike out the name and have done." He called for a brush. The judge hastily presented one, well-dipped in thick black ink. Wukong took up the register, and wherever there was a name among the category of monkeys he struck them all out, every one. Then he flung down the register and said, "It is settled! From now on I am no longer under your authority!" And wielding the cudgel all the way, he smashed his way back out of the Region of Darkness. The Ten Kings dared not come near him; they all made their way to the Azure Cloud Palace, joined together in worship before the Bodhisattva Kshitigarbha, and conferred about drawing up a memorial to lay before Heaven — but of that we shall say no more.

As the Monkey King came smashing his way out of the city, he suddenly tripped over a clump of grass and stumbled headlong — and woke with a start. It had all been but a dream of the Southern Branch. Just as he was stretching himself, he heard the four stalwart commanders and the host

of monkeys calling out, "Your Majesty, how much wine did you drink? You have slept the whole night through and still will not wake!" Said Wukong, "Sleeping is a small matter, but in my sleep I dreamed that two men came here to summon me and carried my soul off to the gate of the Region of Darkness. Only as I woke did I come to my senses. There I displayed my powers, shouting my way into the Hall of Judgment, and quarreled with the Ten Kings. I looked over the register of life and death, and wherever there was a name belonging to any of our kind, I struck it out — so now none of us is subject to that fellow's rule any longer!" The monkeys kowtowed and gave thanks. And from that time on, many of the mountain monkeys never grew old — because their names were no longer recorded in the Office of Shades.

When the Handsome Monkey King had finished telling all that had passed, the four stalwart commanders made it known to the monster-kings of every cave, who all came to offer congratulations. Within a few days the six sworn brothers came again to pay their respects, and when they heard the reason the names had been struck off, every one of them rejoiced; day after day they gathered for revels — but of that we shall say no more.

Now let us tell of the Most High Holy and Greatly Merciful Lord, the Jade Emperor, August Sovereign of the Mysterious Vault on high. One day he sat in court upon the precious throne of the Hall of Divine Mists in the Cloud Palace of the Golden Gate, with the immortal officers civil and martial gathered for the morning audience, when suddenly the Perfected One Qiu Hongji came forward and announced, "Your Majesty, outside the Hall of Universal Brightness, Aoguang, Dragon King of the Eastern Sea, has presented a memorial and awaits the Heavenly Lord's summons." The Jade Emperor gave the command: "Let him be summoned in." Aoguang was led to the foot of the Hall of Divine Mists;

when he had finished making his reverences, an immortal page beside the throne took up the memorial and handed it up. The Jade Emperor read it through from the beginning. It read:

"Your subject Aoguang, lowly Dragon of the Eastern Sea of the Eastern Continent of Superior Spirits, in the watery realm of the lower world, makes report to the Great Holy Sovereign, the Most High August Emperor of the Mysterious Vault: Of late, by reason of one Sun Wukong, a monstrous immortal born on the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit and dwelling in the Water-Curtain Cave, your lowly dragon has been bullied and abused. He forced his way into the water-mansion and demanded weapons, working his magic and flaunting his might; he demanded armor, raging in his fierceness and his power. He terrorized the water-tribes and put the turtles and alligators to flight. The Dragon of the Southern Sea quakes with fear; the Dragon of the Western Sea is wretched and miserable; the Dragon of the Northern Sea has bowed his head in surrender. Your subject Aoguang prostrated himself and made obeisance, and presented the divine pearl-iron cudgel, the phoenix-winged golden cap, the chain-link armor, and the cloud-walking shoes, sending him out with all courtesy. Yet still he flourished his martial arts and displayed his powers, crying only, 'Sorry to trouble you! Sorry to trouble you!' Truly he has no equal and is most difficult to control. Your subject now lays this before you, humbly awaiting Your Holiness's decision. I earnestly beg that Heavenly troops be sent to capture this monstrous creature, that the seas and mountains may be made clean and peaceful and the lower realm secure. Respectfully submitted."

When the Holy Emperor had read it through, he gave the command: "Let the Dragon Spirit return to his sea; I shall presently dispatch a general to seize him." The old Dragon King touched his head to the ground in thanks and departed.

Then from below, the Heavenly Master Ge Xianweng came forward and announced, "Your Majesty, there is a memorial sent up from the Underworld by King Qinguang, presented on behalf of the Lord of the Region of Darkness, the Bodhisattva Kshitigarbha." An attendant Jade Maiden took up the memorial and handed it up, and the Jade Emperor likewise read it through from the beginning. It read:

"The Region of Darkness is the shadowy office of the Earth. Heaven has its spirits and Earth has its ghosts; the bright and the dark turn in their cycles. Birds have their birth and beasts their death; male and female alternate in their courses. Life upon life, transformation upon transformation, conceiving daughters and bringing forth sons — this is the order of nature, and may not be altered. But now there is a monstrous monkey, Sun Wukong, born of Heaven in the Water-Curtain Cave on the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit, who works wickedness and commits violence and will not submit to the summons. Working his magic, he beat down the ghostly envoys of the Nine Shades; relying on his might, he terrified and harmed the merciful Kings of the Ten Courts. He made a great uproar in the Hall of Judgment and forcibly struck out the names from the registers, so that the kind of the monkeys is now beyond all restraint, and the breed of macaques live long beyond their span; stillness and the wheel of rebirth alike are undone, and each is freed from life and death. Your poor monk presents this memorial, daring to offend the Heavenly Majesty. I humbly beg that divine troops be dispatched to subdue this monster, to set the bright and the dark in order and bring lasting peace to the realm of shades. Respectfully submitted."

When the Jade Emperor had read it through, he gave the command: "Let the Lord of the Underworld return to the realm of shades; I shall

presently dispatch a general to seize him." King Qinguang likewise touched his head to the ground in thanks and departed.

The Great Heavenly Lord summoned the assembled immortal officers, civil and martial, and asked, "In what year was this monstrous monkey born, and to what age did he live, that he should have attained the Way to such a degree?" Scarcely had he spoken when there stepped forth from the ranks the Thousand-Mile Eye and the Down-the-Wind Ear, who said, "This monkey is the Heaven-born stone monkey of three hundred years ago. At that time he was thought nothing of, and we do not know in what place he has these few years cultivated himself into an immortal, subduing dragons and taming tigers, and forcibly striking out the registers of death." The Jade Emperor asked, "Which divine general shall go down to the lower world to subdue him?"

Scarcely had he spoken when there stepped forth from the ranks the Great White Planet, the Star of Long Geng, who bowed low and announced, "Most Holy One, of all beings in the Three Realms that possess the nine apertures, every one may cultivate immortality. But this monkey is a body nurtured by Heaven and Earth, a form conceived by the sun and the moon; he too treads the earth and bears up the sky; he feeds upon the dew and dines upon the rosy mists. Now that he has perfected the way of immortality and has the power to subdue dragons and tame tigers, in what is he different from a man? Your subject begs Your Majesty, in mindfulness of the merciful grace of all begetting and transformation, to send down an edict of amnesty and recruitment, summoning him up to the upper realm and granting him some office great or small, entering his name upon the rolls and so binding him here. If he accepts the Heavenly command, then afterward he may be promoted and rewarded; if he defies the Heavenly command, then he may be seized on the spot. In this way, first, the host need not be stirred

nor the army wearied; and second, an immortal is gathered in by the way of the Way." The Jade Emperor was greatly pleased and said, "We shall do as our minister proposes." So he ordered the Star Official of Literary Songs to draft the edict, and bade the Great White Planet of Venus carry out the recruitment.

The Planet of Venus received the edict, went out beyond the Southern Heaven Gate, brought down his auspicious cloud, and came straight to the Water-Curtain Cave on the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit. He said to the little monkeys at the entrance, "I am an envoy of Heaven, sent by Heaven, and I have a holy edict here. I ask that your great king come up to the upper realm. Quickly, make it known." The little monkeys outside the cave passed the word layer by layer into the depths of the cave-heaven: "Your Majesty, outside there is an old man carrying a roll of documents on his back, who says he is an envoy sent down by Heaven, and that he has a holy edict inviting you." The Handsome Monkey King was overjoyed to hear it. "These last two days I have just been thinking I'd like to take a trip up to Heaven," he said, "and here is a Heavenly envoy come to invite me!" He called out, "Quick, show him in!"

The Monkey King hastily put his cap and robes in order and went out beyond the gate to welcome him. The Planet of Venus came straight to the center and stood facing south. "I am the Great White Planet of Venus, of the West," he said. "By the Jade Emperor's edict of amnesty and recruitment I have come down to the lower world to invite you up to Heaven, there to receive the immortal rolls and an appointment." Wukong laughed and said, "Many thanks, venerable Star, for descending here." And he ordered the little ones to lay out a banquet to entertain him. "The holy edict is upon me," said the Planet; "I dare not linger long. I beg the great king to come along with me; once you have won your glorious advancement, there will be time enough at leisure for talk." "It is

an honor that you have called," said Wukong. "I am sorry to send you off empty-handed — sorry to send you off empty-handed." At once he summoned the four stalwart commanders and charged them: "Carefully train my children and grandchildren. Let me go up to Heaven and take a look at the road, and presently I'll bring you all up there to dwell together with me." The four stalwart commanders gave their assent.

Then the Monkey King and the Planet of Venus mounted their clouds and rose into the heights of the empyrean. Truly it was a case of:

Raised high to the rank of an immortal of the upper grade, His name set down in the cloud-borne ranks and the precious rolls.

But as to what office and what rank he was to receive — that you shall hear told in the next chapter.

Chapter 4: A Stable-Keeper's Title Cannot Content Him; The Great Sage Raises Heaven's Banner

The Great White Planet Star and the Handsome Monkey King came out together from the deepest recesses of the cave-heaven and rose into the air on a single cloud. Now Wukong's somersault cloud was unlike any other — wondrously swift — so that he left the Planet Star trailing far behind and arrived first outside the Southern Gate of Heaven. Just as he was about to gather in his cloud and press forward, the Heavenly King

Virūḍhaka, at the head of his mighty heavenly soldiers — Pang, Liu, Gou, Bi, Deng, Xin, Zhang, and Tao — with spears, swords, sabers, and halberds, blocked the gate of Heaven and would not let him pass.

"This old Planet Star is a treacherous fellow!" cried the Monkey King. "He invited me, old Monkey, himself — so why has he set men to brandishing blade and spear and barring the road?"

While he was still bawling, the Planet Star arrived in a flash. Wukong rounded on him at once, fierce-faced. "You old fellow — how dare you cozen me? You told me you came at the Jade Emperor's command to summon me to amnesty and office. So why have these men blocked the gate of Heaven and refused to let old Monkey in?"

The Planet Star laughed. "Calm your anger, Great King. You have never before come to this celestial palace; your name is not yet registered, and these heavenly soldiers have never made your acquaintance. How could they let you barge in as you pleased? Once you have seen the Celestial Venerable, received your immortal scroll, and had your office recorded, you may come and go thereafter as you wish — and who would dare block you then?"

"In that case," said Wukong, "never mind — I won't go in."

But the Planet Star caught hold of him by the hand. "You shall go in together with me."

As they neared the gate of Heaven, the Planet Star called out in a loud voice: "Gatekeepers and heavenly generals, officers and soldiers great and small — clear the way! This is an immortal from the lower world. I bear the Jade Emperor's sacred decree and have summoned him hither."

Only then did Heavenly King Virūḍhaka and his soldiers draw back their weapons and stand aside. Now at last the Monkey King believed the old

man's words, and step by step he passed within alongside the Planet Star, taking in all he saw. And truly it was a sight to behold:

First treading the upper realm, at last entering Heaven's hall. Ten thousand strands of golden light come rolling in red rainbow, a thousand wisps of auspicious vapor breathe forth a purple mist. See the Southern Gate of Heaven: deep-shining azure, wrought all of lapis glaze; dazzling bright, adorned with precious jade. On either side stand rows of marshals who guard the sky, each a pillar bearing the roof-beam, gripping ax-head, clasping standard; on all sides line a dozen gods in golden mail, each one holding halberd, swinging whip, bearing saber, leaning on sword. The outer courts are striking enough; within, the sight astounds. Along the inner walls rise great columns wound about with red-bearded dragons whose golden scales blaze in the sun; and there are long bridges where phoenixes with painted plumes and crimson crests wheel up into the void. Bright sunset clouds reflect the light of Heaven; emerald mists, dense and dim, veil the mouth of the Dipper. Here in the heavens are thirty-

three celestial palaces — the Cloud-Dispatching, the Vaiśravaṇa, the Five Brilliances, the Palace of the Sun, the Palace of Flower and Joy — palace upon palace, each roof-ridge crowned with gold-swallowing beasts; and there are seventy-two layered treasure-halls — the Hall of Court Assembly, the Hall of Soaring Void, the Hall of Precious Light, the Hall of the Heavenly Kings, the Hall of the Numinous Officers — hall upon hall, each pillar ranged with jade unicorns. On the Terrace of the Star of Longevity bloom famous flowers that have not faded in a thousand thousand years; beside the elixir-refining furnace grow embroidered grasses evergreen through ten thousand thousand ages. Before the Tower of Sage-Audience: robes of crimson gauze, bright as scattered stars; caps like hibiscus, gleaming with gold and jade; jade pins and pearled slippers, purple sashes and golden seals. When the golden bell is struck, the spirits of the Three Bureaus bear their

memorials up the vermilion steps; when the heavenly drum sounds, ten thousand saints pay court and worship the Jade Emperor. And at the Numinous Empyrean Treasure-Hall: golden studs stud the jade doors, painted phoenixes dance on the vermilion gates. Galleries and winding corridors, everywhere exquisite, carved through and through; triple eaves in fourfold clusters, tier upon tier where dragons and phoenixes soar. Above sits a great golden gourd-shaped dome, towering and purple, dazzling and bright, rounded and gleaming, blazing with light. Below, heavenly consorts hold up their fans, jade maidens bear immortal kerchiefs; fierce-eyed heavenly generals manage the court, spirited noble immortals guard the throne. In the very center, on a tray of lapis glaze, lie pile upon pile of Grand Monad elixirs; in agate vases stand sprigs of coral trees, curling and twisting. Indeed — every rare thing of the heavenly palace is here; not one of these has the world below. Golden towers, silver

chariots, and the purple courts, jade flowers, gem-grasses, and blossoms of fine jade. By the altar where the Jade Hare grinds, the worshipers pass; beneath where the saints gather, the Golden Crow flies low. The Monkey King is fated to come to Heaven's realm, not to be stained with the muddy dust of the mortal world.

The Great White Planet Star led the Handsome Monkey King to the outer reaches of the Numinous Empyrean Hall and, without waiting for the summons to be announced, went straight up before the throne and bowed in homage. Wukong stood stiffly to one side, offering no obeisance whatever, but cocked his ear to listen as the Planet Star made his report.

"Your servant, in obedience to the sacred decree," the Planet Star announced, "has summoned the demon-immortal, and here he is."

The Jade Emperor lowered the screen and asked, "Which is the demon-immortal?"

Only then did Wukong bow from the waist and answer, "That'd be old Monkey here."

The noble immortals all went pale with astonishment. "This wild ape! Why does he not prostrate himself and pay homage, but dares to answer so — 'That'd be old Monkey here'? He deserves to die! He deserves to die!"

But the Jade Emperor handed down his command. "This Sun Wukong is a demon-immortal of the lower world, only newly come into human form; he does not know the rites of court. Let his offense be pardoned for now."

The noble immortals all cried, "We thank you for your grace." And the Monkey King, at last, made a great long bow toward the throne.

The Jade Emperor summoned the immortal officers of civil and military appointments to find whatever post stood vacant, that Sun Wukong might be installed in it. From the ranks the Star Lord of Wuqu stepped forward and reported, "In all the palaces and halls of the heavenly court, in every quarter and every region, there is no shortage of officers — save that the Imperial Stable lacks a chief to manage its affairs."

The Jade Emperor handed down his command. "Then let him be made a BanMaWen — a Keeper of the Horses." The assembled ministers cried their thanks, and he too merely made a great long bow toward the throne. The Jade Emperor then dispatched the Star Officer of the Wood Virtue to escort him to the Imperial Stable to take up his post.

The Monkey King went off cheerfully with the Star Officer of the Wood Virtue and arrived directly at his new station; the matter settled, the Star Officer returned to his palace. There in the stable Wukong assembled the deputy directors, the assistant directors, the registrar, the grooms, and all the officers and men great and small, examined the affairs of the office, and found that there were just a thousand heavenly horses in his care. They were:

Hualiu and Qiji, Lu'er and Xianli; Longmei and
Ziyan, the wing-hung Sushuang; Jueti and Yinhua,
Yaoniao and Feihuang; Taotu the feather-turner,
Chitu that outraces light; Yuhui and Mijing, mist-
leaping Shenghuang; Wind-chaser, Earth-render,
Skyward-flying steeds; swift as the red lightning, the
Bronze Sparrow that floats on cloud; the dappled,
the dragon-marked, the dust-leaving Zilin — the
great steeds of Dayuan from the four corners of the
earth, the eight chargers and the nine fleet ones,
coursers that leave the herd a thousand li behind.
Such fine horses, each and every one, neigh at the
wind and chase the lightning, strong of spirit; tread
the mist and mount the clouds, long of strength.

The Monkey King examined the ledgers and checked the count of the horses. Within his office, the registrar managed the requisition and provision of fodder; the groom-officers managed the currying and washing of the horses, the cutting of grass, the watering, and the boiling of feed; the deputy and assistant directors helped urge the work along. The Keeper of the Horses neither slept by day nor by night, but tended his charges without rest. By daylight there was sport enough; but at night he watched over them with tireless diligence — rousing any horse

that lay sleeping to feed it grass, catching back any that strayed and tying it fast to the trough. The heavenly horses, when they saw him, laid back their ears and drew in their hooves, so well-kept that every one grew sleek and fat. A good half-month slipped by without his marking it.

One day, at leisure, all the officers of the stable arranged a banquet — partly to welcome him, partly to congratulate him. In the midst of the merry drinking, the Monkey King suddenly set down his cup and asked, "This BanMaWen of mine — what rank of office is it?"

"The title is just that — Keeper of the Horses," they said.

"And what grade does this office hold?" he asked again.

"It has no grade at all," they said.

"No grade?" said the Monkey King. "I suppose that means it is exalted beyond all measure."

"Not great, not great," they said. "It is merely called 'unranked.'"

"What do you mean by 'unranked'?" asked the Monkey King.

"The very bottom," they said. "An office like this is the lowest and smallest of all — fit only for looking after horses. Even after Your Honor took up the post and tended so diligently that the horses grew fat, all you'll earn is a single word of praise. Should they fall the least bit thin and weak, you'll be called to account; and should they suffer any serious harm, you'll be fined, made to pay restitution, and charged with the crime."

When the Monkey King heard this, fire flared up in his heart, and he ground his teeth in great fury. "So this is how they slight old Monkey! On my Flower-Fruit Mountain I am hailed as king and patriarch — and they've gulled me into coming here to tend their horses for them! Horse-

tending is the base drudgery of low-born striplings — is that any way to treat the likes of me? I'll not do it, I'll not do it! I'm off!"

With a clatter he overturned the official desk, drew his treasure from his ear, gave it a shake until it was as thick as a rice-bowl, and with a flourish of fighting moves battled his way clear out of the Imperial Stable and straight to the Southern Gate of Heaven. The heavenly soldiers, knowing he had received an immortal scroll and held the post of Keeper of the Horses, dared not stop him, and let him fight his way out through the gate.

In a moment he pressed down the head of his cloud and returned to Flower-Fruit Mountain. There he saw his Four Mighty Generals and the demon kings of the various caves drilling their troops. The Monkey King called out in a ringing voice, "Little ones — old Monkey is back!" The whole crowd of monkeys came rushing to kowtow before him and welcomed him into the deep recesses of the cave-heaven, urging him to ascend his treasure-seat, while on one side they laid out wine to celebrate his homecoming.

"Congratulations, Great King!" they all cried. "You went up to the upper realm for a dozen years or more — surely you've come home in triumph and high content?"

"I've been gone scarcely a half-month," said the Monkey King. "How could it be a dozen years?"

"Great King," said the monkeys, "up in Heaven one takes no notice of the passing hours. One day in Heaven is a whole year in the world below. May we ask what office the Great King held?"

The Monkey King waved his hand dismissively. "Don't speak of it, don't speak of it — it shames a fellow to death! That Jade Emperor doesn't

know how to use a man. He looked old Monkey over and made me some sort of 'BanMaWen' — which turns out to be a horse-keeper, the kind of post that doesn't even rank in the grades. When I first took it up I didn't know any better, and just amused myself about the Imperial Stable. But today I asked my colleagues, and only then learned how base and lowly it was. My heart was sorely vexed — I overturned the banquet table, refused the title, and so came back down here."

"Welcome, welcome!" cried the monkeys. "Great King, being king in this blessed land and cave-heaven of ours is honor and pleasure beyond measure — why should you go and play groom for him?" And they ordered the little ones to fetch wine quickly, to dispel the Great King's gloom.

In the very midst of this merry drinking, someone came in to report: "Great King, outside the gate are two One-Horned Demon Kings who wish to see Your Majesty."

"Show them in," said the Monkey King.

The Demon Kings straightened their robes, ran into the cave, threw themselves down, and bowed.

"What is your business with me?" the Handsome Monkey King asked them.

"Long have we heard that the Great King seeks out men of worth," said the Demon Kings, "but we found no way to gain an audience. Now that we see the Great King has received the heavenly scroll and come home in triumph, we have brought a robe of russet-yellow as a gift to mark the occasion. If you will not scorn us as base and mean, but take us into your service, we too may render you the labor of dog and horse."

The Monkey King was overjoyed and put on the russet-yellow robe at once. The others gladly fell into ranks to do him homage, and he appointed the Demon Kings then and there to be Vanguard Commanders of the Front Division. The Demon Kings gave their thanks, then spoke again: "The Great King was in Heaven a long while — what office were you granted?"

"The Jade Emperor makes light of the worthy," said the Monkey King, "and named me some sort of 'BanMaWen.'"

When the Demon Kings heard this, they came forward once more. "With supernatural powers such as yours, Great King, why should you tend his horses? Why not proclaim yourself 'Great Sage Equal to Heaven'? What is there to stop you?"

When the Monkey King heard this, his delight knew no bounds. "Good! Good! Good!" he cried, again and again. He ordered the Four Mighty Generals: "Quickly set up a banner for me, and on the banner write the four great words 'GREAT SAGE EQUAL TO HEAVEN.' Raise the pole and hang it out. From this day forward, call me only the Great Sage Equal to Heaven, and never again 'Great King.' Let word of this go out to the demon kings of all the caves as well, that all may know." But of this no more for now.

Now the Jade Emperor held court the following day, and there came Heavenly Master Zhang, leading the deputy and assistant directors of the Imperial Stable, who bowed at the foot of the vermilion steps and reported: "Your Majesty, the newly appointed BanMaWen, Sun Wukong, disdaining the smallness of his office, fled the heavenly palace yesterday in revolt." Even as they spoke, there came also from outside the Southern Gate the Heavenly King Virūḍhaka with his soldiers, who likewise

reported: "The BanMaWen, for reasons unknown, has fled out through the gate of Heaven."

When the Jade Emperor heard this, he straightway handed down his command: "Let the spirits of both reports return each to his proper duty. We shall dispatch heavenly soldiers to capture this monster." From the ranks stepped forth the Pagoda-Bearing Heavenly King Li and his third son, the Prince Nezha, who came forward and memorialized: "Your Majesty, though your servants are without talent, we beg the decree to subdue this monster." The Jade Emperor was greatly pleased, and at once made the Pagoda-Bearing Heavenly King Li Jing the Demon-Quelling Grand Marshal, and the third Prince Nezha the Great Spirit of the Three Altars and the Ocean Assembly, bidding them raise their host and descend to the lower world without delay.

Heavenly King Li and Nezha kowtowed their thanks, took their leave, and went straight to their own palace, where they mustered their three armies and their captains. They named the Mighty Magic Spirit as vanguard, the Fish-Belly General as rearguard, and the Yaksha General to urge the troops along. In an instant they passed out through the Southern Gate and came straight to Flower-Fruit Mountain. Choosing a level open place, they pitched their camp, and the order went forth for the Mighty Magic Spirit to issue the challenge.

Receiving the command, the Mighty Magic Spirit girt himself in good order, swung up his patterned battle-ax, and came to the mouth of the Water-Curtain Cave. There outside the little cave-gate were many demons and monsters — all manner of wolves and serpents, tigers and leopards — in jagged ranks, brandishing spears and whirling swords, leaping and snarling in combat-play. The Mighty Magic Spirit shouted: "You cursed beasts! Hurry and report to your BanMaWen: I am a great general of the upper heavens, come by the Jade Emperor's decree to

subdue him. Tell him to come out at once and submit, lest you all be hacked to pieces."

The monsters went scrambling and stumbling to spread the word within the cave. "Disaster! Disaster!"

"What disaster?" asked the Monkey King.

"Outside the gate," said the demons, "is a heavenly general who calls out your title of 'BanMaWen,' and says he comes by the Jade Emperor's decree to subdue you. He bids you come out quickly to surrender, and so spare our lives."

When the Monkey King heard this, he called for his armor. He set the purple-gold cap on his head, donned the golden mail, slipped on his cloud-treading shoes, took the As-You-Will Golden-Banded Cudgel in hand, and led his host out through the gate, drawing up his battle-line. The Mighty Magic Spirit opened his eyes wide and gazed: a fine Monkey King indeed —

His body clad in golden mail, gleaming and bright;
on his head a golden cap, light flashing forth. In his
hand he raises a golden-banded cudgel; on his feet,
cloud-shoes that match it well. A pair of strange
eyes like bright stars; two ears that pass his
shoulders, keen and hard. Straight and tall, of many
transformations; his voice rings clear as bell and
chiming-stone. Sharp-mouthed, jutting-toothed
BanMaWen — high-hearted, he would be the Great
Sage Equal to Heaven.

The Mighty Magic Spirit cried out in a stern voice, "You insolent ape! Do you know who I am?"

The Great Sage turned sharp eyes upon him. "What hairy little spirit are you, and from what quarter? Old Monkey has never met you. Give me your name, and be quick about it."

"I'll have you yet, you deceitful baboon!" said the Mighty Magic Spirit. "You don't know me? I am the Mighty Magic Heavenly General, vanguard of the Pagoda-Bearing Heavenly King Li of the High Numinous Empyrean, come by the Jade Emperor's decree to subdue you. Strip off your gear at once and submit to Heaven's grace, lest all the beasts of this mountain be put to the sword. Breathe half a word of refusal, and I'll grind you to powder in an instant."

When the Monkey King heard this, great rage rose in his heart. "Foul hairy spirit! Don't boast so loudly or wag so long a tongue. I had a mind to strike you dead with a single blow of my cudgel — but then there'd be no one to carry the message. So I'll spare your life: hurry back to Heaven and tell the Jade Emperor that he sorely fails to use the worthy. Old Monkey has boundless powers — why does he set me to tending his horses? Look at the words on my banner there: if he'll promote me according to that title, I'll lay down my weapons and Heaven and earth will of themselves be at peace. But if he won't, I'll come straight up and beat upon the Numinous Empyrean Treasure-Hall, and he'll not sit easy upon his dragon-throne!"

When the Mighty Magic Spirit heard this, he squinted against the wind and looked — and there indeed, outside the gate, stood a tall pole, and on the pole a banner, and on the banner the four great words "GREAT SAGE EQUAL TO HEAVEN." The Mighty Magic Spirit gave three cold laughs. "This insolent ape! So utterly ignorant of his place, so brazenly without manners — you would be a Great Sage Equal to Heaven? Then taste this ax of mine!" And he hacked straight at the Monkey King's head.

But the Monkey King, being a master of the art, was in no haste; he met the ax squarely with his Golden-Banded Cudgel, weapon answering weapon. And this was a fine fight:

The cudgel named As-You-Will, the ax called Patterned-Blossom. The two of them, meeting for the first time, knew not each other's depth. Ax and cudgel crossed left and right. One concealed a marvelous craft; the other boasted with a great loud mouth. Wielding their arts, they breathed out cloud and mist; spreading their hands, they scattered earth and flung the sand. The heavenly general had his powers and his way, but the Monkey King's transformations were truly without bound. The cudgel raised was like a dragon at play in water; the ax that came was like a phoenix piercing flowers. The Mighty Magic Spirit's fame was known throughout Heaven — yet his skill, it turned out, was no match for the other: the Great Sage lightly swung his iron rod, and one blow to the head left him numb from crown to sole.

The Mighty Magic Spirit could hold his ground no longer. The Monkey King brought his cudgel crashing down upon his head; in a panic the spirit threw up his ax to fend off the blow — but with a sharp crack the

ax-handle was beaten clean in two, and he hastily turned and fled the field to save his life.

The Monkey King laughed. "Soft sack! Soft sack! I've spared you — now hurry off and carry the message!"

The Mighty Magic Spirit returned to camp and went straight to the Pagoda-Bearing Heavenly King, dropping to his knees and stammering, "The BanMaWen truly has vast and far-reaching powers. Your servant could not fight him, and has returned defeated to beg punishment."

Heavenly King Li flew into a rage. "This wretch has blunted my army's keen spirit! Drag him out and behead him!"

But from the side stepped Prince Nezha, who bowed and pleaded, "Calm your anger, Father King, and pardon the Mighty Magic Spirit's offense for now. Let your child go forth first and take the creature's measure." The Heavenly King heeded the counsel, and bade the spirit return to camp to await judgment and manage affairs.

Now Prince Nezha, with his armor all in order, sprang out of the encampment and rushed to the mouth of the Water-Curtain Cave. Wukong, just then drawing in his troops, saw how boldly Nezha came on. A fine prince —

His forelocks scarce shading his brow, his soft hair not yet reaching his shoulders. Wondrously quick of wit and bright of mind, fine of bone and clear of feature. Truly a unicorn-child of Heaven, indeed an immortal phoenix of mist and sunset-cloud.

Dragon-seed by nature, of no common cast; in his tender years, no creature of the dust. About him hung six kinds of divine weapons; his flying transformations boundless and wide. Now, by the golden decree from the Jade Emperor's lips, he is invested with the title of the Three Altars and the Ocean Assembly.

Wukong came forward to meet him and asked, "Whose little lad are you, that you press up to my gate? What is your business?"

Nezha shouted, "Insolent demon-ape! Do you not know me? I am Nezha, third prince of the Pagoda-Bearing Heavenly King, and I come by special commission of the Jade Emperor to seize you."

Wukong laughed. "Little prince, your milk-teeth aren't out yet and your baby-down isn't dry — how dare you talk so big? I'll spare your life and not strike you. Only look at what title is written on my banner, and report it faithfully to the Jade Emperor: grant me that office, and there'll be no need to trouble the host — I'll submit of my own accord. But if it

doesn't suit my heart, I'll surely beat my way up to the Numinous Empyrean Treasure-Hall."

Nezha raised his head and looked — there were the four words "Great Sage Equal to Heaven."

"What great powers can this demon-ape have," said Nezha, "that he dares lay claim to such a title? Fear not — take this sword of mine!"

"I'll just stand here and not move," said Wukong, "and you may hack at me with a few strokes, as you please."

Nezha, roused to fury, gave a great shout — "Change!" — and at once changed into three heads and six arms, fierce and terrible, his six hands gripping his six weapons: the demon-slaying sword, the demon-hacking saber, the demon-binding rope, the demon-subduing pestle, the embroidered ball, and the fire-wheel; and in jagged array he came hurtling at Wukong's face.

Seeing this, Wukong was startled at heart. "This little lad knows a trick or two after all. No insolence, now — watch my powers!" A fine Great Sage: he too gave a great shout — "Change!" — and changed into three heads and six arms; with one shake of the Golden-Banded Cudgel he made it three cudgels, and his six hands took up the three rods to ward off the blows. This battle truly made the earth quake and the mountains shudder — a fine fight indeed:

Six-armed Prince Nezha, the heaven-born fine stone Monkey King — meeting, they were true match for each other, coming to grips at the very source. The one, dispatched, had come to the lower world; the other, deceitful of heart, had stirred up Dipper and Bull. The demon-slaying treasure-sword, keen of edge; the demon-hacking saber, cruel enough to grieve gods and ghosts; the demon-binding rope, like a flying python; the great demon-subduing pestle, like a wolf's head; the fire-wheel flashing lightning, blazing red and hot; the embroidered ball rolling back and forth, again and again. The Great Sage's three As-You-Will cudgels warded front and guarded rear with cunning craft. They fought bitterly through many bouts, neither gaining the upper hand; and the prince's heart would not give over. He made his six weapons each transform into hundreds of thousands of millions, raining down upon the head. The Monkey King, unafraid, laughed aloud, and tumbled his iron rod about by his own

design, turning one into a thousand and a thousand into ten thousand, till the whole sky swarmed with them, dancing like flying serpents. The demon kings of every cave shut fast their doors in fright; all over the mountain the ghosts and goblins hid their heads. The heavenly soldiers' rage made the clouds grow grim; the golden-banded iron rod went whistling through the air. On that side, the heavenly host raised a cry, and every man was afraid; on this side, the monkey-monsters shook their flags, and every one was anxious. Furiously the two sides matched their valor, and who could tell which was the harder, which the softer?

The third prince and Wukong each gave free rein to his divine might, and they fought a full thirty bouts. The prince's six weapons turned into thousands upon thousands; Sun Wukong's Golden-Banded Cudgel turned into ten thousands upon thousands. In the middle air they clashed like raindrops, like shooting stars — and there was no telling victory from defeat.

Now Wukong was quick of hand and sharp of eye. In the very thick of the confusion he plucked out a single hair, cried "Change!", and changed it into his own likeness, holding a cudgel and sparring with Nezha; while

his true body, with one bound, slipped around behind Nezha and struck him a blow on the left arm. Nezha, in the midst of his sorcery, heard the wind of the cudgel-head whistle down; he tried to dodge but could not bring his hands round in time, and took the blow square. Wounded and in pain, he gathered in his magic, drew his six weapons back into his body, and retreated in defeat.

From the field below, Heavenly King Li had already seen it, and was about to lead his troops up in support, when all at once the prince appeared before him, trembling, and reported, "Father King, the BanMaWen truly has skill! With all my powers, your child could not best him, and has been wounded in the arm."

The Heavenly King went pale with shock. "If the creature's powers are such as this, how are we to win?"

"Outside his cave-gate stands a pole with a banner," said the prince, "and on it the four words 'Great Sage Equal to Heaven.' With his own mouth he boasts: let the Jade Emperor invest him with the title of Great Sage Equal to Heaven, and all will be over; but should it not be that title, he will surely beat his way up to the Numinous Empyrean Treasure-Hall."

"If that is so," said the Heavenly King, "then for now let us not hold the field against him. Let us return to the upper realm, report these words in our memorial, and request more heavenly soldiers to encircle and seize the wretch — it will not be too late." The prince, hurt and unable to fight on, accordingly returned to Heaven with the Heavenly King to make their report. But of this no more.

Now see the Monkey King returning to his mountain in triumph. The demon kings of the seventy-two caves and his six sworn brothers all came to offer congratulations, and in the blessed land of the cave-heaven they feasted and made merry beyond compare. Then he said to his six

brothers, "Since I have styled myself Great Sage Equal to Heaven, you too may each take the title of Great Sage."

From among them the Bull Demon King suddenly cried out, "Well said, worthy brother! I shall style myself the Great Sage Who Pacifies Heaven."

The Flood-Dragon Demon King said, "I shall be the Great Sage Who Overturns the Sea."

The Roc Demon King said, "I shall be the Great Sage Who Confounds Heaven."

The Lion-Camel Demon King said, "I shall be the Great Sage Who Moves Mountains."

The Macaque Demon King said, "I shall be the Great Sage Who Carries the Wind."

The Lemur-Monkey Demon King said, "I shall be the Great Sage Who Drives the Spirits."

And so the Seven Great Sages, each as he pleased, claimed his own title and styled himself as he would, and made merry a whole day before they each dispersed.

Now Heavenly King Li and the third prince, leading their generals, came straight to the Numinous Empyrean Treasure-Hall and reported: "Your servants, in obedience to the sacred decree, marched forth to the lower world to subdue the demon-immortal Sun Wukong; but his powers proved so vast and far-reaching that we could not prevail. We beg Your Majesty to send more troops to root him out."

"A mere demon-ape," said the Jade Emperor. "How much skill can he have, that you ask for more soldiers?"

The prince came forward again to report: "May Your Majesty pardon your servant's mortal offense. That demon-ape wields an iron rod; he first defeated the Mighty Magic Spirit, then wounded your servant in the arm. Outside his cave-gate he has set up a pole with a banner inscribed with the four words 'Great Sage Equal to Heaven.' He says that if he is invested with this office he will lay down his arms and submit; but if it is not this office, he will yet beat his way up to the Numinous Empyrean Treasure-Hall."

When the Jade Emperor heard this, he exclaimed in astonishment, "How dares this demon-ape be so wild and presumptuous? Let the generals put him to death at once!"

Even as he spoke, the Great White Planet Star stepped forth again from the ranks and said: "This demon-ape knows only how to throw out big words, with no sense of high or low. To send troops against him in battle — I fear he cannot be subdued so easily, and the host would only be worn out to no purpose. Better that Your Majesty extend your great mercy and grace, hand down once more a decree of amnesty, and simply let him be the Great Sage Equal to Heaven. Bestow on him only an empty title — an office without emolument — and there's an end to it."

"What do you mean by 'an office without emolument'?" asked the Jade Emperor.

"His name shall be Great Sage Equal to Heaven," said the Planet Star, "but give him no affairs to manage and no salary to draw. Keep him quietly somewhere between Heaven and earth, so as to gather in his wayward heart and let no wild presumption arise. Then the cosmos will be at peace, and the seas and skies will gain their calm."

When the Jade Emperor heard this, he said, "We will do as our minister advises." And he commanded that the decree be drawn up, and again

sent the Planet Star to carry it down.

The Planet Star passed out through the Southern Gate of Heaven once more and came straight to the mouth of the Water-Curtain Cave on Flower-Fruit Mountain. This time the scene was unlike before: an awe-striking majesty, a grim and murderous air, and demon-sprites of every sort — there was no kind that was not there. Each one gripped sword or hefted spear, took up saber or brandished staff, snarling and leaping. At sight of the Planet Star, they all surged forward to lay hands on him.

"You captains there," said the Planet Star, "trouble yourselves to go and report to your Great Sage: I am a heavenly envoy sent by the Lord on High, bearing a sacred decree to invite him."

The demons ran in at once to report: "Outside is an old man who says he is an envoy from the upper realm, and has a decree to invite you."

"Welcome, welcome!" said Wukong. "This must be that Great White Planet Star who came before. That time he invited me up to the upper realm — and though the office wasn't fit to hold, still I walked the heavens once and learned the roads within and without the gate. Now he comes again — surely with good intent." And he ordered the captains to throw wide the banners and drums and form up the ranks to receive him. The Great Sage then led his troop of monkeys forth; with cap on head and mail upon his body, the russet-yellow robe over the mail, and cloud-shoes on his feet, he hurried out the cave-gate, bowed from the waist, and called out loudly: "Old Star, come in, and forgive me the offense of failing to welcome you properly."

The Planet Star stepped briskly forward, went straight into the cave, and stood facing south. "Now I tell you, Great Sage," he said. "Some while ago, because the Great Sage disliked the smallness of his office, he left the Imperial Stable. The officers of the stable, great and small, reported it

to the Jade Emperor, who handed down his command: 'In conferring office, all proceeds from low to high — why should he disdain the smallness?' Whereupon Heavenly King Li led Nezha down to the lower world to give battle. Not knowing the Great Sage's powers, they met with defeat, and returning to Heaven reported: 'The Great Sage has set up a banner and would be the Great Sage Equal to Heaven.' The military officers still wished to dispute it, but it was I, your old servant, who at the risk of offense made the report on the Great Sage's behalf, so as to spare the raising of the host, and begged that the Great King be granted the scroll. The Jade Emperor approved the memorial, and so I have come to invite you."

Wukong laughed. "Last time you put yourself to trouble on my account; now again I am favored with your kindness. My thanks, my thanks! But I do not know — will the upper Heaven truly grant me the office and title of Great Sage Equal to Heaven?"

"It was with this very title that I obtained the Emperor's approval before I dared come bearing the decree," said the Planet Star. "Should it not come to pass, let the blame rest on your old servant alone."

Wukong was overjoyed and pressed him earnestly to stay for a banquet, which the Planet Star declined. So the two of them mounted an auspicious cloud and came outside the Southern Gate of Heaven, where the heavenly soldiers and generals all clasped their hands in welcome. They went straight in below the Numinous Empyrean Hall, and the Planet Star bowed and reported: "Your servant, in obedience to the decree, has summoned the BanMaWen Sun Wukong, who is now arrived."

"Let Sun Wukong come forward," said the Jade Emperor. "Today We proclaim you Great Sage Equal to Heaven. The office could not be higher

— but on no account are you to behave wildly." The Monkey, again, merely made a long bow toward the throne and said, "I thank you for your grace."

The Jade Emperor then commanded the master-builders Zhang and Lu, the two craft-officers, to raise on the right-hand side of the Garden of Immortal Peaches a Mansion of the Great Sage Equal to Heaven; and within the mansion to establish two bureaus — one named the Bureau of Peace and Quiet, the other the Bureau of Tranquil Spirit. Each bureau had its immortal clerks to attend him left and right. He further dispatched the Star Lords of the Five Bushels to escort Wukong to take up his post, and bestowed in addition two bottles of imperial wine and ten golden flowers, charging him to settle his heart and steady his will, and never again to behave wildly.

The Monkey King received the orders and obeyed. That same day he went with the Star Lords of the Five Bushels to his mansion, opened the bottles of wine, and drank them down together with his company. Then he saw the Star Officers back to their own palaces, and at last, his heart content and his wishes fulfilled, gladdened in earth and joyful in heaven, he took his pleasure in the heavenly palace with never a care or a hindrance. Truly it is said:

His immortal name forever set in the scroll of long life; no more to fall through the wheel of rebirth — handed down for all the ages.

And in the end, there is no knowing what came after; so listen to the telling in the next chapter.

Chapter 5: The Great Sage Plunders the Peaches and Steals the Elixir

Now then — for all his grand title, the Great Sage Equal to Heaven was at bottom nothing but a monkey-spirit. He neither understood the ranks and gradations of office nor cared whether his stipend ran high or low; so long as his name was on the rolls, he was content. In the offices beneath his Equal-to-Heaven residence the two bureaus of immortal clerks waited upon him morning and night, while he himself knew only this: three meals by day, one bed by night, no cares to entangle him, free and at ease in every way. In his idle hours he visited his friends and roamed the celestial palaces, forging bonds and swearing brotherhoods. When he met the Three Pure Ones he addressed them as "Venerable"; when he encountered the Four Emperors he said "Your Majesty." With the Nine Luminaries, the Generals of the Five Quarters, the Twenty-Eight Constellations, the Four Great Heavenly Kings, the Twelve Branches of Time, the Five Elders of the Five Regions, and all the starry hosts of heaven and the divinities of the River of Stars — with every one of them he stood as brother to brother, hailing them all as equals. Today he wandered east, tomorrow he roamed west, drifting with the clouds, coming and going as the whim took him, his comings and goings never fixed.

One day, as the Jade Emperor held his morning audience, the Perfected Man Xu Jingyang stepped forth from the ranks, bowed low, and made his report: "This Great Sage Equal to Heaven, having nothing to occupy him, idles his days away and consorts with all the stars and constellations of heaven, calling high and low alike his friend. I fear that, with nothing to do, he will one day breed mischief in his idleness. It would be better to set him over some single charge, so that no other trouble may arise."

The Jade Emperor heard this and at once issued a summons. The Monkey King came tripping in, all delight, and said, "Your Majesty — for what advancement or reward have you summoned Old Monkey?"

"Seeing that you are idle and unoccupied," said the Jade Emperor, "I give you a duty. Take charge for the present of the Garden of Immortal Peaches, and mind it well, morning and evening."

The Great Sage, overjoyed, gave thanks for the favor, made his bow before the throne, and withdrew.

He could scarcely wait, and at once went into the Peach Garden to inspect it. There a local earth-god barred his way and asked, "Where does the Great Sage go?"

"I am sent by the decree of the Jade Emperor," said the Great Sage, "to take charge of the Peach Garden, and I have come now to inspect it."

At once the earth-god made his bow and summoned the whole company — the laborers who hoed the roots, the laborers who carried water, the laborers who tended the trees, the laborers who swept the grounds — to come and kowtow before the Great Sage, and they led him within. And there he beheld:

Luxuriant and glowing, bough on bough, tree upon tree. Luxuriant and glowing, the blossoms crowd the branches; bough upon bough, the fruit weighs heavy on the limbs. The fruit upon the boughs hangs down like brocade pellets; the blossoms on the trees are clustered thick as rouge. Now flowering, now fruiting, ripened in a thousand years — without a summer, without a winter, slow-maturing through ten thousand ages. The early-ripened wear a flushed and wine-drunk face; the still-green keep their stems and pale unripened skins. The misty flesh shows green beneath; against the sun they bare their crimson glory. Beneath the trees rare flowers and strange herbs, through all four seasons never fading, every hue in even rank; to left and right, the towers and halls, their heights forever veiled in cloud and rainbow. No common stock of the mortal world is this — the Queen Mother of the Jade Pool planted it with her own hand.

The Great Sage gazed and reveled long, then asked the earth-god, "How many trees are there in this garden?"

"There are three thousand six hundred," said the earth-god. "The twelve hundred in front bear small blossoms and little fruit; they ripen once in three thousand years, and a man who eats of them becomes an immortal and attains the Way, his body hale, his frame made light. The twelve hundred in the middle bear layered blossoms and sweet fruit; they ripen once in six thousand years, and a man who eats of them ascends in rosy mists and flies aloft, deathless and unaging. The twelve hundred behind bear fruit with purple veins and pale yellow stones; they ripen once in nine thousand years, and a man who eats of them lives as long as heaven and earth, of one age with the sun and moon."

Hearing this, the Great Sage was beside himself with joy. That very day he made his count of the trees, looked over the pavilions and lodges, and returned to his residence. From that time on he came every three or five days to enjoy the sight, and he neither sought out his friends nor wandered elsewhere.

One day he saw that on the boughs of the older trees the peaches were more than half ripe. He had a mind to taste a few and try the new fruit — but the earth-god, the laborers, and the immortal clerks of his own residence followed him too closely for comfort. Of a sudden he hit upon a scheme. "Step outside the gate, all of you, and wait there," he said. "Let me rest a little while upon this pavilion." The whole company duly withdrew. Then the Monkey King slipped off his cap and robes, climbed one of the great trees, picked out the largest and ripest peaches, plucked a great many, and there among the branches ate his fill at his leisure. When he had stuffed himself, he leapt down, set his cap on, donned his robes, and called his attendants and retinue back to the residence. And

two or three days later he went again and contrived to steal the peaches, indulging himself to his heart's content.

Now one morning the Queen Mother prepared a banquet, threw open her precious halls, and made ready in the Jade Pool the grand Festival of Immortal Peaches. She sent the immortal maidens — robed in red, in green, in white, in black, in purple, in yellow, and in blue, seven maidens each bearing a flower-basket — to the Peach Garden to pluck the peaches and lay the feast. The seven-robed maidens came straight to the garden gate, and there they found the earth-god, the laborers, and the two bureaus of immortal clerks from the Equal-to-Heaven residence all keeping watch at the gate.

The maidens drew near and said, "By the gracious command of the Queen Mother, we have come to pluck the peaches for the banquet."

"Wait, fair immortals," said the earth-god. "This year is not as years gone by. The Jade Emperor has appointed the Great Sage Equal to Heaven to oversee this place, and we must inform him before we dare open the garden."

"Where is the Great Sage?" asked the maidens.

"He is within the garden," said the earth-god. "Being weary, he has gone off by himself to sleep upon the pavilion."

"If that is so," said the maidens, "let us go and find him without delay."

The earth-god went in with them. They searched all the way to the flower-pavilion and saw no one — only his cap and robes lying there, with no telling where he had gone; and search as they might in every quarter, there was no finding him. For the truth was that the Great Sage, after sporting awhile and eating his fill of peaches, had changed himself

into a little manikin no more than two inches tall and fallen asleep beneath the dense leaves at the very top of one of the great trees.

"We came at the Queen Mother's command," said the seven-robed maidens, "and we cannot find the Great Sage. How dare we go back empty-handed?"

An immortal attendant standing nearby said, "Since you fair maidens come by command, you need not hesitate. Our Great Sage is much given to idle wandering and has likely gone out of the garden to visit his friends. Go and pluck your peaches; we will answer for you."

The maidens did as he said and went down among the trees to pluck. From the front trees they took two baskets; from the middle trees, three; but when they came to the rear trees they found the blossoms and fruit grown sparse, with only a few green-skinned, hairy-stemmed peaches remaining. For all the ripe ones the Monkey King had already eaten. The seven maidens looked this way and that, and saw on a southward bough but a single peach, half red and half white. The green-robed maiden pulled the branch down with her hand, the red-robed maiden plucked the fruit, and then they let the branch spring back.

Now it so happened that the Great Sage, transformed, lay sleeping upon that very branch, and the jolt woke him. At once he resumed his true form, drew the gold-banded cudgel from within his ear, shook it until it grew thick as a bowl, and roared out, "What sort of monsters are you, that you dare so boldly to steal and pluck my peaches?"

Terrified, the seven maidens fell to their knees together and cried, "Stay your wrath, Great Sage! We are no monsters, but the seven-robed maidens sent by the Queen Mother to gather the immortal peaches for the grand opening of her precious halls and the holding of the Festival of Immortal Peaches. We came here and first met the earth-god and the

other spirits of this garden, but could not find the Great Sage. Fearing to be late, we could wait no longer, and so plucked the peaches here. We beg you to forgive our fault."

At these words the Great Sage turned from anger to delight. "Rise, fair maidens," he said. "This banquet the Queen Mother holds — who is invited?"

"The upper assembly has its old established custom," said the maidens. "Those invited are the Buddha of the Western Heaven, the Bodhisattvas, the holy monks, the Arhats; the Guanyin of the South Pole in the south; the Sage Emperor of Exalted Grace in the east, and the immortal sages of the Ten Continents and Three Islands; the Mystic Numen of the North Pole in the north; and the Great Immortal of the Yellow Horn at the center — these being the Five Elders of the Five Quarters. There are also the Star Lords of the Five Bushels; in the upper Eight Caves the Three Pure Ones, the Four Emperors, the Grand Unity and the celestial immortals; in the middle Eight Caves the Jade Emperor, the Nine Mounds, and the gods of sea and peak; in the lower Eight Caves the Lord of the Dark Underworld and the earthbound immortals who watch over the world; and the great and lesser honored gods of every palace and every hall — all alike will attend the splendid Feast of Peaches."

The Great Sage laughed and said, "And am I invited?"

"We have not heard you mentioned," said the maidens.

"I am the Great Sage Equal to Heaven," said he. "Why should Old Monkey not be invited to sit in the place of honor?"

"That is the old custom of the upper assembly," said the maidens. "What may be done at this present feast, we cannot say."

"You are right," said the Great Sage, "and no blame to you. Stand here awhile and let Old Monkey go ahead and find out the news — whether or not he is to be invited."

Good Great Sage! He made the magic sign, recited a spell, and said to the maidens, "Stay! Stay! Stay!" This was a body-fixing spell, and it left the seven-robed maidens, every one of them, standing rooted beneath the peach trees, eyes glazed, blank-faced and stiff. Then the Great Sage mounted an auspicious cloud, sprang out of the garden, and set off straight along the road to the Jade Pool. As he traveled, he saw, off to one side:

Heaven all bright with auspicious haze, light
wavering and aglow, five-colored clouds of blessing
flying without cease. The white crane's cry resounds
through the Nine Marshes; the purple fungus
blooms in glory, parting a thousand leaves. And in
their midst appears an immortal, his features
heaven-formed, his bearing all his own. Spirit-
dancing on the rainbow, he sweeps across the starry
sky, at his waist a precious scroll, deathless and
undying. The Barefoot Great Immortal is his name,
come specially to the Peach Feast to add to the years
of life.

The Barefoot Immortal came face to face with the Great Sage. The Great Sage lowered his head and laid his scheme: he meant to gull the true immortal so that he might go secretly to the feast in his stead, and so he asked, "Venerable Sir, where do you go?"

"By the Queen Mother's gracious invitation," said the Immortal, "I go to the splendid Feast of Peaches."

"Venerable Sir, you do not know," said the Great Sage. "Because Old Monkey's somersault cloud is so swift, the Jade Emperor has charged me to go by all five roads and invite the worthies, that they may first perform the rites of ceremony below the Hall of Universal Brightness, and afterward go on to the feast."

Now the Barefoot Immortal was an open and upright man, and he took the Sage's lie for truth. "In years past," he said, "the rites of thanksgiving were performed at the Jade Pool itself. How is it that this year we first go to the Hall of Universal Brightness to perform the rites, and only then to the Jade Pool for the feast?" But there was no help for it, and so he turned his auspicious cloud about and made straight for the Hall of Universal Brightness.

The Great Sage, riding his cloud, recited a spell, shook himself, and changed into the very likeness of the Barefoot Immortal, then sped on to the Jade Pool. Before long he arrived at the precious halls, stayed his cloud, and softly, step by careful step, walked within. And there he saw:

Rare incense curling, auspicious haze in profusion.
The jasper terrace spread with colored knots, the
precious halls awash in fragrant mist. Phoenixes
soaring, simurghs in flight, their forms half-
glimpsed; golden flowers and jade calyxes, their
shadows floating, sinking. Set out above: the nine-
phoenix screen of rosy cloud, the eight-jeweled
stools of purple rainbow, the five-hued tables traced
with gold, the thousand-flowered basins of green
jade. Upon the tables, dragon-liver and phoenix-
marrow, bear's paws and the lips of apes. Rare
viands of a hundred flavors, each one delicious;
strange fruits and choice morsels, each fresh in its
own color.

Everything was laid out in perfect order — but not a single immortal had yet arrived.

The Great Sage had not taken in half of what there was to see when of a sudden a gust of wine-fragrance came stealing to his nose. He turned his head, and there beneath the long gallery on the right-hand wall were several wine-making immortal officers and dreg-turning laborers, leading a few water-carrying Daoists and fire-tending lads, washing the vats and

scrubbing the jars — for they had already made the jade-fluid and jasper-nectar, the fragrant brew and the choicest vintage. The Great Sage could not keep the drool from the corners of his mouth, and longed to go and drink — but all those people were there. So he worked a piece of magic: he plucked a few hairs, tossed them into his mouth, chewed them small, spat them out, and recited a spell, crying, "Change!" At once they became several sleep-insects, which flew onto the faces of the company. And look — that whole crew went limp at the hands, drooped at the head, knit the brow, and closed the eyes; dropping their charges, every one of them drifted off to doze. Then the Great Sage helped himself to the hundred-flavored delicacies, the choice morsels and rare dishes, walked into the long gallery, and there beside the vats and against the jars he opened his gullet and drank deep — a long and hearty bout. When he had drunk a good long while, he was thoroughly fuddled with wine. He felt and fumbled at himself and said, "This is bad — this is bad! In a little while, when the invited guests arrive, will they not lay the blame on me? If I am caught here, how shall I fare? Better get home early and sleep it off."

Good Great Sage! Reeling and swaying, propped up by the wine, he blundered along just as the fancy took him. Soon he lost the road — and instead of arriving at the Equal-to-Heaven residence, he came to the Tushita Palace. The sight of it brought him to his senses with a start. "The Tushita Palace stands above the Thirty-Three Heavens," he said, "in the Heaven of Parted Sorrows, the dwelling of Lord Lao Tzu, the Supreme Patriarch. How have I blundered here? Well, no matter — I have long meant to call on this old gentleman and never managed it. Now that my idle steps have brought me, I may as well pay him a visit." So he straightened his clothes and barged in — but Lord Lao was nowhere to be seen, nor was there a soul in sight. For the truth was that Lord Lao and the Ancient Buddha Dipankara were expounding the Way upon the Vermilion Mound Cinnabar Terrace in the three-storied high

hall, and all the immortal lads, immortal generals, immortal officers, and immortal clerks stood attending to left and right, listening. The Great Sage went straight into the elixir-chamber but, seek as he might, found no one. He saw only, beside the elixir-stove, the fire still glowing in the brazier; and to left and right of the stove stood five gourds, and within the gourds was all the refined golden elixir.

"This stuff is the supreme treasure of the immortal folk!" the Great Sage said in delight. "Ever since Old Monkey attained the Way, I have grasped the principle that inner and outer are one and the same, and I too have meant to refine some golden elixir to succor mankind, but never had the leisure once I got home. Today fortune favors me, and I have stumbled on the very thing. While the old gentleman is away, let me eat a few pellets and try them." So he tipped out all the gourds and ate the lot, crunching them down as one cracks roasted beans.

In a little while the elixir had cleared the wine from his head, and again he reckoned with himself. "This is bad — this is bad! This is a calamity bigger than the sky itself. If the Jade Emperor learns of it, my life is forfeit. Go — go — go! Better to go down to the world below and be a king there." So he ran out of the Tushita Palace, and not by the old road — slipping instead through the Western Heaven Gate by a spell of invisibility, he made his escape. He pressed down his cloud and returned to the bounds of the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit, where he saw banners flashing and halberds gleaming, for the Four Mighty Generals and the seventy-two cave-kings of monsters were drilling at their martial arts.

"My little ones, I am back!" the Great Sage called out in a loud voice. The whole horde of monsters threw down their weapons and fell to their knees. "How easy in heart the Great Sage is!" they cried. "You left us so long and never came to look in on us."

"It was no long time," said the Great Sage. "No long time at all."

Talking and walking, he passed straight into the deep recesses of the cave-heaven. The Four Mighty Generals swept and made ready his resting place, kowtowed and paid their respects, and when that was done they all asked, "The Great Sage has been a hundred years and more in heaven. What office did you truly hold?"

The Great Sage laughed. "By my reckoning it was but half a year," he said. "How can you speak of a hundred years and more?"

"One day in heaven," said the Generals, "is a year in the world below."

"It is well, then," said the Great Sage, "that this time the Jade Emperor took such a liking to me. He did indeed enfeoff me as the Great Sage Equal to Heaven, raised up an Equal-to-Heaven residence for me, and set up the two bureaus of Tranquillity and Spirit-Repose, each with immortal clerks and guards. Later, seeing I had nothing to do, he set me to mind the Garden of Immortal Peaches. Now of late the Queen Mother held her grand Feast of Peaches and never invited me. So I did not wait for her invitation, but went first to the Jade Pool, where I stole and ate the whole of her immortal delicacies and immortal wine. Coming out of the Jade Pool, staggering and lurching, I blundered into Lord Lao's palace by mistake, and there I stole and ate the golden elixir from his five gourds as well. But fearing the Jade Emperor would charge me with the crime, I made my way out of the heavenly gate just now."

At this the whole horde of monsters rejoiced greatly. At once they set out wine and fruit to welcome him, and brimmed a stone bowl with coconut wine and offered it up. The Great Sage took one sip and at once grimaced and bared his teeth. "It has no taste — no taste at all," he said.

The two generals Beng and Ba said, "The Great Sage has been drinking immortal wine and eating immortal fare in the heavenly palace, so coconut wine is little to his liking. As the old saying has it, 'Sweet or not sweet, it's the water of home.'"

"And you," said the Great Sage, "are 'kin or not kin, they're the folk of home.' When I was reveling this morning at the Jade Pool, I saw beneath the long gallery a great many bottles and jars, all full of jade-fluid and jasper-nectar — and none of you has ever so much as tasted it. Wait while I go and steal a few bottles back, and each of you shall drink half a cup, and every one of you shall be deathless and unaging."

The monkeys were overjoyed beyond measure. The Great Sage went out of the cave-mouth, turned a somersault, and by a spell of invisibility went straight to the Peach Feast and into the palace of the Jade Pool. There he found the wine-makers, dreg-turners, water-carriers, and fire-tenders still snoring and not yet awake. He seized the largest jars, tucked two under his arms and carried two in his hands, then turned his cloud about and went back. Gathering the monkeys in the cave, he held a feast of immortal wine; each drank a few cups and they made merry — but of that we say no more.

Now those seven-robed maidens, once the Great Sage had laid his body-fixing spell upon them, could not break free until a full day and night had gone round. Each took up her flower-basket and went back to report to the Queen Mother, saying, "The Great Sage Equal to Heaven worked his magic to bind us fast, and that is why we are so late in returning."

"How many peaches did you pluck?" asked the Queen Mother.

"Only two baskets of small peaches and three of middling," said the maidens. "When we came to the rear trees, there was not half a large peach to be found — all eaten, we think, by the Great Sage. And as we

were searching, he himself came out and fell upon us in a fury, then asked who was invited to the feast. We told him the whole matter of the upper assembly, whereupon he fixed us where we stood and went off, none knows where. Only now have we come to ourselves and returned."

When the Queen Mother heard this, she went at once to the Jade Emperor and laid the whole affair before him. Scarcely had she finished when the company of wine-makers came in with their immortal officers and reported: "Someone — we know not who — has thrown the grand Feast of Peaches into confusion and stolen and drunk the jade-fluid and jasper-nectar; the eight delicacies and hundred flavors have all been stolen and eaten as well." Then came four Grand Celestial Masters to report: "The Supreme Patriarch of the Way has arrived." The Jade Emperor went out with the Queen Mother to greet him. When Lord Lao had finished his salutations, he said, "In this old Daoist's palace I had refined some Nine-Cycle Golden Elixir against the day Your Majesty should hold the Grand Elixir Assembly — but it has been stolen away by a thief, and I come expressly to make it known to Your Majesty." The Jade Emperor heard the report with dismay.

In a little while the immortal clerks of the Equal-to-Heaven residence came kowtowing and said, "Sun the Great Sage has neglected his charge. Since yesterday he has gone off roaming and to this hour has not returned, and there is no knowing where he is." This added still more to the Jade Emperor's misgivings. Then the Barefoot Great Immortal bowed low and reported: "By the Queen Mother's summons, your servant went yesterday to attend the feast, and by chance met the Great Sage Equal to Heaven, who told me that Your Majesty had decreed he should invite us all to perform the rites of ceremony first at the Hall of Universal Brightness, and only then proceed to the feast. Trusting his word, your servant returned at once to the foot of the Hall of Universal Brightness,

but saw nothing of Your Majesty's dragon-carriage and phoenix-chariot, and so hastened here to wait." The Jade Emperor was more alarmed than ever. "This wretch has counterfeited a decree and gulled our worthy minister!" he said. "Quick — set the Inspecting Numinous Officer to track down the trail of this wretch."

The Numinous Officer received the command, went out from the hall, and made inquiry everywhere; and having learned the whole matter in full detail, he returned and reported: "He who has thrown the heavenly palace into confusion is none other than the Great Sage Equal to Heaven." And he related the whole affair from beginning to end. The Jade Emperor was sore wroth, and at once dispatched the Four Great Heavenly Kings, together with the Pagoda-Bearing Heavenly King Li and Prince Nezha; and he mustered the Twenty-Eight Constellations, the Nine Luminary Star-Officers, the Twelve Branches of Time, the Revealers of the Five Quarters, the Four Duty-Gods of the Watches, the stars of east and west, the deities of south and north, the gods of the Five Sacred Peaks and the Four Great Rivers, and all the starry hosts of heaven — a hundred thousand heavenly soldiers in all — to spread eighteen frames of heaven-and-earth net and descend upon the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit, there to surround and besiege the wretch and seize him without fail for punishment.

The host of gods raised their army at once and departed the heavenly palace. And as they went, behold:

Yellow wind rolling, rolling, darkens the very sky;
purple fog surging, surging, blots the earth in
gloom. All because a monkey-monster has flouted
the High God, the assembled saints come down into
the dust of the world. The Four Great Heavenly
Kings, the Revealers of the Five Quarters: the Four
Great Kings hold the supreme command, the Five
Revealers marshal the many troops. Li, the Pagoda-
Bearer, in the central host gives the signals; fierce
Nezha leads the vanguard. Rahu the star takes the
muster as chief; Ketu the star presses on towering
behind. The star of the Moon's Essence is full of
dash and vigor; the star of the Sun shines clear and
bright. The stars of the Five Elements excel in valor;
the Nine Luminary stars love best to strive. The
Branch-stars of midnight, noon, dawn, and dusk —
each and every one a mighty heaven-warrior. The
Five Plagues and Five Peaks ranged east and west,
the Six Ding and Six Jia marching left and right. The
dragon-gods of the Four Rivers split above and

below, the Twenty-Eight Constellations in dense and serried ranks. Horn, Neck, Root, and Room lead all the rest; Stride, Bond, Stomach, and Mane are practiced in the tumult. Dipper, Ox, Maid, Void, Roof, House, and Wall; Heart, Tail, and Basket — every star a champion. Well, Ghost, Willow, Star, Bow, Wing, and Axletree — brandishing spears and waving swords, they show their awesome might. Halting the clouds and lowering the mist, they came down to the mortal world, and pitched their camp before the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit.

A poem says:

The heaven-born Monkey King, of myriad transformations, stole the elixir, stole the wine, made merry in his mountain den. Only because he threw the Peach Feast into confusion, a hundred thousand heavenly soldiers spread their net for him.

Now the Heavenly King Li gave his orders, bidding the host of heavenly soldiers strike camp and ring the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit so close

that not a drop of water could leak through; above and below they spread the eighteen frames of heaven-and-earth net. Then he sent the Nine Luminaries, those fierce stars, out to give battle first. The Nine Luminaries led their troops straight to the cave-mouth, where they saw monkeys great and small leaping and sporting at their play. The star-officers cried out in stern, loud voices: "You little fiends! Where is that Great Sage of yours? We are the heavenly gods dispatched from the realm above, come to subdue this rebel. Tell him to come quickly and submit — and if he so much as breathes a word of refusal, you shall all be put to the sword together."

In alarm the little fiends rushed the word within: "Great Sage — disaster! Disaster! Outside there are nine fierce gods who call themselves heavenly gods sent down from the realm above, come to subdue the Great Sage."

The Great Sage was just then sharing out the immortal wine with the seventy-two cave-kings and the Four Mighty Generals. Hearing this report, he paid it no heed at all. "Today there is wine, today get drunk," he said. "Never mind what's right or wrong at the door." Scarcely had he spoken when another band of little fiends came leaping in: "Those nine fierce gods are at the door with their foul and abusive talk, hurling challenges to battle!"

The Great Sage laughed. "Pay them no mind," he said. "With poems and wine I'll take my pleasure for today; as for rank and fame, ask not when they'll come to pass." But the words were hardly out of his mouth when yet another band of little fiends came running to report: "Father! Those nine fierce gods have broken down the door and are fighting their way in!"

The Great Sage flew into a rage. "These vile hairy gods! What gross effrontery! I had meant to take no quarrel with them — how dare they come to my very door to bully me?" At once he ordered the One-Horned Demon King: "Lead forth the seventy-two cave-kings to give battle. Old Monkey will follow after with the Four Mighty Generals." The Demon King swiftly led his fiend-soldiers out of the gate to meet the foe — but the Nine Luminaries fell upon them all together and pinned them down at the head of the iron-plank bridge, so that they could not break out.

In the thick of the uproar the Great Sage arrived, crying out, "Make way!" He whipped out his iron cudgel, shook it once till it was thick as a bowl and a good twelve feet long, threw himself into his stance, and came striking forth. Not one of the Nine Luminaries dared withstand him, and in a moment he beat them back. The Nine Luminaries planted their battle-line and called out, "You reckless, death-defying Protector of the Horses! You have committed the ten unpardonable crimes — you stole the peaches, you stole the wine, you threw the grand Feast of Peaches into confusion, you filched Lord Lao's immortal elixir, and you have stolen the imperial wine to make merry here. Crime heaped upon crime — do you not know it?"

The Great Sage laughed. "These several matters — they are true, all true. But what of it now?"

"We bear the golden decree of the Jade Emperor," said the Nine Luminaries, "and have led our host here to subdue you. Submit at once and spare these living creatures their lives — if not, we will trample this mountain flat and overturn this cave of yours!"

"What power have a pack of paltry hairy gods like you," the Great Sage roared in fury, "that you dare utter such wild words? Stand and take a taste of Old Monkey's cudgel!" The Nine Luminaries leapt forward all

together — but the Handsome Monkey King, not in the least afraid, swung up his gold-banded cudgel, parrying left and warding right, and battered the Nine Luminaries till their sinews ached and their strength failed, and one by one they trailed their weapons and fled the field in rout, hastening into the central command-tent. There they said to the Pagoda-Bearing Heavenly King, "That Monkey King is fierce and brave indeed. We could not stand against him, and have come back beaten."

Then the Heavenly King Li sent forth the Four Great Heavenly Kings and the Twenty-Eight Constellations to march out in one body and give battle. And the Great Sage, plainly unafraid, called out the One-Horned Demon King, the seventy-two cave-kings, and his Four Mighty Generals, and drew them up in battle-line outside the cave-mouth. Behold this melee — a terrible sight indeed:

Cold wind whistling, eerie fog hanging dark. On that side, banners flying their colors; on this side, halberds glittering bright. Helmets gleaming, rank on rank; armor flashing, fold on fold. Rank on rank of gleaming helmets caught the sun like silver chimes battering heaven; fold on fold of flashing armor walled the cliffs like icy peaks bearing down upon the earth. Great broadswords flew like cloud and lightning; white-tasseled spears pierced fog and cloud. Square-heaven halberds, tiger-eye whips, ranged thick as a hemp-grove; green bronze swords, four-bright shovels, set close as a forest. Curved bows and stiff crossbows, eagle-feathered arrows; short cudgels and serpent-lances that snatched away the soul. The Great Sage's single As-You-Will cudgel, turning and overturning, fought the gods of heaven. They battled till in the sky no bird flew over, and through the mountains tigers and wolves fled; flung sand and rolling stones blackened heaven and earth, whirling earth and flying dust darkened

all the universe. Only the clash and clatter, startling sky and ground; the fierce and awful fury, shaking gods and ghosts.

This battle was arrayed from the hour of the Dragon, and the slaughter raged on until the sun went down behind the western hills. By then the One-Horned Demon King and the seventy-two cave-monsters had all been taken captive by the host of heavenly gods. Only the Four Mighty Generals and the troop of monkeys got away, hidden deep at the bottom of the Water-Curtain Cave.

The Great Sage, with his single cudgel, held off the Four Great Heavenly Gods, Li the Pagoda-Bearer, and Prince Nezha, all in the middle air; and after a long bout of slaughter, seeing that the day was drawing to its close, he plucked out a handful of his hairs, threw them into his mouth, chewed them small, spat them out, and cried, "Change!" At once they became a thousand and a hundred Great Sages, each one wielding a gold-banded cudgel, and they beat back Prince Nezha and routed the five heavenly kings.

His victory won, the Great Sage gathered in his hairs and hastened back into the cave. There at the head of the iron-plank bridge the Four Mighty Generals met him, leading the host, and bowed in welcome; and the whole company wept three sobbing, choking sobs, and then laughed three loud, hearty laughs.

"You see me again," said the Great Sage, "and you both weep and laugh — why is that?"

"This morning," said the Four Mighty Generals, "when we led the host to do battle with the heavenly kings, the seventy-two cave-kings and the

One-Horned Demon King were all taken captive by the host of gods, and we ourselves escaped only with our lives — and that is why we wept. Now that the Great Sage has returned victorious and unhurt, that is why we laughed."

"Victory and defeat are the common lot of soldiers," said the Great Sage. "The ancients say, 'Slay ten thousand of the foe, and lose three thousand of your own.' Besides, those captains who were carried off are creatures of the tiger and leopard, wolf and reptile kind — badgers and roebucks, foxes and raccoon-dogs — and of our own monkey-kin not one was harmed. Why should we fret? Though I beat them back with my body-dividing magic, they will still pitch camp at the foot of our mountain. Let us keep close watch and ward, eat our fill, sleep with easy hearts, and nurse our strength. Tomorrow at daybreak you shall see Old Monkey work a mighty magic, take these heavenly captains, and avenge our host." So the Four Generals and the troop of monkeys drank a few bowls of coconut wine and went to their rest with quiet minds — but of that we say no more.

As for the Four Great Heavenly Kings, they withdrew their troops and broke off the battle, and each reported his merits: some had taken tigers and leopards, some had taken lions and elephants, some had taken wolves and reptiles, foxes and raccoon-dogs — but not a single monkey-spirit had been caught. Then they pitched their barracks afresh and laid out a great encampment, rewarded the generals who had won merit, and gave their orders to the soldiers of the heaven-and-earth net; and each man shook his bell and called his watchword, ringing the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit about and waiting only for the great battle of the morrow. Each held to his command and kept strict guard at his post. Truly:

The monkey-monster's rising shook both heaven and earth; they spread their net and kept their watch by day and night.

And how, after the dawn broke, the matter was dealt with — that you shall hear told in the next chapter.

Chapter 6: Guanyin Comes to the Feast and Asks the Cause; The Little Sage Subdues the Great Sage

Let us leave aside the heavenly soldiers ringing him round while the Great Sage took his ease. The tale turns instead to the Bodhisattva Guanyin — the Greatly Merciful, Greatly Compassionate Deliverer from Pain and Rescuer from Calamity, the Efficacious One Who Hears the Cries of the World — who dwells upon Mount Potalaka by the Southern Sea. Having been invited by the Queen Mother to attend the Grand Peach Festival, she had climbed together with her chief disciple, the pilgrim Huian, up to the jeweled pavilion beside the Jasper Pool. There she found the place forlorn and desolate, the banquet tables in ruins and disorder. A few heavenly immortals were present, but none of them had taken their seats; instead they stood about in noisy clusters, all talking at once.

When the Bodhisattva had exchanged greetings with the assembled immortals, they told her at length all that had happened. Said the Bodhisattva, "Since there is to be no grand feast, and no cups are being passed, you may all come with this humble nun to see the Jade Emperor."

The immortals followed her gladly. Before the Hall of Penetrating Brightness they found the Four Grand Preceptors and the Barefoot Immortal and the rest, all waiting there, who came forward to receive her. They explained that the Jade Emperor was sorely vexed, that he had dispatched his heavenly armies to capture the monster, and that the troops had not yet returned. Said the Bodhisattva, "I wish to see the Jade Emperor. Pray be so good as to carry word in for me." At once the Preceptor Qiu Hongji entered the Hall of Divine Mists and announced her, and she was summoned inside. The Supreme Lord Lao Zi was seated above, and the Queen Mother behind.

The Bodhisattva led the others within, and when she had paid her respects to the Jade Emperor, she greeted Lao Zi and the Queen Mother as well, and all took their seats. Then she asked, "How fared the Grand Peach Festival?"

Said the Jade Emperor, "Every year the gathering is held in joy and gladness. This year a monstrous ape ran riot, and the invitations all came to nothing."

"Where did this monstrous ape come from?" asked the Bodhisattva.

The Jade Emperor replied, "He was hatched from a stone egg on the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit, in the Country of Aolai, in the Eastern Continent of Superior Spirit. At the moment of his birth his eyes flashed with golden light that shot up to the Palace of the Dipper. At first I gave it no mind; but he grew into a sprite, subdued dragons and tamed tigers, and struck his own name from the registers of the dead with his own hand. The Dragon Kings and Yama, King of the Dead, both sent up petitions. I meant to seize and arrest him, but the Star Spirit Changgeng petitioned, saying, 'Among the Three Realms, any creature possessed of nine orifices may attain immortality.' So I extended instruction and

nurtured the worthy: I summoned him to the upper realm and appointed him to the office of Bimawen, Keeper of the Imperial Stables. But the wretch despised the post as too lowly and rebelled, fleeing the Heavenly Palace. I then sent Heavenly King Li and Prince Nezha to subdue and capture him; yet I also issued a decree of pardon and conciliation, summoning him back to the upper realm, and bestowed upon him the title of Great Sage Equal to Heaven — though it was an office with rank but no stipend. Having nothing to occupy or administer, he wandered idly east and west. Fearing he might breed fresh trouble, I set him to oversee the Peach Orchard in my stead. But he heeded no law: he stole and devoured every great peach on the oldest trees. And when the feast was being arranged, since he was a person without stipend, he was not invited. So he contrived a scheme, hoodwinked the Barefoot Immortal, then took on that immortal's very likeness and entered the gathering, where he stole and ate up all the celestial viands and celestial wines. He stole Lao Zi's elixir of immortality as well, and made off with a quantity of royal wine besides, carrying it back to share in revelry with the apes of his own mountain. It is this that vexes my heart, and so I have mustered a hundred thousand heavenly soldiers, with Heaven-Net and Earth-Snare, to take him. A whole day has passed without report, and I do not know how the fight goes."

When the Bodhisattva had heard all this, she straightway charged the pilgrim Huian, saying, "Go you quickly down from the Heavenly Palace to the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit, and spy out how the battle stands. If you meet the enemy, you may lend a hand and do some service; but be sure to bring back a truthful account."

The pilgrim Huian smoothed his robe and gown, took up his iron rod, and mounting a cloud departed the palace, going straight to the foot of the mountain. There he saw the Heaven-Net and Earth-Snare laid layer

upon dense layer, the gate of every camp ringing its bells and crying its watchwords, the mountain hemmed round so tightly that not a drop of water could leak through. Huian halted and called out, "You sentinels at the camp gate, be so good as to pass on this word: I am Moksha, second prince of Heavenly King Li — Huian, chief disciple of Guanyin of the Southern Sea — come expressly to spy out the state of the war."

The spirit-soldiers of the Five Sacred Peaks within the camp passed the message inward through the gate of the headquarters. Presently the Star Spirits — Empty-Day Rat, Pleiades-Day Cock, Heart-Day Horse, and Room-Day Hare — carried his words to the central command tent. Heavenly King Li sent down his command flag, ordering the Heaven-Net and Earth-Snare opened to let him through. The east was just growing light as Huian followed the flag inside, where he saw the Four Heavenly Kings and Heavenly King Li, and bowed before them. When the bows were done, Heavenly King Li said, "My child, from what quarter have you come?"

Huian answered, "Your foolish son went with the Bodhisattva to attend the Peach Festival. The Bodhisattva, seeing the grand feast laid waste and the Jasper Pool deserted, led the immortals and your son to see the Jade Emperor. The Jade Emperor told us in full how my royal father and the rest had descended to the lower world to subdue the monstrous ape, and that a whole day had passed without report, the outcome unknown. So the Bodhisattva charged your son to come here and learn the truth of it."

Said Heavenly King Li, "Yesterday we arrived here, pitched our camp and set our palisades, and ordered the Nine Luminary Stars to challenge him. But this wretch worked his magic mightily, and the Nine Luminaries were all routed and fled back. Afterward we ourselves led out our troops, and the wretch too drew up his battle line. Our hundred thousand heavenly soldiers fought him in a great melee until evening, when he

used a body-dividing trick to fight us off. When we recalled the troops and made our count, we had captured only some wolves, vermin, tigers, and leopards — not so much as half a monstrous ape. Today he has not yet come out to fight."

Before he had finished speaking, a messenger came to report outside the headquarters gate: "The Great Sage is leading a band of ape-sprites and calling for battle out front!" The Four Heavenly Kings, Heavenly King Li, and the prince were just conferring about sending out troops when Moksha said, "Royal father, your foolish son was charged by the Bodhisattva to come down and gather news, and she said that should I meet a battle I might lend a hand. Unworthy though I am, I beg leave to go and see what manner of Great Sage this is."

Said the Heavenly King, "My child, you have practiced cultivation these several years under the Bodhisattva; doubtless you too have some magic powers. But you must take the greatest care."

Brave prince! He whirled his iron rod two-handed, cinched up his embroidered tunic, leaped out the headquarters gate, and shouted aloud, "Which of you is the Great Sage Equal to Heaven?"

The Great Sage hefted his As-You-Will cudgel and answered, "Old Monkey is he. And who are you, that you dare so freely to ask after me?"

Said Moksha, "I am Moksha, second prince of Heavenly King Li, and now I serve before the jeweled throne of the Bodhisattva Guanyin as a disciple guarding the Faith; my religious name is Huian."

"Why have you left off your cultivation in the Southern Sea," said the Great Sage, "and come here to see me? What is your purpose?"

Moksha replied, "My master sent me to spy out the state of the war; and seeing you so rampant, I have come on purpose to capture you."

Said the Great Sage, "You dare to boast so big? Stay where you are, then, and taste Old Monkey's cudgel!"

Moksha was not in the least afraid, and met him with his iron rod, blow for blow. The two of them, midway up the mountain and outside the headquarters gate, fought a splendid combat:

Rod faced rod, yet the iron of each was unlike; arms clashed against arms, yet the men were not the same. One was the Great Sage, hailed as a Scattered Immortal of the Primal One; the other Guanyin's disciple, a true dragon of the prime essence. The wrought-iron rod, beaten under a thousand hammers, wielded by the spirit-might of the Six Ding and Six Jia gods; the As-You-Will cudgel, that once stilled the River of Heaven, the Sea-Calming divine treasure, mighty in its power. The two met as true and matched opponents, their passes and ripostes, coming and going, without end. This one's sinister-handed rod was savage past counting, coiling round the waist, swift as the wind; that one's clamping spear-strokes were never spent in vain, warding left, blocking right — how could they yield? On that side the banners flickered and flashed; on this side the war-drums thundered and boomed. Ten thousand heavenly generals ringed them about; a whole cavern of monstrous apes

clustered in throngs. Weird mists and grieving clouds spread over the underworld; wolf-smoke and killing vapors shot toward the Heavenly Palace. Yesterday's melee was hard enough to bear; today's contention was fiercer still. Admirable the Monkey King's true prowess — Moksha was beaten again, and fled for his life.

The Great Sage and Huian fought some fifty or sixty rounds, until Huian's arms grew sore and numb and he could no longer hold the field. He made a feint, then turned and fled, beaten. The Great Sage too recalled his ape-soldiers and encamped outside the cavern gate. There at the camp gate of the Heavenly King, soldiers great and small received the prince, opened a broad path, and led him straight into the headquarters. Before the Four Heavenly Kings, the Pagoda-Bearer Li, and Nezha, panting and gasping, scarcely able to catch his breath, he said, "A mighty Great Sage! A mighty Great Sage! His magic powers are truly vast — your son cannot stand against him, and has come back beaten again!"

Heavenly King Li was alarmed at the sight, and at once ordered a memorial drawn up begging for aid. He dispatched the Mighty Magic Spirit King and Prince Moksha to ascend to Heaven and lay the matter before the throne.

The two dared not linger. They burst out through the Heaven-Net and Earth-Snare and rose upon auspicious vapors and propitious clouds. In a moment they came straight beneath the Hall of Penetrating Brightness, where they saw the Four Grand Preceptors, who led them to the Hall of

Divine Mists, and they presented the memorial. Huian then paid his respects to the Bodhisattva, who asked, "How fared your spying?"

Huian answered, "When first I received the command and reached the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit, I had the gate of the Heaven-Net and Earth-Snare opened, saw my father, and told him my master's purpose in sending me. My royal father said, 'Yesterday I fought one battle with that Monkey King, and captured only his tigers, leopards, lions, and elephants — not a single ape-sprite.' While we were still speaking, he came again to demand battle, and your disciple wielded an iron rod against him some fifty or sixty rounds, but could not prevail, and retreated to camp beaten. For this reason my father sent the Mighty Magic Spirit King together with your disciple to come to the upper realm and beg for help." The Bodhisattva bowed her head in thought.

Now the Jade Emperor had opened the memorial, and seeing the plea for aid, he laughed and said, "Insufferable! How great can this ape-sprite's powers be, that he dares stand against a hundred thousand heavenly soldiers? Heavenly King Li comes again begging for help — but which divine troops shall I send to aid him?" Before he had finished, Guanyin pressed her palms together and addressed the throne: "Let Your Majesty set his mind at ease. This humble nun will recommend a deity who can capture this ape."

"Whom do you recommend?" asked the Jade Emperor.

Said the Bodhisattva, "It is Your Majesty's own nephew, the True Lord Erlang of Manifest Sanctity, who now dwells at the Mouth of the Guan River in Guanzhou and enjoys the incense and worship of the lower world. In days past he slew six monsters by his own strength; he commands, moreover, his sworn brethren of Plum Mountain and twelve hundred grass-headed spirits before his tent, and his magic powers are

vast. But he answers only to summons, not to command. Let Your Majesty send down a decree of troop-mustering ordering him to lend his strength, and the ape may be taken."

When the Jade Emperor had heard this, he straightway issued the troop-mustering decree, and dispatched the Mighty Magic Spirit King to carry the summons.

The Spirit King, having received the decree, at once mounted a cloud and went straight to the Mouth of the Guan River; in less than half a watch he arrived at the True Lord's temple. The gate-guarding demon-judges hurried inside to report, "Outside there is a heavenly envoy, come bearing a decree." Erlang and his brethren came out to receive it, burned incense, and read it aloud. The decree ran thus:

The monstrous ape of the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit, the Great Sage Equal to Heaven, has made rebellion. Because he stole peaches, stole wine, and stole elixir within the palace, and threw the Grand Peach Festival into uproar, a hundred thousand heavenly soldiers and eighteen frames of Heaven-Net and Earth-Snare have hemmed the mountain to subdue him, yet have won no victory. We now expressly muster Our worthy nephew, together with his sworn brethren, to go at once to the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit to lend their strength in the work of extermination. When the task is accomplished, there shall be high promotion and rich reward.

The True Lord rejoiced and said, "Heavenly envoy, you may return. I shall go at once and draw my blade to lend aid." The Spirit King went back to make his report — but of that no more.

The True Lord then summoned his six brethren of Plum Mountain — the four Marshals Kang, Zhang, Yao, and Li, and the two Generals Guo Shen and Zhi Jian — and gathered them before the hall, saying, "Just now the Jade Emperor has mustered us to go to the Mountain of Flowers and

Fruit to subdue a monstrous ape. Let us go together." His brethren were all glad to set out. They mustered their spirit-soldiers, loosed the hawks and led the hounds, set their crossbows and drew their bows, and riding a furious gale crossed the Eastern Great Ocean in an instant, coming straight to the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit. Finding the Heaven-Net and Earth-Snare laid in layer upon dense layer so that they could go no farther, they called out, "Hark, you divine generals of the Heaven-Net and Earth-Snare: I am the True Lord Erlang of Manifest Sanctity, mustered by command of the Jade Emperor to capture the monstrous ape. Open your camp gate at once and let me pass." The deities passed the word inward, layer by layer. The Four Heavenly Kings and Heavenly King Li all came out the headquarters gate to receive him. When greetings were done and the matter of victory and defeat was raised, the Heavenly King laid out the whole affair from the beginning.

The True Lord laughed and said, "Since the Little Sage has come here, he must contend with me in transformations. Gentlemen, draw not the net over the top — keep it tight only on the four sides, and let me wager combat with him. If I lose, you need not aid me; I have my brethren to support me. And if I win, you need not bind him; I have my brethren to lay hands on him. I ask only that the Pagoda-Bearing Heavenly King hold up the demon-revealing mirror and stand watch in the air. Lest the wretch be beaten and flee elsewhere, you must shine it clear and bright so that he cannot escape." The Heavenly King took his post, and the heavenly soldiers drew up in their ranks.

The True Lord, leading the four Marshals and two Generals — seven sworn brothers counting himself — came out of camp to give battle, ordering his remaining generals to guard the camp closely and keep the hawks and hounds in check. The grass-headed spirits received their orders. The True Lord came right up to the mouth of the Water-Curtain

Cave, and there saw a band of apes drawn up neat and orderly in the formation of a coiling dragon. In the center of their host stood a single banner pole, and on it were written four words: GREAT SAGE EQUAL TO HEAVEN. Said the True Lord, "That foul monster — how dare he lay claim to a rank equal to Heaven?"

The six brethren of Plum Mountain said, "Spare your wonder, and go challenge him to battle."

When the little apes at the camp mouth saw the True Lord, they ran in haste to report it. The Monkey King at once drew out his gold-banded cudgel, set straight his golden armor, stepped into his cloud-walking shoes, settled his cap of purple gold, and sprang out the camp gate. With a sharp look he saw that the True Lord's features were indeed pure and rare, and his bearing fair and elegant. Truly:

His bearing pure and noble, his face open and grand, two ears hanging to his shoulders, his eyes alight with fire. On his head a Three-Mountains flying-phoenix cap, his body clad in a robe of pale goose-yellow. Gold-threaded boots set off coiling-dragon stockings, a jade belt with rounded flowers, decked in the Eight Treasures. At his waist hung a pellet-bow shaped like the new moon, in his hand he gripped a three-pointed, double-edged spear. With an axe he once split Peach Mountain to rescue his mother; with a pellet he once felled twin phoenixes in the palm-grove. By his might he slew eight monsters, and his fame spread far; in sworn brotherhood he ranged with the Seven Sages of Plum Mountain. Lofty of heart, he disowned his kin in the house of Heaven; proud of nature, he returned to godhood and dwelt by the Guan River. The bright-souled holy one of Chicheng, manifest and merciful, his transformings without bound — and his name is Erlang.

When the Great Sage saw him, he lifted his gold-banded cudgel with a grin and shouted, "What petty general are you, that you dare come so boldly here to challenge me?"

The True Lord roared back, "You wretch, with eyes but no pupils — do you not know me? I am the Jade Emperor's nephew, the True Lord Erlang, by decree enfeoffed as King of Bright Mercy and Manifest Sanctity. By imperial command I have come to capture you — the Bimawen monkey who rebelled against the Heavenly Palace — and still you do not know whether you live or die!"

Said the Great Sage, "I recall how in years past the Jade Emperor's younger sister, yearning for the mortal world, came down to earth, mated with the lord Yang, and bore a son who split Peach Mountain with an axe — is that you? I had half a mind to revile you, but there is no quarrel between us; and half a mind to give you a blow of my cudgel, but it would be a pity to cut short your young life. You young master, you stripling — hurry back and call out your Four Heavenly Kings for me!"

When the True Lord heard this, his heart blazed with fury. "Foul monkey! No more of your insolence — taste my blade!" The Great Sage dodged aside, swiftly raised his gold-banded cudgel, and returned the stroke blow for blow. The two of them fought a fine and deadly fight:

The god of Bright Mercy, Erlang; the Great Sage of Heaven, Sun the Monkey. This one, high of heart, scorned his foe — the handsome Monkey King; that one, strange of face, would crush him down — a true pillar and beam. The two, meeting at first sight, each found his sport in the wager. Never before had they known the shallow from the deep; only today did they learn the light from the heavy. The iron rod rivaled a flying dragon; the divine blade was like a dancing phoenix. Warding left, attacking right; meeting in front, glancing behind. On that side the six brethren of Plum Mountain lent their ardor; on this side the four Generals of the Ma and Liu clans relayed commands. Banners waved and drums rolled, each side of one mind; war-cries and clanging gongs, all swelling the fervor. Their two keen blades watched for the opening, coming and going without a seam between. The gold-banded cudgel is a treasure of the sea, able through its transformings

and soarings to win. Should the body but slow, life is forfeit; a single misstep, and all goes to ruin.

The True Lord and the Great Sage fought past three hundred rounds, and still the outcome was unknown. Then the True Lord roused his divine might: he gave his body a shake and transformed, growing to a height of ten thousand fathoms, his two hands lifting the three-pointed, double-edged divine blade. He was just like a peak atop Mount Hua — blue-faced, fanged, with hair of vermilion red — and savagely he hacked straight at the Great Sage's head. The Great Sage too worked his magic and transformed, making his body the very match of Erlang's, his face and features the same, and lifting his As-You-Will gold-banded cudgel like the Sky-Propping Pillar atop Mount Kunlun, he held the god Erlang off. So terrified were the Marshals Ma and Liu that they trembled and could not wave their banners; the Generals Beng and Ba quailed in fear and could not raise their swords. On the other side, Kang, Zhang, Yao, Li, Guo Shen, and Zhi Jian relayed the command and loosed the grass-headed spirits, who set the hawks and hounds upon the apes outside the Water-Curtain Cave, drew their crossbows and bent their bows, and fell on them all together in a slaughter. Pitiable! — they scattered the four valiant ape-commanders and captured two or three thousand of the magic creatures. Those apes threw down their halberds and cast off their armor, dropped their swords and flung away their spears; the runners ran, the screamers screamed, those for the mountain made for the mountain, those for the cave returned to the cave — like night-owls startling birds from their roost, scattering across the sky like a rain of stars. Of the brethren's victory we say no more.

Now while the True Lord and the Great Sage were locked in their heaven-spanning, earth-shadowing combat, the Great Sage suddenly saw the

apes of his own camp scattered in terror. His heart grew anxious; he gathered in his magic form, hefted his cudgel, and turned to flee. The True Lord, seeing him run defeated, strode after him in great steps, calling, "Where do you run? Surrender now, while you may, and I'll spare your life!" But the Great Sage had no stomach for further fighting and ran with all his heart. As he neared the cave mouth, he ran headlong into the four Marshals Kang, Zhang, Yao, and Li and the two Generals Guo Shen and Zhi Jian, who led their host to block him, crying, "Foul monkey! Where do you think you're going?" The Great Sage lost his nerve. He pinched his gold-banded cudgel down to an embroidery needle and hid it in his ear, then gave his body a shake and changed into a sparrow, and flew up to perch on a treetop. The six brethren, flustered and bewildered, hunted high and low and could not find him, and all together set up a shout: "The ape-sprite has got away! The ape-sprite has got away!"

While they were still clamoring, the True Lord arrived and asked, "Brothers, you chased him to this spot — where did he vanish?"

The deities said, "We had him surrounded here, and then he was gone." Erlang opened wide his phoenix eyes and looked about, and spotted the Great Sage perched on the tree, changed into a sparrow. He drew in his magic form, set aside his divine blade, slipped off his pellet-bow, gave his body a shake, and changed into a hawk-falcon; shaking out his wings, he flew up to strike. The Great Sage saw him coming, and with a whirl flew off, changing into a great cormorant that soared into the sky. Seeing this, Erlang quickly ruffled his feathers, shook his body, and changed into a great sea-crane, piercing up into the clouds to snap at him. The Great Sage then lowered his body, dropped into a ravine stream, and changed into a fish, plunging into the water. Erlang chased to the streamside but saw no trace, and thought to himself, "That ape has surely gone into the water and changed into some fish or shrimp. Let me change again and

catch him." So he changed into a fish-hawk and drifted on the wave-surface at the lower reach of the stream, watching and waiting. The Great Sage, swimming with the current in the form of a fish, suddenly spied a bird overhead — like a blue falcon, yet its feathers were not blue; like an egret, yet it wore no plume on its crown; like an old stork, yet its legs were not red. "That," he thought, "must be Erlang changed and lying in wait for me." He quickly turned, splashed up a little flurry, and swam off. Erlang saw it and said, "That fish that splashed — like a carp, but its tail is not red; like a mandarin-fish, but I see no patterned scales; like a snakehead, but no stars on its head; like a bream, but no spine on its gills. Why did it turn back the moment it saw me? It must surely be that monkey transformed." He swooped down and pecked at it — but the Great Sage darted out of the water, changed, and became a water-snake, swimming to the bank and wriggling into the grass. Erlang, having missed his peck, saw a snake dart out in the splashing water and knew it at once for the Great Sage. He turned swiftly and changed again, into a vermilion-crested grey crane, stretching out his long beak like a pair of sharp iron pincers, and came straight to devour the water-snake. The snake gave a hop and changed once more, into a spotted bustard, standing dull and still upon a sandbar amid the smartweed. Erlang, seeing him changed into so base a creature — for the bustard is the lowest and lewdest of birds, mating without distinction with phoenix, hawk, or crow alike — would not go near it. He resumed his true form, walked over, took up his pellet-bow, drew it full, and with one pellet sent the bustard tumbling head over heels.

The Great Sage, seizing the chance, rolled down the mountain cliff, lay low, and changed again, into a little temple of the local god. His wide-open mouth became the temple gate; his teeth became the door-leaves; his tongue became the bodhisattva within; his eyes became the latticed windows. Only his tail was awkward to dispose of, so he stood it up

behind and made it into a flag pole. The True Lord chased down to the foot of the cliff, but did not see the bustard he had felled — only a small temple. Sharply he opened his phoenix eyes and examined it closely, and seeing the flag pole standing up behind, he laughed and said, "It is that monkey! Now he means to fool me again. I have seen temples before, but never one with a flag pole standing up behind it. This is surely that beast playing tricks. If he means to lure me inside, he'll bite me with one snap of his mouth. Why should I oblige him? Let me first smash the windows with my fist, then kick down the doors." The Great Sage heard him and was alarmed: "How vicious! The doors are my teeth, the windows are my eyes — if he breaks my teeth and smashes my eyes, what then?" With a tiger's leap he sprang up and vanished again into the air.

The True Lord chased about, front and back, when up came the four Marshals and two Generals all together, asking, "Elder brother, have you caught the Great Sage?"

The True Lord laughed and said, "That monkey just now changed into a temple to fool me. I was about to smash his windows and kick his doors when he gave a spring and vanished without a trace. How strange! How strange!" They were all astonished and looked in every direction, but there was no shadow of him. Said the True Lord, "Brothers, keep watch and patrol here. Let me go up to seek him." Swiftly he sprang up and rode a cloud into mid-air. There he saw Heavenly King Li holding high the demon-revealing mirror, with Nezha standing at his side at the cloud's edge. Said the True Lord, "Heavenly King, have you seen the Monkey King?"

The Heavenly King said, "He has not come up here. I have him shining in the mirror." The True Lord told him the whole tale — the wager of transformations, the working of magic, the rout of the apes — then added, "He changed into a temple, and just as I was about to strike, he

got away." Hearing this, Heavenly King Li shone the demon-revealing mirror about the four quarters, then laughed aloud and said, "True Lord, make haste! That monkey has used a body-concealing trick to slip out through the camp ring and has gone off to your own Mouth of the Guan River." Hearing this, Erlang took up his divine blade and turned back in pursuit toward the Mouth of the Guan River.

Now the Great Sage had already reached the Mouth of the Guan River. He gave his body a shake and changed into the very likeness of the lord Erlang, lowered his cloud, and went straight into the temple. The demon-judges could not tell the difference, and one and all kowtowed to receive him. He settled into the central seat and inspected the offerings: there were the three beasts that Li Hu had vowed in thanks, the prayers for blessing that Zhang Long had pledged, the petition of Zhao Jia praying for a son, the votive plea of Qian Bing reporting his illness. While he was looking them over, someone came to report, "Another lord has arrived!" The demon-judges hurried out to look, and not one but was struck with alarm. The True Lord stepped forward and said, "Has there been any so-called Great Sage Equal to Heaven here just now?"

The demon-judges said, "We have seen no Great Sage — there is only one lord inside, going over the offerings."

The True Lord rushed in through the door, and the Great Sage, seeing him, dropped his disguise and showed his true form. "Young master," he said, "save your shouting — this temple goes by the name of Sun now!" The True Lord at once raised his three-pointed, double-edged divine blade and hacked straight at his face. The Monkey King used a deft body-feint to let the blade pass, drew out his embroidery needle, shook it until it was as thick as a bowl, rushed forward, and returned the stroke face to face. Clamoring and brawling, the two of them fought their way out through the temple gate; half in mist, half in cloud, they battled all the

way back to the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit. The Four Heavenly Kings and the rest were thrown into alarm and tightened their guard all the more. Marshals Kang and Zhang and the others joined the True Lord, and combining their strength with one heart, ringed the Handsome Monkey King round — but of that no more.

The tale now tells how the Mighty Magic Spirit King, having mustered the True Lord and his six brethren to lead their troops off to capture the demon, ascended to the upper realm to report. The Jade Emperor, with the Bodhisattva Guanyin, the Queen Mother, and the assembled immortal ministers, were at that very moment conversing in the Hall of Divine Mists. Said the Emperor, "Since Erlang has already gone to give battle, why has a whole day passed with no report?"

Guanyin pressed her palms together and said, "Let this humble nun ask Your Majesty to go with the Patriarch of the Way beyond the Southern Heaven Gate and see for yourselves how the matter truly stands." Said the Jade Emperor, "Reasonably spoken." At once he ordered his carriage made ready, and together with Patriarch Lao Zi, Guanyin, the Queen Mother, and the immortal ministers, passed through the Southern Heaven Gate. Heavenly soldiers and strong men received them, opened the gate wide, and they gazed afar. They saw the heavenly soldiers spreading their net and hemming in all four sides; Heavenly King Li and Nezha holding aloft the demon-revealing mirror as they stood in the air; and the True Lord with the Great Sage locked together in furious combat at the center of the ring.

The Bodhisattva opened her mouth and said to Lao Zi, "How fares the Erlang I recommended? Truly he has magic powers — he has already hemmed the Great Sage in, though he has not yet captured him. Let me now lend a hand, and I shall surely take him." Said Lao Zi, "What weapon would the Bodhisattva use? How will you aid him?"

Said the Bodhisattva, "I will cast down my pure vase of willow to strike the monkey's head. Even if it does not kill him, it will knock him sprawling, so that the Little Sage Erlang may easily take him." Said Lao Zi, "That vase of yours is porcelain. Well enough if it strikes him true — but if it misses his head and falls upon his iron rod instead, would it not shatter to pieces? Stay your hand. Let old Lao Zi lend his aid instead."

"What weapon do you have?" asked the Bodhisattva.

Lao Zi said, "I have one, I have one." Rolling up his sleeve, he took from his left forearm a ring and said, "This weapon is forged of kun-steel, refined and quickened by my Reverting Elixir until it has been suffused through and through with spirit-energy. It excels at transformation; neither water nor fire can harm it, and it can lasso any living thing. One name for it is the Diamond Snare; another, the Diamond Bracelet. In the old days, when I passed through the Hangu Pass and converted the western barbarians, I owed much to it. Morning and night it is the finest of guards upon one's person. Let me cast it down and give him a stroke."

When he had spoken, he flung it down from atop the Heaven Gate. Whirling as it fell, it dropped straight into the camp on the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit and landed square upon the Monkey King's crown. The Monkey King, all his mind bent on the bitter fight against the Seven Sages, never knew that a weapon had dropped from the heavens, and the blow struck him on the top of his head. He could not keep his footing and went down in a tumble, but he scrambled up and ran. Then the slender hound of the lord Erlang overtook him and, with one bite at his calf, dragged him down in a second fall. He lay sprawled upon the ground, cursing, "You wretched cur! Why do you not go plague your own master, but come to bite old Monkey instead!" He twisted hastily to rise but could not, and the Seven Sages swarmed in and pinned him down.

They bound him fast with cords and ran a hooked blade through his pipa-bone collar so that he could transform no more.

Then Lao Zi recovered his Diamond Snare and asked the Jade Emperor, Guanyin, the Queen Mother, and the assembled immortals to return with him to the Hall of Divine Mists. Below, the Four Heavenly Kings, Heavenly King Li, and all the deities recalled their troops and struck their camps, then came forward to congratulate the Little Sage, one and all saying, "This is the Little Sage's achievement!"

Said the Little Sage, "This is the vast blessing of the Heavenly Honored One and the awesome authority of all you deities — what achievement could I claim?" Kang, Zhang, Yao, and Li said, "Elder brother, no more of such talk. Let us march this wretch up to the upper realm to see the Jade Emperor and beg a decree for his sentence."

Said the True Lord, "Worthy brothers, you have not yet received the heavenly registers, and may not appear before the Jade Emperor. Let the armored spirit-soldiers escort him, while I go up with the Heavenly King and the rest to report the decree fulfilled. You lead the host here and search the mountain; when it has been swept clean, return to the Mouth of the Guan River. When I have claimed my reward and reckoned my merit, I'll come back and we shall make merry together." The four Marshals and two Generals assented and obeyed. Then the True Lord and the others mounted their clouds and, singing songs of triumph, returned victorious to Heaven.

In a little while they reached the gate of the Hall of Penetrating Brightness. The Grand Preceptor announced, "The Four Heavenly Kings and the rest have captured the monstrous ape, the Great Sage Equal to Heaven, and have come to await your summons." The Jade Emperor handed down a decree, ordering the Mighty Magic Spirit King and the

heavenly soldiers to march the wretch to the Monster-Slaying Terrace and there hack his corpse to mincemeat. Ah — truly it is said:

For deceit and cunning he now meets the bitter rigor of the law; the hero's lofty spirit is brought, for the time, to an end.

As for how the Monkey King's life would fare — listen to the next chapter told.

Chapter 7: The Great Sage Escapes the Eight-Trigrams Furnace; The Buddha Subdues the Mind-Monkey

Riches, rank, fame, and merit are all portioned out by destiny's earlier ties — so let no man ever cheat his own heart. Walk upright and shining-clear, for loyalty and goodness ripen into ever-deeper fruit. The least breath of arrogance draws Heaven's rebuke, and the moment of reckoning, though slow to come, is sure to arrive. Ask the Lord of Spring: why should calamity press in so close? Only because a heart that climbed too high reached for the boundless, refusing to know high from low, throwing all good counsel into ruin.

Our tale turns to the Great Sage Equal to Heaven, hauled away by the hosts of Heaven to the foot of the Demon-Slaying Platform and bound fast to the Pillar of Subduing Monsters. They hacked at him with swords, chopped at him with axes, stabbed him with spears and gouged him with

blades — yet not one stroke could so much as scratch his skin. The Star Lord of the Southern Dipper ordered the gods of the Fire Department to set him ablaze and roast him, but the flames would not take hold. Then the gods of the Thunder Department were called to drive their thunderbolts into him, and still they could not harm a single hair.

The mighty Demon King and the others reported, "Your Majesty, this Great Sage — we know not where he learned this art of guarding his body. We hewed at him with sword and axe, scorched him with fire and battered him with thunder, and could not damage him in the slightest. What is to be done?"

The Jade Emperor heard this and said, "A creature like this — how in the world are we to deal with him?"

At once the Most High Lord Lao Zi stepped forward to memorialize: "That monkey ate the peaches of immortality, drank the imperial wine, and stole the elixir besides. My five gourds of cinnabar, both the raw and the refined, he gulped down whole into his belly. There, by the working of his samadhi-fire, they have fused into a single mass, so that his whole frame has become a body of adamantine gold — it cannot easily be wounded. It would be best to let me, old Daoist, take him away and set him within my Eight-Trigrams Furnace. With civil fire and martial fire I shall smelt him, and when my elixir has been drawn out of him, his body will of itself be reduced to ashes."

Hearing this, the Jade Emperor commanded the Six Ding and Six Jia spirits to loose him from the pillar and hand him over to Lord Lao. Lord Lao received the decree and departed.

Meanwhile the court summoned Erlang, the Illustrious Sage, and bestowed upon him a hundred golden flowers, a hundred bottles of imperial wine, a hundred grains of restorative elixir, rare treasures,

bright pearls, brocades and embroideries, bidding him share these with his sworn brothers. The True Lord gave thanks for the favor and returned to the mouth of the Guan River — but of that we say no more.

Lord Lao came to his Tushita Palace, unbound the Great Sage's ropes, withdrew the hook that had been thrust through his collarbone, and pushed him into the Eight-Trigrams Furnace. He charged the Daoist who tended the furnace and the boys who fanned the fire to raise the flames and begin the smelting. Now this furnace was divided according to the eight trigrams — Qian, Kan, Gen, Zhen, Xun, Li, Kun, and Dui. The Great Sage promptly squeezed himself down into the quarter of Xun. Xun is the trigram of wind, and where there is wind there is no fire. But the wind whipped the smoke about, and it so reddened and inflamed both his eyes that they remained sore ever after — and from this came his famous fiery eyes and golden pupils.

Truly time flies swiftly, and before anyone knew it the full forty-nine days — seven times seven — had passed, and Lord Lao's smelting was complete. One day the furnace was opened to take out the elixir. The Great Sage was just then covering his eyes with both hands, rubbing them and weeping, when he heard a clatter at the furnace head. He blinked, saw the daylight, and could bear confinement no longer — with a single bound he leaped clear of the furnace. With a thunderous crash he kicked the Eight-Trigrams Furnace over and made for the door. The fire-boys, the furnace-keepers, and the Ding-Jia guards came rushing to grab him, but he knocked them down one after another — like a white-browed tiger seized by madness, like a single-horned dragon driven wild by the wind. Lord Lao lunged and made one grab at him, but the Sage gave him a twist that sent him tumbling head over heels, and so broke free.

Then from his ear he drew out the As-You-Will cudgel. He waved it once into the wind and it grew thick as a bowl, and he gripped it in his hand. Caring nothing for good or ill, he ran riot once more through the Halls of Heaven, beating until the Nine Luminary Stars shut their doors and bolted them fast, and the Four Heavenly Kings vanished without a trace. A fine monkey-spirit! There are verses to prove it:

His primal substance, true and whole, accords with
the prime of Heaven; through ten thousand kalpas,
a thousand turns, it remains but Nature itself.
Boundless, dim, in non-action — utterly the Great
One; serene, unmoving, thus and so — he is named
the First Mystery. Long smelted in the furnace, yet
no mere lead and mercury; beyond all things,
deathless — he is the original immortal. Endlessly
he transforms, and transforms again past counting
— of the Three Refuges and Five Precepts let
nothing more be said.

And again:

One point of numinous light pierces the Great Void;
so too is that staff of his. Now long, now short, as
the wielder wills, crosswise or upright, ranged at
random, rolled out or rolled up at his pleasure.

And again:

The ape's body, in the Way, is matched to the
human mind; the mind is the very ape — the
meaning runs deep. "Great Sage Equal to Heaven"
— no idle boast, yet the office of "Keeper of Horses"
— how could it know his worth? Let horse and ape
work as one, mind and will in accord, bound tight
and tethered fast — seek them not outside yourself.
All forms return to the True from a single principle;
and the Tathagata, sharing that bond, dwells in the
Twin-Tree Grove.

This time the Monkey King recognized neither high nor low. With his
iron rod he struck east and parried west, and there was not a single god
who could withstand him. He fought his way at last into the Hall of
Penetrating Brightness, right up to the doors of the Hall of Numinous

Mists. Happily there stood on guard Wang Lingguan, the lieutenant of the True Lord Protector of the Sages. Seeing the Great Sage rampaging freely, he raised his golden whip and stepped forward to bar the way, crying, "Reckless monkey, where do you think you are going? I am here — do not run wild!" The Great Sage, without a word of argument, lifted his cudgel and struck, and Lingguan met him with the whip. The two of them grappled before the Hall of Numinous Mists — a marvelous fight:

One, of crimson loyalty and good faith, his fame is great; one, who flouts Heaven and deceives his lord, his name is ruined. The low against the worthy — happily they hold their ground; hero against champion, locked in the same wager. The iron rod is fierce, the golden whip is swift; upright and selfless — how could he endure such insolence? This one is the Reverend One of the Great Unity, the Thunder-Voice made manifest; that one is the Great Sage Equal to Heaven, the monkey-monster. Golden whip and iron rod, both houses skilled, and both are the holy weapons of the immortal palaces. This day before the Treasure Hall of Numinous Mists they flaunt their power, each displaying his prowess — truly a thing to admire. One, with a cheating heart, would seize the Palace of the Dipper and the Ox; one, with all his strength, would uphold the realm of the Mysterious Sages. Bitterly they strive, neither yielding, showing their divine arts — whip and rod going back and forth, with neither winner nor loser.

The two of them battled with no decision in sight. Soon the True Lord Protector of the Sages dispatched his officers to send word to the Thunder Bureau, calling out the full Thirty-Six Thunder Generals to come at once. They surrounded the Great Sage in their midst, and each, fierce and savage, joined the desperate fray. Yet the Great Sage showed not a flicker of fear. Wielding his single As-You-Will cudgel, he shielded left and warded right, blocking behind and meeting in front. When he saw the press of the Thunder Generals' swords and spears, blades and halberds, whips and maces, hammers and bludgeons, battle-axes and golden melon-maces, banners, sickles, and moon-shaped shovels coming on hard, he gave his body a shake and transformed: he grew three heads and six arms. He waved the As-You-Will cudgel and it became three cudgels; with his six hands he plied all three at once, whirling like a spinning wheel, round and round, dancing through the heart of the encirclement. None of the Thunder Gods could come near. Truly:

Round and perfect, blazing with light, it has endured since time began — how could men learn it? Cast into fire, it cannot be burned; plunged into water, when was it ever drowned? A single shining mani-pearl, untouched by sword or halberd, blade or spear. It can be good, it can be evil; good and evil, here and now, are his to do. In goodness, he becomes a Buddha or an immortal; in evil, he wears fur and bears horns. With boundless transformations he troubled the Halls of Heaven — the Thunder Generals and divine soldiers could not lay hold of him.

So the gods pressed the Great Sage into one spot yet could not get at his body, and the air rang with nothing but shouting and the clash of arms. Word of it soon startled the Jade Emperor, who issued a decree sending the Roving Inspector Lingguan together with the True Lord Assisting the Sages westward, to beg the Ancient Buddha to come and subdue him.

Having received the decree, the two sages went straight to the holy realm of Spirit Mountain and presented themselves before the precious temple

of the Thunderclap. There they paid their respects to the Four Vajra Guardians and the Eight Bodhisattvas, then asked that their errand be conveyed within. The gods ascended before the Precious Lotus Throne and made it known, and the Tathagata summoned them in. The two sages circled the Buddha three times in reverence and stood in attendance below the throne.

The Tathagata asked, "What matter has brought the two sages all this way to trouble themselves?"

The two sages reported: "Some time ago, on the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit, a monkey was born who there worked his divine arts, gathered the monkey-hordes about him, and threw the world into confusion. The Jade Emperor sent down a decree of amnesty and appointed him Keeper of the Imperial Horses, but he scorned the office as too low and rebelled. Li the Heavenly King and the Prince Nezha were sent to seize him and failed. He was offered amnesty again and made 'Great Sage Equal to Heaven' — a title with rank but no stipend. He was put in charge of the Garden of Immortal Peaches, whereupon he stole the peaches; then he went to the Jasper Pool, stole the viands and the wine, and wrecked the great festival; emboldened by drink he slipped secretly into the Tushita Palace and stole Lord Lao's elixir, then broke out of Heaven altogether. The Jade Emperor sent a hundred thousand heavenly soldiers, and still they could not subdue him. Then Guanyin recommended Erlang the True Lord, who with his sworn brothers pursued and fought him. The monkey changed shape a thousand ways, but thanks to Lord Lao's flung diamond snare striking him down, Erlang was at last able to take him. He was brought before the throne and ordered executed, but sword and axe, fire and thunder could not harm him. Lord Lao obtained leave to take him away and smelt him with fire. After forty-nine days the cauldron was opened — and he leaped out of the Eight-Trigrams Furnace, beat back the

heavenly guards, and pressed straight into the Hall of Penetrating Brightness, to the very doors of the Hall of Numinous Mists. There Wang Lingguan, lieutenant of the True Lord Protector of the Sages, barred his way in bitter combat, and the Thirty-Six Thunder Generals were called to hem him in — yet none could come near him. The matter is urgent, and so the Jade Emperor expressly entreats the Tathagata to come and rescue the throne."

When the Tathagata had heard all this, he said to the assembled bodhisattvas, "All of you remain seated here in the Hall of the Law. Do not disturb your meditation-seats. I shall go and subdue this demon and rescue the throne."

The Tathagata then called his two honored disciples Ananda and Kasyapa to accompany him, left the Thunderclap, and went straight to the gate of the Hall of Numinous Mists. Suddenly he heard shouts that shook the very air — it was the Thirty-Six Thunder Generals hemming in the Great Sage. The Buddha-Patriarch gave his sacred command: "Let the Thunder Generals lay down their weapons and open their ranks. Call that Great Sage out, and let me ask what powers he has." The generals duly withdrew. The Great Sage too put away his magic forms, resumed his true shape, and came forward with his anger blazing, bellowing in a stern voice, "What manner of holy man are you, that you dare come here to stop the fighting and question me?"

The Tathagata smiled and said, "I am Sakyamuni, the Honored One of the Western Paradise of Ultimate Bliss. Namó Amitabha! I have heard that you, a wild and reckless rustic, have time and again rebelled against the Halls of Heaven. I do not know where you were born, in what year you attained the Way, or why you are so violent and overbearing."

The Great Sage said, "I am one who —

Was born of Heaven and Earth, a numinous, primal immortal, an old ape upon the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit. In the Water-Curtain Cave I made my home and estate; I sought out friends and masters and awoke to the Great Mystery. I refined the arts of long life past all counting, and learned transformations boundless and beyond all bounds. Because the mortal world felt cramped and narrow to me, I set my mind firmly on dwelling in the Jasper Heaven. The Treasure Hall of Numinous Mists shall not be his for long — through the ages, even mortal kings hand the throne about in turn. The strong should be honored; the seat should yield to me; the hero alone dares step forth to claim the foremost place."

The Buddha-Patriarch heard him and laughed a cold laugh: "Ha! You are nothing but a monkey turned spirit, and yet you dare to be so brazen — to seek the venerated seat of the Jade Emperor himself, the Supreme Lord? From his youth he cultivated the Way, enduring one thousand seven hundred and fifty kalpas. Each kalpa is a hundred and twenty-nine thousand six hundred years — reckon for yourself how many years one must accumulate before one may enjoy this boundless Great Way! And you, a beast newly come into your first life as a being of intelligence — how dare you speak so grandly? Shameful! Shameful! You are cutting short your own allotted span. Submit and take refuge at once, and talk no more nonsense — for I fear you may meet a cruel hand, and your very life be snuffed out in an instant. What a pity that would be for your original true face."

The Great Sage said, "Young or old in cultivation, he should not occupy that seat forever. As the saying goes, 'The emperorship passes in turns — next year it comes to my house.' Let him only move out and yield the Halls of Heaven to me, and the matter is settled. But if he will not yield, I shall keep up the uproar, and there will never be peace."

The Buddha-Patriarch said, "Besides your arts of long life and transformation, what other powers have you, that you dare to seize the

holy realm of Heaven?"

The Great Sage said, "My talents are many indeed! I have seventy-two transformations and a life that does not age through ten thousand kalpas. I can ride the somersault cloud, and with one leap cover a hundred and eight thousand leagues. Why should I not sit upon the throne of Heaven?"

The Buddha-Patriarch said, "Let me make a wager with you. If you have the skill to leap clear of the palm of my right hand in a single somersault, you win; and then, with no more need of swords and spears or bitter fighting, I shall ask the Jade Emperor to go and dwell in the West and yield the Halls of Heaven to you. But if you cannot leap out of my palm, then go back down to the lower world to be a monster, cultivate yourself for a few more kalpas, and come quarrel again."

When the Great Sage heard this, he laughed to himself: This Tathagata is a thorough fool! With one somersault I, old Sun, go a hundred and eight thousand leagues — and his palm is not even a foot across. How could I possibly fail to jump out of it? Eagerly he spoke up: "Since you say so — can you truly make good on it?"

The Buddha-Patriarch said, "I can, I can." He stretched out his right hand; it was about the size of a lotus leaf.

The Great Sage put away his As-You-Will cudgel, summoned his divine might, and with one bound stood in the center of the Buddha's palm. Then he called out, "I'm off!" Watch him — a streak of cloud-light, formless and shadowless, gone in an instant. The Buddha-Patriarch watched with his eye of wisdom and saw the Monkey King whirling on like a pinwheel, pressing ever forward.

As the Great Sage flew on, he suddenly saw five flesh-colored pillars propping up a band of blue-green vapor. He said to himself, "This must be the end of the road. When I go back with the Tathagata as witness, the Hall of Numinous Mists is surely mine to sit in." Then he thought again: "Wait — let me leave some mark here, so I'll have proof when I speak to the Tathagata." He plucked out a hair, blew on it a breath of immortal energy, and cried, "Change!" It became a writing-brush thick with ink, and on the middle pillar he wrote in great characters: "The Great Sage Equal to Heaven was here." When he had finished, he drew the hair back. Then, with no reverence whatsoever, at the foot of the first pillar he let fly a puddle of monkey-piss. He flipped his somersault cloud around and went straight back to where he had started, stood in the Tathagata's palm, and said, "I went, and now I've returned. Tell the Jade Emperor to yield the Halls of Heaven to me."

The Tathagata cursed him: "You piss-spirit of a monkey! You never even left the palm of my hand."

The Great Sage said, "You don't know what you're talking about! I went to the very end of Heaven and saw five flesh-colored pillars propping up a band of blue-green vapor. I left a mark there — do you dare come with me and look?"

The Tathagata said, "No need to go. Just lower your head and look for yourself."

The Great Sage opened wide his fiery eyes and golden pupils, lowered his head, and looked — and there, on the middle finger of the Buddha-Patriarch's right hand, were written the words, "The Great Sage Equal to Heaven was here." And in the cleft at the base of his thumb the rank smell of monkey-piss still lingered. The Great Sage was startled and said, "Can such a thing be? Can such a thing be? I wrote those words on a

pillar that props up the sky — how can they be on his finger? Surely he has some art of foreknowledge. I won't believe it — I won't! Let me go again and see."

Brave Great Sage! In haste he gathered himself for another leap. But the Buddha-Patriarch turned his palm over and gave him a single push, shoving the Monkey King out beyond the western gate of Heaven. He transformed his five fingers into the five elements — Metal, Wood, Water, Fire, and Earth — joined into five linked peaks, which he named the Mountain of Five Phases, and gently pressed the Great Sage down beneath them. The Thunder Gods, with Ananda and Kasyapa, all pressed their palms together in praise and exclaimed, "Excellent! Excellent!"

In that year, hatched from an egg, he learned to be a man; he fixed his will on cultivation and won the true fruit of the Way. Through ten thousand kalpas, unmoving, he dwelt in the holy realm; but in one day he changed, and his vital spirit was scattered. Flouting Heaven, deceiving his lord, he coveted the high seat; affronting the sages, stealing the elixir, he overthrew the great order. Now that his cup of evil is brimful, the reckoning has come — and who knows on what day he may turn his body free again."

Having destroyed the demon-monkey, the Buddha-Patriarch called Ananda and Kasyapa to return with him to the Western Paradise of Ultimate Bliss. Just then the Heavenly Marshal of the Canopy and the Heavenly Protector came hurrying out of the Hall of Numinous Mists and said, "We beg the Tathagata to wait a little — our sovereign's great chariot is coming." Hearing this, the Buddha-Patriarch turned and gazed upward.

In a moment there appeared a phoenix-carriage of the eight scenes, a canopy of nine lights, with the sound of mystic songs and wondrous music, the chanting of measureless divine scriptures, scattering jeweled

flowers and spreading true incense. It came right up before the Buddha, and the Jade Emperor gave thanks, saying, "We owe it entirely to your great Law that this demon-fiend has been subdued and destroyed. We beg the Tathagata to tarry but one day, that we may invite all the immortals to hold a feast of thanksgiving."

The Tathagata dared not refuse, and pressing his palms together he said in thanks, "This old monk came here only at the bidding of the Great Heavenly Honored One — what power of mine was it? It was the boundless blessing of the Heavenly Honored One and all the gods. How could I trouble you to thank me?"

The Jade Emperor then issued his decree, sending the gods of the Thunder Department to go in all directions and invite the Three Pure Ones, the Four Imperial Lords, the Five Elders, the Six Ministries, the Seven Primes, the Eight Poles, the Nine Luminaries, the Ten Capitals, the Thousand True Ones and the Myriad Sages, all to come to the feast and together give thanks for the Buddha's grace. He further commanded the Four Great Heavenly Teachers and the Nine Heavenly Maidens to throw wide the Golden Towers of the Jade Capital, the Treasure Palace of Supreme Mystery, and the Jade Hall of the Cavern of Yang, to invite the Tathagata to take the high seat upon a Numinous Dais of seven treasures, and to set out the ranked places, arranging dragon-livers and phoenix-marrow, jade nectar and immortal peaches.

In no time at all came the Heavenly Honored One of Jade Purity, the Primordial Beginning; the Heavenly Honored One of Upper Purity, the Numinous Treasure; the Heavenly Honored One of Grand Purity, the Way and Its Power; the True Lords of the Five Influences, the Star Lords of the Five Dippers, the Three Officers and the Four Sages, the True Lords of the Nine Luminaries, the Left Assistant and the Right Supporter, the Heavenly Kings and Nezha — every numinous and far-

reaching power, in paired banners and twin canopies, all bearing bright pearls and rare treasures, longevity-fruits and wondrous flowers. They bowed before the Buddha and presented their gifts, saying, "We are grateful to the Tathagata's measureless power of the Law for subduing the demon-monkey. By the grace of the Great Heavenly Honored One a feast is laid, and we have all been called here to offer our thanks. Will the Tathagata bestow a name upon this gathering?"

The Tathagata, accepting the gods' request, said, "If a name is to be given, let it be called the Assembly for the Peace of Heaven." With one voice the immortals and elders all cried, "A fine 'Assembly for the Peace of Heaven'! A fine 'Assembly for the Peace of Heaven'!" So saying, each took his seat, and the goblets went round and the wine-cups were passed. They wore flowers in their hair and struck the zithers — truly a splendid gathering. There are verses to prove it:

A feast was set with immortal peaches — the monkey threw it into chaos; the Assembly for the Peace of Heaven surpasses the Peach Feast itself. Dragon-banners and phoenix-chariots, auspicious light glowing soft; jeweled standards and pennoned canopies, lucky vapors drifting high. Immortal music and mystic songs, their tones and rhythms sweet; phoenix flutes and jade pipes ringing loud and clear. Fragrant jasper-incense curling, the throng of immortals gathered — the cosmos clear and at peace, hailing the holy court.

While all rejoiced in the happy gathering, behold — the Queen Mother of the West led in a troupe of immortal maidens, fairy girls, lovely consorts and beautiful women, who came floating and swaying in dance before the Buddha. Bowing, she said, "Lately the demon-monkey threw my Peach Feast into disorder, so that the gathering of immortals and Buddhas could not be completed. Now, by the Tathagata's great Law, that stubborn monkey has been smelted and chained, and we celebrate the joyous Assembly for the Peace of Heaven. Having nothing else to offer in

thanks, I have with my own clean hands plucked several great peaches of immortality from the largest tree, to present to you." Truly:

Half red, half green, breathing a sweet fragrance, these glorious immortal roots that endure ten thousand ages. Laughable are the seedlings sown at Wuling's spring-source — how could they vie with the rarer, mightier fruit of the Heavenly Court? Purple-veined, tender and delicate, few in all the world; pale-kerneled, clear and sweet, with no match under heaven. They lengthen life, extend the years, and can transform the body — and one who is fated to eat them becomes a being beyond the ordinary.

The Buddha-Patriarch joined his palms and gave thanks to the Queen Mother. She then bade the immortal maidens and fairy girls sing and dance, and the whole assembly of immortals praised them in admiration. Indeed:

Faint, ethereal heavenly fragrance fills every seat; riotous immortal blossoms and fairy flowers. In the Golden Towers of the Jade Capital, glory beyond measure; rare wares and wondrous treasures of priceless worth. Pair upon pair, long-lived as Heaven itself; couple upon couple, gaining ten thousand kalpas more. Let the mulberry-fields and the blue seas change as they will — they themselves know neither alarm nor amazement.

While the Queen Mother had the immortal maidens singing and dancing, and the goblets and tallies passed back and forth, before long there came once more—

A gust of strange fragrance reached every nose, startling all the stars and constellations in the hall. Heaven's immortals and the Buddha-Patriarch set down their cups; each raised his head and gazed in welcome. In the midst of the empyrean appeared an old man, bearing in his hands the numinous fungus, soaring amid embroidered mists. His gourd held hidden a ten-thousand-year elixir; his treasured register inscribed a thousand-cycle span of life. Within his cave, heaven and earth

are his to roam at will; in his gourd, sun and moon ripen at his pleasure. Wandering the Four Seas, he delights in quiet leisure; free and easy through the Ten Isles, he draws all together. Many a time at the Peach Feast he has come and grown tipsy; and waking, found the bright moon still as it was before. Long of head and large of ear, short of body — the South Pole's own, he is called the Old Star of Long Life.

The Star of Longevity had arrived. Having paid his respects to the Jade Emperor, he turned also to the Tathagata and gave thanks, saying, "When I first heard that the demon-monkey had been led by Lord Lao to the Tushita Palace and smelted there, I thought peace was assured — never expecting that he would break out again. Happily the Tathagata has well subdued this fiend, and a feast of thanks has been laid; therefore, hearing word of it, I have come. I have nothing else to offer — only this purple fungus and jade-grass, this jade lotus-root and golden elixir, which I present to you." His verse ran:

Jade lotus-root and golden elixir I offer to Sakyamuni — may the Tathagata's myriad years be as the sands of the Ganges. Pure and peaceful, ever joyous in the brocade of the Three Vehicles; hale and long-lived among the flowers of the Nine Ranks. In the gate of formlessness, the true Lord of the Law; in the heaven of form-and-emptiness, the home of immortals. Through heaven and earth, the great land, all hail him as Patriarch — his sixteen-foot golden body, with blessings and long life to spare.

The Tathagata gladly accepted his thanks. The Star of Longevity took his seat, and as before the goblets and cups went round. Then came also the Barefoot Great Immortal, who bowed low before the Jade Emperor, and turning to the Buddha-Patriarch likewise gave thanks: "Deeply do I feel the power of your Law in subduing the demon-monkey. Having nothing worthy to mark my respect, I present these two cross-pears and several fire-jujubes." His verse ran:

The Great Immortal, barefoot, with fragrant jujubes and pears, reverently offers them to Amitabha, that his life-span be long. The seven-jeweled lotus dais, steady as a mountain; the thousand-gold flower-throne, adorned like brocade. To say his life equals heaven and earth is no falsehood; to say his blessings outdo the vast waves is no wild talk. Blessing and long life, exactly as he wished — truly so; that quiet, supremely blissful land of the West.

The Tathagata gave thanks once more and bade Ananda and Kasyapa take up all the gifts that had been offered and store them away, one by one. Then he turned to the Jade Emperor to give thanks for the feast, and all were thoroughly drunk. Just then a patrolling Inspector Lingguan came to report, "The Great Sage has stuck out his head!"

The Buddha-Patriarch said, "No matter, no matter." From his sleeve he drew out a slip of paper on which were written six golden words: "Om Mani Padme Hum." He handed it to Ananda and bade him paste it on the mountaintop. The honored disciple took the slip, carried it out through the gate of Heaven to the summit of the Mountain of Five Phases, and pasted it firmly upon a square stone. At once the mountain took root and its seams closed shut. The Great Sage could still draw breath and move his hand to claw it out a little, could manage a feeble struggle — but no more. Ananda returned and reported, "I have pasted the slip."

The Tathagata then took his leave of the Jade Emperor and all the gods, and with the two honored disciples passed out beyond the gate of Heaven. Moved once more by compassion, he recited a true incantation and summoned a Local Spirit of the Mountain of Five Phases, who together with the Revealers of the Five Quarters was to dwell upon that mountain and keep watch over the prisoner. "When he is hungry," the Buddha ordered, "give him iron pellets to eat; when he is thirsty, give him molten copper to drink. When the days of his punishment are fulfilled, there will of itself come one to save him." Indeed:

The bold demon-monkey rebelled against the Halls of Heaven, but was subdued at last by the Tathagata's hand. Thirsty, he drinks molten copper to wear out the years; hungry, he eats iron pellets to pass the time. Suffering heaven's calamity, he endures the grinding torment; through cold misfortune in human affairs, he is glad his life is long. If ever the hero may put forth his strength again, in some later year he shall serve the Buddha and go west.

And again a verse:

Vaunting his might, his great power flourished; he tamed dragons and subdued tigers, plying his crafty skill. Stealing peaches and stealing wine, he roamed the Heavenly Court; receiving register and grace, he dwelt in the Jade Capital. His cup of evil brimful, his body now is bound; but his root of goodness unbroken, his spirit yet shall rise. Surely, when he has slipped free of the Tathagata's hand, he will wait for the Tang dynasty to send forth its holy monk.

After all, no one knows in what year or what month his calamity and punishment will at last be fulfilled — so listen to the next chapter for the explanation.

Chapter 8: The Buddha Forges the Scriptures, and Guanyin Seeks the Pilgrim

Try if you can to test the gate of Chan— Countless are they who have sought and questioned, and time and again come to nothing, grown old in vain. Grinding a brick to make a mirror, hoarding snowfall for grain— how many years of youth are lost in delusion? A single hair swallows the great sea, a mustard seed holds up Mount Sumeru, and the golden-bodied ascetic faintly smiles. In the moment of waking he soars past the Ten Stages and Three Vehicles, while the heedless stay mired in the Four Births and Six Paths. Who is there to listen, before the Cliff of No Thought, beneath the Shadowless Tree, when the cuckoo cries out the spring dawn?

The road to Caoxi is perilous, the clouds over Vulture Peak hang deep, and in such a place the voices of old friends fade away. From cliffs of ice a thousand fathoms high, where the five-petaled lotus opens, the ancient hall's curtain droops as incense curls. In that very season, once the source of all is seen through, the Dragon King's Three Treasures stand revealed.

This poem is set to the tune "Su Wu Slowly." Our tale tells how the Buddha, the Tathagata, having taken his leave of the Jade Emperor, returned to his precious temple of Thunderclap. There he beheld the Three Thousand Buddhas, the Five Hundred Arhats, the Eight Great Vajra Guardians, and Bodhisattvas beyond number — each one bearing banners and streamers, jeweled canopies, rare treasures, and immortal flowers — arrayed in welcome beneath the twin sala trees of the Spirit Mountain's blessed land. The Tathagata reined in his auspicious cloud and addressed the assembly:

"With my profound wisdom I have looked upon the Three Realms entire. The root nature, in its essence, is utter stillness and extinction. Like the form of empty space, it is wholly without substance. The vanquishing of the unruly monkey is a matter no one can fathom. It marks the beginning of birth and death; the marks of all phenomena are thus."

Having spoken, he released the radiance of the sacred relic, and forty-two rainbows of white light filled the sky, joining north to south. The whole congregation, beholding this, bowed down and worshiped. After a little while the auspicious clouds and bright mists gathered, and the Buddha ascended his lotus throne of the highest grade and seated himself in serene composure. Then the Three Thousand Buddhas, the Five Hundred Arhats, the Eight Vajra Guardians, and the Four Bodhisattvas came forward with palms pressed together, made their obeisance, and asked: "Who was it that threw Heaven into uproar and ravaged the Peach Banquet?"

The Tathagata replied: "That creature was a monstrous monkey born of the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit, whose crimes overtopped the very sky and were beyond all telling. Not one of Heaven's gods and generals could subdue him. Though Erlang captured him and Lord Lao Zi smelted him in fire, even that could do him no harm. When I arrived, he stood amid the lords of thunder flaunting his might, vaunting his prowess, and showing off his spirit. I stayed their weapons of war and asked him of his origins. He boasted of his magic powers, his arts of transformation, and his somersault cloud that carries him a hundred and eight thousand miles at a bound. So I made a wager with him; he could not pass beyond my hand, and with a single grasp I seized him, transformed my fingers into the Mountain of Five Phases, and sealed him there beneath it. The Jade Emperor flung wide the golden gates of his jasper palace, invited me to the seat of honor, and held a Great Banquet for the Peace of Heaven in my thanks. Only then did I take my leave and return."

The assembly, hearing this, rejoiced and praised him without end.

When the thanksgiving was done, they divided into their ranks and withdrew, each taking up his own task, all delighting together in the truth of their nature. Truly it was so:

Auspicious haze drifts over the Indian realm, rainbow light enfolds the World-Honored One. The West is called the foremost of all lands, the gate of the formless Dharma King. Often the dark gibbons offer fruit, the spotted deer bring flowers in their mouths; the azure simurgh dances, the bright phoenix sings; the holy tortoise bears longevity, the immortal crane holds the magic fungus. In peace they dwell in the Pure Land's grove, enjoying the Dragon Palace, the realm of the Dharma. Day after day the flowers open, hour after hour the fruit ripens. Practicing stillness, returning to the true, meditating in Chan, perfecting the fruit— neither perishing nor arising, neither increasing nor diminishing. The misted haze drifts faint as they come and go; neither cold nor heat intrudes, and the years go uncounted.

And the verse runs:

Coming and going at ease, they roam at leisure, with neither dread nor sorrow in their hearts. In the field of Utmost Bliss all is open and broad; in the vastness of the great cosmos there are no springs nor autumns.

The Buddha-Patriarch dwelt within the precious temple of Great Thunderclap on Spirit Mountain. One day he summoned together all the Buddhas, Arhats, Guardians, Bodhisattvas, Vajra Lords, and the monks and nuns of his order, and said: "Since I subdued that unruly ape and brought peace to Heaven, I have lost all count of the months and years here; but I reckon that some five hundred years have passed in the mortal world. Today falls on the full moon of early autumn. I have a precious basin, and in it I have set out a hundred kinds of rare flowers and a thousand sorts of strange fruits, that you may share with me this Ullambana Feast. What say you?"

The whole assembly, each one of them, pressed their palms together and circled the Buddha three times in reverence and consent. The Tathagata then took the flowers and fruits and dainties from the precious basin, bidding Ananda hold them up and Kasyapa scatter them abroad. The multitude, moved with gratitude, each offered a poem in thanks.

The poem of Blessing ran:

The Star of Blessing shines bright before the World-Honored One; the store of blessing, deeper still, grows ever more far-reaching. The virtue of blessing knows no bound, enduring as the earth; the bond of blessing holds its joy, joined to the very heaven. The field of blessing, widely sown, flourishes year by year; the sea of blessing, vast and deep, stands firmer age by age. With blessing filling heaven and earth, its sheltering grace is manifold; blessing increased beyond all measure, forever whole and complete.

The poem of Prosperity ran:

Prosperity weighs heavy as a mountain, the bright phoenix sings; prosperity rides on the seasons' peace, hailing the morning star. Prosperity adds ten thousand measures, the body sound and strong; prosperity gives a thousand goblets, the world serene and calm. Prosperity's salary equals heaven's, lasting and secure; prosperity's renown is like the sea, the purer and the clearer. Prosperity's grace, far handed down, draws many an admiring gaze; prosperity's rank without a bound, a glory to ten thousand realms.

The poem of Longevity ran:

The Star of Longevity offers its radiance before the Tathagata; the realm of long life, in splendor, opens from this hour. The fruits of longevity heap the platter, breeding auspicious haze; the flowers of longevity, freshly picked, are set upon the lotus throne. The verse of longevity, pure and elegant, is full of rare delight; the song of longevity, tuned in measure, is crafted with fine skill. The span of longevity, drawn out long, matches the sun and moon; long life like mountains and seas, more boundless yet, and far.

When the Bodhisattvas had finished offering their poems, they begged the Tathagata to make plain the root of all things and to unravel for them the source and stream. The Tathagata gently parted his benevolent lips, expounded the Great Law, and proclaimed the True Fruit. What he taught were the wondrous scriptures of the Three Vehicles, the Surangama of the Five Aggregates. And there one saw the heavenly dragons circling round, and a rain of flowers falling in profusion. Truly:

The Chan mind shines clear as the moon on a thousand rivers; the true nature holds pure within it the sky of ten thousand miles.

When the Tathagata had finished his discourse, he addressed the assembly: "I have observed the four great continents, and the good and

evil of their living beings differ from place to place. In the Eastern Continent of Superior Body, men revere Heaven and honor Earth; their hearts are bright and their dispositions even. In the Northern Continent of Kuru, though they are fond of slaughter, it is only to fill their bellies; their natures are crude and their feelings sparse, and they do little real harm. In my own Western Continent of Cattle-Gift, men neither covet nor kill; they nourish their breath and conceal their spirit, and though they have no supreme sages, every one of them attains a firm and long life. But in that Southern Continent of Jambu, men are greedy and lustful, delighting in mischief; they kill much and quarrel much — truly a battleground of wicked tongues, a sea of strife and slander. Now I have the Three Stores of True Scriptures, by which men may be exhorted to do good."

Hearing this, the Bodhisattvas pressed their palms together in submission and, facing the Buddha, asked: "And what are these Three Stores of True Scriptures that the Tathagata possesses?"

The Tathagata said: "I have one Store of the Vinaya, which speaks of Heaven; one Store of the Sastras, which tells of Earth; and one Store of the Sutras, which redeems the dead. Together the Three Stores comprise thirty-five divisions, totaling fifteen thousand one hundred and forty-four scrolls. They are the scriptures of cultivating the truth, the very gateway to goodness. I should like to send them to the Eastern Lands; but I fear the living beings of that quarter are foolish and benighted — they would slander the true words, failing to grasp the essential meaning of my Dharma gate and despising the orthodox teaching of Yoga. How might I find one of magic power to go to the Eastern Lands, and seek out there a good and faithful seeker, to teach him to journey in hardship over a thousand mountains and across ten thousand waters until he comes to my dwelling to ask for the True Scriptures, that they may be handed

down forever in the East and turn the multitudes toward good? That would be a blessing high as the mountains and a beneficence deep as the sea. Who is willing to make the journey?"

At this the Bodhisattva Guanyin drew near the lotus throne, circled the Buddha three times in reverence, and said: "Though your disciple is of small worth, she is willing to go to the Eastern Lands to seek out a scripture-pilgrim."

The whole assembly raised their heads to look, and this is what they saw of the Bodhisattva:

Her understanding is rounded with the Four Virtues, her wisdom fills her golden body. Strings of pearls and kingfisher gems hang down, a fragrant ring of jeweled brightness is clasped about her. Dark clouds deftly piled in a coiled-dragon coiffure; an embroidered sash floats light with bright phoenix plumes. Buttons of green jade, a robe of plain silk, wrapped round in auspicious light; a brocaded skirt, a golden chain, shrouded and met by lucky vapors. Her brows are like a slender crescent moon, her eyes are like a pair of stars. Her jade face is born to joy, her vermilion lips a single point of red. The pure vase of sweet dew is full year after year, the slanting willow sprig is green age after age. She unbinds the Eight Calamities, she redeems the throngs of the living, great in mercy and compassion: so she keeps watch over the great mountain, dwells in the Southern Sea, saving the afflicted, seeking out the voices of distress, answering ten thousand calls with ten thousand replies, a thousand-saint, a thousand-spirit presence. Her orchid heart delights in the purple bamboo, her gentle nature loves the fragrant vines. She is the merciful mistress upon Potalaka Mountain, the living Guanyin within the Tide-Sound Cave.

The Tathagata, beholding her, rejoiced greatly in his heart and said: "No other could make this journey. It must be the Honored Guanyin, whose magic powers are vast and far-reaching—only she is equal to the task."

The Bodhisattva said: "What instructions does your disciple carry as she goes to the Eastern Lands?"

The Tathagata said: "On this journey you must survey the road on foot; you may not travel high in the empyrean. You must go half by cloud and half by mist, passing over mountains and rivers with your eyes open, taking careful note of the distances along the route, so that you may later instruct the scripture-pilgrim. But lest the good and faithful one find the way too hard, I shall give you five treasures." He at once bade Ananda and Kasyapa bring out a brocaded cassock and a nine-ringed monk's staff, and said to the Bodhisattva: "This cassock and this staff may be given to the scripture-pilgrim for his own use. If he sets his heart firmly on coming here and wears my cassock, he shall escape the wheel of rebirth; if he carries my staff, he shall not meet with poison or harm."

The Bodhisattva bowed in submission and received them. The Tathagata then brought out three fillets and handed them to the Bodhisattva, saying: "These treasures are called the Tightening Fillets. Though the three are all alike in form, each is used in a different way. I have three spells of golden binding and restraint. If along the road you should meet with demons of vast and far-reaching power, you must urge them to embrace goodness and to follow the scripture-pilgrim as his disciples. If any of them will not submit to command, you may set one of these fillets upon his head, and of itself it will take root in the flesh. Then recite the proper spell, and his eyes will swell, his head will throb, his very skull will split—and that will surely bring him into my gate."

Hearing this, the Bodhisattva leapt for joy, bowed low, and withdrew. She at once summoned her disciple Hui'an to accompany her. This Hui'an wielded an iron rod of solid black metal weighing a thousand pounds, and he served at the Bodhisattva's side as a mighty demon-quelling guardian. The Bodhisattva made the brocaded cassock into a bundle and

had him carry it on his back. She hid the golden fillets away, took up the monk's staff, and descended straight from Spirit Mountain. This journey was destined to bring it about that:

The Buddha's son returns at last to fulfill his original vow, and the Elder Golden Cicada is wrapped once more in sandalwood.

When the Bodhisattva reached the foot of the mountain, the Great Immortal of the Golden Crown at the Jade Truth Abbey met her at the gate and invited her in to take tea. The Bodhisattva did not dare to linger and said: "I have today received the Buddha's command to travel to the Eastern Lands to seek a scripture-pilgrim."

The Great Immortal said: "When will this scripture-pilgrim arrive?"

The Bodhisattva said: "It is not yet fixed—perhaps in two or three years he may come this far." Then she took her leave of the Great Immortal and pressed on, traveling half by cloud and half by mist, marking the distances of the route. There is a poem to bear witness:

Across ten thousand miles she seeks her man and does not speak of it, yet they say to fulfill one's purpose wholly is hard. If to seek a man should ever be just so as this, then is my whole life's labor mere chance and accident? To preach the Way with method becomes idle talk; to make it plain without faith is empty transmission too. Willing to bare her heart and liver to find a kindred soul, she reckons that up ahead there must be destined ties.

As mistress and disciple journeyed on, they suddenly came upon a stretch of the Weak Water Three Thousand Leagues—the boundary of the Flowing Sands River. The Bodhisattva said: "Disciple, this is a hard place to cross. The scripture-pilgrim will be of muddy bone and common flesh—how will he ever get over?"

Hui'an said: "Master, how wide do you judge the river to be?"

The Bodhisattva halted her cloud-step and looked, and saw only this:

*Eastward it joins the desert sands, westward it reaches the foreign tribes,
southward it runs to Wuge, northward it links with the Tartars. Straight across it
stretches eight hundred miles; up and down, ten million leagues in length. The water
flows as if the very earth turned over, the waves roll up like mountains heaving their
backs. Vast and boundless, dim and limitless, ten miles off one hears its thunder ten
thousand fathoms high. An immortal's raft could never reach this place, and the
lotus leaf can find no float upon it. Withered grass in the slanting sun by the
winding shore, yellow clouds darkening the sun above the long embankment. Where
do merchants ever come and go? When has a fisherman ever made his rest here? On
the level sands no wild goose alights; on the far bank only the gibbon cries. Only the
red knotweed knows the season's hue, and the white duckweed, faintly fragrant,
drifts as it will.*

As the Bodhisattva was gazing about her, all at once a splashing crash erupted from within the river, and out of the waves leaped a monster, hideous beyond measure. This was how he was made:

*Not green, not black, a face of ill-omened hue; not tall, not short, a bare-footed,
sinewy frame. His eyes flashed and flickered like twin lamps beneath a stove; the
corners of his mouth forked open like a butcher's brazier. His tusks thrust out like
sword-blades, his red hair was tangled and wild. A single roar of his bellow was like
a clap of thunder, and his two feet rushed onward like a rolling gale.*

The monster gripped a precious staff in both hands, came up the bank, and made to seize the Bodhisattva—but Hui'an drew his solid iron rod to block him, shouting: "Stand and don't run!" The monster met him at once with his precious staff. The two of them fought a fearsome battle there on the shore of the Flowing Sands, a battle truly terrifying to behold:

Moksa's solid iron rod displayed the Dharma-guard's divine power; the monster's demon-quelling staff strained to show its heroic might. Two silver pythons danced by the riverside, a pair of holy monks clashed on the bank. The one made his might to overawe the Flowing Sands; the other strove to guard Guanyin and win great merit. The one churned the waves and leaped the billows, the other spat the mist and breathed forth the wind. Churning waves and leaping billows darkened heaven and earth; spitting mist and breathing wind dimmed the sun and moon. That demon-quelling staff was like a white tiger come down from the hills; this solid iron rod was like a yellow dragon stretched across the road. When the one struck out, it was like beating the grass to start a snake; when the other flung free, it was like a falcon scattering through the pines. They fought till all was dim and dark, the stars and constellations blazing; till the mists came surging up, and heaven and earth grew hazy. The one, long dwelling in the Weak Water, was the fiercer there; the other, newly come from Spirit Mountain, won his first great merit.

The two of them went back and forth, fighting some twenty or thirty bouts with neither gaining the upper hand. At last the monster fended off the iron rod and called out: "What temple do you hail from, monk, that you dare come and stand against me?"

Moksa said: "I am Moksa Hui'an, second prince of the Pagoda-Bearing Heavenly King Li, and I am now escorting my master to the Eastern Lands to seek a scripture-pilgrim. What manner of monster are you, that you dare so boldly to block our way?"

At these words the monster seemed to come to himself and said: "I remember you—you cultivated the Way alongside Guanyin of the Southern Sea in the Purple Bamboo Grove. Why have you come here?"

Moksa said: "Is that not my master there upon the bank?"

Hearing this, the monster murmured assent again and again, put away his precious staff, and let Moksa lead him down to where Guanyin stood.

He bowed his head to the ground and made his plea: "Bodhisattva, forgive my crime, and let me tell my tale. I am no fiend or demon born. I was once the Curtain-Raising Marshal who attended the imperial carriage before the Hall of the Numinous Empyrean. Only because at the Peach Banquet I let slip my hand and shattered a crystal goblet, the Jade Emperor had me beaten eight hundred strokes and banished down to this world, transformed into this monstrous shape. And further, once every seven days he sends a flying sword to pierce my breast and ribs a hundred times and more before it returns. Such is my torment. Helpless, unable to bear the hunger and cold, every two or three days I come out from the waves and seize a passerby to eat. Today, in my ignorance, I never thought I should affront the great and merciful Bodhisattva."

The Bodhisattva said: "You sinned in Heaven and were banished here, and now you go on harming living things in this way—this is truly crime piled upon crime. I have received the Buddha's command to go to the Eastern Lands to seek a scripture-pilgrim. Why do you not enter my gate, take refuge in the fruit of goodness, and follow the scripture-pilgrim as his disciple on the journey to the Western Heaven to worship the Buddha and seek the scriptures? I will see to it that the flying sword no longer comes to pierce you. And when the work is accomplished, your sin shall be remitted and your former office restored. What say you to that?"

The monster said: "I am willing to take refuge in the true fruit." Then he came forward again and said: "Bodhisattva, in this place I have devoured men beyond counting. Several scripture-pilgrims have come this way before, and I ate every one of them. The heads of those I ate I flung into the Flowing Sands, and they sank straight to the bottom—for in this water not even a goose feather will float. Only nine skulls of scripture-pilgrims float upon the surface and will not sink. I thought them strange things, so I strung them together with a cord and would take them out to

play with in my idle hours. But on this journey, I fear the scripture-pilgrim may never get this far—and then would I not have ruined my own future after all?"

The Bodhisattva said: "How could there be no chance of his arriving? You may hang those skulls about your neck and wait for the scripture-pilgrim—there will be a use for them." The monster said: "If that is so, I am willing to receive your teaching." Then the Bodhisattva laid her hand upon his crown and gave him the precepts, taking "sand" for his surname, so that he was called Sha; and she gave him a religious name, calling him Sha Wujing—Sand-Awakened-to-Purity. From that hour he entered the Buddhist order, saw the Bodhisattva across the river, washed his heart clean and purged his thoughts, harmed living things no more, and waited single-mindedly for the scripture-pilgrim.

The Bodhisattva took her leave of him and, together with Moksa, hastened on straight toward the Eastern Lands. They traveled a good while, and again came upon a high mountain over which a baleful vapor hung so thick that they could not climb it on foot. Just as they were about to ride their cloud over the summit, all at once a wild wind sprang up and out flashed another monster. He too was a creature most fierce and dangerous; this is how he looked:

His snout hung down, fleshy and dangling like a lotus pod; his ears were like rush-leaf fans, and his golden eyes shone bright. His tusks were sharp and keen as a file of steel; his long mouth gaped open like a brazier of fire. A golden helmet was tightly strapped beneath his cheeks; his armor was bound with cords, like the sloughed scales of a python. In his hands he held a rake like a dragon's questing claws; at his waist hung a curved bow like the half-disk of the moon. Bristling with might, he overawed the very Year-Star; soaring in spirit, he overbore the gods of Heaven.

He charged straight at them and, with no regard for good or ill, lifted his rake against the Bodhisattva and struck. But Moksa blocked him with his rod, crying out in a great voice: "Vile monster, hold your insolence! Look to my rod!"

The monster said: "This monk does not know whether he is alive or dead. Look to my rake!" The two of them clashed at the foot of the mountain, gambling on victory or defeat—and truly it was a fine battle:

The monster fierce and savage, Hui'an mighty and able. The iron rod pounded at his heart, the rake came chopping at his face. Scattering earth and raising dust, they darkened heaven and earth; flying sand and rolling stones startled the very gods and ghosts. The nine-toothed rake, flashing bright, its double rings ringing loud; the single rod, black and blurred, flying in his two hands. This one was the Heavenly King's prince, that one a marshal's wandering spirit. The one is a Dharma-guard at Potalaka, the other a goblin in a mountain cave. This meeting was a contest for the higher hand— who could tell which would lose and which would win?

Just as the two of them had fought to the very pitch, Guanshiyin, from amid the air, cast down a lotus blossom that parted the rake and the rod. The monster, seeing it, was struck with alarm and demanded: "What temple do you hail from, monk, that you dare conjure such tricks with flowers before my eyes to fool me?"

Moksa said: "You fleshly-eyed, common-born vile creature! I am the disciple of the Bodhisattva of the Southern Sea. This is a lotus blossom flung down by my master, and you do not even know it!"

The monster said: "The Bodhisattva of the Southern Sea—is that the Guanshiyin who sweeps away the Three Calamities and saves from the Eight Difficulties?" Moksa said: "Who else should it be?" The monster threw down his rake, bowed his head to the ground, and said: "Elder

brother, where is the Bodhisattva? Pray trouble yourself to present me to her."

Moksa lifted his face and pointed: "Is that not she up there?" The monster knocked his head upon the ground and cried out in a loud voice: "Bodhisattva, forgive my crime! Forgive my crime!"

Guanyin brought her cloud down low, came forward, and asked: "What wild boar turned to a spirit are you, what old swine become a fiend, that you dare to block my way here?"

The monster said: "I am no wild boar, nor any old swine. I was in truth the Marshal of the Heavenly Reeds in the River of Heaven. Only because, in my cups, I made sport with the moon-goddess Chang'e, the Jade Emperor had me beaten two thousand strokes with the mallet and banished me to the mortal dust. My spirit went straight down to seize a dwelling and be born again; but I lost my way and entered the womb of a sow, and so was changed into this shape. I bit the sow to death, slew the whole litter of swine, and here took possession of the mountain ground, living by devouring men. I never thought to run against the Bodhisattva—I beg you, save me, save me!"

The Bodhisattva said: "What is this mountain called?" The monster said: "It is called Mount Fuling. In the mountain there is a cave called the Cloud-Ladder Cave. In the cave there once lived a maiden named Second-Sister Egg. Seeing that I had some skill in arms, she took me in as the master of her house—what they call marrying into the household. But before a year was out she died, and all the cave's possessions came to me to enjoy. Long years I have dwelt here with no honest livelihood to support me, doing nothing but living by my old trade of eating men. I beg the Bodhisattva to forgive my crime."

The Bodhisattva said: "The ancients say, 'If you would have a future, do not do what has no future.' You broke the law in the upper realm, and now you still do not mend your savage heart but harm the living and breed sin—is this not to deserve punishment for both crimes at once?"

The monster said: "A future, a future! If I followed your way, you would have me feed on wind. As the saying goes: 'Follow the law of the magistrate and you will be beaten to death; follow the law of the Buddha and you will be starved to death.' Off with you, off with you! I had far rather catch myself a traveler, plump and juicy, and eat him whole—and what care I for two crimes or three, a thousand crimes or ten thousand!"

The Bodhisattva said: "'When a man has a good wish, Heaven will surely grant it.' If you are willing to take refuge in the true fruit, you shall have your own means of livelihood. The world has its five grains, which can relieve hunger—why must you live by eating men?"

Hearing these words, the monster was like a man waking from a dream. He said to the Bodhisattva: "I would gladly follow the right, but 'whoever has sinned against Heaven has none to whom he may pray.'"

The Bodhisattva said: "I have received the Buddha's command to go to the Eastern Lands to seek a scripture-pilgrim. You may follow him as his disciple and make the journey to the Western Heaven, atoning for your crime through your merit, and I will surely see you delivered from your calamity and corruption."

The monster cried with all his heart: "I am willing to follow, I am willing to follow!" Then the Bodhisattva laid her hand upon his crown and gave him the precepts, taking his own nature for his surname, so that he was named Zhu—Pig; and she gave him a religious name, calling him Zhu Wuneng—Pig-Awakened-to-Power. So he received the command and returned to the truth, keeping the fast and abstaining from meat, cutting

himself off from the five strong herbs and the three forbidden meats, and waited single-mindedly for the scripture-pilgrim.

The Bodhisattva then took her leave of Wuneng, and with Moksa pressed on, half-raising cloud and mist. As they traveled, they saw in the air above them a jade dragon crying out in distress. The Bodhisattva drew near and asked: "What dragon are you, suffering punishment here?"

The dragon said: "I am the son of Aorun, Dragon King of the Western Sea. Because I set fire to the bright pearls upon the hall, my royal father sent a memorial to the courts of Heaven charging me with unfilial conduct. The Jade Emperor has hung me up here in the air, given me three hundred strokes, and within a few days I am to be executed. I beg the Bodhisattva to save me, to save me!"

When Guanyin heard this, she at once went up with Moksa through the Southern Gate of Heaven, where the Heavenly Masters Qiu and Zhang met her and asked: "Whither are you bound?"

The Bodhisattva said: "This poor nun wishes to have one audience with the Jade Emperor." The two Heavenly Masters at once went in to report it, and the Jade Emperor descended from his hall to receive her. The Bodhisattva stepped forward, made her obeisance, and said: "This poor nun has received the Buddha's command to go to the Eastern Lands to seek a scripture-pilgrim. On the road I encountered a sinful dragon hanging in punishment, and I have come especially to make this request—that you spare his life and bestow him upon this poor nun, to serve the scripture-pilgrim as his means of conveyance."

When the Jade Emperor heard this, he at once issued a decree of pardon and dispatched a heavenly general to loose the dragon and deliver him to the Bodhisattva. She gave thanks for the imperial grace and withdrew. The little dragon bowed his head and gave thanks for the gift of his life,

and submitted himself to the Bodhisattva's command. She placed him in a deep ravine, there to wait until the scripture-pilgrim should come, when he would change into a white horse and go to the West to win his merit. The little dragon received the command and hid himself away—of which no more.

The Bodhisattva, leading the disciple Moksa, passed over that mountain and again hastened toward the Eastern Lands. They had not gone far when suddenly they beheld ten thousand shafts of golden light and a thousand strands of auspicious vapor rising in the distance. Moksa said: "Master, that place where the light shines forth is the Mountain of Five Phases, and the Tathagata's sealing-charm is set upon it."

The Bodhisattva said: "Then this is where the Great Sage Equal to Heaven—he who threw the Peach Banquet into uproar and ran riot through the Palace of Heaven—now lies crushed beneath."

Moksa said: "Just so, just so." Master and disciple climbed the mountain together to examine the charm, which bore the six-syllable true mantra: *Om mani padme hum*. The Bodhisattva, having read it, sighed and lamented without end, and composed a poem. The poem ran:

Pitiable is the monster-monkey who would not serve the common good; in years past, in his wild presumption, he played the hero bold. With reckless heart he threw the Peach Banquet into uproar; with brazen daring he stole into the Tushita Palace. Amid a host of a hundred thousand he had no equal foe; through the ninefold heaven above he carried his mighty pride. But once he met the snares of my Buddha, the Tathagata, on what day will he stretch himself again and show his merit anew?

While master and disciple were speaking, their voices startled the Great Sage. From beneath the roots of the mountain he cried out in a thunderous voice: "Who is that up there on the mountain, chanting verses and laying bare my faults?"

When the Bodhisattva heard this, she went straight down the mountain to seek him out. There at the foot of the stone cliff she found the local Earth-God, the Mountain-Spirit, and the heavenly general who guarded the Great Sage, all coming forward to bow and receive her. They led her before the Great Sage, and she saw that he was indeed crushed within a casket of stone, able to speak with his mouth but unable to stir his body.

The Bodhisattva said: "You who are surnamed Sun—do you know me?"

The Great Sage opened wide his fiery eyes and golden pupils, nodded his head, and cried out in a great voice: "How should I not know you? You are she of the Southern Sea, of Potalaka Mountain, who saves from suffering and rescues from distress—the greatly merciful, greatly compassionate Bodhisattva Guanshiyin. I am grateful for your visit, grateful indeed. Here I pass my days like years, and not one acquaintance has ever come to look in upon me. From where have you come?"

The Bodhisattva said: "I have received the Buddha's command to go to the Eastern Lands to seek a scripture-pilgrim, and passing this way I have spared a few weary steps to look in upon you."

The Great Sage said: "The Tathagata deceived me and crushed me beneath this mountain. For more than five hundred years now I have not been able to stir. I beg the Bodhisattva, of her kindness, to grant me some small grace and save your old Sun—save me!"

The Bodhisattva said: "Your sins and crimes are deep beyond measure, and I fear that if I freed you, you would only breed fresh disaster—which would turn out badly after all."

The Great Sage said: "I have already learned to repent. I only beg the great and merciful one to point out a road, and I will willingly take up cultivation." And this was truly so:

Let the human heart but give birth to a single thought, and Heaven and Earth shall know it through and through. If good and evil met with no requital, then surely there would be partiality in the cosmos.

When the Bodhisattva heard these words, her heart was filled with gladness, and she said to the Great Sage: "The sacred scriptures say: 'If his words be good, then from a thousand miles away men answer to them; if his words be not good, then from a thousand miles away men turn against them.' Since you have this mind, wait until I have reached the great land of Tang in the Eastern Lands and found a scripture-pilgrim there. I will have him save you. You may follow him as his disciple, uphold and observe the teaching, enter my Buddhist gate, and once more cultivate the true fruit. What say you?"

The Great Sage cried again and again: "I am willing to go, I am willing to go!"

The Bodhisattva said: "Since you are bent on the fruit of goodness, let me give you a religious name."

The Great Sage said: "I already have a name—I am called Sun Wukong, Awakened-to-Emptiness."

The Bodhisattva rejoiced and said: "I have already brought two others before to submission, whose names are likewise of the 'Wu—Awakened' rank. You too are of the 'Wu' rank, which fits well with theirs—very good, very good. There is then no need for further charge. I take my leave." So the Great Sage, having seen his nature and made clear his heart, turned toward the Buddhist teaching, while the Bodhisattva, keeping her purpose in mind, went on to seek the holy monk.

She and Moksa left that place and went straight on to the east, and within a day or so they came to the great land of Tang at Chang'an. There

they gathered in their mists and folded away their clouds, and master and disciple transformed themselves into two scabby, mangy wandering monks, and entered the city of Chang'an. Before they knew it, the day grew late. As they walked along beside the great market street, they saw a shrine of the local Earth-God, and the two of them went straight in. This so flustered the Earth-God that his heart leaped in fright and his spirit-soldiers trembled; knowing it was the Bodhisattva, they bowed their heads and received her in. The Earth-God then hurried off in haste to report to the City-God, the Local Spirit, and all the gods of every shrine throughout Chang'an, who all knew it was the Bodhisattva and came to pay their respects, saying: "Bodhisattva, forgive us gods the offense of our late reception."

The Bodhisattva said: "On no account let a breath of this leak out. I have received the Buddha's command and have come here especially to seek out a scripture-pilgrim. I will borrow your shrine to lodge in for a few days, until I have found the true monk, and then I shall return." The several gods each went back to their own places, and they hustled the Earth-God off to lodge for the while in the City-God's temple. There master and disciple concealed their true forms.

And in the end there is no knowing what scripture-pilgrim they would seek out—so listen to the next chapter, where it will all be explained.

Chapter 9: The River-Float Monk and the Long Road to Vengeance

In the great land of Shaanxi stood the city of Chang'an, the capital chosen by emperors through age after age. Ever since the dynasties of Zhou, Qin, and Han, three districts had bloomed like brocade there, and eight

rivers wound about the walls—truly a realm renowned for its beauty. It was in this place that the Emperor Taizong of the great Tang ascended the throne, changed the reign-title to Zhenguan, and had now ruled for thirteen years. The cyclical year was *jisi*; the empire was at peace, tribute flowed in from the eight directions, and the four seas acknowledged him as their lord.

One day, when the emperor had taken his seat and the civil and military officials had completed the rites of court audience, the Prime Minister Wei Zheng stepped forth from the ranks and made his report.

"The realm is now at peace," he said, "and the eight directions are tranquil. We should follow the ancient custom and open the examination halls, summoning worthy men and promoting the talented, that they may aid in the governance of the world."

"What you propose is sound, my worthy minister," replied Taizong. He thereupon issued a proclamation calling for the worthy, posting it throughout the empire: in every prefecture, district, and county, whether of military or common stock, any scholar of the Confucian school whose grasp of letters was clear and whose mastery of the three examinations was complete should come to Chang'an to sit for the tests.

The notice came in time to the region of Haizhou, where there lived a man named Chen E, styled Guangrui. When he read the proclamation he returned home at once and spoke to his mother, Lady Zhang.

"The court has sent down its golden notice," he said, "decreeing that the southern hall be opened to select men of worth. It is my wish to go and sit for the examination. Should I win some office, however small, I would bring honor to my parents and glory to my name, secure rank for my wife and shade for my sons, and shed luster upon our gate. Such is my ambition, Mother, and I have come to tell you of it before I go."

"My son is a scholar," said Lady Zhang. "In youth he studies; in his prime he goes forth to act.' This is exactly as it should be. But on the road to the examination you must take care, and once you have your office, come home to me quickly."

Guangrui thereupon bade his servant pack the baggage, took leave of his mother with a bow, and pressed on his journey. When he reached Chang'an the halls had just been thrown open, and he entered to sit the tests. When the examinations were done, he was among those chosen; and when he had answered the three palace questions, the Tang sovereign with his own brush conferred upon him first place—the rank of *zhuangyuan*. He was given a horse to parade through the streets for three days.

It happened, as he rode, that he passed before the gate of the Prime Minister Yin Kaishan. Now the minister had a daughter named Wenjiao, also called Mantangjiao, who was not yet betrothed. At that very moment she had raised a high tower hung with colored silk, from which she meant to cast an embroidered ball to choose her husband. Just as Chen Guangrui passed beneath the tower, the young lady caught sight of him. Seeing how his bearing surpassed other men, and knowing him for the newly crowned first scholar, her heart was filled with delight—and she let the embroidered ball fall. It struck Guangrui squarely upon his black gauze cap.

At once a strain of pipes and flutes broke into delicate music, and a dozen maids and attendants came down from the tower, took hold of Guangrui's horse by the head, and led the first scholar into the minister's mansion to be wed. The minister and his lady came straightway into the hall, summoned the master of ceremonies, and gave their daughter in marriage to Guangrui. They bowed to Heaven and Earth, husband and wife bowed to one another, and then they made obeisance to the bride's

father and mother. The minister ordered a feast set out, and they drank in joy through the night before the two of them, hand in hand, withdrew together into the orchid chamber.

Next day, at the third mark of the fifth watch, Taizong took his seat upon the golden throne in the precious hall, and the civil and military officers hastened to court.

"To what office should the newly crowned first scholar, Chen Guangrui, be appointed?" the emperor asked.

Wei Zheng came forward and replied: "Your servant has searched the prefectures under our authority, and there is a vacancy for governor at Jiangzhou. I beg my lord to grant him that post."

Taizong thereupon named Guangrui governor of Jiangzhou and ordered him to set out at once and not miss the appointed term. Guangrui gave thanks for the grace and withdrew from court. Returning to the minister's mansion, he took counsel with his wife, bade farewell to his father- and mother-in-law, and together with her set out for his post at Jiangzhou. So they left Chang'an and took to the road.

It was the season of late spring, when mild breezes set the willows greening and a fine rain dappled the flowers red. Guangrui turned his way homeward, and together with his wife bowed before his mother, Lady Zhang.

"I rejoice for you, my son," said Lady Zhang, "and that you have brought a bride home as well."

"It was by leaning on Mother's blessings and protection," said Guangrui, "that I unworthily took first place. The court granted me the parade through the streets, and as I passed the gate of the Prime Minister Yin, I happened to be struck by the embroidered ball he had cast down—and

the minister at once made me his daughter's husband. The court has appointed me governor of Jiangzhou, and now I have come to take Mother with me to my post."

Lady Zhang was overjoyed, and they made ready for the road.

After some days of travel they came to the inn of Liu the Younger, in the town of Ten Thousand Flowers, and there they lodged. Lady Zhang suddenly fell ill, and she said to Guangrui, "I am not well. Let us stay at the inn a day or two to recover, and then go on." Guangrui obeyed.

The next morning he saw a man at the inn door crying his wares — a golden carp held up for sale. Guangrui at once bought it for a string of cash, meaning to cook it for his mother. But then he saw the carp blink its eyes, again and again.

Marveling, Guangrui said, "I have heard that when a fish or a serpent blinks its eyes, it is surely no common creature." So he asked the fisherman, "Where was this fish caught?"

"It was taken from the Hong River, fifteen *li* from the prefectural town," the man replied.

Guangrui thereupon carried the fish to the Hong River and set it free, and returning to the inn he told his mother what he had done.

"To set a creature free is a good deed," said Lady Zhang. "My heart is much gladdened by it."

"We have lodged here three days now," said Guangrui, "and the imperial term presses hard. My thought is to set out tomorrow — but I do not know whether Mother is well enough."

"I am still unwell," she answered, "and the road just now is hot and close; I fear it would only worsen my sickness. You may rent a room here for

me to rest in, and leave me a little money for expenses. You and your wife go on ahead to take up the office, and when the cool of autumn comes, return for me."

Guangrui took counsel with his wife, and so rented a dwelling, gave money to his mother, and with his wife bowed farewell and went on.

The road was hard, traveling by dawn and resting by night, until at last, before they knew it, they reached the Hong River ferry crossing. There they saw two boatmen, Liu Hong and Li Biao, who poled their craft to the bank to meet them. It was fated from a former life that Guangrui should suffer this calamity, and so he fell in with these two enemies. He bade his servant carry the baggage aboard, and just as husband and wife had together stepped onto the boat, Liu Hong fixed his eyes upon the lady Yin — her face like the full moon, her eyes like autumn waters, her small mouth like a cherry, her slender waist like a green willow. Truly she had a beauty to sink fishes and bring down wild geese, to shame the moon and put flowers to blush. A wolf's heart rose up in him at the sight, and he and Li Biao laid their plot, poling the boat to a place where no smoke of habitation rose.

They waited until the dead of the third watch, when all was still. First they slew the servant; then they beat Guangrui to death and pushed both corpses into the water. When the lady saw her husband murdered, she made to throw herself into the river as well, but Liu Hong seized her in his arms.

"If you yield to me, all will be well," he said. "If you refuse — one stroke, and I'll cut you in two."

The lady, finding no way out, could only consent for the moment and so submit to Liu Hong. The villain poled the boat to the southern bank, handed it over to Li Biao to keep, and then, putting on Guangrui's robes

and cap and taking up his official seal, went off with the lady to take the post at Jiangzhou.

Now the body of the servant whom Liu Hong had killed went floating off downstream; but the corpse of Chen Guangrui sank to the bottom and did not stir. A patrolling sea-yaksha at the mouth of the Hong River saw it and flew like a shooting star to report it in the Dragon Palace. The Dragon King had just taken his seat in the hall when the yaksha announced: "At the mouth of the Hong River, some person unknown has beaten a scholar to death and flung his body into the depths."

The Dragon King ordered the corpse carried in and set before him, and when he had looked at it closely he said, "Why, this is the very man who saved my life! How comes it that he has been murdered? As the saying goes, 'Repay kindness with kindness.' Today I must save his life, to requite the favor of those days past."

He at once wrote out a dispatch and sent the yaksha straight to the City God and the Earth God of Hongzhou, demanding that the soul of the scholar be brought to him. The City God and the Earth God thereupon summoned a little demon to deliver up the soul of Chen Guangrui to the yaksha, who carried it back to the Crystal Palace and reported to the Dragon King.

"What is your name, scholar," asked the Dragon King, "and from what place do you come? How did you come to be beaten to death?"

Guangrui made his bow. "I am Chen E, styled Guangrui, a man of Hongnong county in Haizhou. I had the unworthy honor of being made the new first scholar and was granted the governorship of Jiangzhou. As I traveled with my wife to take up the post, we boarded a boat at the riverside, and the boatman Liu Hong, coveting my wife, beat me to death and cast away my body. I beg Your Majesty to save me."

When the Dragon King heard this he said, "So that is how it stands. Sir, the golden carp you set free that day — that was none other than I. You are my benefactor, who saved my life; now that you are in trouble, how could I do otherwise than save you?"

So he set Guangrui's body carefully aside, placed within its mouth a pearl that preserves the features so that it would not spoil, that one day he might return to life and take his revenge. "As for your true soul," he said, "let it remain for the time being in my water-realm and serve as a commander." Guangrui bowed his head in thanks, and the Dragon King held a feast in his honor — but of that no more.

Now the lady Yin loathed the villain Liu so bitterly that she could have eaten his flesh and slept upon his skin. But because she was with child, and did not yet know whether it would be a boy or a girl, she could do nothing but force herself, against all will, to go along with him. In the turn of an eye they came to Jiangzhou, where the clerks and runners all came out to meet them, and the officials of the district set a feast in the public hall to welcome the new governor.

"It is wholly through the great support of you gentlemen," said Liu Hong, "that this student has come to his post."

"You, our lord governor, are a man of high talent and the highest distinction," the officials replied. "Naturally you will look upon the people as upon your own children, so that lawsuits are few and punishments clean. We who serve beneath you have only to rely on you. Why do you speak so modestly?" When the feast was over, they all dispersed.

Time flew swiftly by. One day Liu Hong went off far away on official business. The lady, alone in the yamen, thought of her mother-in-law and her husband, and sighed and grieved upon the flower pavilion. Suddenly

her body grew heavy and a pain seized her belly; she fell to the ground in a swoon, and before she knew it she had given birth to a son. And a voice spoke beside her ear:

"Mantangjiao, hear what I charge you. I am the Star Lord of the Southern Pole, and by the command of the Bodhisattva Guanyin I have brought you this child. In days to come his fame shall be great and far-reaching — he is no common man. If the villain Liu returns, he will surely do this child harm — so guard him with all your heart. Your husband has been saved by the Dragon King; one day husband and wife shall meet again, mother and son shall be reunited, and the day will come when wrongs are cleansed and vengeance taken. Mark my words well. Wake now, wake now." And with that the voice was gone.

The lady woke, remembering every word, and held her son fast — yet she could think of no plan. Suddenly Liu Hong returned, and the moment he saw the child he wished to drown him.

"It is late in the day now," said the lady. "Let us wait until tomorrow to cast him into the river." By good fortune, early next morning Liu Hong was suddenly called away on urgent business.

The lady thought to herself: "If this child is here when the villain returns, his life is forfeit. Better to cast him into the river at once and leave him to live or die. If perhaps Heaven takes pity and someone saves and rears him, the day may yet come when we meet again." But fearing he could never be recognized, she bit her finger and wrote a letter in blood, setting down in full the names of his father and mother and all the circumstances of his birth. Then she bit off the little toe of the child's left foot, that it might serve as a token of proof, and wrapped him in an undershirt taken from against her own body. Taking advantage of a vacant hour, she carried him out of the yamen.

It was fortunate that the yamen lay not far from the river. Reaching the bank, the lady wept aloud one bitter while. As she was about to cast the child away, she saw a plank of wood come floating up to the very edge of the bank. The lady bowed in prayer toward Heaven, laid the child upon the plank, bound him fast with a sash, tied the bloody letter at his breast, and pushed him out into the river, leaving him to go where the current willed. Then, choking back her tears, she returned to the yamen — but of that no more.

The child upon the plank went floating down with the current until at last it came to rest at the foot of the Temple of the Golden Mountain. The abbot of that temple was a monk named Faming, who had cultivated truth and awakened to the Way, and had attained the subtle secret of no-rebirth. As he sat in meditation, contemplating Chan, he suddenly heard the crying of an infant. His heart was stirred, and he hurried to the riverside to look — and there on a plank at the water's edge lay a sleeping babe. The abbot quickly rescued the child, and finding the bloody letter at his breast, he learned the whole story. He gave the boy a milk-name, calling him Jiangliu — River-Float — and entrusted him to others to be raised, while he himself kept the bloody letter carefully hidden away.

Time sped like an arrow, the sun and moon shuttling by, and before anyone marked it River-Float had grown to be eighteen years old. The abbot then had him shave his head and take up the religious life, giving him the dharma-name Xuanzang. He touched the crown of his head and bestowed the precepts upon him, and with a steadfast heart the young man cultivated the Way.

One day in late spring, the monks were gathered together beneath the shade of the pines, expounding the scriptures and contemplating Chan, discoursing on profound mysteries — and there a certain wine-and-meat

monk found himself bested in argument by Xuanzang. In a great rage he cursed the youth: "You beast of bad karma! You don't even know your own name, you don't even know your own father and mother — what mischief are you stirring up here?"

Stung by such words, Xuanzang went into the temple, knelt before his master, and with tears streaming down both cheeks said, "A man born between Heaven and Earth, endowed with *yin* and *yang* and nourished by the five elements, owes his being wholly to a father's begetting and a mother's rearing. How can there be one who walks the world without father or mother?" Again and again he pleaded, begging to know the names of his parents.

"If you truly wish to seek your parents," said the abbot, "come with me to the abbot's chamber." Xuanzang followed him there. The abbot climbed to the cross-beam above and took down a small box; opening it, he drew out the bloody letter and the undershirt and handed them to Xuanzang. Xuanzang unfolded the letter and read it through, and only then learned in full his parents' names and the whole tale of their wrongs.

When he had finished reading he fell weeping to the ground. "If I cannot avenge my father and mother's wrong," he cried, "how can I call myself a man? For eighteen years I knew not those who bore me, and only this day do I learn that I have a mother. Had my master not rescued and reared me, how should I have lived to this day? Let your disciple go and find his mother — and then, bearing the censer-bowl upon my head, I will rebuild this temple's halls and repay my master's deep kindness."

"If you would go to seek your mother," said his master, "take this bloody letter and this undershirt with you. Go in the guise of a monk begging alms, straight to the private yamen at Jiangzhou — only so will you be able to meet her."

Xuanzang received his master's instructions, and dressed as an alms-begging monk he made his way straight to Jiangzhou. It happened that Liu Hong was away on business — and it was Heaven's own intention that mother and son should meet — and so Xuanzang came directly to the gate of the private yamen to beg.

Now the lady Yin had that very night dreamed a dream: she saw the moon, once waned, grow round again. To herself she thought: "I have no word of my mother-in-law; my husband was murdered by that villain; my own child was cast into the river. If anyone has saved and reared him, he would by my reckoning be eighteen years old now. Perhaps Heaven means today that we should meet — who can say?"

As she sat thus musing, she suddenly heard someone before the yamen chanting scripture and calling again and again for alms. Taking her chance, the lady came out and asked, "Where have you come from?"

"This poor monk," answered Xuanzang, "is the disciple of the Abbot Faming of the Temple of the Golden Mountain."

"Since you are the disciple of the abbot of the Golden Mountain Temple..." said the lady, and she called him into the yamen and gave him a vegetarian meal to eat. As she watched his bearing and listened to his speech, she saw how like he was to her husband.

She sent her serving-maids away and asked him quietly, "Little master, did you leave home to become a monk in your childhood, or in your middle years? What is your name? And have you father and mother?"

"I did not leave home as a child," Xuanzang answered, "nor did I leave home in middle age. When I tell it — my wrong is great as Heaven, my grievance deep as the sea. My father was murdered, and my mother was

seized by the villain. My master, the Abbot Faming, sent me to seek my mother within the yamen of Jiangzhou."

"What is your mother's surname?" the lady asked.

"My mother's surname is Yin," said Xuanzang, "and her name is Wenjiao. My father's surname is Chen, his name Guangrui. My milk-name was River-Float, and my dharma-name was given as Xuanzang."

"I am Wenjiao!" said the lady. "But what proof have you?"

When Xuanzang heard that this was his mother, he fell upon both knees and wept piteously. "If my mother does not believe me, here are the bloody letter and the undershirt for proof." Wenjiao took them and looked, and they were indeed genuine. Mother and son embraced and wept.

"My son, go quickly!" she said.

"For eighteen years I have not known those who bore me," said Xuanzang, "and only this morning have I seen my mother. How can I bear to tear myself away?"

"My son," she said, "you must withdraw at once. If the villain Liu returns, he will surely take your life. Tomorrow I will feign an illness and say that years ago I vowed to give away a hundred pairs of monk's shoes, and will come to your temple to fulfill the vow. Then I shall have words to say to you." Xuanzang obeyed and took his leave with a bow.

Now after the lady had seen her son, her heart was at once full of sorrow and of joy. One day she feigned sickness, would touch neither tea nor rice, and lay upon her bed. When Liu Hong returned to the yamen and asked the reason, the lady said, "When I was young I once made a vow to give away a hundred pairs of monk's shoes. Five days ago I dreamed of a

monk holding a sharp blade, demanding the shoes — and ever since I have felt unwell."

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"Such a small matter," said Liu Hong. "Why did you not say so sooner?" He went up to the hall and ordered Clerk Wang of the left office and Clerk Li of the right: every household in the city of Jiangzhou was to make one pair of monk's shoes, to be delivered within five days. The people all complied and delivered them in full.

"The shoes are made," the lady said to Liu Hong. "Is there any temple hereabouts where I may go to fulfill my vow?"

"There are the Golden Mountain Temple and the Burnt Mountain Temple here in Jiangzhou," said Liu Hong. "You may go to whichever you choose."

"I have long heard that the Golden Mountain Temple is a fine one," said the lady. "I will go there." Liu Hong at once called Clerks Wang and Li to make ready a boat. The lady took her trusted attendants and went aboard, and the boatmen poled off and headed for the Golden Mountain Temple.

Now Xuanzang had returned to his temple and told the Abbot Faming all that had passed, and the abbot was greatly pleased. The next day a maidservant came ahead to announce that the lady was coming to fulfill a

vow, and all the monks came out to greet her. The lady went straight in at the temple gate, paid her devotions to the Bodhisattva, and set out a great offering-feast. She bade her maid place the monk's shoes and stockings upon a tray and carried them to the dharma-hall, where she again lit incense in worship and had the Abbot Faming distribute them among the monks.

When Xuanzang saw that the monks had dispersed and there was no one left in the dharma-hall, he drew near and knelt down. The lady bade him take off his shoes and stockings, and looked — and there, sure enough, the little toe was missing from his left foot. Then again the two embraced and wept, and gave thanks to the abbot for the kindness of rearing him.

"Now that mother and son have met," said Faming, "I fear the treacherous villain may come to know of it. You must withdraw quickly, lest disaster fall."

"My son," said the lady, "I give you this incense-ring. Go straight to the region northwest of Hongzhou — some fifteen hundred *li* — and there you will find the inn of Ten Thousand Flowers. There I once left your grandmother, Lady Zhang; she is your father's own mother. I will write you another letter as well: take it straight to the imperial city of the Tang sovereign, to the household of the Prime Minister Yin Kaishan, to the left of the golden hall — they are my own father and mother. Give my letter to your grandfather and bid him petition the Tang king to send forth troops, seize and slay this villain, and avenge your father. Only then can your old mother's body be delivered. I dare not stay longer now, for I fear the villain will hold it against me if I return too late." And so she went out from the temple, boarded her boat, and departed.

Xuanzang wept his way back into the temple, took counsel with his master, and at once bade him farewell and set out straight for Hongzhou. Coming to the inn of Ten Thousand Flowers, he asked the innkeeper, Liu the Younger, "Years ago, the traveler Chen of Jiangzhou left a mother lodging at your inn. How does she fare now?"

"She was indeed at my inn," said Liu the Younger. "But afterward her eyes grew dim, and for three or four years she paid me no rent at all. Now she lives in a ruined tile kiln by the south gate, going out each day to beg on the streets to keep herself alive. That traveler went off long ago, and to this day there has been no word of him — I cannot tell why."

When Xuanzang heard this he hurried to the ruined kiln by the south gate and found the old woman.

"Your voice is much like my son Chen Guangrui's," she said.

"I am not Chen Guangrui," said Xuanzang. "I am Chen Guangrui's son. The lady Wenjiao is my mother."

"Why have your father and mother not come?" she asked.

"My father was beaten to death by a brigand," said Xuanzang, "and my mother was seized by the brigand for his wife."

"How did you come to know to seek me out?" she asked.

"My mother sent me to find you, Grandmother. Here is a letter from her, and an incense-ring as well." The old woman took the letter and the ring and wept aloud.

"My son went off for the sake of rank and honor," she said, "and I had thought he had turned his back on duty and forgotten kindness. Little did I know he had been murdered. Yet I am glad that Heaven has taken

pity and not cut off my son's line — that today there is still a grandson to come and seek me."

"Grandmother," Xuanzang asked, "how is it your eyes have grown so dim?"

"It was through longing for your father," she said. "Day after day I watched for him and never saw him come, and so I wept until both my eyes grew dark."

Xuanzang knelt down and prayed toward Heaven: "I, Xuanzang, am now eighteen years old, and I have not been able to avenge my parents' wrong. Today, at my mother's bidding, I have come to seek my grandmother. If Heaven looks with pity upon your disciple's sincerity, restore the light to my grandmother's eyes." His prayer done, he licked her eyes with the tip of his tongue. In a moment both eyes were opened and were as they had been before.

The old woman looked at the little monk. "You are indeed my grandson," she said. "You are the very image of my son Guangrui." And she was at once joyful and grieved. Xuanzang then led his grandmother out from the kiln and back to Liu the Younger's inn, where he paid some rent to take a room for her to dwell in, and gave her money for expenses.

"I will be gone only a month or so before I return," he told her. And so he took leave of his grandmother and went straight on toward the capital.

Finding his way to the mansion of the Prime Minister Yin on the eastern street of the imperial city, he said to the gatekeeper, "This poor monk is a kinsman, come to call upon the minister." The gatekeeper reported this to the minister.

"I have no kinsman among the monks," said the minister.

But the lady said, "Last night I dreamed that our daughter Mantangjiao came home. Could it be that our son-in-law has sent some word back?" So the minister had the little monk brought into the hall.

When the little monk saw the minister and his lady, he fell weeping to the ground in obeisance, and from within his robe he drew a letter and handed it to the minister. The minister opened it and read it through from the beginning, and then wept aloud.

"My lord, what is the matter?" asked the lady.

"This monk is your grandson and mine," said the minister. "Our son-in-law Chen Guangrui was murdered by a brigand, and Mantangjiao was seized by the brigand for his wife." When the lady heard this, she too wept without ceasing.

"Do not grieve, my lady," said the minister. "Tomorrow I shall lay the matter before our sovereign, and I myself will lead troops and surely avenge our son-in-law."

The next day the minister went to court and made his report to the Tang king: "Your servant's son-in-law, the first scholar Chen Guangrui, was leading his household to take up his post at Jiangzhou when he was beaten to death by the boatman Liu Hong, who seized his wife for his own, falsely took my son-in-law's place, and has held office there for many years. This is a thing of monstrous strangeness. I beg Your Majesty to send forth troops at once and root out the bandit."

When the Tang king heard the report he was greatly angered, and dispatched sixty thousand of the imperial guard, with the Prime Minister Yin to command the army and lead it forth. The minister received the edict and left the court; going to the parade ground, he mustered the troops and set out straight for Jiangzhou. Traveling by dawn and resting

by night, beneath falling stars and the calls of waking birds, they came at last to Jiangzhou, where the minister's troops encamped on the northern bank.

In the dead of night he sent a golden tablet to summon the assistant prefect and the district magistrate of Jiangzhou. The minister told them of the matter and bade them raise their own soldiers to help, and together they crossed the river. While it was yet dark they surrounded Liu Hong's yamen. Liu Hong was deep in a dream when he heard the boom of a cannon and the clash of gongs and drums all at once; the soldiers stormed into the private quarters of the yamen, and Liu Hong, taken unawares, was seized before he could lift a hand. The minister gave the order, had Liu Hong and his accomplices bound and marched off to the execution-ground, and commanded the rest of the army to make camp outside the city.

The minister went straight into the yamen and seated himself in the main hall, and called for the lady to come out and meet him. The lady wished to go out, yet was ashamed to face her father, and made to hang herself. Xuanzang heard of it and hurried to save his mother. Falling on both knees, he said to her, "Your son and his grandfather have led troops here to avenge my father. Now the villain is taken — why, Mother, do you instead seek death? If you die, how can your child live on?" The minister too came into the yamen to comfort her.

"I have heard," said the lady, "that a woman follows one husband to the end. My husband, alas, was slain by the villain — how could I, with brazen face, have followed such a man? It was only because I bore his child in my womb that I endured shame and stole a wretched life. Now happily my son is grown, and I see my old father has brought troops to avenge us. But as a daughter, with what face can I look upon you? There is nothing left but to die, to requite my husband."

"This was no changing of your fidelity for the sake of fortune," said the minister. "It was all forced upon you by necessity. How can it be counted shame?" Father and daughter embraced and wept, and Xuanzang too could not cease his bitter weeping.

The minister wiped away his tears. "Do not, you two, give way to grief," he said. "I have now captured the enemy villain; let me go and deal with him." He rose and went to the execution-ground. Just then the assistant prefect of Jiangzhou had also sent scouts who had caught the river-bandit Li Biao and brought him in. The minister was greatly pleased, and bade the guards bring forth Liu Hong and Li Biao, and had each given a hundred heavy blows of the rod. He took their confessions, and they admitted the whole truth of how they had wickedly plotted years before to murder Chen Guangrui. First Li Biao was nailed to a wooden donkey and pushed off to the marketplace, where he was sliced a thousand cuts and beheaded as a warning to the crowd. Then Liu Hong was brought to the ferry crossing of the Hong River — the very place where years before he had beaten Chen Guangrui to death. There the minister, the lady, and Xuanzang — all three — went down to the riverside and made their offering toward the sky; they cut out the living heart and liver of Liu Hong, offered them to Guangrui, and burned a written eulogy.

As the three of them wept toward the river, their grief soon stirred the water-realm, and a patrolling sea-yaksha brought the eulogy before the Dragon King. When the Dragon King had read it, he sent his Marshal Turtle to invite Guangrui to come before him.

"Sir, I give you joy! I give you joy!" he said. "Your lady, your son, and your father-in-law are all at the riverside making offerings to you. Now I shall send you back to life, and grant you besides one wish-fulfilling pearl, two rolling-tray pearls, ten lengths of fine silk gauze, and a belt set with bright pearls and jade. Today you may be reunited — husband and wife,

mother and son." Guangrui gave thanks again and again. The Dragon King then bade the yaksha bear Guangrui's body out to the river-mouth and restore him to life, and the yaksha went off to obey.

Now the lady Yin, having wept her offering over her husband, again wished to throw herself into the water and die, and Xuanzang in his alarm clung to her with all his strength. In the very midst of their confusion, a corpse suddenly came floating on the surface of the water and drew near the bank. The lady hurried forward to look, and knew it for her husband's body, and burst into wailing without end. Everyone came to look — and they saw Guangrui unclench his fists and stretch out his legs, his body little by little beginning to move; then all at once he scrambled up and sat. They were all struck with the greatest astonishment.

Guangrui opened his eyes, and there before him he saw the lady Yin, his father-in-law the Prime Minister Yin, and the little monk, all weeping at his side.

"Why are you all here?" said Guangrui.

"Because you were beaten to death by the villain," said the lady, "and afterward I bore this child. By good fortune the abbot of the Golden Mountain Temple raised him to manhood, and he came to find me. I bade him seek out his grandfather, and when my father learned of it he reported it to the court and led troops here, and we have captured the villain — just now we cut out his living heart and liver and made our offering toward the sky for you, my husband. But how is it, husband, that you have come back to life?"

"It is all because of the golden carp you and I bought and set free that year at the inn of Ten Thousand Flowers," said Guangrui. "Who would have thought that carp was the Dragon King of this very place? Later,

when the traitor pushed me into the water, it was wholly thanks to him that I was saved. And just now he has granted me return to life and bestowed these treasures upon me — they are here upon my body. Little did I imagine you had borne this son, and that my father-in-law would avenge me. Truly, bitterness ended turns to sweetness — there is no greater joy."

When the officials heard of it, they all came to offer congratulations. The minister had a feast prepared to thank the local officials, and that same day the army began its homeward march. Coming to the inn of Ten Thousand Flowers, the minister gave the order to encamp. Guangrui, with Xuanzang, went to Liu's inn to seek his mother.

The old woman had that very night dreamed a dream: she saw a withered tree break into bloom, and behind the house magpies chattered again and again. "Could it be my grandson coming?" she thought. The words were scarcely out when there, outside the inn door, came Guangrui and his son together.

"Is this not my grandmother?" said the little monk, pointing. When Guangrui saw his old mother, he hastened to bow down before her. Mother and son embraced and wept aloud, and he told her all that had happened. They settled the rent with Liu the Younger and set out, returning to the capital.

Entering the minister's mansion — Guangrui with the lady, and the grandmother with Xuanzang — all came to greet the minister's wife. The lady's joy was beyond measure, and she bade the servants set out a great banquet of celebration.

"Today's feast," said the minister, "may be named the Feast of Reunion." And truly the whole household rejoiced together.

The next day at the early audience, when the Tang king took his seat, the Prime Minister Yin came forth from the ranks and laid the whole affair, from first to last, in full before the throne, and recommended Guangrui as a man fit for high employment. The Tang king approved the petition and at once commanded that Chen Guangrui be raised to the rank of Academician, to serve at court in the governance of affairs. Xuanzang, steadfast in his resolve to practice meditation, was sent to cultivate the Way at the Temple of Vast Blessings. Afterward, the lady Yin quietly took her own life; and Xuanzang returned to the Golden Mountain Temple to repay the kindness of the Abbot Faming.

What befell hereafter is not yet known — listen, and the next chapter will make it clear.

Chapter 10: The Old Dragon King's Reckless Scheme Breaks Heaven's Law

Let us set aside for now the tale of Guangrui fulfilling his office and Xuanzang pursuing his cultivation. Instead, let us tell of two worthy men who lived beyond the walls of Chang'an, on the banks of the Jing River. One was a fisherman named Zhang Shao; the other a woodcutter named Li Ding. They were scholars who had never sat for the examinations, mountain hermits who happened to be lettered.

One day, having sold the firewood from his shoulders and traded away the carp in his basket, the two of them went together into a wine shop, drank until they were half-tipsy, and then, each carrying a bottle, strolled slowly homeward along the bank of the Jing River.

Said Zhang Shao, "Brother Li, when I consider the men who scramble after fame, they lose their lives because of fame; those who snatch after

profit perish for the sake of profit; those who receive titles sleep as though embracing a tiger; those who bask in imperial favor walk as though a snake were coiled in their sleeve. Reckon it all up, and none of them comes anywhere near to us — clear waters and green hills, free and unfettered, content with our plain fare, drifting along as fortune carries us."

"Brother Zhang speaks with reason," said Li Ding. "Yet your clear waters cannot match my green hills."

"Your green hills are no match for my clear waters," replied Zhang Shao.

"I have a lyric to the tune *Butterflies Love Flowers* to prove it. The words run:

A small skiff upon ten thousand miles of misty
waves, quietly leaning against the lonely awning,
while a voice as sweet as Xishi's lingers all around.
Washed clean of cares, washed clean of name and
gain, I idly pluck the smartweed plumes and reed-
grass blades.

A few dots of sandy gulls — there is the Way to delight in, willowed
banks and reedy coves, wife and child laughing together in joy. One
sound sleep, and wind and waves are stilled — no glory, no
disgrace, and not a single care."

Said Li Ding, "Your clear waters cannot match my green hills. I too have a lyric to the same tune *Butterflies Love Flowers* for proof. The words run:

A stretch of cloud-wreathed forest, pine pollen drifting full, and silently I listen to the orioles cry, their clever tongues like tuned pipes. Reds thinning, greens fattening — spring is at its warmest, then suddenly the summer solstice turns the light.

Again comes autumn, easy in its change, yellow blossoms fragrant, fit for delight. Swiftly stern winter passes like a snap of fingers — through all four seasons I roam free, with no man to rule me."

Said the fisherman, "Your green hills cannot match my clear waters, where I take my pleasure in fine things. I have a lyric to the tune *Partridge Sky* for proof:

Among the immortals' clouds and waters my whole living lies, I work the oar and turn my boat — and that is home. Fresh-scaled fish carved alive, green turtles stewed, purple crabs steamed at once, red shrimp set boiling.

Green reed-shoots, water-fern sprouts, water-chestnuts and gorgon-fruit are worthier still. Tender lotus-root, old lotus, celery leaves so green, arrowhead, wild rice-stem, and the heron-flower bloom."

Said the woodcutter, "Your clear waters cannot match my green hills, where I take my pleasure in fine things. I too have a lyric to *Partridge Sky*

for proof:

Towering steep peaks that touch the edge of heaven,
a thatched hut, a grass-roofed cell — that is my
home. Salted and cured fowl beat any crab or turtle,
river-deer, hare, and venison surpass your fish and
shrimp.

Fragrant toon leaves, golden chinaberry sprouts, bamboo shoots
and mountain tea are worthier still. Purple plums, red peaches, ripe
apricots and mei, sweet pears, sour jujubes, and the osmanthus
flower."

Said the fisherman, "Your green hills truly cannot match my clear waters.
I have yet another, to the tune *Immortal of Heaven*:

A single leaf of a boat goes wherever it lodges, ten thousand folds of misty wave, and not a trace of fear. I drop the hook and cast the net to take the fresh-scaled fish — no sauce, no grease, and yet a flavor all its own, while old wife and young child gather round in joy.

When the fish are many, I sell them in Chang'an's market, and trade for fragrant brew to drink myself to bliss. My straw cape for a quilt, I lie upon the autumn river, snore upon snore I sleep, with not a worry, never coveting the world's glory and rank."

Said the woodcutter, "Your clear waters still cannot match my green hills. I too have one to the tune *Immortal of Heaven*:

A thatched cottage of a few rafters built below the hill, with pine and bamboo, plum and orchid — truly to be loved. Through the woods, over the ridges, I seek out the dry kindling, and no man blames me; I sell as I please, a little or a lot, just as the world will have it.

I take the coin and buy my wine, glad as my heart desires, with earthen bowl and crockery cup, wholly at my ease. Dead drunk, I lie down in the shade of the pines, with nothing to bind me, nothing to harm me, heedless of the world's rising and its fall."

Said the fisherman, "Brother Li, your trade in the mountains is not so merry as my livelihood upon the water. I have a lyric to *The Moon over the West River* for proof:

Red smartweed blossoms thick, mirrored in the
moon, yellow reed-leaves wildly tossing in the wind.
The azure sky stretches clear above the empty Chu
River, and a tug of the line sets a whole pool of stars
trembling.

Great fish swim into the net in schools, small mandarin-fish
swallow the hook in shoals. Brought home and cooked, the flavor is
the richer — I laugh aloud, proud lord of river and lake at my
carousing."

Said the woodcutter, "Brother Zhang, your trade upon the water is not so
merry as my livelihood in the mountains. I too have a *Moon over the West
River* for proof:

Withered leaves and dry vines fill the path, broken
branch-tips and old bamboo crowd the hills. The
wild creeper and dry kudzu tangle and clamber, I cut
them down, gather the rope, and lash my load.

Worm-eaten, hollow-hearted elm and willow, wind-snapped,
headless pine and nanmu. I gather them, pile them up against the
winter cold, and trade them for wine, trade them for coin, as I
please."

Said the fisherman, "Your mountains may be a match, yet they cannot
equal the secluded grace of my clear waters. I have a lyric to *Immortal by*

the River for proof:

When the tide ebbs I shift my lonely skiff away, and
deep in the night I cease the oar and come singing
home. Straw cape under a waning moon — how
secluded and serene! The roosting gulls, startled, do
not rise, and at the sky's rim the bright clouds open.

Weary, I lie upon the reed-isle with not a care, the sun three poles
high, and still I lie at ease. As heart and whim incline, I arrange my
own affairs — while courtiers shiver, waiting for the dripping clock
to summon them, how can their lot compare to my broad ease of
mind?"

Said the woodcutter, "The secluded grace of your clear waters still cannot
match the deeper seclusion of my green hills. I too have an *Immortal by the
River* to prove it:

Down the mossy path, autumn high, I drag my axe
away, and in the cool of evening shoulder my load
back home. Wildflowers tucked at my temples —
stranger still and finer! I push aside the clouds to
find my road out, and wait upon the moon to call
the gate to open.

Young children and mountain wife greet me with glad smiles, grass
bed and wooden pillow where I lean and rest. Steamed pears and
millet cooked are spread out in a moment, and in the jar the new-
brewed wine is ripe — truly it swells the secluded heart."

Said the fisherman, "These are but the trades by which the two of us feed
ourselves; yet you cannot match the pleasure of my idle hours. I have a
poem for proof. The poem runs:

Idle I watch the azure heaven where white cranes
fly, I moor my boat by the brook and close my plain
gate fast. Leaning on the awning I teach my son to
twist his fishing line, the oar laid by, with my wife I
dry the netting ring. The temper settled is indeed
like waters calm, the body at peace will feel the
wind itself grow soft. Green straw cape and blue
bamboo hat I wear as the hour requires — better
than wearing the purple-corded robes of court."

Said the woodcutter, "Your idle hours are still not so good as my idle
hours. I too have a poem for proof. The poem runs:

Idle I watch the faint white clouds that float on high, alone I sit in my thatched cell and shut the bamboo gate. With nothing to do I teach my son and open up a book, and now and then with a guest I set the chessmen out. When joy comes I take my staff and sing along the fragrant lane, when the mood rises I carry my zither up the verdant slopes. Straw sandals, hempen cord, and a quilt of coarse cloth — a heart at ease is better far than wearing gauze and silk."

Said Zhang Shao, "Li Ding, the two of us are truly fit to be intimate companions in our soft chanting; we have no need of clappers and golden goblets. But to scatter off mere lyric verses is nothing rare. Let us each link a few lines together and see how our fisher-and-woodcutter parley turns out." Said Li Ding, "Brother Zhang's words are most apt. I beg my brother to chant first." So Zhang Shao began:

My boat lies moored amid green water's misty waves, his home is set deep in the mountains' open wilds. I love above all the brook-bridge when the spring waters rise, he loves above all the rocky crags veiled in dawn cloud. Fresh carp from the Dragon Gate I stew from time to time, worm-eaten dry kindling he sets ablaze each day. The hook and net, in all their kinds, can keep a man to his old age, the carry-pole and rope — two things — can see one through to the end. In my little boat, lying back, I watch the wild geese fly, on the grassy path, leaning aside, he hears the wild swans cry. In the wrangling-grounds of gossip I have no part, in the seas of right and wrong few are my footprints found. By the brook I hang and dry my net like a brocade, upon the rock he grinds his axe again to a keen edge. Under the bright autumn moon I often fish alone, on the silent spring mountains he meets no man at all. Fish in plenty I trade for wine and drink it with my wife, kindling to spare he sells for a jug and

shares it with his son. Each of us sings to himself, pours for himself, abandoned and free, long we sing, long we sigh, careless of the whirling wind. Calling our brothers, hailing our mates, we summon the boat-fellows, taking friends, leading comrades, we gather the country elders. Playing the wine-game, guessing fingers, we pass the cup round and round, breaking the dominoes, spelling the words, we idly pass the chime. Boiling shrimp and cooking crab, each morning is a joy, frying duck and braising chicken, each day is a feast. My homely wife brews the tea, her manner free and light, his mountain wife cooks the rice, her bearing calm and slow. At dawn I lift my pole to dredge through the light waves, at sunrise he shoulders his wood across the great divide. After the rain I don my cape and catch the living carp, before the wind he plies his axe and fells the withered pine. Hiding our tracks, shunning the world, we play the dull and foolish, concealing

our names, burying our surnames, we feign the deaf and dumb."

Said Zhang Shao, "Brother Li, just now I presumed to lead off with the opening lines. Now it falls to my brother — you too lead off with a couplet, and I, your younger brother, will follow on." So Li Ding began:

Feigning madness in wind and moon, a wild fellow
of the hills, lodging his pride in river and lake, an
old man past his prime. The pure and idle have
their share of free and easy ways, with no gossip in
our ears, we delight in the great peace. On moonlit
nights my body sleeps secure in its thatched hut,
when the sky darkens I cover myself with a light
bamboo cape. Forgetting the world, I make my
friends of the pine and the plum, gladly I bind in
fellowship with the gull and the egret. In my heart
no scheming after name and gain, at my ear no
sound of shield and spear. As the hour permits, a
single cup of fragrant brew, to pass the day, three
meals of wild-herb broth. Two bundles of kindling
are my means of life, a single rod and line are my
whole livelihood. Idly I call my young son to grind
the steel axe sharp, quietly I summon my simple
boy to mend the old net. When spring comes I love
to watch the willows turn green, when the season
thaws I gladly see the reeds grow blue. In summer's

heat I trim fresh bamboo for the cool, in the sixth month, taking the air, I pluck the tender water-chestnuts. When frost descends the chickens are fat and often slaughtered, at the Double Ninth the crabs are plump and stewed in season. When winter comes, the sun well risen, I sleep on still, through the deepest cold the sky is high, yet I feel no chill at all. Through the eight festivals in the mountains I follow my nature, through the four seasons on the lake I please my mood at will. In gathering firewood there is the joy of the immortals' households, in dropping the hook there is nothing of the world's vulgar form. Beyond my gate the wildflowers bloom fragrant and bright, at my boat's prow the green waters lie level and calm. The body at ease, I speak not of the rank of the Three Dukes, the temper settled is stronger than a city walled ten miles round. A city walled ten miles high must guard against the watch-commands, the high office of the Three Dukes must heed the herald's proclamations.

To delight in mountains, to delight in waters — this is rare indeed. Thanks be to Heaven, thanks be to Earth, thanks be to the gods!"

When the two of them had each spoken their lyric verses and linked their poems together, they came at last to the place where their roads parted, and bowing, they took their leave. Said Zhang Shao, "Brother Li, take care along the way. As you go up the mountain, watch closely for tigers. If some peril should befall you, then indeed 'on the street tomorrow there will be one old friend the fewer."

At these words Li Ding flew into a great rage. "You worthless rascal!" he cried. "A good friend would lay down his life for me — how can you curse me like that? If I should meet a tiger and come to harm, then you are bound to meet the waves and be capsized in the river!"

"I shall never in all my life be capsized in the river," said Zhang Shao.

"The sky holds unforeseen winds and clouds; a man holds sudden fortune and disaster," said Li Ding. "How can you be so sure of coming to no harm?"

"Brother Li," said Zhang Shao, "though you talk this way, it is you who can take no measure of your trade — whereas my livelihood I can take the full measure of, and I shall surely come to no such mishap."

"Your business on the water," said Li Ding, "is most perilous, most dangerous, hidden and dark — what measure can you possibly take of it?"

"You do not understand," said Zhang Shao. "In the city of Chang'an, on the street by the West Gate, there is a fortune-teller. Every day I bring

him a golden carp, and he gives me a reading from his sleeve. I follow the directions he gives, and it is a hundred casts, a hundred hauls — never a miss. Today I went again to buy a reading, and he told me to cast my net on the east side of the bend in the Jing River, and to throw my hook on the western bank, and I shall surely come home with a full load of fish and shrimp. Tomorrow I'll go up to the city, sell them for coin, buy wine, and we'll meet again, old brother." And so the two parted.

Now this is just the case of "words spoken on the road, with someone hidden in the grass." For it happened that in the water-palace of the Jing River there was a patrolling yaksha on the night-watch, who, hearing those words of "a hundred casts, a hundred hauls," went hurrying back to the Crystal Palace and reported to the Dragon King in a panic, "Disaster! Disaster!"

"What disaster?" asked the Dragon King.

Said the yaksha, "Your servant, patrolling the waters, came to the riverbank, and there I heard two men — a fisherman and a woodcutter — in conversation. As they parted, their words were exceedingly dangerous. The fisherman said that in the city of Chang'an, on the street by the West Gate, there is a fortune-teller whose reckonings are most exact. Every day he brings the man a carp, and the man gives him a reading from his sleeve, telling him a hundred casts, a hundred hauls — never a miss. If by such accurate reckoning he goes on, then will not all our water-tribe be utterly fished out? How then shall we keep the grandeur of the water-palace? How then shall we leap the waves and overturn the billows to aid Your Majesty's might?"

The Dragon King was enraged. He seized his sword at once and was about to go up to Chang'an to slay this fortune-teller, when forth stepped the dragon-sons and dragon-grandsons, the shrimp-ministers and crab-

officers, the shad field-marshal, the mandarin-fish vice-minister, and the carp prime-minister, who together submitted, "Let Your Majesty restrain his wrath. As the old saying goes, 'Words that pass the ear should not be believed.' If Your Majesty goes thus, you must be attended by clouds and aided by rain, and we fear you would alarm the common folk of Chang'an, and Heaven above would call you to account. Your Majesty appears and vanishes past all fathoming, and changes without fixed form — so let us merely transform into a single scholar and go into the city of Chang'an to make inquiry. If such a man truly exists, there will be time enough to slay him; but if there is no such man, would it not be a wanton injury to an innocent person?"

The Dragon King heeded their counsel, and so he laid aside his precious sword, raised neither cloud nor rain, went up onto the bank, and with a shake of his body transformed himself into a scholar in white. Truly:

His bearing handsome and heroic, towering aloft as if to brush the clouds. His steps proper and composed, observing measure and rule. His speech followed Confucius and Mencius, his courtesy embodied the rites of King Wen. His body clad in jade-colored gauze and silken robes, his head crowned with a free-and-easy single-band kerchief.

Taking to the road, he spread out his cloud-stride and went straight to the great street by the West Gate of Chang'an. There he saw a knot of people, crowded and jostling, noisy and clamorous. Among them one

was holding forth grandly: "He whose fate-sign is the Dragon, and he whose sign is the Tiger, are in conflict. The signs of Tiger and Dragon, Snake and Pig — though they are called a harmonious set, what is feared most is when the day offends the Lord of the Year." When the Dragon King heard this, he knew at once that this was the place of divination. He came forward, parted the crowd, and looked within. He saw:

The four walls hung with pearls and jade, the whole hall filled with embroidered silks. The treasure-duck censer never ceasing its incense, the porcelain vase with water so clear. On either side arrayed the paintings of Wang Wei, above the seat hung high the portrait of Guiguzi. An inkstone of Duanxi, golden smoke-ink, set off against the great frost-tipped brush; the Fire-Pearl Grove text, the calculations of Guo Pu, faced squarely by the new Classic of the Terrace's governance. Versed in the Six Lines, perfect in the Eight Trigrams, he could know the principles of Heaven and Earth, and well understood the ways of ghosts and gods. The compass-board with its meridian fixed and set, his breast full of stars laid out in clear array. Truly the things to come, the things gone by, he viewed as in a moon-bright mirror; how many houses prosper, how many fall, he discerned as clear as a god. He knew ill and fixed good fortune, foretold death and spoke of life. Opening his talk, the wind and rain

rushed forth; setting down his brush, the very ghosts and gods were startled. The signboard bore his name in writing — Master Yuan Shoucheng, the diviner of spirit-readings.

Who was this man? He was, in fact, the uncle of Master Yuan Tiangang, Director of the Imperial Astronomical Bureau at court — this Yuan Shoucheng. The master was indeed of rare appearance and elegant bearing, his name famed throughout the great realm, his art unmatched in all Chang'an. The Dragon King came in at the door and greeted the master. The courtesies done, the master invited his guest to take the seat of honor, and a serving-boy brought tea. The master asked, "On what business has the gentleman come to inquire?"

Said the Dragon King, "I beg a reading concerning the matter of fair weather and foul in the heavens."

The master at once drew a reading from his sleeve and pronounced, "The clouds shroud the mountain-peaks, the mist veils the forest-tops. If you would divine the rain, it falls for certain tomorrow morning."

"At what hour tomorrow will it rain?" asked the Dragon King. "And how much — how many feet and inches?"

Said the master, "Tomorrow the clouds will spread at the hour of the Dragon, the thunder will break at the hour of the Snake, the rain will fall at the hour of the Horse, and the rain will be complete at the hour of the Goat — altogether three feet, three inches, and forty-eight drops of water."

The Dragon King laughed and said, "These words are not to be taken in jest. If it indeed rains tomorrow according to the hours and amounts you have pronounced, I will send you fifty taels of gold as my reading-fee in thanks. But if there is no rain, or if it does not match your hours and amounts, then I tell you plainly: I will surely smash the front of your shop, tear your signboard to pieces, and drive you out of Chang'an this instant, never to deceive the multitude here again."

The master answered cheerfully, "That shall be entirely as you please. Go now, go now. Tomorrow, after the rain, we will meet again."

The Dragon King took his leave, departed Chang'an, and returned to the water-palace. The water-spirits great and small received him and asked, "How did Your Majesty fare in seeking out that fortune-teller?"

Said the Dragon King, "There is one, there is one — but he is only a glib-tongued fellow peddling forecasts of spring. I asked him when it would rain, and he said it would rain tomorrow. I asked him at what hour and in what amount, and he said the clouds would spread at the hour of the Dragon, the thunder break at the hour of the Snake, the rain fall at the hour of the Horse, and the rain be complete at the hour of the Goat — altogether three feet, three inches, and forty-eight drops of water. I made a wager with him: if it should fall exactly as he says, I'll send him fifty taels of gold in thanks; but if it differs by the least bit, I'll smash the front of his shop, drive him on his way, and never let him deceive the people of Chang'an again."

The water-tribe laughed and said, "Your Majesty is the chief commander of the Eight Rivers, the great Dragon-Spirit who governs the rain. Whether there is rain or no rain, Your Majesty alone knows it. How dare he talk such nonsense? That fortune-teller is certain to lose — certain to lose!"

Just then, while the dragon-sons and dragon-grandsons, the fish-lords and crab-officers, were still laughing and talking gleefully of this matter, there came a cry from the middle air: "Let the Dragon King of the Jing River receive the decree!" All looked up, and there was a strongman in golden robes, holding in his hands the edict of the Jade Emperor, coming straight toward the water-palace. In a fluster the Dragon King set his garments straight, composed himself with all solemnity, burned incense, and received the decree. The golden-robed strongman returned through the air. The Dragon King gave thanks for the grace, broke the seal, and looked. There it was written:

By imperial command to the Commander of the
Eight Rivers: drive the thunder, hurl the lightning
forth; tomorrow morning send down the rain to
bless and save the city of Chang'an.

The hours and the amounts named in the decree did not differ by a hair's breadth from what the master had judged. The Dragon King was so startled that his soul flew off and his spirits scattered. After a moment he came to himself and said to the water-tribe, "That there should be in the dusty mortal world a man of such power, who can truly penetrate the principles of Heaven and Earth — am I then to lose to him?"

The shad field-marshal submitted, "Let Your Majesty set his mind at ease. To beat him — where is the difficulty? Your servant has a small scheme that will surely silence that fellow's mouth." The Dragon King asked his plan, and the field-marshal said, "Let the rain be sent at the wrong hour and short of the proper count — then that fellow's reading

will be wrong, and how can he fail to be beaten? Then we smash his signboard and drive him on his way — what is hard in that?"

The Dragon King took his counsel and set aside his worry.

The next day, he summoned the Earl of Wind, the Duke of Thunder, the Cloud-Lads, and the Mother of Lightning, and went straight up to the nine heavens above the city of Chang'an. He held off until the hour of the Snake before spreading the clouds, let the thunder break at the hour of the Horse, sent the rain down at the hour of the Goat, and stopped the rain at the hour of the Monkey — and even then let fall only three feet and forty drops. Thus he altered the hour by one watch, and cut short the count by three inches and eight drops. When the rain was done he dismissed the spirit-officers and sent his troops home. Then he pressed his cloud-head down again, transformed himself once more into the scholar in white, and going to the great street within the West Gate, burst into Yuan Shoucheng's divining shop. Without a word of explanation, he smashed the signboard, the brushes, the inkstones, and all to pieces. The master sat in his chair without stirring. The Dragon King then snatched up a door-plank to strike him, cursing, "You sorcerer who lies about fortune and disaster! You wretch who deludes the people's hearts! Your reading was false, your words wild and absurd. The hour and the count of today's rain that you spoke of were all wrong. And yet you sit there grandly aloft! Get out at once, and I'll spare you the death you deserve!"

Yet Shoucheng remained utterly unafraid. He turned his face up to heaven and laughed coldly, saying, "I am not afraid, I am not afraid. I have no crime worthy of death — but I fear that it is *you* who have a crime worthy of death. Others you may deceive, but it is hard to deceive me. I know you: you are no scholar — you are the Dragon King of the Jing River. You have defied the decree of the Jade Emperor, altered the

hours, and cut short the count — you have broken the law of Heaven. On the Dragon-Quartering Terrace, I fear, you can scarcely escape the blade. And here you stand cursing me?"

When the Dragon King heard this, his heart quailed and his courage failed, his hair stood on end and his flesh crept. He flung away the door-plank at once, straightened his robes, made his obeisance, and knelt down before the master, saying, "Master, do not blame me. My earlier words were spoken in jest — how could I know that the make-believe would become real, and that I should truly break the law of Heaven? What am I to do? I beg the master to save me, to save me — and if you do not, then in death I will not let you go!"

Said Shoucheng, "Save you I cannot — but I can point out to you a path to life, that you may find your way." Said the Dragon King, "I beg you to instruct me." The master said, "Tomorrow, at the third quarter of the hour of the Horse, you are to be brought for sentence of beheading before the officer of human affairs, Wei Zheng. If you truly wish to keep your life, you must go at once, with all speed, and plead with the present sovereign, Emperor Tang Taizong — that will be best. For this Wei Zheng is the prime minister beneath the throne of the Tang king; if you can win from him some favor, then your safety is assured."

The Dragon King heard this, took his leave with bows and brimming tears, and departed. Before he knew it, the red sun was sinking in the west and the moon-star had risen. There was to be seen:

Mist gathers, mountains turn purple, the homing
crows grow weary, travelers on the distant road put
in at their inns. By the ferry-head the new wild
geese roost on the sandy shoals, the Milky Way
appears, the watch-tally is sounded, and in the
lonely village the lamplight burns without a flame.
The wind curls the censer-smoke about the quiet
temple yard, in the butterfly's dream the dreamer is
nowhere seen. The moon shifts the shadows of the
flowers up onto the railing, the starlight scatters,
the dripping-clock changes its tally, and unawares
the deep, deep night is already half gone.

The Dragon King of the Jing River did not return to his water-palace, but stayed up in the air. He waited until about the hour of the Rat, then gathered up his cloud-head, drew in his horns of mist, and went straight to the gate of the imperial palace. At that very time the Tang king was dreaming that he had walked out beyond the palace gate and was strolling under the moon in the shade of the flowers. Suddenly the Dragon King, in the form of a man, came forward, knelt and bowed, and cried out, "Your Majesty, save me, save me!" Said Taizong, "Who are you? I will surely save you." Said the Dragon King, "Your Majesty is the True Dragon; your servant is a doomed dragon. Because I have broken the law of Heaven, I am to be beheaded by Your Majesty's worthy minister, the

officer of human affairs, Wei Zheng — and so I have come to make my plea, hoping Your Majesty will save me, will save me." Said Taizong, "Since it is Wei Zheng who is to behead you, I can save you. Set your heart at ease and go." The Dragon King rejoiced, kowtowed his thanks, and departed.

When Taizong woke from his dream, he kept the matter fixed in his mind. Already it was the third point of the fifth watch. Taizong held court and gathered the two ranks of civil and military officials. There was to be seen:

Mist enwreathing the phoenix-towers, fragrance hovering over the dragon-halls. The light shimmers, the vermilion screens stir; the clouds brush the kingfisher-plumed canopies as they flow. Sovereign and ministers in concord, like Yao and Shun; their rites and music, stern in majesty, near to Han and Zhou. The attendants' lamps, the palace-maids' fans, pair upon pair reflecting bright colors; the peacock screens, the unicorn hall, everywhere the light floats high. They cry "Ten thousand years!" to the hills, they wish a thousand autumns of glory. The silencing-whip cracks three times, and the capped and gowned bow to the crown. Palace blossoms blazing bright, the heavenly fragrance wafts; the dike-willows soft and gentle, the imperial music sings. The pearl curtains, the kingfisher curtains, drawn up high on golden hooks; the dragon-and-phoenix fans, the mountains-and-rivers fans, where the treasure-carriage halts. The civil officials handsome and refined, the military generals fierce

and rousing. The royal way divides high from low,
the vermilion steps array the ranks of office. Golden
seals and purple cords ride upon the three elephants
— long as earth, enduring as heaven, ten thousand
thousand autumns.

When the officials had finished their court salutations, each took his place by rank. The Tang king opened his phoenix-eyes and dragon-pupils and looked them over one by one. Among the civil officials he saw Fang Xuanling, Du Ruhui, Xu Shiji, Xu Jingzong, Wang Gui, and the rest; among the military he saw Ma Sanbao, Duan Zhixuan, Yin Kaishan, Cheng Yaojin, Liu Hongji, Hu Jingde, Qin Shubao, and the rest — each one of awesome and solemn bearing. But the prime minister Wei Zheng was nowhere to be seen. The Tang king summoned Xu Shiji up to the hall and said, "Last night I had a strange dream. A man came forward and made his obeisance to me, calling himself the Dragon King of the Jing River. He said that he had broken the law of Heaven and was to be beheaded by the officer of human affairs, Wei Zheng, and he begged me to save him, and I gave my promise. Today, of all those before the court, only Wei Zheng is absent. Why is this?"

Shiji answered, "This dream foretells the truth. Wei Zheng must be summoned to court at once, and Your Majesty must not let him go out of the door. Keep him detained through this one day, and the dragon of the dream may yet be saved." The Tang king rejoiced and at once issued an order that the officer on duty should summon Wei Zheng to court.

Now the prime minister Wei Zheng, at his own residence, had been observing the celestial signs by night and burning precious incense,

when he heard the cry of a crane in the nine heavens — it was a heavenly messenger sent by the gods, bearing a golden decree of the Jade Emperor, charging him at the third quarter of the hour of the Horse to behead in a dream the old dragon of the Jing River. The prime minister gave thanks for Heaven's grace, fasted and bathed, and in his residence tested the blade of wisdom and exercised his primal spirit — and for this reason he had not gone to court. When suddenly he saw the officer on duty arrive bearing the summons, he was filled with dread; yet not daring to delay the sovereign's command, he could only make haste, set his garments and girdle straight, and go in with the summons to the court, where before the imperial presence he kowtowed and begged pardon for his fault. Said the Tang king, "I absolve my minister of all blame." The other officials had not yet withdrawn from court; now the king commanded the screens be rolled up and the court dismissed. He kept Wei Zheng alone, summoned him up to the golden throne-room, called him into the side hall, and first discussed with him the strategies for securing the realm and the plans for settling the state.

When the time drew near the end of the hour of the Snake and the beginning of the hour of the Horse, the king commanded the palace attendants, "Bring the great chessboard. I will play a game with my worthy minister." The palace ladies fetched the board and set it out upon the imperial table. Wei Zheng gave thanks for the grace and at once played against the Tang king, each setting down a piece in turn, laying out their formations. It accorded well with the *Classic of the Rotted Axe-Handle*, which says:

The way of chess prizes care and rigor. The strong play to the center, the weak to the edges, the middling to the corners — this is the common method of the chess-master. The rule says: "Rather lose a single stone than lose a single move." Strike to the left while watching the right; attack behind while looking before. There is a leading that comes after, and a following that comes first. Where two are alive, do not cut them; where all are alive, do not connect them. Be not too sparse in your openness, nor too crowded in your density. Better than clinging to a stone in search of life is to abandon it and take the victory; better than going alone with nothing to do is to make yourself firm and repair your own position. When the enemy is many and you are few, first contrive your own survival; when you are many and the enemy few, strive to spread out your force. The good winner does not contend; the good arrayer does not fight; the good fighter is not defeated; the good loser is

not thrown into disorder. For chess begins by joining with the orthodox and ends by winning through the unexpected. When an enemy with nothing to do mends his own position, he has a mind to invade and cut you off; when he abandons the small and does not save it, he has a heart set on the great. He who plays as his hand falls is a man without a plan; he who responds without thought takes the road to defeat. The *Book of Songs* says: "Anxious and careful, as if standing at the edge of an abyss." This is what is meant.

The poem runs: The chessboard is the earth, the stones are heaven, their colors set by yin and yang, the work of creation complete. Played to the subtle point where the changes are fathomed through, one laughs and boasts of that immortal of the bygone Rotted Axe.

The two of them, sovereign and minister, played on. The game had come just to the third quarter of the hour of the Horse, with a single ruined position not yet resolved, when Wei Zheng suddenly bent forward over the edge of the table and fell fast asleep, snore upon snore. Taizong laughed and said, "My worthy minister is truly wearied with the toil of upholding the altars of state, and spent with the labor of founding the realm — and so without knowing it he has dozed off." Taizong let him sleep and would not call to him. After no long while Wei Zheng woke, prostrated himself upon the ground, and said, "Your servant deserves ten

thousand deaths, ten thousand deaths! Just now I was overcome with weariness and knew not what I did — I beg Your Majesty to forgive your servant the crime of slighting his sovereign." Said Taizong, "What crime of slighting have you? Rise now, clear away the ruined game, and we will play afresh."

Wei Zheng gave thanks for the grace and had just taken a stone into his hand when suddenly there came a great shouting and clamor from outside the court gate. It was Qin Shubao, Xu Maogong, and the others, who bore in a dripping dragon's head and flung it down before the throne, submitting, "Your Majesty, that the seas should run shallow and the rivers run dry has been seen before — but such a marvel as this has never been heard of!" Taizong and Wei Zheng rose to their feet and said, "Where did this thing come from?" Said Shubao and Maogong, "South of the Thousand-Pace Gallery, at the crossroads, this dragon's head fell down from the midst of the clouds, and your servants dared not fail to report it." The Tang king, startled, asked Wei Zheng, "What is the meaning of this?" Wei Zheng turned, kowtowed, and said, "It is the dragon that your servant just now beheaded in his dream."

When the Tang king heard this he was greatly astonished. "When my worthy minister was dozing," he said, "I saw you neither move your body nor stir your hands, and you had neither blade nor sword — how then did you behead this dragon?" Wei Zheng submitted, "My sovereign, my body was before my king, but my dream departed from Your Majesty's side. My body before my king faced the unfinished game, my eyes closed in a drowsy haze; yet my dream departed from Your Majesty, riding an auspicious cloud, my spirit roused and vigorous. That dragon, upon the Dragon-Quartering Terrace, was bound fast by the heavenly troops and generals. And I declared: 'You have broken the law of Heaven, and the crime deserves death. I bear the mandate of Heaven, to behead your

remaining life.' The dragon, hearing this, wailed in misery. Your servant roused his spirit. It laid down its claws and drew in its scales and willingly received death; your servant hitched up his robe, stepped forward, and raised the frost-bright blade. With a clashing stroke the blade swept down, and the dragon's head fell away into the empty air."

When Taizong heard this, his heart was divided between sorrow and joy. He was glad, for he praised Wei Zheng as a fine minister: with such a hero in his court, why should he fear that the realm would not be secure? He was sorrowful, for in the dream he had promised to save the dragon, and had not expected it would come to be slain after all. He could only force up his spirits and issue a decree that Shubao should hang the dragon's head in the marketplace to make it known to the common folk of Chang'an. He rewarded Wei Zheng, and the officials dispersed.

That evening he returned to the palace, his heart heavy with melancholy. He thought of the dragon of the dream, how it had wept and wailed and begged for its life — little knowing that impermanence is hard to escape, that such a calamity could not be avoided. He brooded on it for a long while, and gradually felt his spirit grow weary and his body unwell. That very night, at about the second watch, he heard the sound of wailing and weeping outside the palace gate, and Taizong grew the more terrified. Just as he lay in a drowsy half-sleep, he saw again that Dragon King of the Jing River, holding in his hand a dripping, bloody head, crying aloud, "Tang Taizong, give me back my life! Give me back my life! Last night your mouth was full of promises to save me — how is it that at daybreak you turned about and summoned the officer of human affairs to behead me? Come out, come out! You and I will go before the King of the Underworld and argue this out!" He seized hold of Taizong and clamored again and again, refusing to let go. Taizong's mouth was sealed, he could

not speak, and he could only struggle until the sweat ran down his whole body.

Just at this moment of hopeless deadlock, behold — in the southern sky fragrant clouds came curling and colored mists came drifting, and a female immortal came forward and with her hand waved a willow-branch. At that, the headless dragon, weeping and wailing piteously, went off straight to the northwest. Now this was none other than the Bodhisattva Guanyin, who, bearing the Buddha's command, had come to the Eastern Land to seek out the pilgrim who would fetch the scriptures, and was lodging in the city-god's temple of Chang'an. Hearing by night the ghost's weeping and the spirit's cries, she had come expressly to drive back the doomed dragon and rescue the emperor. The dragon went straight to the courts of the underworld to lodge its complaint — but of that, no more for now.

When Taizong came to himself, he could only cry out, "A ghost! A ghost!" In their fright, the queens of the Three Palaces and the consorts of the Six Courts, together with the attendant eunuchs, trembled and quaked, and not one of them slept the whole night through.

Before they knew it, it was the third point of the fifth watch, and all the civil and military officials of the court waited outside the court gate for the audience. They waited until full daylight, yet still no audience was held, and one and all were struck with alarm and uncertainty. When the sun was three poles high, at last a decree came forth: "My heart is unwell; the officials are excused from audience." Five or seven days passed unawares; the officials grew anxious and fearful, and were just about to force the gate and seek an audience to inquire after the emperor's health, when there came an order from the Empress Dowager summoning the court physician into the palace to administer medicine. The crowd waited outside the court gate for news. After a little while the

physician came out, and they asked what the illness was. Said the physician, "His Majesty's pulse is irregular — empty, and yet rapid; he raves wildly and sees ghosts. And I find that the pulse skips once in every ten beats: the five viscera are without vital force, and I fear the worst within seven days."

When the officials heard this, they were stricken pale with dismay.

In the midst of their dismay, there came another decree from the Empress Dowager summoning Xu Maogong, the Duke who Guards the Realm, and Yuchi Gong to an audience. The three lords obeyed the summons and hurried in to the foot of the Detached Palace Tower. When the obeisances were done, Taizong, composing his face and forcing himself to speak, said, "My worthy ministers, at nineteen I led troops, campaigning south and warring north, blocking the east and clearing the west; through bitter years of hardship I never once saw the least trace of evil spirits — yet today I am plagued by ghosts." Said Yuchi Gong, "In founding the realm you slew men beyond all counting; why then fear ghosts?" Said Taizong, "You do not believe it. Outside the door of my sleeping-chamber, when night comes, they fling bricks and rattle the tiles, the demons and goblins cry and howl, and it is truly past enduring. The daytime is bearable, but the dark of night is not to be borne." Said Shubao, "Set your heart at ease, Your Majesty. Tonight your servant and Jingde will stand guard at the palace gate and see what manner of ghost it is." Taizong granted the request. Maogong gave thanks for the grace and withdrew.

That evening, when darkness came, the two generals donned their helmets and cuirasses in full array, took up the golden mace and the battle-axe, and stood guard outside the palace gate. What fine generals! See how they were arrayed:

On their heads gleaming golden helmets, dazzling bright; their bodies cased in scaled armor like dragon-mail. The heart-guarding treasure-mirrors flash with auspicious clouds, the lion-buckled belts drawn tight, the embroidered sashes fresh with rosy light. This one's phoenix-eyes turned skyward make the very stars and constellations quail; that one's ringed eyes, mirroring the lightning, set the moonlight afloat. They were heroes and stalwarts, old ministers of merit — and so they came to be, for a thousand years, hailed as the Guardians of the Gate, and through all ages to serve as the Gods of the Door.

The two generals stood guard beside the gate, and through the whole night until dawn there was not the least sign of any evil. That night Taizong slept in the palace in peace and untroubled. When morning came he summoned the two generals and rewarded them richly, saying, "Since I fell ill, for several days I could get no sleep, yet tonight, by the might of the two generals, I have been wholly at peace. Go now and rest yourselves, and tonight stand guard once more." The two generals gave thanks for the grace and withdrew.

Thus for two or three nights the watch was kept and all was peaceful. But the imperial meals dwindled, and the illness grew the heavier. Taizong, unwilling that the two generals should be so wearied, summoned Shubao and Jingde, together with Du and Fang and the other lords, into the palace, and charged them: "These past days, though I have been at peace, it has been a hardship for generals Qin and Hu to keep watch through the whole night. I wish to summon a skilled painter to take the true likenesses of the two generals and paste them on the door, to spare them the toil. How would that be?" The officials at once obeyed the order, chose two who were skilled at portraiture, had the two lords Hu and Qin armored as before and painted to the life, and the likenesses pasted on the door. And through the night there was again no trouble.

So it went for two or three days. Then from the rear palace gate came a clattering and banging, bricks and tiles rattling in confusion. When morning came, Taizong at once summoned the officials and said, "These last days the front gate has happily been quiet, but tonight the rear gate clamors again — does it not nearly frighten me to death?" Maogong came forward and submitted, "When the front gate was troubled, Jingde and Shubao guarded it; for the rear gate's trouble, Wei Zheng should stand guard." Taizong granted the request and summoned Wei Zheng to guard the rear gate that night. Wei Zheng received the command, and that night, accoutered in full array, grasping the precious sword with which he had slain the dragon, stood guard before the rear palace gate. Truly a fine hero! See how he was arrayed:

A black kerchief of fine silk bound across his brow, a brocade robe with jade-girt belt hanging at his waist. The wind-catching cape's wide sleeves flutter like frost; he outdoes in aspect the very gods of the gate. His feet in black boots, seated firm; in his hand the keen blade, fierce and bold. His two eyes glaring round, peering on every side — what evil spirit dares come near?

The whole night through, bright as day, not a demon stirred. And though front gate and rear gate were now both at peace, still his body grew steadily heavier.

One day, the Empress Dowager issued a decree, summoning the officials to deliberate on the affairs of the funeral and interment. Taizong once more summoned Xu Maogong, charged him with the great affairs of state, and enjoined him after the manner of the Lord of Shu entrusting his orphan. When he had finished speaking, he bathed and changed his garments, and only awaited his hour. Then Wei Zheng stepped forward at his side, took hold of the dragon-robe with his hand, and submitted, "Let Your Majesty set your heart at ease. I have one thing that will surely secure Your Majesty's long life." Said Taizong, "The sickness has already entered the vitals and my life is in peril — how can it be secured?" Said Wei Zheng, "Your servant has a letter which I present to Your Majesty, to carry down to the underworld and deliver to the Judge of Fengdu, Cui Jue." Said Taizong, "Who is Cui Jue?" Said Wei Zheng, "Cui Jue was a

minister before the throne of the late former emperor. He first received the post of Magistrate of Cizhou, and was later promoted to Vice-Minister of Rites. In his lifetime he and your servant swore brotherhood with eight bows, and our friendship ran deep. He is now dead, and serves in the underworld as the Judge of Fengdu, in charge of the registers of life and death; in my dreams he often comes to meet me. If on this journey you give him this letter, then mindful of his old bond with your servant, he will surely send Your Majesty back. I warrant that the soul shall return to the world of the living, and that the dragon-countenance shall surely come again to the imperial city." When Taizong heard this, he took the letter in his hand, tucked it into his sleeve, and then closed his eyes and died.

The queens of the Three Palaces and the consorts of the Six Courts, the empress and the imperial concubines, the chief attendants and the heir apparent, and the two ranks of civil and military officials all raised the wail of mourning and donned their mourning weeds. In the Hall of the White Tiger the coffin was laid in state — but of that, no more.

As for how, in the end, Taizong returned to life — listen to the next chapter as it is told.

Chapter 11: The Emperor's Soul Journeys Through the Underworld

A poem says:

A hundred years of light and shadow flow away like water; a whole life's labors are no more than bubbles on the stream. Yesterday the face was flushed with the color of peach blossoms; today the snowflakes drift and gather at the temples. Only when the white-ant armies crumble is their pomp shown false; when the cuckoo's cry grows urgent, turn back early. Since ancient times, hidden good deeds can lengthen a life; do good without begging for pity, and Heaven looks after all.

Now we tell how Emperor Taizong, dim and dazed, drifted in a faint, his soul slipping out from before the Tower of the Five Phoenixes. There he saw the cavalry of the Imperial Forest Guard, who begged the great carriage to ride forth from court and go hunting. The Emperor cheerfully consented and went off into the mist and haze. He traveled a long while — and then men and horses alike vanished. He was left all alone, wandering across desolate moors and weedy wilds.

Just as he was floundering in alarm, unable to find the road, he saw someone off to one side who cried out in a loud voice: "Great Tang Emperor — come this way! Come this way!" Hearing the call, Taizong lifted his head and looked. He saw a man whose appearance was thus:

On his head a cap of black gauze; about his waist a sash of rhinoceros horn. The black gauze cap with its soft fluttering bands; the rhinoceros-

horn sash set in gleaming gold. In his hand he gripped an ivory tablet, wrapped in auspicious vapors; on his body he wore a silken robe, glowing with hidden good omen. On his feet a pair of white-soled boots that trod the clouds and hastened the mists; in his breast he carried a Register of Life and Death, fixing who should live and who should die. His sidelocks were tousled, drifting above his ears; his whiskers flew and curled about his cheeks. In days gone by he had been a minister of the Tang realm; now he kept the records as an officer attending King Yama.

When Taizong drew near, he saw the man kneel and bow beside the road, calling out: "Your Majesty, forgive your servant the offense of failing to come farther to welcome you." Taizong asked, "Who are you? And on what business have you come forward to receive me?" The man said, "Half a month ago, in the Hall of Endless Shadows, I saw the ghost-dragon of the Jing River accuse Your Majesty of promising to save him and then having him put to death instead. King Qinguang of the First Hall at once dispatched ghostly couriers to summon Your Majesty, that the case might be tried before the Three Tribunals. Knowing this, I came here to wait and welcome you. I did not expect to arrive late today — I beg you, forgive my fault, forgive my fault." Taizong said, "What is your surname and given name? What office do you hold?" The man replied, "While I lived in the world of light, I served before the late sovereign's throne as magistrate of Cizhou, and afterward was raised to Vice-President of the Board of Rites. My surname is Cui, my name is Jue. Now in the shadow realm I have been granted the post of Records Judge of Fengdu." Taizong was greatly pleased. He stepped forward and, with his own imperial hand, hastily raised the man up, saying, "Sir, you have toiled far on my account. My minister Wei Zheng entrusted me with a letter addressed to you — and now, how fortunate, we have met!" The judge gave thanks and asked where the letter might be. Taizong reached

into his sleeve, drew it out, and handed it over. Cui Jue received it with a bow, broke the seal, and read. The letter said:

With unworthy affection, your younger brother Wei Zheng bows his head and presents this letter to the desk of the Senior Records Officer, his sworn elder brother, the venerable Cui: I remember our old fellowship; your voice and face are still before me. In a flash several years have passed, and I have heard nothing of your wise teaching. Always at the festival seasons I have set out vegetable offerings in sacrifice — though I cannot tell whether you have partaken. And then, not disdaining me, you appeared to me in a dream, and only then did I learn that you, my elder, had risen high. Yet, alas, the realms of light and shadow keep us apart, the heavens set us in separate quarters, and we cannot meet face to face. Now, because my Emperor Taizong, the Civil and Cultured, has suddenly passed away — I reckon his case is to be tried before the Three Tribunals, and surely he will come to meet with you, elder brother. I beg you, in remembrance of our lifelong friendship, to grant

some small accommodation, and let my sovereign return to the world of light. That would be a singular kindness. I shall thank you again hereafter. Words cannot say it all.

When the judge had read the letter, his heart was filled with joy, and he said, "I knew long since of how the human officer Wei beheaded the old dragon in a dream the other day — it is a deed beyond all praise. And he has so kindly looked after my children and grandchildren morning and evening. Now that this letter has come, let Your Majesty set your heart at ease. Your humble servant will see Your Majesty back to the world of light, that you may again ascend the jade throne." Taizong gave his thanks.

While the two of them were talking, a pair of blue-robed page-boys appeared bearing pennants, banners, and a precious canopy, who called out: "King Yama requests your presence — your presence is requested." So Taizong, together with Judge Cui and the two boys, stepped forward and advanced. Suddenly there appeared a city, and over its gate hung a great placard inscribed with seven large golden characters: "The Gate of Ghosts of the Dark and Dismal Region of the Dead." The blue-robed boys shook out their pennants and led Taizong straight into the city, walking down the street. There along the roadside stood his late father Li Yuan, his late elder brother Jiancheng, and his dead younger brother Yuanji, who came forward crying: "Shimin has come! Shimin has come!" Jiancheng and Yuanji rushed up to seize him and demand back their lives. Taizong could not dodge in time and was caught fast in their grasp. Luckily Judge Cui summoned a green-faced, fang-toothed ghost-courier, who bellowed Jiancheng and Yuanji back, and only then did Taizong win

free and get away. Before he had gone many li, he saw a tower of emerald tiles, truly grand and splendid. Behold:

Drifting and heaped, ten thousand folds of colored sunset clouds; dim and shadowed, a thousand strands of red mist appear. Bright and shining, monster-heads soar from the eaves; gleaming and glowing, five-layered mandarin-duck tiles. Through the gate run rows of red-gold studs; on the threshold lies one bar of white jade. The lattice-windows let the dawn-smoke's brightness through; the bamboo blinds flash bright as bolts of red lightning. The tower soars high to touch the blue empyrean; the corridors stretch level, joined to courts of treasure. From beast-shaped censers the incense-clouds sweep over royal robes; in crimson gauze the lantern-fires light the palace fans. To the left, fierce and grim, are ranked the Ox-Heads; to the right, towering and rugged, stand the Horse-Faces. Receiving the dead and sending off the ghosts, the gold tablets turn; guiding the souls and summoning the spirits, white streamers hang. This is called the Great Assembly Gate of the Shadow

World — below it, old Yama's Hall of Endless Shadows.

While Taizong was looking on from outside, he heard the tinkling of girdle-pendants from within the walls, and a strange and rare immortal fragrance drifted out. Two pairs of attendants came bearing candles, and behind them descended the Ten Kings of the Underworld, coming down the steps to meet him — the Ten Kings of the Ages, namely: King Qinguang, King Chujiang, King Songdi, King Wuguan, King Yama, King Pingdeng, King Taishan, King Dushi, King Biancheng, and King Zhuanlun. The Ten Kings came forth from the Treasure Hall of Endless Shadows, bowing low with arched backs to welcome Taizong. Taizong, in humility, dared not go forward. The Ten Kings said, "Your Majesty is a king of men in the world of light; we are ghost-kings of the world of shadow. Such is the proper order of things — why need you yield so much?" Taizong said, "I have given offense at your court — how should I dare to argue the ways of light and shadow, of men and ghosts?" And he deferred without end. At last he went forward, entered the Hall of Endless Shadows, exchanged courtesies with the Ten Kings, and they took their seats, host and guest in their proper places.

After a little while, King Qinguang clasped his hands and spoke: "The ghost-dragon of the Jing River accuses Your Majesty of promising to save him and then killing him instead. Why was this?" Taizong said, "I did indeed dream one night that the old dragon begged for rescue, and I truly granted that no harm should come to him. I did not expect that, having committed a crime that merited execution, he was to be beheaded by my human officer Wei Zheng. I had summoned Wei Zheng into the hall to play chess with me, and I did not know that in a single dream he carried out the beheading. This was the divine working of that human officer's

mysterious power, and likewise it was that the Dragon King had committed a crime that merited death — how can it be counted my fault?" When the Ten Kings heard this, they prostrated themselves in courtesy and said, "Even before that dragon was born, it was already recorded in the Register of Death of the Southern Dipper Star that he was fated to be slain at the hand of a human officer. We have long known it. But because he so stubbornly disputed the matter here, insisting that Your Majesty be brought to face the case before the Three Tribunals, we have already sent him into the Wheel of Transmigration to be reborn. Now we have troubled Your Majesty to descend to us — we beg you, forgive our fault in summoning you." This said, they ordered the Records Judge who held the Register of Life and Death to fetch the book at once and see how many years of earthly life and Heaven-allotted fortune Your Majesty should have. Judge Cui hurried back to the records office, took up the master register of the Heaven-allotted fortunes of all the kings of all the myriad nations, and examined it one by one. There he found that the Emperor Taizong of Great Tang, of the Southern Continent of Jambudvipa, was recorded as fated for thirteen years of the Zhenguan reign. Judge Cui gave a start, and quickly took up a thick brush dipped in heavy ink, added two strokes atop the character "one," and then presented the book. The Ten Kings looked it over from the top, and saw that beneath Taizong's name was recorded "thirty-three years." King Yama asked in surprise, "How many years has Your Majesty sat upon the throne?" Taizong said, "I came to the throne, and now it has been thirteen years." King Yama said, "Then set your heart at rest, Your Majesty, and have no worry — you still have twenty years of earthly life remaining. Now that this case has been clearly tried, we beg you to return to your roots and go back to the world of light." Hearing this, Taizong bowed and gave thanks. The Ten Kings of Yama dispatched two officers, Judge Cui and Grand Marshal Zhu, to escort Taizong back to life.

As Taizong left the Hall of Endless Shadows, he again raised his hands and asked the Ten Kings, "How fare the old and young of my palace?" The Ten Kings said, "All are well — but we fear the lifespan of the imperial sister may not be long." Taizong bowed once more and gave his thanks: "When I return to the world of light, I have nothing with which to repay you — only melons and fruit, that is all." The Ten Kings said happily, "Here we have plenty of winter-melons and watermelons — we lack only southern melons, the pumpkins." Taizong said, "When I return, I shall send them at once — I shall send them at once." And so, with bows of farewell, they parted.

Then the Grand Marshal took up a soul-leading banner and went ahead to guide the way, while Judge Cui followed behind escorting Taizong, and they went straight out of the dark offices. Taizong raised his eyes and looked — it was not the old road. He asked the judge, "Is this the wrong way?" The judge said, "It is not wrong. In the shadow realm it is just so: there is a way out, but no way back in. Now we escort Your Majesty so that you may issue forth from the Wheel of Transmigration. First, that Your Majesty may tour and behold the Region of the Dead; second, that Your Majesty may be carried over into rebirth." Taizong had no choice but to follow the two of them as they led the way forward.

When they had gone a few li, they suddenly saw a high mountain where dark clouds hung down to the ground and black mists blotted out the sky. Taizong said, "Master Cui, what mountain is that yonder?" The judge said, "It is the Mountain of the Dark and Dismal Shadow-Side." Taizong said in terror, "How shall I get across it?" The judge said, "Set your heart at ease, Your Majesty — we will lead you." Trembling, Taizong followed the two of them up through the mountain crags. Lifting his head to look, he saw:

Its shape all hollows and bumps, its slopes rugged and steep. Sharp as the ranges of Shu, high as the cliffs of Lu. No famous mountain of the world of light, but a perilous place of the shadow realm. In thicket upon thicket of brambles lurk ghosts and monsters; among the glittering stone crags hide demons and fiends. To the ear comes no cry of beast or bird; to the eye appear only the walking shapes of ghosts and goblins. The shadow-wind sighs and whistles; the black mist rolls and spreads. The shadow-wind sighs and whistles — it is the smoke piped from the mouths of spirit-soldiers; the black mist rolls and spreads — it is the breath spewed by ghosts in the dark. Look far, high and low, and there is no scenery; look about, left and right, and all is savage ruin. There are mountains here, and peaks, and ridges, and caves, and ravines — only the mountains grow no grass, the peaks pierce no sky, the ridges bear no travelers, the caves hold no clouds, the ravines run with no water. On the slopes

before are all goblins; below the ridges, all demons; the caves take in the wild ghosts; the ravine-bottoms hide the evil souls. Before the mountain and behind, the Ox-Heads and Horse-Faces clamor in confusion; half-hidden, half-concealed, the hungry ghosts and ruined souls weep to each other. The life-hastening judges hurry and bustle, passing on their summons-tickets; the soul-pursuing marshals shout and bellow, speeding their official documents. The swift-footed runners roll along like whirlwinds; the arresting officers swirl thick in the black mist.

Relying wholly on the judge's protection, Taizong crossed the Shadow Mountain.

Going onward, they passed through many more government offices, and at every one of them mournful cries rang in the ears and hideous monsters startled the heart. Taizong asked again, "What place is this?" The judge said, "These are the Eighteen Layers of Hell, behind the Shadow Mountain." Taizong said, "Which are the eighteen layers?" The judge said, "Listen, and I will tell you:

The Hell of the Hanging Sinews, the Hell of Dark Injustice, the Hell of the Fire-Pit — silent and forlorn, fretful and full of woe — these are all for the thousand kinds of evil done in life, whose punishments are reckoned and paid after death. The Hell of Fengdu, the Hell of the Tongue-Pulling, the Hell of the Flaying — weeping and wailing, wretched and grim — for the disloyal and unfilial who wounded the principles of Heaven, who had Buddha's mouth and a serpent's heart, and fell through this gate. The Hell of the Grinding, the Hell of the Pounding-Pestle, the Hell of the Crushing Cart — skin split and flesh torn, mouths wiped and teeth bared — for those who deceived their own hearts and dealt unjustly, who with clever words and flowery speech secretly ruined others. The Hell of the Freezing Ice, the Hell of the Shell-Stripping, the Hell of the Gut-Drawing — grime-faced and tangle-haired, brows knit and eyes wrinkled — these are all for the big measures and little scales

that cheated the foolish and dull, bringing calamity heaped upon their own heads. The Hell of the Oil-Cauldron, the Hell of the Utter Darkness, the Hell of the Mountain of Knives — quaking and shuddering, grieving and sorrowing — all because the violent oppressed the good and gentle; now they huddle and shrink their necks in bitter loneliness. The Hell of the Pool of Blood, the Avici Hell, the Hell of the Steelyard Beam — skin stripped and bones laid bare, arms broken and sinews snapped — these too are for those who plotted to seize wealth and took life, who butchered beasts and slaughtered the living; fallen for a thousand years, hard to release, sunk forever, never to turn back. Each one is bound fast and chained tight, wound about with cords and ropes. There are dispatched red-haired ghosts and black-faced ghosts with long spears and short swords; Ox-Head ghosts and Horse-Face ghosts with iron tablets and brazen mallets — beating them till their faces wrinkle in pain and the

blood streams down, calling on earth and heaven
with none to answer. Truly it is:

In life, then, let no one deceive his own heart; gods
and ghosts shine forth — whom do they let off?

Good and evil in the end are surely repaid; the only
question is whether it comes early or late."

When Taizong heard this, his heart was struck with horror.

Going on a little farther, he saw a band of ghost-soldiers, each bearing pennants and banners, who knelt by the roadside and said, "The Bridge Officers have come to receive you." The judge ordered them to rise, then led Taizong forward, and they crossed by way of a golden bridge. Taizong saw, off to one side, a silver bridge, upon which walked several men of loyalty, filial piety, virtue, and worth — fair, upright, and great-hearted people — who were likewise met and led across with pennants and banners. And over yonder was yet another bridge, where a cold wind rolled and waves of blood surged, and the sound of weeping and wailing never ceased. Taizong asked, "What is the name of that bridge?" The judge said, "Your Majesty, that is called the Bridge of No Recourse. When you return to the world of light, be sure to record it. Below that bridge are all these:

Rushing, surging waters; a perilous, narrow road. It looks like a bolt of silk laid across the long river, yet seems a fire-pit floating up to the world above. The shadow-vapor presses on you, cold through to the bone; the reeking wind strikes the nose, its stench boring to the heart. The waves roll and the billows churn, yet to and fro there is no ferryboat to carry men across; barefoot and tangle-haired, all who pass in and out are sin-laden ghosts. The bridge is several li long, but only three spans wide; a hundred feet high, yet a thousand layers deep. Above there is no handrail or balustrade; below there are vicious monsters who snatch at men. Bound in cangues and fetters, they are driven onto the perilous road of the Bridge of No Recourse. Look how fierce and brutal are the spirit-generals at the bridge's edge, how truly wretched are the sinful souls within the river. On the forking trees hang silken garments of green, red, yellow, and purple; crouched before the cliff-walls are the lewd, shrewish women who cursed

their husbands' parents. Brazen serpents and iron dogs feed on them at will; fallen forever into the River of No Recourse, with no way out."

A poem says:

At times the ghosts' weeping and the spirits' howling are heard; the muddy waves of blood-water rise ten thousand fathoms high. Countless Ox-Heads and Horse-Faces, ferocious and grim, stand guard at the Bridge of No Recourse.

While they spoke, the several Bridge Officers had already gone back. Taizong's heart was alarmed again; he nodded and sighed to himself, grieving silently. Following the judge and the marshal, they soon passed over the foul waters of the River of No Recourse and the bitter region of the Bowl of Blood. Then they came to the City of the Wrongfully Dead. There he heard nothing but an uproar of shouting voices, plainly crying: "Li Shimin has come! Li Shimin has come!" When Taizong heard the cries, his heart quailed and his courage shook. He saw a band of phantoms — some dragging their waists, some with broken arms, some with legs but no heads — who came forward to block his path, all crying out: "Give me back my life! Give me back my life!" Terrified, Taizong dodged and hid, calling only: "Master Cui, save me! Master Cui, save me!" The judge said, "Your Majesty, these are all the ghost-souls of the princes and chieftains of the sixty-four places of dust and tumult and the

seventy-two haunts of grass-bandits. They are all wrongfully dead, with no one to gather them and no one to keep them, unable to be reborn, and having no money or means for the road — all of them lonely, destitute, hungry ghosts. If Your Majesty will give them some money, I can save you." Taizong said, "I came here empty-handed — where am I to get any money?" The judge said, "Your Majesty, in the world of light there is a man who has deposited a great sum of gold and silver here in our shadow realm. Your Majesty may put your name to a bond, with this humble judge as guarantor, and borrow one storehouse of his to scatter among these hungry ghosts — then you may pass." Taizong asked, "Who is this man?" The judge said, "He is a man of Kaifeng prefecture in Henan, surnamed Xiang, named Liang. He has thirteen storehouses of gold and silver here. If Your Majesty borrows of his, you need only repay him when you reach the world of light." Taizong was glad to hear it, and willingly put his name to the loan. So he drew up a document with the judge, borrowed one storehouse of gold and silver, and bade the marshal scatter the whole of it. The judge then instructed the ghosts: "This gold and silver you may divide and use among yourselves, and let your Great Tang sovereign pass. His earthly span is still far from spent. I have received the Ten Kings' command to send him back to life, and to bid him hold, when he reaches the world of light, a Grand Mass of Land and Water to deliver you all into rebirth. Make no more trouble." When the ghosts heard this and had received the gold and silver, they all murmured assent and withdrew. The judge ordered the marshal to wave the soul-leading banner, and led Taizong out of the City of the Wrongfully Dead onto the broad level road, where they drifted and floated onward.

After going on for some time, they came at last to the place of the Six Paths of Transmigration. There Taizong saw those who rode the clouds, draped in rosy cloud-capes; those who had received the registers of ordination, with golden fish-tokens hung at their waists. Monks and

nuns, Taoists and laymen, running beasts and flying birds, goblins and demons — all of them, in a teeming flood, hastened down beneath the Wheel of Transmigration, each entering his own path. The Tang king asked, "What does this mean?" The judge said, "Your Majesty, with a clear mind perceiving your own nature, you must surely remember this and make it known to the people of the world of light. This is called the Six Paths of Transmigration: those who did good ascend and are transformed into the Path of the Immortals; the wholly loyal rise to be reborn into the Path of the Noble; the filial are reborn into the Path of Blessing; the fair and just return to be born again into the Path of Men; those who heaped up virtue are reborn into the Path of Wealth; the wicked and venomous sink down into the Path of Ghosts." Hearing this, the Tang king nodded and sighed:

How good, how truly good! Do good, and the fruit is free of disaster. Let the good heart be ever earnest; let the path of good be opened wide. Do not let evil thoughts arise, and you will surely have fewer crooked troubles. Say not that there is no requital — gods and ghosts have it all arranged.

The judge escorted the Tang king right up to the gate of the Path of the Noble Reborn, and bowing, called out to him: "Your Majesty, this is the place of emerging into the world. Your humble judge takes his leave and returns; let Grand Marshal Zhu escort you the rest of the way." The Tang king thanked him, saying, "I have troubled you, sir, to come so far." The judge said, "When Your Majesty reaches the world of light, be sure by all

means to hold a Grand Mass of Land and Water to deliver those masterless, wronged souls. Do not forget. If in the shadow realm there are no voices of grievance, then the world of light may enjoy the blessings of great peace. In every place where there is anything not good, let it be amended, point by point. Exhort all the people of the world to do good, and I warrant your posterity shall be long and unbroken, your realm and altars forever secure."

The Tang king assented to every word, took leave of Judge Cui, and went in through the gate together with Grand Marshal Zhu. Inside the gate the marshal saw a bay sea-horse, saddle and harness all in readiness, and hastily begged the Tang king to mount, supporting him on left and right. The horse went like an arrow, and soon they reached the bank of the Wei River. There on the surface of the water a pair of golden carp were turning the waves and leaping in play. The Tang king, seeing them, was delighted at heart, and reined in his horse to gaze, unwilling to part with the sight. The marshal said, "Your Majesty, hasten on a little; let us make speed and reach the city in good time." But the Tang king kept on gazing, unwilling to go forward. Then the marshal seized him by the feet and cried aloud, "Why won't you go? What are you waiting for?" — and with a splash thrust him down off the horse into the Wei River. And so he slipped free of the shadow realm and returned straight to the world of light.

Now we tell how the ministers of the Tang court — Xu Maogong, Qin Shubao, Hu Jingde, Duan Zhixuan, Ma Sanbao, Cheng Yaojin, Gao Shilian, Li Shiji, Fang Xuanling, Du Ruhui, Xiao Yu, Fu Yi, Zhang Daoyuan, Zhang Shiheng, Wang Gui, and the rest, both files of civil and military officers — were guarding the Crown Prince of the Eastern Palace together with the Empress, the imperial consorts, the palace maidens, and the chief attendants, all keeping mourning in the Hall of the White

Tiger. On the one hand they discussed issuing the proclamation of mourning to make it known throughout the empire, intending to set the Crown Prince upon the throne. At that moment Wei Zheng was standing by, and he said, "My lords, hold a moment — it must not be, it must not be. If we alarm the prefectures and counties, I fear something unforeseen may arise. Let us wait and watch one more day; my sovereign will surely return to life." Then up stepped Xu Jingzong from below, who said, "Prime Minister Wei speaks most absurdly. Since ancient times it is said: 'Spilt water cannot be gathered up; the dead do not return.' How can you still utter such empty words, confusing men's hearts? What sense is there in it?" Wei Zheng said, "To tell you the truth, Master Xu, from my youth I was instructed in the immortals' arts, and my reckoning is most clear. I warrant His Majesty will not die."

While they were still speaking, they suddenly heard from within the coffin a loud, repeated cry: "You're drowning me! You're drowning me!" It so frightened the civil officers and military officials that their hearts were thrown into confusion, and the Empress and consorts trembled in terror. Every one of them:

Faces like the yellow mulberry leaves after autumn,
waists like the tender willow withes before spring.
The heir-apparent's legs went weak — he could
scarcely lean on the mourning-staff to complete the
rites of grief; the chief attendants' souls flew off —
how could they don the ridged caps and keep the
filial ceremony? The consorts stumbled and fell, the
colorfully dressed maids tottered and swayed. The
consorts stumbled and fell, like wild wind blowing
down the withered lotus; the maids tottered and
swayed, like a sudden rain beating crooked the
delicate lotus-buds. The ministers were struck with
dread, their bones soft and their sinews numb.
Quaking and shuddering, dumbstruck and tongue-
tied — the whole Hall of the White Tiger was like a
bridge with a broken beam; the mourning platform
was like a collapsed and ruined temple.

At that moment all the palace folk ran clean away, and who dared go near the bier to tend the coffin? It was thanks to the upright Xu Maogong, the principled Prime Minister Wei, the bold Qin Qiong, and the headlong,

fierce Jingde that they came forward to hold the coffin, calling out: "Your Majesty, if there is anything weighing on your heart, tell it to us — do not play the ghost and so terrify your kin." Wei Zheng said, "It is no playing the ghost — this is His Majesty come back to life. Quick, fetch tools." They pried open the coffin lid, and there indeed they saw Taizong sitting up inside, still crying: "I'm drowned! Who will save me and pull me out?" Maogong and the others came forward and raised him up, saying, "Your Majesty, compose yourself; do not be afraid. We are all here to guard Your Majesty." Only then did the Tang king open his eyes and say, "What bitter straits I have just been through: barely escaping the wicked ghosts' torments in the shadow realm, then meeting with the calamity of losing my life upon the water." The ministers said, "Set your heart at ease, Your Majesty, and have no fear — what flood-calamity could there be?" The Tang king said, "I was riding my horse, going along, and had just reached the bank of the Wei River, where I saw twin fish at play. Then Grand Marshal Zhu, with deceitful heart, thrust me down from my horse, and I fell into the river and was all but drowned." Wei Zheng said, "Your Majesty's ghost-vapor is not yet dispelled." He hurriedly bade the Imperial Medical Academy bring soul-soothing, spirit-settling decoctions and medicines, and had gruel and food prepared besides. After taking them once or twice, the Emperor at last returned to his roots and recovered his true self, and came to know human affairs once more. Reckoning it up, the Tang king had been dead three days and nights, and now had come back to the world of light to be sovereign. There is a poem as proof:

Through all the ages the rivers and hills have changed how many times; through the generations the tallies of failure and success have run. Zhou and Qin, Han and Jin had many marvelous matters — but who, like the Tang king, died and came to life again?

That day the sky had already grown dark, and the ministers begged the king to retire to rest, and each dispersed.

Early the next morning, they doffed their mourning garments and changed into colored robes — every one in red gown and black cap, every one with purple sash and golden seal — and waited outside the gate of the court for the summons.

Now we tell how Taizong, since taking the soul-soothing, spirit-settling potions and drinking gruel-broth several times, had been helped by the ministers into his bedchamber, where he slept soundly through the night, nourishing his vital spirit, and did not rise until daybreak. Then he shook out his majestic dignity. See how he was arrayed:

He wore a Heaven-piercing crown, and a robe of reddish-ochre yellow. He bound on a belt of green Lantian jade, and trod a pair of "Founding-the-Realm, Free-of-Care" shoes. Stately of countenance, surpassing the courts of old; awesome and fierce, renewing the glory of this day. What a fine, fair, and well-governed Great Tang king — the Emperor Li, dead and brought back to life again!

The Tang king went up to the Golden Chimes Treasure Hall and assembled both files of civil and military officers. When the cries of "Long live the King!" were done, they took their ranks by grade. Then was heard the imperial command proclaimed: "Let any who have business come forth from the ranks and report; those with no business, the court is dismissed." From the eastern wing stepped forth Xu Maogong, Wei Zheng, Wang Gui, Du Ruhui, Fang Xuanling, Yuan Tiangang, Li Chunfeng, Xu Jingzong, and others; from the western wing stepped forth Yin Kaishan, Liu Hongji, Ma Sanbao, Duan Zhixuan, Cheng Yaojin, Qin Shubao, Hu Jingde, Xue Rengui, and others. Together they came forward, and before the white-jade steps they bowed low and reported: "How is it that Your Majesty, after a former dream, took so long to awaken?" Taizong said, "Some days ago, after I received Wei Zheng's letter, I felt my soul go out from the hall, and saw the Imperial Forest Guard begging me to come out hunting. As I was riding along, men and horses vanished without a trace, and then I saw my late royal father and my late brothers quarreling and clamoring. Just when I could not resolve

it, I saw a man in a black cap and dark gown — it was Judge Cui Jue — who bellowed my late brothers back. I handed Wei Zheng's letter to him. As he was reading, I again saw a blue-robed one bearing pennants and banners, who led me within, to the Hall of Endless Shadows, where I sat in converse with the Ten Kings of the Ages. They spoke of how the Jing River dragon had falsely accused me of promising to save him and then killing him instead, and I laid out the whole prior matter to them. They said the case had already been tried before the Three Tribunals, and quickly ordered the Register of Life and Death brought, to examine my earthly span. Then Judge Cui handed up the register, and when King Yama had looked at it, he said I had thirty-three years of Heaven-allotted fortune, of which thirteen had passed, so that twenty years of earthly life were still owed me. At once he had Grand Marshal Zhu and Judge Cui escort me back. I took leave of the Ten Kings, and promised to send them melons and fruit in thanks for their grace. After I came out of the Hall of Endless Shadows, I saw in the shadow realm the disloyal and unfilial, the unmannerly and unjust, those who wasted the five grains, who cheated openly and deceived in secret, who used big measures and little scales — the lewd, the thievish, the false and treacherous — suffering the tortures of grinding, burning, pounding, and chopping, the punishments of searing, scorching, hanging, and flaying — thousands upon thousands of them, more than the eye could take in. Then I passed through the City of the Wrongfully Dead, where there were countless wronged souls: all the grass-bandits of the sixty-four places of dust and tumult and the souls of the rebels of the seventy-two haunts, who blocked my homeward road. Luckily Judge Cui stood guarantor, and I borrowed one storehouse of gold and silver from old Xiang of Henan, bought off the ghost-souls, and only so was able to go on. Judge Cui charged me that, on returning to the world of light, I should by all means hold a Grand Mass of Land and Water to deliver those masterless, lonely souls — these words he urged

on me again and again. After parting and coming out from beneath the Six Paths of Transmigration, Grand Marshal Zhu begged me to mount, and we went, as if flying, to the bank of the Wei River, where I saw twin-headed fish at play. Just as I was delighting in the sight, he seized me by the feet and thrust me down into the water — and so I was able to return to life." When the ministers heard these words, there was not one who did not offer congratulations. And so it was set down and proclaimed throughout the empire, and the officials of every prefecture and county sent up memorials of felicitation — but of this we will say no more.

Now we tell how Taizong further issued a decree pardoning the criminals of the empire. He also reviewed the grave offenders in the prisons. At that time the presiding officers, having examined the prisoners of the Board of Punishments condemned to strangling or beheading, found upward of four hundred names and presented them. Taizong released them all and pardoned them to go home — to take leave of their parents and brothers, to entrust their property to their kin, sons, and nephews — and on this same day the next year to come to the courts and there receive the punishment they had earned. The prisoners gave thanks for the grace and withdrew. He also issued a proclamation of relief for orphans. And he reviewed the palace women, old and young, of whom there were three thousand in all, and issued an order to match them in marriage with the soldiery. From this time, within the palace and without, all was good. There is a poem as proof:

The great Tang king's grace and virtue were vast; his Way surpassed Yao and Shun, and the myriad people flourished. Four hundred condemned to death all left their cells; three thousand resentful women were released from the palace. The many officials of the empire wished him long life; the assembled ministers of the court hailed him as the Primal Dragon. One single thought of a good heart, and Heaven sent its blessing — and the shelter of that fortune was to pass down through seventeen reigns.

When Taizong had thus released the palace women and freed the death-row prisoners, he issued besides a proclamation of his own composing, spread throughout the empire. The proclamation said:

Heaven and earth are vast; the sun and moon shine
and judge with clearness. The universe is broad;
Heaven and earth will not harbor the wicked clique.
Scheme with cunning and tricks, and the retribution
falls within this very life; spread shallow goodness
and beg for little, and you gain blessing — speak
not of the world to come. A thousand clever plots
are not as good as being a man within one's lot; ten
thousand kinds of violent men are no match for
following circumstance and living thriftily. Let the
heart act in mercy and goodness — what need to
labor over reading the scriptures? But if the mind
would harm others, then in vain has one read the
whole Tripitaka of the Buddha!

From this time, under all of Heaven there was not one person who did not strive to do good. On the one hand, he issued a proclamation calling for worthies, summoning someone to bear melons and fruit into the shadow realm; on the other, he took one storehouse of gold and silver from the treasure-store and dispatched Yuchi Gong and Hu Jingde to Kaifeng prefecture in Henan, to seek out Xiang Liang and repay the debt.

The proclamation had been posted several days when there came a worthy man willing to undertake the bearing of melons and fruit. He was a native of Junzhou, surnamed Liu, named Quan, and his household had a fortune of ten thousand strings of cash. It happened that his wife, Li Cuilian, had drawn the golden hairpin from her hair at the gateway to give alms to a monk, and Liu Quan had cursed her for it, saying she did not keep the way of a wife, presuming to step beyond the women's quarters. Unable to bear the shame of it, Lady Li hanged herself and died, leaving behind a young son and daughter who wept day and night. Liu Quan could not bear to look upon it, and at his wits' end, he resolved to give up his own life — abandoning his household estate, leaving his children behind — and willingly, by his own death, to bear the melons. He tore down the imperial proclamation and came before the Tang king. The king issued his command, bidding him go to the Golden Pavilion Lodge, to balance a pair of southern melons upon his head, to carry paper money in his sleeve, and to hold medicine in his mouth.

Liu Quan swallowed the poison and died. His single soul, bearing the melons and fruit upon his head, soon arrived at the Gate of Ghosts. The ghost-courier who kept the gate bellowed, "What man are you, daring to come to this place?" Liu Quan said, "I come on the imperial commission of the Great Tang Emperor Taizong, sent expressly to present melons and fruit for the enjoyment of the Ten Kings of the Ages." The ghost-courier gladly received him and led him in. Liu Quan went straight to the Treasure Hall of Endless Shadows, and seeing King Yama, presented the melons and fruit, saying, "By the command of the Tang king, I have borne melons and fruit from afar, to thank the Ten Kings for the grace of their leniency." King Yama was greatly pleased, and said, "What a faithful and virtuous emperor is Taizong!" And so he accepted the melons and fruit. Then he asked the melon-bearer's name and what region he came from. Liu Quan said, "Your humble servant is registered among the people of

Junzhou city. My surname is Liu, my name is Quan. Because my wife, Lady Li, hanged herself and left behind our children with no one to tend them, your servant willingly gave up his home and forsook his sons, offering up his body to repay his country, and came expressly to present melons and fruit at my king's order, to thank you great kings for your bounteous grace." When the Ten Kings heard this, they ordered the case of Liu Quan's wife, Lady Li, to be looked into. The ghost-courier swiftly brought her to the foot of the Hall of Endless Shadows, and there husband and wife — Liu Quan and Lady Li — were reunited. When they had told over the former matters between them, they turned and gave thanks to the Ten Kings for the grace of their pardon. Then King Yama, examining the Register of Life and Death, found that this husband and wife both had the lifespan of those destined to become immortals, and quickly dispatched a ghost-courier to send them back. The ghost-courier reported, "Li Cuilian has been long in the shadow realm, and her body no longer exists — to what shall her soul attach itself?" King Yama said, "The Tang emperor's imperial sister, Li Yuying, is fated to die just now; you may borrow her body, and let Lady Li return to life by means of it." The ghost-courier received the command, and at once brought Liu Quan and his wife back toward life, and together they went forth out of the shadow realm.

In the end we do not yet know how the husband and wife returned to life — so listen to the explanation in the next chapter.

Chapter 12: The Borrowed Body and the Bodhisattva's Sign

Now, the ghostly envoy led Liu Quan and his wife out of the realm of shades, and a cold, swirling wind carried them straight to the great

capital of Chang'an. There the envoy thrust Liu Quan's soul into the golden pavilion of the courier station, while he bore Cuilian's soul into the inner courts of the imperial palace. It happened that the Princess Yuying was just then walking beneath the shade of the flowering trees, stepping slowly across the green moss, when the envoy rushed straight into her and knocked her sprawling to the ground. He seized her living soul and pressed Cuilian's soul into Yuying's body. Then the envoy turned back to the underworld — but of that no more need be said.

Meanwhile the waiting-maids of the court, great and small, saw that Yuying had fallen dead, and ran in haste to the golden throne hall to report to the empresses of the three palaces: "The princess has fallen dead!" The empresses were aghast and sent word at once to Emperor Taizong. When the emperor heard, he nodded and sighed: "So it is true after all. I once asked the Kings of the Ten Courts of Hell, 'Are the old and young of my house safe?' And they answered, 'All are safe, save that we fear the emperor's sister has but a short span left.' Their words have come to pass."

All the household came weeping, and they hurried to the shade of the flowers to look — and behold, the princess still breathed faintly. The Tang emperor said, "Do not weep! Do not weep! You will startle her." He came forward, lifted her head with his own royal hand, and called, "Sister, wake! Wake!" The princess suddenly rolled over and cried, "Husband, walk slower — wait for me!" Taizong said, "Sister, it is we who are here." The princess raised her head, opened her eyes, looked about, and demanded, "Who are you, that you dare lay hands on me?" Taizong said, "I am your royal brother, and this your royal sister-in-law." The princess said, "Where would I get a royal brother or a royal sister-in-law? My maiden family is surnamed Li, and my childhood name was Li Cuilian. My husband is surnamed Liu, named Quan, and we are both folk

of Junzhou. Three months ago I drew the gold pin from my hair to give alms to a monk at our gate. My husband blamed me for stepping unbidden past the inner door and breaking the rules of a wife. He scolded me with sharp words, and my breast filled with such rage that I hung a white silk sash from the beam and strangled myself, leaving behind a son and a daughter to weep day and night. Now, because my husband was sent by the Tang emperor to carry melons and fruit to the underworld, the King of Hell took pity and released us both to return. He walked ahead, and because I came late and could not catch him up, I stumbled and fell. You people are rude! You do not even know my name — how dare you seize me?"

When Taizong heard this, he said to the assembled household, "It seems my sister was stunned by the fall and is babbling nonsense." He commanded the Imperial Academy of Medicine to bring potions, and Yuying was helped into the palace.

The Tang emperor sat in his hall when suddenly the officer on duty announced, "Your Majesty, the man Liu Quan who carried the melons and fruit has returned to life, and now waits outside the palace gate for your command." The Tang emperor was astonished and quickly ordered Liu Quan summoned in. The man prostrated himself before the vermilion steps. Taizong asked, "How fared the matter of the melons and fruit?" Liu Quan said, "Your servant bore the melons and fruit straight to the Gate of Ghosts, was led up to the Hall of Judgment, and there beheld the Kings of the Ten Courts of Hell. I presented the offering and conveyed in full my king's earnest gratitude. The Kings were greatly pleased and bowed many times to honor my king, saying, 'Truly Taizong is an emperor of faith and virtue!'" The Tang emperor said, "And what did you see in the underworld?" Liu Quan said, "Your servant did not travel far and saw little. I only heard the King of Hell ask my native place and

my name. I told him how I had abandoned home and children because my wife had hanged herself, and how I had volunteered to carry the melons. He swiftly dispatched a ghostly envoy who brought my wife, and we met below the Hall of Judgment. Then they examined the Registers of Life and Death, declared that we both still had the span of immortals before us, and sent us back by the envoy. I walked ahead, my wife behind, and by good fortune I have returned to life. But I do not know into what place my wife has gone." The Tang emperor asked with alarm, "Did the King of Hell say anything about your wife?" Liu Quan said, "The King said nothing, but I heard the envoy say, 'Li Cuilian has long been among the dead; her corpse no longer survives.' And the King said, 'The Tang emperor's sister, Li Yuying, is fated to die soon — let Cuilian borrow Yuying's body and return to life that way.' I do not know where this Tang emperor's sister lives, nor in what house, and I have not yet been able to go seek her out."

When the Tang emperor heard this report, his heart was filled with joy, and he said to his many officials, "When I took my leave of the King of Hell, I asked after the affairs of my palace. He said, 'The old and young are all safe, save that we fear the emperor's sister has but a short span.' And indeed, just now my sister Yuying fell dead beneath the flowering trees. I hurried to lift her, and in a little while she revived, crying, 'Husband, walk slower — wait for me!' I took it for the babble of one stunned by a fall. But when I questioned her further, her words matched Liu Quan's exactly." Wei Zheng came forward and said, "If the emperor's sister chanced to come to the end of her span, and revived to speak such words, this is the matter of Liu Quan's wife borrowing a body to return to life. Such things do happen. Let the princess be brought out, that we may see what she has to say." The Tang emperor said, "I have just sent the Academy of Medicine to give her physic — I do not know how she fares." So he ordered the consorts to go into the palace and fetch her. But

the princess within was shouting wildly: "What medicine should I take? Whose house is this? My home has cool tiled roofs, not this jaundice-yellow chamber with its gaudy painted doors! Let me out! Let me out!"

While she was still shouting, four or five court women and two or three eunuchs came supporting her, all the way up into the hall. The Tang emperor said, "Do you recognize your husband?" Yuying said, "What kind of talk is that? The two of us have been wedded since childhood and have borne sons and daughters together — how could I not know him?" The Tang emperor ordered an attendant to help her down. The princess descended from the throne hall and went straight to the foot of the white jade steps. When she saw Liu Quan she seized him fast and cried, "Husband, where were you going, that you would not even wait for me? I stumbled and fell, and all those unreasonable people surrounded me and shouted — what is the meaning of this?" Liu Quan heard the very words of his wife from her lips, yet saw that the face was not his wife's face, and he dared not own the kinship.

The Tang emperor said: "Truly, when mountains crumble and the earth splits, someone may witness it — but to catch the living standing in for the dead is a thing hard to meet with." A king of true virtue indeed: he granted Liu Quan the whole of his sister's dowry — her garments, her jewels, her ornaments — exactly as a wedding portion. He also gave a royal decree exempting him forever from corvée and taxes, and bade him take the princess home. The two of them gave thanks for the grace at the foot of the steps and returned joyfully to their native place. There is a poem to prove it:

A man's life and a man's death are the bond of a former age; short or long, each has his appointed years. Liu Quan carried the melons and returned to the world of the living; Li Cuilian borrowed a body and her soul came home.

The two of them took their leave of the king and went straight to the city of Junzhou. They found their old estate and their children all well, and the couple spread the fame of good karma far and wide — but of this no more.

Now, of the storehouse of gold and silver: the general Yuchi Gong took it to Kaifeng prefecture in Henan to seek out one Xiang Liang. This Xiang Liang, it turned out, made his living selling water, and together with his wife, of the Zhang family, peddled black crockery and earthenware at their gate. Whatever small coins they earned, they kept only enough for their daily needs; the rest they spent on alms to monks, on buying paper gold and silver ingots, recording them to a treasury and burning them. And so this good fruit had ripened upon him: in the world of the living he was a poor man fond of doing good; in that other world he was a wealthy elder with heaped jade and piled gold. When Yuchi Gong brought the gold and silver to his door, it so frightened the old husband and wife that their souls flew out of them. With prefectural officials besides, and carriages and horses crowding outside their thatched hut, the old couple stood dumb and dazed as idiots, kneeling on the ground and doing nothing but knock their heads and bow.

Yuchi Gong said, "Old folk, please rise. Though I am an imperial envoy, I have brought my king's gold and silver to repay you." Trembling, the old man answered, "Your humble servant has no gold or silver out at interest. How should I dare receive this wealth of unclear origin?" Yuchi Gong said, "I have looked into it and learned you are a poor man — only that you gave alms to monks and spent all you had on it, and bought paper gold and silver ingots and burned them, recording them to the underworld. In the underworld there is the money you laid by. When our Emperor Taizong died for three days and then revived, he borrowed in the underworld a storehouse of your gold and silver, and now repays it to you to the last coin. Take it, every piece, so that I may go back and report." But the two of them only worshipped toward heaven and dared not receive it, saying, "If we humble folk took this gold and silver, we should die the sooner. True, we burned paper and recorded it to a treasury, but that is a matter of the dark unseen world. And besides — that His Majesty borrowed gold and silver in the other world, what proof is there of it? We dare by no means receive it." Yuchi Gong said, "His Majesty said the thing he borrowed of you is warranted by Judge Cui as surety. Take it." Xiang Liang said, "Even unto death we dare not receive it."

Seeing how bitterly they refused, Yuchi Gong had no choice but to draw up a memorial and send a man to report. When Taizong saw the memorial and learned that Xiang Liang would not take the gold and silver, he said, "This is truly a good and worthy elder." At once he decreed that Yuchi Gong should use the gold and silver to repair temples and raise a living shrine, and invite monks to do good works on Xiang Liang's behalf — counting it the same as repaying him. On the day the decree arrived, Yuchi Gong bowed toward the palace in thanks and proclaimed it, and all knew of the matter. So with the gold and silver he bought a parcel of ground within the city, unencumbered by soldier or commoner,

fifty mou broad on every side, and there set the work in motion. He raised up a temple and named it "The Imperially Founded Xiang Kingdom Temple," and at its left set the living shrine of the old man and his wife, with a carved tablet and an inscribed stone that read: "Built under the supervision of Yuchi Gong." This is the very temple now called the Great Xiang Kingdom Temple.

When the work was finished and reported, Taizong was greatly pleased. Then he gathered his many officials again, posted notices to summon monks, and ordered the building of a Great Mass of Land and Water to deliver the orphaned souls of the dark courts. The notices went out over all the realm, charging the officials of every region to choose virtuous high monks and send them up to Chang'an for the assembly. Within a month's span, monks from all under heaven had arrived. The Tang emperor decreed that the Grand Astrologer Fu Yi should select the high monks and undertake the Buddhist rites. But when Fu Yi heard the command, he at once submitted a memorial to stop the building of pagodas, arguing that there was no Buddha. His memorial read:

The teaching of the Western Lands knows neither prince and minister nor father and son; with its Three Paths and Six Ways it deludes the foolish. It chases after sins long past and peers after blessings yet to come; men mumble its Sanskrit syllables hoping to steal away from their due. Yet life and death, long span and short, are rooted in nature itself; punishment and virtue, awe and reward, belong to the lord of men. Now I hear the common herd lean on it idly, all saying it comes from the Buddha. From the Five Emperors and Three Kings there was no Buddha-law, yet rulers were enlightened and ministers loyal, and the years of the dynasties ran long. Not until Emperor Ming of the Han was the barbarian god first set up — and even then only the monks of the Western Lands

passed on their own teaching. In truth it is the barbarian encroaching upon the Middle Kingdom, and not worthy of belief.

When Taizong heard this, he cast the memorial down before his assembled ministers for debate. Then the chancellor Xiao Yu stepped from the ranks, bowed low, and submitted: "The Buddha-law has flourished through dynasty after dynasty; it spreads good and stems evil, secretly aiding the state — there is no reason to cast it aside. The Buddha is a sage. To be no sage and yet defy the law deserves a heavy punishment." Fu Yi disputed with Xiao Yu, saying, "Ritual is rooted in serving one's parents and one's prince; yet the Buddha turns his back on his parents and leaves home, sets a common man against the Son of Heaven, and as heir defies those who bore him. Xiao Yu was not born of a hollow mulberry, yet he follows a teaching that has no father — this is precisely what is meant by saying the unfilial have no parents." Xiao Yu only pressed his palms together and said, "Hell was established precisely for such men as this."

Taizong summoned the Grand Coachman Zhang Daoyuan and the Secretariat Director Zhang Shiheng, and asked them how the merit of Buddhist rites might answer. The two ministers replied, "The Buddha lies in purity, benevolence, and forbearance; the true fruit is the Buddha-emptiness. Emperor Wu of the Zhou ranked the Three Teachings in their order; the Chan master Dahui has praises that reach into the far and deep; through all the offerings of the multitudes none has gone unmanifested; the Fifth Patriarch entered the womb, Bodhidharma showed his form. From of old all have said the Three Teachings are most venerable and may not be defamed, may not be cast aside. We humbly beg Your Majesty's sagely discernment and clear judgment." Taizong was greatly pleased and said, "The words of my ministers accord with reason. Whoever speaks further against this shall be punished." So he charged

Wei Zheng, together with Xiao Yu and Zhang Daoyuan, to invite the various Buddhist monks and to choose one of great virtue and conduct to be master of the altar and set up the place of the Way. All bowed their heads in thanks and withdrew. From this time forth a law went out: whoever defamed monks or slandered the Buddha would have his arm struck off.

The next day the three court ministers gathered the monks together in the Altar of Mountains and Rivers, and one by one, from first to last, examined and chose them. Among them they selected one high monk of great virtue and conduct. And who do you think he was?

His spirit-pervading true title was once Golden Cicada, only because he listened heedlessly to the Buddha's preaching. Cast down to the dusty mortal world to suffer grinding pain, born into the common age to fall into the net of snares. Entering the womb and dropping to earth, he met with violence at once; before he was even born, he stood among wicked men. His father was Chen, top graduate of Haizhou; his grandfather a Commander-in-Chief, an elder of the reigning court. Born under a star of the fate of "falling into the river," he drifted with the current, tossed upon the waves. At Gold Mountain isle there lay a great affinity; the monk Qian'an took him in and reared him. At eighteen years he sought out his true mother, and made his way to the capital to seek his grandfather. The Commander opened the campaign and led the great army, at Hongzhou he wiped out the bandits and slew the wicked crew. Graduate Guangrui escaped the heavenly net; father and son, reunited, were

worthy of all joy and reward. He went again before the reigning lord and received his grace, and his worthy name rang out upon the Tower of Mist. Honored with office, he would not take it, but vowed to be a monk; at Hongfu temple he sought the Way among the sands. His small name was River-Float, the Old Buddha's child; his dharma name was called Chen Xuanzang.

That day they brought before the assembly the Dharma Master Xuanzang. This man had been a monk from his youth; from the moment he left his mother's womb he kept the fasts and held the precepts. His grandfather was Yin Kaishan, Commander-in-Chief of the reigning court; his father Chen Guangrui had been top graduate and was appointed Grand Academician of the Hall of Profound Letters. Yet Xuanzang's whole heart cared nothing for glory or splendor and delighted only in cultivating quietude and extinction. His origins were found to be good and his virtue lofty besides; in the thousand scriptures and ten thousand classics there was nothing he had not penetrated; of the Buddha's chants and the immortals' tones there was no kind he could not perform.

The three ministers led him before the throne, where he stirred the dust in obeisance and bowed low. When the formalities were done, they reported: "Your servants Xiao Yu and the rest, by Your Majesty's command, have chosen one high monk: Chen Xuanzang." When Taizong heard the name he pondered a long while, then said, "Could this be Xuanzang, the son of the Academician Chen Guangrui?" River-Float

knocked his forehead to the floor and said, "Your servant is indeed he." Taizong said with joy, "Truly the choice was not amiss. Here is a monk of virtue and conduct, of a Chan heart indeed. I bestow upon you the offices of Left Controller of Monks, Right Controller of Monks, and Grand Controller of Monks of all the realm." Xuanzang bowed his head in thanks and received the great offices of Controller. The emperor further granted him a five-colored cassock woven with gold and a Vairocana cap, and bade him bow again before the enlightened monks, arrange the order of the abbot's company, draw up the decree, and proceed to the Temple of Transformation-Birth, there to choose an auspicious day and propitious hour to begin the expounding of the scriptures.

Xuanzang bowed again, received the command, and went out. He came to the Temple of Transformation-Birth, gathered the many monks together, had Chan couches built, fitted out the appointments of merit, and set the music in order. He chose enlightened monks great and small, twelve hundred in all, and divided them among three halls — upper, middle, and lower. Before every image of the Buddha the ritual implements were complete, each thing in its proper sequence. They chose the third day of the ninth month of that year, an auspicious day of the zodiac, to open the Great Mass of Land and Water, to last seven times seven — forty-nine days. The matter was set down in a memorial and duly reported. Taizong, with his civil and military officials and the imperial kinsmen, all came to the assembly on the appointed day to offer incense and hear the preaching. There is a poem to prove it:

In the thirteenth year of Zhenguan the dragon gathers; the king proclaims to the multitude the discoursing of the scriptures. The place of the Way opens to expound the measureless Law; through cloud and mist the light bears up the great vow's shrine. By imperial command and grace the high temple is built; the Golden Cicada slips its shell to be transformed in the western sphere. Good fruit is spread abroad to lift up the sunken; upholding the teaching, it is proclaimed to all the generations, past and to come.

In the thirteenth year of Zhenguan, the year of jisi, the ninth month of jiaxu, on the third day, the auspicious hour of guimao, the Grand Controller Dharma Master Chen Xuanzang gathered twelve hundred high monks, all in the Temple of Transformation-Birth in the city of Chang'an, to begin expounding the various wondrous scriptures. The emperor, his morning audience concluded, led his many civil and military officials and, riding in phoenix carriage and dragon car, came forth from the golden throne hall and went straight to the temple to offer incense. And how was that imperial cortège? Truly it was thus:

A whole sky of auspicious vapor, ten thousand beams of blessed light. The kindly breeze drifts soft and light; the transforming sun shines with uncommon brightness. A thousand officials in their girdle-jades, ranked before and behind; the Five Guards with banners and standards arrayed on either side. They bear the golden melon-maces, lift the axes and halberds in pair upon pair; crimson gauze candles, the imperial censer's incense, in solemn order, hall upon hall. Dragons soaring, phoenixes dancing, ospreys commended, hawks aloft. The sage and enlightened Son of Heaven is upright; his loyal and righteous great ministers are good. Their blessing surpasses a thousand years of Shun and Yu; their peace outdoes ten thousand ages, rivaling Yao and Tang. And then are seen the bent-handle parasol and the rolling-dragon robe, their splendor shooting back and forth; the linked jade rings and the painted-phoenix fans, their blessed haze floating upon the air. Pearled crowns

and jade girdles, purple cords and golden seals. A thousand companies guard the carriage; two ranks flank the imperial chariot. This emperor, bathed and reverent, honors the Buddha; taking refuge in good fruit, he gladly offers incense.

The Tang emperor's great cortège soon reached the temple gate, and there he had the music and instruments stilled. He stepped down from his carriage, led his many officials, and worshipped the Buddha with offered incense. When the three circuits were done, he raised his head and looked, and truly it was a fine place of the Way. Behold:

Banners and streamers fluttering and dancing,
jeweled canopies winging with light. Banners and
streamers fluttering and dancing — against the void
they shake, ray after ray of colored cloud; jeweled
canopies winging with light — reflecting the sun,
fluttering, red lightning shoots clean through. The
World-Honored One's golden image is fair of face;
the arhats' jade visages are stern with might. Vases
set with immortal flowers, censers burning sandal
and aloeswood. Vases set with immortal flowers —
brocade trees gleaming, spreading over the jeweled
temple; censers burning sandal and aloeswood —
fragrant clouds in haze piercing the clear empyrean.
Fresh seasonal fruits heaped on vermilion plates,
strange shapes of sugar and pastry piled on painted
tables. The high monks ranked in rows chant the
true scriptures, vowing to pluck the orphaned souls
from their misery.

Taizong and his civil and military officials each offered incense, bowed to the Buddha's golden body, and paid homage to the arhats. Then they saw

the Grand Controller Dharma Master Chen Xuanzang lead the assembled monks in bowing low before the Tang emperor. The rites done, they divided into ranks and each took his Chan seat. The Dharma Master offered up the proclamation for the deliverance of the orphaned souls for Taizong to read. The proclamation said:

The utmost virtue is vast and dim; the Chan school is silence and extinction. Pure and spirit-pervading, it circulates through the Three Realms. With its thousand changes and ten thousand transformations it governs yin and yang. Its substance and function, true and constant, are without limit or end. Behold those orphaned souls — deeply do they merit pity and compassion. Now, by Taizong's sage command, we gather the various monks to practice Chan and preach the Law. We open wide the gate of expedient means, broadly ply the boat and oar of mercy, and universally save the host of beings in the sea of bitterness, freeing them from the lingering sickness of the Six Ways. We lead them back to the true road, that they may roam the boundless; in stillness and motion alike doing nothing, they merge into pure simplicity. By this good cause we invite them to feast at the cinnabar towers of the pure capital; riding upon our victorious assembly, they slip free of hell's mortal cage. Soon they shall ascend to the Land of Bliss to wander at ease, going and coming in the Western Region as they please.

And the poem said: One censer of incense of everlasting life; a few scrolls of the register that delivers from rebirth. The boundless wondrous Law is proclaimed; the limitless grace of heaven bathes us. Grudges and karmic burdens are wholly dissolved; the orphaned souls all come out of prison. May it keep safe our land and house, at peace and clear, with blessing ten-thousand-fold.

That night's evening scene we leave untold. Next morning the Dharma Master ascended his seat again, gathered the assembly, and chanted the scriptures — but of that no more.

Now, the Bodhisattva Guanshiyin of Potalaka Mountain in the Southern Sea had received the command of the Tathagata Buddha and was in the city of Chang'an, searching out a good man to fetch the scriptures. For many days she had met no one truly virtuous. Then suddenly she heard that Taizong was proclaiming good fruit, choosing high monks, and opening a great assembly. And she saw that the Dharma Master and altar-master was none other than the monk River-Float — the very son of the Buddha who had come down from the Land of Bliss, the very abbot whom she herself had once guided to enter the womb. The Bodhisattva was greatly pleased. She took up the treasures the Buddha had bestowed, carried them out into the long street, and set about selling them with Moksha. And what treasures were these? There was one rare and precious brocade cassock and a nine-ringed monk's staff. There were

also the three golden fillets — the Gold, the Tight, and the Forbidding — which she kept hidden close away to await later use. Only the cassock and the staff did she put up for sale.

In the city of Chang'an there was a foolish monk who had not been chosen for the assembly but who happened to have a few strings of country cash. Seeing the Bodhisattva transformed into a scabby, mange-ridden shape — body wrapped in a tattered robe, barefoot and bald-headed, holding the cassock fast, all aglow with brilliant light — he came forward and asked, "You scabby monk, how much do you ask for that cassock?" The Bodhisattva said, "The cassock is worth five thousand taels; the staff, two thousand taels." The foolish monk laughed: "These two scabby monks are madmen — idiots! Two coarse things like these, selling for seven thousand taels of silver? Unless putting them on made a man live forever and never grow old, or made him a Buddha or a patriarch on the spot, they would never be worth so much! Take them away — there is no sale here!"

The Bodhisattva did not argue but went on ahead with Moksha. After they had walked a good while they came before the Donghua Gate, and there they ran straight into the chancellor Xiao Yu, returning from the morning court, his outriders shouting to clear the street. The Bodhisattva, openly and without stepping aside, stood in the middle of the road holding the cassock and went straight up to meet the chancellor. Xiao Yu reined in his horse to look, and seeing the cassock glowing with brilliant light, he had his men ask the seller his price. The Bodhisattva said, "The cassock five thousand taels; the staff two thousand taels." Xiao Yu said, "What virtue has it, that it commands so high a price?" The Bodhisattva said, "This cassock has its good points and its bad points; there are times it costs money and times it costs nothing." Xiao Yu said, "What is its good, and what its bad?" The Bodhisattva said, "He who

wears my cassock will not sink into the round of death, will not fall into hell, will not meet with the harm of venom and malice, and will not encounter the calamity of tiger and wolf — that is its good. But the foolish monk who is greedy for lust and gladdened by misfortune, the monk who keeps no fast and holds no precept, the common man who defames the scriptures and slanders the Buddha — these can never look upon the face of my cassock. That is its bad." Xiao Yu asked again, "And how does it cost money, or cost nothing?" The Bodhisattva said, "He who does not follow the Buddha's Law, who does not revere the Three Treasures, and would force the purchase of cassock and staff — for him the price is fixed at seven thousand taels. That is when it costs money. But he who reveres the Three Treasures, who rejoices at the sight of goodness, who takes refuge in the Buddha — to such a one I am willing to give the cassock and staff freely, and forge a bond of good karma with him. That is when it costs nothing."

When Xiao Yu heard this, his face filled with springlike joy, for he knew at once that this was a good man. He dismounted and greeted the Bodhisattva with proper courtesy, saying, "Great Dharma Elder, forgive the offense of Xiao Yu! Our Tang emperor is exceedingly fond of doing good, and there is not an official in all the court who does not practice it. Just now he has begun the building of a Great Mass of Land and Water, and this cassock would be just the thing for the Grand Controller, Dharma Master Chen Xuanzang, to wear. Come — you and I into the court, to see His Majesty."

The Bodhisattva gladly consented, turned her steps, and went straight in at the Donghua Gate. The Gate Officer reported, and a command came summoning them to the throne hall. Seeing Xiao Yu lead in two scabby monks who stood below the steps, the Tang emperor asked, "What has Xiao Yu to report?" Xiao Yu prostrated himself before the steps and said,

"Your servant, coming out before the Donghua Gate, chanced upon two monks selling a cassock and a staff. Your servant thought the Dharma Master Xuanzang might wear this robe, and so brought the monks to your presence." Taizong was greatly pleased and asked the price of the cassock. The Bodhisattva and Moksha stood below the steps, offered no obeisance, and when asked the cassock's price, answered, "The cassock five thousand taels; the staff two thousand taels." Taizong said, "What good has the cassock, that it is worth so much?" The Bodhisattva said:

This cassock — let a dragon wear a single thread of it, and it escapes the calamity of being devoured by the roc; let a crane hang a single strand upon it, and it gains the wonder of passing beyond the common into the holy. Wherever its wearer sits, ten thousand spirits come to do him homage; in every motion, the Seven Buddhas attend his body. This cassock is spun from the drawn silk of the ice-silkworm, twisted into thread by a skilled craftsman, woven by immortal maidens, and completed on the loom of a goddess. Patch upon patch, the embroidered flowers are sewn; piece upon piece, brocade heaped upon brocade. Delicate and scattered, the blossoms vie in adornment; bright and shimmering, the light gushes forth in jeweled splendor. Put on, it wreathes the whole body in red mist; taken off, it flies away as a stretch of colored cloud. Beyond the Three Heavens' Gate it shines with primal light; before the Five Sacred Peaks it breeds a precious vapor. Layer on layer the Western lotuses are set in; gleaming and bright the pearls hang in the likeness of the stars and constellations. At its four corners are night-shining pearls; at its crown a single grandmother-emerald. Though it does not shine forth its whole original substance, still it bears the light-breeding cluster of eight treasures. This cassock, in idle times, is folded away; only when meeting a sage is it worn. Folded in idle times, its thousand layers wrap up and shine through the rainbow; worn at the meeting of a sage, it startles all the heavens, and gods and ghosts take

fright. Upon it are the wish-granting pearl, the mani pearl, the dust-repelling pearl, the wind-stilling pearl; and there are red agate, purple coral, night-shining pearls, and relic-beads. They steal the moon's whiteness and contend with the sun's redness. Strand upon strand, immortal vapor fills the sky; cluster upon cluster, blessed light upholds the holy. Strand upon strand, immortal vapor fills the sky and lights clean through the gate of heaven; cluster upon cluster, blessed light upholds the holy and casts its image over all the world. It lights the mountains and rivers, startling tiger and leopard; it shadows the sea-isles, stirring fish and dragon. Along its borders run two cords of inwrought gold; at its collar are linked rings of white jade.

And the poem said: Lofty and lofty the Three Treasures, the Way is to be honored; the Four Births and Six Ways are all weighed and judged. Clearing the heart, it knows how to nurture the law of men and gods; seeing the nature, it can pass on the lamp of wisdom. Guarding the body, majestic, in the golden world; body and mind made pure, like jade-pot ice. Ever since the Buddha first ordained the cassock, through ten thousand kalpas who has dared cut off the monkhood?

When the Tang emperor heard this, he at once had the cassock spread open and examined it closely from head to foot. Truly it was a fine thing.

He said, "Great Dharma Elder, I will not deceive you. I have now opened wide the teaching of goodness and broadly sown the field of blessing. In yonder Temple of Transformation-Birth many monks are gathered, expounding the scriptures and the Law. Among them is one of great virtue and conduct, whose dharma name is Xuanzang. I would buy these two treasures of yours to bestow upon him for his use. What price do you truly ask?" When the Bodhisattva heard this, she and Moksha pressed their palms together in homage, intoned the Buddha's name, and bowing low said, "Since there is one of such virtue and conduct, this poor monk is willing to give them to him, and will by no means take money." So saying, she turned to go. The Tang emperor quickly had Xiao Yu hold her back, and rising from his seat he asked, "You first said the cassock was five thousand taels and the staff two thousand. Now that you see me wish to buy them, you will take no money. Do you mean to suggest that I, leaning upon the position of my throne, would seize your goods by force? There is no such reason. I will repay you at your original price — you must not refuse and evade." The Bodhisattva raised her hands and said, "This poor monk made a vow beforehand: I said that if there were truly one who reveres the Three Treasures, who rejoices at the sight of goodness, who takes refuge in my Buddha, I would take no money, but give them gladly. Now I see that Your Majesty is of clear virtue and given to goodness, honoring my Buddha's gate; and moreover that the high monk is of virtue and conduct, proclaiming the great Law. By rights I should offer these things up freely; I will by no means take money. This poor monk is willing to leave them behind and take my leave." When the Tang emperor saw how earnest she was, he was greatly pleased. He at once ordered the Court of Imperial Entertainments to lay out a great vegetarian feast in thanks. But the Bodhisattva firmly declined to receive it, and went away contented, returning as before to hide herself in the local shrine of the city god — but of this no more.

Now Taizong held a noon audience and ordered Wei Zheng to bear a command summoning Xuanzang into court. The Dharma Master was just then gathering the assembly upon the altar, chanting scriptures and reciting verses, when he heard the summons. He at once came down from the altar, straightened his robes, and went with Wei Zheng to see the emperor. Taizong said, "I have troubled you, Dharma Master, in seeking the proof of good works, and have had nothing to repay you. This morning Xiao Yu met two monks who wished to give me a rare and precious brocade cassock and a nine-ringed staff. Now I have specially summoned you, Dharma Master, to take them for your use." Xuanzang knocked his head in thanks. Taizong said, "Dharma Master, if you do not disdain it, put it on and let me see." The Elder then shook out the cassock and draped it over his body, took the staff in his hand, and stood waiting before the steps. Prince and ministers, every one, were filled with delight. Truly he was a son of the Tathagata Buddha. Look at him:

Stern and majestic of countenance, refined and fair,
the Buddha-robe fits his body as though cut to
measure. Its radiant brilliance fills heaven and earth;
its woven colors in profusion gather up the cosmos.
Bright, bright the pearls ranged above and below;
layer on layer the gold threads run before and
behind. On all four sides the tula-down edges the
brocade; ten thousand rare wonders spread out in
figured silk. The eight treasures adorn the flowers,
bound with knotting threads; golden rings clasp the
collar, fastened with woolen loops. Buddhas of
heaven, great and small, ranged high and low; stars
and constellations, noble and humble, divided left
and right. Dharma Master Xuanzang has a great
affinity; this thing before him he is worthy to
receive. Wholly like a living arhat of the Land of
Bliss, surpassing the true awakened sages of the
West. The staff goes ringing, its nine rings vying;
the Vairocana cap shines forth, rich and full. Truly

he is a son of the Buddha — no false report; better than bodhi, with no deceit or error.

Then the civil and military officials before the steps shouted their applause. Taizong was beyond measure pleased, and at once had the Dharma Master don the cassock and take the precious staff. He further granted him two files of ceremonial attendants and ordered his many officials to escort him out of the palace gate, bidding him walk the great street in procession on his way back to the temple, exactly like a top graduate displaying his honors. At this Xuanzang bowed again in thanks and went down the great street in dazzling, thunderous splendor, swaying and stately. And in the city of Chang'an — merchants traveling and merchants in their shops, young lords and sons of kings, men of letters and men of ink, grown men and little women — there was not one who did not vie to look and to praise, all saying, "What a fine Dharma Master! Truly a living arhat come down, a living Bodhisattva descended to the mortal world!"

Xuanzang reached the temple, and the monks came down from their couches to meet him. As soon as they saw him wearing this cassock and holding this staff, they all said the King Kṣitigarbha had come, and each took refuge and waited upon him to left and right. Xuanzang went up into the hall, burned incense, and worshipped the Buddha. He spoke to the assembly, recounting the emperor's grace, and when that was done they each returned to their Chan seats. And again, before anyone knew it, the red wheel of the sun sank into the west. Truly it was:

The sun sets, mist veils grass and trees; in the imperial city the bells and drums first sound. Ding, ding, three strokes, and the people's walking stops; before and behind, the streets fall silent. In the high temple the lamps and fires blaze; the lonely village lies cold and soundless. The Chan monk enters meditation and tends the worn scriptures — just the time to refine away the demons and nurture the nature.

The days slipped through the fingers, and now came the seventh day, the chief assembly. Xuanzang again drew up a memorial inviting the Tang emperor to offer incense. By this time the fame of goodness filled all under heaven. Taizong at once arrayed his cortège and led the civil and military officials, the empresses and consorts and imperial kin, early to the temple. And the whole city, great and small, noble and humble, all came to hear the preaching.

Then the Bodhisattva said to Moksha, "Today is the chief assembly of Land and Water; one seven joined to seven sevens — it is enough. You and I will mingle in the crowd: first, to see what this assembly is like; second, to see whether the Golden Cicada's son has the blessing to wear my treasure; and third, to hear what gate of scripture-law he expounds." So the two of them went into the temple. Truly it was — with affinity one meets an old acquaintance; the Prajñā returns to its own place of the Way. Entering the temple to look, truly it was: a great realm of the

heavenly court, surpassing even the Sahā world, outdoing the Jeta Grove and Śrāvastī, no less than the noblest temple-ground. A strain of immortal music rang clear and loud, and the Buddha's name resounded in clamor.

The Bodhisattva went straight up to the side of the many-jeweled dais, and there indeed was the very likeness of the wise and enlightened Golden Cicada. The poem said:

Ten thousand phenomena clear and bright, without
a speck of dust; at the great rite Xuanzang sits upon
the high dais. The orphaned souls he delivers come
secretly in the dark; the lofty ones who hear the
Law come from the marketplace. Giving things as
the moment requires, his heart's road runs far;
bringing forth life at will, the Tripitaka's gate swings
open. Facing one another, he expounds the
measureless Law; old and young, every one, gives
way to joy of heart.

And again the poem said:

Roaming the Dharma-world, within the lecture hall,
he meets a knowing friend, not of the common sort.
They tell of the thousand, ten thousand things now
present; they speak of the many merits across the
dusty kalpas. The Dharma-clouds drift, unfurling
over the ranges of mountains; the teaching-net is
spread, filling the great void. Examining human life,
returning to the thought of goodness, in confusion
the rain of heaven falls in red blossoms.

The Dharma Master upon the dais chanted for a while from the *Scripture for Receiving Life and Delivering the Dead*, discoursed for a while upon the *Seal of Heavenly Treasure for Securing the Realm*, and proclaimed for a while the *Scroll Exhorting Cultivation and Merit*. Then the Bodhisattva drew near, struck the precious dais, and called out in a stern, loud voice: "You, monk! You only know how to discourse on the teaching of the Lesser Vehicle. Can you discourse on the Greater Vehicle?" When Xuanzang heard this, his heart was filled with joy. He turned and leapt down from the dais, raised his hands to the Bodhisattva, and said, "Old master, this disciple has been remiss — many are my faults. The assembled monks before us all preach the teaching of the Lesser Vehicle. I do not know how the teaching of the Greater Vehicle goes." The Bodhisattva said, "This Lesser Vehicle teaching of yours cannot deliver the dead to ascend on high; it can only let one drift along with the common dust. I have the Three Baskets of the Greater Vehicle Buddha-Law, which can deliver the

dead to ascend to heaven, can save the suffering from their misery, can cultivate a body of measureless life, and can make one neither come nor go."

While they were thus discoursing, the incense-officer who patrolled the hall reported in haste to the Tang emperor: "The Dharma Master was just discoursing on the wondrous Law when two scabby wandering monks pulled him down and are talking wild nonsense." The king ordered them seized. Many people pushed and crowded the two monks into the rear Hall of the Law. When they saw Taizong, the monks neither raised their hands nor bowed, but lifted their faces and said, "What does Your Majesty ask of us?" The Tang emperor recognized them and said, "Are you not the monks who gave me the cassock the other day?" The Bodhisattva said, "We are." Taizong said, "Since you came here to hear the preaching, you should have eaten a little of the vegetarian fare and let it be. Why did you talk wild with my Dharma Master, disturbing the scripture-hall and spoiling my Buddhist rites?" The Bodhisattva said, "Your Dharma Master preaches the teaching of the Lesser Vehicle, which cannot deliver the dead to ascend to heaven. I have the Three Baskets of the Greater Vehicle Buddha-Law, which can deliver the dead from suffering and grant a body of life that does not decay." Taizong's face brightened with solemn pleasure as he asked, "Where is this Greater Vehicle Buddha-Law of yours?" The Bodhisattva said, "It is in the Western Heaven, in the Country of India, at the Temple of the Great Thunderclap Sound, in the place of my Buddha the Tathagata. It can untie the knots of a hundred grievances and dispel calamities undeserved." Taizong said, "Can you remember it?" The Bodhisattva said, "I remember it." Taizong said in great joy, "Let the Dharma Master lead you up; I beg you to ascend the dais and expound it."

Then the Bodhisattva, taking Moksha with her, flew up onto the high dais, and treading upon blessed clouds rose straight to the ninth empyrean. There she revealed her true body — the Deliverer from Suffering, holding the pure vase and the willow sprig. On her left stood Moksha Huian, gripping his staff, his spirit fierce and rousing. This so delighted the Tang emperor that he worshipped toward heaven, and the civil and military officials all knelt to the ground and burned incense. Throughout the temple, monks and nuns, Daoists and laymen, scholars, craftsmen, and merchants — there was not one who did not bow and pray, "What a Bodhisattva! What a Bodhisattva!" There is a hymn of praise to prove it. Behold:

The auspicious haze scatters in profusion; blessed light guards the Law-body. In the ninth empyrean's flowery Milky Way appears the female sage. This Bodhisattva: upon her head she wears a fringe of hanging pearl-strings — gold-leaf clasps, kingfisher-flower spread, casting golden light, breeding blessed vapor; on her body she wears a pale-hued, lightly adorned robe of plain blue silk, with gold-coiled dragons and soaring painted phoenixes worked through the weave; before her breast hangs a fragrant set of ringing girdle-pendants, facing the bright moon, dancing in the clear wind, of mingled jewels and pearls, clustered emerald and jade; about her waist is bound an embroidered skirt of ice-silkworm silk, woven with gold edging, treading the colored clouds, hastening over the jasper sea. Before her she leads a yellow-feathered, red-billed white parrot that flies over the Eastern Ocean, roams the whole world, grateful for grace and practicing filial piety. In her hand she holds a precious vase that

gives grace and saves the world, and in the vase is set a willow sprig that sprinkles the blue empyrean, scatters great evils, and sweeps away the lingering mist. The jade rings thread the embroidered clasps; deep beneath her tread the golden lotuses. Through the Three Heavens she goes in and out at will. This indeed is Guanshiyin, who saves from suffering and rescues from disaster.

So delighted was Tang Taizong that he forgot his realm; so smitten were the civil and military officials that they neglected all court etiquette; and the assembled multitude chanted as one, "Namo Bodhisattva Guanshiyin!" Taizong at once issued a decree that a skilled painter should sketch the Bodhisattva's true likeness. The word was no sooner spoken than there was chosen one who could paint the divine and write the holy, of far sight and high skill — Wu Daozi, the very man who later painted the meritorious ministers on the Tower of Mist. At once he spread out his wondrous brush and painted the true form. The Bodhisattva's blessed cloud gradually drew off, and in a moment the golden light was gone. But there was seen, fluttering down out of mid-heaven, a single slip of paper on which were written a few lines of verse, clear and plain. The verse said:

We greet on high the lord of the Great Tang; in the West there is a wondrous text. The road is a hundred and eight thousand li; let the Greater Vehicle be earnestly sought. When this scripture returns to your land, it can deliver ghosts and lift them from the crowd. If there be one willing to go, he shall seek the true fruit and a body of gold.

When Taizong saw the verse, he at once commanded the monks: "For now, close the goodly assembly. Wait until I have sent someone to fetch the Greater Vehicle scriptures, and then, with renewed sincerity, we will cultivate the good fruit anew." Not an official but obeyed. Then, there in the temple, he asked, "Who is willing to take up my command, to go to the Western Heaven to worship the Buddha and seek the scriptures?" Before the words were out of his mouth, the Dharma Master stepped forth from the side, made obeisance before the emperor, and said, "This poor monk, though without talent, is willing to render the service of a dog or a horse, to seek the true scriptures for Your Majesty, and to pray that my king's realm be forever secure." The Tang emperor was overjoyed. He came forward and lifted him up with his own royal hand, saying, "Dharma Master, if you can indeed exhaust this loyalty, fearing neither the long road nor the toil of crossing mountains and rivers, I am willing to bow with you as sworn brothers." Xuanzang knocked his head to the ground in thanks. The Tang emperor was indeed a man of great worth and virtue: he went before the Buddha in the temple and bowed four times to Xuanzang, calling him "Imperial Younger Brother, the Holy

Monk." Xuanzang gave thanks without end and said, "Your Majesty, what virtue, what ability have I, that I should dare receive such heavenly grace? On this journey I am resolved to give my body to the utmost effort, going straight to the Western Heaven. If I do not reach the Western Heaven and obtain the true scriptures, then though I die, I will not dare return to my country, but will fall forever into the sinking hell." Then before the Buddha he offered incense and made this his vow. The Tang emperor was greatly pleased and at once ordered the cortège to return, to choose a fortunate, propitious day and hour, to issue the travel papers and set out — and so the imperial carriage went back and all dispersed.

Xuanzang too returned to Hongfu Temple. The many monks of that temple, together with several of his disciples, had already heard of the scripture-fetching errand, and all came to see him. They asked, "Is it true that you have vowed to go to the Western Heaven?" Xuanzang said, "It is true." His disciples said, "Master, we have often heard that the road to the Western Heaven is long, and that there are many tigers, leopards, and demons besides. We fear that you will go and not return, that your life can hardly be kept safe." Xuanzang said, "I have already made a great vow and a mighty oath: if I do not fetch the true scriptures, I will fall forever into the sinking hell. In the main, I have received the king's favor and grace, and cannot but exhaust my loyalty to repay my country. The outcome of this journey is truly vague and uncertain; good fortune and ill are hard to foretell." And he added, "Disciples, after I have gone — in two or three years, or in five or seven years — if you see the branch-tips of the pine within the mountain gate turn toward the east, then I am coming back; if not, then surely I shall not return." The disciples all engraved these words earnestly upon their hearts.

The next morning Taizong held court and gathered the civil and military officials. He had the scripture-fetching travel papers written out and stamped with the great seal of free passage. An official of the Bureau of Astronomy reported, "Today the stars are in their lucky station, fit for a man to set out upon a far road." The Tang emperor was greatly pleased. Then the Gate Officer reported, "The Imperial Younger Brother, the Dharma Master, waits outside the palace gate for your command." At once he was summoned to the throne hall, and the emperor said, "Imperial Brother, today is the lucky day to set forth. Here are the passage papers. I have also a purple-gold alms-bowl to give you, for begging your food along the way. And I have chosen two attendants for the long road, and a horse with reddish-white markings to bear you on your far journey. You may set out at once." Xuanzang was greatly pleased, gave his thanks, received the gifts, and showed no thought of lingering. The Tang emperor arrayed his cortège and, with his many officials, escorted him beyond the pass. There the monks of Hongfu Temple and his disciples were already waiting with Xuanzang's winter and summer clothing. When the Tang emperor saw this, he first had the baggage and horse put in order, and then had an official take up a flagon and pour the wine. Taizong raised the cup and asked, "What elegant title does the Imperial Brother go by?" Xuanzang said, "This poor monk is one who has left the household; I have not dared take a title." Taizong said, "The Bodhisattva said the Western Heaven holds scriptures in three baskets — the Tripitaka. Imperial Brother, you may take your title from the scriptures and be styled Tripitaka. How would that be?" Xuanzang gave thanks again, took the royal wine, and said, "Your Majesty, wine is the very first of a monk's prohibitions. Since I became a monk I have never drunk wine." Taizong said, "Today's journey is not like other matters; this is a plain, unfermented wine — drink only this one cup, that I may fulfill my wish of seeing you off." Tripitaka dared not refuse and took the cup.

Just as he was about to drink, he saw Taizong stoop, pinch up a bit of dust with his royal fingers, and flick it into the wine. Tripitaka did not understand his meaning. Taizong laughed and said, "Imperial Brother, on this journey, when you reach the Western Heaven, how long before you can return?" Tripitaka said, "In only three years I shall come straight back to my country." Taizong said, "The days are long and the years deep, the mountains far and the road distant. Imperial Brother, drink this wine: rather cherish a pinch of dust from your own homeland than love ten thousand taels of gold from another land." Then Tripitaka understood the meaning of the pinched dust, gave thanks once more, drank the cup dry, took his leave, and went out beyond the pass. And the Tang emperor's carriage turned back.

After all, no one knows how this going fared. Listen to the next chapter, and it shall be made clear.

Chapter 13: Into the Tiger's Pit, and the Mountain Lord's Aid

A poem says:

Great was the Tang king who sent the imperial decree, dispatching Xuanzang to seek the Chan truth's seed. With steadfast heart he chiseled toward the dragon's lair, with single mind he labored up toward Vulture Peak. Through borderlands and distant realms past counting, through cloud-wreathed ranges folded ten thousand deep — from this day forth he parts from court and turns toward the West, upholding the teaching, awakening to the Great Void.

Now we return to Tripitaka. On the thirteenth day of the ninth month of the thirteenth year of the Zhenguan reign — three days before the full moon — the Tang king and a host of officials had seen him off beyond the gates of Chang'an. For a day or two his horse never paused, and he soon arrived at the Temple of the Law Gate. The abbot of the temple and the senior monks led out more than five hundred of the brotherhood, who lined up in two ranks to receive him and brought him within, where they greeted one another and offered tea. After tea came a vegetarian meal, and before they knew it, evening had fallen. It was just as the verse describes:

Shadows stir as the River of Stars draws near; the moon shines bright, not a speck of dust to see. Wild geese cry across the far Milky Way, and washing-blocks ring rhythm from the western lane.

Returning birds roost in the withered trees, the Chan monks chant their Sanskrit melodies. Upon a single couch with cushion of rush they sit until the night has split toward dawn.

By lamplight the monks debated the settled purpose of the Buddha's gate, and the reasons for the journey to fetch the scriptures from the Western Heaven. Some said the waters were far and the mountains high; some spoke of roads thick with tigers and leopards; some warned of sheer ridges and steep cliffs impossible to cross; others, of venomous demons and vicious monsters hard to subdue. Tripitaka sealed his lips and said nothing — he only pointed with his finger to his own heart and nodded several times. The monks could not fathom his meaning, and pressing their palms together, they asked: "Master, why do you point to your heart and nod?"

Tripitaka answered: "When the heart is born, every kind of demon is born; when the heart is extinguished, every kind of demon is extinguished. I, your disciple, once vowed a mighty oath before the Buddha at the Temple of Transformation, and I cannot but exhaust this heart of mine. On this journey I am bound for the Western Heaven to behold the Buddha and seek the scriptures, that the Wheel of the Law

may turn once more, and that the imperial throne may stand secure forever." When the monks heard these words, every one of them admired him, and every one proclaimed his praise. They cried out together: "A loyal and true-hearted master of the great teaching!" Their praise was without end, and they invited him to his couch to rest.

Soon the bamboo struck the waning moon down, and the cock's crow raised the dawn-clouds. The monks rose to set out the tea and water and the morning meal. Xuanzang then donned his cassock, climbed to the main hall, and bowed before the Buddha, saying: "I, your disciple Chen Xuanzang, go to the Western Heaven to fetch the scriptures. But these eyes of flesh are dull and deluded, and I cannot recognize the true form of the living Buddha. Now I make this vow: that along the road, wherever I meet a temple I will burn incense, wherever I meet a Buddha I will bow, wherever I meet a pagoda I will sweep it. I pray only that our Buddha in his mercy may soon reveal his sixteen-foot golden body, and bestow the true scriptures to be handed down in the Eastern Land." His prayer finished, he returned to the abbot's quarters for the meal. When it was done, his two attendants prepared the saddle and horse and urged the journey onward. Tripitaka came out the mountain gate and bid the monks farewell. Unable to bear the parting, they walked with him fully ten miles before turning back, tears welling in their eyes. And Tripitaka pressed straight on toward the West.

It was the season of late autumn, and this is what met his eye:

In a few villages the leaves have fallen, reed-blossoms shattered; on scattered trees the maple and willow drop their crimson leaves. The road runs through smoke and rain, old friends grow scarce; the yellow chrysanthemum is lovely, the mountain's bones grow thin. The water turns cold, the lotus breaks, and men grow gaunt with care. White duckweed, red knotweed under a frost-white sky like snow; the sinking glow, a lone wild duck plunging down the endless air. Faint and somber the wild clouds fly, the swallows depart, the guest-geese come, their crying, crying, sob-broken cries that splinter through the night.

For several days master and servants traveled, until they came to the city of Gongzhou, where the assembled officials and townsfolk came out to welcome them in. They rested for a night, and early the next morning set out from the city again. Along the way they ate when hungry and drank when thirsty, lodging at night and walking at dawn. After two or three days they reached the garrison of Hezhou — the very border of the great Tang's mountains and rivers. The frontier commander and the local monks and Taoists, hearing that this was the imperial envoy and sworn brother of the emperor, a master bound westward to behold the Buddha,

all received him with reverence. They brought him in and provided for him, and the head of the monks invited him to lodge at the Fuyuan Temple. The temple's monks came one by one to pay their respects and arranged an evening meal. When it was done, Tripitaka instructed his two attendants to feed the horse well, for they would set out before daybreak.

When the cock had only just begun to crow, he roused his attendants — and this in turn startled the temple monks, who set about preparing tea and a meal. When it was eaten, they departed beyond the border. But the master's heart was anxious, and he had risen far too early. For it was now deep autumn, and the cocks crowed early; in truth it was no more than the fourth watch of the night. The three travelers, with the horse making four, set their faces against the clear frost and walked beneath the bright moon. After some tens of miles they came upon a mountain ridge, where they had to part the grass to seek the path — and words cannot tell how rough and hard the going was. Fearing they had strayed from the trail, they hesitated in doubt — and then suddenly their feet gave way, and all three men together with the horse tumbled down into a pit.

Tripitaka's heart leapt in terror; his attendants shook with fear. And while they were still trembling, they heard from within a roaring and howling, a voice that cried: "Bring them in! Bring them in!" Then a wild wind came rolling, and out swarmed fifty or sixty fiends, who seized Tripitaka and his attendants and dragged them up. The master, quaking and shivering, stole a glance — and the demon king seated above was monstrously fierce. Truly he was:

Majestic in his might, his body grave and grim,
savage in his temper, terrible in form. His lightning
eyes shot dazzling flame, his thunder-voice shook
all four quarters wide. His saw-teeth jutted past his
lips, his chisel-fangs bared along his jaws. Brocade
wrapped round his body, a striped pelt cloaked his
spine. His steel-stiff whiskers showed scarce a hint
of flesh, his hooked claws were keen as frost. The
Yellow Duke of the Eastern Sea would dread him —
the White-Browed King of the Southern Hills.

This drove Tripitaka's soul to flee his body and scatter, and left his two attendants limp in bone and slack in sinew. The demon king shouted the order to bind them, and all the fiends together lashed the three with ropes. They were just about to set them out and devour them when a clamor arose outside, and someone came to report: "Mountain Lord Xiong and Squire Te, the two of them, have arrived!"

Hearing this, Tripitaka raised his head and looked. The one walking in front was a black fellow. And what was his appearance? Hear it:

Bold and full of daring, nimble yet thick of frame.
Crossing water, sheer brute force; ranging the
woods, he flaunts his wrathful might. Long ago a
sign of auspicious dreams, today alone he shows his
hero's bearing. The green trees he can bend and
snap, he knows the cold and aptly tells the season.
Where his true spirit plainly shows, for this he
bears the name of Mountain Lord.

And then he saw the one coming behind — a stout fellow. And what was his appearance? Hear it:

Towering, with a crown of double horns, grave and
stately, his shoulders and back upraised. Quiet by
nature, robed in steady blue, his hoofed step often
slow and lingering. By his line his sire is called the
bullock, by his stock his dam is called the heifer.
Able to do the labor of the fields, for this he bears
the name of Squire Te.

These two came swaggering and swaying in, and the demon king rushed out in a fluster to greet them. Mountain Lord Xiong said: "General Yin,

you have been in fine form of late — congratulations, congratulations!" Squire Te said: "General Yin, your bearing surpasses the ordinary — how delightful, how delightful!" The demon king said: "And how have you two gentlemen been these past days?" The Mountain Lord said: "I merely keep to my simple ways." The Squire said: "I merely follow the times as they come." Their greetings done, each took a seat to talk and laugh.

Now the attendants, bound in agony, wept and wailed bitterly. The black fellow said: "Where did these three come from?" The demon king said: "They delivered themselves to my very door." The Squire laughed and said: "Might they serve to entertain your guests?" The demon king said: "I am honored to oblige, honored to oblige." The Mountain Lord said: "There is no need to use them all up. Eat two, and keep one back." The demon king assented, and at once called to his attendants on either side. They cut open the bellies of the two servants and dug out their hearts, hacking the corpses to pieces. The heads, hearts, and livers they offered to the two guests; the four limbs the demon king ate himself; and the rest of the bones and flesh he shared among the fiends. Nothing was heard but the sound of gnawing and gulping — truly like tigers devouring lambs — and in a moment all was consumed. The master was very nearly frightened to death. This was indeed the first trial of suffering since leaving Chang'an.

In the midst of their grief and terror, the east gradually grew pale. The two monsters did not disperse until daybreak, when they said: "Today we have imposed greatly upon you; another day we will repay your hospitality with all our hearts." Then they crowded out and withdrew.

Before long the red sun rose high. Tripitaka was in a daze, unable to tell east from west, north from south. Just as he hung between life and death, he suddenly saw an old man approaching, leaning on a staff. The old man walked up, gave a single sweep of his hand, and all the ropes fell

broken. He blew a breath upon Tripitaka's face, and the monk revived. Tripitaka knelt and bowed to the ground, saying: "Many thanks, venerable grandfather, for saving this poor monk's life." The old man returned the bow and said: "Rise. Have you lost anything?" Tripitaka said: "My attendants have already been devoured by the monsters. I only do not know where my baggage and my horse have gone." The old man pointed with his staff: "Yonder — is that not a horse and two bundles?" Tripitaka turned to look, and indeed they were his own things, nothing lost. Only then did his heart settle a little.

He asked the old man: "Venerable grandfather, what place is this? And how is it you come to be here?" The old man said: "This is Twin-Fork Ridge, a den of tigers and wolves. How did you come to fall into it?" Tripitaka said: "At cockcrow I set out beyond the Hezhou garrison. I did not expect to rise so early, and braving the frost and brushing the dew, I suddenly found myself in this place. I met a demon king, monstrously fierce, who bound me and my two attendants. Then came a black fellow who called himself Mountain Lord Xiong, and a stout fellow who called himself Squire Te. They came in and addressed the demon king as General Yin. The three of them ate my two attendants and did not disperse until daylight. I cannot imagine what great destiny and fortune I possess, that I should be blessed with your coming to save me."

The old man said: "The Squire is the spirit of a wild ox; the Mountain Lord is the spirit of a bear; General Yin is the spirit of an old tiger. The fiends on either side are all hill-sprites and tree-ghosts, monstrous beasts and gray wolves. It was only because your true nature is fundamentally bright that they could not eat you. Come with me, and I will set you on your road."

Tripitaka, overcome with gratitude, slung his bundles upon the horse, took the reins, and followed the old man straight out of the pit and up

onto the great road. He tethered the horse to a clump of grass beside the way and turned to bow his thanks to the venerable one — whereupon the old man changed into a gust of clear wind, mounted a white crane with a vermilion crest, and rose into the sky and away. From the wind there fluttered down a single slip of paper, on which were written four lines of verse:

I am the Great White Star of the Western Heaven,
come on purpose to save your living soul. Ahead
there will be holy disciples to aid you — do not, for
hardship's sake, resent the scripture-quest.

Tripitaka read it, then bowed toward heaven and said: "Many thanks, Venus, Star of Gold, for delivering me from this peril." His bow finished, he led the horse and pressed on alone — solitary and forlorn — bitterly forward. Upon that ridge, truly it was so:

Cold and gusting, the wind through the rain-soaked woods; murmuring and rushing, the water down the gorge. Fragrant and rich, the wildflowers in bloom; dense and heaped, the tumbled jumble of rocks. Clamoring and noisy, the deer and the apes; in troops and herds, the river-deer and roe. Loud and jangling, the many voices of birds; silent and still, no trace of human affairs. That master — trembling and quaking, his heart unquiet; this horse — feeble and faltering, its hooves hard to lift.

Tripitaka risked his life and pressed up into that steep ridge. He traveled half a day and still saw no wisp of cooking-smoke, no village, no cottage. For one thing his belly was empty; for another the road was uneven and treacherous. Just at this moment of crisis, he saw before him two fierce tigers roaring, and behind him several long snakes coiling. To his left swarmed venomous insects; to his right loomed monstrous beasts. Alone and helpless, Tripitaka could only let go of body and mind and resign himself to heaven's will. And to make matters worse, the horse went weak in the back and buckled at the hoof; it knelt down and lay flat upon the ground, and beat it as he might, it would not rise; pull it as he might, it would not move. The poor master had nowhere to turn — truly in the deepest distress, already counting himself as good as dead.

But though he was beset by calamity, rescue was at hand. Just as he hung between life and death, he suddenly saw the venomous insects scurry off, the monstrous beasts take flight, the fierce tigers slink away, and the long snakes vanish. Tripitaka raised his head and looked — and there was a man, a steel trident in his hand and a bow and arrows at his waist, coming around from before the mountain slope. Truly he was a fine, stout fellow. Look at him:

Upon his head a cap of mugwort-patterned, dappled leopard skin; on his body a robe of brocade woven from lamb's wool; round his waist a belt clasped with a lion's-mask buckle; on his feet a pair of boots of roe-deer hide. His ringed eyes were round and full, like a mourner come to call; his curling whiskers wild and tangled, like the constellation Kui. A pouch of poisoned arrows and bow he carried; a great pole-trident of pointed steel he gripped. His thunder-voice could shatter the gall of mountain vermin; his fierceness could blast the souls of the wild pheasants.

When Tripitaka saw him drawing near, he knelt by the roadside, pressed his palms together, and cried out loudly: "Great king, save my life! Great king, save my life!" The fellow came up, set down his steel trident, and

helped him to his feet, saying: "Master, do not be afraid. I am no villain. I am a hunter of these mountains; my surname is Liu and my name is Boqin, and my nickname is the Mountain-Guarding Defender. I came just now to seek a couple of mountain beasts for my food, and did not expect to meet you here. I have given you a fright." Tripitaka said: "I am a monk, the imperial envoy under the Tang court, going to the Western Heaven to worship the Buddha and seek the scriptures. Just now I came to this place and met with wolves, tigers, snakes, and insects that ringed me on all sides so that I could go no further. Suddenly I saw you, Defender — and all the beasts fled, and you saved my life. Many thanks, many thanks." Boqin said: "I live here and make my living by hunting these wolves and tigers, catching these snakes and insects to get by; that is why the beasts feared me and ran. Since you have come from the Tang court, you and I are countrymen. This is still the territory of the great Tang, and I too am a subject of Tang; you and I drink the same water and tread the same soil of our sovereign — we are truly people of one country. Do not be afraid; come with me, rest your horse at my dwelling, and tomorrow morning I will set you on your road." Hearing this, Tripitaka's heart filled with joy. He thanked Boqin, led his horse, and went along.

When they had passed the slope, they heard again a whistling of wind. Boqin said: "Master, do not move — stay here. Where the wind whistles, a mountain cat is coming. Let me catch it to take home and entertain you." Hearing this, Tripitaka was again terrified and dared not stir a step. The Defender gripped his steel trident, strode out, and went up to meet it. And there was a striped tiger that came face to face with him. Seeing Boqin, it quickly turned its head to flee. The Defender gave a thunderclap of a shout and barked: "Where do you go, you cursed beast!" The tiger, seeing the pursuit close upon it, wheeled round, swung its claws, and pounced. The Defender raised his three-pronged trident to meet it in

battle. The sight left Tripitaka collapsed and limp upon the grass — never since he came forth from his mother's belly had this monk witnessed so perilous a thing. The Defender and the tiger grappled there below the slope, man and beast locked together, and truly it was a fine fight. Behold:

Wrath upon wrath, wild wind upon wind. Wrath upon wrath — the Defender, hair bristling under his cap, full of brawn; wild wind upon wind — the striped beast, flaunting its force, spewing red dust. The one bares its fangs and flails its claws; the other shifts his step and turns his body. The three-pronged trident hoists to the sky and dazzles the sun; the thousand-flowered tail stirs the mist and sends the clouds aflight. The one stabs wildly at the chest; the other lunges forward to swallow him whole. Whoever dodges may live to tell of it; whoever is struck will surely meet King Yama. One hears the striped beast roar and howl; one hears the Defender's voice grow savage. The striped beast roars and howls, splitting the hills and rivers, startling the birds and beasts; the Defender's voice grows savage, shouting open the heavenly courts to reveal the stars. The one thrusts out his golden eyes in fury; the other summons his courage and breeds his rage. Lovable is Liu the Mountain-Guarding

Defender; praiseworthy is this lord of beasts who holds the ground. Man and tiger, each greedy for life, contend for victory — the least slack, and three souls are lost.

The two of them fought for the space of a full watch, until at last the tiger's claws went slack and its haunches loosened, and the Defender raised his trident and drove it level through its chest, throwing it down. Pitiful — the steel trident's point pierced clean through its heart and liver, and in a moment blood ran all over the ground. Seizing it by the ears, he dragged it up onto the road. A fine man — his breath unhurried, his color unchanged — he said to Tripitaka: "What luck, what luck! This mountain cat is enough to feed you for a day." Tripitaka praised him without end: "The Defender is truly a mountain god!" Boqin said: "What skill have I that I should merit such praise? This is the master's own great good fortune. Come along — let us hurry and skin it, cook some meat, and entertain you properly."

With one hand gripping the trident and the other dragging the tiger, he led the way ahead. Tripitaka led the horse and followed behind. Winding along over the slope, they suddenly came upon a mountain farmstead. Before its gate, truly it was:

Ancient trees reaching to the sky, wild vines sprawling across the path. In ten thousand ravines the wind and dust are cold; on a thousand cliffs the air and aspect are strange. One trail of wildflower fragrance steals upon the body; a few stalks of secluded bamboo, green and lush, lean close. A thatched gate-tower, a hedge-fenced yard — fit to be painted, fit to be sketched; a stone-slab bridge, white earthen walls — truly joyful, truly rare. The autumn face is bleak and bare, the bracing air lone and lofty. By the road the yellow leaves fall; over the ridge the white clouds drift. In the thin woods the mountain fowl chatter and squawk; outside the farm gate the slim hounds bay and yelp.

When Boqin reached the gate, he flung down the dead tiger and called: "Where are you lads?" Out came three or four household servants, all of monstrous and ugly aspect, who came forward and hauled and tugged the tiger inside. Boqin instructed them to skin it quickly and prepare it to entertain his guest. Then he turned back to welcome Tripitaka in; they greeted one another, and Tripitaka again bowed his thanks for Boqin's deep kindness and mercy in saving his life. Boqin said: "We are men of the same homeland — why trouble yourself with thanks?" When they

were seated and had finished their tea, an old dame appeared, leading a young wife, to pay their respects to Tripitaka. Boqin said: "This is my mother, and my humble wife." Tripitaka said: "Pray, let your honored mother take the seat of honor, and allow me to make my bows to her." The old dame said: "Master, you are a guest from afar — pray spare yourself; there is no need for bows." Boqin said: "Mother, he is under the Tang king's command, sent to the Western Heaven to behold the Buddha and seek the scriptures. Just now I met him upon the ridge-top, and thinking of him as a man of our own country, I invited him home to rest his horse; tomorrow I will set him on his road." Hearing this, the old dame was greatly pleased and said: "Good, good, good! Even had we wished to invite him, it could not have fallen out so well. Tomorrow is the anniversary of your father's death. Let us trouble the master to perform some good works and recite a scroll of scripture, and the day after we shall send him on his way." Now this Liu Boqin, though a slayer of tigers and the Defender who guarded the mountain, had a measure of filial devotion in him. Hearing his mother's words, he set about preparing incense and paper money, and kept Tripitaka there.

As they were talking, the day unknowingly drew toward evening. The servants set out tables and stools and brought up several platters of well-cooked tiger meat, steaming hot, and placed them on the table. Boqin invited Tripitaka to make do with it for now, and said he would prepare more food. Tripitaka pressed his palms together at his breast and said: "Mercy! I will not deceive you, Defender — from the time I came out of my mother's womb I have been a monk, and I have never once eaten meat." Hearing this, Boqin pondered a long while and said: "Master, for generations my household has never known how to prepare vegetarian fare. Even when we have a few bamboo shoots, or gather some wood-ear fungus, or find some dried vegetables, or make some bean curd — they are all fried in the fat of river-deer, deer, tiger, or leopard, and there is

nothing truly vegetarian about them. Even my two cooking-stoves are soaked through with grease. What is to be done? It is I who have wronged you by inviting you here." Tripitaka said: "Defender, do not trouble yourself overmuch — pray, enjoy your own meal. Even if I, a poor monk, go three or five days without eating, I can endure the hunger; only I dare not break my vow of abstinence." Boqin said: "But what if you should starve to death?" Tripitaka said: "By the Defender's heaven-sent grace I have been rescued from the den of tigers and wolves. Even to starve to death would be better than to be fed to the tigers."

Boqin's mother, hearing this, called out: "Son, do not waste idle words with the master. I have vegetarian things of my own that can serve to entertain him." Boqin said: "Where would vegetarian things come from?" His mother said: "Never you mind — I have my own." She bade the young wife take down the small pot and burn off its grease with fire; they scrubbed it and scrubbed it again, washed it and washed it again, then set it back upon the stove. First they boiled half a pot of water for another use. Then they took some mountain elm-leaves and steeped them in water to make a tea. After that they took some yellow millet and cooked it into rice, and boiled some dried vegetables until tender. They filled two bowls and brought them out and set them on the table. The old mother said to Tripitaka: "Master, please take your meal. This tea and rice my daughter-in-law and I have prepared with our own hands — perfectly clean and pure." Tripitaka came down from his seat and thanked them, then settled himself at the table.

Boqin laid out a separate place for himself, heaping bowls and platters with tiger meat, fragrant river-deer, python, fox, rabbit, and dried strips of minced venison — all without salt or sauce — to keep Tripitaka company at the meal. But just as he sat down and was about to lift his chopsticks, he saw Tripitaka press his palms together and begin to chant

a sutra. This so startled Boqin that he dared not move his chopsticks; he rose hastily and stood to one side. Tripitaka had chanted only a few lines when he bade Boqin take his meal. Boqin said: "So you are a monk who recites a short scripture?" Tripitaka said: "That was no scripture — it was a single scroll of grace before meat." Boqin said: "You who have left home certainly have many fine particulars — you must chant and chant even merely to eat a meal."

When the meal was finished and the bowls and platters cleared away, the day gradually grew late. Boqin led Tripitaka out of the central house and round to the rear for a stroll. Passing through a narrow lane, they came to a thatched pavilion. He pushed open the door and they went inside. On the four walls hung several strong bows and stiff crossbows, with quivers of arrows thrust among them; over the beams were draped two blood-reeking tiger hides; at the foot of the walls were ranged many spears, knives, tridents, and staves; and in the very center stood two seats. Boqin invited Tripitaka to sit a while. But finding the place so fierce and unclean, Tripitaka dared not linger, and so they came back out of the thatched pavilion. Walking further toward the rear, they came to a great garden, where chrysanthemums heaped up their gold without end, and the maple and willow hung clothed in crimson. Then, with a sudden rush, out bounded a dozen or so fat deer and a great herd of yellow river-deer, who, seeing the men, only blinked dully and showed no fear at all. Tripitaka said: "Are these river-deer and deer creatures the Defender has kept tame?" Boqin said: "Just as in your city of Chang'an the wealthy households hoard up treasure and the landed ones gather in grain, so we who hunt can only keep and raise some wild beasts, to provide against the days of foul weather." The two of them talked and strolled idly, and before they knew it dusk had fallen; they turned back to the front house to rest.

Early the next morning the whole household, old and young, rose and prepared a vegetarian feast to entertain the master, and asked him to begin reciting the scriptures. The master washed his hands, and together with the Defender lit incense before the family altar and bowed before it. Then Tripitaka struck the wooden fish, and first chanted the true words for purifying the karma of the mouth, then the spirit-charm for purifying body and mind, and after that opened a scroll of the Sutra for Delivering the Dead. When that was finished, Boqin asked him to write out a memorial for the departed soul, and then to open and chant the Diamond Sutra and the Guanyin Sutra, each recited aloud in a clear, carrying voice. When these were done they ate the midday meal, and then chanted the Lotus Sutra and the Amitabha Sutra, several scrolls of each, and a scroll of the Peacock Sutra, and discoursed on the story of the cleansing of karma — and again the day grew late. They offered up incense and burnt offerings of every kind, burned the paper horses for the spirits, and committed the memorial document to the flames. The Buddhist service complete, each retired to rest.

Now the soul of Boqin's father, delivered up out of the depths of perdition, came as a ghost to his own house and entrusted a dream to the whole family, old and young alike, saying: "In the underworld I suffered torments I could not escape, and for long days I could not be reborn. Now, by good fortune, the holy monk has chanted the scriptures and dissolved my sins; King Yama has dispatched men to send me to the rich land of China, to be reborn into a house of consequence. You must thank and see off the master well — do not be remiss, do not be remiss. I am going now." This indeed proved true: the myriad laws, in their solemn majesty, surely have their purpose — delivering the dead from suffering, lifting them out of perdition.

The whole family woke from their dreams just as the sun was rising in the east. Boqin's wife said: "Defender, last night I dreamed Father came home and said that in the underworld he had suffered torments he could not escape, and for long days could not be reborn. Now, by good fortune, the holy monk had chanted the scriptures and dissolved his sins; King Yama dispatched men to send him to the rich land of China, to be reborn into a house of consequence. He bade us thank the master well and not be remiss with him. Having spoken, he went straight out the door and drifted away. We called to him but he did not answer; we tried to hold him but could not. Then I woke, and it was a dream." Boqin said: "I too had just such a dream — the very same. Let us rise and tell Mother." The two of them were just about to go and tell her when the old mother called out: "Boqin my son, come here — I have something to say to you." The two came before her, and the old mother, sitting up on her bed, said: "Son, last night I had a happy dream. I dreamed your father came home and said that, all thanks to the master's deliverance, his sins were already dissolved, and he was bound for the rich land of China, to a house of consequence, to be reborn." Husband and wife both laughed aloud: "My wife and I both had this very dream, and were just coming to report it — and now Mother calls us, and it is the same dream as well." Then they called the whole household, young and old, to rise and arrange their thanks, and to ready the horse. They all came forward and bowed in gratitude, saying: "Many thanks to the master for delivering our departed father from suffering and lifting him to rebirth — our gratitude is beyond repaying." Tripitaka said: "What power have I, that you should trouble yourselves to thank me?"

Boqin recounted to Tripitaka the dreams of all three, and Tripitaka rejoiced with them. They had prepared a vegetarian meal early, and the family also offered a tael of silver in thanks. Tripitaka would not accept a single coin. The whole family pleaded with him most earnestly, but in

the end Tripitaka accepted nothing at all. He only said: "If you are willing to show mercy and see me on my way a short distance, I shall be deeply moved by your kindness." Boqin and his mother and wife, having no choice, hastily made some coarse-flour travel-cakes for provisions, and bade Boqin see him far along the road. Tripitaka gladly accepted them. The Defender, acting on his mother's command, summoned two or three household servants, each bearing hunting gear, and together they set out upon the great road. There was no end to the wild scenery of the mountains, the splendor of ridge upon ridge.

When they had traveled half a day, they saw before them a great mountain — truly it rose to touch the blue heavens, towering and perilous and sheer. In no long time Tripitaka came to its foot. The Defender climbed this mountain as though walking on level ground. When they had come just to the middle of the slope, Boqin turned about and halted below the path, saying: "Master, pray go forward by yourself; I must now take my leave and turn back." Hearing this, Tripitaka rolled from his saddle and dismounted, saying: "I beg you, Defender — by all means, see me a little further on." Boqin said: "Master, you do not understand. This mountain is called the Mountain of Two Borders. Its eastern half belongs to the rule of our great Tang; its western half is the territory of the Tartars. The wolves and tigers over there will not submit to my taming, and I cannot cross the border. You must go on by yourself." At this Tripitaka's heart leapt with fear. He flung out his arms and clutched at Boqin's clothes and sleeves, his tears falling, unable to part. And just at this moment of earnest, lingering farewell, there came from the foot of the mountain a shout like thunder: "My master has come! My master has come!" It so startled Tripitaka that he was struck dumb, and Boqin too was thrown into confusion.

After all, there is no knowing who it was that shouted — so listen to the explanation in the next chapter.

Chapter 14: The Mind-Monkey Returns to the Right, and the Demon is Slain

A poem says:

The Buddha is the mind, the mind is the Buddha,
yet mind and Buddha both depend on things. Know
that there is no thing and no mind, and you are the
true mind, the Dharma-body Buddha.

The Dharma-body Buddha has no shape at all — a single round of
light enfolding all forms. The bodiless body is the one true body,
the formless form is the form that is real.

Not matter, not void, and not "not-void," not coming, not going, not
turning back. No difference, no sameness, no being, no non-being,
hard to renounce, hard to grasp, hard to hear or behold.

The sacred light, within and without, is everywhere the same; a
whole Buddha-land lies in a single grain of sand. One grain of sand
contains the thousandfold worlds; one body and mind holds all the
laws as one.

To know this you must master the no-mind secret: undefiled,
unhindered — that is pure karma. A thousand strands of good and
evil, yet doing nothing at all — that is the homage, *Namo*
Sakyamuni.

Now the story tells how Liu Boqin and the Tang Monk Tripitaka, still trembling with fright, heard the voice cry out again: "Master, you have come!" The household servants said: "That call must be the old ape in the stone box at the foot of the mountain." The Guardian said: "It is he, it is he." Tripitaka asked: "What old ape is this?" The Guardian replied: "This mountain was once called the Mountain of Five Phases. But when our great Tang Emperor went west and pacified the realm, its name was changed to the Mountain of Two Frontiers. In years past I heard the old folk say that in the days when Wang Mang usurped the Han, Heaven sent down this mountain and pressed beneath it a divine monkey who fears neither cold nor heat, eats no food nor drinks, but is kept under guard by an earth-spirit who feeds him iron pellets when he hungers and molten bronze when he thirsts. From ancient times until now he has neither frozen nor starved to death. That cry must surely be his. Do not be afraid, Elder — let us go down the mountain and look."

Tripitaka could only consent, and led his horse downward. Before they had gone two or three miles, there, sure enough, in a stone box was a monkey, his head bared, one hand thrust out, waving wildly and crying: "Master, why have you come only now? You have come well, you have come well! Free me from here, and I will guard you all the way to the Western Heaven." The Elder drew near and looked at him closely. And how did the creature appear?

A pointed snout and sunken cheeks, with golden pupils and eyes of fire. Moss heaped upon his head, creeping vines sprouting in his ears. By his temples little hair, but much green grass; beneath his chin no beard, but emerald sedge. Dirt in his brows, mud crusted in his nose-hollows — a thoroughly wretched sight. Thick at the fingertips, heavy in the palms, caked with the grime of ages. Yet the eyes were glad enough to roll, the throat and tongue to sound out sweet. Quick though his speech might be, his body could not stir. This was the Great Sage of five hundred years ago, who this day, his ordeal fulfilled, escapes the net of Heaven.

The Guardian Liu, truly bold of heart, stepped forward and plucked away the grass at the monkey's temples and the sedge beneath his chin, then asked: "What is it you wish to say?" The monkey answered: "I have nothing to say to you. Have that master come up; I have a question to ask him." Tripitaka said: "What would you ask me?" The monkey said: "Are you the one sent by the great lord of the Eastern Land to fetch the scriptures from the Western Heaven?" Tripitaka said: "I am indeed. Why do you ask?" The monkey said: "I am the Great Sage Equal to Heaven, who five hundred years ago made the great uproar in the Palace of

Heaven. Because I committed the crime of deceiving my superiors, the Buddha-Patriarch pressed me down in this place. Some time ago the Bodhisattva Guanyin came bearing the Buddha's command to seek out a scripture-pilgrim in the Eastern Land. I begged her to save me, and she counseled me to do no more violence, to take refuge in the Buddha's Law, and with all my heart to protect the scripture-pilgrim on his journey west to worship the Buddha — promising that when the work was done there would be good reward. So day and night I have kept my heart in readiness, from dawn to dusk I have hung in suspense, awaiting only a master to come and set me free. I am willing to protect you on your quest for scriptures and to be your disciple."

When Tripitaka heard this he was filled with joy and said: "Though you have such a good heart, and have received the Bodhisattva's instruction, and wish to enter the gate of the Buddha, yet I have neither axe nor chisel — how am I to free you?" The monkey said: "No need for axe or chisel. Only be willing to save me, and I will come out by myself."

Tripitaka said: "I am willing to save you — but how will you get out?"

The monkey said: "On the summit of this mountain is the Tathagata's gold-lettered seal-slip. Only climb up and peel away the slip, and I shall come out at once." Tripitaka did as he was told, and turning back, entreated Liu Boqin: "Guardian, I would have you make the climb up the mountain with me." Boqin said: "I do not know whether what he says is true or false." The monkey called out loudly: "It is true! I would never dare to lie."

Boqin had no choice but to summon his servants to lead the horses while he himself supported Tripitaka and once more they ascended the high mountain. Clutching at vines and clinging to creepers, they climbed until they reached the very topmost peak, where indeed ten thousand beams of golden light blazed forth and a thousand strands of auspicious vapor

drifted on the air. There stood a great four-square boulder, and upon it was pasted a paper seal bearing six golden words: Om Mani Padme Hum. Tripitaka drew near and knelt down, gazing at the golden words upon the stone, bowed several times, and facing west prayed aloud: "Your disciple is Chen Xuanzang, sent by imperial command to seek the scriptures. If indeed it is my lot to have a disciple, let me peel away these golden words, free the divine monkey, and together attain the Spirit Mountain. But if it is not my lot to have a disciple — if this is some fierce and stubborn monster seeking to deceive your disciple, with no good fortune to follow — then let the slip refuse to lift." Having prayed, he bowed again; and his bows finished, he stepped forward and gently peeled the six golden words away.

At once a gust of fragrant wind arose and snatched the seal-slip from his very hand up into the sky, and a voice cried, "I am the guard set over the Great Sage. This day his ordeal is fulfilled; we now return to see the Tathagata and to give back this seal-paper." Tripitaka and Boqin and all their company, terrified, bowed toward the empty sky. Then they went straight down the high mountain and came again to the stone box, and Tripitaka said to the monkey, "The seal is peeled away — come out now." The monkey rejoiced and called, "Master, please stand back a little, so I can come out. I would not startle you."

Hearing this, Boqin led Tripitaka and all the company back eastward at a run. When they had gone some five or seven miles, the monkey shouted again: "Further, further!" Tripitaka went on a good way more and came down off the mountain — and then there was a thunderous crash, as though the earth split and the mountains crumbled. Everyone shook with terror. And there was the monkey, already arrived before Tripitaka's horse, kneeling stark naked and crying, "Master, I have come out!" He bowed to Tripitaka four times, then sprang up and made a great salute to

Boqin, saying, "Thank you, elder brother, for escorting my master, and for weeding the grass from my face." His thanks done, he set to gathering up the luggage and saddling the horse. But when the horse saw him, its loins went soft and its hooves buckled, and trembling it could not stand still — for the monkey had once been the Heaven-Stable Master, Bimawen, who tended the dragon-horses of Heaven and knew certain arts, so that ordinary horses are afraid of him.

Seeing that the monkey was truly of good intent and indeed had the bearing of a man of the Buddhist gate, Tripitaka called to him: "Disciple, what is your surname?" The Monkey King said, "My surname is Sun." Tripitaka said, "Let me give you a religious name, so that you may be called by it." The Monkey King said, "There is no need to trouble yourself, Master — I already have a religious name. It is Sun Wukong, 'Awakened to Emptiness.'" Tripitaka said joyfully, "Why, that fits our own lineage perfectly! And as for your appearance — you look just like a little novice mendicant. Let me give you a common nickname too, and call you Pilgrim. Will that do?" Wukong said, "Good, good, good!" And from that time he was also called Pilgrim Sun.

When Boqin saw that Pilgrim Sun was wholeheartedly packing up and eager to go, he turned to Tripitaka and made a bow, saying, "Elder, you are fortunate to have gained so fine a disciple here — I am most glad. This fellow will surely serve. But now I must take my leave." Tripitaka bent in courteous thanks: "I have given you great trouble; my gratitude is beyond words. When you return home, please convey my warmest regards to your honored mother and your good wife. I have imposed greatly upon your household; when I return I shall come to thank you in person." Boqin returned the courtesy, and so the two parted ways.

Now Pilgrim Sun invited Tripitaka to mount, while he himself went ahead with the luggage on his back, stark-bodied, striding along. Before

long they had crossed the Mountain of Two Frontiers, when suddenly a fierce tiger came roaring and lashing its tail toward them. Tripitaka, on his horse, was struck with fear. But Pilgrim, by the roadside, rejoiced and said, "Master, do not fear him — he has come to bring me a set of clothes." He set down the luggage, drew a needle from his ear, faced the wind and gave it a shake, and behold — it was an iron rod as thick as a bowl. Taking it in hand he laughed and said, "This treasure I have not used in more than five hundred years; today I bring it out to earn myself a suit of clothes." Watch how he opened his stride and went to meet the fierce tiger, crying, "Cursed beast! Where do you think you're going?" The tiger crouched low and pressed itself into the dust, not daring to stir. The monkey brought the rod down full on its head, and the brains burst out in ten thousand points of peach-red, the teeth spattered out like beads of jade. So terrified was Chen Xuanzang that he tumbled from the saddle, bit his finger, and cried, "Heaven! O Heaven! The brindled tiger that Guardian Liu fought the other day kept him at it half a day — and today Sun Wukong, without a struggle, beats this tiger to a pulp with a single blow! Truly, beyond the strong there is always the stronger!"

Pilgrim dragged the tiger over and said, "Master, sit a while and rest; let me peel off his skin and put it on to walk in." Tripitaka said, "Where does he have any skin worth wearing?" Pilgrim said, "Never mind, Master — I have my own way." Good Monkey King! He plucked out one of his hairs, blew on it a breath of magic, and cried, "Change!" — and it became a sharp ox-ear knife. With it he slit the hide along the tiger's belly, stripped it downward, and peeled the whole thing off in one piece. He chopped off the claws and cut away the head, then trimmed the hide into a neat square. Holding it up and measuring it, he said, "A bit too wide — one panel will make two." So he took up the knife, cut it into two panels, stowed one away, and wrapped the other around his waist. He pulled a length of vine from the roadside, bound it tightly, and so covered his

lower body. "Master, let us go, let us go," he said. "When we reach some house, I'll borrow a needle and thread and sew it up properly — it won't be too late." He gave the iron rod a twirl, and it shrank back into a needle, which he tucked into his ear. Then he shouldered the luggage and invited his master to mount.

As the two went forward, the Elder asked from his horse, "Wukong, that iron rod with which you just slew the tiger — where has it gone? I cannot see it anywhere." Pilgrim laughed. "Master, you do not understand. This cudgel of mine was got from the Dragon Palace in the great Eastern Ocean. It is called the Divine Treasure Iron that Stills the Bed of the Heavenly River, and also the As-You-Will Gold-Banded Cudgel. In the old days when I rebelled against Heaven, I owed much to it. It changes at my will — when I want it big, it grows big; when I want it small, it shrinks small. Just now I made it into the likeness of an embroidery needle and stowed it in my ear. When there is need, I take it out again." Tripitaka heard this and was secretly delighted. He asked further, "Just now, when that tiger saw you, why did it not move at all, but let you strike it at your leisure? How do you explain that?" Wukong said, "Not to deceive you, Master — never mind a tiger; even a dragon, seeing me, would not dare be insolent. I, old Sun, have no small skill in subduing dragons and taming tigers, in overturning rivers and stirring the seas. I read faces and judge their colors; I hear voices and discern their meaning. Made large, I can measure myself against the universe; made small, I can withdraw into a single hair. My transformations are without limit, my comings and goings beyond all reckoning. To peel off a tiger's hide — what is there strange in that? Wait till we come to some place of real difficulty, and then you shall see my true powers." Hearing these words, Tripitaka was all the more set at ease, free of care, and urged his horse onward.

Master and disciple went along the road, talking as they went, until before they knew it the sun sank in the west. And they beheld:

The flaming slant of sunset throwing back its glow;
at the world's edge, at the sea's far corner, the
clouds returning home. On a thousand peaks the
birds cried frequent and shrill, seeking their roosts,
plunging into the woods in flocks. The wild beasts
went in pairs and couples, returning to their dens in
clans and herds. A hook of new moon broke the
dusk; ten thousand points of bright stars haloed the
sky.

Pilgrim said, "Master, step lively — the day grows late. There among those dense-clustered trees there must be some farmstead; let us hurry on and beg a night's lodging." Tripitaka indeed urged his horse forward and made straight for the dwelling, dismounting before the gate. Pilgrim flung down the luggage, went up, and called out, "Open the gate! Open the gate!" From within an old man came leaning on a staff, and with a creak he opened the gate. But when he saw Pilgrim's fearsome looks — a tiger-skin tied at his waist, for all the world like the Duke of Thunder — his legs went weak and his body numb, and he stammered out, "A ghost has come! A ghost has come!" Tripitaka stepped forward and steadied him, saying, "Old patron, do not be afraid. He is this poor monk's disciple, not a ghost or a demon." The old man raised his head, and seeing Tripitaka's clear and noble features, at last stood firm and asked,

"From what temple are you, monk, that you bring this fearsome fellow to my door?" Tripitaka said, "This poor monk has come from the Tang court, journeying to the Western Heaven to worship the Buddha and seek scriptures. Passing this way as night fell, I have come to your honored dwelling to beg a single night's lodging; tomorrow before daybreak I shall be on my way. I beg only a little kindness." The old man said, "Though you may be a man of Tang, that fearsome one is no man of Tang."

Wukong cried out in a stern voice, "Old fellow, you have no eyes at all! The man of Tang is my master; I am his disciple. And I am no 'sugar-man' nor 'honey-man' either — I am the Great Sage Equal to Heaven! There are people in these parts who know me. I have seen you before, too." The old man said, "Where did you ever see me?" Wukong said, "When you were small, did you not gather firewood before my face? Did you not pick vegetables upon my very cheeks?" The old man said, "This rascal talks nonsense! Where do you live? Where do I live? And I came before your face to gather firewood and pick vegetables?" Wukong said, "It's my own child who talks nonsense! You don't know me — but I am the very Great Sage from the stone box of this Mountain of Two Frontiers. Look again." The old man at last understood and said, "You do indeed look somewhat like him. But how did you get out?" So Wukong told the old man in full how the Bodhisattva had counseled him to virtue and bidden him wait for the Tang Monk to peel away the seal and set him free.

Only then did the old man bow down, and he invited the Tang Monk inside, calling his old wife and his sons and daughters all to come and pay their respects. He told them the whole matter, and every one of them was glad. He ordered tea brought, and when the tea was done, he asked Wukong, "Great Sage, you must be well on in years?" Wukong said, "And how old are you this year?" The old man said, "In my foolishness I have reached one hundred and thirty." Pilgrim said, "Then you'd still be my

great-great-grandchild! I cannot recall the year of my birth; but I have been at the foot of this mountain more than five hundred years already." The old man said, "True, true. I remember my grandfather saying that this mountain came down from Heaven and pressed down a divine monkey — and only now, this very day, have you escaped. When I saw you in my childhood, you had grass on your head and mud on your face, and I was not afraid of you. Now there's no mud on your face and no grass on your head, and you look a little thinner — but with that great tiger-skin draped at your waist, how do you differ much from a goblin?" When the whole household heard this, they all roared with laughter.

This old man was quite the worthy soul, and at once ordered a vegetarian meal prepared. After they had eaten, Wukong said, "What is your family's surname?" The old man said, "Our humble house bears the surname Chen." Hearing this, Tripitaka at once came forward and clasped his hands, saying, "Old patron, you and this poor monk are of one clan." Pilgrim said, "Master, you are of the Tang surname — how are you of one clan with him?" Tripitaka said, "In my lay family I too was surnamed Chen, a man of Juxian Village in Hongnong Prefecture of Haizhou, in the Tang realm. My religious name is Chen Xuanzang. It was only because our great Tang Emperor Taizong bestowed on me the title of Imperial Brother Tripitaka, taking 'Tang' as my surname, that I am called the Tang Monk." When the old man heard they shared a surname, he was the more delighted.

Pilgrim said, "Old Chen, I've troubled your house every which way, and I haven't bathed in over five hundred years. Could you go and heat some water, so my master and I may wash ourselves? When we leave, we'll thank you all the more." The old man at once ordered water heated and basins brought, and lit the lamps. When master and disciple had bathed, they sat before the lamp, and Pilgrim said, "Old Chen, there's one more

thing to trouble you with: have you a needle and thread I might use?" The old man said, "Yes, yes, yes," and at once bade his wife fetch needle and thread and hand them to Pilgrim. Now Pilgrim had a sharp eye: seeing that his master, while bathing, had taken off a short white cloth tunic and not put it on again, he pulled it over and threw it about himself. Then he took off the tiger-skin, stitched it into one piece, made a horse-face pleat in it, wrapped it about his waist and bound it with the vine, and came before his master, saying, "How does old Sun's get-up today compare with yesterday?" Tripitaka said, "Good, good, good! Dressed like this, you finally look like a real pilgrim." And he added, "Disciple, if you don't mind its being worn and old, you may keep that tunic and wear it." Wukong made a bow and said, "I accept the gift, I accept the gift." Then he went and found some fodder to feed the horse. By then all the chores were done, and master, disciple, and the old man each went to their rest.

Early next morning Wukong rose and asked his master to take the road. Tripitaka dressed and bade Pilgrim pack up the bedding and luggage. Just as they were about to take their leave, the old man had already prepared water for washing and a vegetarian meal besides. When the meal was over, they at last set out. Tripitaka mounted and Pilgrim led the way; and without their marking it they ate when hungry and drank when thirsty, lodging by night and traveling by dawn. It was now early winter, and they beheld:

Frost has withered the red leaves; a thousand groves grow thin. On the ridges a few pines and cypress keep their grace. Plum buds, not yet open, scatter a faint, hidden fragrance; the days are warm and short — the little spring of the season. The chrysanthemums are spent, the lotus gone, but the mountain camellia thrives; by cold bridges the ancient trees vie branch against branch. Down winding gullies the spring-water trickles and purls; pale clouds, heavy with coming snow, drift and fill the sky. The north wind gusts suddenly, tugging at sleeve and hem — toward evening the cold strikes hard: how is a man to bear it?

Master and disciple had been traveling a good while when suddenly, by the roadside, there came a sharp whistle, and out burst six men — each gripping a long spear or a short sword, a keen blade or a stout bow — shouting in a great voice, "Where do you think you're going, monk? Leave your horse and set down your baggage at once, and we'll spare your life to pass!" So terrified was Tripitaka that his souls flew off and scattered; he tumbled from his horse and could not utter a word. Pilgrim helped him up and said, "Master, rest easy — it's nothing at all. These men have come to bring us clothes and traveling money." Tripitaka said,

"Wukong, your ears must be a little stopped up. They say we are to leave our horse and baggage, and you turn round and ask them for clothes and money?" Pilgrim said, "You keep watch over the clothes, the baggage, and the horse; let old Sun have a bout with them and see how it goes."

Tripitaka said, "A good fist is no match for two fists, and two fists no match for four hands. There are six big men over there, and you such a small little person — how dare you contend with them?"

But Pilgrim's daring was great from birth, and brooking no argument he stepped forward, folded his hands before his breast, and saluting the six men said, "Sirs, for what cause do you block this poor monk's road?" The men said, "We are the great kings of the highway, the goodly lords of this mountain. Our great names have long been famous — surely you must have heard. Leave your things at once and we'll let you pass; but utter so much as half a 'no,' and we'll grind you to pulp and powder your bones!" Pilgrim said, "I too am a great king by ancestral descent, a mountain-lord of long standing — yet I have never heard that you sirs have any great names." The men said, "You don't know? Then let me tell you: one of us is called Eye-That-Sees-and-Delights; one, Ear-That-Hears-and-Rages; one, Nose-That-Smells-and-Craves; one, Tongue-That-Tastes-and-Longs; one, Mind-That-Perceives-and-Desires; and one, Body-That-Is-the-Root-of-Care." Wukong laughed and said, "So you're six petty hair-thieves! You fail to recognize that this man of religion is your true master — yet you come to block the road. Bring out the precious loot you've plundered, and I'll split it with you in seven shares and let you off." At this the thieves — the glad one glad, the angry one angry, the craving one craving, the longing one longing, the desiring one desiring, the careworn one careworn — all rushed forward together, yelling, "This monk has no manners! You've nothing at all of your own, and now you turn round and ask us to share our things!" They whirled their spears and brandished their swords and crowded in as one, hacking at Pilgrim's head — bang,

clang, bang — for seventy or eighty strokes. Wukong stood there in the midst of it all as though he felt nothing. The thieves said, "What a monk! Truly his head is hard!" Pilgrim laughed, "It'll pass well enough. You've worn your hands out striking — now it's old Sun's turn to take out a little needle and play." The thieves said, "This monk must be some acupuncture-doctor in disguise. We've no illness — what's this talk of plying a needle?"

Pilgrim reached into his ear and drew out an embroidery needle, gave it a shake in the wind, and lo, it was an iron rod fully as thick as a bowl. Taking it in hand he said, "Don't run — let old Sun strike one blow just to try his hand!" So terrified were the six thieves that they scattered and fled in every direction. But he opened his stride, ran them all down, and beat each and every one of them to death. He stripped off their clothes, seized their traveling money, and came back smiling. "Master, please proceed — those thieves have all been wiped out by old Sun." Tripitaka said, "What a calamity you have wrought! Though they were highway robbers, even if they had been taken before the magistrate it would not have been a capital crime. With all your skill, you needed only to drive them off — why beat them all to death? This is taking lives without cause! How can you call yourself a monk? A man who has left the household sweeps the floor for fear of harming an ant's life, and shades his lamp with gauze out of pity for moths. How could you, drawing no distinction of black from white, beat them all dead in a single bout? You have not a single shred of mercy or love of goodness. It is well that this is wild country with no one to make inquiry; but if we came to a town and someone gave you a moment's affront, and you fell to your savagery, swinging your cudgel and wounding men at random — I could hardly stand by with clean hands. How then should we escape?" Wukong said, "Master, if I had not beaten them to death, they would have beaten you to death." Tripitaka said, "I, a man of religion, would sooner die than dare

to do violence. Even if I died, it would be but one body; but you have killed six men — how do you reason that away? If this matter were brought before the magistrate, then even if your own father held the office, it could not be talked round." Pilgrim said, "Not to deceive you, Master — five hundred years ago, in the days when I held sway as a monster-king on the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit, I cannot tell how many men I killed. By your reckoning, if it had all gone to the magistrate, there'd have been some fine indictments." Tripitaka said, "It was precisely because you were unrestrained and unmanaged, raging savagely through the world, bullying Heaven and deceiving your superiors, that you suffered that ordeal of five hundred years. Now that you have entered the gate of religion, if you go on doing violence as you did then, killing living things at every turn, you cannot reach the Western Heaven, you cannot be a monk. Too wicked! Too wicked!"

Now this monkey, all his life, could never endure a scolding. Hearing Tripitaka go on nagging and muttering, he could not hold down the fire that flared in his heart, and burst out: "Since you say I cannot be a monk and cannot reach the Western Heaven, then have done with this endless carping and railing at me — I'll go back, and that's that!" Tripitaka made no reply. And the monkey, giving way to his temper, leapt up with a bound, cried, "Old Sun's off!" — and was gone. Tripitaka quickly raised his head, but already the monkey was nowhere to be seen; he heard only a whoosh, and away Wukong went eastward. The Elder was left utterly alone, nodding to himself and sighing, grieving and lamenting without end: "That fellow! So past all teaching — I said only a few words to him, and he goes off without form or shadow, straight back where he came from! Enough, enough, enough! It must be that it is not in my fate to win a disciple or gather any companion. Now if I wished to seek him there is no place to seek; if I wished to call him he would not answer. On, then, on." Indeed:

Staking body and life, he turns toward the West alone — leaning on no other, he must be his own master.

The Elder had no choice but to gather up his luggage, sling it on the horse, and — not even riding but going on foot, one hand propping his pewter staff, the other clutching the reins — press on westward, forlorn and desolate. He had not gone far when, on the mountain road ahead, he saw an aged woman holding out a cotton-padded garment, and upon the garment a flowered cap. When Tripitaka saw her draw near, he hurriedly led his horse aside and stood to let her pass. The old woman asked, "Where are you from, Elder, that you go all alone and forlorn in this place?" Tripitaka said, "Your disciple is one sent by the great Tang of the Eastern Land to journey to the Western Heaven, to worship the living Buddha and seek the true scriptures." The old woman said, "The Buddha of the West is at the Temple of Great Thunderclap, in the land of India; the way thither is a hundred and eight thousand miles. Traveling as you are — a single man and a lone horse, with no companion and no disciple — how can you ever get there?" Tripitaka said, "Some days ago I gained a disciple, but he was savage and headstrong, and when I spoke a few words to him he would not take instruction, and went off into the void." The old woman said, "I have here a cotton tunic and a gold-inlaid flowered cap that once belonged to my son. He was a monk for but three days when, alas, his life was cut short and he died. I have just been to his temple to weep for him, took leave of his master, and brought away these two things as a remembrance. But since you have a disciple, Elder, let me make you a gift of this garment and cap." Tripitaka said, "I am grateful for your generosity, old mother, but my disciple has already gone, and I dare

not receive them." The old woman said, "Which way did he go?" Tripitaka said, "I heard a whoosh, and he went off eastward." The old woman said, "My own home is not far to the east; he has surely gone that way. I have besides a spell, called the Spell of the Settled Mind, also named the Tight-Fillet Spell. You should silently con it until you know it by heart, fix it firmly in your mind, and never let a single soul learn of it. I will go and overtake him and bid him come back and follow you again, and you shall give him this garment and cap to put on. If he will not obey your command, only recite this spell in silence, and he will never again dare to do violence, nor ever again dare to leave you."

Hearing this, Tripitaka bowed his head in grateful thanks. The old woman changed into a beam of golden light and went off eastward. Then Tripitaka knew in his heart that it was the Bodhisattva Guanyin who had bestowed this true spell upon him, and he hastily gathered earth in place of incense and burned it, bowing earnestly toward the east. His bows done, he took up the garment and cap and hid them in the middle of his bundle. Then, sitting by the roadside, he conned and practiced the Spell of the Settled Mind, reciting it over and over until he had it letter-perfect and fixed firm in his breast — but of that we say no more.

Now the story tells how Wukong, having parted from his master, took a single somersault of cloud and went straight back to the great Eastern Ocean. Pressing down his cloud-head, he parted the watery way and came straight to the front of the Crystal Palace. The Dragon King, alarmed, soon came out to receive him and brought him within to be seated. The courtesies done, the Dragon King said, "Of late I have heard that the Great Sage's ordeal was fulfilled — my congratulations, belated though they be! No doubt you are putting your fairy mountain in order and returning to your ancient cave?" Wukong said, "I had such a mind, but I have become a monk besides." The Dragon King said, "A monk?

How so?" Pilgrim said, "I owe it to the Bodhisattva of the Southern Sea, who counseled me to virtue and bade me attain the right fruit, following the Tang Monk of the Eastern Land westward to worship the Buddha, taking refuge in the Buddhist gate; and I am called Pilgrim now." The Dragon King said, "This is truly to be congratulated! This is indeed to forsake the crooked and return to the straight, to chasten the heart toward goodness. But since it is so, why are you not going west — why have you come back east?" Pilgrim laughed and said, "It's that the Tang Monk does not understand a man's nature. There were a few hair-thieves robbing the highway, and I beat them to death; but the Tang Monk went nagging and muttering and reckoned up no end of my faults. You may imagine — can old Sun bear such stifling reproaches? So I left him, meaning to go back to my own mountain, and came first to pay you a visit and beg a cup of tea." The Dragon King said, "I am honored, I am honored." Straightway the dragon-sons and dragon-grandsons brought up fragrant tea and presented it.

When the tea was done, Pilgrim turned his head and saw, hanging on the rear wall, a painting called "The Presenting of the Shoe at the Yi Bridge." Pilgrim said, "What scene is this?" The Dragon King said, "Great Sage, you came before this event — that is why you do not know it. This is called 'Thrice Presenting the Shoe at the Yi Bridge.'" Pilgrim said, "What is 'Thrice Presenting the Shoe'?" The Dragon King said, "The immortal here is Huang Shigong, and the young man is Zhang Liang of the Han age. Shigong was sitting on the Yi Bridge when of a sudden his shoe fell off below the bridge, and he called Zhang Liang to fetch it. The young man at once fetched it and knelt to present it before him. This happened three times, and Zhang Liang showed not the least hair of arrogance or sloth. So Shigong, loving his diligence and respect, gave him by night a heavenly book and charged him to uphold the Han. Afterwards Zhang Liang did indeed plan strategy within the tent and decide victory a

thousand miles away. When peace was won, he gave up his office and returned to the mountains, roamed with Master Red Pine, and awakened to the Way of immortals. Great Sage, if you do not protect the Tang Monk, do not give your full diligence, do not accept instruction, then in the end you will be but a goblin-immortal — never think to attain the right fruit." Wukong heard this and brooded in silence a good while, saying nothing. The Dragon King said, "Great Sage, you must decide for yourself; do not, for the sake of present ease, ruin your future." Wukong said, "Say no more — old Sun will go back and protect him, and there's an end." The Dragon King said joyfully, "Since it is so, I dare not keep you long. I beg the Great Sage to show his mercy early, and not stay parted too long from your master."

Pilgrim, seeing him press to be gone, hastily sprang up, left the sea-treasury, mounted his cloud, and took leave of the Dragon King. As he went, he met the Bodhisattva of the Southern Sea. The Bodhisattva said, "Sun Wukong, why is it that you do not take instruction, do not protect the Tang Monk, but come to do business here?" In a fluster, Pilgrim made obeisance upon his cloud and said, "Some time ago I received the Bodhisattva's good words, and indeed a Tang monk came, peeled away the seal, saved my life, and I followed him as his disciple. But he blamed me for being savage and headstrong, so I gave him the slip for a moment; and now I am going back to protect him." The Bodhisattva said, "Go quickly, then, before you lose your resolve." With that, each went their separate way.

In a moment Pilgrim saw the Tang Monk sitting downcast by the roadside. He went up and said, "Master, why are you not on the road? What are you still doing here?" Tripitaka raised his head and said, "Where have you been? You left me neither daring to go on nor daring to stir; I could only sit here waiting for you." Pilgrim said, "I went to the

house of the old Dragon King in the great Eastern Ocean to beg a cup of tea." Tripitaka said, "Disciple, a man of religion should not tell lies. You had been gone from me scarcely an hour, and you say you went to the Dragon King's house for tea?" Pilgrim laughed. "Not to deceive you, Master — I can ride the somersault cloud, and a single somersault carries a hundred and eight thousand miles. That is how I could go and come back so quickly." Tripitaka said, "I spoke to you a trifle too heavily, and you took offense and went off in a temper, abandoning me. For one of your gifts, you may go and get a cup of tea; but one like me, who cannot go anywhere, can only sit here enduring hunger. You ought to feel some shame!" Pilgrim said, "Master, if you're hungry, I'll go and beg some food for you." Tripitaka said, "There's no need to beg. There's still some dry provision in my bundle, given me by Guardian Liu's mother. Go and fetch the alms-bowl, find some water, and let me eat a little so we can be on the road."

Pilgrim went to unfasten the bundle, and in the midst of the wrappings he found several coarse-flour cakes, which he took out and handed to his master. He also saw a glossy, glowing cotton tunic and a gold-inlaid flowered cap. Pilgrim said, "Did you bring these garments from the Eastern Land?" Tripitaka answered glibly, "These are what I wore when I was small. With this cap on, even the untaught can recite the scriptures; with this tunic on, even the unrehearsed can perform the rites." Pilgrim said, "Good Master, give them to me to wear." Tripitaka said, "I only fear they may not fit; but if you can wear them, put them on." Pilgrim took off his old white cloth tunic, donned the cotton tunic — it fit as though cut to his measure — and set the cap upon his head. When Tripitaka saw him put the cap on, he stopped eating his dry provision and silently recited the Tight-Fillet Spell once through. Pilgrim cried, "My head aches, my head aches!" The master recited it again and again without stopping, until Pilgrim was rolling on the ground in agony and had clawed the

gold-inlaid flowered cap to tatters. Then Tripitaka, fearing he would snap the gold fillet, ceased reciting; and when he stopped, the pain ceased too. Pilgrim reached up to feel his head, and there it was, clamped tight like a thread of gold — it could not be taken off nor snapped through, for it had already taken root. He drew the needle from his ear, thrust it into the fillet, and pried wildly to get it loose. Tripitaka, fearing he would break it apart, recited the spell again; and at once the pain returned as before, so that Pilgrim stood on his head, turned somersaults, his ears red and his face crimson, his eyes bulging and his body numb. Seeing him in such a state, the master could not bear it, and once more fell silent; and the pain left his head. Pilgrim said, "This head of mine — so it is Master who has put a curse on me!" Tripitaka said, "I was reciting the Tight-Fillet Scripture — when did I ever curse you?" Pilgrim said, "Recite it again and see." Tripitaka did indeed recite it again, and Pilgrim was indeed in pain again, crying only, "Stop, stop! The moment you begin I am in agony. What is the meaning of this?" Tripitaka said, "Will you now heed my teaching?" Pilgrim said, "I will heed it." "And will you do no more violence?" Pilgrim said, "I dare not."

Though he answered so with his mouth, his heart still harbored ill intent. Giving the needle a shake — till it was thick as a bowl again — he made to bring it down upon the Tang Monk. In a fright the Elder recited the spell two or three times more, and the monkey toppled to the ground, dropped the iron rod, and could not lift his hand, crying only, "Master, I understand! Recite no more, recite no more!" Tripitaka said, "How dare you, with such a treacherous heart, try to strike me?" Pilgrim said, "I never dared strike you. But I ask you, Master — who taught you this trick?" Tripitaka said, "An old mother just now handed it down to me." Pilgrim flew into a rage and said, "No need to say more — that old mother is surely none other than Guanshiyin! How could she harm me so? Let me go up to the Southern Sea and beat her!" Tripitaka said, "Since

it was she who taught me this spell, she must surely know it already. If you go looking for her and she recites it, won't you be done for?" Pilgrim saw the reason in this and truly dared not stir. Instead he turned his heart, knelt, and pleaded piteously: "Master, this is her device to keep me in check and make me journey west with you. I will not go provoke her — and you, do not take it as a common matter to keep reciting. I am willing to protect you, with never again a thought of turning back." Tripitaka said, "Since it is so, then help me to mount and let us be on our way." And only then did Pilgrim, his heart wholly given over, brace up his spirit, gird tight the cotton tunic, saddle the horse, shoulder the luggage, and press on toward the west.

What more befell on this journey, and what was said hereafter — listen to the explanation in the next chapter.

Chapter 15: The Hawk-Grief Gorge and the Dragon-Horse

We left off with Wukong attending upon the Tang Monk as they pressed westward. For several days they journeyed on, and it was now the deep cold of the year's last month, with a bitter north wind howling and ice slicking every surface. Their road wound along sheer cliffs and broken precipices, over folded ridges and tier upon tier of perilous peaks.

Tripitaka was upon his horse when, from far off, he heard the rushing of water clamoring in his ears. He turned his head and called, "Wukong, where is that water sounding?"

Wukong answered, "I recall that this place is called Coiled-Snake Mountain, and the stream here is the Hawk-Grief Gorge. That must be the gorge water making that noise." Before he had finished speaking, the

horse reached the bank, and Tripitaka reined in to look. What he saw was this:

A trickling cold vein winds and pierces the clouds,
Clear deep waters mirror the sun in crimson. Its
voice stirs like night rain heard in a hidden valley,
Its colors flare like dawn glow dazzling the empty
sky. Down a thousand fathoms the spray flies,
spitting shattered jade, A single pool roars and
answers the pure wind. The flow returns at last to
vast leagues of misty waves, Where gull and egret
forget themselves, far from any angler's line.

While master and disciple were both gazing, all at once the middle of the gorge gave a great roar, and a dragon bored upward through the water. Pushing the waves and heaving up the swells, it shot from the cliffside straight at the elder. In his fright Wukong dropped the luggage, snatched his master down from the horse, and ran. The dragon could not catch up to them, so instead it swallowed the white horse — saddle, bridle, and all — in a single gulp, then sank again and hid its tracks beneath the water.

Wukong settled his master on a high mound to sit, then went back to fetch the horse and shoulder the load. But there was only the one load of luggage — the horse was nowhere to be seen. He carried the baggage over and set it before his master, saying, "Master, that wicked dragon has vanished without a trace. It has only frightened my horse away."

Tripitaka said, "Disciple, how then are we to find the horse again?"

"Rest easy, rest easy," said Wukong. "Let me go and have a look." He gave a whistle and leapt into the air. With his fiery eyes and golden pupils he shaded his brow with one hand and searched in all four directions, but nowhere could he see a sign of the horse. He brought his cloud down and reported, "Master, our horse has certainly been eaten by that dragon. I can find no trace of it anywhere."

Tripitaka said, "Disciple, how large a mouth can that creature have, that it could swallow a horse whole — saddle and bridle and all? More likely it was startled and slipped its rein, and has bolted into some fold of the mountains. Look again, and look closely."

Wukong said, "You do not know my powers. With these two eyes of mine, in broad daylight I can commonly see fortune and disaster a thousand li off. Within that thousand li, if a dragonfly so much as spreads its wings, I would see it — how then could I miss a horse that size?"

Tripitaka said, "If indeed the creature has eaten it, how am I to go forward? Pity me — across these thousand mountains and ten thousand rivers, how am I ever to travel?" As he spoke, his tears fell like rain.

When Wukong saw him begin to weep, he could not hold back his hot temper, and he shouted aloud, "Master, don't carry on in this spineless way! Sit there, sit there, and let old Sun go find that creature and make it return our horse — that is all there is to it."

But Tripitaka caught hold of him and said, "Disciple, where will you go to find it? What if it comes lunging out from some hidden place behind you and harms me too? Then both man and horse would be lost — what good would that do?"

At these words Wukong grew angrier still and bellowed like thunder, "You are useless, utterly useless! You want a horse to ride, yet you won't let me go — at this rate I'll sit here minding the baggage until I grow old!"

He was raging fiercely and could not master his fury, when all at once a voice spoke from the air, calling, "Great Sage Sun, do not be vexed; royal younger brother of Tang, do not weep. We are the host of guardian deities dispatched along this road by the Bodhisattva Guanyin, come in secret to protect the seeker of scriptures." Hearing this, the elder hastily made his bows.

Wukong said, "Which of you are these? Report your names, that I may take the roll."

The gods said, "We are the Six Ding and Six Jia, the Guardians of the Five Quarters, the Four Sentinels of the Hours, and the eighteen Protectors of the Faith — each of us taking turns to stand watch by day and await your commands."

Wukong said, "Who stands duty today?"

The Guardians said, "The Ding and Jia spirits, the Sentinels, and the Protectors serve in rotation. As for the Guardians of the Five Quarters, only the Gold-Headed Guardian stays close by your side day and night without leave."

Wukong said, "Very well. Those not on duty may withdraw. Leave the Six Ding spirit-generals and the Day-Sentinel of the Hours, together with the Guardians, to keep watch over my master. Let old Sun go down to the gorge and make that wicked dragon return my horse." The host of gods obeyed.

Only then did Tripitaka set his heart at ease and sit down upon the stone cliff, charging Wukong to be careful. "Just keep your mind at rest," said Wukong.

What a fine Monkey King! He girded up his cotton tunic, hitched up his tiger-skin kilt, gripped his gold-banded iron cudgel, roused his spirits, and went straight down to the gorge. Half on cloud and half on mist, he hovered above the water's face and shouted aloud, "You filthy mud-loach, give me back my horse! Give me back my horse!"

Now that dragon, having eaten Tripitaka's white horse, lay coiled at the gorge bottom, nursing its spirit and tending its nature. Hearing someone above cursing and demanding the horse, it could not keep down the fire blazing in its heart. With a sudden bound it leapt through the waves and broke the surface, crying, "Who dares come here mouthing such big talk?"

When Wukong saw it, he gave a great shout — "Don't run! Give me back my horse!" — and whirling his cudgel, struck straight at its head. The dragon bared its fangs and lashed its claws to seize him. The two of them fought a valiant bout there at the edge of the gorge. Behold:

The dragon stretched its keen claws, The monkey raised his gold-banded staff. The one's whiskers hung like threads of white jade, The other's eyes flashed like lamps of red gold. The one's barbel-pearl spat out a rainbow mist, The other's iron rod danced up a wild wind. The one was an unfilial whelp that shamed its sire and dam, The other a spirit who had bullied the hosts of Heaven. Both, through misfortune, had endured their torments, And now, to win merit, each displayed his might.

Back and forth they went, battling for a long while, circling and wheeling, until the dragon's strength softened and its sinews went slack, and it could resist no longer. With a single twist it dove again into the water, sank deep to the gorge bottom, and would not show its head — though the Monkey King railed at it without cease, it only played deaf.

Having no recourse, Wukong could only return to Tripitaka and say, "Master, I cursed that monster out, and it fought me for a good while, then turned coward and fled. Now it skulks at the bottom of the water and will not come out again."

Tripitaka said, "But are you certain it was truly that creature that ate my horse?"

Wukong said, "Listen to you! If it had not eaten it, would it have come out to answer me and pit itself against old Sun?"

Tripitaka said, "When you slew that tiger the other day, you said you had the art of subduing dragons and taming tigers. How is it that today you cannot subdue this one?"

Now this monkey could not bear to be pressed. When he heard Tripitaka throw this rebuke in his face, his divine fury blazed up and he said, "Say no more, say no more! Let me go and have it out with him once again."

The Monkey King strode off and sprang to the gorge's edge, and there he worked his sea-overturning, river-churning magic. The waters of that bottomlessly clear Hawk-Grief Gorge he stirred up until they surged like the flooding waves of the Yellow River winding through its nine bends. Down in the deep gorge the wicked dragon could neither sit nor lie in peace, and thought to itself, "Truly, blessings never come in pairs, and disasters never come singly. I have only just escaped a death sentence under Heaven's law; for not even a full year have I been passing my days here, and now I run into this loutish demon come to do me harm." The more it thought, the angrier it grew, until it could no longer endure the affront. Gritting its teeth, it leapt forth and cursed, "What lout of a demon are you, come from who knows where, to bully me like this?"

Wukong said, "Never mind where I am from — just give back my horse, and I will spare your life."

The dragon said, "Your horse is down in my belly. How am I to vomit it up again? I will not give it back — what of it?"

Wukong said, "If you will not return the horse, then look out for my cudgel. I will beat you to death, and you can pay for my horse with your life — that will settle it." And the two of them fought another bitter

battle beneath the mountain cliff. But after only a few exchanges the little dragon truly could not hold out. With a flick of its body it transformed into a small water-snake and slithered away into the grass.

The Monkey King chased after with his cudgel, parting the grass in search of the snake, but not the least sign of it could he find. So vexed was he that the three corpse-spirits within him leapt and smoke poured from his seven orifices. He recited the syllable "Om," and at once summoned the local Earth-god and the Mountain-spirit of that place. Together they came and knelt, saying, "The Mountain-spirit and the Earth-god come to attend you."

Wukong said, "Stick out your shanks — five strokes apiece to greet me, and let old Sun ease his temper."

The two gods knocked their heads and pleaded, "We beg the Great Sage's indulgence; let your humble servants speak."

"Speak, then," said Wukong. "What is it?"

The two gods said, "The Great Sage was long pent up, and your humble servants did not know when you would come forth, which is why we failed to meet you. We beg ten thousand pardons for the offense."

Wukong said, "Very well, I will not beat you. But tell me: that monster dragon in the Hawk-Grief Gorge — where is it from? And how did it come to snatch and eat my master's white horse?"

The two gods said, "Great Sage, you never had a master before. You were originally a primal immortal who would submit neither to Heaven nor to Earth. How do you come to have any master's horse?"

Wukong said, "You two simply do not know. It was for the matter of my deceiving Heaven that I suffered five hundred years of misery. Now, by

the grace of the Bodhisattva Guanyin's exhortation to virtue, a true monk under the Tang court's commission has rescued me, and bidden me follow him as his disciple to journey to the Western Heaven, there to worship the Buddha and seek the scriptures. Because our road passed through this place, my master lost his white horse."

The two gods said, "So that is how it stands. There never was any demon in this gorge before — only that it is deep, steep, broad, and wide, and the water gleams clear to the very bottom, so that even crow and magpie dare not fly across; for the clear water shows them their own reflections, which they take for birds of their own flock, and again and again they hurl themselves into it. That is why it is named the Steep Hawk-Grief Gorge. Some years ago, when the Bodhisattva Guanyin was traveling to seek out the scripture-pilgrim, she saved a jade dragon and sent it here, bidding it await that pilgrim and commit no evil deeds. Only when hungry does it come up onto the bank to snatch a few birds, or catch river-deer for its food. We do not know how, in its ignorance, it has today collided with the Great Sage."

Wukong said, "The first time, it traded blows with old Sun and circled with me a few rounds. The second time, old Sun cursed and railed at it, but it would not come out again. So I worked a river-churning, sea-overturning spell and muddied up the gorge water, and then it came leaping forth, still bent on a fight. But it could not withstand the weight of old Sun's cudgel, and changed itself into a water-snake and slithered off into the grass. I chased after it and found no trace."

The Earth-god said, "Great Sage, you don't know — this gorge has ten thousand passages all connecting through, which is why its currents run so deep and far. The dragon must have slipped away down one of them. There is no need for the Great Sage to rouse his temper hunting here. To

capture this creature, you need only invite the Bodhisattva Guanyin to come, and naturally it will submit."

Hearing this, Wukong called the Mountain-spirit and Earth-god to come with him to Tripitaka, and he laid out the whole matter. Tripitaka said, "But if we must go and invite the Bodhisattva, when will we ever get her back here? Your poor monk — how am I to endure the cold and hunger?" Before he had finished speaking, they heard the Gold-Headed Guardian call out of the empty air, "Great Sage, you need not stir from your place. Your humble spirit will go and invite the Bodhisattva."

Wukong was overjoyed and called out, "What trouble for you, what trouble! Go quickly, go quickly!" The Guardian at once mounted his cloud and flew straight up toward the Southern Sea. Wukong charged the Mountain-spirit and Earth-god to guard his master, sent the Day-Sentinel of the Hours to seek out provisions, and himself went back to patrol the gorge bank — but of that no more.

Now the Gold-Headed Guardian, riding his cloud, soon arrived at the Southern Sea. He pressed down his auspicious light and went straight into the Purple Bamboo Grove of Potalaka Mountain. There he had the gold-armored devas and Moksha the Hui'an page convey his message, and was at last granted an audience with the Bodhisattva.

The Bodhisattva said, "On what errand have you come?"

The Guardian said, "The Tang Monk, at Coiled-Snake Mountain by the Steep Hawk-Grief Gorge, has lost his horse, and the Great Sage Sun is so beset that he can move neither forward nor back. When they questioned the local earth-spirits, they were told that the wicked dragon the Bodhisattva placed in the gorge has swallowed it. So the Great Sage sent me to beg the Bodhisattva to subdue this wicked dragon and restore their horse."

Hearing this, the Bodhisattva said, "This creature is the son of Aorun, Dragon King of the Western Sea. Because he set fire to the bright pearls upon the palace hall, his father accused him of unfilial defiance, and in the Court of Heaven he was condemned to death. It was I who appeared before the Jade Emperor in person and pleaded for him, so that he might serve as the Tang Monk's mount and bearer. How is it that, on the contrary, he has eaten the Tang Monk's horse? If that is how it stands, then let me go myself."

The Bodhisattva descended from her lotus throne, left her immortal grotto, and with the Guardian rode upon the auspicious light, crossing over the Southern Sea. There are verses to attest it:

The Buddha preached the Paramita Tripitaka
scriptures; The Bodhisattva spread goodness to fill
the Long Wall. The Mahā wondrous words pass
through Heaven and Earth; The Prajñā true mantras
rescue ghost and spirit. Thereby the Golden Cicada
cast off his shell anew, And so Xuanzang was made
to cultivate again. Only because the road was barred
at Hawk-Grief Gorge, The dragon's son returned to
truth and took the form of a horse.

In no great while the Bodhisattva and the Guardian arrived at Coiled-Snake Mountain. There in mid-air they halted their auspicious cloud, and looking down, they saw Sun Wukong at the gorge's edge cursing and

railing. The Bodhisattva bade the Guardian go down and summon him. The Guardian brought his cloud down and, not pausing at Tripitaka's side, went straight to the gorge bank and said to Wukong, "The Bodhisattva has come."

Hearing this, Wukong sprang up on his cloud into the air and shouted at her, "You — teacher of the Seven Buddhas, compassionate founder of the faith — how could you cook up such a scheme to do me harm?"

The Bodhisattva said, "You insolent horse-monkey, you boorish bare-bottomed simpleton! With all my care I won you a scripture-pilgrim, again and again, and earnestly charged him to save your life. How is it that instead of coming to thank me for the grace of sparing you, you come here to make an uproar at me?"

Wukong said, "You've served me well indeed! When you set me free, you should have let me roam wherever I pleased and amuse myself in peace. The other day you met me upon the sea and wounded me with a few words, telling me to come and serve the Tang Monk with all my heart and strength — well and good. But why did you give him a flowered cap to trick me into wearing on my head, to suffer for it ever after? You've made this band grow fast into old Sun's very skull, and taught him besides some Tight-Band Spell. That old monk recites it again and again, and my head aches and aches — is this not your doing me harm?"

The Bodhisattva laughed and said, "You monkey! If you will not obey instruction and will not accept the true fruit, then unless you are bound in this way, you'll go deceiving Heaven and bullying your betters again — how would you ever know good from ill? If you go blundering into calamity as before, who would there be to take you in hand? Only by getting this demon-headband will you be willing to enter the gateway of my yoga."

Wukong said, "Well, count that affair as my own demon-band, then. But why have you taken that guilty wicked dragon and set it here to work mischief and eat my master's horse? This too is letting a wrongdoer loose to do evil — most unkind of you!"

The Bodhisattva said, "That dragon I personally petitioned the Jade Emperor for, and begged him to spare expressly so it might serve the scripture-seeker as a mount and bearer. Consider — how could a common horse from the Eastern Land ever survive ten thousand rivers and a thousand mountains? How could it ever reach the Buddha-land of Spirit Mountain? Only by getting this dragon-horse can the journey be made."

Wukong said, "But this creature fears old Sun so much that it skulks and will not come out — what's to be done?"

The Bodhisattva called to the Guardian, "Go down to the gorge bank and call out: 'Third Prince Jade Dragon, son of Dragon King Aorun, come forth — the Bodhisattva of the Southern Sea is here.' Then it will come out."

The Guardian went indeed to the gorge bank and called twice. The little dragon broke through the waves and leapt from the water, changing into human form. Treading a cloud, it rose into the air, bowed to the Bodhisattva, and said, "I thank the Bodhisattva for the grace of saving my life. I have waited here a long while, yet have heard no tidings of any scripture-pilgrim."

The Bodhisattva pointed at Wukong and said, "Is this not the chief disciple of the scripture-pilgrim?"

The little dragon looked and said, "Bodhisattva, this is my adversary! Yesterday, hungry in my belly, I truly ate his horse. Trusting in some

strength of his, he battled me until I lost heart and fled, and then cursed me until I dared not come out of my door. He never once mentioned a single word about seeking scriptures."

Wukong said, "You never asked me my surname or my name — how was I to say?"

The little dragon said, "Did I not ask you, 'What lout of a demon are you, come from where?' And you bawled, 'Never mind where from or not from — just give me back my horse!' When did you so much as utter half the word Tang?"

The Bodhisattva said, "That monkey-head trusts only in his own strength and is never willing to give another's name before his own. Going forward from here, there will be more who join you. When they ask, first bring up the words seeking scriptures, and then, without need of any toil, they will submit of themselves."

Wukong gladly accepted the teaching. The Bodhisattva stepped forward and plucked the bright pearl from beneath the little dragon's throat. Dipping her willow sprig in the sweet dew, she sprinkled it over the dragon's body, blew upon it a breath of immortal vapor, and cried, "Change!" At once the dragon changed into a horse with hair and markings exactly like the old white horse. Then she gave it her charge: "You must devote your whole heart to working off your karmic debt. When the merit is achieved, you shall rise above the rank of common dragons and be granted a golden body and the true fruit." The little dragon took the bit-bone crosswise in its mouth and assented with all its heart.

The Bodhisattva bade Wukong lead it to see Tripitaka. "I am returning to the sea," she said. But Wukong clutched at her and would not let go, crying, "I won't go on! I won't go on! The road to the West is so rugged,

and guarding this mortal monk — when will we ever arrive? With torments and tribulations like these, old Sun's own life is hard to keep whole — how am I ever to achieve any merit or fruit? I won't go on, I won't go on!"

The Bodhisattva said, "In years past, before you had attained the Way of man, you were still willing to cultivate enlightenment with all your heart. Now that you have escaped your heavenly calamity, how is it you turn so slothful? In our gate, it is by stilling and extinction that one attains the truth; you must keep faith to win the true fruit. If you should come to some place of bodily injury and bitter torment, I grant that you may call upon Heaven and Heaven will answer, call upon Earth and Earth will respond. And if at the very last you reach some pass from which there is no escape, I will come in person to save you. Come here — let me grant you one more power." The Bodhisattva plucked three leaves from her willow, set them at the back of Wukong's head, and cried, "Change!" At once they changed into three life-saving hairs. She told him, "When you come to a time of utter helplessness with no master to turn to, you may transform these as the moment requires, to rescue you from urgent and bitter calamity."

Hearing all these kind words, Wukong at last gave thanks to the greatly merciful, greatly compassionate Bodhisattva. And the Bodhisattva, wreathed in fragrant winds and drifting colored mists, turned straight back toward Potalaka and was gone.

Only then did Wukong bring his cloud down, grasp the dragon-horse by the forelock, and come to Tripitaka, saying, "Master, the horse is here."

The moment Tripitaka saw it he was greatly delighted and said, "Disciple, how is it this horse is even plumper and sleeker than before? Where did you find it?"

Wukong said, "Master, you must still be dreaming. Just now the Gold-Headed Guardian invited the Bodhisattva to come, and she transformed the dragon of the gorge into our white horse. The hair and markings are the same — only it lacks saddle and bridle. Old Sun has led it here."

Tripitaka was astonished and said, "Where is the Bodhisattva? Let me go and bow my thanks to her."

Wukong said, "By now the Bodhisattva has reached the Southern Sea — no use troubling yourself." Still, Tripitaka gathered up a pinch of earth for incense and bowed toward the south. His bows finished, he rose, and together with Wukong made ready to press on. Wukong dismissed the Mountain-spirit and Earth-god, gave his charges to the Guardian and the Sentinel, and then invited his master to mount.

Tripitaka said, "But how can one ride a horse without saddle or bridle? Let us wait and find a boat to cross the gorge, and then make further arrangements."

Wukong said, "What an impractical master you are! In this wild mountain waste, where would a boat come from? This horse has lived here a long while and must know the lay of the water. Just ride it, and let it carry you across."

Tripitaka, having no choice, did as he said and bestrode the dragon-horse. Wukong shouldered the baggage, and they came to the gorge bank. There, on the upper reach of the stream, they saw an old fisherman poling a raft of dead wood down along the current. When Wukong saw him, he beckoned and called, "Old fisher, come here, come here! I am from the Eastern Land, going to fetch the scriptures. My master has reached this place and cannot get across — come and ferry him over."

Hearing this, the fisherman at once poled in close. Wukong helped his master down from the horse and supported him on either side. Tripitaka

stepped onto the raft, the horse was led aboard, and the luggage was settled. The old fisherman poled the raft off, and swift as the wind, swift as an arrow, before they knew it they had crossed the Steep Hawk-Grief Gorge and come up on the western bank.

Tripitaka bade Wukong open the bundle, take out a few cash of Great Tang coin, and offer them to the old fisherman. But the old fisherman gave his raft a single shove with the pole and said, "I'll take no money, I'll take no money," and off he went into the midstream, dim and far away. Tripitaka felt most uneasy and kept pressing his palms together in thanks. Wukong said, "Master, no need to make so much of it. Don't you recognize him? He is the water-spirit of this gorge. He never came to meet old Sun, and old Sun was minded to beat him for it — letting him off the beating is reward enough. How would he dare take money?" The master half believed and half doubted, but could only mount the dragon-horse once more and follow Wukong, heading straight onto the main road and pressing west. Truly this is it:

By the broad and great True Suchness he gains the
far shore; With a sincere heart, his nature made
clear, he climbs Spirit Mountain.

As master and disciple journeyed on together, before they knew it the red sun sank into the west and the daylight grew late. Behold:

Pale clouds in disarray, the mountain moon grown dim;
A whole sky of frost-color breeds the cold, And
on every side the sound of wind pierces the body.
When the lone bird departs, the gray islet stretches wide;
Where the falling glow gleams bright, the far mountains lie low.
A thousand trees of the thin forest roar;
On the empty ridge a solitary gibbon cries.
Along the long road no trace of any traveler;
For ten thousand li the homeward boat enters the night.

Tripitaka, gazing afar from his horse, suddenly saw a manor by the roadside. He said, "Wukong, there is a household ahead. We might lodge there for the night and travel on at dawn."

Wukong raised his head and looked, then said, "Master, that is no household manor."

"How is it not?" said Tripitaka.

Wukong said, "A household manor has no ridge-beasts of soaring fish and crouching creatures on its roof. That is surely a temple or a hermitage."

While master and disciple were still talking, they had already reached the gate. Tripitaka dismounted and saw above the gate three great characters: "Shrine of the Local Earth-god." So he went in through the gate. Within

was an old man with a string of prayer-beads about his neck, who came forward with palms pressed together to welcome them, calling, "Master, please be seated."

Tripitaka hastily returned the courtesy, went up into the hall, and made his obeisance before the holy image. The old man then called a boy-attendant to bring tea. When the tea was finished, Tripitaka asked the old man, "Why is this shrine called the Local Earth-god's?"

The old man said, "This humble place lies within the borders of the country of Habi, in the western lands. Behind this temple is a manor of households, who all, with reverent hearts, raised up this shrine. *Li* means the soil of one village and district; *she* means the earth-god of one parish. At every season — spring plowing, summer weeding, autumn harvest, winter storing — each household prepares the three sacrificial beasts, with flowers and fruit, and comes here to sacrifice to the she-god, that the four seasons may be clear and auspicious, the five grains abundant, and the six kinds of livestock thriving."

Hearing this, Tripitaka nodded and praised it: "Truly, 'three li from home and already another district's ways.' Where I come from, the people have no such good custom."

The old man then asked, "Master, what blessed land is your home?"

Tripitaka said, "Your poor monk is from the country of Great Tang in the Eastern Land, sent by imperial decree to go to the Western Heaven to worship the Buddha and seek the scriptures. Passing your precious district as the sky grows late, I have come especially to your holy shrine to beg lodging for one night; at first light I will go on."

The old man was greatly pleased, said several times, "I have failed to welcome you properly," and again called the boy to prepare a meal. When

Tripitaka had eaten, he gave his thanks.

Now Wukong's eye was sharp, and he spied a clothesline hanging beneath the eaves. He went over, gave it a yank to break it off, and used it to tie the horse's legs. The old man laughed and said, "Where did you steal this horse?"

Wukong said angrily, "You old fellow, you don't know high from low! We are holy monks come to worship the Buddha — how would we steal a horse?"

The old man laughed. "If it isn't stolen, why has it no saddle, bridle, or rein, that you must come and break off my clothesline?"

Tripitaka made his apologies: "This rascal — he is only of a hasty temper. If you wanted to tie the horse, you should have asked the old gentleman nicely for a rope. Why break off his clothesline? — Old sir, don't take offense, don't take offense. This horse of mine — to tell you the truth — is no stolen beast. Yesterday, coming from the east, we reached the Steep Hawk-Grief Gorge, where I had a white horse to ride, complete with saddle and bridle. Unexpectedly there was a wicked dragon in that gorge, grown into a spirit, and it swallowed my horse, saddle and bridle, in one gulp. Luckily my disciple here has some powers, and we were favored by the Bodhisattva Guanyin, who came to the gorge bank to subdue that dragon and bade it change into the very white horse I used to ride — hair and markings all the same — to carry me to the West to worship the Buddha. We have only just now crossed the gorge, not yet a full day past, and have already come to your holy shrine; we have not yet had a chance to procure a saddle and bridle."

The old man said, "Master, don't take offense — your old fellow was only making a joke; who knew your honored disciple would take it in earnest. When I was young I had a bit of country money and rather liked to ride a

fine horse myself. But through years of misfortune — suffering bereavement and fire — I came at last to this state with nothing left, and so I serve as temple-keeper, tending the incense and getting by on the alms of the donor families of the manor behind. As it happens, I still have a saddle and bridle here — a thing I have cherished all my life, and even in this poverty I have never been willing to sell it. Now, hearing the venerable master's words — that even the Bodhisattva should rescue a divine dragon and turn it into a horse to bear you — how can your old man fail to lend a little help? Tomorrow I will fetch that saddle and bridle and gladly present them to the venerable master, to be fitted upon the horse's back for the road. I beg you to accept them with a smile."

Hearing this, Tripitaka thanked him without end. Soon the boy brought out the evening meal. When the meal was done, the lamps were lit, the bedding laid out, and each lay down to rest.

By early the next morning Wukong rose and said, "Master, that old temple-keeper promised us a saddle and bridle last night. Ask him for them, and don't let him off the hook." Before he had finished speaking, the old man indeed came bearing a saddle, bridle, saddle-cloth, rein, halter, and everything else needed for a horse — all complete — and set them down beneath the corridor, saying, "Master, I present the saddle and bridle."

When Tripitaka saw them he received them with delight, and bade Wukong take them up and put them on the horse to see whether they suited. Wukong stepped forward and lifted them one piece at a time to examine — they were indeed fine things. There are verses to attest it:

The carved saddle gleams bright with silver stars;
The precious stirrups flash their light, gold threads
ablaze. The saddle-cloth, layer on layer of folded
felt; The leading-rein, three plies of purple silk cord.
The bridle-head's leather worked with rosettes,
dazzling; The cloud-flaps drawn in gold, dancing
with beast-forms. The ring-bit forged of tempered,
well-hammered iron; And hanging down on both
sides, water-dipped tassels of hair.

In his heart Wukong was secretly pleased. He set the saddle and bridle upon the horse, and they fit as though made to measure. Tripitaka bowed his thanks to the old man, but the old man hastily raised him up, saying, "How embarrassing, how embarrassing! Why trouble yourself with thanks?" He did not detain them further, but invited Tripitaka to mount. The elder came out through the gate, took hold of the saddle, and climbed up. Wukong shouldered the luggage. The old man then drew from his sleeve a riding-whip — a handle of fragrant rattan studded with leather, and a lash strung and knotted of tiger-tendon silk — and standing by the roadside, offered it up with cupped hands, saying, "Holy monk, I have besides a hand-whip; let me give you that as well."

Tripitaka, on his horse, took it and said, "Many thanks for your charity, many thanks for your charity."

But just as he was exchanging these courtesies, all at once the old man was nowhere to be seen. And when he looked back at the Shrine of the Local Earth-god, there was nothing but a patch of bare ground. He heard only, from out of the air, a voice speaking: "Holy monk, forgive my poor reception. I am the Mountain-spirit and Earth-god of Potalaka Mountain, sent by the Bodhisattva to deliver the saddle and bridle to you. Strive on westward, and do not for a moment grow slack." In alarm Tripitaka tumbled out of the saddle and down from the horse, bowing toward the sky and saying, "Your disciple has but fleshly eyes and a mortal frame, and did not recognize the honored spirit's honored face. I beg ten thousand pardons. Pray convey my message to the Bodhisattva — I am deeply favored by her gracious protection." And there he was, knocking his head toward Heaven beyond all counting.

By the roadside the Great Sage Sun was fairly toppled over with laughter, beside himself with mirth — that fine Handsome Monkey King! He came forward and took hold of the Tang Monk, saying, "Master, get up. He's already gone far off — he can't hear your prayers, he can't see you knocking your head. What are you bowing for?"

The elder said, "Disciple, while I knock my head like this, you not only fail to bow even once, but stand there at the side grinning and sneering — what is the meaning of that?"

Wukong said, "What do you know of it? For one who plays hide-and-seek like this, head tucked and tail showing, he ought by rights to get a good beating! Only out of regard for the Bodhisattva's face do I spare him — that is quite enough. How would he dare receive old Sun's bow? From a boy, old Sun played the hero and never learned to bow to anyone. Even before the Jade Emperor and Lord Lao Zi I do no more than make a salute — that's the end of it."

Tripitaka said, "You graceless creature, don't talk such empty nonsense. Get up at once, and don't delay our journey." So the master rose, gathered up their things, and they set off toward the west.

From there they traveled two months of peaceful road, meeting only Lolo tribesmen, Hui folk, wolves, serpents, tigers, and leopards. Time sped swiftly by, and early spring came round again. They saw the mountain forests dressed in brocade green, grass and trees putting out their first bright sprouts; the plum blossoms all fallen, the willow's eyes just opening. As master and disciple traveled, taking pleasure in the spring scenery, once again they saw the sun sinking into the west. Tripitaka reined in his horse and gazed afar, and in a fold of the mountains made out the shadowy forms of towers and terraces, halls and pavilions sunk deep among the hills. He said, "Wukong, what sort of place do you see over there?"

Wukong raised his head and looked, then said, "That is no palace — it must surely be a monastery. Let us hurry on and beg lodging there for the night." Tripitaka gladly agreed, gave the dragon-horse its head, and headed straight toward it.

And after all, there is no knowing what sort of place this was that they went to — so listen to the explanation in the next chapter.

Chapter 16: The Monks of Guanyin

Temple Scheme for the Treasure

Now the story tells how master and disciple urged their horse onward until they came right up to the temple gate to take a look — and indeed it was a true monastery. Behold:

Hall upon hall, terrace upon terrace, cloister upon cloister, range upon range. Beyond the triple gate, ten thousand towering paths of bright-hued cloud hung veiled across the sky; before the Hall of the Five Blessings, a thousand strands of vivid red mist coiled and wreathed about. Pine and bamboo lined the two approaches; juniper and cypress filled a single grove. The pine and bamboo, ageless and unrecorded, kept their own clear and secluded calm; the juniper and cypress, rich in hue and color, stood proud and lovely as their nature pleased. One saw besides the high bell-and-drum tower, the steep and soaring pagoda spire. The meditating monks composed their natures still; the birds that cried among the trees sang idle and free. Lonely and dustless — truly a place of stillness; pure and void, possessed of the Way — and so truly pure and void.

A poem says:

A lofty cloister, a Jeta Grove hidden in green hollows, a sanctuary whose splendor rivals the world beyond. Indeed such Pure Lands are rare among mankind — of all the famous mountains under heaven, the monks claim most.

The elder dismounted; Pilgrim set down the carrying-pole. They were just about to step through the gate when out from within came a whole company of monks. Look at how they appeared:

On their heads, the left-pinned caps; on their bodies, the spotless robes. Bronze rings hung double from their ears; silken sashes bound their waists. Steady they came in their straw sandals, wooden fish gripped in their hands. Their mouths forever murmured the chants — all taking refuge in the Prajna.

When Tripitaka saw them he stood waiting respectfully beside the gate and offered a courteous greeting. The monks hastily returned his salute and said with a smile, "Forgive us for not noticing you sooner." Then they asked, "Where have you come from? Please come inside the abbot's quarters and take some tea." Tripitaka said, "I am a disciple of the

Buddha, sent by imperial commission from the Land of the East, bound for the Thunderclap Monastery to bow to the Buddha and seek the scriptures. Reaching this place as the day grows late, I should like to borrow the shelter of your noble temple for a single night." The monks said, "Please come in and be seated, please come in and be seated." Only then did Tripitaka call to Pilgrim to lead the horse inside.

But when the monks suddenly caught sight of Pilgrim's features, they grew rather afraid and asked, "What sort of thing is that, leading the horse?" Tripitaka said, "Softly, softly! He is quick-tempered. If he hears you call him a 'thing' he will take offense. He is my disciple." The monks gave a shiver and, biting their fingers, said, "Such an ugly, monstrous-looking head — and you took him as a disciple?" Tripitaka said, "You can't tell by looking. Ugly he may be, but he is exceedingly useful."

So the monks had no choice but to enter the gate together with Tripitaka and Pilgrim. Inside the gate, upon the main hall, they saw four great characters written: "Meditation Temple of Guanyin." Tripitaka rejoiced and said, "Time and again I have felt the holy grace of the Bodhisattva, yet never managed to give thanks. Now that I have come upon her meditation temple, it is as good as seeing the Bodhisattva herself — a fine chance to bow my gratitude." Hearing this, the monks at once ordered a lay servant to open the hall doors and invited Tripitaka to make his obeisance. Pilgrim tethered the horse, flung down the baggage, and went up into the hall with Tripitaka. Tripitaka stretched out his back and limbs, pressed his breast to the ground, and bowed his head before the golden image. The monks went to beat the drum; Pilgrim went to strike the bell. Tripitaka lay prostrate before the altar, pouring out his heart in prayer. When his prayers and bows were done, the monks left off the drum — but Pilgrim kept right on striking the bell without stopping, now fast, now slow, ringing it on for a good long while. The lay servant

said, "The worship is finished — why are you still ringing the bell?"

Pilgrim at last let go of the bell-hammer and laughed, "What would you know! This is a case of: 'Be a monk for a day, ring the bell for a day.'"

By this time the clanging had startled every monk in the temple, high and low, great and small. Hearing the wild ringing, they came crowding out together, crying, "What wild man is in here banging the bell and drum about?" Pilgrim leapt out and with a shout cried, "It's your Grandpa Sun, ringing it for sport!" When the monks saw him they tumbled and rolled in terror and groveled on the ground, crying, "Lord Thunder-God! Lord Thunder-God!" Pilgrim said, "The Thunder-God is my great-grandson. Get up, get up, don't be afraid. We are lords come from the Great Tang in the Land of the East." Only then did the monks make their bows. When they saw Tripitaka, their hearts were eased and they were afraid no longer. The abbot of the temple stepped forward and invited them, saying, "My lords, come to the abbot's quarters at the rear and take some tea." So they loosed the reins and led the horse, took up the baggage, passed around the main hall, and went straight into the rear chambers, where they sat in due order.

The abbot offered tea and then had a vegetarian meal prepared. The daylight was still early; Tripitaka had not finished expressing his thanks when from behind, two young acolytes came supporting an aged monk. See how he was got up:

On his head a Vairocana square cap, its cat's-eye gem-knob gleaming with light; on his body a brocaded velvet tunic, kingfisher-feathered with bright gold edging. A pair of monk's shoes set with the Eight Treasures, a single staff inlaid with cloud-and-star. His face all furrowed with wrinkles — like the Old Mother of Mount Li; his pair of dim and clouded eyes — like the Dragon Lord of the Eastern Sea. His mouth could not hold the wind, his teeth being gone; his back was bent and humped from cramping sinews.

The monks said, "Our Patriarch has come." Tripitaka bowed and offered his greeting: "Venerable Abbot, your disciple makes his salutation." The old monk returned the courtesy, and they sat together. The old monk said, "Just now the little ones told me that lords had come from the Tang court of the Land of the East — so I have come out to pay my respects." Tripitaka said, "I have intruded carelessly upon your noble mountain, knowing no better — forgive me, forgive me." The old monk said, "Do not say so, do not say so." Then he asked, "My lord, how many miles is it from the Land of the East to here?" Tripitaka said, "From the borders of Chang'an it is somewhat more than five thousand miles. Crossing the Mountain of Two Frontiers, I took on a young disciple; traveling on from there, I passed through the Western foreign kingdom of Habi, and after

two months and another five or six thousand miles, I have only now reached your honored place." The old monk said, "Then it is a journey of ten thousand miles and more. I, your disciple, have idled my whole life away and never so much as stepped beyond the temple gate — truly what they call 'sitting in a well to look at the sky,' a worthless and rotten old stump." Tripitaka then asked, "Venerable Abbot, what is your honored age?" The old monk said, "I have foolishly reached the age of two hundred and seventy." Pilgrim heard this and said, "Then he's still a grandson of mine, ten thousand generations removed." Tripitaka shot him a glare and said, "Mind your tongue! Do not go about not knowing high from low and offending people." Then the monk asked, "My lord, and how many years have you?" Pilgrim said, "I daren't say."

The old monk took this for mad talk, paid it no mind, and asked no further, but called for tea to be served. A little page brought out a tray of mutton-fat jade bearing three cloisonné teacups rimmed with gold. Another page carried a white-bronze pot and poured out three cups of fragrant tea — and truly its color shamed the pomegranate blossom for brightness, its flavor surpassed the cassia flower for sweetness. When Tripitaka saw it he praised it without end, saying, "Fine things, fine things — truly fine fare served in fine vessels." The old monk said, "They offend the eye, they offend the eye. My lord comes from the celestial Tang, a superior realm, and has gazed widely upon rare and precious things — what are vessels such as these, that you should overpraise them? My lord, coming from so great a land, surely you have some treasure you might let your disciple behold?" Tripitaka said, "Alas, in my Land of the East there is nothing of any worth; and even were there, the road is so long I could not have carried it." Pilgrim, at his side, spoke up: "Master, the other day in the bundle I saw that cassock of yours — is that not a treasure? Why not take it out and show it to him?" When the monks heard the word "cassock," every one of them gave a cold smile.

Pilgrim said, "What are you smirking at?" The abbot said, "My lord just now said a cassock is a treasure — those words are truly laughable. If we speak of cassocks, men like us have no fewer than twenty or thirty apiece; and as for our Patriarch, who has been a monk in this place for two hundred and fifty or sixty years, he has a good seven or eight hundred." And he called out, "Bring them forth to be seen!"

The old monk too, in a fit of showing off, ordered the lay servants to open the storeroom, and the ascetics carried out the chests — twelve in all — and set them down in the courtyard and unlocked them. Clothes-racks were erected on either side, ropes strung all around, and the cassocks shaken open one by one and hung up for Tripitaka to view. Indeed, the whole courtyard became a hall of damask embroidery, the four walls draped in silk and gauze.

Pilgrim looked them over one by one — all flower-stitched, brocade-padded, embroidered and gold-worked things — and laughed. "Good, good, good. Put them away, put them away. Now bring out ours for a look." Tripitaka caught hold of Pilgrim and said softly, "Disciple, do not go contesting wealth with people. You and I are alone out here; I only fear something may go wrong." Pilgrim said, "Where is the harm in simply looking at a cassock?" Tripitaka said, "You do not understand. The ancients had a saying: 'A rare and precious treasure must not be shown to the greedy and the false.' Once it meets the eye, it stirs the heart; once the heart is stirred, schemes are born. If they demand it, you must answer their demand; otherwise ruin of body and loss of life may all spring from this one act. It is no small matter." Pilgrim said, "Rest easy, rest easy — it is all on old Sun's shoulders."

Look at him — without another word he went hurrying off, undid the bundle, and at once rays of rosy light came bursting forth, for two wrappings of oiled paper still enclosed it. He stripped off the paper and

took out the cassock, and when he shook it open, red light flooded the room and colored vapors swirled through the courtyard. When the monks beheld it, there was not one whose heart did not leap and whose mouth did not pour out praise. Truly a fine cassock! Upon it:

A thousand cunning marvels, hung with bright pearls; ten thousand rarities, clustered with the Buddha's gems. Above and below, dragon-whiskers spread the colored damask; on all four sides, tula-cotton bordered the brocade. Wear it, and goblins and demons are thereby destroyed; don it, and ogres and sprites are sent to the Yellow Springs. A transformed celestial wrought it with her own hands — none but a true monk dares to put it on.

When the old monk beheld so rich a treasure, his heart was seized at once with wicked greed. He stepped forward, knelt down before Tripitaka, and with tears streaming from his eyes said, "Your disciple is truly luckless." Tripitaka raised him up and said, "Venerable Abbot, what have you to say?" He said, "My lord, this treasure of yours has only just been spread out, yet the day has grown dark, and alas, my eyes are dim and clouded so that I cannot see it clearly — is that not to be luckless?" Tripitaka said, "Bring up a lamp, and you may look again." The old monk said, "My lord's treasure is already radiant; light a lamp on top of that and it will only dazzle the more, and I shall never make it out clearly." Pilgrim said, "How would you like to look at it, then?" The old monk said, "My

lord, if in your broad mercy you would set your heart at ease and let your disciple take it to the rear chamber to study carefully through the night, I would return it to you tomorrow morning to send you on your way westward. I do not know what your honored will may be?" Hearing this, Tripitaka started and reproached Pilgrim, "It is all your doing, all your doing!" Pilgrim laughed, "What is there to fear from him? Let me wrap it up and let him take it away to look at. If there is any mishap, old Sun will see to it all." Tripitaka could not stop him; he handed the cassock to the old monk and said, "As you please, look at it — only return it to me tomorrow morning exactly as it is, with not the least bit of damage or stain." The old monk, full of joy, had a page carry the cassock inside. Then he instructed the monks to sweep clean the front meditation hall, fetch two rattan beds, lay out bedding, and invite the two lords to rest; and on the other hand had them prepare a morning meal to see them off. So all dispersed, and master and disciple shut up the meditation hall and lay down to sleep — of which no more.

Now the story tells how the old monk, having cheated the cassock into his hands, carried it to the rear chamber, set it under the lamp, and there wept and wailed so bitterly that the monks of the temple dared not go to sleep ahead of him. Even the little page did not know why, and went to report to the others, saying, "Grandfather has wept until the second watch and still will not stop." Two grand-disciples whom the old monk dearly loved came forward and asked, "Master, why do you weep?" The old monk said, "I weep at my own ill luck — that I cannot look upon the Tang Monk's treasure." The young monks said, "Grandfather, you have gone overboard in your old age. His cassock lies right before you; you need only undo it and look — why all this bitter weeping?" The old monk said, "But I cannot look at it for long. This year I am two hundred and seventy, and for nothing have I scraped together several hundred cassocks. How shall I ever come by one like his? How shall I ever become

a Tang Monk?" The young monks said, "Grandfather, you are mistaken. The Tang Monk is a wandering pilgrim who has left his home and forsaken his native land. You, at your great age, enjoying such comforts — that should surely be enough; yet you wish to become a wandering pilgrim like him? Why?" The old monk said, "Though I sit at home in ease and delight in the comforts of my declining years, I shall never get to wear his cassock. If you could let me wear it for but a single day, I would close my eyes in death content — it would mean I had been a monk to some purpose in this mortal world." The young monks said, "What nonsense. If you want to wear his, where is the difficulty? We will keep him here a day tomorrow and you wear it for a day; keep him ten days and you wear it for ten days — and that is that. Why this bitter weeping?" The old monk said, "Even if we kept him a year, I could wear it only for a year; in the end I would not have it for good. When he means to go, we would just have to let him go — how can we keep it forever?"

While they were talking, a little monk named Guangzhi — Broad Wisdom — put himself forward and said, "Grandfather, if you want it forever, that is easy enough." The old monk, hearing this, brightened at once and said, "My child, what brilliant notion have you?" Guangzhi said, "Those two Tang men are travelers, utterly worn out from the road, and by now they are fast asleep. Let us gather a few strong fellows, take spears and knives, break open the meditation hall, and kill them. We will bury the corpses in the back garden, and only our own household will know. Then we make off with the white horse and the baggage besides, and keep the cassock here as a family heirloom forever — is that not a plan for the lasting prosperity of our descendants?" When the old monk heard this he was overjoyed, and wiping away his tears he said, "Good, good, good — this plan is masterly!" And he set about readying spears and knives.

But among them was another little monk named Guangmou — Broad Scheme — the younger brother in faith of Guangzhi, who stepped forward and said, "This plan will not do. If you mean to kill them, you must first see how things stand. That white-faced one looks easy enough, but that hairy-faced one looks hard. If by chance we fail to kill him, will we not bring disaster down on ourselves instead? I have a method that uses neither blade nor spear — I do not know how it sits with your honored will." The old monk said, "My child, what method is that?" Guangmou said, "By your grandson's reckoning, let us now summon the heads of all the dormitories on the eastern hill, great and small, and have each bring one bundle of dry firewood. We will sacrifice those three rooms of the meditation hall and set them ablaze, so that the men have no door by which to flee, and burn them, horse and all. Even if the households before and behind the mountain see it, they will only say the men were careless themselves and let a fire get loose that burned down our meditation hall. Will not both monks be burned to death? And it neatly hoodwinks everyone besides. Will the cassock not then be our heirloom treasure?" When the monks heard this, not one was not delighted, and they all said, "Strong, strong, strong — this plan is even better, even better!" So they ordered the dormitory heads to carry firewood over. Alas! This one scheme was precisely the cause that:

the long-lived old monk was fated to meet his end,
and the Meditation Temple of Guanyin was to be
turned to dust.

It turned out that within this temple there were seventy or eighty dormitories, and great and small the monks numbered more than two hundred. That very night they came crowding to haul firewood, piling it

all around the meditation hall, front and back, hemming in all four sides until there was no way through, making ready to set the fire — of which no more.

Now the story tells how master and disciple had settled down to rest. But Pilgrim, being a spirit-monkey, though he had lain down was only nourishing his spirit and refining his breath, his eyes drowsing half-awake. Suddenly he heard people moving about outside without cease, and the rustling and crackling of firewood borne on the rising wind. His heart grew suspicious, and he thought, "It is the dead of night and all is still — how is it there are footsteps? Could it be thieves and robbers come to do us harm?" In one bound he sprang up, meaning to open the door and go out to look — but feared to wake his master. So watch him work his wonders: with a shake of his body he changed into a honeybee. Truly:

Sweet-mouthed and venom-tailed, slim of waist and light of frame. Threading flowers, skimming willows, it flies like an arrow; clinging to catkins, seeking fragrance, it falls like a star. Its tiny little body can bear a heavy load; its faint and humming wings can ride upon the wind. Out from beneath the rafter-edge it slipped, to see the matter plain.

He saw the whole crowd of monks hauling firewood and dragging straw, already ringing the meditation hall and setting it alight. Pilgrim laughed to himself, "So it is just as my master said! They want our lives and

scheme for my cassock — that is why they have conceived this poisonous plot. I would like to take my cudgel and beat them, but the pitiful wretches cannot stand a beating; one round of the cudgel and I would kill them all, and then my master would blame me for cruelty. Enough, enough, enough — I will do them a 'lead the sheep away as the hand passes,' turn their own scheme against them, and see to it they cannot go on living here!"

Good Pilgrim! With one somersault he leapt up to the Southern Heaven Gate. The startled guardians Pang, Liu, Gou, and Bi bowed; Ma, Zhao, Wen, and Guan arched their backs, all crying, "This is bad, this is bad! The one who made havoc in Heaven has come again!" Pilgrim waved his hand and said, "My lords, spare the ceremony — do not be alarmed. I have come looking for the Broad-Eyed Heavenly King." He had hardly finished when the Heavenly King himself arrived, and coming to meet Pilgrim said, "Long time, long time! I heard lately that the Bodhisattva Guanyin came to see the Jade Emperor and borrowed the Four Duty-Gods, the Six Ding and Six Jia, the Revealers and the rest, to guard the Tang Monk on his journey west to fetch the scriptures — and that you had become his disciple. How is it you have found the leisure to come here today?" Pilgrim said, "Never mind catching up. The Tang Monk has met evil men on his road who have set a fire to burn him — the matter is desperate beyond measure. I have come specially to borrow your Fire-Averting Cover to save him. Quick, hand it over for me to use, and I will return it at once." The Heavenly King said, "You have it wrong. If evil men have set a fire, you should borrow water to save him — why a fire-averting cover?" Pilgrim said, "How would you know the inside of it? Borrow water to save it, and the fire would never catch — which would only suit them. No, I will use this cover to shield the Tang Monk from harm, and the rest I do not care about — let it all burn. Quick, quick! By now I fear it may already be too late — do not spoil the business I have

below." The Heavenly King laughed, "This monkey is still as unkindly-minded as ever — he looks only to his own and cares nothing for others." Pilgrim said, "Hurry, hurry, do not wag your tongue and wreck the whole affair!" The Heavenly King dared not refuse, and so handed the cover over to Pilgrim.

Pilgrim took it and, pressing down the head of his cloud, came straight to the ridgepole of the meditation hall and covered over the Tang Monk, the white horse, and the baggage. Then he went and sat upon the roof of the rear abbot's chamber where the old monk lodged, to protect the cassock. When he saw the men start the fire, he turned and made a magic sign, recited a spell, and facing the southeast drew in a breath and blew it out — and a gust of wind sprang up that fanned the flames into a roaring blaze. Fine fire, fine fire! Behold:

Black smoke spreading thick, red flames leaping high. Black smoke spreading thick — in all the vast sky not a single star; red flames leaping high — the whole earth lit, a thousand miles of red. At first, glittering golden serpents; after, fierce and bloody horses. The Three Spirits of the South display their valor, and Huilu, the great Fire-God, plies his power. Dry tinder kindled the fierce nature of the blaze — what need to speak of Suiren drilling wood? Hot oil before the gate scattered colored flames, outdoing the Patriarch when he opened his furnace. Truly when heartless fire breaks out, how can it withstand a willful wickedness? Far from quelling the disaster, it abetted the cruelty. Wind followed the fire's force — flames flew a thousand fathoms high; fire borrowed the wind's might — ashes burst beyond the ninefold clouds. Crack and bang, like firecrackers at year's end; sputter and crackle, like cannon-fire in the camp. It burned so that the Buddha-images in the hall could not

escape, and the temple-guardians of the eastern courts had nowhere to hide. It outdid the night-long battle at Red Cliff, it surpassed the fire within the Epang Palace.

This was indeed a case of a single spark able to set ablaze ten thousand acres of field. In a moment the wind raged and the fire flourished, and the whole Temple of Guanyin glowed red from end to end. Look at the crowd of monks — hauling chests and lugging baskets, snatching tables and clutching pots — the whole courtyard filled with wails of misery rising to heaven. Sun the Pilgrim guarded the rear abbot's chamber, the fire-averting cover shielded the front meditation hall, and all the rest, front and back, blazed in a great conflagration — red flames glaring brilliant to the sky, golden light shining through the very walls.

It happened that, as the fire rose, it disturbed a beast-fiend of the mountains. Some twenty miles due south of the Temple of Guanyin there stood a Black Wind Mountain, and within it a Black Wind Cave, and in the cave there dwelt a goblin who had just woken from sleep and was turning over. Seeing brightness through the window, he took it for daybreak; but rising to look, he found it was the glare of a fire to the north below. The goblin was greatly startled and said, "Aha! That must be a fire broken out at the Temple of Guanyin. What careless monks! Let me go and lend them a hand to put it out." Good goblin — he leapt up on his cloud and came straight down beneath the smoke and flame. Truly the fire reached to the sky; the halls in front stood empty, while the two cloisters were just then alight with smoke and fire. He strode in with great steps, and was just calling for water to be brought when he saw that the rear chamber had no fire, and that on its roof-ridge a man sat

raising the wind. At this he understood how things stood, and hurried inside to look — and saw in the midst of the abbot's chamber a rosy glow and colored vapors, and on the writing-table a bundle wrapped in green felt. He undid it and looked, and saw it was a brocade cassock, a rare treasure of the Buddhist gate. Truly, "wealth stirs the human heart": he no longer fought the fire, no longer called for water, but seized the cassock and, taking advantage of the uproar to loot, drew back his cloud-steps and went straight off to the eastern mountain.

That fire burned only until the fifth watch and the break of day, and then at last died out. Look at the crowd of monks — stark naked and stripped bare, weeping and wailing, all going to search the ashes for copper and iron, raking through the rotted charcoal, scrabbling for gold and silver. Some, within the broken walls, propped up makeshift sheds; some, at the foot of a scorched wall, set up pots to cook their rice. They cried out their wrongs and their grievances, jabbering and quarreling in confusion — of which no more.

Now the story tells how Pilgrim took the fire-averting cover and with one somersault sent it back up to the Southern Heaven Gate, handing it over to the Broad-Eyed Heavenly King with thanks: "Thank you for the loan, thank you for the loan." The Heavenly King took it back and said, "The Great Sage is most honest. I was just worrying you wouldn't return my treasure and I'd have nowhere to seek it — and to my joy, here you bring it back." Pilgrim said, "Is old Sun the sort to swindle a thing to its owner's face? This is what they call: 'Borrow well and return well, and the next loan comes easily.'" The Heavenly King said, "We haven't met in a long while — won't you come into my palace and sit a moment?" Pilgrim said, "Old Sun isn't as he was in the old days, lounging on broken benches and holding forth in lofty talk. Now I'm guarding the Tang Monk and have no leisure. Some other time, some other time." Hastily he took

his leave and dropped down on his cloud, and saw the sun-star already rising. He came straight back before the meditation hall, shook his body and changed into a honeybee, flew inside, and resuming his true form to look, found his master still sound asleep.

Pilgrim called out, "Master, it's daylight — get up." Only then did Tripitaka wake, and turning over he said, "So it is." He put on his clothes, opened the door, and stepped out — and lifting his head, suddenly saw nothing but toppled walls and reddened brick, the towers and halls all gone. Greatly alarmed, he cried, "Aiya! How is it the halls are all gone, and everything is blackened brick and red char? What has happened?" Pilgrim said, "You're still dreaming. There was a fire here tonight." Tripitaka said, "How is it I knew nothing of it?" Pilgrim said, "It was old Sun who guarded the meditation hall; seeing the master deep in sleep, I didn't disturb you." Tripitaka said, "If you had the power to guard the meditation hall, why then did you not save the other rooms from the fire?" Pilgrim laughed, "Let me tell you the truth, master: it was just as you said yesterday. They coveted our cassock and plotted to burn us to death. If old Sun hadn't been aware of it, by now we'd be nothing but charred bones." Hearing this, Tripitaka was afraid and said, "Was it they who set the fire?" Pilgrim said, "If not they, then who?" Tripitaka said, "Could it not be that they slighted you, and this is some doing of yours?" Pilgrim said, "Is old Sun so worthless a fellow as to do such a base thing? It was truly their household that set the fire. Old Sun, seeing their hearts were poisonous, indeed did not help put it out — I only helped them along with a little wind." Tripitaka said, "Heavens, heavens! When fire breaks out you should help with water — how could you turn and help it with wind?" Pilgrim said, "You know the ancients' saying: 'If a man bears no harming heart toward the tiger, the tiger bears no harming mind toward the man.' Had they not played with fire, how would I have stooped to play with wind?" Tripitaka said, "Where is the cassock? It's

surely not burned, is it?" Pilgrim said, "It's all right, it's all right — it can't have burned; the abbot's chamber where the cassock was kept had no fire." Tripitaka said resentfully, "I'll have none of your excuses. If there's the least bit of damage to it, I'll just recite that little spell of mine over and over — and you'll be a dead monkey." Pilgrim took fright and said, "Master, don't recite, don't recite — I'll see to it your cassock is found and returned, that's all. Just let me go and fetch it, and we'll be on our way." Then Tripitaka led the horse and Pilgrim shouldered the load, and they came out of the meditation hall and went straight to the rear abbot's chamber.

Now the story tells how the monks, in the very midst of their grief, suddenly saw master and disciple come leading their horse and shouldering their burden, and were so terrified that the souls fled from every one of them. "The wronged ghosts have come to claim our lives!" Pilgrim shouted, "What wronged ghosts claiming lives? Quick, return my cassock!" The monks all fell to their knees together, kowtowing and saying, "My lord, a wrong has its wronger, a debt has its debtor. If you've come to claim lives, it's no concern of ours — it was Guangmou and the old monk who laid the plot to harm you; don't seek your payment from us!" Pilgrim gave a snort and said, "I'll have at you, you death-deserving beasts — who's asking any of you for a life? Just hand over the cassock and let us be on our way!" Among them were two monks of greater courage who said, "My lord, you were already burned to death in the meditation hall — and now you come again asking for the cassock. Are you truly men, or ghosts?" Pilgrim laughed, "You spawn of sin — where's there any fire? Go to the front and have a look at the meditation hall, then come back and talk." The monks scrambled up and went to look, and the doors and windows and lattices of the meditation hall had not been so much as singed. The crowd was awestruck, and only then did they recognize that Tripitaka was a holy monk of divine breed and

Pilgrim a venerable guardian of the Law. Together they came forward, kowtowing and saying, "We had eyes but no pupils and failed to know the true men come down to the world. Your cassock is at the rear, in the abbot's chamber, with the old Patriarch." Tripitaka passed by three or five layers of ruined walls and broken partitions, sighing without end. And indeed the abbot's chamber had no fire. The monks rushed inside and called out, "Grandfather, the Tang Monk is a divine being and was not burned to death — and now you've only ruined your own household's property. Hurry and bring out the cassock and return it to him."

It turned out that the old monk could not find the cassock, and had besides burned down the temple's own buildings, and was in a state of utter vexation and feverish distress. Hearing these words, how could he dare to answer? Finding no way out, with no road forward or back, he flung open his stride, bent his back, and dashed his head with all his force against the wall — and pitiable to tell, he only smashed his skull and spilled his brains, his soul scattered, his throat's breath cut off, dyeing the red earth crimson. There is a poem to prove it. The poem says:

Lament the old monk, his nature dull and benighted, who lived in vain his span as a graybeard of the world. He wished the cassock to pass to far-off ages — how could he know the Buddha's gem is no common thing? Taking the easy way, he thought to make it last; but bleakness and ruin were sure to be his reward. What use were Broad Wisdom and Broad Scheme in the end? To harm others for one's own gain comes all to nothing.

The horrified monks wept, crying, "Grandfather has dashed himself to death, and still the cassock is nowhere to be seen — what are we to do?" Pilgrim said, "I suppose you lot have stolen and hidden it. Come out, all of you, and draw up a register of every name, so old Sun can check you off one by one." The abbots of the upper and lower dormitories drew up two registers of the temple's monks, ascetics, pages, and lay servants — high and low, great and small, two hundred and thirty persons in all. Pilgrim asked his master to sit in the high seat, while he himself called the names over from the top one by one, having each open the lapels of his robe and pass clearly through inspection — but there was no cassock. He then searched again, item by item, through all the chests and boxes and goods the dormitory heads had snatched out — but nowhere was there any trace of it.

Tripitaka's heart was vexed, and his resentment of Pilgrim was endless; sitting up above, he began to recite the spell. Pilgrim toppled flat to the

ground with a thud, clutched his head in unbearable agony, and could only cry, "Don't recite, don't recite — I'll see the cassock found and returned!" When the monks saw it, every one of them trembled with fear and came forward to kneel and plead, and only then did Tripitaka close his mouth and cease. Pilgrim sprang up with a bound, whipped the iron cudgel from his ear, and was about to strike the monks, but Tripitaka shouted him down: "You monkey-head! Your head still aches, and you're still afraid of nothing? Stay your hand — don't harm anyone — and question them once more for me." The monks kowtowed and bowed, beseeching Tripitaka, "My lord, spare our lives! We truly never saw it. This is all the fault of that dead old wretch. Last night, gazing on your cassock, he wept until the deep watches, and dared not so much as look away, for he was scheming to keep it forever and make it an heirloom treasure for his line. He laid the plot and fixed the plan to burn you, my lord, to death. From the moment the fire arose, a wild wind blew up, and every man looked only to fighting the fire and snatching out the goods — none of us knows where the cassock went."

Pilgrim was greatly enraged. He strode into the abbot's chamber, dragged out the corpse of the wretch who had dashed himself to death, stripped it bare and examined it closely — but nowhere on the body was that treasure. He dug down three feet into the floor of the abbot's chamber — but there was not a shadow of it. Pilgrim pondered a good while, then asked, "Is there any goblin or fiend hereabouts that has become a spirit?" The abbot said, "My lord, had you not asked, we'd never have thought to tell you. Due southeast of here there stands a Black Wind Mountain, and within the Black Wind Cave there lives a Black Great King. This dead old wretch used often to discuss the Way with him — and he is a goblin. There is nothing else of the sort." Pilgrim said, "How far is that mountain from here?" The abbot said, "Only twenty miles — that mountain peak you can see yonder is the one." Pilgrim laughed, "Set your heart at ease,

master, no need to say more. Beyond a doubt it's that black fiend who's stolen it." Tripitaka said, "His place is twenty miles from here — how can you be so sure it's him?" Pilgrim said, "You didn't see the fire in the night — its light surged ten thousand miles, its brightness pierced the threefold heavens. Never mind twenty miles, it would have been seen at two hundred. It stands fixed that he saw the dazzling glare of the fire and, seizing the chance, came secretly here; and seeing our cassock was a treasure, he surely took advantage of the uproar to carry it off. Let old Sun go and look for him." Tripitaka said, "If you go, on whom am I to rely?" Pilgrim said, "Have no fear of that — in the unseen there are spirits to protect you, and in the seen I'll have these monks wait upon you." At once he called the monks over and said, "Some of you go and bury that old ghost; the rest wait upon my master and tend my white horse." The monks assented.

Pilgrim went on, "And don't you go answering me with your lips only and then, once I'm gone, fail to attend him. Those who look after my master must wear cheerful, pleasant faces; those who tend the white horse must keep his water and fodder evenly supplied. If there's the least thing amiss, here's the kind of cudgel I'll show you." He drew out his cudgel and, against the fire-scorched brick wall, gave a single thump—smashing the wall to powder, the shock toppling seven or eight courses of brickwork besides. When the monks saw it, every one of them went soft in the bones and limp in the body, and they knelt kowtowing with streaming tears, crying, "My lord, go in peace—we will serve our lord with all our strength and a true heart, and dare not be in the least remiss."

Good Pilgrim! He swiftly mounted his somersault cloud and rose straight up toward Black Wind Mountain to seek the cassock. Truly it was that:

The Golden Dhyana sought the right and left the capital lands, staff in hand, turned westward, crossing the green ranges. Where tigers, leopards, wolves, and serpents roamed at large, merchants, craftsmen, scholars, travelers were rarely seen. On the road he met the foolish monk of a foreign land, all envy; he leaned wholly on the might of the Great Sage Equal to Heaven. Fire broke out, wind arose, the meditation temple lay in ruin; and a black bear by night stole the brocade-bordered robe.

After all, this journey—whether the cassock be found or no, and whether the outcome be fortune or ill—listen to the next chapter told.

Chapter 17: The Black Wind Mountain and the Bear Who Stole the Treasure Coat

When Sun Wukong leapt up into the air with a single somersault, the monks of the Guanyin Temple—great and small alike, together with the ascetics, the serving boys, and the Daoist hangers-on—were so terrified that every one of them bowed toward heaven and cried out, "Master, oh Master! So he was a holy one come down to earth, riding the clouds and harnessing the mist—no wonder fire could not harm him. Curse that

blind old skinflint of ours, who schemed and plotted with his crafty heart, and today has only brought ruin upon himself."

Tripitaka said, "Rise, gentlemen, and trouble yourselves no further with cursing. If we recover the cassock, the whole matter is finished. But should it not be found, my disciple has something of a difficult temper, and I do not know what may become of your lives—I fear not one of you would escape." Hearing these words, the monks were each gripped with dread. They called upon heaven and made vows, asking only that the cassock be found so that their lives might be spared. But of this no more.

Now the Great Sage, having risen into the void, gave his waist a single twist and arrived at once upon Black Wind Mountain. Halting his cloud, he looked carefully about him, and indeed it was a fine mountain—and the season being the full glory of spring, this was what he saw:

Ten thousand ravines vie in their streaming, a thousand cliffs contend in their splendor. Birds call, yet no man is seen; blossoms fall, yet the trees keep their fragrance. After rain, the sky meets the green wall's gleam; wind comes, and the pines unfurl a kingfisher screen. Mountain grasses sprout, wild flowers open upon hanging cliffs and sheer ridges; creeping vines grow, lovely trees shine over towering ranges and level downs. No hermit is met—then who shall seek the woodcutter? Beside the brook two cranes drink; upon the rocks the wild apes run mad. Heaped and heaped, the conch-shell peaks arrayed in dark eyebrow-hue; lofty and lofty, embracing emerald, toying with the haze's light.

While the Pilgrim was admiring the mountain scenery, he suddenly heard voices drifting up from the slope of fragrant grass before him. Lightly he crept forward, treading in stealth, and slipped beneath an overhang of rock to peer out with a sidelong eye. There he saw three fiends sitting upon the ground. At the head sat a swarthy fellow; to his left was a Daoist; to his right was a scholar dressed in white. All three were holding forth grandly, discoursing on setting up cauldrons and tending furnaces, on rolling cinnabar and refining mercury, on "white

snow" and "yellow sprouts"—the heterodox arts of the side-doors and outer ways.

In the midst of their talk, the swarthy fellow laughed and said, "The day after tomorrow is the anniversary of my mother's travail—my birthday. I trust you two gentlemen will favor me with your presence." The scholar in white replied, "Year after year we have come to wish the Great King long life; how could this year be any different?" The swarthy fellow said, "Last night I came into a treasure—a Buddha-robe of brocade, called the Cassock of the Embroidered Gauze. It is truly a marvelous thing to delight in. Tomorrow I mean to make it the centerpiece of my festivities: I shall throw open a grand banquet, invite the Daoist officials of every mountain, and celebrate the Buddha-robe. We shall call it the 'Buddha-Robe Assembly.' What say you?" The Daoist laughed, "Splendid, splendid, splendid! Tomorrow I shall come first to offer my birthday wishes, and the day after I shall return for the feast."

When the Pilgrim heard the words "Buddha-robe," he was certain at once that this was his cassock. He could not contain his fury. Bounding out from beneath the rock, he raised the golden-banded cudgel in both hands and shouted, "I'll have at you, you pack of thieving fiends! You stole my cassock, and now you mean to hold some Buddha-Robe Assembly? Bring it back to me this instant!" With a roar of "Don't run!" he whirled the cudgel and brought it crashing down toward their heads. In a panic the swarthy fellow turned to wind and fled; the Daoist mounted a cloud and was gone; and only the scholar in white was caught by the blow and struck dead. Dragging the body over to examine it, the Pilgrim found it was a white-flowered serpent-spirit. For good measure he hoisted it up and tore it into five or six pieces. Then he pressed straight into the deep mountain to hunt down the swarthy fellow.

Rounding a sharp peak and skirting a steep ridge, he came upon a sheer cliff before which a cave-dwelling rose up. And this was the sight of it:

Mists and rosy vapors, faint and far; pines and cypress, dense and deep. Mists and vapors, faint and far, fill the gateway with their gleam; pines and cypress, dense and deep, ring the doors in green. The bridge is trodden over a weathered, withered log; the peak's crown is wound about with creeping vine. Birds bearing red petals fly to the cloudy ravine; deer treading the fragrant thickets climb the stone terrace. Before that gate the seasons hasten the flowers to bloom, and the wind carries their scent abroad. Along the dyke green willows turn to golden orioles; beside the bank tender peaches flutter the powdered moths. Though a wild and open place, not to be boasted of, still it rivals the scenes below the Penglai hills.

The Pilgrim came to the gate and found two leaves of stone door shut fast. Above the door was a horizontal slab of stone, plainly inscribed with six great characters: "Black Wind Cave of Black Wind Mountain." At once he raised his cudgel and shouted, "Open the door!" Inside, a little imp

who kept the gate pulled it open and came out, asking, "Who are you, that dares to come pounding upon our immortal cave?" The Pilgrim cursed him: "You death-courting beast! What sort of place is this, that you dare call it an 'immortal cave'? Is the word 'immortal' yours to claim? Get back inside and report to your swarthy master—tell him to send out your old grandfather's cassock at once, and I'll spare the whole nestful of your lives."

The little imp ran hurriedly back inside and reported, "Great King, the Buddha-Robe Assembly cannot go forward—there is a hairy-faced, thunder-god-beaked monk at the gate demanding a cassock." Now the swarthy fellow, having been chased home from the fragrant-grass slope by the Pilgrim, had only just barred his door and had not yet settled himself when he heard this report. He thought to himself, "I don't know where this fellow has come from, that he should be so insolent as to come bawling at my very door." He called for his armor, and when he had buckled it on he took up a black-tasseled spear and strode out the gate. The Pilgrim slipped to one side, gripped his iron cudgel, opened his eyes wide, and looked—and indeed the monster was ferociously made:

A bowl-shaped iron helmet, lacquer-bright; black-gold armor, dazzling and brilliant. A black silk gown girt with a wind-flap sleeve, a dark-green silken sash, its tassels long. In his hand a single black-tasseled spear; on his feet a pair of black-leather boots. His eyes flashed golden pupils like lightning — truly this was the Black Wind King of the mountain.

The Pilgrim laughed to himself: "This fellow looks for all the world like one fresh from a kiln, no different from a coal-heaver—he must make his living shoveling charcoal here. How else could he be so black from head to foot?" The monster shouted in a stern voice, "What sort of monk are you, that you dare be so bold in this place of mine?" The Pilgrim, gripping his iron cudgel, rushed up to his face and bellowed, "No idle chatter! Give back your old grandsire's cassock, and be quick about it!" The monster said, "From what temple are you a monk? Where did you lose this cassock of yours, that you dare come demanding it from me?"

The Pilgrim said, "My cassock was kept in the rear abbot's quarters of the Guanyin Temple, due north of here. Because that temple caught fire, you took the chance amid the uproar to loot and plunder, and you stole it away to hold your Buddha-Robe Assembly in celebration of your birthday. How dare you deny it? Give it back quickly, and I'll spare your life. But if you so much as let half a 'No' grind out between your teeth, I'll

topple Black Wind Mountain, trample Black Wind Cave flat, and grind every fiend in this den to powder."

When the monster heard this, he laughed coldly. "Ho, ho! So you reckless creature—it was you who set last night's fire, then. You worked your mischief upon that abbot's rooftop, raising the wind, and it was I who carried off a single cassock. What of it? Where do you come from? What is your surname and name? What manner of powers have you, that you dare spout such vast boasting and reckless talk?" The Pilgrim said, "It seems you don't even recognize your own grandfather. Your grandfather is the disciple of the Imperial Younger Brother, the Tripitaka Master who serves before the throne of the Great Tang in the Upper Kingdom. My surname is Sun, my name is Wukong, the Pilgrim. And if you ask after old Sun's powers—why, once I tell them out, they'll scatter your soul and shatter your wits, and you'll die where you stand." The monster said, "I've never had the acquaintance. What powers have you? Tell them out and let me hear." The Pilgrim laughed, "My boy, stand still and listen carefully:

From my youth my powers and arts were high;
riding the wind, I changed and transformed, a hero
bold. I nurtured my nature and cultivated truth,
enduring the suns and moons, leaping clear of the
wheel of rebirth, escaping with my life. With a
single point of sincere heart I once went seeking the
Way, on the Mountain of the Spirit Terrace I
gathered the herbs of medicine. On that mountain
dwelt an old immortal elder, a hundred and eight
thousand years in span of life. Old Sun bowed to
him as master and teacher, and he pointed me to
the one road of long life. He said the elixir lies
within the body itself, and to seek it outside is labor
spent in vain. I received the Great Grade Heavenly
Immortal's secret formula— yet without the root
and ground, it is truly hard to bear. Turning the
light to shine within, I sat with stilled mind; in my
body the sun and moon, the trigrams Kan and Li,
conjoined. Thinking on nothing, with desires made
few, the six senses pure, the body firm and sound.

To turn from age back to youth is easily had; the road from the common to the sage is not far off. In three years, without leakage, I formed the immortal body, no longer like the vulgar herd to suffer the boiling pot. Through the Ten Continents and Three Isles I went roaming at play, to the sea's corners and sky's edges I made a circuit round. Fated to live three hundred years and more, yet I could not soar aloft into the Ninefold Empyrean. I went down into the sea, subdued the Dragon, won a true treasure—and so I came by this one golden-banded cudgel. Before the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit I was the chief commander, in the Water-Curtain Cave I gathered my host of fiends. The Jade Emperor sent down his summoning decree and titled me Equal to Heaven, of the highest rank. Several times I made great havoc in the Hall of Divine Mists; more than once I stole the peaches of the Queen Mother. A hundred thousand heavenly soldiers came to subdue me, ranged layer upon layer, dense with

spear and blade. I beat back the Heavenly King, who returned to the upper realm; Nezha, nursing his wounds, led his troops in flight. The Illustrious Sage, the True Lord, could change and transform—yet old Sun matched him hard and threw him to a draw. The Daoist Ancestor, Guanyin, and the Jade Emperor too watched from the Southern Heaven's Gate as they subdued the fiend. But then Lord Lao lent his aid in one assault, and Erlang seized me, hauling me to the Heavenly Court. They bound my body to the Fiend-Subduing Pillar and ordered the divine soldiers to strike off my head. Blades hacked, hammers pounded—they could do me no harm; then they had thunder strike and fire come to burn. Old Sun, in truth, has powers, and I was not afraid by half a hair. They sent me into Lord Lao's furnace to be smelted, and the Six-Ding divine fire slowly seared me. When the days were full and the furnace opened, I leapt out, iron cudgel in hand, and ran circling all of heaven. Crosswise and lengthwise,

nowhere was there a barrier; through the Thirty-Three Heavens I made havoc all the way. Then my Buddha, the Tathagata, brought his Dharma-power to bear, and the Mountain of Five Phases pressed down upon old Sun's waist. A full five hundred years I was pinned beneath it, till happily I met Tripitaka setting out from the Tang. Now I have turned to the right path, going west, climbing on to Thunderclap to behold the Jade Brow. Go ask through heaven and earth and the four seas around — I am, through all the ages, the most famous demon, first of all!

When the monster heard this, he laughed. "So you're that Bimawen who made havoc in Heaven's Palace, are you?" Now what most enraged the Pilgrim was to be called Bimawen—"Keeper of the Heavenly Stables." Hearing that name, his heart blazed with fury, and he cursed, "You thieving fiend! You stole the cassock and won't return it, and instead you'd wound your master! Don't run—watch the cudgel!" The swarthy fellow dodged aside, took up his long spear, and met the blow head on. A fine fight the two of them made:

The compliant cudgel, the black-tasseled spear—the two before the cave mouth flaunted their strength. One stabs splitting the heart, slashing the face; one strikes the arm, aiming at the head. This one whirls a sinister sideways cudgel-stroke; that one drives straight, three sudden spear-thrusts. A white tiger climbing the hill comes probing with its claws; a yellow dragon lying across the road turns swiftly round. They blow out colored mists, spit out radiant light—two fiend-immortals beyond all measure. One is the cultivated and corrected Sage Equal to Heaven; one is the Black Great King grown into a spirit. This struggle here within the mountains was all for a cassock, and neither of them right.

The monster and the Pilgrim battled for a dozen-odd rounds without deciding the victory, and gradually the red sun stood at noon. The swarthy fellow raised his spear to fend off the iron cudgel and said, "Sun the Pilgrim, let us two break off for now. Wait until I've had my meal, and then I'll wager battle with you again." The Pilgrim said, "You beast—and you call yourself a man? What kind of man fights half a day and then

must eat? Why, when old Sun lay pinned beneath the mountain root for five hundred years and more, he never so much as tasted soup or water—where was the hunger in that? Don't make excuses. Don't run. Give back my cassock, and then I'll let you go eat." The monster made a feint with his spear, drew back his body, slipped into the cave, barred the stone door, and called in his little imps. He set about arranging a banquet and writing out invitations, summoning the demon kings of the various mountains to the celebration—but of this no more.

The Pilgrim, unable to break open the door by assault, had no choice but to return to the Guanyin Temple. The monks of that temple had already buried the old abbot and were all in the abbot's quarters waiting upon the Tang Monk. The morning meal being finished, they had laid out the midday meal as well. They were just there refilling soup and changing water when they saw the Pilgrim descend from the air. The monks bowed and ushered him in, and he came before Tripitaka. Tripitaka said, "Wukong, you've come back? What of the cassock?"

The Pilgrim said, "I've found the root of the matter. It's well we did not wrong these monks—it was indeed a fiend of Black Wind Mountain who stole it. Old Sun went secretly to seek him out, and there I found him sitting before a fragrant-grass slope, talking with a scholar in white and an old Daoist. He was a self-confessing monster, too: all at once he came out with it, saying the day after tomorrow is the anniversary of his mother's travail, his birthday, and that he'd invited all the fiends to come celebrate; that last night he'd come by a brocade Buddha-robe and meant to make it his birthday centerpiece, throwing a grand banquet he called the Buddha-Robe Assembly. Old Sun charged up to his face and struck him a blow; the swarthy fellow turned to wind and fled, the Daoist also vanished, and only the scholar in white I beat to death—he turned out to be a white-flowered serpent grown into a spirit. Then I hurried to his

cave mouth and called him out to do battle. He's admitted it—he's the one who carried it back. We fought half a day, neither prevailing. The monster went back into his cave, wanting to eat, and barred his stone door, too cowardly to come out and fight. So old Sun has come back to look in on my master and bring this news first. We now know the whereabouts of the cassock; there's no fear he won't return it."

When the monks heard this, those who could press their palms together pressed their palms, those who could kowtow kowtowed, and all chanted aloud, "Namo Amitabha! Today we have learned its whereabouts—now at last our lives are safe." The Pilgrim said, "You needn't be so glad and easy yet. I haven't got it in hand, and my master hasn't yet gone out the door. Only when the cassock is recovered and my master is sent well on his way will you have your place of peace. But if there's the least mishap, old Sun is not a master to be trifled with! Has there been good tea and food for my master? Has there been good fodder for the horse?" The monks all answered with their mouths full of assurances: "Yes, yes, yes—we have not been the least bit remiss with the Master."

Tripitaka said, "In the half-day since you left, I have already had tea three times and two vegetarian meals; they have not dared to slight me. Only put your whole heart and strength into fetching back the cassock." The Pilgrim said, "Don't fret. Since we know its whereabouts, I'll surely seize this fellow and return your property. Rest easy, rest easy."

As they were speaking, the head of the upper hall once more set out a vegetarian offering and invited Master Sun to eat. The Pilgrim took a little, then mounted his auspicious cloud again and went off in search. As he traveled, he saw a little imp coming along the main road, a pear-wood box tucked under his left arm. The Pilgrim reckoned there must be some letter or note inside the box, raised his cudgel, and brought it down on the creature's head. Pity the imp—he could not bear the blow,

and was beaten flat as a meat-cake. The Pilgrim dragged him to the roadside, opened the box, and looked—and indeed, there was an invitation. The card read:

Your humble younger student, Xiongpi the Bear, with bowed head, respectfully addresses the elixir-chamber of the venerable Elder of the Golden Pool, Great Master and Spreader of the Faith: Repeatedly have I received your kind favors, and I am moved to the depths. Last night I beheld the calamity of the Fire God's wrath, and I failed to come to your rescue—yet I trust that, with your immortal contrivance, no harm has come to you. By chance I have come into a single Buddha-robe, and I wish to hold an elegant gathering. I have humbly prepared a few cups of flowered wine and beg the honor of your refined appreciation. When the day comes, I most earnestly entreat your immortal carriage to pass by for a meeting. This is my hope. Sent two days in advance.

When the Pilgrim read it, he laughed aloud. "Ho, ho! That old skinflint—he didn't die one whit unjustly; he was in league with fiends after all. No wonder he lived to two hundred and seventy: I suppose that monster taught him some petty breath-nurturing arts, and so he came by such long years. Old Sun still remembers his looks. Let me change into that monk and stroll into the cave to see where my cassock is kept. If I can lay hands on it, I'll carry it straight back—that will save some effort."

A fine Great Sage! He chanted his spell, faced the wind, and with one transformation became the very likeness of the old monk. Hiding his iron cudgel, he strode along and came straight to the cave mouth, calling, "Open the door!" The little imp opened it, and seeing this figure, hastily turned and reported, "Great King, the Elder of the Golden Pool has come." The monster was greatly startled. "I only just sent the little one off with the invitation to ask him," he thought, "and by now the imp can't even have reached him—how has the Elder come so quickly? It must be that the imp never met him, and that this is surely Sun the Pilgrim, conjured here to demand the cassock. Steward—hide the Buddha-robe; don't let him see it."

The Pilgrim came in through the front gate and saw in the courtyard pines and bamboo crossing their jade-green, peaches and plums vying in their bloom, clump upon clump of opening flowers, cluster upon cluster of fragrant orchids—truly a cave-heaven of a place. He also saw, upon the inner gate, a matched couplet that read: "Quietly secluded deep in the hills, no worldly cares; / dwelling apart in the immortal cave, delighting in heaven's truth." The Pilgrim thought to himself, "This fellow too is a creature who has shed the dirt and left the dust, who knows his allotted fate." Passing through the gate and going farther forward, he reached the third tier of doors, all painted beams and carved rafters, bright windows and colored casements.

There he saw the swarthy fellow, dressed in a black-green ramie-silk lined jacket, draped with a crow-blue patterned-damask cloak, wearing a soft hat of black horn and a pair of black deerskin boots. Seeing the Pilgrim come in, he straightened his clothes and cap, descended the steps to receive him, and said, "Old friend of the Golden Pool, I have been wanting in attentiveness these past days. Please be seated, please be seated." The Pilgrim returned his courtesy. When the greetings were done they sat, and when they were settled, tea was served. After the tea, the monster bowed slightly and said, "Just now I sent a little note to invite you for a meeting the day after tomorrow. Why does my old friend favor me with his visit today?"

The Pilgrim said, "I was on my way to pay my respects when, unexpectedly, I met your splendid letter upon the road. Seeing there was to be an elegant Buddha-Robe Assembly, I hurried here in haste, wishing to beg a glimpse of it." The monster laughed. "Old friend, you are mistaken. This cassock belongs to the Tang Monk. He was lodging at your place—surely you have already seen it; why come to me to look at it?" The Pilgrim said, "Your poor monk only borrowed it, and as it was late at night, I had not yet spread it out to look, when unexpectedly the Great King carried it off. And then the fire burned my humble mountain temple and I lost my household goods. That Tang Monk's disciple, moreover, is something of a fierce fellow, and in all the confusion I searched everywhere and could not find it. It turns out it was the Great King's great good fortune that gathered it in—so I have come especially to have a look."

Just as they were talking, a mountain-patrolling imp came in and reported, "Great King, disaster! The little scout who carried the invitation has been beaten to death by Sun the Pilgrim on the high road, and he has taken the note and changed himself into the Elder of the Golden Pool to

come and cheat you of the Buddha-robe!" When the monster heard this, he thought to himself, "I said—how is it the Elder came today, and came so fast? It is indeed him." Swiftly he sprang up, snatched his spear, and thrust at the Pilgrim. The Pilgrim quickly drew his cudgel from his ear, showed his true form, fended off the spear-point, and went leaping out from the central hall, fighting from the courtyard out beyond the front gate. The fiends within the cave were so terrified their courage failed them, and the old and young of the household were all frightened out of their wits. A fine struggle they fought there upon the mountaintop, and this time it was different from before. A fine fight:

That Monkey King, bold of gall, played the monk;
this swarthy fellow, sharp of wit, hid away the robe.
Words went and words came, the chance contrived
with skill; meeting each turn with a turn, never a
step amiss. He longed to see the cassock, but no
way could he see it— a treasure dark and subtle,
truly wondrous and fine. The little fiend patrolling
spoke of the disaster, and the old fiend, kindling
rage, displayed his divine might. Turning his body,
he fought out of Black Wind Cave; spear and cudgel
grappling to tell the right from wrong. The cudgel
parrying the long spear rang out clear and loud; the
spear meeting the iron cudgel flashed its gleaming
light. Wukong's transformations are rare among
men; the monster's divine powers are scarce in this
world. This one would make the Buddha-robe his
birthday celebration; that one, without the cassock,
would never willingly yield. This bitter fight was
hard indeed to part— even a living Buddha come to
earth could not have broken the siege.

The two of them fought from the cave mouth up to the mountaintop, and from the mountaintop out beyond the clouds, spitting fog and blasting wind, flinging sand and rolling stones, until the red sun sank in the west, and still neither had won or lost. The monster said, "Sun—stay your hand. It's late today, and no good for grappling. Go, go; come again early tomorrow, and we'll settle life and death." The Pilgrim shouted, "Boy, don't run! If you'll fight, fight like a fighter, and don't put me off with 'it's late.'" He laid on, heedless of head or face, working his cudgel down upon him. But the swarthy fellow changed once more into a pure breeze, turned back into his own cave, and shut the stone door fast, coming out no more.

The Pilgrim, having no stratagem to do anything about it, had no choice but to return again to the Guanyin Temple. Lowering his cloud, he called out, "Master." Tripitaka, who had been gazing for him with anxious, longing eyes, was overjoyed to see him appear of a sudden—but seeing no cassock in his hand, grew afraid again. He asked, "How is it you still have no cassock this time?" The Pilgrim drew from his sleeve a little note and handed it to Tripitaka, saying, "Master, that monster and the dead old skinflint were friends. He'd sent a little imp with this note, inviting him to come to the Buddha-Robe Assembly. Old Sun beat the little imp to death, changed into that old monk, and went into his cave, where I was cheated of a cup of tea to drink. I meant to ask him for the cassock to look at, but he wouldn't bring it out. Just as we were sitting, some mountain-patrol fellow let the wind out of the secret, and so he fell to fighting me. We battled until just now, neither above the other. Seeing it was late, he slipped back into his cave and shut the stone door fast. Old Sun, with no help for it, has come back for the moment."

Tripitaka said, "How do your powers compare with his?" The Pilgrim said, "I'm not much harder than he—we only fought to a draw." Tripitaka

then read the note and handed it on to the temple's head, saying, "Could it be that your own master was a fiend too?" The head of the temple knelt down in alarm and said, "Master, my teacher was a man. It was only because that Black Great King had cultivated his way to the human path, and would often come to the temple to expound the scriptures with my teacher, and had taught my teacher certain arts of nurturing the spirit and ingesting the breath, that they addressed each other as friends." The Pilgrim said, "This pack of monks has no fiendish air about it—every one of them has a round head crowning heaven and square feet treading earth; they're only a bit fatter and taller than old Sun, and no fiends. But look here—the note is signed 'humble younger student, Xiongpi the Bear.' This creature must surely be a black bear grown into a spirit."

Tripitaka said, "I have heard the ancients say, 'The bear and the orangutan are of one kind.' Both are beasts. How, then, did he become a spirit?" The Pilgrim laughed. "Old Sun is of the beast kind, and look—I'm made the Great Sage Equal to Heaven. How is he any different? Generally, of all things in the world, whatever has the nine apertures can cultivate itself and become an immortal." Tripitaka said again, "You just said his abilities are a match for yours—how then will you win, and fetch back my cassock?" The Pilgrim said, "Don't worry, don't worry—I have a way to deal with it."

While they were deliberating, the monks laid out the evening meal and invited master and disciple to eat. Tripitaka ordered the lamps lit and went again to the meditation hall at the front to rest. The monks all bunked along the walls and leaned against the partitions, throwing up makeshift shelters, and each lay down to sleep, leaving only the rear abbot's quarters for the heads of the temple to lodge in. By now the night was still, and this was the sight of it:

The River of Heaven shows its image; the jade firmament is without dust. The whole sky's stars are brilliant; on the one water the wave-marks are gathered in. All the ten thousand voices are stilled; on a thousand hills the birds are silent. Beside the brook the fisher-fires are out; on the pagoda the Buddha-lamps grow dim. Last night the monks' bells and drums resounded; tonight, one round of weeping is heard.

That night he lodged in the meditation hall. But Tripitaka, brooding over the cassock, could not sleep soundly. Suddenly he turned and saw the window paling white, and he rose in haste and called, "Wukong, day has broken—go quickly and seek the cassock." The Pilgrim rolled to his feet in a single bound. Seeing the monks standing in attendance and offering up soup and water, he said, "You take good care of my master—old Sun is off." Tripitaka got down from the bed and caught hold of him. "Where are you going?" The Pilgrim said, "I've been thinking—this whole business is the fault of the Bodhisattva Guanyin's want of reason. She has this meditation temple of hers here, receiving the incense and offerings of the people hereabouts, and yet she lets that monster live as a neighbor. I'm going to the Southern Sea to find her, to have it out with her, and make her come in person to demand the cassock from the fiend and return it to me." Tripitaka said, "When you go like this, when will you be back?" The Pilgrim said, "At the least, by the time the meal is done; at the most, by

noon, the thing will be settled. Those monks can wait on you well enough. Old Sun is off."

No sooner had he said "off" than he was gone without a trace. In a moment he reached the Southern Sea and halted his cloud to look. And this was the sight of it:

The boundless ocean stretching far, the press of waters joined to the sky. Auspicious light enwraps the universe; propitious vapors shine on mountain and stream. A thousand layers of snow-billows roar to the blue empyrean; ten thousand folds of misted waves surge in the white day. Water flies to the four quarters, waves roll all around. Water flying to the four quarters cracks like rolling thunder; waves rolling all around peal like the thunderbolt. Speak not of the water's force—look rather to the midst. Five-colored, hazy, the treasure-heaped hill: red, yellow, purple, black, green, and blue. Now is seen Guanyin's true and surpassing realm— behold the Potalaka Mountain of the Southern Sea. A fine place! The mountain peaks soar high, their crowns piercing the void. In the midst are a thousand kinds of rare flowers, a hundred sorts of auspicious herbs. The wind sways the treasure-trees; the sun reflects on golden lotuses. Guanyin's hall, roofed with glazed tile; the Tide-Sound Cave, its doorway paved

with tortoise-shell. In the shade of green willows the parrot speaks; in the purple bamboo grove the peacock cries. Upon the figured stone, the Dharma-guardians stand in majesty; before the agate strand, Moksha stands stalwart.

The Pilgrim could not look his fill at these strange and uncommon scenes. He lowered his cloud straight down and came beneath the bamboo grove. At once the various devas came out to receive him, saying, "The Bodhisattva, before the assembly, has greatly proclaimed that the Great Sage has turned to the good—she has praised it often. Now that you are guarding the Tang Monk, how do you find the leisure to come here?" The Pilgrim said, "Because of guarding the Tang Monk, I have met with a certain matter on the road, and have come specially to see the Bodhisattva. I trouble you to announce me." The devas went to the cave mouth to report, and the Bodhisattva summoned him in. The Pilgrim proceeded according to the rule and bowed beneath the precious lotus dais.

The Bodhisattva asked, "What have you come for?" The Pilgrim said, "My master, on the road, came upon your meditation temple. You receive the incense of the human world there, yet you let a black-bear spirit dwell as a neighbor, and he has stolen my master's cassock. I have demanded it of him several times and he will not give it up. So I have come especially to ask it of you." The Bodhisattva said, "This monkey talks with no manners at all. If the bear-spirit stole your cassock, why come and demand it of me? It is all because you, you reckless monkey, were so bold as to make a show of the treasure, taking it out for a small-minded man to see; and

then you worked your violence, called up the wind and started the fire, and burned my Cloud-Lodging Lower Court—and now you come to my place to play your tricks." When the Pilgrim heard the Bodhisattva say this, he knew that she understood matters past and present, and he bowed in haste. "Bodhisattva, I beg you to forgive your disciple's fault—it is indeed just so. But I am vexed that the monster will not give me the cassock, and my master is ready to recite that little spell of his, and old Sun cannot bear the headache. That is why I have come to trouble the Bodhisattva. I beg the Bodhisattva, of her compassionate heart, to help me capture that monster, recover the robe, and go westward." The Bodhisattva said, "That monster has a great many divine powers—he is no less than your equal. Very well—for the Tang Monk's sake, I will go and make a turn with you." When the Pilgrim heard this, he gave thanks and bowed again. Then he followed the Bodhisattva out the door, and together they mounted the auspicious cloud and soon reached Black Wind Mountain. They lowered their cloud and followed the path toward the cave.

As they were going along, they saw a Daoist come out from before the mountain slope, carrying a glass tray in his hand, in which were set two pellets of immortal elixir. He was walking straight ahead. The Pilgrim ran full into him, drew out his cudgel, and brought it down on his head with a single blow, beating out his brains and sending the blood spurting from his frame. The Bodhisattva was greatly startled. "You monkey, still as wild and lawless as ever! He never stole your cassock, he is no acquaintance of yours, and there is no grudge or feud between you—why have you beaten him to death?" The Pilgrim said, "Bodhisattva, you don't know him. He is a friend of that black-bear spirit. Yesterday he and a scholar in white were both sitting and talking before the fragrant-grass slope. The day after tomorrow is the black spirit's birthday, and they were both invited to come celebrate the Buddha-Robe Assembly. Today

he comes first to offer his birthday wishes; tomorrow he would come to celebrate the robe. That is how I knew him—surely today he was going to wish the fiend long life on the fiend's behalf." The Bodhisattva said, "If that is how it is, then never mind." The Pilgrim then went and turned the Daoist over to look, and found he was a gray wolf. Beside him, on the underside of the tray, were carved some words, reading: *Made by the Master of Soaring Emptiness*.

When the Pilgrim saw it, he laughed. "Good fortune, good fortune! Old Sun is in luck, and the Bodhisattva is spared some labor too. This fiend may be said to have confessed without being struck, and that fiend has appointed his own undoing today." The Bodhisattva said, "Wukong, what do you mean by that?" The Pilgrim said, "Bodhisattva, old Sun has a word for it—it is called turning the enemy's scheme to your own advantage. I do not know whether the Bodhisattva will be willing to go along with me." The Bodhisattva said, "Speak." The Pilgrim said, "Bodhisattva, you see, in this tray are two pellets of immortal elixir—those will be our gift of introduction to the fiend; and the four characters carved on the back of the tray, 'Made by the Master of Soaring Emptiness'—those will be our hook into him. If the Bodhisattva will go along with me, I can lay out a plan, and then there will be no need to set spear and shield in motion, no need to toil at battle: the monster will meet his doom on the spot, and the Buddha-robe will come to hand on the spot. But if the Bodhisattva will not go along with me, then the Bodhisattva goes west and old Sun goes east; the Buddha-robe may as well be a gift bestowed, and Tang Tripitaka may as well come to nothing." The Bodhisattva laughed. "This monkey has a glib tongue." The Pilgrim said, "I would not dare—it truly is a plan." The Bodhisattva said, "And how does this plan of yours go?"

The Pilgrim said, "On this tray is carved 'Made by the Master of Soaring Emptiness.' I should think this Daoist was himself called the Master of

Soaring Emptiness. Bodhisattva, if you will go along with me, you can change into this Daoist, and I will eat one of these elixir-pellets and change into the other—made a little larger. You take up this tray with its two pellets and go to wish the monster long life; give the larger pellet to the fiend. When the fiend swallows it at one gulp, old Sun will do his work from inside: if he will not hand over the Buddha-robe, old Sun will weave him one straight out of his bowels." The Bodhisattva, having no other way, could only nod her head and go along with him. The Pilgrim laughed. "Well, then?"

At that, the Bodhisattva, with her vast compassion and boundless Dharma-power, her hundred million transformation-bodies—with mind meeting intention, and intention meeting body—in the space of a flicker changed into the immortal Master of Soaring Emptiness:

The crane-feather robe, the immortal wind blowing brisk; wafting and floating, about to step the void. The aged countenance, old as pine and cypress; a comeliness unequaled in past or present. Going and going, yet without abiding; thus and thus, of itself set apart. All comes at last to one single Dharma—it is only the husk of the body that divides.

The Pilgrim looked and said, "Marvelous, marvelous! Is it the fiend who is the Bodhisattva, or the Bodhisattva who is the fiend?" The Bodhisattva laughed. "Wukong—Bodhisattva and fiend, both are a single thought; and as for the original ground, both belong to non-being." The Pilgrim's heart

was suddenly enlightened, and turning his body he changed into a single pellet of immortal elixir:

Rolling on the tray, never coming to rest; round and bright, yet without a fixed shape. Three threes conjoined in the Goulou rite; six sixes weighed in the Shaoweng's count. The tile-fragment with the yellow-gold flame; the relic-pearl with the broad-day light. The lead and mercury without— not lightly may their measure be discussed.

The Pilgrim having changed into the pellet, it came out a little larger than the other. The Bodhisattva marked it well, took up the glass tray, and went straight to the mouth of the fiend's cave to look. And truly it was:

The cliffs deep, the grottoes perilous; clouds rising over the ridges. The cypress dark, the pines green; wind blowing through the woods. The cliffs deep, the grottoes perilous—indeed where fiends come and go and human smoke is rare; the cypress dark, the pines green—here too the immortal true may cultivate and hide, rich in the Way's own mood. The mountain has its ravine, the ravine its spring: the murmuring running water sobs like a sounding lute—fit to wash one's ears; the cliff has its deer, the wood its crane: the deep and secret immortal piping stirs among the peaks—fit too to please the heart. This is the fiend-immortal who has his portion to descend to Bodhi, and the great vow, boundless, that lets down its pity.

The Bodhisattva looked, and secretly rejoiced in her heart. "This beast has seized this mountain cave, but he has, after all, something of a portion in the Way." And so compassion was already stirring within her.

She came to the cave mouth, and the little imps who kept the cave somewhat recognized her, saying, "The immortal elder, the Master of Soaring Emptiness, has come!" While one passed word in, another

ushered her forward. The monster had already come out to meet her at the door. "Master of Soaring Emptiness, I am obliged for the trouble of your immortal carriage's precious visit—my humble cottage is honored by your light." The Bodhisattva said, "This poor Daoist respectfully presents a pellet of immortal elixir, and ventures to wish you a thousand years of life." When the two of them had finished their bows and settled into their seats, they began again to speak of the previous day's affair. The Bodhisattva did not answer, but hastily took up the elixir-tray and said, "Great King, let me first show you my poor intention." She fixed her eye on the larger pellet and pushed it toward the fiend, saying, "I wish the Great King a thousand years of life." The fiend likewise pushed a pellet across and offered it to the Bodhisattva, saying, "I would share it with the Master of Soaring Emptiness."

The courtesies done, the fiend was just about to swallow his pellet when it rolled straight down his throat of its own accord. The Pilgrim revealed his true form and braced himself into the four-square stance, and the fiend tumbled to the ground. The Bodhisattva showed her true appearance and demanded the Buddha-robe of the fiend. The Pilgrim had already come out through his nostrils. And the Bodhisattva, fearing the fiend might still be unruly, flung a band onto the fiend's head. The fiend rose up and lifted his spear to thrust, but the Pilgrim and the Bodhisattva had already risen into the air and begun to recite the True Words. The monster's head ached as before; he threw down his spear and rolled about upon the ground. In the half-sky the lovely Monkey King laughed himself breathless, and on the level ground the black-bear fiend rolled himself to ruin.

The Bodhisattva said, "Beast—will you submit now and take refuge in the faith?" The fiend cried out, "My heart is willing to take refuge—only spare my life!" The Pilgrim, fearing it would delay the work, meant to

strike him then and there. But the Bodhisattva hastily stopped him.

"Don't harm his life—I have a use for him." The Pilgrim said, "A monster like this—if you don't beat him to death, what use will you keep him for?"

The Bodhisattva said, "Behind my Potalaka Mountain there is no one to keep watch—I mean to take him to be a guardian deity of the mountain." The Pilgrim laughed. "Truly you are a merciful Lord who

saves from suffering—not one soul lost. If old Sun had a spell like that, I'd recite the wretched thing on him a thousand times over. In a little while there'd be no end of black bears, all of them brought to book!"

Now the fiend, having endured the pain a good while, could no longer in fairness bear it, and had no choice but to kneel upon the ground and plead, "Only spare my life, and I will take refuge in the true fruit." The Bodhisattva then lowered her auspicious radiance, laid her hand upon his crown, gave him the precepts, and bade him take up the long spear and follow at her side. And the black bear—in a single day his wild heart was settled, and his boundless stubborn nature was in that hour gathered in.

The Bodhisattva instructed him, "Wukong, you may go back now. Wait well upon the Tang Monk, and henceforth no more slacking off or making trouble." The Pilgrim said, "I am deeply grateful the Bodhisattva has come so far—your disciple ought to see you off a way." The Bodhisattva said, "Spare yourself the trouble." The Pilgrim then took up the cassock, knocked his head in farewell, and parted from her. The Bodhisattva led off the bear, Xiongpi, and went straight back to the great sea. There is a poem in proof:

Auspicious light, soft and dense, congeals the golden image; ten thousand rays in radiant profusion, truly to be admired. Broadly she succors the people of the world, letting down her pity; everywhere she beholds the Dharma-realm, manifesting the golden lotus. Now she has come mostly for the sake of conveying the scriptures; and going hence, there was, from the first, no blemish or flaw. Subduing the fiend and bringing it to truth, she returns to the great sea— and the gate of emptiness has again recovered its brocade cassock.

In the end we do not yet know how the matters that follow will turn out; listen, and the next chapter will explain it.

Chapter 18: The Tang Monk Escapes His Trouble at Guanyin Mountain

Sun Wukong took his leave of the Bodhisattva, lowered his cloud, and hung the brocade cassock upon a fragrant nan-wood tree. Then he drew out his iron rod and went smashing his way into the Black Wind Cave— but not a single small imp was to be found within. The truth was that, having seen the Bodhisattva reveal herself and bring the old fiend

writhing helplessly to the ground, every last one of them had scattered and fled. Wukong, with his blood up, piled dry kindling against the several layers of gates within the cave, front and back, and set it all ablaze at once, turning the Black Wind Cave into a Red Wind Cave. Then he took up the cassock, mounted the auspicious light, and turned back toward the north.

Now Tripitaka had been waiting and watching, and when Wukong did not quickly return, his heart filled with doubt. He could not tell whether the Bodhisattva had refused to come, or whether Wukong had made some excuse and run off for good. While he was lost in these wild guesses and uneasy musings, all at once a glory of bright-colored mist came shimmering down from the middle air, and Wukong suddenly dropped to his knees before the steps and said, "Master, the cassock has come back!" Tripitaka rejoiced greatly, and the assembled monks, too, were one and all delighted. "Wonderful, wonderful!" they cried. "Only now, this very day, are our lives made whole again." Tripitaka received the cassock and said, "Wukong, when you went off this morning you reckoned to be back by noon at the latest. Why do you return now, with the sun in the west?" So Wukong recounted in full how he had invited the Bodhisattva, how she had worked her transformations, and how the monster had been subdued. When Tripitaka heard it, he set out an incense table, bowed to the south in thanks, and then said, "Disciple, since we have the Buddha-robe again, let us pack up at once and be on our way."

"No hurry, no hurry," said Wukong. "It is growing late, and this is no time to be traveling. Let us wait and set out early tomorrow." The monks all knelt down together. "Master Sun speaks rightly," they said. "For one thing, the day is far gone; for another, we have certain vows to fulfill. Now that all is safe and the treasure recovered, let us pay our vows, and

we beg the elder to share his blessings with us. Tomorrow morning we will see you off again on your westward road." "Just so, just so," said Wukong. And so you should have seen those monks empty out their purses to the very bottom, gathering whatever scraps of property they had snatched from the fire, each contributing what he could; they laid out a vegetarian feast, burned paper offerings for peace and safety, and chanted several scrolls of scripture to dispel calamity and undo misfortune. That evening the matter was finished.

Early the next morning they groomed and saddled the horse, packed up the baggage, and set out. The monks accompanied them a long way before turning back. Wukong led the road ahead. It was now the season when spring was at its mellowest, and behold what they saw:

Soft grass cushioned the white horse's hoofprints;
willows swayed their golden threads, fresh with
dew. Peach and apricot filled the woods, vying in
loveliness; creeping vines wreathed the path and put
forth their vigor. On the warm sandy banks the
mandarin ducks drowsed; in the mountain streams,
fragrant with blossom, butterflies grew tame. Thus
autumn had gone, winter waned, and spring was
half over— yet who knew in what year their
pilgrimage would be fulfilled and the true scriptures
won?

Master and disciples traveled some five or seven days along wild roads. Then one day, toward dusk, they spied far off a cluster of houses nestled against a slope. Said Tripitaka, "Wukong, look—there's a hamlet close by yonder hillside. Suppose we go and beg a night's lodging, and travel on again tomorrow?" "Wait until old Monkey has gone to look whether the omens are good or ill," said Wukong, "and then we'll decide what to do." The master reined in his silken bridle, and Wukong fixed his eyes and looked. Truly it was a place where—

Bamboo fences stood thick, thatched roofs clustered close. Wild trees, towering to the sky, greeted the gate; a winding brook and a stream-bridge mirrored the doors. Beside the road the willows hung green and tender; within the gardens the flowers opened with rich fragrance. At this hour the setting sun was sinking westward, and everywhere through the mountain woods the birds and sparrows clamored; evening smoke curled up from the cookfires, and along every lane the oxen and sheep came winding home. He saw, too, the well-fed chickens and pigs drowsing in the corners of the houses, and a tipsy old neighbor coming along singing in his cups.

When Wukong had finished looking, he said, "Master, ride on—it is surely a village of good folk, and just the place to borrow a night's rest." The elder urged the white horse forward, and they soon reached the head of the street. There they saw a young fellow, his head wrapped in cotton cloth, dressed in a blue jacket, carrying an umbrella and a pack on his back, his trousers tucked up and bound, his feet shod in a pair of three-eared straw sandals—a brisk, vigorous lad striding hurriedly out of the village. Wukong reached out and grabbed him fast. "Where are you off to? Let me ask you for a bit of news: what place is this?" The man only struggled and shouted, "Is there nobody else in my village, that you must question me?" Wukong said with a smile, "Don't be angry, good sir. 'Do

another a kindness, and you do yourself one.' What harm is there in telling me the name of this place? I might even be able to relieve your troubles." The man could not pull his hand free, and stamped about in a fury. "Bad luck, bad luck! I can't bear the unjust temper of my master, and now I run smack into this bald-pate and have to swallow his impertinence too!" "If you have the strength," said Wukong, "pry my hand open, and then you may go—and good riddance." The man twisted left and right, but he could not budge it; it was as though an iron pincers had clamped him fast. So enraged was he that he flung down his bundle, tossed aside his umbrella, and came clawing at Wukong with both hands like falling rain. Wukong steadied the baggage with one hand and fended the man off with the other, and however the fellow flailed and dodged, he could never lay a finger on him. The more he struggled, the tighter Wukong held, until the man fairly crackled with rage like thunder.

Tripitaka said, "Wukong, isn't someone else coming yonder? Ask that man instead, and have done. Why keep dragging this one about? Let him go." Wukong laughed and said, "Master doesn't understand. If I ask someone else, there'll be no profit in it. It must be this one—there's business to be done here." The man, finding himself held and not released, had no choice but to speak. "This is the land within the borders of the Kingdom of Wusi-Tibet, and it is called Gao Village. More than half the families in the village are surnamed Gao, and so it is called Gao Village. Now let me go!"

"By your traveling gear," said Wukong, "you're no man bound on a short errand. Tell me truly where you mean to go and what business you're really about, and then I'll let you go." Helpless, the man had to tell the truth. "I am a servant of Squire Gao, and my name is Gao Cai. My master has a youngest daughter, twenty years old this year, who has never been betrothed to anyone. Three years ago she was seized by a monster, who

has been her husband these three years. My master is far from pleased, and says, 'A daughter married to a monster is no lasting arrangement: for one thing it ruins the family's name, and for another there's no proper in-law to come and go with us.' All along he has wanted to be rid of this monster, but the creature won't go—indeed he has shut my mistress away in his back apartments, and for nearly half a year now has not let her out to see any of the household. My master gave me a few taels of silver and sent me to seek out a master of spells to capture the fiend. All this while I've had no rest; I've gone here and there and engaged three or four men—but all of them were useless monks and weak-bellied Taoists, and none could subdue the creature. Just now my master cursed me roundly, saying I'm good for nothing, and gave me five mace of silver for traveling expenses and told me to go off again and fetch a capable exorcist. Then I run into you, you ill-starred jinx, and you grab hold of me and hold up my journey—so I get it from inside and out, and that's why, in my helplessness, I shouted at you. And now it turns out you've got some grip on you, and I can't break free, and so I've told you the whole truth. Let me go!"

"Your luck's in!" said Wukong. "This is right in my line of work—the very thing, as neat as four-plus-six making ten. You needn't travel far, and you needn't waste your silver. We are no useless monks nor weak-bellied Taoists. We have real skill, and we're old hands at catching monsters. As the saying goes, 'First, the physician is well looked after; second, the eyes are well cured.' Be so good as to go back and tell your master that we are holy monks—the imperial brother sent under commission from the Land of the East, journeying to the Western Heaven to worship the Buddha and seek the scriptures—and that we are well able to subdue fiends and bind monsters."

Gao Cai said, "Don't you go fooling me. I'm a man with a bellyful of grievance already; if you've lied to me and have no skill, and can't lay hold of the monster, then you'll only drag me into more trouble." "I promise I won't let you down," said Wukong. "Lead me to your master's gate." The man, having no other choice, picked up his bundle and his umbrella, turned about, and led master and disciple to the gate. "Reverend sirs," he said, "sit a moment on the mounting-block while I go in and tell my master." Only then did Wukong let go his hand. He set down the load, led the horse aside, and master and disciple sat and stood by the gate, waiting.

Gao Cai went in through the main gate and walked straight on to the central hall, where, as it happened, he ran square into Squire Gao. The old man scolded him: "You barbarian-hided beast! Why haven't you gone to find someone? What have you come back for?" Gao Cai set down his pack and umbrella and said, "Allow me to report, master: I had just gone out to the head of the street when suddenly I ran into two monks—one riding a horse, one carrying a load. He grabbed hold of me and wouldn't let go, asking where I was bound. I refused, again and again, to tell him; but he pestered me past all bearing, and I couldn't get my hand loose, so at last I told him the whole of your business. He was overjoyed at it, and wants to catch the monster for us." "Where do they come from?" asked the old man. "He says they are holy monks—the imperial brother dispatched by decree from the Land of the East—on their way to the Western Heaven to worship the Buddha and seek scriptures." Said the squire, "Since they are monks come from afar, perhaps they really have some skill. Where are they now?" "Waiting outside the gate," said Gao Cai.

The squire hurriedly changed his clothes and came out with Gao Cai to receive them, calling, "Reverend elder!" Tripitaka heard, turned quickly,

and there the old man was, already before him. He wore a black silk-gauze cap, a robe of onion-white Shu brocade, a pair of calf-leather boots the color of brown rice, and a girdle of black-green cord; he came forward with smiling words to greet them, saying, "Reverend elders, my respects to you." Tripitaka returned the courtesy, but Wukong stood stock-still and did not move. Seeing how fierce and ugly his features were, the old man did not dare bow to him. "Why don't you make your bow to old Monkey?" demanded Wukong. The old fellow, somewhat frightened, said to Gao Cai, "You little wretch, you'll be the death of me! There's an ugly-mugged, monstrous-headed son-in-law in the house already that we can't get rid of—why have you led in this very Thunder God to plague me?"

"Old Gao," said Wukong, "you've lived to such a great age and still haven't learned sense. If you judge people purely by their looks, you'll go clean wrong. Ugly I may be, but I have some abilities. I'll capture the monster for your house, seize the fiend, take hold of your son-in-law, and give you back your daughter—and that will be a good thing done. Why need you keep harping on a man's looks?" The squire, hearing this, trembled and shook, but mustered his spirits as best he could and called, "Please, come in." At the invitation, Wukong led the white horse in, had Gao Cai shoulder the baggage, and went inside with Tripitaka. Caring nothing for ceremony, he tied the horse to a pillar of the open hall, dragged over a polished-lacquer folding chair, and bade his master be seated; then he pulled over another chair and sat down at his side. Said old Gao, "This little reverend makes himself quite at home." "If you'll only let me stay half a year," said Wukong, "I'll be more at home still."

When they were seated, old Gao asked, "My servant said just now that you two reverends are come from the Land of the East?" "Just so," said Tripitaka. "I am sent by imperial command to the Western Heaven to worship the Buddha and seek the scriptures, and passing your honorable

village, I would beg one night's lodging and be on my way in the morning." "If you two only came to lodge," said old Gao, "how is it you speak of catching the monster?" "Since we're lodging here anyway," said Wukong, "we'll catch a monster or two for sport while we're about it. May I ask how many monsters there are in your house?" "Heavens above!" said old Gao. "How could we put up with any more? This one monster of a son-in-law has worn us to a frazzle already." "Tell me from the beginning," said Wukong—"the whole story of this monster, and how great his powers are—so that I may catch him for you."

Old Gao said, "From ancient times down to now, this village of ours has never known any ghost or goblin, any specter or evil spirit working mischief. It was only my own misfortune that I had no son, but only three daughters: the eldest named Xianglan, the second Yulan, the third Cuilan. The two elder ones were betrothed in childhood to families of this very village. Only the youngest I wished to keep at home with a husband taken into our house—I'd hoped he would live here with me and support me in my old age, hold up the household, and do the work and the labor. But three years ago there came a fellow, of really rather handsome appearance, who said he was a man from the Fuling Mountains, surnamed Zhu, with no parents above him nor brothers below, and that he was willing to marry into a household as a son-in-law. Seeing him to be a man without root or tie, I took him in. And when first he came, he was diligent enough: he plowed the fields and harrowed the ground without need of oxen or tools; he reaped the grain without knife or sickle; he came in at dusk and went out at dawn, and truly all was well. There was only this one thing—he had a way of changing his face."

"Changing it how?" asked Wukong. Said old Gao, "When he first came he was a stout, dark fellow; but afterward he turned into an idiot creature with a long snout and great ears, a tuft of bristles down the back of his

head, a body coarse and frightful, and a face for all the world like a hog's. And his appetite is huge: at a single meal he must eat three or five pecks of rice, and for a morning's snack alone he wants a hundred-odd baked cakes before he's satisfied. Luckily he keeps a vegetarian diet still; if he took to meat and wine besides, why, the whole of my estate and lands and all would be eaten clean away inside half a year." "Because he does so much," observed Tripitaka, "that's why he eats so much." "The eating is the lesser matter," said old Gao. "What's worse, he has lately learned to make winds—coming in clouds and going in mist, sending stones rolling and sand flying—and he has so frightened my whole household and all the neighbors that none can live in peace. And he has shut my young daughter Cuilan away in the back apartments, so that for half a year now she's not been seen face to face, and we don't even know whether she's alive or dead. By this we know he is a monster, and so we wished to engage some exorcist to drive him off."

"That's no hard matter," said Wukong. "Set your mind at rest, old man. This very night I'll catch him for you, make him write a deed of divorce, and give you back your daughter. How's that?" Old Gao rejoiced greatly. "It mattered little enough that I took him in," he said, "but how much of my good name he's ruined, how many of my kinsfolk he's estranged! Only catch him—what need of any deed? Just be so good as to root the creature out for me." "Easy, easy," said Wukong. "When night falls, you'll see how things stand."

The old man, overjoyed, had the tables and chairs wiped clean and a vegetarian feast laid out. When the meal was over and evening drew on, he asked, "What weapons do you need? How many men to attend you? Best to have them ready early." "I have my own weapon," said Wukong. "But you have only that single monk's staff," said the old man. "How can a monk's staff strike down a monster?" Wukong thereupon reached inside

his ear, drew out a tiny embroidery needle, rolled it between his fingers, and with one shake into the wind it became an iron rod bound with gold, as thick as a rice bowl. He held it out toward old Gao and said, "Look at this cudgel — how does it compare with the weapons in your house? Will it serve to beat that monster or no?" Old Gao said, "Since you have a weapon, do you want men to go with you?" "I need no men," said Wukong, "only a few aged and virtuous gentlemen to sit and keep my master quiet company while I slip away from him. Let me bring the monster back, and before them all extract his confession, and root him out for you." The old man at once summoned his houseboys and invited in several friends and kinsmen. When all had arrived and the greetings were done, Wukong said, "Master, sit easy and rest secure — old Monkey is off."

Now see him grip his iron rod and tug at old Gao: "Take me to the back apartments where the monster lives, and let me have a look." So old Gao led him to the door of the rear chambers. "Go and fetch the key," said Wukong. "Just look at it," said old Gao. "If a key were any use, I'd not have sent for you." Wukong laughed: "Old man, you may be great in years, but you can't take a joke. I only said it to tease you, and you take it in earnest." He stepped up and felt about — the lock turned out to be one poured solid with bronze. With a furious thrust of his gold-banded rod he burst the door-leaves open. Within it was black as a cave. "Old Gao," said Wukong, "call out to your daughter and see if she's inside." The old man screwed up his courage and cried, "Third sister!" The girl recognized her father's voice and, faint and feeble, answered, "Father, I'm here." Flashing his golden eyes into the darkness, Wukong looked her over closely. And how did she look? Behold:

Her cloudy tresses lay tumbled, uncombed; her jade-fair face, unwashed, was stained with grime. Her one orchid-pure heart was as before, but all her tender grace had fallen to ruin. Her cherry lips had not a trace of color; her slender waist bent, cowering and bowed. Sorrow-knit her brow, the moth-wing eyebrows pale; thin and shrinking, her voice gone low and weak.

She came forward, and seeing old Gao she seized him, buried her head against him, and wept aloud. "Don't cry, don't cry," said Wukong. "Let me ask you — where has the monster gone?" The girl said, "I don't know where. These days he goes off at daybreak and comes back at nightfall, in clouds and mists, coming and going I know not whither. Because he knows my father wants to be rid of him, he's always on his guard, coming at dusk and leaving at dawn." "No need to say more," said Wukong. "Old man, take your daughter off to the front rooms and have your long-deferred talk together, and leave old Monkey here to wait for him. If he doesn't come, don't blame me; but if he does, I'll surely cut him off at the root for you." So old Gao, happy and relieved, led his daughter away to the front.

Then Wukong worked his magic: he shook himself and changed, taking on the very form of the girl, and sat alone in the room to await the monster. Before long a gust of wind came up — and truly it sent stones rolling and sand flying. A fine wind it was:

At first it came soft and gentle, swaying; later it grew vast and boundless, dim. Soft and gentle — yet heaven and earth were great with it; vast and boundless — and nothing could withstand it.

Withering flowers, snapping willows, like crushing hemp; toppling trees, flattening woods, like pulling up greens. It churned the rivers and stirred the seas till ghosts and gods grieved; it split rocks and crumbled hills till Heaven and Earth marveled. The flower-grazing deer lost track of their way; the fruit-plucking apes were stranded abroad. Seven-storied iron pagodas leaned against the Buddha's head; eight-sided banners and pennants tore the precious canopies. Golden beams and jade pillars rocked at their roots; roof-tiles flew like swallows whirled away. The boatman, plying his oar, vowed offerings in fear; the ferryman, casting off, hastened to pledge pigs and sheep. The local earth-god abandoned his shrine; the Dragon Kings of the Four Seas bowed up toward heaven. Along the shore a yaksha's boat was

dashed to wreck, and half a stretch of the Great Wall was blown flat.

Where that wild wind passed, there appeared in mid-air a monster, and an ugly one indeed: a black face with short bristles, a long snout and great ears; he wore a cotton-weave gown that was neither quite green nor quite blue, with a kerchief of flowered cloth bound about him.

Wukong laughed to himself: "So this is the article!" He neither went to meet the creature nor questioned him, but lay upon the bed feigning illness, groaning and moaning without ceasing. The monster, unable to tell true from false, came into the room, threw his arms about "her," and would have a kiss. Wukong chuckled inwardly: "So he really means to come making sport of old Monkey!" He used a wrestling trick — caught hold of the monster's long snout, gave it a quick twist, a little throw they call it — wrenched the head over, and flung him sprawling off the bed with a thump. The monster scrambled up and, steadying himself against the bedside, said, "Sister, why are you cross with me today? I suppose it's because I came back late?" "Not cross, not cross," said Wukong. "If you're not cross with me," said the monster, "why throw me down like that?" Wukong said, "Why must you be so common, grabbing me to kiss the moment you come in? I'm a bit out of sorts today; if I were well as usual, I'd have got up and opened the door to wait for you. Just take off your clothes and lie down."

Not catching the meaning, the monster truly went to undress. Wukong sprang up and sat on the chamber-pot. The monster came groping back to the bed, felt about, and finding no one there, called, "Sister, where've you gone? Come, take off your things and lie down." "You first," said Wukong. "Wait till I've eased myself." So the monster took off his clothes and got into bed.

Then Wukong suddenly heaved a sigh and exclaimed, "What rotten luck!" "What's eating you?" said the monster. "How can your luck be rotten? Since I came into your family, though I've eaten a bit of your food, I've not eaten it for nothing: I've swept your floors and cleared your drains, hauled brick and carried tile, rammed earth and built walls, plowed the fields and harrowed the ground, sown wheat and set out rice-seedlings — I've built up your house and made your fortunes. Now you wear brocade on your back and gold in your hair, with flowers and fruit to enjoy in all four seasons and fresh vegetables at every festival. What is there still not to your liking, that you sigh and groan like this and talk of rotten luck?" "It isn't that," said Wukong. "Today my parents, just on the other side of the wall, were flinging bricks and tiles, abusing me roundly and cursing me." "Why should they beat and curse you?" said the monster. "They say," said Wukong, "that since you and I became man and wife, you, being a son-in-law of their house, have shown not the least propriety. A man with such an ugly mug, who cannot be presented to his wife's relations nor shown to the kin — and who knows where you come from, riding clouds and mists, what family you belong to, what your name is — you ruin their good name and disgrace their house, and that's why they beat and curse me so, and that's what grieves me."

"Ugly I may be," said the monster, "yet if it's good looks you want, that's no hard matter. When first I came, I made it plain to them, and only then, willingly, did they take me in. Why bring all this up today? My home is in the Cloud-Ladder Cave on the Fuling Mountains. I take my surname from my looks, and so my surname is Zhu — Hog — and my given name is Zhu Ganglie, Hog the Stiff-Bristles. If they ask you again, just tell them this." Wukong rejoiced in secret: "What an honest monster! No need for torture — he's confessed it all this plainly. Now that I have his place and his name, I'll catch him whatever happens."

Wukong said, "They mean to invite an exorcist to come and catch you." The monster laughed: "Go to sleep, go to sleep, and pay no mind to them. I have thirty-six transformations of the Heavenly Ladle's number and a nine-toothed muckrake — what do I care for exorcists, monks, or Taoists? Even if your old father were earnest enough to call down the Patriarch Exorcist of the Nine Heavens himself, I've been acquainted with him too, and he'd not dare do anything to me." "They say," said Wukong, "that they'll invite a certain one surnamed Sun — the Great Sage Equal to Heaven, who five hundred years ago made his great uproar in the Heavenly Palace — to come and catch you." The moment the monster heard that name, he was three parts frightened. "If that's how it is," he said, "I'd best be off — our marriage is at an end." "Why should you go off?" said Wukong. "You don't know," said the monster. "That Protector of the Horses who made the uproar in Heaven has real abilities, and I'm afraid I'd be no match for him; I'd lose my good name and cut a poor figure."

So saying, he pulled on his clothes, opened the door, and started straight out. But Wukong seized him fast, wiped a hand across his own face to reveal his true form, and bellowed, "Fine monster — where do you think you're going? Lift your head and see who I am!" The monster turned his eyes and saw Wukong's jutting fangs and gaping jaws, his fiery eyes and golden pupils, his butting brow and hairy face — the very image of a living Thunder God. He was so terrified that his hands went numb and his legs grew weak; with a ripping tear he burst clean out of his clothes, turned himself into a wild wind, and fled. Wukong hurried forward, raised his iron rod, and struck a blow at the wind. The monster turned into ten thousand shafts of fiery light and went straight back to his own mountain. Wukong mounted a cloud and gave chase, crying, "Where do you run? If you climb to the sky, I'll chase you to the Palace of the Dipper

and the Ox; if you go into the earth, I'll pursue you to the Hell of the Unjustly Dead!"

Ah! — but there is no telling, in the end, to what place this chase will lead, nor what the victory or defeat will be. Listen, and the next chapter will make it clear.

Chapter 19: The Cloud-Ladder Cave, Where Wukong Wins the Heart of the Pig

We left off with the monster racing ahead in a streak of fire, while the Great Sage came close behind on his banner of rosy cloud. As they flew, a high mountain suddenly reared up before them. The monster gathered his red glow into one knot, resumed his true shape, and plunged into a cave. From within he fetched out a nine-pronged muckrake and turned to give battle.

"Vile creature!" Wukong roared. "What demon are you, and from where? How do you come to know old Sun's name? Tell me plainly what powers you have, and I may yet spare your life."

"So you don't know my abilities either," the monster said. "Step up and stand your ground, and I'll tell you. Listen:

From my very birth my nature was crude and dull,
greedy for idleness, slothful, never resting. I never
nourished my spirit nor cultivated truth, but
muddled my heart and squandered the suns and
moons. Then one idle day I met a true immortal,
who sat and spoke with me of warmth and cold, and
urged me to turn back and not fall to the common
world, for harming life heaps up boundless sin.
When the great limit comes and the breath of life is
spent, the Eight Hardships and Three Paths leave no
time for regret. Hearing his words, my mind turned
toward the Way; hearing his counsel, my heart
sought the marvelous secret. By destiny I bowed
there and took him as my master, who showed me
the gates of Heaven and the doors of Earth. I
learned the Nine-Cycle Great Reverting Elixir, and
labored at it night and day without a pause. Up to
the Mud-Pellet Palace in the crown of the head,
down to the Bubbling-Spring point in the soles of
the feet. The kidney water flowed round into the

Floriante Pool, and the Cinnabar Field was warmed to a gentle heat. The Infant and the Fair Maiden joined yin and yang, lead and mercury combined, dividing sun and moon. The Li dragon and Kan tiger were harmonized, the numinous tortoise drank dry the golden crow's blood. The Three Flowers gathered at the crown and returned to the root, the Five Breaths faced the origin, flowing clear and through. My merit complete, my practice full, I rose in flight, and immortals came in pairs to welcome me. Bright colored clouds were born beneath my feet, light of body, sound of limb, I attended the golden gates. The Jade Emperor held a feast for the assembled immortals, ranking each by grade and arraying us in rows. By decree he made me Marshal of the Heavenly River, commander of all the water troops, bearing the rod of office. But when the Queen Mother held her Feast of Peaches, spreading a banquet at the Jasper Pool and inviting the guests, that day I grew drunk and my wits went dim,

lurching east and west, raising a drunken brawl. In my swagger I blundered into the Vast Cold Palace, where the lovely fairy maiden came to receive me. Seeing her beauty that steals away men's souls, my old mortal heart could not be quenched. Forgetting all rank, high and low, I lost all reverence, seized hold of Chang'e and demanded she lie with me. Three times, four times, she would not consent, dodging east and hiding west, her heart displeased. My lust grew bold as the sky, I bellowed like thunder, and nearly shook down the very gates of Heaven. The Inspector-General reported me to the Jade Emperor, and on that day my fortune was wretched indeed. The Vast Cold was ringed about, no breath of wind let through, no door to advance or retreat, no way to escape. Then the host of gods laid hold of me, but, with wine still in my breast, I felt no fear. Hauled up to the Hall of Divine Mists before the Jade Emperor, by the law I was sentenced to be put to death. I owe my life to the Great White

Planet, Li the Gold Star, who stepped from the ranks, bowed low, and pleaded for me. My sentence was changed to two thousand heavy blows; my flesh was split, my skin laid open, my bones near broken. Spared and banished, I was driven out of Heaven's gate, and below Mount Fuling I sought to make a home. Because of my sin I was thrown into the wrong womb, and so my common name is Zhu Ganglie, the Bristled Hog."

When Wukong heard this he said, "So you are the Water God, Marshal Tianpeng, fallen to the lower world. No wonder you knew old Sun's name."

"Hah!" cried the monster. "You insolent Bimawen, you Keeper of the Heavenly Horses! When you stirred up that calamity back then, you've no idea how many of us you dragged down with you. And now here you come again, bullying others. Enough of your rudeness — taste my rake!"

Wukong was hardly inclined to mercy. He lifted his cudgel and struck straight at the monster's head. The two of them fought there halfway up the mountain in the black of night. It was a fine battle:

The Monkey's golden eyes flashed like lightning,
The demon's ringed eyes glittered like silver flowers.
This one spat colored mist from his mouth, That
one breathed out red clouds from his lungs. Red
clouds breathed out lit up the dark, Colored mist
spat gave the night its glow. The gold-banded
cudgel, the nine-pronged rake — Two heroes truly
worth the praising: One the Great Sage come down
to the mortal world, One the Marshal banished to
the ends of the sky. That one, for losing his dignity,
had become a monster; This one, having luckily
escaped his torments, had joined the holy order.
The rake came in like a dragon stretching its claws,
The cudgel met it like a phoenix piercing the
flowers. That one cried, "Wrecking a man's marriage
is like killing his father!" This one cried, "Raping a
young girl deserves arrest!" Idle words and wild
shouting, Back and forth, cudgel against rake. They
fought on until the sky began to lighten, And the
monster felt both his shoulders go sore and numb.

The two of them battled from the second watch of the night clear through till the east turned white. The monster could fight no longer; beaten, he fled, changing once more into a wild gust of wind and bolting straight back to his cave, where he barred the door fast and would not show his head again.

Outside the cave Wukong saw a stone tablet inscribed with three characters: Cloud-Ladder Cave. Since the monster would not come out and it was now full daylight, he thought to himself, "My master may be anxious and waiting. I had best go back and let him see me, then return to catch this fiend — there's no harm in waiting that long." So with a single step on the cloud he soon arrived at the Gao Family Village.

Tripitaka had passed the whole night talking with the old men of past and present, never sleeping a wink. He was just wondering why Wukong had not returned when, all at once, Wukong appeared standing in the courtyard. Wukong put away his iron cudgel, straightened his robe, and stepped up into the hall. "Master, I'm back," he called.

The old men, flustered, all bowed together and thanked him: "Such trouble for you, such trouble!"

Tripitaka asked, "Wukong, you've been gone the whole night — where is the monster you caught?"

"Master," said Wukong, "that monster is no common evil spirit of the mortal world, nor a wild beast of the mountains. He is the Marshal of the Heavenly Reeds, come down among men. Only because he was cast into the wrong womb his face is shaped like a wild boar — yet his spiritual nature remains intact. He told me he takes his very form for his surname and is called Zhu Ganglie, the Bristled Hog. Old Sun went after him with the cudgel from the rear courtyard, but he turned into a gust of wind and got away. I caught him with one blow as he rode the wind, and he

changed into a streak of fire and made straight for his home cave. There he fetched out a nine-pronged muckrake and fought me the whole night through. Just now, as the sky was about to brighten, he lost his nerve and fled, barring his cave door tight and refusing to come out. I wanted to break the door down and have it out with him for good, but I feared you might be here worried and waiting, so I came first to bring you word."

When he had finished, old Gao came forward and knelt. "Reverend Sir, there's no help for it. You may have driven him off, but after you've gone he'll come back again — then what's to be done? Better, I beg you, that you take the trouble to seize him and pull him up by the roots, so there is no future trouble. I, old fellow that I am, will not be ungrateful: I'll have my kinsmen and friends draw up a deed and divide my whole estate — house, land, and goods — equally with you, Reverend. Only cut the grass and dig out the root, and don't let my honest house's good name be spoiled."

Wukong laughed. "Old man, you don't know your limits. That monster himself told me that, big eater though he is, in exchange for the tea and rice he consumed at your house he also did a great deal of good work — these past years he built up a fine fortune for you by his own strength alone. He didn't eat your food for nothing, so why are you so set on driving him off? By his own account he's a heavenly spirit come down to the lower world to slave away keeping your house, and he never once harmed your daughter. A son-in-law like that is well matched to your family and does no harm at all to your reputation or your good name. Truly, you might as well keep him."

"Reverend Sir," said old Gao, "though he does no harm to public morals, the name of it sounds none too pleasant. At every turn people say, 'The

Gao family has taken on a monster for a son-in-law.' How is anyone to bear a saying like that?"

Tripitaka said, "Wukong, since you've already had one round with him, finish the business and see it through to the end, so there is a proper beginning and a proper close."

"I was only testing him a little, for sport," said Wukong. "This time I'll surely bring him back for you all to see — don't fret." He called out, "Old Gao, take good care of my master. I'm off." And with that word he leapt, formless and shadowless, up to the mountain and came to the mouth of the cave. With a few strokes of his iron rod he smashed both leaves of the door to splinters, cursing aloud: "You chaff-eating clod! Come out quick and fight old Sun!"

The monster, panting and worn out, was just then asleep inside the cave. Hearing the door crash and hearing himself cursed as a chaff-eating clod, he could not master his fury. Dragging out his rake and rousing his spirits, he rushed out and railed in a fierce voice: "You Bimawen, you Keeper of Horses — what shameless gall! What business of yours is this, that you come breaking down my front gate? Look at the law: forcing your way in through a man's front gate is a capital offense among the lesser crimes!"

Wukong laughed. "You blockhead! Even if I have broken your gate, there's an argument to be made for it. But you — seizing a man's daughter without the three matchmakers and six witnesses, without so much as a cup of tea or a gift of wedding wine — now that's a true crime, worthy of beheading!"

"Enough of this idle talk," said the monster. "Look out for old Hog's rake!"

Wukong fended it off with his cudgel and said, "Is this the same rake you used as a hired hand at old Gao's, digging the ground and planting vegetables? What's so fine about it that I should fear it?"

"You've mistaken it," said the monster. "Do you take this rake for a thing of the mortal world? Just listen while I tell you:

This was forged from divine ice-iron, Ground and polished to a bright and gleaming work. Lord Lao himself wielded the hammer and tongs, And the Fire Star added the charcoal with his own hands. The Five Emperors of the Five Quarters lent their thought, The Six Ding and Six Jia spirits spent their pains. They wrought nine teeth of pendant jade, And cast two rings with leaves of hanging gold. Its body adorned with the Six Luminaries, ranged with the Five Stars, Its frame conformed to the Four Seasons and the Eight Festivals. Its length and breadth, high and low, fix Heaven and Earth; Left and right, yin and yang, divide the sun and moon. The spirit-generals of the Six Lines follow Heaven's statutes, The stars of the Eight Trigrams are ranged like the Dipper. It is named the Supreme Treasure, the Gold-Steeped Rake, Presented to the Jade Emperor to guard the Cinnabar Court. Because I had perfected myself as a Great Luo Immortal, Become a deathless guest of eternal life, By decree I

was made Marshal, titled Tianpeng, And granted
this muckrake as my imperial badge. Lift it up, and
it blazes with flame and radiant light; Bring it down,
and a fierce wind scatters auspicious snow. The
spirit-generals of the Heavenly Bureau are all
dismayed, And Yama of the Underworld loses his
nerve. Where in the mortal world is there a weapon
like this? In all the earth there is no such iron. It
changes its shape at will to suit my mind, Tumbling
and turning as my spell directs. For several years it
has gone with me, never parted; For many a year it
has kept me company, no day apart. At my three
daily meals it is never set aside; At my single night's
sleep it is never put away. I have carried it to the
Feast of the Peaches, And borne it to attend at the
Imperial Court. But because I leaned on wine and
turned to violence, Because I trusted in my strength
and ran wild, Heaven banished me down to the
mortal dust, And in the lower world I worked out
my sins. In the stone cave my evil heart once

devoured men, At Gao Village my fond heart made a marriage. This rake, plunged into the sea, overturns the dragons' and crocodiles' dens; Raised in the mountains, it tears apart the tigers' and wolves' lairs. Of all the other weapons let's say no more — There is none so keen as this rake of mine. To win the contest by it is no hard thing; To gain merit in the fight needs no saying. Though your head be bronze and your skull be iron, your whole body steel, When the rake strikes, your soul will flee and your spirit drain away."

Hearing this, Wukong put away his iron cudgel and said, "Stop your boasting, blockhead. Old Sun will stick his head out right here — give it one stroke and let's see if my soul flees and my spirit drains."

The monster truly raised his rake and brought it down with all his force. There was a loud crack; the rake threw off a shower of flickering sparks — yet it had not so much as stirred a single hair of the scalp. The shock left his hands numb and his legs weak, and he cried out, "What a head! What a head!"

"You don't understand," said Wukong. "When old Sun made havoc in Heaven — stealing the elixir of immortality, robbing the peaches, filching the imperial wine — I was captured by the Young Sage Erlang and held before the Dipper-and-Bull Palace. The host of heavenly gods hacked at

me with axes, pounded me with mallets, slashed me with knives, stabbed me with swords, burned me with fire, and struck me with thunder, and never harmed me a jot. Then Lord Lao the Supreme took me away and set me in his Eight-Trigrams Furnace, where he tempered me with divine fire and refined me into one with fiery eyes and golden pupils, a bronze head and iron arms. If you don't believe it, give me a few more strokes and see whether it hurts or not."

"Monkey," said the monster, "I remember that when you stirred up Heaven, your home was in the Water-Curtain Cave on the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit, in the Aolai Country of the Eastern Continent of Superior Body. It's been so long since I've heard your name — how do you come to be here, knocking at my door to bully me? Could it be my father-in-law went and invited you?"

"Your father-in-law never invited me," said Wukong. "It's because old Sun has reformed from evil and returned to the right, given up the Way of the Tao for the order of monks, and now guards a holy man — the younger brother by imperial favor of the Great Tang Emperor in the Land of the East, a master of the Law called Tripitaka, bound for the Western Heaven to bow before Buddha and seek the scriptures. Passing through Gao Village, we lodged for the night, and when the old man brought up the matter in conversation, he begged me to rescue his daughter and seize you, you chaff-eating clod."

The moment the monster heard this, he flung down his rake and made a deep bow. "Where is this scripture-seeker? Pray take the trouble to introduce me."

"What do you want with him?" asked Wukong.

"It was the Bodhisattva Guanyin who exhorted me to do good," said the monster. "I took the vows from her, and here I keep a fast and abstain

from meat, waiting for her command to follow the scripture-seeker to the Western Heaven, bow before Buddha and seek the scriptures, and so atone for my sins and win the true fruit. She told me to wait for him these several years, but I had heard no news. Now since you are his disciple, why didn't you say so at the start — instead of trusting to brute strength and coming to my door to thrash me?"

"Don't think you can trick me with cunning words, hoping for some scheme to slip free," said Wukong. "If you truly mean to protect the Tang Monk, with no falsehood, then swear an oath to Heaven, and I'll take you to see my master."

The monster dropped flat to his knees and, bowing toward the sky like a pestle pounding rice, kowtowed again and again: "Amitabha, Namó Buddha — if I am not sincere and true in heart, may I be charged with breaking the laws of Heaven and have my corpse hacked into ten thousand pieces."

Seeing him swear and vow so earnestly, Wukong said, "Very well. Then set a fire and burn down this dwelling of yours, and I'll take you along." The monster truly gathered up some reeds and brambles, lit a torch, and burned the Cloud-Ladder Cave until nothing remained but a heap of broken tiles. He said to Wukong, "Now I've nothing left to hold me back. Lead me away."

"Hand me your rake to hold," said Wukong. The monster passed it over. Then Wukong plucked out a single hair, blew on it with a breath of immortal air, and cried, "Change!" At once it became a three-stranded hemp rope. He stepped over and bound the monster's hands behind his back. The monster let his hands be tied without resistance, submitting to whatever binding Wukong chose. Then Wukong seized him by the ear and dragged him along, calling, "Hurry up, hurry up!"

"Go gently, won't you," said the monster. "Your hand's heavy — you're hurting the root of my ear."

"I can't go gently — there's no helping you," said Wukong. "As the old saying has it, 'A good hog is roughly handled.' Only when you've seen my master and proved you truly mean it will I let you go." So the two of them, half on cloud and half in mist, made straight back to the Gao Family Village. There is a verse to prove it:

The hard, strong nature of metal can subdue wood;
The Mind-Monkey has brought the Wood-Dragon to
heel. Metal and wood, when they accord, become
one; Wood, cleaving to metal's kindness, brings all
to full play. Host and guest, the two, with no
division between them; Three meetings, three
unions, holding a subtle mystery. Nature and feeling
alike rejoice when truth and origin are gathered;
Together they prove the West — and the saying
does not fail.

In a moment they reached the front of the village. Wukong, holding the rake and gripping the monster's ear, said, "Look — who is it sitting so solemnly there in the hall? That is my master." When old Gao and his kinsmen and friends saw Wukong bringing the monster along, hands bound behind him and ear firmly in hand, every one of them came

joyfully to meet them in the courtyard, crying, "Reverend Sir, Reverend Sir — that's our son-in-law, sure enough!"

The monster stepped forward, fell to both knees, and, with his hands still bound behind him, kowtowed to Tripitaka, calling out, "Master, your disciple failed to welcome you! Had I known you were lodging at my father-in-law's house, I'd have come to receive you, and not put myself through all this trouble."

"Wukong," said Tripitaka, "how did you subdue him so that he comes to bow before me?"

Only then did Wukong let go his hand, and tapping the monster with the handle of the rake, he barked, "Blockhead — speak!" The monster then recounted in full how the Bodhisattva had exhorted him to do good.

Tripitaka was overjoyed and called out, "Squire Gao, bring out an incense table." Old Gao hurried to carry one out. Tripitaka washed his hands, lit incense, and bowed to the south, saying, "My deep thanks for the Bodhisattva's holy grace." The old men added their own incense and bowed together. When the worship was done, Tripitaka took the high seat in the hall and bade Wukong loose the monster's bonds. Wukong gave his body a shake and drew the hair back into himself, and the binding came undone of itself. The monster bowed anew to Tripitaka and vowed to follow him to the West. He bowed also to Wukong and, since Wukong had entered the order first, called him elder brother, addressing him as Brother Wukong.

"Since you have embraced the good fruit and wish to be my disciple," said Tripitaka, "let me give you a religious name, so that it will be easy to call you morning and night."

"Master," said the monster, "the Bodhisattva already touched the crown of my head, gave me the vows, and named me Zhu Wuneng — Awakened to Power."

Tripitaka smiled. "Good, good. Your elder brother is called Wukong, and you are called Wuneng — truly you belong to the same lineage within my school."

"Master," said Wuneng, "I took the Bodhisattva's vows and cut off the five pungent roots and the three forbidden meats; at my father-in-law's house I kept a strict fast and never once touched meat. But now that I've seen you, my master, may I break my fast?"

"No, no," said Tripitaka. "Since you do not eat the five pungent roots or the three forbidden meats, let me give you another name as well — I shall call you Bajie, the Eight Prohibitions."

The simpleton, delighted, said, "I humbly obey my master's command." And so he became known also as Zhu Bajie.

When old Gao saw him turn from evil and return to the right path, he was all the more pleased, and ordered his servants to prepare a banquet to thank the Tang Monk. Bajie went up and caught hold of old Gao by the arm. "Father-in-law," he said, "won't you ask my poor wife to come out and pay her respects to her grandfather-in-law and uncles?"

Wukong laughed. "Worthy brother, now that you've entered the gate of the Way — become a monk — from this day on you mustn't bring up that talk of 'my poor wife' again. In this world there may be such a thing as a married Taoist priest; but where did anyone ever hear of a married monk? Let's simply take our seats in order, eat a vegetarian meal, and get an early start on the road west."

Old Gao arranged the tables and asked Tripitaka to take the place of honor; Wukong and Bajie sat to left and right, and the kinsmen took the lower seats. Old Gao opened a jar of vegetarian wine, filled a cup to the brim, poured a libation to Heaven and Earth, and offered the first cup to Tripitaka.

"To tell the truth, Squire," said Tripitaka, "this poor monk has been a vegetarian since the womb and has never eaten meat from childhood."

"Knowing your reverence's pure abstinence," said old Gao, "I have not dared to serve any meat. This wine, too, is of the pure sort — surely there is no harm in one cup."

"I dare not take wine either," said Tripitaka. "Wine is the first of the prohibitions for us monks."

Wuneng grew flustered. "Master, I kept the fast, but I never gave up wine."

"Old Sun's capacity is small — I cannot manage a whole jar," said Wukong, "but I never gave up wine either."

"Well then," said Tripitaka, "let my two disciples drink a little of the vegetarian wine — only no drinking to drunkenness and spoiling our affairs." So the two of them took the first cups. Then all sat down again as before, and the vegetarian feast was spread. Words could not exhaust the splendor of the cups and dishes or the abundance of the fare.

When master and disciples had finished their feast, old Gao brought out a red-lacquered tray bearing two hundred taels of broken gold and silver, which he offered to the three reverends for their traveling expenses; he also brought three robes of padded cloth to serve as outer garments.

Tripitaka said, "We are mendicant monks, begging our rice at the villages and our meals wherever we go. How could we dare accept gold, silver, and silk?"

But Wukong stepped forward, swept out his hand, grabbed a fistful, and called, "Gaocai! Yesterday you took the trouble to lead my master here, and today we have gained a new disciple, yet we have nothing to thank you with. Take this broken gold and silver as a guide's fee, and buy yourself some straw sandals. Hereafter, whenever there are monsters about, bring me a few more of these jobs, and there will be more to thank you for." Gaocai took it, kowtowed, and thanked him for the reward.

Old Gao spoke again. "Since the reverends will not accept gold or silver, I hope you will graciously receive these coarse garments as a small token of my regard."

"We who have left the household life," said Tripitaka, "if we accept so much as a thread of bribe, will struggle through a thousand kalpas without attaining the Way. It will be quite enough to take along some of the cakes and fruit left over from the feast as dry rations."

But Bajie spoke up from the side. "Master, brother — don't you two be so hasty. I've been a son-in-law in this house these several years; my back-pay alone ought to come to three measures of grain. Father-in-law! My cassock was torn by my brother last night — give me a robe of green brocade. And my shoes have split — give me a good new pair." Old Gao, hearing this, dared not refuse, and at once brought out a new pair of shoes and a padded gown, exchanging them for the old worn things.

Then Bajie, swaggering this way and that, made a bow to old Gao and said, "Convey my respects to my mother-in-law, to the elder and younger aunts, to the uncles and all the kin. I'm off today to be a monk and

haven't time to take my leave to their faces — don't hold it against me. Father-in-law, take good care of my wife, won't you. For if we should fail to get the scriptures, I can always come back and return to lay life, and go on being your son-in-law as before."

"Clod!" Wukong shouted. "Don't talk such nonsense."

"It's not nonsense," said Bajie. "I'm only afraid that if there's some slip along the way, I'll have spoiled my chance both at being a monk and at having a wife, and be left empty-handed on both counts."

"Enough idle chatter," said Tripitaka. "Let's get an early start." So they packed up the luggage, which Bajie shouldered; saddled the white horse, which Tripitaka rode; and Wukong, his iron cudgel across his shoulder, led the way in front. The three of them together took leave of old Gao and all his kin and friends, and set off westward. There is a verse to prove it:

Smoke and rosy mist filling the land, the tree-colors high; The Buddha's son of the Tang, toiling on in bitter labor. Hungry, he eats from one bowl the rice of a thousand homes; Cold, he wears against the chill one patched robe of a thousand stitches. Let the will-horse in your breast not run loose and wild; Let the mind-monkey, willful and wayward, not be allowed to howl. When feeling is calmed and nature is settled, all conditions accord; When the moon is full in the golden flower, the hair is trimmed away.

The three of them traveled on along the western road, and for a month or so all was smooth and steady. They passed beyond the borders of Tibet, when suddenly, looking up, they saw a high mountain before them. Tripitaka reined in his horse and said, "Wukong, Wuneng — the mountain ahead is high; you must be very, very careful."

"No matter," said Bajie. "This mountain is called Vulture Peak. In it lives a Zen Master of the Crow's Nest, who cultivates his practice here. Old Hog has met him before."

"What is his business?" asked Tripitaka.

"He has some attainment of the Way," said Bajie. "He once urged me to follow him in his practice, but I never went, and that was the end of it."

As master and disciples talked, before long they arrived at the mountain.
A fine mountain it was! Behold:

On the mountain's south, green pines and emerald cypress; On the mountain's north, green willows and red peach. Noisily, mountain birds answer one another; Fluttering in dance, immortal cranes fly together. Fragrant, fragrant, the flowers in a thousand hues; Green and luxuriant, the mingled grasses in ten thousand wonders. Below the ravine, water rushes green; Before the cliff, auspicious clouds in drifting flakes. Truly a place of uncommon quiet and grace, Still and silent, with never a traveler in sight.

The master, gazing far from his horse, saw before a fragrant cypress a nest of brushwood and grass; on the left a river-deer held a flower in its mouth, on the right a mountain monkey offered fruit; and in the treetops blue simurghs and colored phoenixes sang together, while dark cranes and brocade pheasants gathered all around. Bajie pointed and said, "There — isn't that the Crow's Nest Zen Master?" Tripitaka spurred his horse forward and rode straight up beneath the tree.

When the Zen Master saw the three of them coming, he left his nest at once and leapt down from the tree. Tripitaka dismounted and made his

bow. The Zen Master raised him up with his hand, saying, "Holy monk, please rise. Forgive my failure to welcome you." Bajie said, "Old Zen Master, my respects." The Zen Master started in surprise and asked, "Aren't you Zhu Ganglie of Mount Fuling? How have you come by such good fortune as to travel with this holy monk?"

"The year before last," said Bajie, "I had the grace of the Bodhisattva Guanyin's exhortation and vowed to follow him as a disciple."

"Good, good, good!" cried the Zen Master with great joy. Then, pointing at Wukong, he asked, "And who is this one?"

Wukong laughed. "How is it, old Zen Master, that you know him but don't know me?"

"Because I've had little acquaintance with you," said the Zen Master.

"He is my eldest disciple, Sun Wukong," said Tripitaka.

The Zen Master smiled apologetically. "My oversight, my oversight."

Tripitaka bowed again. "May I ask where the Great Thunderclap Monastery of the Western Heaven lies?"

"Far, far away," said the Zen Master. "The road is thick with tigers and leopards, and hard to travel."

Tripitaka pressed his inquiry earnestly, asking again, "Just how far is it, in truth?"

"Far though the road may be," said the Zen Master, "in the end there will surely come a day of arrival — only the demon-miasmas are hard to dispel. I have a scroll of the *Heart Sutra*, fifty-four sentences in all, two hundred and seventy characters together. Whenever you come to a place of demon-miasma, recite this sutra, and you will suffer no harm."

Tripitaka prostrated himself on the ground and earnestly begged to receive it, and the Zen Master then recited and transmitted it to him by mouth. The sutra runs:

The Maha Prajna-paramita Heart Sutra: When the Bodhisattva Avalokiteshvara was practicing the deep Prajna-paramita, he illuminated and saw that the five aggregates are all empty, and so passed beyond all suffering and distress. Shariputra, form is not different from emptiness, emptiness is not different from form; form is itself emptiness, emptiness is itself form. So too are sensation, perception, volition, and consciousness. Shariputra, all these things are marked with emptiness: they neither arise nor cease, are neither defiled nor pure, neither increase nor decrease. Therefore in emptiness there is no form, no sensation, perception, volition, or consciousness; no eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, or mind; no form, sound, smell, taste, touch, or thought; no realm of the eye, and so on up to no realm of mind-consciousness; no ignorance, and no ending of ignorance; and so on up to no old-age-and-death, and no ending of old-age-and-death. There is no suffering, no origin, no cessation, no

path; no wisdom and no attainment. Because there is nothing to attain, the Bodhisattva, relying on Prajna-paramita, has a mind without hindrance; and because there is no hindrance, there is no fear. Far removed from all confused dream-thoughts, he reaches the ultimate Nirvana. The Buddhas of the three ages, relying on Prajna-paramita, attain Anuttara-samyak-sambodhi. Therefore know that Prajna-paramita is the great divine spell, the great spell of light, the supreme spell, the spell beyond all spells, able to remove all suffering — true and not false. So he proclaimed the spell of Prajna-paramita, the spell that runs: "Gate, gate, paragate, parasamgate, bodhi svaha!"

Now this master of the Law of the Tang dynasty had a foundation of true roots, so that on hearing the *Heart Sutra* through but once, he could remember it entire; and so it has come down to the world to this day. This is the all-encompassing scripture of cultivating the truth, the gateway to becoming a Buddha.

When the Zen Master had transmitted the text of the sutra, he stepped onto a radiant cloud, meaning to return to his Crow's Nest. But Tripitaka

caught hold of him again and would not let go, insisting that he tell him plainly the road that lay to the west. The Zen Master smiled and said:

The road is not hard to travel; Just listen to my instructions. A thousand mountains, a thousand streams, deep; Many a miasma, many a demon-haunted place. If you come to a cliff that reaches the sky, Set your heart at ease and do not fear. When you reach the Ear-Rubbing Crag, Tread sidelong, planting your steps with care. Be wary of the Black Pine Forest, Where demon foxes throng to block the road. Sprites fill the cities and the towns, Demon-lords crowd the mountains where they dwell. Old tigers sit as masters in the hall, Gray wolves serve as registrars. Lions and elephants all call themselves kings, Tigers and leopards all act as courtiers. A wild boar shoulders the carrying-pole, A water-fiend you'll meet up ahead. An ancient stone monkey of many years — there harbors a smoldering wrath. Ask of one well acquainted there: he knows the road that runs to the west.

Hearing this, Wukong gave a cold laugh. "Let's be off. There's no need to ask him — ask me, and that's enough." Tripitaka still did not catch his meaning. The Zen Master changed into a beam of golden light and went straight up to his Crow's Nest. The elder bowed upward in thanks, but in his heart Wukong was greatly enraged, and he raised his iron cudgel and lashed wildly upward — only to see a thousand lotus blossoms spring forth and auspicious mists shield the nest in a thousand layers. Though Wukong had strength to churn the seas and overturn rivers, he could not so much as tug loose a single vine of the Crow's Nest.

When Tripitaka saw this he caught hold of Wukong. "Wukong, what do you mean by smashing a Bodhisattva's nest like this?"

"He cursed the two of us — my brother and me — and then went off," said Wukong.

"He was speaking of the road to the Western Heaven," said Tripitaka. "When did he ever curse you?"

"How would you understand?" said Wukong. "When he said 'a wild boar shoulders the carrying-pole,' that was a jibe at Bajie; and 'an ancient stone monkey of many years' was a jibe at old Sun. How could you make out his meaning?"

"Brother, calm your anger," said Bajie. "This Zen Master knows the things of past and future alike. Let's simply see whether his words 'a water-fiend you'll meet up ahead' prove true or not, and let him be." Seeing the lotus blossoms and auspicious mists still wreathing the nest, Wukong could only ask his master to mount, and they descended the mountain and pressed on toward the west. And as they went:

It surely makes pure blessings few among men, And
causes calamity and demons to throng in the
mountains.

In the end there is no knowing how the road ahead truly turned out — so
listen to the next chapter for the explanation.

Chapter 20: The Yellow Wind Ridge and the Tiger Vanguard

The Dharma is born from the mind, and from the mind it likewise dies. Birth and death — by whom are they decreed? Reader, judge for yourself. Since all of it is your own mind, why need another tell you so? Only set yourself to bitter toil, and wring the blood from iron. Thread the soft cord through the nose, and tie it fast in the empty void. Tether it to the tree of non-doing, and let it not run wild.

Mistake not the thief for a son; let mind and Dharma both be wholly forgotten. Suffer him not to deceive you — strike him through with the first blow of your fist. When mind appears, there is no mind; when Dharma appears, Dharma too falls still. When neither man nor ox is seen, the blue sky shines clear and bright. Round as the autumn moon — and which is which, none can tell apart.

This verse is the hymn that the Master of the Law, Tripitaka, composed when he had pierced through to the heart of the *Heart Sutra* and thrown open the door of understanding. The elder recited it always and held it close, so that a single point of holy light shone clear within him.

Now the three of them ate the wind and slept by the water, journeyed beneath the moon and cloaked in starlight, until at last the season turned to the blazing heat of summer. And this is what they saw:

The flowers all spent, no butterflies remained to court them; the trees grown tall, the cicadas shrilled their clamor. Wild silkworms spun their cocoons; the fiery pomegranate bloomed; and in the ponds the fresh new lotus rose.

One day, as they were walking, evening came on suddenly, and beside the mountain road they spied a village dwelling. Tripitaka said, "Wukong, look — the setting sun has hidden its mirror of fire behind the western hills, and the moon lifts its wheel of ice from the eastern sea. Luckily there is a household by the road. Let us beg a night's lodging here and travel on tomorrow."

Zhu Bajie said, "Well said. Old Hog is getting rather hungry too. Let's go to that house and beg some food, so we'll have strength enough to carry the luggage."

The Pilgrim said, "You homesick ghost — you've been away from home only a few days, and already you're full of complaints."

"Brother," said Bajie, "I'm not like you, who can live on wind and breathe in smoke. Since I joined the Master these past days, I've gone half-starved the whole while. Did you know that?"

Hearing this, Tripitaka said, "Wuneng, if your heart is so heavy with thoughts of home, then you are no true monk. You may as well go back."

Frightened, the blockhead dropped to his knees. "Master, don't listen to my elder brother — he has a way of slandering people. I never complained about anything, and he says I complain. I'm a plain, straight-gutted fool. All I said was that my belly was empty and we ought to find a house and beg some food, and he calls me a homesick ghost. Master, I have received the Bodhisattva's commandments, and I have your kind pity besides. I am willing to serve you all the way to the Western Heaven, and I swear I shall never turn back in regret. This is what they call 'enduring bitterness to cultivate the Way.' How can you say these are not the words of a true monk?"

"If that is so," said Tripitaka, "then get up."

The blockhead sprang to his feet, muttering and grumbling under his breath, shouldered the carrying-pole, and resigned himself to following along. Soon they reached the door of the roadside house. Tripitaka dismounted, the Pilgrim took the bridle, and Bajie set down the luggage, and they all stood waiting in the cool green shade. Tripitaka, leaning on his nine-ringed staff and straightening his rattan-woven bamboo hat, went first to the door. There he saw an old man reclining on a bamboo couch, his lips murmuring the name of the Buddha. Not daring to speak loudly, Tripitaka called out softly, "Patron, my greetings to you."

The old man scrambled up in a single bound, hastily gathered his robe, and came out to return the greeting. "Reverend, forgive me for not

welcoming you. Where have you come from, and why have you come to my humble door?"

"I am a poor monk from the Great Tang in the eastern land," said Tripitaka, "sent by imperial decree to the Thunderclap Monastery to worship the Buddha and seek the scriptures. Reaching your honored region just as night fell, I had a mind to beg a single night's shelter at your gracious house. I beg you, grant us this small kindness."

The old man waved his hands and shook his head. "You cannot go. The scriptures of the Western Heaven are not to be had. If you must seek scriptures, go to the eastern heaven instead."

Tripitaka said nothing aloud, but inwardly he pondered: *The Bodhisattva pointed me westward — why does this old man say to go east? What scriptures could there be in the east?* Shy and uncertain, he stood for a long while without answering.

But the Pilgrim, fierce and headstrong by nature, could hold back no longer. He stepped forward and cried out, "You old fellow, with all those years on you, you understand nothing at all. We are men who have left the household life, come from far away to beg a night's lodging — and you try to frighten us off with such dreary, dull talk. If your house is so cramped that there's nowhere to sleep, then we'll sit out the night beneath the trees and not trouble you at all."

The old man caught hold of Tripitaka. "Master, you say nothing, but that disciple of yours — that crook-faced, hollow-cheeked creature with the thunder-god's beak and the red eyes, that consumptive little devil — how dare he affront an old man like me?"

The Pilgrim laughed. "Old man, you've got no eye for things at all. The handsome ones — they're what we call 'fine to look at but no good to

eat.' Now old Sun, though I'm small, I'm tough as can be — every inch of me wrapped in sinew."

"You must have some skills, then," said the old man.

"I'll not boast," said the Pilgrim, "but I'll do well enough to get by."

"Where is your home," asked the old man, "and what made you shave your head and become a monk?"

"Old Sun's ancestral home," said the Pilgrim, "is the Water-Curtain Cave on the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit, in the Aolai Country east of the sea, in the Eastern Continent of Superior Body. From childhood I learned to be a monster, and I called myself Wukong. By my own abilities I made myself a Great Sage Equal to Heaven. But because I would not accept Heaven's registry, I rebelled in the great revolt against the Celestial Palace and brought a great calamity down upon myself. Now, having escaped that disaster and dissolved that doom, I have turned to the gate of the Buddha and seek the right fruit ahead. I am guarding this Master of mine, who serves under the Tang court, on his way to worship the Buddha in the Western Heaven. What do I fear of high mountains and perilous roads, of broad waters and wild waves? Old Sun can catch demons and subdue fiends, tame tigers and capture dragons, kick the sky and stir the wells — I know a little of all of it. And should there be any brick-throwing or tile-flinging at your house, any pot that howls or door that opens of itself, old Sun can set it all at peace."

When the old man heard this speech, he laughed aloud. "So you're a glib-tongued monk who goes about knocking on doors begging alms."

"Your son's the glib-tongued one," said the Pilgrim. "Me — I've been so weary tramping the road after my Master all this time that I've even grown too lazy to talk."

"If you weren't weary, and weren't too lazy to talk," said the old man, "I dare say you'd chatter me clean to death. But since you have such skills, then the Western Heaven can be reached after all — yes, it can be reached. How many are there in your party? Come into my thatched hut and rest the night."

"Many thanks to you, old patron, for not driving us off," said Tripitaka. "There are three in my party."

"And where is the third?" asked the old man.

The Pilgrim pointed. "This old fellow's eyes are dim — isn't that him standing there in the green shade?"

The old man's eyes were indeed dim. He raised his head and looked carefully, and the moment he caught sight of Bajie's face he was so terrified that he went stumbling and tripping at every step, running pell-mell into the house and crying, "Shut the door! Shut the door! A monster is coming!"

The Pilgrim ran up and caught hold of him. "Don't be afraid, old man. He's no monster — he's my fellow disciple."

Trembling all over, the old man said, "Well, well, well — each monk uglier than the last."

Bajie stepped forward. "Old sir, if you judge people by their looks, you're clean mistaken. Ugly we may be, but we're all of us useful."

While the old man stood at the door talking with the three monks, two young men from the southern end of the farmstead came home from transplanting rice, bringing with them an old woman and three or four small children, their clothes tucked up and their feet bare. Seeing a white horse and a load of luggage clustered at their door, and not knowing

what manner of folk these were, they all rushed forward and demanded, "What are you doing here?"

Bajie turned his head, wagged his ears a few times, and stretched out his long snout — and the sight so terrified those people that they went toppling this way and that, scattering and tumbling in confusion. In a fluster, Tripitaka called out to them, "Don't be afraid, don't be afraid! We are not evil men — we are monks going to fetch the scriptures."

Only then did the old man come back out the door, and taking the old woman by the arm, he said, "Get up, granny, and don't be so frightened. This master comes from the Tang court. It's only that his disciples are a bit ugly of face — but they're foul of feature and fair of heart. Take the children indoors." The old woman clung to his arm, and the two young men led the children inside.

Tripitaka sat down upon the bamboo couch in the gatehouse and grumbled, "Disciples — the two of you, with your ugly faces and coarse tongues, have frightened this whole household half to death. You're heaping sins upon me!"

"I'll not deceive you, Master," said Bajie. "Since Old Hog joined you, I've grown a good deal handsomer. Why, back in the old days at the Gao family village, if I jutted my snout out front and wagged my ears at both ends, I'd scare twenty or thirty people to death at a stroke."

The Pilgrim laughed. "Blockhead, stop your nonsense — and tidy that ugliness away a bit."

"Listen to what Wukong says," said Tripitaka. "His looks are what he was born with. How do you expect him to tidy them away?"

"Tuck that rake-snout of his into his bosom and don't let it out," said the Pilgrim, "and press those fan-ears flat against the back of his head and

don't let them flap — that's what I call tidying up."

So Bajie did indeed tuck in his snout and flatten his ears, and bowing his head he stood off to one side. The Pilgrim carried the luggage in through the door and tethered the white horse to a post.

Presently the old man came leading a young man who carried a wooden tray, and they offered the three guests cups of clear tea. When the tea was done, he gave orders for a meal to be prepared. The young man fetched an old table, full of holes and stripped of its lacquer, and set out two broken-backed, splay-legged stools in the courtyard, inviting the three of them to sit in the cool evening air. Tripitaka asked, "Old patron, what is your honored surname?"

"My humble name is Wang," said the old man.

"And how many sons have you?"

"Two boys, and three little grandsons."

"Congratulations, congratulations," said Tripitaka. "And how old are you?"

"I have foolishly reached sixty-one years."

"Good, good, good," said the Pilgrim — "you've come round to a second cycle of the sixty-year span."

Tripitaka asked again, "Old patron, why did you say at first that the scriptures of the Western Heaven are hard to fetch?"

"It is not the scriptures that are hard to fetch," said the old man, "but the road that is rough and hard to travel. About thirty li west of here there is a mountain called the Yellow Wind Ridge, eight hundred li across, and in that mountain there are many monsters. That is why I said it would be

hard. But if this little reverend truly has such skills as he claims, then it can be done."

"No matter, no matter," said the Pilgrim. "With old Sun here, and this fellow disciple of mine, no monster — whatever it may be — will dare to trouble us."

While they were speaking, the son brought in the rice and set it on the table. "Please, eat," he said. Tripitaka pressed his palms together and began to chant the grace before meals. But Bajie had already gulped down a whole bowl, and before the elder had finished the few lines of his grace, the blockhead had bolted down three more.

"This chaff-guzzler," said the Pilgrim — "he must have run smack into a hungry ghost."

Old Wang, seeing how swiftly he ate and understanding how things stood, said, "This reverend must be truly famished. Quick, bring more rice." And indeed the blockhead's gullet was vast — never lifting his head, he downed a dozen bowls one after another, while Tripitaka and the Pilgrim each ate scarcely two. Still the blockhead would not stop, but kept on eating.

"We had no relish ready on such short notice, and dare not press you hard," said old Wang. "Do take another mouthful."

"Enough for us," said Tripitaka and the Pilgrim together.

But Bajie said, "Old man, what are you dithering about? Who's asking you to cast my fortune, prattling on about five lines and six lines? If there's rice, just keep bringing it." And so the blockhead, at one sitting, ate up every last grain in the whole household's stores, and still claimed he was only half full. Then the cooking things were cleared away, and

beneath the gatehouse a bamboo bed and plank pallet were made up, and they lay down to sleep.

The next day at dawn, the Pilgrim went to saddle the horse and Bajie went to arrange the luggage. Old Wang had the old woman prepare a few cakes and some hot broth to see them on their way, and then the three thanked him and took their leave. "If you should meet with any mishap on the road ahead," said the old man, "be sure to come back to my hut."

"Old man," said the Pilgrim, "speak no foolish words. We who have left the household never walk the road back." And so they whipped the horse and shouldered the load and set off westward.

Ah! Going on like this — west toward the Western Region there is surely no easy road, and there must be some evil fiend waiting to bring down a great disaster. The three had not gone half a day before they came upon a high mountain, towering and exceedingly steep. When Tripitaka rode his horse up to the brink of the cliff and tilted his precious hat to look, he saw truly:

High were the mountains; sheer were the ridges; steep were the cliffs; deep were the gorges; loud were the springs; bright were the flowers. The mountain — how high? Its peak touched the blue empyrean. The ravine — how deep? At its bottom one could glimpse the underworld. Before the mountain rolled banks of white cloud and jugged grotesque crags, and there stretched, beyond all telling, cliffs a thousand and ten thousand fathoms high that clutched at the very soul. Behind the cliffs wound a twisting Hidden-Dragon Cave, and within the cave, drip by drip, a dripping water-ledge. There one saw branching, antlered deer, and dull, gazing river-deer that stared at men; coiling red-scaled pythons, and frisking, white-faced apes. At dusk the mountain tigers sought their lairs; at dawn the dragons churned the waves and rose from the water, so the cave-mouth boomed and roared. Birds in the grass flapped whirring up; beasts in the forest went loping by. Suddenly a pack of wolves and serpents

passed, and a man's heart pounded and quaked with terror. Truly, fold upon fold of caverns, cavern upon overturned cavern, caves overturning upon the mountain. The dark green pigment dyed a thousand fathoms of jade; the azure gauze shrouded ten thousand mounds of mist.

The Master gently spurred his silver-grey horse; the Great Sage Sun halted his clouds and walked slowly; and Zhu Wuneng dragged his load along at a measured pace. Just as they were gazing at the mountain, a sudden whirlwind sprang up in a great blast. Tripitaka, on his horse, grew alarmed at heart and said, "Wukong, the wind is rising."

"A wind — what's there to fear in that?" said the Pilgrim. "It's only one of Heaven's four seasonal airs. What is there to dread?"

"This wind is fierce and foul," said Tripitaka, "not at all like a heavenly wind."

"How can you tell it's not a heavenly wind?" asked the Pilgrim.

"Look at this wind," said Tripitaka:

Vast and surging, howling and whirling, dim and boundless, it issues from the azure heights.

Crossing the ridges, one hears a thousand trees roar; entering the forest, one sees ten thousand stalks sway. On the bank the willows shake, stirred to their very roots; in the garden it blows the blossoms, scattering them with their leaves. The fishing boats that gather their nets all fasten their cables tight; the passenger skiffs that lower their sails all cast their anchors down. Halfway along the road the traveler loses his way; in the mountains the woodcutter can scarcely shoulder his load.

Among the immortal fruit-groves the monkeys scatter; within the rare-flower thickets the deer take flight. Before the cliff the cypress and juniper topple one by one; below the ravine the pine and bamboo wither leaf by leaf. It flings up earth and raises dust, the sand spurting and flying; it overturns the rivers and stirs the seas, the billows surging and rolling.

Bajie stepped up and seized the Pilgrim by the hand. "Elder brother, the wind is terribly strong — let's just dodge aside and be clear of it."

The Pilgrim laughed. "Brother, you're no good at all. The moment the wind blows hard, you want to hide. But if we should come face to face with a demon, what then?"

"Brother," said Bajie, "haven't you heard the saying, 'Shun lust as you would shun an enemy; shun the wind as you would shun an arrow'? If we dodge aside a little, no one's the worse for it."

"Say no more," said the Pilgrim. "Let me grab a fistful of this wind and have a sniff at it."

Bajie laughed. "There you go telling tall tales again, brother. Who can grab a wind and sniff it? And even if you grabbed it, it'd be gone in an instant."

"Brother," said the Pilgrim, "you don't know that old Sun has a method for grabbing the wind." Splendid Great Sage — he let the head of the gust go by, caught hold of the tail of the wind, and gave it a deep sniff. There was something rank about it. "It's truly no good wind," he said. "The flavor of this wind isn't a tiger's wind — it's surely a monster's wind. There's something amiss here, beyond a doubt."

Before he had finished speaking, there leapt out from the foot of the slope, flicking its tail and bounding on its hooves, a brindled fierce tiger. So alarmed was Tripitaka that he could not sit firm in his carved saddle but tumbled head over heels off the white horse and lay slumped at the roadside, truly with his three souls scattered and his seven spirits flown.

Bajie threw down the luggage, whipped out his nailed rake, and — not letting the Pilgrim get ahead of him — gave a great shout: "Cursed beast, where do you think you're going!" And he charged forward to strike

straight at its head. But the tiger reared up bolt upright, raised its left forepaw, hooked its own breast, and with a downward rip — *slick!* — peeled off its hide and stood by the roadside. And what a hideous shape it took! Just look at that figure:

Its bared red body, raw and dripping with blood; its bent and ringed legs, an angry crimson. The fiery tufts at its temples bristling wild; its two stiff eyebrows standing straight up. Four steel fangs, white and gleaming; a pair of golden eyes, blazing and bright. In a towering rage it roared with all its might; ferocious and grim, it shrieked aloud.

It shouted, "Slow down, slow down! I am no ordinary creature — I am the Vanguard of the Road under the Great King of the Yellow Wind. Today, by the King's strict command, I patrol the mountain to seize a few mortal men to serve as relish for his wine. What sort of monk are you, that you dare lift a weapon against me?"

Bajie cursed at him: "I'll have you, cursed beast! You don't know who I am. We're no passing mortals — we're the disciples of Tripitaka, the imperial younger brother of the Great Tang in the eastern land, sent by decree to worship the Buddha in the West and seek the scriptures. Get yourself far off to some other quarter, clear the road, and don't go startling my Master, and I'll spare your life. But if you keep up this insolence, once my rake is raised there'll be no mercy in it."

The monster gave him no time to argue. He stepped quickly close, struck a pose, and clawed straight at Bajie's face. Bajie dodged aside in haste and swung his rake to strike. The monster, having no weapon in hand, turned and fled. Bajie chased after him, and the monster, reaching the boulder-strewn thicket at the foot of the slope, drew out two red-bronze sabers, swiftly raised them, and turned to meet him. The two of them, back and forth, charge and clash, fought it out before the slope.

The Pilgrim, meanwhile, helped Tripitaka up. "Master, don't be afraid. Sit still here, and let old Sun go help Bajie. We'll knock the monster down and then be on our way." Tripitaka managed to sit up, trembling, and chanted the *Heart Sutra* under his breath — but no more of that.

The Pilgrim whipped out his iron rod and shouted, "Take that!" At this, Bajie summoned his spirits afresh, and the monster fell back in defeat. "Don't spare him," cried the Pilgrim. "Be sure to run him down." The two of them, raising rake and iron rod, chased him down the mountain. The monster, his hands and feet in a panic, played the trick of the golden cicada shedding its shell: he rolled over, revealed his true form, and once more became a fierce tiger. The Pilgrim and Bajie, unwilling to let him go, pursued the tiger, determined to root him out altogether. Seeing them close upon him, the monster again hooked his breast, peeled off his hide, draped it over a crouching-tiger rock, slipped free in his true body, transformed into a blast of wild wind, and went straight back to the head of the road. There he suddenly saw the Master, still reciting the *Heart Sutra* — and with one grab he seized him, mounted the long wind, and carried him off. Pity poor Tripitaka — born to the river's current and fated to many torments, his merit and works so hard to win within the gate of perfect quiescence!

The monster brought Tripitaka to the mouth of his cave, stilled the wild wind, and said to the gatekeeper, "Go report to the Great King that the

Tiger Vanguard of the Road ahead has captured a monk and awaits his orders outside the gate."

The cave-lord gave the order to bring him in. The Tiger Vanguard, the two red-bronze sabers thrust in his belt, lifted Tripitaka up in both hands, came forward, and knelt. "Great King, your unworthy little general, having received your command to patrol the mountain, suddenly came upon a monk — he is Tripitaka, the Master of the Law and imperial younger brother under the Great Tang of the eastern land, going west to worship the Buddha and seek scriptures. I have captured him and present him to you, a small dish for your table."

When the cave-lord heard this, he was startled. "I have heard it said by people before now," he said, "that this Master Tripitaka is a holy monk sent by the Tang emperor's decree to fetch scriptures, and that he has a disciple named Sun the Pilgrim, of vast magic powers and high cunning and strength. How could you manage to capture him?"

"He has two disciples," said the Vanguard. "The first to come wields a nine-toothed nailed rake; he has a long snout and great ears. The other wields an iron rod bound with golden bands; he has fiery eyes and golden pupils. They were just bearing down hard on your little general when I used the trick of the golden cicada shedding its shell, slipped my body free, and seized this monk to offer to you, Great King — a small token toward a meal."

"Don't eat him yet," said the cave-lord.

"Great King," said the Vanguard, "to see food and not eat it — isn't that what they call being a contrary fool?"

"You don't understand," said the cave-lord. "Eating him is no great matter — but I'm only afraid those two disciples of his will come knocking at

our door and making an uproar, and that wouldn't be safe. Let's bind him to the Wind-Stillng Stake in the back garden and wait three to five days. If those two don't come to make trouble, then — first, his body will be clean; and second, there'll be no quarrel — and we can do just as we please. To boil him, or steam him, or fry him, or stir-fry him, and enjoy him at our leisure, won't be too late."

The Vanguard was delighted. "The Great King's deep schemes and far-sighted plans — truly well reasoned. You there, take him away!" Seven or eight binding-hands crowded up from the side and carried Tripitaka off — just as a hawk seizes a swallow — trussing him with cord and winding him with rope. Truly the ill-fated child of the river thought of the Pilgrim; the holy monk in his peril longed for Wuneng. He cried, "Disciples! I know not on what mountain you are seizing monsters, in what place subduing fiends, while I am taken by this fiend-chief to suffer this cruel harm. When shall we meet again? Oh, the bitterness of it! If you come soon, you may still save my life; but if you come too late, then surely I cannot be preserved." And on one hand he sighed, and on the other his tears fell like rain.

Now, the Pilgrim and Bajie had chased the tiger down the slope, and there they saw it fallen and crouched flat before the cliff. The Pilgrim raised his rod and struck with all his might — and the blow jarred his own hands with pain. Bajie struck a blow with his rake, and the rake-teeth sprang back. For it was only a tiger's hide draped over a crouching-tiger rock!

The Pilgrim was aghast. "This is bad, this is bad — we've fallen for his trick!"

"What trick?" asked Bajie.

"This is what's called the golden-cicada-shedding-its-shell trick," said the Pilgrim. "He draped his hide here and made off himself. Let's get back quick and see how the Master is, and pray he hasn't come to harm."

The two hurried back — but Tripitaka was already gone. The Pilgrim cried out like thunder, "What's to be done? The Master's been carried off by him!"

Bajie at once led the horse, tears dropping from his eyes. "Heaven! Oh, Heaven! Where are we to look for him now?"

The Pilgrim lifted his head. "Don't weep, don't weep — weeping only blunts our spirit. He's surely somewhere on this very mountain. Let's go and search."

So the two of them plunged into the mountain, crossing ridges and climbing over peaks. After a good while they saw, rising up beneath a stone cliff, a cave-dwelling. The two halted to take in the sight, and it was fierce and forbidding indeed. They saw:

Tiered barriers and pointed peaks; winding ridges and ancient paths. The green pines and emerald bamboo soft and lush; the green willows and azure phoenix-trees gently swaying. Before the cliff, grotesque rocks in pairs; within the forest, secluded birds two by two. Ravine-water flowing far to dash against the stone walls; mountain springs trickling fine to flood the sandy banks. Wild clouds in drifting wisps; jade-bright grasses lush and thick. Sly foxes and cunning hares darted to and fro like shuttles; antlered deer and fragrant river-deer vied together in valor. Cleaving the cliff, ten-thousand-year vines hung aslant; deep in the gorge, thousand-year cypresses hung half-suspended. Lofty and towering, it put Mount Hua to shame; with falling blossoms and crying birds, it rivaled the Terrace of Heaven.

The Pilgrim said, "Worthy brother, set the luggage down in some wind-sheltered hollow of the mountain, turn the horse loose, and don't show

yourself. Let old Sun go to his door and fight it out with him. I must capture the monster — only then can we rescue the Master."

"No need to tell me twice," said Bajie. "Go quick."

Splendid Pilgrim — he straightened his cassock, cinched up his tiger-skin kilt, whipped out his rod, and rushed up to the door. There he saw six great characters upon the gate: "Yellow Wind Cave of the Yellow Wind Ridge." Planting his feet in a firm T-stance and gripping his rod, he shouted loudly, "Monster! Send my Master out at once, and spare me the trouble of overturning your nest and leveling your dwelling to the ground!"

When the little fiends heard this, they were all of them terrified, and went trembling and quaking into the cave to report: "Great King, disaster!"

The Yellow Wind Fiend, who was sitting within, asked, "What's the matter?"

"At the cave-mouth," said the little fiends, "there's come a monk with a thunder-god's beak and a hairy face, holding an iron rod thick as anything, demanding his Master."

The cave-lord was alarmed, and at once summoned the Tiger Vanguard. "I sent you to patrol the mountain — you should have caught only some mountain oxen, wild boars, fat deer, and goats. Why did you go and seize that Tang monk, and so bring his disciples here to make this uproar? How are we to deal with it now?"

"Great King, set your heart at ease, and rest easy with your head upon a high pillow," said the Vanguard. "Unworthy as I am, your little general is willing to lead fifty of the lesser troops out and bring this Sun the Pilgrim, or whatever he calls himself, back to add to our feast."

"Besides my chief officers, great and small," said the cave-lord, "I have five or seven hundred lesser troops. Choose as you please — take however many you will. Only capture that Pilgrim, and then we may eat that monk's flesh at our leisure and ease, and I'll gladly bow with you as sworn brothers. But if you fail to take him, and come to harm yourself instead — then don't go blaming me."

"Rest easy, rest easy," said the Tiger Fiend. "Wait while I go." And he duly mustered fifty stout, vigorous little fiends, beat the drums and waved the flags, took up his two red-bronze sabers, and came charging out the gate, shouting in a fierce voice: "What sort of monkey-monk are you, that you come here bellowing and shrieking — and to what end?"

The Pilgrim cursed at him: "You skin-peeling beast! What shell-shedding tricks did you play to carry off my Master, and then turn round and ask me what I'm about? Send my Master out, nice and proper, this instant, and I'll still spare you your life."

"Your Master I did capture," said the Tiger Fiend, "to make a dish to go with our King's rice. If you know what's good for you, go back the way you came. Otherwise I'll seize you too, and we'll eat the lot of you together — and isn't that buying one and getting one free?"

Hearing this, the Pilgrim's heart blazed with rage. He ground his steel teeth together with a grating sound and rolled his fiery eyes wide and round, whipped out his iron rod, and shouted, "How great are your skills, that you dare talk so big? Don't run — taste my cudgel!" The Vanguard hastily lifted his sabers to meet it. This was no gentle contest indeed; each displayed his might and prowess. A fine fight:

The monster was a true goose-egg; Wukong, a goose-egg stone. The red-bronze sabers crossing the Handsome Monkey King were as if a heaped-up egg had come to strike a stone. How shall the magpie vie with the phoenix? How dare the wood-pigeon match the hawk and falcon? The monster spewed wind till ash filled the mountain; Wukong belched mist till clouds dimmed the sun. Back and forth, not three or five rounds gone by, and the Vanguard's waist went limp, his strength all spent. He turned to flee and save his life — but Wukong pressed him hard, to the death.

The Tiger Fiend, unable to hold his ground, turned and fled. But because he had boasted before the cave-lord, he dared not return to the cave, and instead made straight for the mountain slope to save his life. The Pilgrim would by no means let him go; gripping his rod, he chased after him with all his heart, howling and roaring, his shouts never ceasing — until he had driven the creature to a wind-sheltered hollow on the mountain. Just then Bajie raised his head and saw the Pilgrim coming. Bajie had been pasturing the horse, and when he heard the howling and shouting he turned to look and saw the Pilgrim driving the routed Tiger Fiend before him. So he flung the horse aside, lifted his rake, and struck a slanting blow straight at the creature's head.

Pity that Vanguard — slipping his body free and meaning to leap clear of the yellow silken net, who could have guessed he would run straight into the fish-trapper? With one stroke of Bajie's rake, nine holes were torn open, gushing fresh blood, and his whole skull was drained dry of its brains. There is a poem to prove it:

Three or five years ago he returned to the orthodox sect, kept the fast and a plain diet, and woke to the truth of emptiness. With a sincere heart he meant to guard the Tang Tripitaka — first taking up the monk's vocation, he stood this merit here.

The blockhead set one foot on the creature's spine and, gripping the rake in both hands, struck again. Seeing this, the Pilgrim was overjoyed.

"Brother, that's exactly it! He led out several dozen little fiends and dared fight it out with old Sun — and I beat him so badly that rather than run back to the cave he ran straight here to meet his death. Lucky you were here to catch him, or he'd have gotten away again."

"Was it this one," asked Bajie, "who worked the wind and carried off the Master?"

"The very one, the very one," said the Pilgrim.

"Did you ask him where the Master is?" said Bajie.

"This monster took the Master into the cave to make a dish to go with some bird-king's rice," said the Pilgrim. "Old Sun grew angry and fought him all the way here, where you put an end to his life. Brother — this merit goes to you. Now stay and keep watch over the horse and the

luggage while I drag this dead monster off and go back to the cave-mouth to challenge them again. We must capture that old fiend himself before we can rescue the Master."

"Brother, that's well reasoned," said Bajie. "Go on, go on. And if you beat that old fiend and chase him back this way, Old Hog will cut him off and slay him."

Splendid Pilgrim — with one hand he carried his iron rod, and with the other he dragged the dead tiger, and went straight back to the cave-mouth. Truly:

The Master of the Law in his peril met with a monster; their natures in harmony, they subdued the unruly fiend.

And in the end, whether on this venture he could subdue the monster and rescue the Tang Monk — listen to the explanation in the next chapter.

Chapter 21: The Wind Demon and the Healing Salve

Now the fifty battered little demons, clutching their torn banners and broken drums, came tumbling back into the cave and reported: "Great King, Tiger Vanguard could not stand against that hairy-faced monk. He was driven down the eastern slope and away." When the old demon heard this, he was deeply troubled. He sat with his head bowed, saying

nothing, silently turning schemes over in his mind, when another of the little demons who had been guarding the front gate came in and said: "Great King, Tiger Vanguard has been beaten to death by that hairy-faced monk. His body lies dragged before our gate, and the monk stands there shouting for battle."

At this the old demon grew more wretched still. "The wretch knows nothing," he said. "I never even ate his master, yet he turns around and slays my own vanguard. Hateful! Hateful!" He called for his armor. "I have only heard talk of some Sun Wukong. Let me go out and see what manner of monk this is, with his nine heads and eight tails. I shall seize him and bring him in to pay with his life for my Tiger Vanguard."

The little demons hurriedly carried out his armor, and the old demon dressed himself in full array. Grasping a three-pronged steel fork, he led the whole troop of demons leaping out of the cave.

The Great Sage stood waiting outside the gate, and when he saw the demon come striding forth, he found him truly fierce and martial. See how he was arrayed:

A golden helmet flashing in the sun, golden armor gleaming with frozen light. From the helmet streamed a pheasant-tail plume; a gauze robe of pale goose-yellow draped the mail. The cords that bound his plates coiled like dragons, bright; the heart-guard mirror dazzled the eyes all around. Boots of deerskin dyed with sophora bloom; a brocade kilt soft as willow leaves. In his hand the keen three-pronged steel fork — no less than that immortal lord of bygone years.

Coming out at the gate, the old demon shouted harshly: "Which of you is Sun Wukong?" Wukong, his feet shod with the skin of the slain tiger and his obedient iron staff in hand, answered: "Your Grandfather Sun is here. Send out my master."

The monster looked him over carefully and saw that the pilgrim was a mean little figure, gaunt of face and barely four feet tall. He laughed. "Pitiful, pitiful! I had thought you some unbeatable hero no man could throw, and here you are — a sickly little skeleton of a ghost."

Wukong laughed back. "You son of mine, your eyes are no good at all. Your grandfather may be small, but if you'll consent to crack me one across the head with that fork-handle, I'll grow six feet taller."

"Hold your head steady," said the monster, "and take my blow."

The Great Sage, wholly without fear, let the monster strike him. He gave his waist a little twist — and shot up six feet, until he stood a full ten feet tall. So startled was the demon that he braced his fork upright and shouted: "Sun Wukong, why do you bring out before my gate these protective tricks of transformation? Enough of your conjuring! Come up here and let me see what you can do."

Wukong laughed. "Son, as the old saying goes: spare your foe and your hand stays down; but once your hand is raised, no foe is spared. Your grandfather's hand falls heavy — I only fear you can't bear a single stroke of my staff."

The monster gave him no room to talk. Twirling his steel fork, he stabbed straight at Wukong's chest. The Great Sage was the master who never hurries and never flusters; he opened up his iron staff, swung it in a "Black Dragon Sweeps the Ground" stance, knocked the fork aside, and aimed a blow at the monster's head. There at the mouth of the Yellow Wind Cave the two of them fought a magnificent battle:

The demon king was wrathful, the Great Sage proud and bold. The demon king was wrathful — he would take the pilgrim to avenge his vanguard; the Great Sage stood proud — he would seize the sprite to save the elder monk. Fork came, staff parried; staff went, fork rose to meet it. One was the mountain's supreme commander, the other the Dharma-guarding Handsome Monkey King. At first they fought down in the dust, then both rose up into the air. The tempered fork was sharp and bright and keen; the obedient staff, black-bodied with bands of gold. Whatever the fork pierced went down to the shades; whatever the staff struck met King Yama for certain. All hung on quick hands and quicker eyes, on strength of arm and a hardy frame. Both sides forgot their lives and warred to the death — who could say which would come safe through, which take the wound?

The old demon and the Great Sage fought thirty rounds, and neither could gain the upper hand. Then Wukong, wanting to show his skill,

used his "body-outside-the-body" art. He plucked a handful of hairs, chewed them to fragments in his mouth, spat them upward, and cried "Change!" — and a hundred or more little Wukongs appeared, all dressed alike, each wielding an iron staff, ringing the monster round in the air.

The monster took fright and worked a trick of his own. He turned quickly, faced the southeast, opened his mouth three times, and with a great "Whoosh!" blew out a single breath — and all at once a yellow wind came howling up out of the sky. What a wind it was, truly terrible:

Cold and keen, it changed both heaven and earth, a yellow whirlwind, shapeless, casting no shadow. It pierced the forests, snapped the ridgelines, toppled pine and plum, flung up the soil, scattered the dust, and crumbled mountain altars. The Yellow River's billows churned muddy to the bed; the Xiang's waters surged and turned their waves about. It rocked the Palace of the Plough in the blue-green sky, and nearly blew down the very Hall of King Yama. Five hundred arhats clamored to high heaven; the eight great Vajra-guardians shouted in confusion. Manjushri lost his blue-maned lion; Samantabhadra's white elephant could not be found. Zhenwu's tortoise and snake were parted from their kind; the mule of Zitong saw its saddle-cloth blown away. Wandering merchants cried out to the grey heavens; boatmen bowed and vowed every kind of vow. Lives floated lost upon the misty waves; the wreck of fame and gain went drifting with the water. Immortal hills and caverns turned to black,

the sea-isles of Penglai to dim obscurity. Lord Lao could not tend his elixir furnace; the Star of Longevity put away his dragon-whisker fan. The Queen Mother, just then going to the Peach Feast, had girdle-sash and ringlets blown into disorder. Erlang lost his way back to Guanzhou town; Nezha could not draw the sword from out its case. The Heavenly King could not see the tower in his palm; Lu Ban let fall his golden-headed awl. Three tiers of the Thunderclap Tower came tumbling down; the stone bridge of Zhaozhou cracked clean in two. The one red sun was swept clear of its light, and all the stars of heaven were thrown into a daze. South-mountain birds flew off toward the northern hills; the eastern lake's waters poured over into the west. Mated pairs were torn apart and could not call; mothers and young, divided, could not cry out. The Dragon King combed the seas to find his yaksha; the Duke of Thunder searched everywhere for his lightning. The Ten Kings of the dead sought their

judge in vain; in the underworld, Ox-Head chased after Horse-Face. This wind blew down the whole of Mount Potala and rolled up one whole scroll of Guanyin's scriptures. The white lotus blossoms scattered and flew along the shore; it toppled the Bodhisattva's twelve courts entire. From Pangu's time till now men have seen wind, but never a wind that came so ill as this. With a great roar — heaven and earth all but split and burst; and the rivers and hills of ten thousand miles stood trembling.

When the monster loosed this raging storm, the little Wukongs made of his hairs were whirled about in mid-air like so many spinning-wheels, with no way to swing a staff or steady themselves. In alarm, Wukong gave his fur a shake and drew the hairs back onto his body. Alone now, he raised his iron staff and pressed forward to strike — but the monster blew a mouthful of yellow wind full into his face, and his two fiery golden eyes were buffeted shut, unable to open. Blinded, he could not wield the staff, and so he was driven from the field. The demon gathered up his wind and returned to his cave — but of that no more.

Now while the yellow wind raged and heaven and earth lost their light, Zhu Bajie had led the horse and guarded the luggage, crouching low in a hollow of the mountain. He dared not open his eyes nor lift his head, but kept reciting the Buddha's name and making vow after vow — for he had no idea whether Wukong had won or lost, nor whether the master was

alive or dead. Just as he was caught up in these doubts, the wind died and the sky cleared. He raised his head and looked toward the cave gate, but saw no weapons there and heard neither gong nor drum. The blockhead dared not approach the gate, yet there was no one to mind the horse and baggage. Truly he could neither go forward nor back, and he fretted in great distress.

While he worried, he heard the Great Sage hallooing as he came up from the west. Bajie stirred himself and went to meet him. "Brother! What a tremendous wind! Where have you come from?"

Wukong waved his hand. "Terrible! Terrible! In all my born days I never saw such a wind. That old demon came at me with a three-pronged steel fork, and we fought above thirty rounds. So I worked my 'body-outside-the-body' trick and ringed him round to beat him. In his desperation he conjured up that wind. It was savage indeed — it buffeted me till I could not keep my feet, and so I packed up my magic and fled before it. Faugh, what a wind! Faugh, what a wind! Old Sun can call up wind himself and summon rain too, but never have I met a wind as wicked as that monster's."

"Elder brother," said Bajie, "and how does the monster's fighting compare?"

"Passable enough," said Wukong. "His fork-work is well-ordered — he fought me to a draw. It is only that wicked wind that makes him hard to beat."

"If that's how it is," said Bajie, "how are we ever to rescue the master?"

"Saving the master can wait," said Wukong. "I don't know whether there's any eye-doctor hereabouts — I'd have him treat my eyes a little."

"What's wrong with your eyes?" asked Bajie.

"When that monster blew his wind in my face, it left my eyeballs aching and smarting, and now they keep running with cold tears."

"Brother," said Bajie, "we're halfway up a wild mountain and the day grows late. Never mind an eye-doctor — there isn't even a place to spend the night."

"Finding lodging is no hard matter," said Wukong. "I reckon the monster won't yet dare harm our master. Let's get back to the main road, find some house, stay the night, and come back tomorrow at first light to subdue the demon."

"Quite right, quite right," said Bajie.

So he led the horse and shouldered the load, and they came out of the hollow onto the road. By now dusk was gathering, and they heard the barking of a dog on a hillside south of the way. The two of them stopped and looked, and there was a farmstead, with the dim glow of lamplight showing. Caring nothing whether there was a path or none, they pushed through the grass straight to the gate. There they saw:

Purple fungus, shadowy and dense; white stones, grey and pale. The purple fungus, shadowy and dense, amid much green grass; the white stones, grey and pale, half veiled in emerald moss. A few small fireflies glimmered with their flickering light; a grove of wild trees stood close and thick in rows. Fragrant orchids breathed their rich perfume; tender bamboo had been freshly set. A clear spring ran through the winding gully, and an ancient cypress leaned against the deep cliff. So remote the spot that no traveler ever came; before the gate only the wildflowers bloomed.

The two did not dare push in unbidden, but called out: "Open up! Open up!" From within an old man came, with several young farmhands, all carrying forks, rakes, and brooms. "Who are you? Who are you?" they demanded.

Wukong bowed and said: "We are disciples of the holy monk of the Great Tang in the Land of the East. We are bound for the Western Heaven to worship the Buddha and seek the scriptures, and passing this mountain our master was carried off by the Great King of Yellow Wind. We have not yet been able to rescue him. The day is late, so we have come to beg

a single night's lodging at your house. We earnestly hope you will oblige us."

The old man returned the bow. "Forgive our poor welcome. This is a place of much cloud and few people, and when we heard the knocking just now we feared it might be demon-foxes, tigers, or mountain bandits. That is why these foolish lads of mine came out so rudely and gave offense — we did not know it was two reverend elders. Please, come in, come in."

The brothers led the horse and carried the load inside, tethered the horse, set down the burden, and exchanged greetings with the old farmer before sitting down. A servant brought tea, and when the tea was finished, several bowls of sesame rice were set out. After they had eaten, bedding was spread for them to rest.

Wukong said: "Not sleeping is well enough — but may I ask, good sir, does your honored district have anyone who sells eye-medicine?"

"Which of the reverend elders has ailing eyes?" asked the old man.

"To tell you the truth, sir," said Wukong, "we men of religion are by nature never ill, and have never known what it is to have sore eyes."

"If your eyes are not sore," said the old man, "why do you ask for medicine?"

"Today, at the mouth of the Yellow Wind Cave, we were trying to save our master," said Wukong, "when that monster blew a mouthful of wind at me without warning, and it left my eyeballs aching and smarting so that they run with tears. That is why I seek eye-medicine."

The old man said: "Mercy, mercy! You are a young elder — how can you speak so lightly of such a thing? That Great King of Yellow Wind — his

wind is the most terrible thing in the world. It is nothing like your spring or autumn breezes, your pine-and-bamboo winds, or the common winds of east, west, south, or north —"

"It must be a brain-cramp wind, a sheep's-ear wind, a great-leprosy wind, or a half-and-whole migraine wind!" put in Bajie.

"No, no," said the elder. "It is called the Samadhi Divine Wind."

"How does one know it to be so?" asked Wukong.

The old man said: "That wind can blow heaven and earth into darkness and make ghosts and gods grieve. It splits stone and crumbles cliffs in its fury, and where it touches a man, his life is forfeit on the instant. Had you met the full force of that wind, do you think you would still be alive? Only an immortal could pass through it unharmed."

"True enough," said Wukong. "We may not be immortals, but immortals are my juniors. This life of mine is not so easily ended — the wind has only left my eyeballs aching and smarting."

"If that is so," said the old man, "then you are indeed a person of some standing. In this poor place of mine there is no one who sells eye-medicine. But I too have suffered cold tears in the wind, and once I met an extraordinary man who passed me a formula. It is called the Three-Flower Nine-Seed Salve, and it can cure every kind of wind-borne eye ailment."

Hearing this, Wukong bowed his head and made his salute. "I beg you to give me a little, that I might try it."

The old man consented, went within, and returned with a small agate-stone jar. He pried out the stopper, dipped a jade hairpin inside, drew out a little of the salve, and applied it to Wukong's eyes, telling him not to

open them but to rest his mind and sleep, and that by morning he would be well. This done, he put away the stone jar and led his young lads off to the inner quarters.

Bajie undid the bundle, spread out the bedding, and invited Wukong to settle down. Wukong, his eyes shut, groped about blindly. Bajie laughed: "Sir, where's your blind-man's stick?"

"You drivel-stuffed blockhead," said Wukong, "you'd have me play the blind man, would you?" The idiot chuckled silently to himself and went to sleep, while Wukong sat up on the bedding and circulated his magic energies, not lying down until past the third watch.

Before he knew it, the fifth watch was nearly upon them. Wukong wiped his face, opened his eyes, and said: "That is truly fine medicine — my sight is a hundred times clearer than before." But when he turned his head and looked around — why! Where were the rooms, the windows, the doors? He saw only old sophora trees and tall willows, and the two brothers lying on a soft green carpet of grass.

Bajie woke. "Brother, what are you shouting about?"

"Open your eyes and look," said Wukong.

The idiot raised his head, saw the house was gone, and in a flurry rolled over and scrambled to his feet. "Where's my horse?"

"Tied to that tree, isn't it?" said Wukong.

"And the luggage?"

"Set there beside your head, isn't it?"

"This family is downright lazy," said Bajie. "They've moved away and never called us once. If they'd only let old Pig know, I'd have given them a

little tea and fruit for the trouble. They must be folk dodging the registers, afraid the village headman would find them out, and so they moved off in the dead of night. — Ai! And we slept like the dead — how is it we never heard a sound while they pulled their whole house down around us?"

Wukong gave a chuckling laugh. "Blockhead, stop your jabbering. Look — what's that paper notice on the tree?"

Bajie went up and pulled it down. On it were four lines of verse:

This farmstead is no dwelling of common folk — a
Dharma-guardian's hermitage, conjured for the
hour. The wondrous salve has healed your aching
eyes; bend all your heart to subdue the demon — do
not waver.

"These ruffian-spirits!" said Wukong. "Ever since I got the dragon-horse I've never once mustered them, and now they come playing their conjuring tricks."

"Brother, don't put on airs," said Bajie. "How could they ever answer to your muster?"

"Brother, you don't yet understand," said Wukong. "These Dharma-guarding monastery-gods, the Six Ding and Six Jia, the Revealers of the Five Quarters, and the Four Sentinel Officers — they all, by the Bodhisattva's holy command, secretly protect our master. From the day they reported themselves to me, since I had you all this while, I never had need of them and so never mustered them — that is all."

"Brother," said Bajie, "since they bear the holy command to protect the master in secret, they cannot show themselves openly, and so they conjured this immortal farmstead. Don't be vexed with them. Yesterday they did you the kindness of treating your eyes, and saw to it that we got a meal of fasting-fare besides — you may well say they did their utmost. Let us go and rescue the master."

"What you say is right, brother," said Wukong. "It's not far from here to the Yellow Wind Cave. Don't stir yourself — just stay in the woods to mind the horse and guard the load. Let old Sun go to the cave and find out what's become of the master, and then I'll fight the demon again."

"Exactly so," said Bajie. "Get one solid word, alive or dead. If the master is dead, each of us can go his own way and see to his own business; if he's not dead, then we'll bend every effort to save him."

"No more idle talk — I'm off," said Wukong.

With a single leap he went straight to the cave gate, which was still shut fast, all asleep behind it. Wukong did not knock, nor would he rouse the demons. Making a magic sign and reciting a spell, he shook himself and changed into a mottle-legged mosquito — truly small and deft. There is a poem to prove it:

A tiny, restless shape with a keen-edged bill,
humming a thread of sound thin as distant thunder.
Through orchid chambers and gauze bed-curtains it
slips at will, loving best the warm air of blazing
summer. It fears only the smoking fumes and
beating fans, and dotes most on the brightness of
lamp and candle. Light and small, marvelously
quick to pierce, it flew straight into the demon's
cave.

He saw the gate-keeping demon snoring fast asleep. Wukong stung him once on the face, and the little demon rolled over and woke. "Ouch, ouch! What a great mosquito — one bite and it's raised a great welt!" Then he opened his eyes. "It's daylight already." And with a creak the second gate was opened. Wukong went humming in, and there saw the old demon ordering each gate to keep careful watch while along one wall weapons were being made ready. "I only fear yesterday's wind didn't blow Sun Wukong to death," the old demon was saying. "He's sure to come again today, and when he does I'll see to it his life is ended for good."

Hearing this, Wukong flew past the great hall and on to the rear, where he found a door barred fast and tight. He slipped in through the crack, and found himself in a great empty garden. Against the far wall, bound with rope and cord to the Wind-Quelling Stake, stood Tripitaka. Tears fell and fell from the master's eyes, his heart fixed only on Wukong and Wuneng, with no notion of where either might be. Wukong folded his

wings and alighted upon the bald crown of his head, calling softly:
"Master!"

The elder knew his voice. "Wukong! You'll be the death of me with longing. Where are you, that you call to me?"

"Master, I'm on your head," said Wukong. "Don't fret your heart, don't be troubled. We must take the demon before we can save your life."

"Disciple," said Tripitaka, "when will you ever take him?"

"The tiger-monster that seized you has already been killed by Bajie," said Wukong. "It's only the old demon's wind that's so fierce. I reckon it'll be this very day — I'll be sure to take him. Set your mind at ease and weep no more. I'm off now."

So saying, he flew humming back to the front, where he saw the old demon seated on high mustering his various captains. Then a little demon-sprite came in from before the cave, brandishing a command-banner, and rushed up to the hall to report: "Great King, I was out patrolling the mountain, and had scarcely gone past the gate when I saw a long-snouted, big-eared monk sitting in the woods. I barely escaped before he nearly caught me. But the hairy-faced monk of yesterday was nowhere to be seen."

"If Sun Wukong is nowhere about," said the old demon, "then likely the wind blew him to death — or else he's gone off somewhere to fetch reinforcements."

The demons said: "Great King, if you really blew him dead, that is our good fortune. But if the wind didn't kill him and he's gone to fetch divine troops, what shall we do?"

"What is there to fear in any divine troops?" said the old demon. "If anyone could quell my wind, it could only be the Bodhisattva Lingji come in person. Aside from him, what is there to dread?"

Up on the roof-beam Wukong heard every word and could not contain his delight. At once he drew off, flew out through the gate, resumed his true form, and came to the woods calling: "Brother!"

"Brother, where have you been?" said Bajie. "Just now a demon with a command-banner came by, and I chased him off."

Wukong laughed. "Well done, well done. Old Sun changed into a mosquito and went into the cave to look for the master. He's bound to the Wind-Quelling Stake, weeping — and old Sun told him to weep no more. Then I flew up to the roof-beam and listened. That banner-bearer came puffing in to report that you'd chased him off, but that I was nowhere to be seen. The old demon guessed wildly that old Sun was blown dead by the wind, or gone to fetch divine troops. And then he himself let slip the name of one person — most excellent, most excellent!"

"And whose name did he let slip?" asked Bajie.

"He said: what's there to fear in any divine troops — the only one who could quell his wind is the Bodhisattva Lingji. But I don't know where Lingji lives."

While they were thus consulting, an old gentleman came walking out from beside the main road. See now what manner of man he was:

Hale of body, needing no staff to lean upon; icy whiskers and snowy temples, all tousled. Golden flowers dazzled his eyes to a dreamy haze; his bones were lean, his sinews worn, yet hard and strong. Bent-backed, head bowed, he walked at a slow pace; his brows were thick, his ruddy face like a child's. Look at his features — a man worthy of praise, as though the Star of Longevity had come out from his cave.

Bajie was overjoyed at the sight. "Elder brother, as the saying goes: to learn the road below the mountain, you must ask the man who comes and goes. Why not step forward and ask him?"

The Great Sage hid his iron staff, let down the skirt of his robe, and stepped forward, calling: "Old sir, my greetings to you."

The old man returned a half-hearted bow. "Where are you a monk from? What business have you in this wild waste?"

"We are holy monks seeking the scriptures," said Wukong. "Yesterday we lost our master hereabouts, and I've come especially to ask you a question, sir: where does the Bodhisattva Lingji dwell?"

"Lingji is away to the due south," said the old man. "It is three thousand miles from here. There is a mountain called Little Mount Sumeru, and

within that mountain is a holy site — the Bodhisattva's hall for expounding the scriptures. Are you going to fetch scriptures from him?"

"I'm not going for his scriptures," said Wukong. "I have a matter to trouble him with — only I don't know which road to take."

The old man pointed south with his hand. "This sheep's-gut footpath is the way." But while he had drawn the Great Sage's head around to look at the path, the old gentleman dissolved into a clear breeze and was silently gone. Only beside the road he had left a slip of paper, on which were four lines of verse:

A message for the Great Sage Equal to Heaven,
attend: the old man is none but Li Changgeng. On
Mount Sumeru is the Flying-Dragon Staff; Lingji
long ago received the Buddha's host.

Wukong took up the note and turned back to the path. "Brother," said Bajie, "our luck's been low these last few days — twice now in broad daylight we've seen ghosts. Who was that old fellow who changed into a wind and vanished?"

Wukong handed the note to Bajie, who read it through. "Who is this Li Changgeng?" he asked.

"It's the title of the Great White Planet of the West," said Wukong.

Bajie hastily bowed toward the sky. "Benefactor, benefactor! Had not the Planet petitioned the Jade Emperor on my behalf, old Pig's life would not know what shape it might have been twisted into."

"Brother," said Wukong, "so you do know how to feel gratitude. But keep your head down — hide deep in this grove and mind the luggage and the horse with care. Let old Sun seek out Mount Sumeru and invite the Bodhisattva to come."

"I understand, I understand," said Bajie. "Just you go quickly. Old Pig has learned the way of the tortoise — when it's time to pull in my head, I'll pull it in."

The Great Sage sprang into the air, riding his cloud-somersault straight to the due south. Truly he was swift: a nod of his head carried him three thousand miles, a twist of his waist above eight hundred more. In a moment he saw a high mountain, halfway up which auspicious clouds gathered and lucky vapors rose in thick drifts. In a hollow of the mountain there was indeed a Chan monastery, and he heard the bells and chimes ringing soft and clear and saw threads of incense-smoke drifting faint on the air. The Great Sage came straight to the gate, where he saw a Taoist acolyte, a string of beads about his neck, reciting the Buddha's name.

"Greetings, acolyte," said Wukong.

The acolyte bowed and returned the courtesy. "Where has the old master come from?"

"Is this the place where the Bodhisattva Lingji expounds the scriptures?" asked Wukong.

"This is the very place," said the acolyte. "What is your business?"

"I trouble you, sir," said Wukong, "to carry word for me. I am the disciple of the Imperial Younger Brother, the Tripitaka Dharma-Master under the Great Tang of the East — the Great Sage Equal to Heaven, Sun Wukong the pilgrim. I have a matter on which I wish to see the Bodhisattva."

The acolyte laughed. "Old master, your words are many and your titles many — I cannot remember them all."

"Just say that Sun Wukong, the disciple of the Tang Monk, has come," said Wukong.

The acolyte did as he was told and went up to the lecture hall to announce him. The Bodhisattva at once donned his cassock, added incense, and came out to welcome him. The Great Sage stepped inside the gate and, looking about him, saw:

The whole hall hung with brocade, the chamber filled with awe. The assembled disciples chanted in chorus the Lotus Sutra; the old precentor lightly struck the gold-cast chime. The offerings before the Buddha were all immortal fruits and flowers; the dishes set upon the table were all fasting-fare and meatless. Brilliant the precious candles — each golden flame shot rainbow light; rich the true incense — each thread of jade smoke flew in colored mist. This was the moment when, the lecture done and the mind at ease, he entered samadhi, while flake on flake of white cloud curled about the pine-tops. Stilled, he sheathed the sword of wisdom and the demon-heads were ended; high was his mastery of the prajna-paramita's grace.

The Bodhisattva straightened his robes and came out to greet him. Wukong mounted the hall, took the guest's seat, and tea was duly ordered. "Spare yourself the tea," said Wukong. "My master is in distress on the Mountain of Yellow Wind. I have come expressly to beg the Bodhisattva to exert his great power, subdue the demon, and rescue him."

The Bodhisattva said: "I received the Tathagata's command and was stationed here to keep the Yellow Wind demon in check. The Tathagata bestowed on me a Wind-Quelling Pellet and a Flying-Dragon Treasure-Staff. In those days I caught the creature, but spared his life and let him go to conceal his nature and return to the mountain, on the condition that he take no life and work no further sin. I did not know that today he would move against your master, in defiance of that command — the fault is mine." The Bodhisattva would have kept Wukong to share a vegetarian meal and talk awhile, but Wukong earnestly declined. So the Bodhisattva took up the Flying-Dragon Staff, and together with the Great Sage rode off upon the clouds.

Before long they reached the Mountain of Yellow Wind. The Bodhisattva said: "Great Sage, this demon stands somewhat in fear of me. I shall hold my position here in the clouds; you go down and challenge him to battle, lure him out, and I will work my power upon him." Wukong agreed, lowered his cloud, and without a word of warning swung his iron staff and smashed in the cave gate, shouting: "Monster! Give me back my master!"

The gate-keeping demons fled inside in a fright to report. "This vile ape is utterly without manners," said the monster. "He still won't yield to kindness — now he comes and smashes my gate. This time I'll go out, loose my divine wind, and blow him dead for certain." He put on his armor once more, grasped his steel fork, and came striding out through the gate. Seeing Wukong, he wasted no words but twirled the fork and stabbed at his chest. The Great Sage dodged aside and, raising his staff, struck back face to face. Before they had fought many rounds, the monster jerked his head toward the southeast quarter, and just as he opened his mouth to summon the wind, the Bodhisattva Lingji flung his Flying-Dragon Treasure-Staff down from the high air. With some spell —

none could tell what he chanted — it became an eight-clawed golden dragon, which snapped two of its claws open, seized the monster by the head, and dashed him two or three times against the rocky cliff at the mountain's edge. There the creature showed his true shape: a yellow-furred sable rat.

Wukong rushed forward and raised his staff to strike, but the Bodhisattva stayed his hand. "Great Sage, do not take his life. I must bring him before the Tathagata." Then he said to Wukong: "This creature was a rat that had attained the Way at the foot of the Spirit Mountain. Because he stole the pure oil from a glazed lamp-cup and so dimmed the lamp's flame, and feared the Vajra-guardians would seize him, he fled here and set himself up as a demon to work his mischief. The Tathagata, seeing all, judged that he did not merit death, and charged me to hold him in custody. But since he has taken life and sinned anew, I shall carry him up to the Spirit Mountain; and now that he has affronted the Great Sage and brought calamity on the Tang Monk besides, I will take him before the Tathagata, where his crimes may be plainly judged — only then will this be reckoned a true merit."

Hearing this, Wukong thanked the Bodhisattva, and the Bodhisattva turned back toward the west — but of that no more.

Now Zhu Bajie, waiting in the woods and brooding over Wukong's long absence, suddenly heard a shout from below the mountain: "Brother Wuneng, bring the horse and the luggage up!" The idiot recognized Wukong's voice at once, hastily gathered everything together, and ran out of the woods. Seeing Wukong, he said: "Brother, how did the business go?"

"I invited the Bodhisattva Lingji," said Wukong, "and with a Flying-Dragon Staff he took the demon. The thing turned out to be a yellow-

furred sable rat that had attained spirit, and the Bodhisattva has carried him off to the Spirit Mountain to stand before the Tathagata. Now you and I will go into the cave and rescue our master."

The idiot grew merry and glad. The two of them charged inside and, with rake and iron staff, beat to death the whole den — cunning hares, demon-foxes, fragrant river-deer, and antlered stags alike. Then they went to the rear garden and bowed before freeing their master. The master came out through the gate and asked: "How did you two manage to take the demon? And how did you come to rescue me?" Wukong recounted from beginning to end the matter of inviting Lingji to subdue the demon, and the master's gratitude knew no end. The brothers prepared a little tea and rice from the vegetarian stores in the cave, ate their fill, and only then went out through the gate and took the main road westward.

What befell them hereafter is not yet known — listen to the telling in the next chapter.

Chapter 22: The Sands That Swallow Men — Friar Sand Joins the Quest

We left the Tang Monk and his two disciples having escaped their last peril and pressing on westward. In less than a day they passed beyond the Yellow Wind Ridge, and beyond it the land opened into a broad, level plain. Time flew swiftly: summer gave way to autumn, and they saw the chill cicadas droning among the withered willows while the great red star of summer slid down toward the west.

As they journeyed on, suddenly before them lay a vast expanse of water — a wild, raging flood, its turbid swells heaving and its waves churning.

From his saddle Tripitaka cried out in alarm: "Disciples, look — the water ahead is so wide, and not a single boat in sight. How are we to cross?"

Pig looked and said, "It's a raging torrent, sure enough. No boat to ferry us over."

Then the Pilgrim, Sun Wukong, leapt up into the air, shaded his eyes with his hand, and gazed across — and even his heart sank. "Master," he said, "this is truly difficult, truly difficult. If it were only old Monkey crossing, I'd give my waist a single twist and be over in a flash. But for you, Master, it would be a thousandfold hard to ferry, a ten-thousand-year hard to traverse."

"From here I can see no end to it," said Tripitaka. "How wide do you make it?"

"Some eight hundred li across, near as I can tell," the Pilgrim replied.

"Brother, how can you fix the distance so exactly?" asked Pig.

"I won't deceive you, worthy brother," said Wukong. "These two eyes of mine can make out fortune and disaster on a road a thousand li off in broad daylight. Just now, from up in the air, I could not see how far this river runs upstream or down — but across it measures a full eight hundred li."

The Elder sat sighing on his horse in distress and turned about to look. Just then he spied a stone tablet standing on the bank. The three of them came up together to read it, and found three seal-script characters carved at the top: **Flowing-Sand River**. Below, in small, neat script, ran four lines:

Eight hundred li of flowing sand, three thousand fathoms of weakling water deep. A goose-feather will not float upon it, a reed-blossom sinks straight to the bed.

While master and disciples were still studying the inscription, they heard the waves surge up like mountains and the billows pile high like ridges, and from the very middle of the river a monster came slithering forth — hideous and ferocious beyond measure:

A shock of flaming red hair, wild and unbound; two round eyes, gleaming bright as lanterns. A face neither black nor green, but indigo-blue; a voice like thunder, like a drum, like an old dragon's roar. Over his shoulders a cape of goose-down yellow; at his waist a doubled cord of pale white rattan. Nine skulls dangling from a string about his neck, and in his hand a fearsome treasure-staff.

The fiend came whirling up the bank in a gust of wind and lunged straight for the Tang Monk. In a panic the Pilgrim flung his arms around his master, scrambled up the high bank, and bore him away to safety. Pig set down his load, whipped out his nine-toothed muckrake, and swung it

at the monster, who parried with his treasure-staff. The two of them, there on the bank of the Flowing-Sand River, each gave full play to his valor. It was a splendid fight:

The nine-toothed rake, the demon-quelling staff —
two warriors locked in battle on the river's shore.

This one, once Marshal of the Heavenly Reeds; that
one, the Curtain-Lifting Captain cast from grace. In
years gone by they'd met in the Hall of Divine Mist;
today they strive to prove which is the stronger.

This rake darts in like a dragon clawing for its prey;
that staff blocks like a tusked elephant grinding its
teeth. Both stretch out wide in their four-square
stance, then bore in close against the driving wind.

This one claws blind for face and skull; that one
strikes without a wasted blow or empty pause. One
is the man-eating spirit who has long held the
Flowing-Sand realm; the other is the warrior who
keeps the faith and treads the path.

Back and forth they went, and after some twenty rounds neither had
gained the advantage.

Now the Great Sage, guarding the Tang Monk and holding the horse, keeping watch over the baggage, saw Pig trading blows with the fiend and ground his teeth with longing — rubbing his palms, cracking his knuckles, unable to hold himself back. Out came his iron cudgel.

"Master, sit here and do not be afraid," he said. "Let old Monkey go have a little sport with him." The Elder begged him in vain to stay. With a whistle Wukong sprang to the front.

The monster and Pig were just at the thick of it, locked too close to part, when the Pilgrim swung up his iron rod and brought it down straight at the fiend's head. The fiend twisted aside in a flash, dodged in a fright, and dived headlong back into the Flowing-Sand River.

Pig was beside himself, hopping with rage. "Brother! Who asked you to come? That monster's strokes were slowing — he could barely hold off my rake. Three or five more rounds and I'd have had him! He saw how fierce you looked, turned tail, and bolted. Now what are we to do?"

The Pilgrim laughed. "Brother, I won't lie to you. Ever since we subdued the Yellow Wind fiend and came down off the mountain, it's been a whole month since I had a chance to swing my cudgel. When I saw how sweetly you two were going at it, I just couldn't stand the itch in my feet, so I jumped in for a bit of fun. How was I to know the monster has no taste for sport and would bolt?"

Arm in arm, talking and laughing, the two went back to the Tang Monk. "Did you catch the monster?" he asked.

"He couldn't stand up to the fight," said Wukong. "He broke off and burrowed back into the water."

"Disciple," said Tripitaka, "this fiend has lived here a long while — he must know the shallows and the deeps. The weakling water stretches

boundless before us and there is no boat at all; we shall need someone who knows the water's ways to guide us across."

"Just so," said the Pilgrim. "As the saying goes, 'Who keeps near vermilion turns red; who keeps near ink turns black.' Living here all this time, the creature surely knows the water. Let us capture him — but not kill him. We will only make him ferry the Master across, and settle the rest afterward."

"Brother, no need to dither," said Pig. "You go take him first, and let old Hog watch over the Master."

The Pilgrim laughed. "Worthy brother, this is one job I dare not boast about. Doings underwater are not much in old Monkey's line. If I simply walk down, I must make the hand-sign and chant the water-repelling spell before I can move at all; otherwise I must change myself into some fish, shrimp, crab, or turtle to go in. Up in the highest mountains, among the clouds, whatever strange and crooked business there may be — old Monkey can manage it all. It is only the trade underwater that sits a bit awkwardly with me."

"In my day old Hog commanded the Heavenly River," said Pig, "and had eighty thousand water-troops under my hand, so I did learn something of the water's ways. But I am afraid that down there the creature may have kinfolk — seven nests and eight generations all coming at once. Then I would be no match for them, and like as not they would drag me off."

"If you go down to fight him in the water," said the Pilgrim, "do not get drawn into a real battle. Lose on purpose, never win — lure him out, and old Monkey will be ready to lend a hand."

"Right you are. I'm off," said Pig. And with that he stripped off his green brocade robe, took off his shoes, gripped his rake in both hands, parted

the waters, and drawing on the old arts of his former days, leapt through the waves and plunged in, going straight down to the river's bed and pressing forward.

Now the fiend, having lost the fight and barely caught his breath, heard someone pushing the water aside with a splashing din. He started up to look, and there was Pig with his rake, shoving through the current. The monster raised his staff and shouted: "Where do you think you're going, monk? Watch out for this!" Pig blocked with his rake. "What sort of fiend are you, daring to bar the road here?"

"So you don't know me," said the monster. "I am no common goblin or ghost, and I am not some nameless nobody."

"If you're no goblin or ghost," said Pig, "then why are you here killing the living? Tell me your true name, plainly, and I will spare your life."

"Listen, then," said the fiend. "I:

From my youth my spirit and force were strong;
across ten thousand li of heaven and earth I roamed.
A hero who showed his power throughout the
world, a champion held up as a model in men's
homes. Through all the lands and the Nine
Provinces I went as I pleased, across the Five Lakes
and Four Seas I barged at will. All because I sought
the Way I wandered to the sky's edge, only to find a
master I traveled the broad earth. Year upon year
my robe and bowl I kept close by me; day upon day
my heart and mind I would not let stray. Over the
land I drifted, cloud-borne, dozens of times, and
idly walked to every place a hundred trips and more.
So at last I met a True Immortal, who opened wide
for me the great Way's golden radiance. First I
gathered in the Infant and the Lovely Maid; then I
set free the Wood Mother and the Metal Lord. The
kidney-water of the Bright Hall I drew into the
Flower Pool; the liver-fire of the storied tower I cast
into the heart. When the three thousand merits

were full, I bowed before Heaven's face, and with whole heart paid court, turned toward the bright and splendid. The Jade Emperor himself raised me in rank, and with his own lips named me Curtain-Lifting Captain. Within the Southern Heaven Gate I was held in honor; before the Hall of Divine Mist I was called a chief. At my waist hung the tiger-head tablet of command; in my hand I held this demon-quelling staff. Atop my head a golden helmet blazed like the sun; upon my body armor bright as rosy dawn. Coming and going, I led the imperial escort; at every audience I stood in the highest place. But because the Queen Mother brought down her peaches of immortality and spread a feast at the Jasper Pool, inviting all the captains, I let a crystal goblet slip and shatter, and every god in heaven was struck with terror. The Jade Emperor flew into a rage, and ordered the Minister of the Left at court: they stripped my cap, my armor, and my title, and thrust my body onto the execution ground. I owe

my life to the Barefoot Great Immortal, who stepped from the ranks and pleaded that I be spared. Reprieved from death, brought back to life with no sentence carried out, I was banished to the eastern shore of the Flowing-Sand. When full, I lie sleeping in this hill; when hungry, I churn the waves to hunt for food. The woodcutter who meets me does not live; the fisherman who sees me loses his life. Back and forth I have eaten many men, over and over I have wrought a pestilence of slaughter. You dare bring your violence to my very door — today my belly has its hopes! Don't say you're too coarse and tough to eat; once I've caught you, I'll take my time and chop you into mince!

When Pig heard this he flew into a fury and cursed him. "You filthy thing! You haven't got a scrap of an eye in your head. Old Hog here can still pinch the froth of refinement from his own skin — and you dare call me coarse and talk of chopping me into mince? It seems you've taken me for some worn-out old hide! No more of your insolence — taste your grandfather's rake!"

Seeing the rake come on, the fiend dodged with a move called "the phoenix nods its head." The two of them fought up from the water's bed

to the surface, each treading the billows and riding the waves. This bout was unlike the last. Just look:

The Curtain-Lifting Captain, the Marshal of the Heavenly Reeds — each displays his powers, a wonder to behold. That one swings the demon-quelling treasure-staff straight at the head; this one's nine-toothed rake follows quick as the hand can move. They leap the waves and shake the mountains and streams, they shove the billows till the whole world darkens. Fierce as the year-god ramming the banners and streamers, savage as the Death-Gate spirit ripping off the precious canopy. This one, heart loyal and stern, guards the Tang Monk; that one, steeped in crime, plays the water-fiend. The rake claws once and leaves nine furrowed wounds; the staff strikes home and routs the very soul. They strain in joyful contest, locked together, bending all their wits to win the wager. Reckon it up — it's all for the scripture-seeker's sake, their wrath pierces heaven, past all enduring. They stir the perch and carp and mandarin-fish to shed their fresh scales, bruise the soft shells of turtle, terrapin,

and great soft-shelled tortoise; red shrimp and purple crabs all lose their lives, and all the spirits of the water-palace bow toward the sky. You hear only the waves churn and the billows roll like thunder-crash, sun and moon gone lightless, heaven and earth aghast.

The two fought for two full watches without a winner. This was truly a case of a copper basin meeting an iron broom, a jade chime answered by a golden bell.

Now the Great Sage, guarding the Tang Monk on the bank, watched with anxious, longing eyes as the two struggled upon the water — but there was no place for him to lend a hand. Then he saw Pig feint with his rake, pretend defeat, and turn back toward the eastern bank. The fiend came after him, drawing close to the shore. The Pilgrim could bear it no longer: he left his master, snatched up his iron rod, sprang to the river's edge, and struck straight down at the fiend's head. The creature dared not face him, and with a whoosh dived back into the river.

Pig bawled, "You Bimawen, you Stable-Boy-of-Heaven — you're nothing but a hot-headed, hasty monkey! If you'd just held off a little longer, I'd have coaxed him up onto high ground, and you could have blocked the river's edge so he couldn't turn back — and then we'd have had him! Now that he's gone in, when will he ever come out again?"

The Pilgrim laughed. "Idiot, stop your bellowing. Let's go back and see the Master."

So Pig went with the Pilgrim up onto the high bank and faced Tripitaka. The Elder leaned forward. "You've had a hard time of it, disciples."

"Never mind the hardship," said Pig. "Only when we've subdued the fiend and got you across the river will the plan be wholly sound."

"How did your fight with the monster go?" asked Tripitaka.

"That fiend's skill is a fair match for old Hog's," said Pig. "We were right in the thick of it when I used a feigned defeat, and he chased me up to the bank. The moment he saw Elder Brother lift his cudgel, he ran."

"In that case, what are we to do?" said Tripitaka.

"Set your heart at ease, Master, and don't fret," said the Pilgrim. "It's late now. Rest here on the cliff-bank, and let old Monkey go beg some food. You'll eat and sleep, and tomorrow we'll see to it."

"Well said," replied Pig. "Be quick there and back."

The Pilgrim leapt up on his cloud, flew straight to a household far to the north, begged a bowl of plain vegetarian food, and brought it back to offer his master. Seeing how quickly he had returned, the Master said, "Wukong, at this house where you begged the meal, why not ask them for some plan to cross the river? Wouldn't that be better than struggling with this fiend?"

The Pilgrim laughed. "That household is dreadfully far — five or seven thousand li off. What would they know of the water here? What good would it do to ask them?"

"Brother, you're spinning lies again," said Pig. "Five or seven thousand li — how could you go and come back so fast?"

"What do you know of it?" said Wukong. "Old Monkey's cloud-somersault carries me a hundred and eight thousand li at a single bound. A trip of five or seven thousand is no more than two nods of the head and one bow of the waist — there and back, where's the difficulty?"

"Brother," said Pig, "if it's that easy, then just carry the Master on your back, give two nods and a bow of the waist, and hop us across! Why bother fighting this fiend so bitterly?"

"Can't you ride a cloud yourself?" said the Pilgrim. "Why don't you carry the Master over?"

"The Master's mortal flesh and common bones are heavier than Mount Tai," said Pig. "How could a cloud-rider like me bear him up? It would take your somersault to manage it."

"My somersault is a cloud-riding too," said Wukong, "differing only in how far it goes. If you can't carry him, how could I? As the old saying has it, 'To shift Mount Tai is light as a mustard-seed, but to carry a mortal man past the red dust is hard.' These vile fiends and venomous monsters may use snatching-spells and conjure the wind, but it's all tugging and dragging, traveling along the ground — they cannot bear a man up into the empty air. That sort of trick old Monkey can also work. There are the spells of invisibility and of shrinking the road, every one of which old Monkey knows. But the Master must wear out the whole journey through these strange lands; he cannot leap clear of the sea of suffering — and so he must go inch by hard-won inch. You and I can only escort him, keep his body whole and his life safe; we cannot take these hardships from him, nor can we fetch the scriptures in his place. Even if we went on ahead and saw the Buddha first, the Buddha would not be willing to hand the scriptures over to you or me. It is just as they say: 'What is got too easily is held too lightly.'"

Hearing this, Pig bowed his assent and took the words to heart. They ate a little of the plain, meatless food, and master and disciples rested at the foot of the eastern cliff of the Flowing-Sand River.

Early next morning Tripitaka said, "Wukong, how shall we manage today?"

"There's no managing it," said the Pilgrim, "except that Pig must go down into the water again."

"Brother," said Pig, "you only want to keep yourself clean and make old Hog do the diving."

"Worthy brother, this time I won't be so hasty," said the Pilgrim. "You just lure him up, and I'll block the riverbank and keep him from getting back. We must take him for certain."

Good Pig! He wiped his face, braced his spirit, gripped his rake in both hands, went to the riverbank, parted the waters, and once more descended to the lair.

The fiend had only just woken from sleep when he heard the splashing of water pushed aside. He whipped his head around, opened his eyes wide, and saw Pig coming with his rake. Out he sprang, blocked the way head-on, and bellowed, "Easy there, easy there — watch out for this staff!" Pig raised his rake to block. "What kind of mourner's staff is that," he jeered, "that you'd have your grandfather watch out for it?"

"You wretch, you know nothing," said the fiend. "This:

This treasure-staff has a name of high renown,
sprung from the sala-tree that grows within the
moon. Wu Gang cut down a single branch of it; Lu
Ban wrought it with the craftsman's perfect skill.
Within runs a single core of gold; without, ten
thousand strands of pearl-set jade. Its name, the
Treasure-Staff, is good for quelling demons, forever
keeping the Hall of Divine Mist, able to subdue all
fiends. Because I was made a Great General, the
Jade Emperor bestowed it for me to carry at my
side. Long or short, it follows my heart's wish; thick
or thin, it bends to my whim. It once guarded the
throne at the peach-feast; it once attended court in
the upper realm. On duty in the hall, the assembled
saints beheld it; lifting the curtain, the immortals all
bowed before it. A spirit-weapon, nurtured to
numinous nature — no common tool of the mortal
world. Since I was banished out the heaven gate, it
roams the seas with me as I please. I'll not be so
bold as to boast too far — but no spear or blade on

earth can match it. As for that rusty nailed rake of yours, it's good for nothing but hoeing fields and digging vegetable beds!

Pig laughed. "You under-thrashed, filthy thing! Never mind vegetable beds — I'm only afraid that one swipe of mine will leave you no place to stick a plaster, with all nine of your holes streaming blood at once. And even if it doesn't kill you, it'll be a lifelong case of lockjaw!" The fiend threw open his guard, and there beneath the water he and Pig fought their way back up to the surface. This bout was truly different from the last. Just look:

The treasure-staff swings, the nailed rake drives; their words don't agree, for they are not of one house. All because the Wood Mother bears down on the Blade-and-Sword, the two are set against each other in the fray. No winner, no loser, no give and take — churning waves and tossing billows, never at peace. How can this one's wrath be contained; how can that one bear the shame of his hurt? Rake comes, staff blocks — each plays the hero; the water boils, the flowing sand does its venom. Spirits high, toil unceasing, all because Tripitaka journeys to the Western Realm. The nailed rake is mighty fierce; the treasure-staff is thoroughly practiced. This one grabs to drag the other up the bank; that one claws to souse the other in the water. The din is like a thunderclap that stirs the fish and dragons, clouds darken, the sky dims, gods and ghosts cower.

Back and forth they fought thirty rounds with neither gaining the upper hand. Then Pig again worked his feigning-defeat trick, trailed his rake, and ran. The fiend came chasing after, riding the billows and seizing the

waves, right up to the cliff's edge. Pig cursed him: "You filthy fiend! Come up here onto the high ground where there's solid earth underfoot — it'll be good fighting!" But the fiend cursed back: "You wretch, you're luring me up so your helper can come at me again! You come down — we'll fight it out in the water, as before." The fiend had grown wary and would by no means come up onto the bank; he kept up his uproar at the river's edge, facing Pig across the shallows.

Now the Pilgrim, seeing he would not come up, grew so hot and frantic with vexation that he longed to snatch him in one grasp. "Master," he said, "you sit here, and let me serve him a hungry hawk pouncing on its food." With that he leapt up in a somersault, sprang into mid-air, and came swooping down to seize the fiend. But the fiend, just then wrangling with Pig, suddenly heard the wind whistle overhead, jerked his head around, saw the Pilgrim dropping from the clouds, drew in his staff, and with one plunge dived into the water — vanished without a trace.

The Pilgrim stood on the bank and said to Pig, "Brother, this fiend has grown slippery indeed. He won't come up on the bank any more — what's to be done?"

"Hard, hard, hard," said Pig. "I can't beat him. I've used up the very strength I sucked at my mother's breast, and I can only just hold him to a draw."

"Let's go see the Master," said the Pilgrim.

The two of them climbed again to the high bank and faced the Tang Monk, telling him in full how hard the fiend was to subdue. The Elder's eyes brimmed with tears. "With such difficulties as these, how are we ever to cross?"

"Master, don't grieve," said the Pilgrim. "This fiend lurks deep in the water, and truly it is hard going. Pig, you stay here and guard the Master, and fight him no more. Let old Monkey make a trip to the Southern Sea."

"Brother, what will you do at the Southern Sea?" asked Pig.

"This scripture-seeking business," said the Pilgrim, "was the doing of the Bodhisattva Guanyin from the start; and it was Guanyin too who delivered each of us. Now that our road is blocked at the Flowing-Sand River and we can go no further, without her how shall we set it right? Let me go ask her — it's far better than wrangling with this fiend."

"Yes, yes," said Pig. "Elder Brother, when you go, do be sure to put in a word for me: tell her I'm grateful for all her past instruction."

"Wukong," said Tripitaka, "if you're going to ask the Bodhisattva, then don't delay — be quick there and back."

The Pilgrim at once mounted his cloud-somersault and made straight for the Southern Sea. Marvelous! In less than half a watch he sighted the bounds of Mount Potalaka. In a moment he set down his somersault, and outside the Purple Bamboo Grove the Devas of the Twenty-Four Roads came forward to greet him. "Whence comes the Great Sage?"

"My master is in trouble," said the Pilgrim, "and I've come especially to see the Bodhisattva."

"Pray be seated, and allow us to announce you," said the Devas. The Deva on duty that day went straight to the mouth of the Tide-Sound Cave and reported, "Sun Wukong is here on business, seeking an audience." The Bodhisattva, who was just then leaning on the railing by the Treasure-Lotus Pool with the pearl-bearing Dragon Maiden, admiring the flowers, heard the announcement, turned back to the cloud-cliff, opened the door,

and called him in. The Great Sage, solemn and reverent, made his obeisance.

"Why are you not guarding the Tang Monk?" asked the Bodhisattva.

"What brings you here to see me again?"

The Pilgrim reported, "Bodhisattva, at the Gao Family Village my master took on another disciple — Zhu Bajie, Pig of the Eight Precepts, to whom you graciously gave the religious name Wuneng. We have just crossed the Yellow Wind Ridge and have now come to the eight-hundred-li Flowing-Sand River, the three thousand fathoms of weakling water, which my master cannot hope to cross. And in the river there is a fiend of high martial skill. Thanks to Wuneng he has been fought three times upon the water, but we cannot prevail; the fiend bars our way, and we cannot cross. So I have come especially to tell you, Bodhisattva, in hope that you will take pity and grant us a means to get across."

"You monkey," said the Bodhisattva, "puffed up with your own self-satisfaction again — wouldn't you let on that you were the one escorting the Tang Monk?"

"We only meant to capture him and make him ferry my master over," said the Pilgrim. "Underwater work I can't manage finely. It was Wuneng who sought out his lair and spoke with him — and I suppose he never let out anything about the scripture-seeking."

"That fiend in the Flowing-Sand River," said the Bodhisattva, "is the Curtain-Lifting Great Captain come down to the mortal world — also one of the faithful whom I converted, charged to protect the scripture-seekers. Had you only let it be known that you are scripture-seekers from the Land of the East, he would surely never have fought you, but would certainly have submitted."

"The fiend now shrinks from battle and won't come up on the bank," said the Pilgrim. "He only lurks hidden in the water. How is he to be made to submit? And how is my master to cross the weakling water?"

The Bodhisattva at once called Huian, drew a little red gourd from her sleeve, and instructed him: "Take this gourd, go with Sun Wukong to the surface of the Flowing-Sand River, and simply call out 'Wujing' — and he will come forth. First lead him to take refuge with the Tang Monk. Then string those nine skulls of his together, arrange them according to the pattern of the Nine Palaces, and set this gourd in the middle. That will make a single dharma-vessel, able to ferry the Tang Monk across the bounds of the Flowing-Sand River."

Huian heard, respectfully obeyed his teacher's command, and with the Great Sage bore the gourd out of the Tide-Sound Cave. Having received the holy order, they took their leave of the Purple Bamboo Grove. There is a poem to attest it:

The Five Phases matched and joined return to heavenly truth; the old master of former days is recognized again. Refine the self, lay the foundation for the marvelous work; distinguish clearly the false and true, and see the root cause. Metal comes home to its nature, returning to its kind; Wood departs seeking feeling, and both sink back together. When the Two Earths' full merit is complete, all is stillness — water and fire harmonized, without a speck of dust.

In no long while the two of them brought down their clouds and came to the bank of the Flowing-Sand River. Pig recognized the Pilgrim Moksha at once and led his master forward to welcome him. Moksha exchanged courtesies with Tripitaka, then greeted Pig. "Honored One," said Pig, "thanks to your former guidance I came to see the Bodhisattva, and old Hog has indeed followed the holy teaching — and now, to my joy, has entered the gate of the faith. All this while I've been so taken up with the toils of the road that I never managed to thank you. Forgive me, forgive me."

"Let's not stand on long talk," said the Pilgrim. "Let's go call that fellow out."

"Call whom?" asked Tripitaka.

"I saw the Bodhisattva," said Wukong, "and set the whole matter before her. She says the fiend of the Flowing-Sand River is the Curtain-Lifting Great Captain come down to the mortal world. For a crime committed in Heaven he fell into this river and forgot his true form, turning into a fiend. He too was once converted by the Bodhisattva, and vowed to follow the Master to the Western Heaven. But because we never said anything about the scripture-seeking, he kept up the bitter struggle. Now the Bodhisattva has sent Moksha with this gourd to make the fellow into a dharma-vessel and ferry you across."

Hearing this, Tripitaka bowed in endless reverence and made obeisance to Moksha, saying, "I beg the Honored One to proceed without delay."

Moksha, holding the gourd firm, rode half on cloud and half on mist straight to the surface of the Flowing-Sand River and cried in a ringing voice, "Wujing! Wujing! The scripture-seeker has been here a long while — why have you still not submitted?"

Now the fiend, in dread of the Monkey King, had gone back to the riverbed and was resting in his lair when he heard his religious name called. He knew at once it must be the Bodhisattva Guanyin; and hearing the words "the scripture-seeker is here," he no longer feared the axe and battle-axe, but quickly churned up through the waves and thrust out his head — and recognized the Pilgrim Moksha. See how, all smiles, he came forward and bowed. "Honored One, forgive me for failing to welcome you! Where is the Bodhisattva now?"

"My teacher has not come," said Moksha, "but sent me ahead to tell you to follow the Tang Monk at once as his disciple. You are to take the skulls hung about your neck, and with this gourd arrange them by the pattern of the Nine Palaces into a dharma-vessel, and ferry him across this weakling water."

"Where is the scripture-seeker?" asked Wujing.

Moksha pointed. "Isn't that he, sitting there on the eastern bank?"

Wujing looked and saw Pig. "That one — I don't know where the filthy thing came from. He's fought me two whole days, and never once spoke a single word about scripture-seeking!" Then he saw the Pilgrim and said, "And that master there is his helper — a mighty dangerous one. I'll not go."

"That is Zhu Bajie, and this is Sun the Pilgrim," said Moksha. "Both are disciples of the Tang Monk, both converted by the Bodhisattva. Why fear them? Come, I'll take you to see the Tang Monk."

Only then did Wujing put away his treasure-staff, straighten his robe of yellow brocade, leap onto the bank, and kneel on both knees before the Tang Monk. "Master, your disciple has eyes but no pupils — I failed to know your honored face, and gave you much offense. I beg you, forgive me."

"You sack of pus," said Pig, "why didn't you submit at the start, instead of insisting on fighting me? What have you to say for yourself?"

The Pilgrim laughed. "Brother, don't blame him. It's only that we never spoke out about the scripture-seeking or our names."

"Are you truly willing, with a sincere heart, to take refuge in our faith?" asked the Elder.

"Your disciple was long ago instructed by the Bodhisattva," said Wujing. "She took the sand for my surname and gave me a religious name — Sha Wujing. How could I not follow you, Master?"

"In that case," said Tripitaka, and called, "Wukong, fetch the precept-knife and shave his head." The Great Sage did as he was told and shaved him at

once. Then Wujing made his bows to Tripitaka, to the Pilgrim, and to Pig, and they settled their ranks of seniority. Seeing that he carried himself with all the bearing of a true monk, Tripitaka named him also Sha the Monk — Friar Sand.

"Since he has taken up the holy charge," said Moksha, "there's no need for more fuss. Make the dharma-vessel quickly and be off."

Wujing dared not delay. He took the skulls from about his neck, strung them with a cord into the pattern of the Nine Palaces, set the Bodhisattva's gourd in the center, and invited the Master down to the bank. The Elder stepped onto the dharma-vessel and sat upon it, and truly it was as steady as a light skiff. On the left Pig supported him, on the right Wujing held him up; Sun the Pilgrim came behind, leading the dragon-horse, following half on cloud and half on mist; and high overhead Moksha kept watch over them. So the Master floated calmly and steadily across the bounds of the Flowing-Sand River — the waves stilled, the wind laid, he passed over the weakling water. Truly it was swift as a flying arrow, and in no long while he set foot on the farther shore, escaped from the mighty flood — not so much as a smear of mud or trail of water on him, but, to his joy, with dry feet and dry hands, clean and serene in perfect repose. Master and disciples set their feet on solid ground.

Then Moksha brought down his auspicious cloud and gathered up the gourd. And lo — in that instant the skulls dissolved into nine streams of dark wind and, silent and still, vanished from sight. Tripitaka gave thanks to Moksha and made obeisance toward the Bodhisattva. Indeed:

Moksha went straight back to the Eastern Ocean Sea; Tripitaka mounted his horse and turned again toward the west.

In the end there is no telling when at last they would win the true fruit and obtain the scriptures — so listen to the next chapter told.

Chapter 23: The Four Saints Test a Pilgrim's Heart

Bearing the Law, they journey west — the road runs long and far; The autumn wind sighs softly down, and frost-flowers fall like stars. The crafty ape is chained up tight — loose not the binding cord; The stubborn horse is reined and curbed — spare it the goading rod. The Wood Mother and the Metal Squire were one from the beginning; The Yellow Dame and the Crimson Child were never two apart. Bite open the iron pellet, and the true tidings come; Through Prajñā-pāramitā you reach the farther shore at last.

This chapter tells how the way of fetching the scriptures is never separate from the single body's labor at its own root. We left our master and his three disciples awakened to True Suchness, the locks of the dust-world flung open all at once, leaping clear of the sea of nature and the flowing sands, free now of every entanglement, striking straight onto the great western road. They crossed green mountains and blue waters, gazed upon more wild grass and idle blossoms than the eye could take in. Truly time runs swift, and again the ninth-month autumn came upon them. They saw such sights as these:

Maple leaves redden across the hills, Yellow
chrysanthemums endure the evening gale. The old
cicada's droning slows and tires, The grieving
cricket frets without an end. The lotus tears its fan
of pale green silk; The citron's fragrance hangs in
golden clusters. How pitiful — a few thin lines of
geese, Dot upon dot, ranged far against the empty
sky.

As they journeyed on, evening came before they marked it. Tripitaka said, "Disciples, the daylight is failing again — where shall we lodge for the night?"

Monkey said, "Master, your words go astray. We who have left the household life dine on the wind and sleep on the water, lie beneath the moon and bed down in the frost — wherever we are is home. Why ask where to lodge?"

Zhu Bajie said, "Brother, that's easy for you to say. You go light along the road — what do you care for another man's burdens? Ever since we crossed the Flowing-Sand River, it's been climbing peaks and crossing ridges, with this heavy load on my shoulders the whole way — it's a hard road for a poor fellow to endure. We ought to find a household: first, to beg some tea and rice; second, to restore our spirits. That would be the sensible thing."

Monkey said, "Idiot, the way you talk, it sounds like you've a complaining heart. You'd still like to lounge about as you did at the Gao Village, idle and asking no blessing — well, that won't do anymore. Now that you've taken your vows as a true monk, you must eat bitterness and bear hardship — only so are you fit to be a disciple."

Bajie said, "Elder Brother, just look how heavy this baggage is." Monkey said, "Brother, ever since we had you and Sha Monk along, I've never once carried it — how should I know how heavy it is?"

Bajie said, "Brother, just reckon the count of it:

Four leaves of yellow rattan-matting, Eight ropes
long and short to bind it; Then, to guard against the
gloomy rains, Three or four layers of felt to wrap it.
The flat carrying-pole frets you with slipping, So
nails are driven in at either end. A nine-ringed staff
of copper-mounted iron, And the great broad rain-
cape wound in woven cane.

A load like this, so much of it — it's no easy thing for old Pig to carry day after day, while you, the favored one, play disciple to the Master and make a hired laborer of me!"

Monkey laughed. "Idiot, who are you talking to?"

Bajie said, "I'm talking to you, Brother."

Monkey said, "You've mistaken your man. Old Monkey looks after the Master's welfare alone; you and Sha Monk are charged with the baggage and the horse. But if you slack off the least bit, you'll first taste a stout cudgel across your ankle-bone."

Bajie said, "Brother, don't talk of beating — beating is just using force to bully a man. I know that grand, haughty nature of yours; you'll surely never carry it. But that horse the Master rides is big and tall and well-fed, and it only bears one old monk. Let it carry a few pieces too — that'd be brotherly feeling."

Monkey said, "You call him a horse, but he's no ordinary horse. He is the son of Aorun, Dragon King of the Western Sea, and was named the Third Prince Dragon-Horse. Because he set fire to the bright pearl in his hall, his father charged him with unfilial conduct, and he broke the laws of Heaven — but for the grace of the Bodhisattva Guanyin, who saved his life. He waited long for the Master at the Eagle-Grief Steep Torrent, and by good fortune the Bodhisattva herself came, stripped away his scales, plucked off his horns, took the pearl from beneath his throat, and changed him into this very horse, that he might willingly bear the Master to the Western Heaven to worship Buddha. This is all his own merit in the working — don't go pestering him."

Sha Monk, hearing this, said, "Brother, is he truly a dragon?" Monkey said, "He is a dragon."

Bajie said, "Brother, I've heard the men of old say a dragon can puff out clouds and breathe forth mists, scatter earth and fling up sand; that he has the power to grip a mountain ridge, and the magic to overturn rivers and stir the seas. How is it, then, that today he plods along so slowly?"

Monkey said, "You want him to go fast? I'll make him go fast for you to see."

Watch now the Great Sage! He gripped his gold-banded cudgel and gave it a shake, and ten thousand beams of colored cloud sprang forth. The horse, seeing the cudgel raised and fearing a blow, took fright; its four hooves flew swift as lightning, and whoosh — it bolted away. The Master, his hands too weak to rein it in, let the brute have its way; up the mountain crag it dashed, until at last it slowed to a heavy, picking stride. Only when his panting had steadied did the Master lift his head and see, far off, a clump of pine-shade with several buildings among it, lofty and imposing indeed. He saw:

Green cypress hangs above the gate; The dwelling
nestles near blue hills. A few pines softly, slowly
sway; Some stalks of bamboo, dappled bright. By
the hedge the wild mums glow with frost; Beside
the bridge the secret orchids redden in the stream.
Whitewashed walls of plastered clay, A round
enclosure laid in brick. The high halls grand and
richly made, The mansion still and clean and calm.
No ox or sheep, no fowl or hound is seen — The
autumn harvest done, the farm-work idle now.

The Master had just reined in to gaze unhurried at it when his disciples came up at last. Wujing said, "Master, you didn't tumble from the horse, I hope?" The Elder scolded, "That ruffian Monkey — he frightened my horse! Lucky I could still keep my seat."

Monkey said, smiling apologetically, "Master, don't scold me. It was all Zhu Bajie, who said the horse went too slow, so I made it go a little faster." And the idiot, having run hard chasing the horse, came up puffing and wheezing, muttering and grumbling under his breath: "It's done for, it's done for! With a belly stuck out and a loose waist-band, a load too heavy to hoist up — and now they set me running to and fro after a horse!"

The Elder said, "Disciple, look there to the side — there stands a manor house. We'd do well to beg a night's lodging there." Hearing this, Monkey quickly lifted his head and looked, and indeed he saw blessed clouds gathered in the upper air, auspicious vapors brimming all about it. He knew at once it was certainly some immortal or buddha working a transformation, but he dared not betray the secret of Heaven, and only said, "Good, good, good — let's go beg a night's lodging."

The Elder hastily dismounted. He saw a gate-tower built with hanging lotus-and-elephant-trunk carvings, painted rafters and sculpted beams. Sha Monk set down his load; Bajie led up the horse and said, "This household is a family of surpassing wealth and substance." Monkey was about to go straight in, but Tripitaka said, "That won't do. You and I are men who have left the household; each of us must avoid all appearance of impropriety, so do not enter uninvited. Let us wait until someone comes out, and then ask for lodging with proper courtesy — that is the way." Bajie tethered the horse and leaned sideways against the foot of the wall; Tripitaka sat upon a stone drum; Monkey and Sha Monk sat at the edge of the terrace-base. A long while passed and no one came out.

Monkey, being of an impatient nature, sprang up and went in through the gate to have a look. There he found a great three-bayed hall facing south, its blinds and lattices hung high. On the screen-door hung a long horizontal scroll painted with "Mountains of Long Life and Seas of

Blessing"; on the gilt-lacquered pillars to either side was pasted a couplet on bright red paper, which read: "Threads of frail willow flutter — evening on the level bridge; / Flecks of snow upon fragrant plum — spring in the little court." In the very center stood an incense-table of polished black lacquer, and upon it an ancient bronze beast-shaped censer. Above were six folding chairs, and on the gable-walls to either side hung four hanging-screens depicting the four seasons.

Monkey was peering about when suddenly he heard footsteps within the rear door, and out came a woman, neither old nor young, who asked in a soft, charming voice, "Who are you, that you dare intrude upon a widow's gate?" Flustered, the great Sage bowed and bowed again, murmuring his apologies: "This humble monk comes from the Land of the East, the Great Tang, sent by imperial decree to the Western Heaven to worship Buddha and seek the scriptures. We are four travelers together. Passing through your precious district, with the daylight already failing, we have come especially to your venerable mansion, good Bodhisattva, to beg a single night's shelter."

The woman, all smiles, welcomed him: "Elder, where are the other three? Pray bring them in." Monkey called out loudly, "Master, please come in." Then Tripitaka, with Bajie and Sha Monk leading the horse and shouldering the load, came in and saw the woman step out from the hall to receive them. Bajie, with sweet, slanting eyes, stole a look at her — and how was she arrayed? See for yourself:

She wore a brocaded gown of official green damask,
Over it a short jacket of pale rose; She bound a five-
colored, goose-yellow embroidered skirt, Below
which flashed high-soled flowered shoes. Her
fashionable coiffure was veiled in black gauze, Set
off by two-toned coiled-dragon tresses; A palace-
style ivory comb gleamed vermilion and kingfisher-
blue, And aslant were thrust two gold-ringed
hairpins. Her cloud-dark hair was half gone gray,
flying like phoenix wings; From her ears hung
double pendants strung with precious pearls.
Without rouge or powder she was lovely still, Her
charm yet that of a young woman's prime.

When the woman had seen the three of them, her delight grew greater still, and with gracious courtesy she invited them into the hall. They made their introductions one by one, and when the greetings were done she asked them each to be seated and called for tea. From behind the screen there appeared a serving-maid with hair in a coiled knot and trailing silk-locks, bearing a tray of yellow gold and cups of white jade — the fragrant tea breathing warm vapor, the rare fruits shedding a delicate scent. With sweeping colored sleeves and slender spring-bamboo fingers she lifted the jade cups and passed the tea round in offering, bowing to

each of them in turn. The tea finished, the woman ordered a vegetarian meal prepared.

Tripitaka raised his hands and asked, "Good Bodhisattva, what is your honored surname? And what is the name of this district?" The woman said, "This is the land of the Western Continent of Cattle-Gift. My maiden family name is Jia; my husband's family name, Mo. In my youth, by misfortune, my father- and mother-in-law died early, and my husband and I kept up the ancestral estate. We have a fortune of ten thousand strings of cash and a thousand acres of good land. But as fate gave us no son, we had only three daughters. The year before last came a still greater misfortune: I lost my husband too. I have lived as a widow, and this year my mourning is fulfilled. There is left only this land and household property, and no kinfolk or relations whatever — only we, a mother and her girls, to take it in hand. To marry out into another family, I cannot bear to give up the estate. Now that you elders have descended upon us, I think — you are a master and three disciples; we are a mother and three daughters, four of us. It is my wish to keep the estate and take in husbands here, and four of you would suit exactly. I wonder whether your honored intentions would consent or no?"

When Tripitaka heard this, he feigned deafness and played dumb, closed his eyes and stilled his heart, and sat silent without a word in answer.

The woman went on: "My poor house has more than three hundred acres of paddy field, more than three hundred acres of dry field, and more than three hundred acres of hill-land orchard and fruit trees; there are over a thousand yellow water-buffalo, mules and horses in droves, pigs and sheep beyond counting; to the east, south, west, and north, our farmsteads, fortified granges, and pasture-grounds together number some sixty or seventy places; in the household there is grain and rice enough for eight or nine years of unused store, silks and gauzes enough

that you could not wear them out in ten years and more, and gold and silver enough that you could not spend it in a lifetime. It is far better than 'hiding the spring behind brocade curtains' — why speak of mere 'two rows of golden hairpins'? If you master and disciples would only turn your hearts and consent to be wedded sons-in-law in our humble home, you could live at ease and enjoy splendor and glory — is that not far better than laboring westward?"

But Tripitaka only sat there as though dull and witless, silent and saying nothing.

The woman said, "I was born in the year of the Boar, on the third day of the third month, in the hour of the cock. My late husband was three years older than I; I am now forty-five. My eldest daughter is named Zhenzhen, and is this year twenty; my second is named Aiai, and is this year eighteen; my third little daughter is named Lianlian, and is this year sixteen — and none of them is yet betrothed to any household. Plain though I am myself, my girls are fortunate enough to have some measure of good looks, and in needlework and embroidery there is nothing they cannot do. Because my late husband had no son, we raised them as if they were boys, and in their childhood we even had them read some Confucian books, so they understand a little of composing verses and matching couplets. Though we dwell in a mountain manor, we are not of the coarse and vulgar sort, and I think they are well matched to you elders. If you will only open wide your hearts, grow out your hair, and become the heads of our household, you shall wear silks and dress in brocade — far better than that earthen begging-bowl and black monk's robe, those straw sandals and rain-cape of woven cloud."

Tripitaka, seated above, was for all the world like a child startled by thunder, like a toad drenched by rain: he only sat dazed and rigid, the whites of his eyes rolling upward, fallen back in a stupor.

But Bajie, hearing of such wealth and such beauty, found his heart itching past all scratching. Seated in his chair, he was as if a needle were jabbing his backside, twisting left and twisting right, unable to bear it. He came forward and gave the Master a tug, saying, "Master, this lady is telling you something — how can you sit there pretending not to hear? You ought at least to make some answer."

The Master snapped up his head, gave a great cry of "Bah!" and barked Bajie back: "You cursed beast! We are men who have left the household — how should we let our hearts be stirred by wealth, our minds detained by beauty? What manner of religion would that be?"

The woman laughed: "Pitiful, pitiful. What good thing is there in leaving the household?" Tripitaka said, "Lady Bodhisattva, and you who stay in the household — what good thing is there in that?"

The woman said, "Elder, sit, and let me tell you the good of those who stay at home. How shall its worth be shown? There is a poem for proof. It runs:

In spring we cut fresh gauze and don new silks; In summer change to light gauze and admire the green lotus; Autumn brings fresh-brewed wine, fragrant from glutinous rice; Winter comes, and in the warm chamber our faces flush with drink. Through the four seasons there is every kind of plenty; At all eight feasts, each rare delicacy in its turn. On the wedding-candle night, on brocade laid over silk — Far better than to tramp the road and bow to Amitābha."

Tripitaka said, "Lady Bodhisattva, you who stay at home enjoy splendor and receive riches; you have what to wear and what to eat, with sons and daughters gathered round — truly that is good. But you do not know that we who have left the household have a good thing of our own. How shall its worth be shown? There is a poem for proof. It runs:

To leave the household and set the will is no common thing — It overturns the hall of former love and tenderness. No outward things give rise to idle gossip of the tongue; Within the body there dwells its own good yin and yang. Merit complete and conduct fulfilled, we attend the golden gate; Seeing our nature, our minds made clear, we return to our old home. Far better than at home to crave the taste of blood and flesh, And in old age sink down into a stinking sack of skin."

When the woman heard this, she flew into a great rage: "You insolent monk! Were it not that I see you have come so far from the Land of the East, I should have you driven out at once. Here am I, in true and honest heart, wishing to take you in and join you to my household's fortunes — and you turn round and wound me with your words! Even granting you have taken your vows and sworn never to return to the lay life, surely among your followers my family might take in even one — why are you so stiff and rigid with your Law?"

Seeing her wrathful, Tripitaka could only humble himself with bows and meekness, and called out, "Wukong, you stay here, then." Monkey said, "From a boy I never knew how to manage such matters — let Bajie stay here." Bajie said, "Brother, don't go planting a man! Let us all reckon it

out together at leisure." Tripitaka said, "If you two won't, then let Wujing stay here."

Sha Monk said, "Just listen to what the Master says! This disciple, by the Bodhisattva's persuading, took the vows of conduct and waited for the Master. Since the Master took me in and granted me his teaching, I have followed him not yet two whole months, and have not gained even half a measure of merit — how should I dare to scheme after such wealth? I would sooner die and go to the Western Heaven; I will never do so faithless a thing."

When the woman saw them all refusing and unwilling, she hastily turned and withdrew behind the screen, slamming the inner door shut with a bang. Master and disciples were left out there with neither tea nor rice, and no one came out again. Bajie, fretting and burning within, grumbled and blamed the Tang Monk: "Master, you really don't know how to handle a thing — you've talked the whole matter dead. You ought to have left a little footing for us, just answered her vaguely and humored her into giving us a meal, so we'd have one comfortable night out of it. Whether we said yes or no tomorrow would still have been up to you and me. But now, with the door shut and no one coming out — this cold hearth and dead ashes — how are we to pass the night?"

Wujing said, "Second brother, you go and be a son-in-law in her house." Bajie said, "Brother, don't plant a man — let's reckon it out at leisure." Monkey said, "What is there to reckon? If you're willing, then we'll just have the Master and that woman join as in-laws, and you can be the son-in-law married into her house. A family so rich and full of treasure would surely furnish a dowry and lay on a fine wedding feast — and we'd all get something good out of it. You return to the lay life here — isn't that a thing good for both sides?" Bajie said, "Well, that's all very fine to say, only it'd be a case of me casting off the religious life and then going back

to the lay — keeping one wife and taking another." Sha Monk said, "So second brother already has a wife?"

Monkey said, "You don't know him yet. He was originally the son-in-law of old Squire Gao of Gao Village in the land of Ushas — until old Monkey subdued him. He too once took the Bodhisattva's vows of conduct; helpless against me, he was caught and made a monk, and so cast off his former wife and took up with the Master to journey west and bow to Buddha. He must have been long parted from her, and has begun thinking again of that old business; and now, hearing of this business, he's certainly got the same notion stirring again. Idiot, you go be the son-in-law of this household — only make a few extra bows to old Monkey, and I'll let it pass and not report you."

The idiot said, "Nonsense, nonsense! Everyone here has the same notion — why single out old Pig to be shamed alone? As the old saying goes, 'A monk is a starving ghost in the matter of lust.' Which of you doesn't want it? You all twist and simper and put on airs, and so spoil the whole good thing, till now we can't get sight of so much as tea or water, and there's no one to mind the lamp and fire. Even if we sweat out this one night — that horse must carry someone again tomorrow and tramp the road again; and if it's starved another night, it'll be fit for nothing but skinning. You sit here; let old Pig go and graze the horse a while."

The idiot hurriedly loosed the halter and dragged the horse out. Monkey said, "Sha Monk, you keep the Master company here while old Monkey goes after him to see where he means to graze the horse." Tripitaka said, "Wukong, go and watch him if you like, but you mustn't keep on mocking him." Monkey said, "I know." The great Sage walked out of the hall, shook himself, and changed into a red dragonfly. Out the front gate he flew and caught up with Bajie.

The idiot was leading the horse, but wherever grass grew he would not let it eat; clucking and chuckling to himself, he drove the horse round to the rear of the house. There he found the woman standing outside the back door with her three daughters, the four of them idling in the garden and gazing at the chrysanthemums for amusement. When they caught sight of Bajie approaching, the three girls slipped away inside. The woman alone remained in the doorway and called out, "Little elder, where are you off to?"

The idiot dropped the halter, stepped forward, and made a bow. "Mother, I've come to graze the horse." The woman said, "Your master is far too finicky. Were he to take in a son-in-law here at my house, wouldn't that beat being a wandering monk and tramping the road west?" Bajie laughed. "They are acting on the Tang Emperor's decree and dare not disobey their sovereign's command, so they'll have none of it. Just now in the front hall they were all planting the blame on me, and I — well, I'm one who can manage those above and serve those below — only I'm afraid Mother finds my snout too long and my ears too large."

The woman said, "I don't mind any of that. The trouble is simply that the house lacks a head; to take one in would do well enough — but I fear my girls may find you a bit ugly." Bajie said, "Mother, tell your worthy daughters not to be so choosy in a husband. Think of that Tang Monk of mine — handsome enough in person, but truly good for nothing. I'm ugly, ugly indeed, but I've a few lines of rhyme to recommend me." The woman said, "How do they go?"

Bajie said, "Here:

Though my person is ugly, I'm diligent and have my uses. If you've a thousand acres of land, No need to drive an ox to plow it: One pass of my rake will do, And the seed comes up in season. No rain? I can pray for rain; No wind? I can call up wind. If the houses seem too low, I'll raise them two or three stories higher. An unswept floor? I'll sweep it; A blocked drain? I'll clear it through. All the household's great and small affairs — Kicking heaven, dredging wells — I can do them all."

The woman said, "Well, since you can manage the household work, go and talk it over once more with your master; if there's no awkwardness about it, I'll take you in." Bajie said, "No need to talk it over — he's not my father who begot me. Whether I do this or not is up to me alone." The woman said, "Very well, very well; let me speak with my girls." And with that she slipped inside and clapped the rear door shut with a bang.

Bajie had not grazed the horse at all; he led it back round to the front. Little did he know that the great Sage Sun had heard every word. Beating his wings, Monkey flew back, resumed his true form, and went at once to the Tang Monk, saying, "Master, Wuneng has brought the horse back." The Elder said, "I was afraid the horse might frolic off if left unled."

Then Monkey laughed aloud and recounted from the beginning all that the woman and Bajie had said together. Tripitaka half believed and half

doubted it. In a little while the idiot came dragging the horse up and tied it down. The Elder said, "Did you graze the horse?" Bajie said, "There was no good grass anywhere — no fit place to graze it." Monkey said, "No place to graze the horse — but a place to lead it, eh?"

When the idiot heard these words he knew the secret was out; and so he hung his head and craned his neck, thrust out his great lips and knitted his brow, and for a long while said nothing. Then there came a creak — the inner door swung open, and out came two pairs of red lanterns and a hand-carried censer trailing thick wreaths of fragrant smoke, with girdle-pendants tinkling softly. The woman led her three daughters into the hall, calling Zhenzhen, Aiai, and Lianlian to come bow before these scripture-seekers. The girls stood ranged across the hall and made their reverence toward the upper seats. Truly they were exquisitely fair; see them:

Each with moth-brows arched in kingfisher-green,
Powdered faces breathing spring. Bewitching, of
nation-toppling beauty; Lithe and graceful, stirring
the heart. Their flowered head-ornaments showed a
wealth of charm; Their embroidered sashes
fluttered, far above the dust. Half-smiling, their lips
were cherries newly split; As they stepped slowly,
orchid-and-musk came wafting. Their heads were
heaped with pearls and kingfisher-jade, Trembling
beneath countless precious hairpins; Their whole
bodies breathed a secret fragrance, Sweet and
delicate with fine threads of flowered gold. Why
speak of the loveliness of the Chu maidens, Or the
tender grace of Xi Shi? Truly they were the
immortal maidens of the Ninth Heaven come down
from above, The Chang'e of the moon stepping forth
from the Cold Palace.

Tripitaka pressed his palms together and bowed his head. The great Sage Sun made a show of taking no notice. Sha Monk turned his back and looked away. But look at that Zhu Bajie — his eyes never turned aside,

his lustful heart in turmoil, his lecherous boldness running riot. He simpered out soft words, murmuring low: "We are honored, fairy maidens, by your descending. Mother, please send the sisters away now." The three girls withdrew behind the screen, leaving behind a pair of gauze lanterns.

The woman said, "Will you four elders set your minds to it and let one of you be matched with my daughter?" Wujing said, "We have talked it over: let the one surnamed Zhu be taken in as son-in-law." Bajie said, "Brother, don't plant this on me — let's reckon it out fairly among everyone." Monkey said, "What is there left to reckon? You've already settled it all neatly at the back door, calling her 'Mother' ever so many times — what further reckoning is needed? The Master shall be the male in-law, this dame the female in-law, old Monkey will stand as guarantor, and Sha Monk as go-between. There's no need even to consult the almanac — today is a lucky day granted by Heaven's own grace. Come now, bow to the Master and go in to be the son-in-law."

Bajie said, "It won't do, it won't do — how could I bring myself to such a business?" Monkey said, "Idiot, don't put on airs. You called her 'Mother' goodness knows how many times, and now you say it won't do! Hurry and consent — bring us along to drink some wedding wine; that'd be a fine thing." With one hand he gripped Bajie and with the other took hold of the woman, saying, "Mother-in-law, take your son-in-law inside." And the idiot, his feet shuffling, made as if to go along.

The woman at once called for her servant-boys: "Wipe down the tables and chairs, set out the evening meal, and entertain the three in-laws. I'll take the son-in-law to his room." She ordered the cook to lay on a banquet, that they might celebrate the wedding properly come morning. The servant-boys received their orders. The three of them ate their meal,

hastily spread their bedding, and lodged for the night in the guest seats — but of that no more.

Now we tell of Bajie, who followed his mother-in-law deep into the interior, passing through layer upon layer of rooms past counting, stumbling and bumping along with every doorsill tripping his feet. The idiot said, "Mother, go a little slower — the way in here is strange to me; you'll have to lead me." The woman said, "These are all the storerooms, the treasuries, the milling-rooms, room after room; we haven't even reached the kitchen yet." Bajie said, "What a great household!" Stumbling and bumping, turning corners and rounding bends, they walked another good while before reaching the inner halls.

The woman said, "Son-in-law, your senior brother declared today a lucky day granted by Heaven's grace and bade you be taken in. But in such haste we've had no time to summon a diviner for the bowing-to-the-hall and the bed-strewing rites. Simply bow eight times to the upper seat." Bajie said, "Mother speaks rightly. Please take the seat of honor, and let me make a few bows — that'll do for the hall-bowing and for thanking the in-laws both at once, two things in one. Isn't that the tidy way?" His mother-in-law laughed. "Very well, very well — truly a thrifty, capable son-in-law! I'll sit; you bow."

Through the whole hall the silver candles blazed, and the idiot bowed toward the upper seat. His bows done, he said, "Mother, which of the sisters will you match with me?" His mother-in-law said, "There's just the trouble of it. If I match you with the eldest, I fear the second will be cross; if with the second, I fear the third will be cross; and if with the third, I fear the eldest will be cross in her turn — and so I cannot make up my mind." Bajie said, "Mother, if they're all afraid of quarreling, then give them all to me, and there'll be no noise and squabbling to upset the household." His mother-in-law said, "What a notion! Would you have

one man take all three of my daughters?" Bajie said, "Just hear how Mother talks! What man hasn't his three wives and four concubines? Even were there a few more, your son-in-law would graciously accept them all. In my younger years I mastered a certain art of long campaigning — I'll warrant I can attend to each one and keep her well pleased."

The woman said, "No, no. I have here a kerchief; put it over your head to cover your face, and try a 'Heaven-appointed marriage.' I'll have my daughters walk past before you; reach out your hands, and whichever one you catch hold of, that one shall be matched to you." The idiot did as she said, took the kerchief, and draped it over his head. There is a poem in proof:

The dull fool knows not the root of things; The
sword of lust wounds the body, and in the dark
wears him away. From of old men trust the rites of
the Duke of Zhou — And today the bridegroom
wears the veil upon his head.

Once the idiot had the kerchief settled in place, he said, "Mother, please have the sisters come out." His mother-in-law called, "Zhenzhen, Aiai, Lianlian — all of you come try the Heaven-appointed marriage, to be matched to your son-in-law." He heard girdle-pendants ringing clear and the drift of orchid-and-musk fragrance, as though fairy maidens were coming and going around him. In earnest the idiot stretched out his hands to grope for someone, lunging this way and that — to the left he caught nothing, to the right he caught nothing. Back and forth they

passed, ever so many figures in motion, yet never could he lay hold of even one. Groping eastward, he embraced a pillar-post; groping westward, he pawed a plank wall. Running both ways until his head spun, he could no longer keep his feet, but stumbled and tumbled without stop — lunging forward, he kicked the door-leaf; staggering back, he ran into the brick wall — until his snout was swollen and his forehead bruised blue, and at last he sat down upon the ground, panting and gasping. "Mother, your daughters are far too nimble and slippery — I can't lay hold of even one! What's to be done, what's to be done?"

The woman lifted the veil from him and said, "Son-in-law, it's not that my daughters are nimble and slippery — it's that they are all giving way to one another, and none will consent to take you." Bajie said, "Mother, since they won't take me, then you take me yourself." The woman said, "What a son-in-law! No sense of high or low — you'd have even your mother-in-law too! Now, these three daughters of mine are most clever of heart and hand; each has knotted a little brocade-bordered, pearl-sewn undershirt. If you can put one of them on, then the one who made it shall take you." Bajie said, "Good, good, good — bring all three out and let me put them on; if I can wear all three, then let all three take me." The woman went back into the room and brought out just one, handing it to Bajie. The idiot stripped off his black brocade-cloth cassock, took the shirt, and pulled it on his body. But before he could even fasten the belt — flop! — he pitched over and fell to the ground. For it had become several stout ropes, binding him fast and tight. The idiot was in pain past all enduring; and all those people were already nowhere to be seen.

Now we tell of Tripitaka, Monkey, and Sha Monk, who slept their sleep, and before they knew it the east grew white with dawn. They opened their eyes and lifted their heads to look about — where now was that grand mansion and high hall? There were no carved beams and painted

rafters either; they were all sleeping in a grove of pine and cypress. In a fright the Elder hastily called for Monkey. Sha Monk cried, "Brother, it's done for, it's done for — we've met with ghosts!" But the great Sage Sun, clear in his own mind, smiled faintly and said, "How do you mean?" The Elder said, "Look where we've been sleeping!" Monkey said, "It's a comfortable enough spot here beneath the pines. Only there's no telling where that idiot is, suffering for his sins." The Elder said, "Who is suffering?" Monkey laughed. "Yesterday that mother and her daughters — there's no knowing what Bodhisattvas they may have been — manifested themselves here to put us to the test. They must have departed in the dead of night; it's only poor Zhu Bajie who's been left behind to suffer for it."

When Tripitaka heard this he pressed his palms together in reverence. Then they noticed, hanging on an old cypress behind them, a slip of paper fluttering in the breeze. Sha Monk hurried to fetch it and brought it to the Master to read. It was an eight-line hymn:

The Old Mother of Mount Li had no thought of the mundane; The Bodhisattva of the Southern Sea invited her down the mountain. Samantabhadra and Mañjuśrī were guests as well — Transformed into fair women within the grove. The holy monk, being virtuous, kept himself free of the worldly; But Bajie, lacking meditation, had the common still in him. From this day on he must still his heart and mend his ways — For if he breeds sloth and slackness, the road ahead is hard.

The Elder, Monkey, and Sha Monk were chanting this hymn aloud when from deep in the grove there came a loud voice crying out: "Master! I'm bound to death — save me, save me! I'll never dare again!" Tripitaka said, "Wukong, is that Wuneng crying out?" Sha Monk said, "It is indeed." Monkey said, "Brother, pay him no mind — let's simply go on." Tripitaka said, "Though that idiot is dull and stubborn by nature, he is an honest, simple-hearted fellow withal, and has some strength in his back — he can carry the baggage. Remember the Bodhisattva's kindness in sending him to us, and let us go and rescue him; surely he will not dare such a thing again." So Sha Monk rolled up the bedding and put the loads in order, the great Sage Sun loosed the halter and led the horse, and together they guided the Tang Monk into the grove to look. Truly it is as the verse says:

In upright cultivation one must walk with care;
Sweep away love and desire, and of itself return to
truth.

In the end there is no knowing whether the idiot fared well or ill — so listen to the next chapter for the explanation.

Chapter 24: The Mountain of Ten Thousand Years and the Stone of Life- Prolonging

The three of them pushed through the woods and in among the trees, where they found the idiot Zhu Bajie trussed up against a trunk, crying out at the top of his voice, unable to bear his misery. Sun Wukong stepped forward, laughing.

"Well now, my fine son-in-law! It's late in the day and you still haven't risen to thank your bride — and you haven't gone to report your good fortune to the Master, either. Are you still hanging here putting on a show for the crowd? Bah! Where's your mother-in-law now? Where's your darling wife? What a splendid bridegroom you make, strung up and dangling and beaten black and blue."

When the idiot saw him coming with such mockery, he was so ashamed that he ground his teeth and swallowed his pain, not daring to cry out. Sha Monk, when he saw the sight, could not bear it. He set down the luggage, went up, untied the ropes, and brought him down. Bajie could

do nothing but kowtow and bow to them, for his shame was past enduring. There is a poem to the tune of "The River Moon" that bears witness:

Lust is the sword that wounds the body; covet it,
and disaster surely comes. A pretty girl of sixteen,
sweetly painted, is fiercer than a fiend in armor.

You have but one original treasure, and no small profit to add to
your purse. Guard your capital well and carefully; hold fast, and let
no wantonness loose.

Now Bajie gathered a pinch of earth, lit incense, and bowed up at the empty sky in worship.

"Do you know who those Bodhisattvas were?" Wukong asked.

"I'd fainted clean away, my head spinning and my eyes a blur," Bajie said.

"How was I to know which of them was which?"

Wukong handed him the little slip of paper. When Bajie saw it was a verse of judgment, he was more ashamed than ever.

Sha Monk laughed. "Second Brother has such virtues, it seems — virtue enough to move four Bodhisattvas to come and offer themselves in marriage."

"Brother, never bring it up again," said Bajie. "I'm no fit son of man. From this day on I'll never play the fool again. Even if I work my bones to splinters, I'll keep my shoulder to the load and follow the Master to the Western Heaven, and that's all."

"If that's how you talk, then it's well said," said Tripitaka.

So Wukong led the Master back up onto the high road. They had traveled a good long while when suddenly a high mountain barred the way. Tripitaka reined in his horse and stayed his whip.

"Disciples," he said, "there's a mountain ahead. We must go carefully — there may be demons and goblins stirring up trouble, looking to harm our band."

"With the three of us before your horse," said Wukong, "what is there to fear from any demon?" And so the elder pressed on with an easy heart.

There before them rose the mountain, and a fine mountain it was:

A high peak soaring to the limit, a great mass
towering grandly. Its roots join the veins of Kunlun;
its summit brushes the Milky Way. White cranes
come to roost in its junipers and cypresses; dark
apes hang at times from its vines and creepers. Sun
lights the clearing groves — layer on layer, a
thousand strands of red mist coil round; wind
springs in the shadowed gorges — floating, ten
thousand banners of bright cloud fly. Hidden birds
chatter wildly in the green bamboo; brocade
pheasants spar among the wildflowers. See the
Thousand-Year Peak, the Five-Blessings Peak, the
Lotus Peak, lofty and stern, casting their fine bright
rays; the Ten-Thousand-Year Stone, the Tiger-Fang
Stone, the Three-Heavens Stone, jutting and
glittering, breathing forth auspicious vapor. Before
the cliffs the grasses are lovely; on the ridges the
plum blossoms are sweet. The thornbushes grow
dense and dark; the orchids and irises are pure and
pale. In the deep woods hawks and phoenixes

gather a thousand fowl; in the ancient grottoes the qilin governs ten thousand beasts. The stream-water has feeling — winding and curving, it lingers and looks back; the ranges are unbroken — ridge upon ridge, they circle round of themselves. See too the green locust, the spotted bamboo, the blue-black pine, swaying for a thousand years, vying in lush splendor; the white plum, the red peach, the emerald willow, blazing through three months of spring, contending in loveliness. Dragons hum and tigers roar; cranes dance and apes cry. The river-deer step forth from the flowers; the blue simurgh calls to the sun. Truly this is an immortal mountain, a land of real blessing — Penglai and Langyuan themselves are no more than this. See too how the flowers open and fall on the hilltops, how the clouds go and come on the ridges and peaks.

Tripitaka, sitting his horse, rejoiced. "Disciple, ever since I started west I've passed through many a mountain and river, all of them craggy and steep and dangerous — but none so fair as this. Its quiet charm is truly out of the ordinary. If we are near the road to Thunderclap and it isn't far,

then we'd best make ourselves solemn and dignified to meet the World-Honored One."

Wukong laughed. "Too early, too early! It's nowhere near."

"Elder Brother," said Sha Monk, "how far is it to Thunderclap from here?"

"A hundred and eight thousand miles," said Wukong, "and of the ten stages, we haven't even finished one."

"Brother," said Bajie, "how many years' walking before we get there?"

"As for the two of you worthy brothers," said Wukong, "you might do it in ten days or so. As for my going, I could make the trip fifty times in a single day and still see daylight. But as for the Master's walking — don't even think it, don't even think it."

"Wukong," said the Tang Monk, "when do you say we'll arrive?"

"You could walk from childhood to old age," said Wukong, "and from old age back to childhood, and round again a thousand times over, and still find it hard. But if you keep your true nature clear and your will sincere, then the moment you turn your thoughts back upon yourself — that very place is the Spirit Mountain."

"Elder Brother," said Sha Monk, "this may not be Thunderclap, but to look at such scenery, surely some good person dwells here."

"Well said," replied Wukong. "There's certainly no evil thing here. This must be the home of some holy monk or company of immortals. Let us stroll along slowly and enjoy ourselves." But of that, no more.

Now this mountain was called the Mountain of Ten Thousand Years. On it stood an abbey called the Five Estates Abbey, and in the abbey lived an Immortal whose Daoist title was Zhen Yuanzi — the Lord of the Origin

— and whose common name was the Lord Coeval with the World. From that abbey there came a rare treasure unlike any other: born at the very dividing of primal chaos, the first parting of the murky void, before Heaven and Earth had opened — a divine root that took shape in that age. Of the four great continents under Heaven, only the Five Estates Abbey of the Western Continent of Cattle-Gift produced it. It was called the Grass-Returning Elixir, and also the Ginseng Fruit. Once in three thousand years it flowered; once in three thousand years it set fruit; and only after another three thousand years did it ripen — so that, all told, a single fruit took ten thousand years before it could be eaten. And in all those ten thousand years the tree set only thirty fruits. Each fruit was shaped exactly like a newborn child not yet three days old, with all four limbs complete and all five features in place. If a person had the right karmic fortune and merely smelled one of these fruits, he would live three hundred and sixty years; if he ate one, he would live forty-seven thousand years.

That very day the Great Immortal Zhen Yuan had received a written summons from the Celestial Worthy of the Primordial Beginning, inviting him to the Maitreya Palace in the Highest Pure Heaven to hear a discourse on "The Fruit of the Way of Primal Unity." The wandering immortals who had come forth from this Immortal's school were beyond counting, and even now he had forty-eight disciples, all of them perfected adepts who had attained the Way. On that day he took forty-six of them up to the higher realms to hear the lecture, leaving behind only the two youngest to mind the house: one called Pure Breeze and the other Bright Moon. Pure Breeze was but one thousand three hundred and twenty years old, and Bright Moon had only just turned one thousand two hundred. Zhen Yuanzi instructed the two boys:

"I must not disobey the Great Celestial Worthy's summons; I am off to the Maitreya Palace to hear the discourse. The two of you mind the house carefully. Before many days an old friend of mine will pass this way — do not slight him. You may knock down two of my ginseng fruits and give them to him to eat, as a small token of our old affection."

"Who is our master's old friend?" the two boys asked. "Tell us, if you please, so that we may receive him properly."

"He is the holy monk in the service of the Great Tang court in the Land of the East," said the Immortal. "His Daoist title is Tripitaka — a monk now journeying to the Western Heaven to worship the Buddha and seek the scriptures."

The two boys laughed. "Confucius said: 'Those whose ways differ make no plans together.' We are of the Mystic Gate of Supreme Unity — what acquaintance should we have with such a monk?"

"You don't understand," said the Immortal. "That monk is the reincarnation of the Golden Cicada, the second disciple of the holy ancient one of the West, the Tathagata Buddha. Five hundred years ago I made his acquaintance at the Ullambana Assembly, where he served me tea with his own hands. As a son of the Buddha he showed me honor — and so he is my old friend."

When the two immortal boys heard this, they obeyed their master's command. As the Immortal was about to depart, he charged them once more: "My fruits are limited in number — give him only two, and waste no more."

"When the orchard was opened," said Pure Breeze, "the assembly together ate two, and there are still twenty-eight on the tree. We dare not waste any."

"Though the Tang Tripitaka is an old friend," said the Immortal, "you must guard against any mischief from his followers. Don't let them get wind of it." The two boys received their orders, and the Great Immortal, attended by his throng of disciples, soared aloft and went straight up to the celestial realm.

Now the Tang Monk and his three disciples were rambling about the mountain when, lifting their heads, they saw a cluster of pines and bamboo and several tiers of towers and halls.

"Wukong," said the Tang Monk, "look — what sort of place is that yonder?"

Wukong looked. "That place is no temple — it must be a Daoist abbey. Let's go on a bit; when we reach it we'll know the truth of it."

Before long they came to the gate and looked, and they saw:

A pine-clad slope, cool and aloof; a bamboo path,
pure and secluded. Coming and going, white cranes
usher the drifting clouds; up and down, gibbons at
times present their fruit. Before the gate the pool is
broad, the tree-shadows long; the rocks have split,
and moss-flowers break through. The palace halls
are arrayed lofty as the Purple Pole; the towers and
terraces float dim, where rosy vapors fall. Truly a
land of blessing, a numinous region — Penglai's
own cloud-grotto. Pure and empty, with little of
human affairs; still and silent, where the heart of
the Way is born. Blue birds ever bear the Queen
Mother's letters; purple simurghs forever carry Lord
Lao's scriptures. Endless the lofty wind of the Way
and its Virtue; truly the hushed dwelling of the
immortals.

Tripitaka dismounted from his saddle, and saw to the left of the
mountain gate a stone tablet bearing ten great characters: "The Mountain
of Ten Thousand Years, a Land of Blessing — The Five Estates Abbey, a
Grotto-Heaven."

"Disciples," said the elder, "this is indeed a Daoist abbey."

"Master," said Sha Monk, "to see such bright and lovely scenery, there must be good folk living within. Let us go in and look. And should we ever return east with our task fulfilled, this too would make a fine sight to remember."

"Well said," replied Wukong. So they all went in together, and over the inner gate they saw a couplet written for spring:

"The dwelling of immortals, eternal life that does
not age; the home of Daoists, long-lived as Heaven
itself."

Wukong laughed. "These Daoists talk big to frighten people. When I, old Sun, made my great uproar in Heaven five hundred years ago, even at the very door of Lord Lao the Most High I never saw such a boast as this."

"Never mind him," said Bajie. "Go in, go in. Perhaps this Daoist has some real virtue — who can say?"

When they came within the second gate, two young boys came bustling out in a hurry to meet them. See how they were dressed:

Bones pure and spirit fresh, with features fair, their hair bound up in tufted knots, the short locks tousled. Their Daoist robes, of themselves, wreath the collar in mist; their feather garments, alone, set the sleeves afloat in wind. A ringed sash binds them tight in a dragon's-head knot; straw sandals are lightly wound with silkworm-throat down. Their bearing unusual, no common breed — these are the two immortal boys, Pure Breeze and Bright Moon.

The boys made their bows, arching their backs and bending low, and came out to welcome the travelers. "Venerable Master, forgive us for failing to greet you sooner. Pray be seated."

The elder rejoiced, and went with the two boys up into the main hall to look about. It was a great hall of five bays facing south, all fitted with carved lattice screens, bright above and dim below. The immortal boys pushed open the screens and invited the Tang Monk into the hall. There he saw, hanging in the middle of the wall, two great characters worked in five colors: "Heaven and Earth." Beneath them stood a vermilion-lacquered, carved incense table, and on the table a golden censer and vase, with neat sticks of incense laid ready beside the censer.

Tripitaka stepped forward, took up a pinch of incense with his left hand and placed it in the censer, and bowed three times in worship. When he had finished, he turned and said, "Immortal boys, your Five Estates

Abbey is truly a fairyland of the West. Why do you not make offerings to the Three Pure Ones, the Four Emperors, and all the ministers of the heavens — why do you tend the incense fire only to these two words, 'Heaven and Earth'?"

The boys laughed. "To tell you the truth, Venerable Master — of these two words, the one above is rightly worthy of our reverence; but the one below is not even fit to receive our incense. That one is something our master put up out of flattery."

"What flattery?" asked Tripitaka.

"The Three Pure Ones are our master's friends," said the boys; "the Four Emperors are his old acquaintances; the Nine Luminaries are his juniors; and the Year-Stars are his humble guests."

When Wukong heard this, he laughed until he doubled over.

"Brother," said Bajie, "what are you laughing at?"

"Everyone says old Sun knows how to play tricks," said Wukong. "It turns out this little Daoist boy knows how to bundle up the wind."

"Where is your master?" asked Tripitaka.

"The Celestial Worthy of the Primordial Beginning sent down a summons," said the boys, "and called him to the Maitreya Palace in the Highest Pure Heaven to hear a discourse on 'The Fruit of the Way of Primal Unity.' He is not at home."

When Wukong heard this, he could hold back no longer, and shouted: "You stinking little Daoist whelps! You don't even know whom you're talking to. Whose face are you playing your tricks before, putting up such a hollow front? Who in that Maitreya Palace is a heaven-immortal of the

Supreme Unity, that they'd invite a pair of muddy ox-hooves like your master to go and lecture about anything?"

Seeing him fly into a rage, Tripitaka feared the boys would talk back and start a quarrel that would breed trouble, so he said: "Wukong, let's have no contention. Since we've come in, we'll go out again presently, and there'd be no sense in it. As the saying goes, 'An egret won't eat egret's flesh.' Their master isn't home — why throw the place into an uproar? You go out to the gate and tend the horse; Sha Monk, keep watch over the luggage; and Bajie, untie the bundle, take out some rice, borrow their pots and stove, and cook us a meal. When we leave, we'll give them a few coppers for firewood, and that will be that. Each to his own task — and let me rest a while here until we've eaten, and then we'll be off." So the three of them each went off to his appointed duty.

Now Bright Moon and Pure Breeze privately praised the monk to no end, saying: "What a fine monk! Truly a Western lover of holiness come down to the mortal world, his true source undimmed. Our master charged us to receive the Tang Monk and give him the ginseng fruit to eat, in token of old friendship — and also to guard against mischief from his followers. Sure enough, those three have fierce, savage faces and coarse tempers. Lucky for us he's sent them off; for if they'd stayed about, the ginseng fruit would never have come face to face with them at all."

"Brother," said Pure Breeze, "we still don't know whether this monk really is our master's old friend. Let's ask him first, lest we make a mistake."

So the two boys came forward again. "May we ask whether the Venerable Master is the Tang Tripitaka, bound from the Great Tang to the Western Heaven for the scriptures?"

The elder returned the courtesy. "I am that humble monk. How do you immortal boys come to know my unworthy name?"

"When our master was setting out," said the boys, "he charged us to go far to meet you. But his carriage came in haste, and so we failed in our welcome. Please be seated, Venerable Master, and let us fetch some tea to offer you."

"I dare not trouble you," said Tripitaka. Then Bright Moon hurried off to his room, brought back a cup of fragrant tea, and offered it to the elder. When the tea was finished, Pure Breeze said: "Brother, we mustn't disobey our master's command. You and I shall go and fetch the fruit."

The two boys took their leave of Tripitaka and went together to their room. One took up a golden mallet, the other a cinnabar tray, and they laid more green cloths to cushion the bottom of the tray. Then they went straight to the ginseng orchard. Pure Breeze climbed up into the tree and struck the fruit with the golden mallet, while Bright Moon waited below, holding up the cinnabar tray to catch it. In a moment two fruits were knocked down and caught in the tray, and the boys carried them straight to the front hall to present.

"Master of Tang," they said, "our Five Estates Abbey lies in a remote corner amid barren hills, and we have nothing worth offering. Here are two humble fruits of the soil — simple country fare, to ease your thirst."

When the elder saw them, he trembled all over and shrank back three feet. "Mercy! Mercy! This very year has seen good harvests and ripe seasons — how can this abbey suffer such famine as to eat people? These are infants not yet three days old. How are they to ease my thirst?"

Pure Breeze said to himself: "This monk has spent his days in the marketplace of tongues, in the sea of right and wrong, until he's grown a fleshly, mortal eye and can't recognize the rare treasure of us immortals."

Bright Moon stepped forward. "Venerable Master, this thing is called the ginseng fruit. There is no harm in eating one."

"Nonsense, nonsense!" said Tripitaka. "Their parents bore them in the womb through untold suffering before they were born. Not three days old, and you'd snatch them up to serve as fruit?"

"It really did grow on a tree," said Pure Breeze.

"Wild talk, wild talk!" said the elder. "How could a tree grow human beings? Take them away — they are no fit thing for a son of man."

When the two boys saw that, push and urge as they might, he would not eat, they had no choice but to take up the tray and go back to their own room. Now the fruits had a strange property: they could not be kept long. Left aside too long, they turned hard and were no good to eat. So the two of them went to their room and, one fruit to each, sat down on the edge of the bed and ate with relish.

Aha — but here is the thing of it! Their Daoist room and the kitchen shared a thin party wall, hard up against each other, so that a soft word spoken on one side was heard at once on the other. Bajie was just then cooking in the kitchen. From the first he had heard the talk of the golden mallet and the cinnabar tray, and had marked it carefully in his heart. Then he heard them say that the Tang Monk hadn't recognized the ginseng fruit, and that they had carried it off to their room to eat themselves. He couldn't keep the saliva from running out of his mouth. How could he get one to taste? But his body was too clumsy and lumbering to manage it alone, so he waited for Wukong to return and scheme it out with him. He had no heart left for tending the fire at the stove-mouth; he kept poking his head out, craning and peering, slipping away to look.

Before long he spotted Wukong leading the horse up. Wukong tied it to a locust tree and was heading straight for the back. The idiot waved his hand wildly: "This way, this way!" Wukong turned and came to the kitchen door. "Idiot, what are you bawling about? I suppose there isn't enough rice — well, let the old monk eat his fill, and we'll beg some more at the next great house up ahead."

"Come in," said Bajie. "It's not that the rice is short. This abbey has a certain treasure — do you know about it?"

"What treasure?" asked Wukong.

Bajie laughed. "Tell you of it, and you'll never have seen it; hand it to you, and you won't even know what it is."

"This idiot's making sport of old Sun," said Wukong. "Five hundred years ago, when I went seeking the Way of the immortals, I roamed to the ends of the sea and the rim of Heaven. What is there I haven't seen?"

"Brother," said Bajie, "have you ever seen the ginseng fruit?"

Wukong started. "That, truly, I've never seen. But I've often heard people say the ginseng fruit is the Grass-Returning Elixir, and that whoever eats it can greatly prolong his life. Where is there any to be had?"

"They have it here," said Bajie. "The boys brought two of them for the Master to eat, but the old monk didn't recognize them — said they were infants not three days old and didn't dare touch them. Those boys are good-for-nothings: since the Master wouldn't eat, they ought to have offered them to us, but instead they kept them from us, and just now in the next room they sat there, one apiece, gobble-gobble, and ate them all up. It set the water fairly flooding in my mouth. How can I get one to taste? I was thinking — you're a nimble fellow. Go into their orchard and steal a few for us to try. How about it?"

"That's easy," said Wukong. "Old Sun will go — I'll have them the moment I reach out." He turned at once to go, but Bajie caught hold of him: "Brother, I heard them say in that room they'd use some golden mallet to knock them down. You've got to manage it properly — don't let the wind get out."

"I know, I know," said Wukong.

The Great Sage worked a spell of invisibility and slipped into the Daoist room to look. But the two boys, having eaten their fruits, had gone up to the hall to talk with the Tang Monk and were not in the room. Wukong looked all about for the golden mallet and saw, hanging on the window lattice, a length of red gold about two feet long and as thick as a finger, with a head at the bottom shaped like a clove of garlic and an eye at the top through which was threaded a cord of green silk. "This must surely be the thing they call the golden mallet," he said. So he took it down, left the Daoist room, and went straight to the back. He pushed open a pair of doors, lifted his head and looked — ah! It was a flower garden! He saw:

Vermilion railings and jeweled balustrades, winding
stone paths and miniature peaks. Rare flowers vie in
beauty with the bright sun; emerald bamboo
contends in green against the blue sky. Beyond the
floating-cup pavilion, a bend of green willows trails
like smoke; before the moon-viewing terrace,
clusters of tall pines stand splashed with indigo.
Red and fiery, the pomegranate in its brocade nest;
green and tender, the embroidered cushion of grass;
blue and downy, the sand-orchids of jade-green;
rippling and gentle, the water beside the brook.
Cinnamon shades the parasol-trees by the golden
well; brocade locust-trees lean by vermilion rails
and jade-stone steps. Here are peach blossoms, red
and white, of a thousand petals; here are autumn
chrysanthemums, fragrant and yellow, of the ninth
month. The rose-trellis sets off the peony pavilion;
the hibiscus terrace adjoins the herbaceous-peony
plot. Endless to view: the gentleman-bamboo that
braves the frost, the high-official pine that defies the

snow. And more — crane-farms and deer-folds, square ponds and round pools; springs that flow like scattered jade, earth-blossoms heaped like gold. The north wind makes the plum-flowers burst forth white; spring's coming dabs the crabapple red. Truly the foremost fairy scene of the human world, the chief flowering grove of the West.

Wukong gazed his fill and then saw another tier of doors. He pushed them open and looked — it was a vegetable garden:

Planted with the vegetables of the four seasons: spinach, celery, beet, and gingershoots; bamboo-shoots, melons, gourds, and water-bamboo; scallions, garlic, coriander, leek, and chive. Lotus-root, crown-daisy, and bitter herbs; bottle-gourd and eggplant must be set in; turnip and radish buried like ram's-heads, red amaranth, green cabbage, and purple mustard.

Wukong laughed. "So he's a Daoist who grows his own and eats his own, too."

Passing the vegetable garden, he saw yet another tier of doors. He pushed them open and looked — ah! There in the very center stood a great tree, with green and fragrant boughs and shadowy emerald leaves shaped like a plantain's. It rose straight up over a thousand feet high, and its trunk was some seven or eight fathoms around. Wukong leaned against the foot of the tree and looked up, and there on a branch facing south hung a single ginseng fruit, exactly like a child. A stem held it at its base, and as it dangled at the branch-tip, its hands and feet were moving, its head nodding and bobbing, and when the wind passed it seemed almost to make a sound. Wukong was overjoyed and praised it quietly: "What a fine thing! Truly rare, truly rare!"

He pressed against the tree, went *whoosh*, and shot up into it — for this monkey had, first and foremost, a gift for climbing trees and stealing fruit. He gave the golden mallet a single tap, and the fruit dropped with a *plop*. He leapt down after it to look — but it was nowhere, utterly gone. He searched all about in the grass, and there was not the faintest trace.

"Strange, strange," said Wukong. "I suppose it has feet and can walk — but even if it ran, it couldn't have jumped over the wall. I know how it is: the local earth-god of this garden won't let old Sun steal his fruit, so he's spirited it away." With that he made the magic sign, recited the sacred word "Om," and compelled the garden's earth-god to appear before him. The earth-god made his bow.

"The Great Sage has summoned this humble spirit — what are your commands?"

"You don't know it," said Wukong, "but old Sun is the most famous chief of thieves under all of Heaven. In years past I stole the Immortal Peaches, filched the imperial wine, and made off with the elixir of the gods, and no one ever dared take a share with me. How is it that today I steal a

single fruit of theirs, and you go and snatch away my portion? This fruit grew on a tree — even the birds that fly past in the air ought to have a share of it. If old Sun eats just one of them, what great harm is there? Yet the instant I knocked it down, you scooped it up and away."

"Great Sage, you wrong this humble spirit," said the earth-god. "This treasure is the possession of an earth-immortal; I am only a ghost-immortal — how would I dare take it? Why, I haven't even the good fortune to give it so much as a sniff."

"If you didn't take it," said Wukong, "then how did it vanish the moment it fell?"

"Great Sage, you know only that this treasure prolongs life," said the earth-god. "You do not know its origins."

"What origins has it?" asked Wukong.

"This treasure flowers once in three thousand years," said the earth-god, "sets fruit once in three thousand years, and ripens only after another three thousand years. All told, in ten thousand years it bears but thirty fruits. Whoever has the karma to smell one will live three hundred and sixty years; whoever eats one will live forty-seven thousand years. But it fears the Five Elements, each in its own way."

"How does it fear the Five Elements?" asked Wukong.

"This fruit falls when it meets metal," said the earth-god; "it withers when it meets wood; it dissolves when it meets water; it scorches when it meets fire; and it sinks into the ground when it meets earth. To knock it down you must use a metal implement — only then will it come free. And when it has come down, you must cushion the tray with silk cloth. If it suffers any contact with wood, it withers, and even if eaten it will not prolong life. To eat it you must use a porcelain vessel, dissolving it in

clear water before you take it. Meet fire, and it scorches and is good for nothing. As for meeting earth and sinking in — Great Sage, the moment you knocked it to the ground just now, it bored its way down into the soil. This soil is forty-seven thousand years old; even a steel drill couldn't pierce the least bit into it, for it is three or four parts harder than wrought iron. That is why those who eat the fruit gain such long life. If the Great Sage doesn't believe it, try striking the ground here and see."

Wukong at once drew out his gold-banded cudgel and struck a single blow. There was a clang, the cudgel bounced back up, and on the earth there was not the slightest mark.

"True enough, true enough," said Wukong. "This rod of mine smashes stone to powder and dents even wrought iron — how is it that one blow left not so much as a scratch? In that case I have wronged you. Go on back."

The earth-god returned to his shrine.

Now the Great Sage had a plan. He climbed back up the tree, working the mallet with one hand while with the other he caught up the front hem of his brocade gown to make a pouch and held it ready. Then he threaded through the branches, parting the leaves, knocked down three fruits, and caught them in the fold of his gown. Down from the tree he jumped and went straight along to the kitchen.

Bajie laughed. "Brother, do you have any?"

"What do you call these?" said Wukong. "Old Sun had them the moment he reached out. We mustn't keep these from Sha Monk either — give him a call."

Bajie at once beckoned and called: "Wujing, come here." Sha Monk set down the luggage, ran into the kitchen, and said, "Brother, why do you

call me?" Wukong opened the fold of his gown. "Brother, look — what are these?"

When Sha Monk saw them he said, "They're ginseng fruits."

"Good for you!" said Wukong. "So you recognize them. Where have you eaten one before?"

"Little brother has never eaten one," said Sha Monk, "but in the old days, when I was Curtain-Lifting Marshal escorting the phoenix-carriage to the Peach Banquet, I often saw the various immortals from beyond the sea offer this fruit to the Queen Mother to wish her long life. See it I have, but eaten it I never have. Brother, may I have a bit to taste?"

"No need to say more — one apiece for us brothers," said Wukong.

So the three of them each enjoyed a fruit. Now Bajie had a deep belly and a wide mouth; and besides, having heard the boys eating earlier, he'd felt the gluttony-worm stirring inside him. So the moment he laid eyes on the fruit, he snatched it up, opened wide, and *gulp* — swallowed it whole down his gullet. Then, rolling his eyes shamelessly, he turned to Wukong and Sha Monk: "What were you two eating?"

"The ginseng fruit," said Sha Monk.

"What does it taste like?" asked Bajie.

"Wujing, pay him no mind," said Wukong. "You ate yours first — and now you come asking us?"

"Brother," said Bajie, "I ate it too fast — not like you two, chewing slow and swallowing slow, getting a proper taste of it. I don't even know whether it had a pit or not; I just bolted it down. Brother — for friendship's sake, see a thing through. You've stirred up my gluttony-

worm now — go get me another one, so old Hog can eat it nice and slow."

"Brother," said Wukong, "you don't know when to stop. This thing isn't like rice or noodles, where you can eat your fill once you come by it. In ten thousand years the tree sets only thirty fruits — for us to eat even three of them is a great stroke of karmic fortune; it's no trifling thing. Enough — that's plenty." He rose, and through the window hole he tossed the golden mallet back into the Daoist room, and paid the matter no more heed.

But the idiot kept up his muttering and grumbling. Just then the two Daoist boys came back into their room to fetch tea for serving — and they heard Bajie still grouching: "I didn't get to enjoy that ginseng fruit. It'd be grand to have one more to eat."

When Pure Breeze heard it, he grew suspicious. "Bright Moon, listen — that long-snouted monk is saying he wants 'one more ginseng fruit to eat.' When our master took his leave, he charged us to guard against mischief from these followers. Could it be they've stolen our treasure?"

Bright Moon turned his head. "Brother, this is bad, this is bad! How did the golden mallet come to be lying on the ground? Let's go and look in the orchard."

The two of them hurried off and found the flower garden standing open. "I shut this gate myself," said Pure Breeze. "How is it open?" They hurried on through the flower garden and found the vegetable-garden gate open as well. They rushed into the ginseng orchard, leaned at the foot of the tree, looked up, and counted; back and forth they counted, every which way, and made it only twenty-two.

"Can you do sums?" asked Bright Moon.

"I can," said Pure Breeze. "Tell me the figures."

"There were thirty fruits to begin with," said Bright Moon. "When our master opened the orchard, two were shared and eaten, leaving twenty-eight. Just now we knocked down two for the Tang Monk to eat, leaving twenty-six. And now only twenty-two remain — so aren't we short four? No question about it — that pack of villains has stolen them. We'll go and curse the Tang Monk for it."

The two of them came out of the orchard gate and went straight to the hall, where they pointed at the Tang Monk and railed at him without ceasing — "baldpate" before and "baldpate" behind, a stream of foul and filthy language; thief-faced, rat-brained, stinking this and rancid that, cursing away in a vicious temper. The Tang Monk could not endure it. "Immortal boys, what is all this clamor? Calm yourselves a little. If you've something to say, say it slowly — there's no harm in that — but don't go ranting wild nonsense."

"Are you deaf?" said Pure Breeze. "Or do I talk gibberish you can't understand? You've stolen and eaten our ginseng fruits — how dare you forbid me to speak of it?"

"What does this ginseng fruit look like?" asked the Tang Monk.

"It's the very thing we brought just now for you to eat," said Bright Moon, "the one you said looked like a child."

"Amitabha!" said the Tang Monk. "The moment I laid eyes on that thing, my heart shook and my gall trembled — how would I dare steal it and eat it? Even if I'd been seized with a craving, I'd never stoop to such thievery. Don't go wronging people unjustly."

"Though you didn't eat it yourself," said Pure Breeze, "you've followers who'd be glad to steal and eat for you."

"In that case, what you say has some sense," said Tripitaka. "Stop your shouting awhile and let me question them. If they truly stole it, I'll make them make it good to you."

"Make it good!" said Bright Moon. "Where would you buy more, even if you had the money?"

"Even if there's money and nowhere to buy it," said Tripitaka, "the old saying goes, 'Benevolence and righteousness are worth a thousand pieces of gold.' Have them offer you an apology, and let that be the end of it. And besides, we still don't even know whether it was them or not."

"How could it not be them?" said Bright Moon. "They're in there quarreling over the unfair shares this very moment!"

Tripitaka called out: "Disciples, all of you come here."

Sha Monk heard it and said: "This is bad — the game's up. The old Master is calling us, and the little Daoist boys are cursing away — if the old business hasn't gotten out, then what is it?"

"What an utter disgrace," said Wukong. "But this is no more than a matter of food and drink. If we confess it, we stand convicted as sneak-thieves of mouthfuls — best just deny it."

"Just so, just so," said Bajie. "Brazen it out."

So the three of them had no choice but to leave the kitchen and go up into the hall.

In the end there is no knowing how they were to brazen it out before the boys — so listen to the explanation in the next installment.

Chapter 25: The Immortal Zhenyuan Pursues the Pilgrims, and the Ginseng Tree

Now the three disciple-brothers came up to the hall and said to their master, "The rice is nearly done. Why have you called for us?"

Tripitaka said, "Disciples, it is not the rice I am asking about. This abbey, it seems, possesses certain ginseng fruit — things shaped like little children. Which of you stole some and ate them?"

"I'm an honest fellow," said Pigsy. "I know nothing of it. I never saw a thing."

"The one who's grinning — that's the one!" cried Clear Wind. "The grinning one, that's him!"

"This old Sun was born with this very grin on his face," Wukong shot back. "Just because you've lost some fruit, am I not even allowed to smile?"

"Disciple, calm your anger," said Tripitaka. "We are people who have left the household life. Do not speak falsehoods, and do not eat food that lies heavy on the conscience. If you truly ate their fruit, then offer them an apology — why deny it so stubbornly?"

Seeing the sense in his master's words, Wukong told the truth. "Master, it is no fault of mine. It was Pigsy who, on the far side of the wall, overheard those two Taoist boys eating some ginseng fruit, and he took a fancy to taste one for novelty's sake. He sent this old Sun to knock down three of them, and we brothers ate one apiece. Well, eaten is eaten — what would you have us do about it now?"

"You stole four of mine," said Bright Moon, "and still this monk says he's no thief!"

"Amitabha!" said Pigsy. "If you stole four, why bring out only three to share — pocketing one ahead of time on the sly?" The simpleton, babbling away, had given the whole game away.

Now that the two boys had wormed out the truth, their abuse grew fiercer than ever. The Great Sage ground his steel teeth till they rang and rolled his fiery eyes wide; again and again he gripped his golden-banded cudgel, again and again he held himself back. "These boys think it's enough to curse a man to his face," he thought. "Let them have their say. But I'll set them up a scheme with no afterward — I'll fix it so none of them ever eats a single one again."

Good Wukong! He plucked a single hair from the back of his head, blew on it a breath of immortal air, and called, "Change!" It became a counterfeit Wukong, who took his place beside Tripitaka, alongside Wuneng and Wujing, enduring the boys' tongue-lashing. Meanwhile his true self sent out his spirit, leapt up onto a somersault cloud, and flew straight to the ginseng garden. There he drew out his golden cudgel and — bang! — struck the tree a single blow. Then, summoning that divine strength which can push down mountains and shift entire ranges, he set his shoulder against the trunk and toppled it.

Pity the tree! Its leaves scattered, its branches sprang apart, its roots tore from the soil — and the Taoists' Grass-Returning Elixir was cut off at its source. Having pushed the tree over, the Great Sage searched the boughs for fruit, but not so much as half a one could he find. For this treasure, you must understand, falls at the touch of metal: both ends of his cudgel were sheathed in gold, and iron itself is counted among the five metals — so the moment he struck, down they dropped; and once they dropped,

they sank straight into the earth at its touch. That was why not one fruit remained upon the tree.

"Good, good, good!" he said. "Now everyone's fire is out." He put away his iron cudgel and went straight back to the front hall. There he shook the hair, drew it back into his body, and rejoined himself whole. The others, being only common mortals with flesh-and-blood eyes, never saw a thing.

Now the immortal boys had cursed and railed for a good long while, until Clear Wind said, "Bright Moon, these monks can certainly take a scolding. We've been cursing them like one scolds a chicken, going at it half the day, and they've never once made a fuss back. Most likely they never stole and ate them after all. Maybe the tree is tall and its leaves are thick, and we miscounted. Let's not curse them for nothing — come, let's go back and check again."

"That's well said," answered Bright Moon. So the two of them went once more into the garden — only to find the tree toppled, its branches splayed, the fruit gone and the leaves strewn on the ground. Terror struck Clear Wind till his legs went soft and he fell flat on his face; Bright Moon's waist gave way and his bones seemed to crumble beneath him. The two of them were frightened clean out of their souls. There is a poem to prove it:

Tripitaka came west to the Mountain of Ten
Thousand Years; Wukong cut off the Grass-
Returning Elixir there. The branches split, the
leaves fell, the immortal root lay bare — And Bright
Moon and Clear Wind grew cold in heart and gall.

The two of them lay sprawled in the dust, their words all jumbled, crying only, "What's to be done? What's to be done? He has ruined the elixir-root of our Five Villages Abbey, cut off the very seed-line of our immortal house! When our master comes home, how shall we two answer him?"

"Brother, don't carry on so," said Bright Moon at last. "Let us set our caps and robes in order and not alarm those few monks. There's no one else who could have done this — it must surely be that thunder-god-faced, hairy-cheeked wretch. He sent out his spirit and worked his magic and destroyed our treasure. If we have it out with him, the wretch is bound to deny it flatly and quarrel with us; and once the quarrel starts, it'll come to blows. Think now — how could we two ever match his four? Better we go and trick him a little. We'll simply say the fruit are all there, that we miscounted, and turn it around to apologize to him instead. Their rice is already done; when they sit down to eat, we'll serve them a few side dishes besides. Each of them will be holding a bowl — and you stand at the left of the door, I at the right, and slam the door shut, snap the lock to, and bolt every gate behind them. We'll not let them out, but wait for the master to come home and let him deal with them as he sees fit. The monk is also our master's old acquaintance: if our master pardons him, that's our master's grace to bestow; and if he does not

pardon him, why, we'll have caught the thief all the same — and so we may yet escape the blame for our own fault."

Hearing this, Clear Wind said, "Good reasoning, good reasoning."

The two of them forced up their spirits, mustered a false cheerfulness, and came straight from the back garden up to the hall. There they bowed low before Tripitaka, bending at the waist, and said, "Master, the words we spoke just now were coarse and gave great offense. Don't take it amiss, don't take it amiss."

"What do you mean?" asked Tripitaka.

"The fruit are all there," said Clear Wind. "It was only that the leaves grew high and thick, and we couldn't see clearly. We went just now to count again, and the number is as it always was."

At this Pigsy seized his footing to tease them: "You little boys, too young to know how things are done — you came scolding and railing, mouthing curses for nothing, slandering us falsely. That's no way for honest children to behave."

Wukong understood it all in his heart but said nothing aloud. To himself he thought: "Lies, all lies. The fruit are finished, the account is settled — how can they talk like this? They must have some method for bringing the dead back to life."

"If that's how it is," said Tripitaka, "then bring out the rice, and we'll eat and be on our way."

So Pigsy went to dish up the rice while Sandy set out the tables and chairs. The two boys hurried to fetch the side dishes — soy-pickled gourd, soy-pickled eggplant, lees-pickled radish, vinegared green beans, pickled water-chestnut sprouts, and parboiled mustard greens — setting

out seven or eight little plates in all for the master and disciples; and they brought out a pot of good tea besides, with two teacups, waiting in attendance on either side. The four of them had no sooner picked up their bowls than the boys, one to each side, slammed the door shut — bang! — and shot home a double-tongued brass lock.

Piggy laughed. "These boys have got it wrong. Bad customs you have around here — why lock the door while people are eating their dinner?"

"Quite so, quite so," said Bright Moon. "Eat your dinner first, good or ill, and then we'll open the door."

But Clear Wind cursed them roundly: "You gluttonous, food-stealing bald thieves! You stole and ate our immortal fruit — a crime of raiding another man's garden already — and then you pushed over our immortal tree, ruining the immortal root of our Five Villages Abbey! And still you want to talk back! If you ever reach the West and look upon the face of Buddha, it will only be after you've turned tail and ridden the wheel of rebirth all over again!"

Hearing this, Tripitaka let his rice bowl fall, and a great stone settled upon his heart. The boys went and locked up the front mountain-gate and the second gate, every one. Then they came back to the door of the main hall and railed on with vicious words, "thief" before and "thief" behind, cursing until the sky grew toward evening. Only then did they go to eat their own meal, and after eating retired to their rooms.

Tripitaka reproached Wukong: "You ape's head — time and again you crash into trouble. You stole and ate their fruit; you should have borne their few angry words and let them curse a bit, and that would have been the end of it. But why did you push over their tree besides? If we reason out the state of affairs, then should they lodge a complaint, even if your own father were the magistrate, the case still couldn't be argued out."

"Master, don't fret," said Wukong. "The boys have all gone to sleep. We'll just wait until they're sound asleep, and then we'll set out under cover of night."

"Brother," said Sandy, "all the gates are locked and shut up tight. How are we to get out?"

Wukong laughed. "Never mind, never mind. Old Sun has his own ways."

"As if anyone doubted you had a way," said Pigsy. "You can change into some bug or worm and fly out through the lattice-holes easily enough. But it's hard on us who can't transform — we'll be left here holding the pot and taking the blame."

"If he pulls a trick like that and doesn't take you and me out with him," said Tripitaka, "then I'll start reciting that old-words sutra, and how will he stomach that?"

Hearing this, Pigsy was both worried and amused. "Master, what are you talking about? I've only ever heard that the Buddhist canon has the Śūraṅgama Sutra, the Lotus Sutra, the Peacock Sutra, the Guanyin Sutra, and the Diamond Sutra. I never heard of any old-words sutra."

"Brother, you don't know," said Wukong. "This band I wear on my crown was bestowed on my master by the Bodhisattva Guanyin. My master tricked me into putting it on, and now it's as though it has taken root — there's no thinking of getting it off. It's called the Tight-Band Spell, also the Tight-Band Sutra. His 'old-words sutra' — that's just this. When he recites it, my head aches fit to split, and that's the trick he has to torment me with. Master, don't recite it. I'll surely not fail you — I'll see to it we all get out together."

By the time they had finished talking, the sky had gone fully dark, and without their noticing the moon had risen in the east. "Right now there's

not a sound in all the world," said Wukong, "and the icy wheel shines clear. This is just the moment to be off."

"Brother," said Pigsy, "no playing ghost-tricks now. The doors are all locked. Where are we to go?"

"Watch my hand," said Wukong. He took the golden cudgel in his grip, worked an Unlocking Spell, and pointed at the door — and at once there came a rending crash, the double tongues of every lock fell away, and with a clatter the leaves of the doors flew open.

Pigsy laughed. "What skill! Even if you called in a little tinker-smith with his picklock, it wouldn't be half so neat as this."

"What's so wonderful about these doors?" said Wukong. "Even the Southern Gate of Heaven — I'd only have to point, and it would open." Then he helped his master out the door and up onto the horse; Pigsy shouldered the luggage, Sandy led the horse, and they made straight along the western road.

"You all go on slowly," said Wukong. "Let old Sun go and see to it that those two boys sleep for a month."

"Disciple," said Tripitaka, "you must not harm their lives—or else you'll have another crime of robbery-with-injury upon you."

"I know," said Wukong. He went back in and came to the door of the room where the boys slept. At his waist he carried sleep-insects—won, as it happens, at the Eastern Gate of Heaven in a game of guess-fingers with the Heavenly King of Increase and Growth. He fished out two of them, flicked them in through the window-holes, and they flew straight onto the boys' faces. The two fell into a deep, snoring slumber with no hope of waking. Then Wukong stretched out his cloud-stride, caught up with Tripitaka, and they hurried straight on westward along the highway.

All that night the horse never stopped its hooves, and they traveled until the sky began to lighten. Said Tripitaka, "This ape's head will be the death of me—on account of your appetite you've dragged me through a whole sleepless night."

"Don't keep complaining," said Wukong. "The sky's light now. Rest a while in that wood by the roadside and nurse your spirit before we go on."

The elder had no choice but to dismount, and he leaned against a pine root, using it for a makeshift meditation seat. Sandy set down the load and dozed; Pigsy pillowed his head on a stone and fell asleep. But the Great Sage had a restless heart all his own—look at him there, leaping among the trees, pulling at the branches, larking about. We'll say no more of the four resting.

Now the Great Immortal had broken up the assembly at the Palace of the Primal Origin, and leading his band of lesser immortals he left the Tushita Heaven, came straight down through the jasper sky, sank his auspicious cloud, and arrived at last before the gate of Five Villages Abbey on the Mountain of Ten Thousand Years. Looking, he saw the abbey gate flung wide and the ground swept clean.

"Clear Wind and Bright Moon are useful boys after all," said the Great Immortal. "Ordinarily, with the sun three poles high, they wouldn't so much as straighten their backs; yet today, with us away, they've actually risen early to open the gate and sweep the ground." All the lesser immortals were pleased.

But when they came up to the hall, the incense was burned out, every human trace was still, and there was no sign of Bright Moon or Clear Wind anywhere. "These two have probably run off with our things while we were away," said the immortals.

"Such a thing is unthinkable!" said the Great Immortal. "Men who cultivate immortality—would they dare so base-hearted an act? Most likely they forgot to shut the gate last night, went off to sleep, and haven't yet woken this morning." The immortals went to the door of the boys' room to look, and indeed the door was shut and the two lay snoring deep. Pound on the door from outside however they would, shout however they would, they could not be roused. The immortals pried off the door-planks and laid hands on the boys to drag them from their beds, but still they would not wake.

The Great Immortal laughed. "Good immortal boys! Men who attain immortality, once their spirit is full, no longer think of sleep—how is it they're so drowsy? Surely someone has worked a trick on them. Quickly, bring water." A boy hurried to fetch half a cup and handed it to the Great Immortal. He recited a spell, took a mouthful of water, and sprayed it on their faces—and at once the sleep-demon was undone.

The two woke up. Suddenly they opened their eyes, rubbed their faces, lifted their heads, and looking about recognized their immortal master, the Lord Coeval-with-the-Age, and all their immortal brethren. In a fluster, Clear Wind knocked his head to the ground, and Bright Moon kowtowed, saying, "Master! Your old acquaintance, that monk who came from the east—he and his companions are a gang of bandits, savage in the extreme!"

The Great Immortal laughed. "Don't be frightened. Tell it to me slowly."

"Master," said Clear Wind, "not long after you took your leave that day, there came indeed a Tang monk from the eastern land, with four monks in his company and five mouths counting the horse. Your disciples dared not disobey your command; we asked the reason for their coming and took down two ginseng fruit to present to them. But that elder, with his

common eyes and dull heart, did not recognize the treasure of our immortal house. He said they were children not yet three days old and would not eat them however we pressed. So your disciples ate one apiece. We never expected that among his followers there were three disciples, and one of them, surnamed Sun, named Wukong the Pilgrim, had already stolen four fruit and eaten them. When your disciples reasoned the matter out with him and spoke a few plain words, he wouldn't have it, and secretly worked a spirit-sending trick. Oh, the bitterness of it!" And reaching this point in their tale, the two boys could not hold back their tears.

"Did the monk beat you?" asked the immortals.

"He didn't beat us," said Bright Moon. "He only knocked over our ginseng tree."

At this the Great Immortal showed no anger at all. "Don't cry, don't cry," he said. "You don't know it, but that one surnamed Sun is himself a Great Monad Scattered Immortal. He once wreaked havoc in the Halls of Heaven, and his divine powers are vast. Since he's knocked over the treasure-tree—would you know those monks again?"

"We'd know them all," said Clear Wind.

"If you'd know them," said the Great Immortal, "then come along with me. And the rest of you disciples, lay out the instruments of punishment and wait until I return to flog them." The immortals received the order.

The Great Immortal, with Bright Moon and Clear Wind, soared up on auspicious light to pursue Tripitaka, and in an instant they had covered a thousand li. From the edge of his cloud the Great Immortal gazed westward, but saw no sign of the Tang monk. Turning his head to look eastward, he found he had overshot by some nine hundred li and more.

For the elder, though his horse never stopped its hooves all night, had gone but a hundred and twenty li; while the Great Immortal's cloud, in one bound, had overshot by more than nine hundred.

"Master," said the immortal boys, "that's the Tang monk, sitting there beneath the tree by the road."

"I've seen him," said the Great Immortal. "You two go back and get the ropes ready; I'll take him myself." So Clear Wind and Bright Moon went on ahead—of which we'll say no more.

The Great Immortal lowered his cloud, shook himself, and changed into a wandering Perfected Man of the Quanzhen sect. And how was he got up?

He wore a hundred-patched robe and bound it with a Lü-gong cord; in his hand he shook a deer-tail whisk and lightly tapped a fisher-drum. Three-eared straw sandals graced his feet, a nine-yang kerchief swathed his head; the wind blew light and full in his sleeves, and from his lips he sang "The Moon Rides High."

He came straight to the foot of the tree and called out loudly to Tripitaka, "Elder, this poor Taoist salutes you." The elder hurriedly returned the courtesy: "Forgive me for not noticing you sooner, forgive me."

"Where does the elder come from," asked the Great Immortal, "and why do you sit in meditation here by the road?"

"This poor monk," said Tripitaka, "is sent from the Great Tang in the eastern land to fetch scriptures in the Western Heaven. Passing this way, I rest here a moment."

The Great Immortal feigned surprise. "Coming from the east, elder—have you by chance passed through these wild hills of mine?"

"I do not know," said the elder, "which treasure-mountain belongs to the immortal officer."

"Five Villages Abbey on the Mountain of Ten Thousand Years," said the Great Immortal, "is this poor Taoist's dwelling place."

Hearing this, Wukong—a man with something on his conscience—spoke up quickly: "No, no. We came up by another road."

The Great Immortal pointed at him and laughed. "You bandit-ape! Whom do you think to deceive? You went into my abbey and knocked over my ginseng-fruit tree, then fled through the night to this place—and still you won't confess! What are you covering up? Don't try to run. Go back at once and return my tree to me."

At these words Wukong's heart flared with rage. He whipped out his iron cudgel and, without a word of explanation, aimed a blow straight at the Great Immortal's head. The Great Immortal twisted his body aside, dodged it, trod his auspicious light, and rose straight into the air. Wukong too mounted his cloud and chased hotly after him. In mid-sky the Great Immortal revealed his true form. And look how he was got up!

On his head a purple-gold crown; a crane-feather cloak, untouched by care, upon his back. Slippers upon his feet; a silken sash bound round his waist. His body had the form of a child, his face the bloom of a beautiful woman. Three wisps of beard drifted beneath his chin; raven-plume locks lay folded at his temples. He met Wukong with no weapon at all—only a jade whisk twirled in his hand.

Wukong, with no high nor low to his blows, flailed wildly with his cudgel. The Great Immortal warded left and parried right with his jade whisk, and held him off through two or three rounds. Then he worked the trick called "Heaven and Earth Within the Sleeve": up in the clouds he let his robe-sleeve open lightly to the wind, and—swish!—swept forward and gathered all four monks and the horse together into a single sleeve.

"This is bad," said Piggy. "We're all stuffed into a sack."

"Simpleton," said Wukong, "it's no sack. We've been bottled up in his sleeve."

"That's no great matter," said Piggy. "Let me give it a few digs with my rake and bore a hole in it; we'll slip out the bottom and just say he was careless and didn't sack us up tight, so we tumbled out." The simpleton plied his rake and jabbed away, but he couldn't make it budge. Pinch the

stuff between your fingers and it felt soft enough, yet strike at it and it was harder than iron.

The Great Immortal turned his auspicious cloud and dropped straight down into Five Villages Abbey, where he took his seat and called for his disciples to bring rope. The lesser immortals attended one and all. And look—from out of his sleeve, just as one plucks out puppets, he drew forth the Tang monk and bound him to a pillar of the eaves before the main hall. Then he drew out the three others and tied one to each pillar. He took out the horse too and tethered it in the courtyard, giving it hay and fodder, and the baggage he tossed down under the corridor.

Then he said, "Disciples, these monks are men who have left the household life; we may not use sword or spear on them, nor lay axe or halberd to them. Just fetch me out the leather whip and give them a flogging—to vent my spleen for the ginseng fruit." The immortals quickly brought out a whip—not of cowhide, nor of sheepskin, nor of buckskin or calfskin, but a Seven-Stars whip made of dragon-hide, kept soaking in water. Bidding a strong lesser immortal take it in hand, the Great Immortal was asked, "Master, which one shall I flog first?"

"The Tang monk Tripitaka sets himself up as the elder and shows no respect," said the Great Immortal. "Flog him first."

Hearing this, Wukong thought in secret, "My old monk can't bear a beating. If a flogging should do him harm, isn't that a sin of my making?" He couldn't hold back, and spoke up: "Sir, you've got it wrong. It was I who stole the fruit, I who ate the fruit, and I too who pushed over the tree. Why not flog me first—what's the use of flogging him?"

The Great Immortal laughed. "This bandit-ape has a fierce tongue in his head. Very well then—flog him first."

"How many strokes?" asked the lesser immortal.

"Match it to the number of fruit," said the Great Immortal. "Give him thirty strokes."

The lesser immortal swung up the whip to strike. Fearing the great power of the immortals' arts, Wukong rolled his eyes wide and fixed his gaze to see where the blows would fall. Sure enough, they fell on his legs—so Wukong gave his waist a twist and called, "Change!" His legs became two legs of tempered iron, and he watched to see how the man would flog. Stroke by stroke the lesser immortal laid on thirty, and by then the morning had drawn toward noon.

The Great Immortal then ordered, "Tripitaka should also be flogged, for being lax in his teaching and letting his wild pupils run riot." So the immortal swung the whip again to strike. Said Wukong, "Sir, you're mistaken again. When the fruit was stolen, my master knew nothing of it—he was up in the hall talking with your two boys, and it was we brothers who did the deed. Even if there is a crime of lax teaching, then as the disciple I ought to take the flogging in his place. Flog me again."

"This bandit-ape," said the Great Immortal, "for all his slyness and crafty mischief, has a touch of filial feeling in him after all. Very well then—flog him instead." The lesser immortal laid on another thirty. Wukong bent his head and looked: his two legs were like bright mirrors, polished gleaming by the blows, and he felt no pain nor itch at all.

By now the sky was drawing toward evening. "Set the whip to soak in water," said the Great Immortal, "and we'll flog them again tomorrow morning." The lesser immortal put away the whip to soak it, and they all returned to their rooms. Their evening fast finished, they went to their rest—of which we'll say no more.

The elder, tears falling from both eyes, reproached his three disciples: "You've gone and brought down disaster, and dragged me here to suffer for it. How did all this come about?"

"Spare the reproaches," said Wukong. "If there's flogging, I'm flogged first; you took no beating at all, so why turn around and moan?"

"Even though I wasn't flogged," said Tripitaka, "my body still aches from being tied up like this."

"Master," said Sandy, "there are others tied up here to bear you company."

"None of you make a fuss," said Wukong. "Wait a bit longer and we'll be on the road again."

"There's my brother playing his tricks again," said Pigsy. "Here we are with hempen rope soaked in water, bound tight as tight can be—a far cry from being shut up in the hall, where you used your Unlocking Spell to spring the door and walk out."

"It's no idle boast," said Wukong, "but were it three-strand hempen rope soaked with water, or even a coir hawser thick as a bowl, it would be no more to me than the autumn wind."

While they were still talking, already there was not a sound in all the world—just the hour when the streets of heaven lie hushed and the people are still. Good Wukong! He made his body small—shrank it down—and slipped right out of his bonds. "Master, let's be off."

Sandy was alarmed. "Brother, save us too!"

"Quiet, quiet," said Wukong. He untied Tripitaka, then set loose Pigsy and Sandy, straightened his short cassock, saddled and loaded the horse, took up the baggage from beneath the corridor, and they all went out the

abbey gate together. Then he told Pigsy, "Go cut down four willow trees from along that cliff."

"What do you want them for?" asked Pigsy.

"There's a use for them—fetch them, quick." The simpleton had a bit of brute strength; off he went, and one snout to one tree, he rooted up four of them and brought them back in an armful. Wukong snapped off the branch-tips, sent the two brothers back inside, and had them bind the trees to the pillars with the original ropes, just as before. Then the Great Sage recited a spell, bit open the tip of his tongue, and sprayed the blood upon the trees, calling, "Change!" One became the elder, one became himself, and the other two became Sandy and Pigsy—all transformed alike in face and form, so that ask them anything and they would answer, call their names and they would respond.

Only then did the two brothers stretch out their stride and catch up with their master. That whole night, once again, the horse never stopped its hooves, and they put Five Villages Abbey far behind them.

By the time dawn came, the elder was nodding and swaying upon his horse like a mortise-peg. Seeing it, Wukong called out, "Master, this won't do. How can one who has left the household life be so worn out? Old Sun could go a thousand nights without sleep and not know the least bit of weariness. Come, dismount—don't let travelers on the road see you and laugh—and let's rest a while down at the foot of the hill, in some sheltered spot out of the wind, and then go on." So they paused.

We'll say no more of master and disciples halting on the road. Let us tell instead how the Great Immortal rose at daybreak, ate his morning fast, and came out to the hall, ordering, "Bring the whip. Today it's the Tang monk Tripitaka's turn to be flogged." The lesser immortal swung the whip and said to "Tripitaka," "It's you we're flogging." And the willow tree

answered, "Flog away." Bang, crash—thirty strokes laid on. Swinging the whip around, he said to "Piggy," "It's you we're flogging." And the willow tree answered too, "Flog away." When it came to flogging "Sandy," it likewise answered to be flogged. And when it came to flogging "Wukong"—at that moment the real Wukong, off on the road, suddenly gave a shiver and said, "This is bad!"

"What do you mean?" asked Tripitaka.

"I changed those four willow trees into us four, master and disciples," said Wukong. "I reckoned that since they flogged me twice yesterday, they'd not flog me again today—but now they're flogging my counterfeit body, and that's why my true self shivers. I'll undo the spell." And in a fluster Wukong recited the spell and withdrew his magic.

Now look at those Taoist boys—seized with terror, they flung down the leather whip and reported, "Master! The first one we flogged was the Tang monk, but this round we've been flogging nothing but willow roots!"

Hearing this, the Great Immortal laughed a cold "ha-ha" and could not stop praising him: "Sun the Pilgrim—truly a fine Monkey King! I had heard how he wreaked havoc in the Halls of Heaven, how they spread nets across the earth and snares across the sky and still could not catch him—and it's true after all. Well enough that you ran off—but how is it you bound some willow trees here to take your name and stand in your place? There'll be no pardoning him. After him!"

At the Great Immortal's word "after him," he soared up on his cloud and looked westward, and there were the monks, baggage shouldered and horse whipped on, traveling right along the road. The Great Immortal dropped down low and called out, "Sun the Pilgrim, where are you running? Give me back my ginseng tree!"

Pigsy heard it and said, "It's all up—here comes our adversary again."

"Master," said Wukong, "for now set aside that word 'kindness,' and let us turn a little fierce and savage and finish him off altogether, and so make our escape." Hearing this, Tripitaka trembled and shook and made no answer at all. But Sandy whipped out his treasure-staff, Pigsy raised his rake, and the Great Sage wielded his iron cudgel; all together they pressed forward and surrounded the Great Immortal in mid-air, striking and jabbing wildly. This was a fierce fight indeed. There is a poem to prove it:

Wukong knew not the immortal Zhenyuan, the
Lord Coeval-with-the-Age, more wondrous and
arcane. Three divine weapons plied their fury fierce
and free— a single deer-tail whisk drifted at its ease.
Warding left, parrying right, he met them as they
came; guarding behind, fending before, he turned
and turned again. By night they went, by morn they
came—yet none could break his hold: tarrying so,
what day would they reach the Western Heaven?

The three disciple-brothers, each plying his divine weapon, attacked all at once; but the Great Immortal merely played his fly-whisk in defense. In less than half a watch he opened his robe-sleeve once more and, as before, gathered the four monks, the one horse, and the baggage all into

its folds. Then he turned his cloud and came back to the abbey, where the immortals received him.

The immortal master took his seat in the hall and again drew them out of his sleeve one by one. He bound the Tang monk to a low locust tree at the foot of the steps, Pigsy and Sandy each to a tree on either side, and Wukong he had trussed and thrown down.

"I expect this is for interrogation," said Wukong.

In a little while the binding was all done, and the Great Immortal ordered ten bolts of long cloth fetched out. Wukong laughed. "Pigsy, this gentleman means well—he's bringing out cloth to make us inner sleeves. Save a bit of it and make me a full robe instead." The lesser immortals carried out the homespun cloth, and the Great Immortal said, "Wrap up the Tang monk Tripitaka, Pigsy, and Sandy in cloth." The immortals stepped forward together and wrapped them tight.

Wukong laughed. "Good, good, good—they're laying us out for the coffin while we're still alive!" In a moment the wrapping was finished. Then he ordered lacquer brought out. The immortals quickly fetched some of the raw and cooked lacquer they had gathered and dried themselves, and lacquered the three of them over, cloth and all, head to foot—wrapped wholly in cloth and lacquer, with only their heads and faces left bare.

"Sir," said Pigsy, "the top end doesn't matter much, but down below you'd best leave a hole, so we can relieve ourselves properly."

Then the Great Immortal ordered a great cauldron carried out. Wukong laughed. "Pigsy—our luck's in! They're carrying out a cauldron; I expect they mean to cook us some rice to eat."

"That'd be all right too," said Pigsy. "Let us eat a bit of rice and at least make handsome, well-fed ghosts of ourselves."

Sure enough, the immortals carried out a great cauldron and set it up at the foot of the steps. The Great Immortal ordered dry firewood stacked and a fierce blaze kindled, saying, "Pour a cauldronful of clear oil and heat it till it boils; then drop Sun the Pilgrim into the oil-cauldron and fry him a turn, to avenge my ginseng tree."

Hearing this, Wukong rejoiced in secret. "This is just to old Sun's liking. I haven't had a bath in all this while, and my skin's gone a bit dry and itchy; a good scalding, however it turns out, would be most obliging of them." In a moment the oil-cauldron was on the boil. But the Great Sage took thought and care, fearing the immortal's arts might be hard to fathom and that he'd find no chance to work his hands once inside the cauldron. He turned his head and glanced about: there beneath the terrace, to the east, stood a sundial platform, and to the west a stone lion. Wukong gave a leap, rolled over to the west, bit open the tip of his tongue, spat a mouthful of blood upon the stone lion, and called, "Change!" It became his very own likeness, trussed up in a bundle just as he had been. Meanwhile his true spirit issued forth and rose into the clouds, looking down upon the Taoists below.

Now the lesser immortal reported, "Master, the oil-cauldron is boiling." The Great Immortal ordered, "Carry Sun the Pilgrim down into it." Four immortal boys tried but could not lift him; eight came, and still could not lift him; another four were added, and still they could not lift him.

"This monkey clings to the earth and won't be moved," said the immortals. "Small as he is, he's solid all the same." So they set twenty lesser immortals to heave him up, and pitched him into the cauldron with a great splashing crash, sending up spatters of boiling oil that raised blister-welts on the faces of the little Taoists. Then the fire-tending boy cried out, "The cauldron's sprung a leak! The cauldron's sprung a leak!" Before the words were out, the oil had all run dry and the bottom of the

cauldron was smashed through—for inside it was nothing but a stone lion.

The Great Immortal was furious. "This bandit-ape! What outrageous insolence—working his sleight-of-hand right under my eyes! Well enough that you ran off—but why have you wrecked my stove besides? This bandit-ape there's no holding for anything; and even if you caught him it would be like kneading sand or playing with quicksilver, like catching shadows or snatching at wind. Enough, enough, enough—let him go. Now untie the Tang monk Tripitaka instead, change the cauldron for a new one, and fry him a turn to avenge the ginseng tree." And the lesser immortals truly set to work, tearing off the cloth and lacquer.

Up in mid-air Wukong heard it all plainly, and he thought to himself, "My master can't stand it. Once he's in the oil-cauldron, one boil and he's dead, two boils and he's scorched, and by three or five boils he'll be rendered into a mush of a monk. I'd best go down and save him." Good Great Sage! He dropped down through the clouds, stepped forward with hands folded, and said, "Don't go tearing off the cloth and lacquer and frying my master—wait for me to come down into the oil-cauldron instead."

The Great Immortal started and cursed, "You macaque! How did you work your trick and wreck my stove?"

Wukong laughed. "When you ran up against me, your stove was bound to come to grief—what has that to do with me? I was just about to receive a little of your kindness in oil-broth and oil-water, but I had an urgent call of nature; if I'd let it go in the cauldron, I feared I'd foul your good cooking oil and spoil it for seasoning the dishes. Now that I've thoroughly relieved myself, it's just the right time to go into the cauldron. Don't fry my master—come fry me instead."

Hearing this, the Great Immortal laughed his cold "ha-ha," walked out of the hall, and seized hold of him with one hand.

After all, there's no knowing what words were said, nor truly how he got himself free—so listen to the next chapter told.

Chapter 26: The Three Isles and the Sweet Dew of Mercy

A poem says:

In living in the world, keep the blade upon your heart's intent; In cultivating self, recall the mark beside the inch. The common saying names the knife the seed of livelihood— yet think thrice over, and beware of wrath and fraud. The highest gentleman does not contend; so it has been since ancient days, and sages carry virtue forward into their own time. The strong forever meet a kind more strong than they, and in the end all comes to emptiness and naught.

We left off with the Great Immortal Zhenyuan steadying Pilgrim with his hand and saying, "I know your abilities well enough, and I have heard your famous name. But this time you have trampled all reason and

cheated your own conscience. Even with your tricks and transformations, you cannot slip from my grasp. I'd pursue you all the way to the Western Heaven, and even before that Buddha of yours, you would still have to restore my ginseng-fruit tree. Don't go playing with your magic powers."

Pilgrim laughed. "What a petty, small-minded gentleman you are! If it's only the tree being made to live again, where's the difficulty in that? Had you said so earlier, we might have spared ourselves all this quarreling."

"If there were no quarrel," said the Great Immortal, "you think I'd let you off so easily?"

"Free my master," said Pilgrim, "and I'll give you back a living tree—how's that?"

"If you truly have such power," said the Immortal, "and can cure the tree back to life, then I'll bow to you eight times and we'll be sworn brothers."

"That's nothing," said Pilgrim. "Let them go, and old Monkey guarantees you'll get your living tree back."

The Great Immortal, judging that he could not escape, at once ordered Tripitaka, Pigsy, and Sandy released. Sandy said, "Master, I don't know what kind of trick big brother is up to."

"What trick?" said Pigsy. "This is what they call a 'kindness shown to your face by a devil.' The tree is dead—can it really be cured back to life? He's putting on a fine smooth show, pretending to go off seeking a remedy for the tree, but really he's just slipping the noose and skipping town. Do you suppose he'll give a thought to you and me?"

"He'd never dare abandon us," said Tripitaka. "Let us ask him where he means to seek the cure." So he called out, "Wukong, how did you trick the Immortal into freeing us?"

"Old Monkey spoke true and honest words," said Pilgrim. "How could I have tricked him?"

"Where will you go to seek the remedy?" asked Tripitaka.

"The ancients said, 'Remedies come from over the sea,'" said Pilgrim. "I mean now to go up to the Great Eastern Ocean, to roam through all the Three Isles and Ten Continents, to seek out the immortal elders and sage patriarchs, and ask for a method of raising the dead and restoring life. I'll guarantee the tree is cured."

"And how long before you return?" asked Tripitaka.

"Three days will do it," said Pilgrim.

"Very well, then," said Tripitaka. "I'll grant you three days as you say. Come back within three days and all is well. But if you are not back after three days, I will recite that little sutra of mine."

"I obey, I obey," said Pilgrim.

Look at him then, hurriedly straightening his tiger-skin kilt and going out the door to face the Great Immortal. "Set your mind at ease, sir. I go and I return. But you must wait well upon my master—three cups of tea and six meals a day, each day, with nothing lacking. If there's the least bit short, old Monkey will settle accounts with you when I'm back, and the first thing I'll do is smash in the bottom of your cooking pot. If his clothes get soiled, see they're rinsed and washed. If his face has gone the least bit sallow, I won't have it; and if he's grown the least bit thin, I'm not stirring from this place."

"Go, go," said the Great Immortal. "I'll certainly not let him go hungry."

Good Monkey King! He leapt onto his somersault cloud, took leave of the Five Estates Temple, and went straight up to the Great Eastern

Ocean. In mid-air, swift as a lightning bolt and fast as a shooting star, he soon arrived at the fairy region of Penglai. He pressed down the head of his cloud and looked carefully below—truly a splendid place. There is a poem to prove it:

A great-earth fairyland where ranks of sages dwell,
Penglai parts and joins, holding down the surging
waves. The jasper terrace dips its shadow in
heaven's cold heart, the giant gate's light floats high
above the ocean's face. Five-hued mist and rosy
cloud enfold the jade-toned flutes; the ninth
empyrean's stars and moon shoot at the golden
tortoise. The Queen Mother of the Western Pool
often comes here, bringing many peaches to wish
the three Immortals long life.

Pilgrim could not take in all the fairy sights, but went straight into Penglai. As he walked along, he saw, outside the White Cloud Cave beneath the shade of the pines, three old men gathered round a game of chess. The one watching the board was the Star of Longevity; the two playing were the Stars of Blessing and Emolument. Pilgrim went forward and called, "Old brothers, my respects to you!"

The three stars looked up, brushed aside the chessboard, and returned the bow. "What brings the Great Sage here?"

"I've come especially to play and amuse myself with you," said Pilgrim.

"We heard," said the Star of Longevity, "that the Great Sage had cast off Taoism and turned to Buddhism, that he had spared his life to protect the Tang Monk on the way to the Western Heaven for the scriptures, day after day toiling along the mountain roads. Where would you find the leisure to come amusing yourself?"

"I'll not deceive you, gentlemen," said Pilgrim. "Old Monkey, on his way west, has run into a bit of a snag along the road, and I've come to trouble you over a small matter—I don't know whether you'll oblige me."

"What place is it?" asked the Star of Blessing. "What is the snag? Tell us clearly, and we'll see what can be done."

"It's because I passed Longevity Mountain and the Five Estates Temple, and there I'm held up," said Pilgrim.

The three old men were astonished. "The Five Estates Temple is the fairy palace of the Great Immortal Zhenyuan! Don't tell us you went and stole and ate his ginseng fruit?"

Pilgrim laughed. "And what's so great about stealing and eating it?"

"You monkey, you don't know good from bad!" said the three. "Merely to smell that fruit lets a man live three hundred and sixty years. To eat one lets him live forty-seven thousand years. It's called the Myriad-Years Herb-and-Cinnabar Elixir. Our Way doesn't come near to matching his. He gained it so easily that he can rank his lifespan with Heaven itself, while we must still nourish our essence, refine our breath, preserve our spirit, harmonize the dragon and tiger, seize the Kan and fill the Li—and who knows how much toil it costs us. How can you say his fruit is nothing worth fussing over? In all the world there is only this single numinous root."

"Numinous root, numinous root," said Pilgrim. "I've already gone and snapped that root of his clean through."

"How, snapped the root?" cried the three, alarmed.

"The other day," said Pilgrim, "we were at his temple, but the Great Immortal was not at home — only two young acolytes there to receive my master. They offered my master two ginseng fruits, but my master didn't know what they were and kept insisting they were newborn babies not three days old, and refused over and over to eat. So the boys took the fruits away and ate them themselves, never offering us any. Then old Monkey went and stole three of them, and we three brothers ate them. Those boys, not knowing how to conduct themselves, cursed us up and down, before our faces and behind our backs, without stopping. So old Monkey grew angry, gave the tree a single blow with my staff, knocked it over to the ground — all its fruit gone, its boughs split and leaves fallen, its roots torn up and branches wounded, and the thing withered dead on the spot. The boys, not expecting it, locked us in, but old Monkey wrenched the lock open and we got away. The next morning that gentleman came home, gave chase, and in the back-and-forth our words did not agree, so we fell to fighting him. He gave a flick, spread open his sleeve, and swept all of us up into that one sleeve. He had us bound with rope and cord, flogged and beaten under questioning, and beat us a whole day. That night we escaped again; he overtook us and bagged us up just as before. He carries not an inch of iron on him — only a fly-whisk to parry with — yet we three brothers, with our three kinds of weapons, couldn't so much as touch him. This time he arranged it all over again: he wrapped my master and my two fellow disciples in cloth daubed with lacquer, and set me down in a cauldron of oil. But I worked another escape-trick and got away, and smashed all his cauldrons. Seeing he couldn't hold me, he turned somewhat sour — so I had a good talk

with him, and got him to release my master and brothers in exchange for my curing the tree alive. Only then will the two households have peace. I remembered that 'remedies come from over the sea,' and so I have come roaming these fairy regions to call on you three old brothers. If you have any remedy for curing the tree, teach it to me, so I may save the Tang Monk from his misery without delay."

When the three stars heard this, their hearts too grew troubled. "You monkey, you don't know people at all. That Zhenyuanzi is the patriarch of the earthbound immortals, while we are merely of the lineage of the celestial spirits. And you, though you've attained the rank of heavenly immortal, are still of the loose, uncounted Grand-Unity sort — you've not entered the true stream. How could you slip out of his hands? If the Great Sage had killed some beast or bird, some insect or scaled creature, a single grain of our millet-cinnabar could bring it back to life. But the ginseng fruit is the root of a fairy tree — how is it to be cured? No remedy, no remedy."

When Pilgrim heard there was no remedy, his brows knit together in twin locks and his forehead furrowed with a thousand creases. The Star of Blessing said, "Great Sage, if there's no remedy here, there may be one elsewhere — why fall into vexation so soon?"

"To go seeking a remedy elsewhere is easy enough," said Pilgrim. "Even to roam to the corners of the sea and the ends of the sky, to turn through all the thirty-six heavens, would be a small thing. The trouble is that my Elder Tang is strict in his rules and narrow in his patience — he's granted me only three days. If I'm not back after three days, he'll recite that tight-fillet spell."

The three stars laughed. "Good, good, good! If it weren't for this little device to rein you in, you'd be drilling up through the heavens again."

Then the Star of Longevity said, "Set your heart at ease, Great Sage; there's no need to fret. That Great Immortal, though he ranks above us, is also an acquaintance of ours. For one thing, it's been long since we parted and we haven't paid him a visit; for another, it would be a kindness to the Great Sage. Now we three will go together to call on him, plead your case, and tell that Tang Monk not to recite the tight-fillet spell. Never mind three days or five — we'll only take our leave once you've found a remedy and returned."

"My thanks, my thanks!" said Pilgrim. "Then please, you three old brothers, be on your way, and I'll be off." The Great Sage took leave of the three stars — no more of that.

Now the three stars mounted their auspicious radiance and went at once to the Five Estates Temple. The whole assembly within the temple suddenly heard the cry of cranes across the vast sky — it was the three old men arriving in their glory. And there they saw:

Filling the sky, dense banks of auspicious light;
through the cloud-river, billowing waves of
fragrance. A thousand strands of colored mist guard
their feathered robes; a single soft cloud upholds
their immortal feet. The green simurgh flies, the
cinnabar phoenix soars, their sleeves draw a scented
wind that sweeps across the ground. Their staffs,
hung with dragons, kindle joyous laughter; their
snowy beards, dripping jade, brush across their
breasts. Childlike of face, glad and free of all care;
sturdy of frame, mighty and full of blessing. They
grasp the star-tallies, add to the sea-house years,
with gourds at their waists and treasure-talismans.
Through myriad ages and thousand decades their
fortune and life endure; through the Ten Continents
and Three Isles they lodge as fate provides. Often
they come to the world to deliver a thousand
blessings, and each time to mankind they add a
hundredfold of fortune. Through all of Heaven and
Earth, in glory of blessing and emolument, blessing

and longevity boundless — and now this happy meeting won.

The three old men rode their auspicious light to pay their respects to the Great Immortal, and the hall of blessing was all of harmonious air, beyond all measure. When the fairy boy saw them, he hurried to report: "Master, the three Stars from over the sea have come!"

Zhenyuanzi was just then chatting idly with the Tang Monk and his disciples. Hearing the news, he came down the steps to welcome them. When Pigsy saw the Star of Longevity, he went right up and seized hold of him, laughing. "You fleshy-headed old fellow, I haven't seen you in ages — still as carefree as ever, and you didn't even bring a cap along." With that he snatched one of his own monk's caps and slapped it down onto the old man's head, then clapped his hands and roared with laughter. "Good, good, good — this truly is 'adding the cap, advancing in emolument'!"

The Star of Longevity flung the cap to the ground and scolded, "You clumsy lout! What a great oaf, knowing neither high nor low!"

"I'm no clumsy lout," said Pigsy. "It's you lot who are the real lackeys."

"You're the clumsy lout," said the Star of Blessing, "and you dare turn round and call others lackeys?"

Pigsy laughed again. "If you're not somebody's lackeys, then how is it you're called 'Add-Longevity,' 'Add-Blessing,' 'Add-Emolument'?" At this Tripitaka shouted Pigsy down, hurriedly straightened his robes, and made his bows to the three stars.

The three stars greeted the Great Immortal with the courtesy due from juniors, and only then took their seats. Once seated, the Star of Emolument said, "We've long been parted from your honored countenance and have failed in our respects. Today, because the Great Sage Sun has stirred up trouble on the fairy mountains, we've come especially to call on you."

"Did Pilgrim Sun go to Penglai, then?" asked the Great Immortal.

"He did," said the Star of Longevity. "Because he injured the Great Immortal's cinnabar tree, he came to our place to seek a remedy to cure it. We had none, so he went off to seek elsewhere. But he feared he'd overrun the three-day limit set by the Holy Monk and have the tight-fillet spell recited over him. So we've come — first, to pay our respects; second, to beg an extension of the limit."

Hearing this, Tripitaka answered at once, again and again, "I won't recite it, I won't recite it."

Just as they were speaking, Pigsy came running in again and grabbed hold of the Star of Blessing, demanding fruit to eat. He went groping all through his sleeves, digging about his waist, ceaselessly lifting his robes to search him over. Tripitaka laughed. "What manners are these, Pigsy?"

"It's not bad manners," said Pigsy. "This is what's called 'every turn brings blessing.'" Again Tripitaka shouted at him to get out. The idiot went to the door and stood glaring at the Star of Blessing, fixing him with a furious, unblinking stare.

"You clumsy lout," said the Star of Blessing, "when did I ever do you wrong, that you should hate me so?"

"It's not that I hate you," said Pigsy. "This is called 'turning the head to look back upon blessing.'"

As the idiot came out the door, he spied a young acolyte carrying four tea-spoons, just going to fetch cups and bring fruit and tea. Pigsy snatched them away in one grab, ran up onto the hall, took a little chime in hand, and went banging and beating it about, playing at both ends.

"This monk grows ever more disrespectful," said the Great Immortal.

Pigsy laughed. "It's not disrespect — this is called 'the four seasons of good fortune and celebration.'"

But let us leave Pigsy clowning and carrying on. Let us tell instead how Pilgrim rode his auspicious cloud away from Penglai and soon came to the fairy mountain of Fangzhang — a truly splendid place. There is a poem to prove it:

Fangzhang towers lofty, a separate heaven of its own, where the Palace of the Grand Origin gathers the immortals. The purple terrace's light shines on the Three Pure Ones' road; the fragrance of flower and tree floats up through five-hued mist. The golden phoenix abounds about the coiled-stamen towers; who forces the jade-cream to irrigate the mushroom fields? Emerald peaches and purple plums newly ripen, and the immortals' tidings change again after ten thousand years.

Pilgrim brought down the head of his cloud, but had no heart to enjoy the scenery. As he walked along, he caught only a thick wave of fragrant wind and the cry of a black crane — and there, by that wall, stood an immortal. He saw:

Filling the sky, ten thousand rays of rosy light appear; colored mist drifts and floats, its glow unbroken. The cinnabar phoenix holding a flower is fresher still; the green simurgh wheels and dances, its cry tender and bright. Blessing like the Eastern Sea, longevity like the mountains; his face like a young boy's, his body hale. In his gourd lie hidden cave-heavens and the deathless elixir; at his waist hangs the longevity-script as old as the sun. Many a time he has sent down good omens to mankind; many a time he has dispelled the world's calamities and woes. Emperor Wu once proclaimed him to add to his years of life; at the Jasper Pool he attends each Flat-Peach banquet. He teaches the host of monks to cast off worldly bonds, and points open the great Way, bright as lightning. He too has crossed the sea to wish a thousand autumns, and often goes to the Spirit Mountain to behold the Buddha's face. His holy title is the Great Sovereign

Lord of Eastern Florescence, the first among the immortal kin of mist and rosy cloud.

Sun Pilgrim went forward with a friendly face, calling out, "Sovereign Lord, my greetings to you!"

The Sovereign Lord hurriedly returned the bow. "Great Sage, forgive my failure to receive you. Pray come to my humble dwelling and take some tea." Taking Pilgrim by the hand, he led him in. It was truly a fairy palace of cowrie gateways, with jasper pools and gem-bright pavilions past all telling. They had just sat down to wait for tea when, from behind a kingfisher screen, there came a young boy. And how was he got up?

Clad in Taoist robes that flutter with the glint of rosy cloud, a silken sash at his waist, its light scattered in tangles. On his head a scholar's kerchief patterned with the Dipper's stars; on his feet straw sandals for roaming the fairy peaks. He has refined the True Origin, sloughed off the husk of self; when merit and conduct are complete, joy follows the will. He has seen through the source — the essence, breath, and spirit; his master knows him true, with never a false stroke. Fled from fame, he now rejoices in life without bound; the cycle of the sexagenary years cannot constrain him. Through winding corridors, up to the treasure-tower he climbs; three times he has filched the Flat Peaches of Heaven. Out from behind the kingfisher screen, on faint and fragrant cloud — this little immortal is none other than Dongfang Shuo.

Seeing him, Pilgrim laughed. "So the little thief is here too! There are no peaches in the Sovereign Lord's place for you to steal and eat."

Dongfang Shuo made a bow toward the high seat and answered, "You old thief, what have you come here for? My master has no elixir of immortality for you to steal and eat."

"Manqian, stop your wild talk," called the Sovereign Lord. "Bring the tea." (Manqian was Dongfang Shuo's Taoist name.) He hurried inside and brought out two cups of tea.

When they had drunk, Pilgrim said, "Old Monkey has come on a matter I wish to lay before you — I don't know whether you'll grant it."

"What matter?" said the Sovereign Lord. "I'll gladly hear your instruction."

"Lately, while escorting the Tang Monk westward, I passed Longevity Mountain and the Five Estates Temple. Because that temple's young acolyte behaved insolently, I lost my temper for a moment and pushed over his ginseng-fruit tree. So we are held up, and the Tang Monk cannot get free. I've come especially to your honored presence to beg the gift of a remedy to cure it. I beseech you, be generous."

"You monkey," said the Sovereign Lord, "with no thought for the consequences, you go stirring up trouble everywhere. That Zhenyuanzi of the Five Estates Temple, whose holy title is 'Sovereign as Old as the World,' is the patriarch of the earthbound immortals — how could you go and offend him? His ginseng-fruit tree is the Herb-Restoring Elixir; merely to steal and eat the fruit was already a crime, yet you went on to push over the tree as well. Would he ever let that drop?"

"That's just it," said Pilgrim. "We made our escape, but he overtook us and bagged us all up in one sleeve like so many sweat-rags — and that's what galls me. There was nothing for it but to promise to seek a cure for him, and so I've come to beg of you."

"I have a pellet of the Nine-Turn Grand-Unity Restorative Elixir," said the Sovereign Lord, "but it can only cure the living creatures of the world; it cannot heal a tree. A tree is the soul of soil and wood, nourished by Heaven and moistened by Earth. If it were a common mortal fruit-tree, a cure might still be managed. But this Longevity Mountain is a blessed land of the primordial Before-Heaven, and the Five Estates Temple is a cave-heaven of the He Continent, and the ginseng fruit is a numinous root born of the very opening of Heaven and Earth. How could it be cured? No remedy, no remedy."

"Since there's no remedy," said Pilgrim, "old Monkey takes his leave." The Sovereign Lord still wished to keep him for a cup of jade nectar, but Pilgrim said, "The rescue is urgent — I dare not linger." So he mounted his cloud and went on to the sea-isle of Yingzhou — also a splendid place. There is a poem to prove it:

Pearl-trees, exquisite and fine, shine through the purple mist; Yingzhou's palaces and towers join with all the heavens. Green hills and emerald waters, the jasper-blossom bright; jade nectar, and Kunwu steel hard as iron and stone. Five-hued azure cockerels crow to the sea-borne sun; thousand-year cinnabar phoenixes drink the vermilion vapor. Worldly men never fathom the scene within the gourd — beyond all images, the spring light of a billion years.

When the Great Sage reached Yingzhou, he saw, beneath the cinnabar cliffs and pearl-trees, several white-haired, hoary-bearded elders — immortals with childlike faces and crane-feathered temples — playing chess and drinking wine, talking and laughing, singing songs. Truly it was:

Auspicious clouds full of light, lucky vapors floating fragrant. Bright simurghs cried at the cave-mouth; black cranes danced upon the mountaintop. Emerald lotus-root and water-peaches served as relish for the wine; cross-grafted pears and fire-jujubes for a thousand autumns of long life. Each of them heeded no cinnabar summons of the court, yet each was enrolled in the immortals' register. Carefree, they drifted with the waves; at ease, they yielded to the pure and tranquil. The cycle of the heavens could not rein them in; the whole of Earth and sky was theirs to

roam free. Black gibbons offering fruit followed in pairs, full of lovely affection; white deer holding flowers bowed down in couples, full of devoted tenderness.

The old men were just then merry in their feasting when Pilgrim called out in a loud voice, "How about taking me along to play and amuse myself a bit?"

Seeing him, the immortals hurried forward to greet him. There is a poem to prove it:

The ginseng-fruit tree's numinous root is snapped;
the Great Sage calls on immortals to seek a
wondrous art. Winding through cinnabar mist, out
from the treasure-grove, the Nine Elders of
Yingzhou come forward to receive him.

Pilgrim recognized them as the Nine Elders and laughed. "Old brothers, you have it easy here!"

"Great Sage," said the Nine Elders, "had you kept to the straight path in those years and not made havoc of Heaven's palace, you'd be even more at ease than we. But all is well now — we hear you've returned to the true and turned westward to worship the Buddha. How is it you've found the leisure to come here?"

Pilgrim laid out the whole matter of seeking a remedy to cure the tree. The Nine Elders too were greatly alarmed. "You really do go courting disaster — courting disaster! We honestly have no remedy."

"Since there's no remedy," said Pilgrim, "then I'll bid you farewell." The Nine Elders still pressed him to drink the jasper draught and eat the emerald lotus-root. Pilgrim absolutely refused to sit; he only stood and drank one cup of the draught and ate one piece of lotus-root, then hurriedly left Yingzhou and went straight back across the Great Eastern Ocean.

Soon he sighted Potalaka Mountain not far off, so he brought down his cloud and went straight up onto the Potalaka cliff. There he saw the Bodhisattva Guanyin in her purple bamboo grove, expounding the scriptures and preaching the Dharma to the great spirits of the heavens, to Moksha, and to the Dragon Maiden. There is a poem to prove it:

The sea-lord's city stands high, its lucky vapors
dense; behold besides the wondrous things, marvels
without end. Know that beyond the thousand kinds
of dim half-seen, all issues from the single grade of
faint and subtle. The Four Sages, in their season,
attain the true fruit; the Six Common Beings,
having heard, escape the cage. Shaolin holds
another taste of truth besides — flower and fruit,
fragrant and fair, fill the trees with red.

The Bodhisattva had already seen Pilgrim coming and at once bade the great mountain-guarding spirit go to meet him. The great spirit came out of the grove and called, "Sun Wukong, where are you off to?"

Pilgrim raised his head and shouted, "You bear-monster! Is 'Wukong' a name for the likes of you to be calling? If old Monkey hadn't spared you in the old days, you'd long since have been a corpse-ghost of Black Wind Mountain. Now that you've followed the Bodhisattva, received the good fruit, dwell on this fairy mountain, and constantly hear the teaching of the Dharma — can't you call me even one 'Your Honor'?"

That black bear had indeed attained the true fruit, and now guarded Potalaka in the Bodhisattva's service, styled the Great Spirit — and it was all thanks to Pilgrim. So he could only smile apologetically. "Great Sage, the ancients said, 'A gentleman does not dwell on old wrongs.' Why keep bringing it up? The Bodhisattva sent me to receive you."

At this Pilgrim composed himself in grave reverence and went with the great spirit into the purple bamboo grove to pay his respects to the Bodhisattva.

"Wukong," said the Bodhisattva, "how far has the Tang Monk traveled now?"

"He has traveled as far as Longevity Mountain in the Western Continent of Cattle-Gift," said Pilgrim.

"On that Longevity Mountain there is a Five Estates Temple, and the Great Immortal Zhenyuan," said the Bodhisattva. "Have you met him?"

Pilgrim bowed his head and said, "It is because of the Five Estates Temple that I have come. Your disciple did not recognize the Great Immortal Zhenyuan, and injured and destroyed his ginseng-fruit tree. He has held up my master, who cannot go forward."

The Bodhisattva, knowing it well, said reproachfully, "You reckless ape — you don't know good from bad! That ginseng-fruit tree of his is a numinous root from the very opening of Heaven and Earth. Zhenyuanzi

is the patriarch of the earthbound immortals; even I yield him three parts. How could you go and injure his tree?"

Pilgrim bowed again. "Your disciple truly did not know. That day the Great Immortal was not at home — only two fairy boys attended us. It was Zhu Wuneng who knew he had fruit and wanted one to taste. Your disciple did indeed steal three of them, and we brothers divided and ate them. When the boys found out, they cursed us without end, and so your disciple lost his temper and pushed over the tree. The next day the Great Immortal returned and overtook us, bagged us all up in one sleeve, bound us with rope, and flogged us with a whip, beating us under questioning a whole day. We escaped that night, but he overtook us and bagged us again, just as before — twice and three times, and there was truly no escaping. I have already agreed to cure the tree for him, and so I went seeking a remedy over the sea, roaming all the Three Isles, but none of the immortals had the power. And so, with single-hearted devotion, your disciple has come especially to beg of the Bodhisattva, hoping in your mercy you will graciously bestow a remedy, to save the Tang Monk so he may go west soon."

"Why didn't you come to see me sooner," said the Bodhisattva, "instead of going off to search the isles?"

Hearing this, Pilgrim secretly rejoiced in his heart. What luck, what luck! The Bodhisattva surely has a remedy! And he went forward again to beg.

"The sweet-dew water at the bottom of my pure vase," said the Bodhisattva, "is good for curing fairy trees and numinous sprouts."

"Has it ever been tested?" asked Pilgrim.

"It has been tested," said the Bodhisattva.

"What proof is there?" asked Pilgrim.

"In years past," said the Bodhisattva, "the Supreme Lord Lao Tzu once made a wager with me. He pulled off a sprig of my willow, set it in his cinnabar-refining furnace, scorched it dry and crisp, and sent it back to me. I took it and stuck it in my vase, and within a single day and night it grew green twigs and leaves again, just as it was before."

Pilgrim laughed. "What luck indeed, what luck indeed! If a thing scorched and crisped can be cured back to life, how much more a tree merely pushed over — where's the difficulty in that?"

The Bodhisattva instructed her assembly, "Keep watch over the grove; I'll go and return." Then, holding the pure vase in her hand, with the white parrot singing sweetly ahead and the Great Sage following behind, she set out. There is a poem to prove it:

The jade-tuft and golden form the world can
scarcely tell of — truly the merciful one who saves
from suffering. In ages past she met the Buddha-of-
No-Defilement; to this day she has won a body of
efficacious action. Through many lives she calmed
the waves of desire's sea; a single field of heart, free
of the smallest dust. The sweet dew, long proven a
truly wondrous Dharma, will surely keep the
treasure-tree forever in eternal spring.

Now in the temple the Great Immortal and the three old men were just then in pleasant talk, when suddenly they saw the Great Sage bring down

his cloud, calling out, "The Bodhisattva is coming — quick, go meet her, go meet her!"

In a flurry, the three stars together with Zhenyuanzi, and Tripitaka with his disciples, all went out together from the treasure-hall to receive her. The Bodhisattva had only just halted her auspicious cloud. First she exchanged words with Zhenyuanzi, then made her courtesies to the three stars, and when the courtesies were done, took the high seat. Before the steps, Pilgrim led the Tang Monk, Pigsy, and Sandy to make their bows, and the various immortals of the temple came forward to pay their respects as well.

"Great Immortal," said Pilgrim, "no need to hesitate. Hurry and set out an incense table at once, and invite the Bodhisattva to go and cure that fruit-tree of yours."

The Great Immortal bowed and thanked the Bodhisattva. "It's such a trifling affair — how could I dare to trouble the Bodhisattva to descend?"

"The Tang Monk is my disciple," said the Bodhisattva, "and Sun Wukong has offended you, sir; it is only right that he make amends for your treasure-tree."

"Since that's so," said the three old men, "there's no need for modest demurrals. Let us all go into the garden, Bodhisattva, and have a look."

The Great Immortal at once ordered the incense table set out and the rear garden swept clean. He invited the Bodhisattva to go ahead, with the three old men following. When Tripitaka and his disciples and all the immortals of the temple came into the garden to look, there lay the tree fallen on the ground, the soil split open and its roots exposed, leaves fallen and branches withered.

"Wukong," called the Bodhisattva, "stretch out your hand." Pilgrim opened his left hand. The Bodhisattva dipped her willow-sprig into the sweet dew of the vase and drew upon Pilgrim's palm a talismanic sign for raising the dead and restoring life, then bade him press it down beneath the tree's roots and watch for the water to come forth as his measure. Pilgrim clenched his fist and thrust it down beneath the roots, and in a moment there welled up a pool of clear spring water.

"That water must not touch any vessel of the Five Elements," said the Bodhisattva. "You must scoop it out with a jade dipper, raise the tree upright, and pour it down from the top. Then the roots and bark will naturally knit together, the leaves will grow and the buds sprout, the branches turn green and the fruit appear."

"Little Taoists," said Pilgrim, "quick, fetch a jade dipper."

"This poor Taoist's humble mountain has no jade dipper," said Zhenyuanzi. "We have only jade tea-bowls and jade wine-cups — will those do?"

"As long as it's a jade vessel that can scoop water, it will do," said the Bodhisattva. "Bring them and let me see."

The Great Immortal at once bade his young acolytes bring out some twenty or thirty tea-bowls and forty or fifty wine-cups, and they scooped the clear spring out from beneath the roots. Pilgrim, Pigsy, and Sandy hoisted up the tree, propped it upright, and heaped soil about it. Then, bowl by bowl, they offered up the sweet spring in the jade vessels to the Bodhisattva, who sprinkled it on with her willow-sprig, finely and carefully, all the while reciting scriptures and spells under her breath.

In a little while, when she had sprinkled out all the scooped water, the tree was indeed green again as before, its leaves shading dense and deep,

and upon it hung twenty-three ginseng fruits.

The two acolytes Pure Wind and Bright Moon said, "When the fruit went missing the other day, we counted over and over and could only make out twenty-two; now that it's come back to life, how is there one more?"

"Time reveals a man's heart," said Pilgrim. "The other day old Monkey stole only three. One of them fell to the ground, and the Local God told me that this treasure, meeting the soil, sinks into it. Pigsy kept yelling that I'd cheated and shorted him — that's how the truth leaked out — and the matter dragged on till now, when it's finally come clear."

"The reason I just now used no vessel of the Five Elements," said the Bodhisattva, "is that I knew this thing stands in dread of the Five Elements."

The Great Immortal was overjoyed, and at once ordered the golden mallet brought and knocked down ten of the fruits. He invited the Bodhisattva and the three old men back to the treasure-hall — first to thank them for their labor, and second to hold a Ginseng-Fruit Assembly. The young immortals arranged tables and chairs, spread out cinnabar trays, and invited the Bodhisattva to take the high seat of honor, the three old men the left seats, the Tang Monk the right seat, and Zhenyuanzi the front seat to keep them company, and each of them ate one. There is a poem to prove it:

Within Longevity Mountain, an ancient cave-heaven: the ginseng ripens once in nine thousand years. The numinous root appeared, its sprouts and branches harmed; the sweet dew nourished it, and fruit and leaves were whole. The three old men, met in joy, are all old friends; the four monks, blessed in the meeting, were fated of old. From now on, all who eat the ginseng fruit shall be immortals of long life, never to grow old.

The Bodhisattva and the three old men each ate one. The Tang Monk, now realizing it was a treasure of the immortal household, also ate one. Wukong and his two brothers each ate one as well; Zhenyuanzi ate one to keep them company, and the immortals of the temple divided one among them.

Then Pilgrim thanked the Bodhisattva and saw her back up to the Potalaka cliff, and sent the three stars straight back to Penglai Isle. Zhenyuanzi then laid out a feast of vegetable dishes and wine and became sworn brothers with Pilgrim. This is the very thing — without a fight there's no acquaintance — and the two households became as one. Master and the four disciples, full of joy and gladness, rested as night fell. And the elder now found that:

Having the karmic bond to eat the Herb-Restoring Elixir, he wins long life — but must yet bitterly endure the monsters' toils.

In the end, how they took their leave the next day — listen to the explanation in the next chapter.

Chapter 27: The Corpse-Demon Thrice Deceives the Tang Monk

So it was that the next morning, at first light, Tripitaka and his disciples made ready to press on. But Master Zhenyuan, having sworn brotherhood with Sun Wukong, found the two of them so wholly of one mind and one heart that he would by no means let them go. Again he laid out a feast and pressed his hospitality upon them, so that they lingered five or six days in all. Yet the elder, having tasted of the Herb-of-Return elixir, felt truly as though he had sloughed off his mortal frame and been born anew — clear of spirit, hale of body. His heart was set so hard upon the scriptures that he could not bear to tarry, and at last, there being no help for it, they set out.

Master and disciples took their leave and went their way. Before long there rose up before them a high mountain. Said Tripitaka, "Disciples, there is a steep and perilous range ahead. I fear the horse may not be able to climb it. We must all take the greatest care." Said Wukong, "Set your heart at ease, Master. We shall manage it ourselves." Good Monkey King — he laid his iron cudgel crosswise before the horse, cut a path open through the mountain, and climbed the high cliffs, gazing out upon a scene that seemed without end:

Peak upon crag in folded ranks, ravine and gully
looping round. Tigers and wolves move in their
packs, the roe and stag go troop by troop. Countless
musk-deer burrow in clusters, foxes and hares
across the slope gather in swarms. Pythons a
thousand feet long, serpents stretching ten
thousand fathoms. The great pythons breathe a fog
of sorrow, the long snakes spit a goblin wind. Beside
the road the brambles trail and tangle, upon the
ridge the pine and cedar stand handsome. Climbing
fig and creeper fill the eye, fragrant grasses run to
meet the sky. Shadows fall toward the dark sea in
the north, clouds part where the Dipper's handle
hangs in the south. Through all the ages it holds the
old primal breath; a thousand peaks loom in ranks,
the sunlight cold.

Upon his horse the elder's heart was struck with dread. But the Great Sage put forth his arts: brandishing the iron cudgel, he gave one roaring howl that sent the wolves and reptiles tumbling and scrambling away, and the tigers and leopards fleeing in rout.

Master and disciples entered the mountain, and when at last they came to a rugged, towering place, Tripitaka said, "Wukong, my belly has gone hungry this whole day. Go somewhere and beg us a little vegetarian food to eat." Wukong answered with a forced smile, "Master, how little you understand. Here we are halfway up a mountain — no village before us, no inn behind us. Even with money in hand there is nowhere to buy. Where would you have me look for a meal?"

Tripitaka was displeased and scolded aloud, "You monkey! Think how you were pinned by the Tathagata inside a stone box at the Mountain of Two Frontiers — your mouth could speak, but your feet could not walk. It was I who saved your life, who laid my hand upon your crown and gave you the vows, and made you my disciple. How is it you will not bestir yourself, but forever harbor a lazy heart?"

Said Wukong, "Your disciple is diligent enough. When have I ever been lazy?"

"If you are so diligent," said Tripitaka, "why will you not beg me a meal? My belly is empty — how am I to travel? Besides, in this place of mountain miasma and pestilent vapors, how shall we ever reach the Thunderclap Monastery?"

Said Wukong, "Master, do not take it amiss, and spare your words. I know your honored temper runs to pride; cross or slight you in the least, and at once you'll be reciting that certain spell. Dismount and sit yourself down in peace, and let me go find where there are folk and beg a meal."

Then Wukong gave a leap and sprang up into the clouds, shaded his eyes with his hand, and gazed out wide. Alas, the road to the West was utterly desolate — no farmsteads, no walled holds, no human dwellings — a place of many trees and little smoke from any hearth. He looked a long while, and at last, away to the south, he saw a high mountain with a

patch of bright red flecks glowing on its sunlit slope. Wukong brought his cloud down and said, "Master, there is something to eat."

The elder asked what it might be. Said Wukong, "There are no homes hereabouts to beg from, but on that southern mountain is a patch of red — surely ripe wild peaches. I'll go pick a few to stave off your hunger." Tripitaka said gladly, "If a man who has left the household life can have peaches to eat, that is a portion above his deserving." So Wukong took up the alms-bowl, called up his auspicious light, and — watch him! — went tumbling and somersaulting away on a chill, whistling wind, and in a moment was off to the southern mountain to pick peaches; of which no more for now.

Now there is an old saying: "Where the mountain is high, there must be monsters; where the ridge is steep, there spirits are born." And true enough, on this very mountain there dwelt a demon whom the Great Sage's departure had startled. Treading the dark wind in the clouds, she looked down and saw the elder sitting upon the ground, and could not contain her joy. "What luck! What luck!" she said. "For years my household has spoken of the Tang monk from the Land of the East, who goes to fetch the Great Vehicle scriptures. He is the very incarnation of the Golden Cicada, the original body of ten lifetimes' cultivation — whoever eats but a single morsel of his flesh wins long life and immortality. And here, this very day, he has come!"

The demon pressed forward to seize him at once — but she saw that at the elder's left hand and right stood two mighty generals guarding him, and she dared not draw near. These two were Bajie and Sha Monk. Though neither possessed any very great powers, Bajie had once been Marshal Tianpeng of the Heavenly River, and Sha Monk the Curtain-Lifting Captain; the awe of their former rank had not yet wholly faded

from them, and so she dared not approach. Said the demon to herself, "Let me toy with him a while, and see what comes of it."

Good demon — she stilled the dark wind, and there in a hollow of the mountain shook her body and transformed, becoming a maiden with a face like the moon and the bloom of flowers, of beauty past telling: brows clear, eyes lovely, teeth white, lips red. In her left hand she carried a little green earthen pot, in her right a green porcelain bottle, and she came straight from the west toward the east, making for the Tang monk:

The holy pilgrim rests his horse upon the crag,
when of a sudden a skirted maiden draws near. Her
kingfisher sleeves sway light, baring jade-shoot
fingers; her Xiang-silk skirt trails slanting, showing
the golden lotus of her feet. Sweat dewes her
powdered face like blossoms holding rain, dust
brushes her moth-brows like willows wreathed in
mist. When one looks close and fixes the eye to
gaze — see, see, she has come right up beside them.

When Tripitaka saw her, he called out, "Bajie! Sha Monk! Wukong said just now that this was a wild and empty place with no people — yet look, here comes someone out yonder!"

Said Bajie, "Master, you and Sha Monk sit still; let old Pig go and have a look." The blockhead set down his nine-toothed rake, smoothed his cassock straight, and went swaggering and swaying along, putting on a

refined and scholarly air, straight up to meet her with an oafish, smirking face. And in truth, from afar she was hard to make out, but seen close at hand she was plain enough — that woman was formed like this:

Ice-flesh hiding bones of jade, her collar baring a creamy breast. Willow brows heaped with kingfisher dark, apricot eyes flashing silver stars. A face fair as the moon's own image, a nature pure by nature's grant. Her form like a swallow nestled in willows, her voice like an oriole warbling in the woods. Half-opened crabapple cupping the dawn-sun, a peony just unfolded, toying with the bright spring.

When Bajie saw how comely she was, the blockhead's earthly passions stirred, and he could not hold his foolish, rambling tongue. He cried, "Lady Bodhisattva, where are you bound? And what is that you carry in your hands?" Plain as day she was a demon, yet he could not tell. The woman answered readily, "Elder, in this green pot is fragrant cooked rice, and in the green bottle is fried wheat-gluten. I have come to this place for no other cause than to fulfill a vow — a vow to feast holy monks."

Hearing this, Bajie's heart was filled with joy. He spun about at once and went galloping back like a pig in a frenzy to report to Tripitaka: "Master! 'The fortunate man has Heaven's own reward.' You were hungry, and bade my elder brother go beg a meal — and that monkey has gone off

heaven-knows-where to pick peaches and play. Eating too many peaches gnaws at the stomach and loosens the bowels. But look — is that not someone come to feast the monks?"

Tripitaka would not believe it. "You great clumsy lout, talking nonsense! We have walked all this stretch and not met one decent soul. Where would a monk-feasting woman spring from?" Said Bajie, "Master — has she not arrived already?"

The moment Tripitaka saw her, he sprang up in haste, pressed his palms together at his breast, and said, "Lady Bodhisattva, where is your honored home? What family are you of? What vow of the heart brings you here to feast the monks?" Plain as day she was a demon, yet the elder too could not tell. Seeing the Tang monk ask after her origins, the demon stood her ground and forged a false tale on the spot, with honeyed words and flowery speech, to cheat and beguile him:

"Master, this mountain is called the White Tiger Ridge, where serpents turn back and beasts take fright. Straight to the west, below, is my home. My father and mother live there; they read the scriptures and love to do good, and they feast every monk of the road who passes by. Because they had no son, they prayed to the gods and worked their merits, and so begot me, their poor daughter. They wished to marry me into another house to raise the family's standing — but then they feared to have no support in their old age, and so instead they took me a son-in-law into the home, to keep them company in age and see them to their graves."

Hearing this, Tripitaka said, "Lady Bodhisattva, your words give me pause. The holy classics say: 'While father and mother are living, one does not roam afar; and if one must roam, it must be to a fixed place.' Since you have father and mother at home, and they have taken you a son-in-law besides, and there is a vow to fulfill, it would have been well

to send your husband. Why do you walk this mountain yourself, with not even a maidservant to attend you? This is not to keep a wife's proper way."

The woman, smiling sweetly, hastened to answer with pretty words: "Master, my husband is in a hollow on the north side of the mountain, hoeing the fields with a few hired hands. This is the midday meal I have cooked to carry down to those men. It is only because in this fifth and sixth month of high summer there is no one else to send, and my parents are aged besides, that I have come to bring it in person. Then of a sudden I met you three travelers from afar, and bethought me how my parents love to do good — and so I would feast these monks with this very food. If you do not scorn it, I would offer it as a poor woman's humble gift."

Said Tripitaka, "Amen, amen! I have a disciple gone to pick fruit; he will return presently. I dare not eat before him. Suppose I, a monk, ate your food, and your husband came to learn of it and scolded you for it — would not the blame for that fall upon this poor monk?"

When the woman saw that the Tang monk would not eat, again her face bloomed like spring, and she said, "Master — that my parents feast the monks is a small thing; but my husband is an even more virtuous man. All his life what he loves is mending bridges and repairing roads, honoring the old and pitying the poor. If he but hears that this food was given for you to eat, then, by the bond of love between us as man and wife, he will hold it dearer by far than anything common." Yet still Tripitaka would not eat.

This enraged Bajie past bearing. The blockhead thrust out his snout and grumbled aloud: "There are monks without number under Heaven, but never one so weak and soft as this old monk of mine! Here is food ready before him, and a third of it he will not touch — he must wait for that

monkey to come, and split it into four before he'll eat!" And without waiting to argue the matter, with one shove of his snout he overturned the pot and was about to fall to.

But just then Wukong, having picked a few peaches from the top of the southern mountain, came tumbling back upon a somersault with the alms-bowl in his hands. Opening wide his fiery eyes and golden pupils to look, he knew the woman for a demon at once. Down went the bowl; out came the iron cudgel, and he aimed a blow straight at her head. The elder, terrified, caught hold of his arm and cried, "Wukong! You come charging up — whom would you strike?"

Said Wukong, "Master, this woman before you — do not take her for a decent person. She is a demon, come to deceive you." Said Tripitaka, "You monkey-head! In your time you had some power of sight; how is it you talk such wild nonsense today? This Lady Bodhisattva has so good a heart as to wish to feast us with her food — how can you say she is a demon?"

Wukong laughed and said, "Master, how should you know? When old Monkey was a demon-king in the Water-Curtain Cave, if ever I had a mind to eat human flesh, this was just my way: I would turn myself into gold or silver, or into a fine mansion, or into a drunken man, or into a woman's charms. And if some lovesick fool grew enamored of me, I would lure him into the cave and there work my will upon him to my heart's content — steaming him or boiling him to my use; and what I could not finish I'd dry in the sun against the rainy weather. Master, had I come back a moment later, you would surely have fallen into her snare and met her cruel hand."

But the Tang monk would by no means believe it, and only kept saying she was a good person. Said Wukong, "Master, now I understand you.

You saw her good looks, and your earthly passions are stirred. If that is truly your meaning, let Bajie fell a few trees, let Sha Monk gather some grass, and I'll play carpenter and put up a little hut here on the spot, where you and she can consummate the match. We'll all break up and go our ways — and would that not be a tidy bit of business? Why go on toiling over mountains, fetching scriptures and all?"

Now the elder was by nature a soft and gentle man, and he could in no wise stomach such talk. He was so shamed that his shaven scalp flushed crimson clear to his ears.

While Tripitaka stood there in his shame and confusion, Wukong's temper flared again. He whipped out the iron cudgel and struck full at the demon's face. But the monster had some skill: she worked her "corpse-release method," and when she saw the cudgel coming, she rallied her spirit and slipped away beforehand, leaving a false corpse struck dead upon the ground.

This so terrified the elder that he shook and trembled and muttered with his lips, "This monkey is utterly without manners! Time and again I counsel him, and he will not heed, but slays a living person for no cause at all!"

Said Wukong, "Master, do not take it amiss. Come and have a look at what is in this pot." Sha Monk supported the elder and brought him near to look — and where was any fragrant rice? It was a pot full of long, tail-dragging maggots; and where was any wheat-gluten? It was a few green frogs and warty toads, hopping all over the ground. Now at last the elder was a third part convinced.

But that could not stop Bajie from his sullen spite. Standing aside, he leaked out mischief by the measure, egging the master on: "Master, to speak of this woman — she was a farm-wife of these parts, taking food

down to the fields, who chanced to meet us on the road. How can he frame her as a demon? Elder brother's cudgel is heavy. He came up and struck one blow, and unexpectedly beat her to death. Fearing you would recite the Tight-Fillet Spell, he has worked a deliberate eye-blinding trick — turned her remains into this sort of thing to dazzle your sight, so you will not say the spell."

From this one speech all Tripitaka's ill luck flowed. For he truly believed the blockhead's prodding, and, making the secret sign with his fingers, recited the spell with his lips. Wukong at once cried, "My head! My head aches! Stop, stop — say what you have to say!" Said the Tang monk, "What is there to say? A man who has left the household life must ever be merciful, must never let kindness depart from his thoughts — sweeping the floor for fear of harming an ant's life, screening the lamp in pity for the moth. How is it that you act with violence at every step, and have beaten this innocent person to death? What use is it to fetch scriptures? Go back where you came from!"

Said Wukong, "Master, where would you have me go?" Said the Tang monk, "I will not have you for my disciple." Said Wukong, "If you will not have me for your disciple, I only fear you will never make your way to the Western Heaven." Said the Tang monk, "My life is in Heaven's keeping. If it is fated that yonder demon should steam me and eat me, or boil me, that cannot be helped. But you — you could never save me from my appointed end. Be off with you, quick."

Said Wukong, "Master, that I should go is well enough — only I've never yet repaid your kindness." Said the Tang monk, "What kindness have I ever shown you?" Hearing this, the Great Sage knelt down at once and knocked his head upon the ground. "Old Monkey, because I made great havoc in the Heavenly Palace, brought down upon myself the disaster of bodily harm, and was pinned by our Buddha beneath the Mountain of

Two Frontiers — by good fortune the Bodhisattva Guanyin gave me the discipline of the vows, and by good fortune you, Master, set my body free. If I do not go up to the Western Heaven at your side, it would show me one who knew a kindness yet did not repay it — no true man — and would make a name to be cursed through ten thousand ages and a thousand autumns."

Now this Tang monk was a holy man of compassion and mercy, and seeing Wukong plead so piteously, his heart relented. "Since you put it so," he said, "I'll forgive you this once more. But never again be insolent. If you go on doing evil as before, I'll recite the spell over and over — twenty times round." Said Wukong, "Thirty times, if you please — only I'll strike no one again." Then at last he helped the Tang monk back onto his horse and offered up the peaches he had picked. The Tang monk ate a few there in the saddle, to stave off his hunger for the while.

Now the demon, it turned out, had escaped with her life and risen into the air; for that one blow of Wukong's had not slain her — she had sent her spirit forth and slipped away. There in the clouds she gnashed her teeth and silently cursed him: "For years I'd only heard tell of his powers, and today, sure enough, the tale proves no idle boast. That Tang monk no longer knew me, and was just about to eat the food. Had he but bent his head and given it a single sniff, I'd have snatched him up in a trice — would he not have been mine? But unlooked-for, that fellow came charging back and broke up my game, and very nearly struck me down with a single blow. If I let this monk go, then truly all my labor is for nothing. I'll go down again and toy with him once more."

Good demon — she brought down her dark cloud, and there at the foot of the mountain ahead shook her body and changed, becoming an old woman, fully fourscore years of age, leaning on a crook-headed bamboo staff, coming along the road with a wail at every step. When Bajie saw

her, he cried out in great alarm, "Master, this is bad! That old dame has come looking for someone!" Said the Tang monk, "Looking for whom?" Said Bajie, "The one elder brother beat to death must surely be her daughter — and this is surely the mother, come searching for her!"

Said Wukong, "Brother, don't talk rubbish. That woman was eighteen, and this old dame is eighty. How could she be bearing children sixty years on? It's a sham, beyond all doubt. Let old Monkey go and have a look." Good Wukong — he strode forward and drew near, and the monster was:

Falsely changed into a granny, both temples white
as ice and snow. Slow and dragging is her gait, timid
and faltering her step. A frail thin body, gaunt and
spare, a face like a withered cabbage-leaf. Her
cheekbones jut up high, her lips turn down apart.
Old age is not as youth once was — her whole face
is creased like a folded lotus-leaf.

Wukong knew her for the demon, and wasting no words on argument, he raised the cudgel and struck straight at her head. When the monster saw the cudgel rise, she rallied as before, sent her primal spirit forth, slipped her true self away, and left a false corpse struck dead at the side of the mountain road.

The instant the Tang monk saw it, he tumbled in fright from his horse and lay down by the roadside; and without a single further word, he recited the Tight-Fillet spell — fully twenty times over. Poor Wukong —

his head was squeezed tight as a pinch-waisted gourd, and the pain was past all bearing. He came rolling forward and pleaded, "Master, stop the spell! Whatever you have to say, say it and be done." Said the Tang monk, "What is there to say? A man who has left the household life, whose ear hears words of good, falls not into Hell. I exhort and reform you so — how is it you do nothing but act with violence? You've beaten one innocent person to death, and now another! What account will you give of this?" Said Wukong, "She was a demon." Said the Tang monk, "This monkey talks nonsense — could there be so very many demons? You are a fellow with no heart turned toward good, a man with a will set on evil. Be gone!"

Said Wukong, "Master, you'd send me off again? Go back I will, if go I must — but there's one thing that doesn't sit right." Said the Tang monk, "What is it that doesn't sit right with you?" Bajie put in, "Master, he wants to divide the baggage with you. He's been a monk in your train these several years — he can't well go back empty-handed. Take a couple of those old worn-out tunics and broken hats out of the bundle and give them to him."

Hearing this, Wukong was so enraged he leapt and stamped. "You sharp-snouted clumsy lout! Old Monkey, all this while keeping faith with the gate of Buddha, has never harbored one hair's-breadth of envy, nor a covetous heart — how should I want to divide any baggage?" Said the Tang monk, "If you've no envy and no greed, then why do you not go?"

Said Wukong, "To tell you the truth, Master, and hide nothing — five hundred years ago, when old Monkey dwelt in the Water-Curtain Cave on the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit, in the full flower of my heroic prime, I subdued the demons of seventy-two caves and had under my hand forty-seven thousand lesser fiends. On my head I wore a cap of purple gold; on my body a robe of ochre yellow; round my waist a belt of

Lantian jade; on my feet cloud-treading boots; and in my hand the As-You-Will Gold-Banded Cudgel. I was truly somebody in my day. But since I passed through the chastening of my sins, shaved my head, and held fast to the upright gate of the monk, and followed you as your disciple, this gold fillet has been clamped upon my head. If I go back now, it would shame me to face the folk of my old home. Master, if you truly want none of me, then recite the Loose-Fillet spell, take this band off, hand it back to you — slip it onto someone else's head — and I'll be glad and content. That too would be a way to have followed you for a season. Surely there's that much human feeling left between us?"

The Tang monk said in great astonishment, "Wukong, at that time the Bodhisattva secretly gave me only the one scroll of the Tight-Fillet spell — there was never any Loose-Fillet spell at all." Said Wukong, "If there's no Loose-Fillet spell, then you'll have to take me along with you yet." The elder, again at his wits' end, said, "Get up, then. I'll forgive you this once more — but you must not act with violence again." Said Wukong, "I'll not dare. I'll not dare again." And once more he helped his master onto the horse, cut the path open, and they went forward.

Now the demon — it turned out Wukong's second blow had not slain her either. There in mid-air the monster heaped praises upon him without ceasing: "What a fine Monkey King! He has eyes indeed. Changed as I was, he still knew me. But these monks travel fast; if they pass this mountain and go forty miles down the western slope, they'll no longer be in my domain. And if some demon of another place should snatch him off, it would split the mouths of others laughing, and grind my own heart to pieces. I'll go down and toy with him once more."

Good demon — she pressed down her dark wind, and at the foot of the mountain shook her body and changed, becoming an old man. And truly he was:

White hair like Pengzu's, hoary beard outdoing the Star of Longevity. In his ears a chiming of jade chime-stones, in his eyes a flickering of golden stars. In his hand a dragon-headed staff, upon his body a crane-down cloak, light. Prayer-beads pinched between his fingers, his mouth reciting the "Namo" scripture.

When the Tang monk saw him from his horse, his heart was filled with delight. "Amitabha! The West is truly a land of blessing! That old fellow can scarce make his way up the road, yet for all that he still recites the scriptures." Said Bajie, "Master, don't praise so soon — this is the very root of disaster." Said the Tang monk, "How so the root of disaster?" Said Bajie, "Elder brother beat his daughter to death, and beat his old wife to death, and this is surely the old man himself come searching. If we blunder into his arms — Master, you'll have to pay with your life, on a capital charge; old Pig, as accomplice, will be sentenced to the army; and Sha Monk, for crying the orders, will be put to the post-stations. But elder brother will work some vanishing trick and slip away — and won't the three of us be left to carry the pot?"

Hearing this, Wukong said, "This blockhead, talking such nonsense, will only frighten the master! Let old Monkey go and have another look." He hid the cudgel close against his body, walked up, faced the monster, and called out, "Old sir, where are you bound? And how is it you walk the road and recite scriptures at one and the same time?" The demon misjudged her mark, taking the Great Sage for some ordinary fellow, and

answered, "Elder, ah — this old man's family has dwelt here for generations. All my life I have loved to do good, to feast monks, to read the scriptures and recite the Buddha's name. By fate I had no son, and begot only a single small daughter, for whom I took a son-in-law into the home. This morning she went to take food down to the fields — I fear she has fallen into a tiger's jaws. My old wife went first to look for her and has not come back either. I know nothing at all of where they've gone, and so this old man has come out on purpose to search. If indeed their lives have been cut down, there's no help for it; I'll only gather up their bones to carry home and bury them in the family graves."

Wukong laughed and said, "I'm the very grandsire of all tiger-makers — how is it you've got a ghost tucked up your sleeve, come to fool me? You may deceive everyone else, but you cannot deceive me. I know you for a demon." The demon was so struck dumb she could not say a word.

Wukong drew out the cudgel, and reasoned within himself: "If I don't strike her, she'll seem to have conjured a wind out of nothing; but if I do strike her, I fear the master will recite that certain spell." Then he thought again: "If I don't beat her to death, in some idle moment she'll seize her chance and snatch the master off — and then won't I have to fret and labor all over again to save him? Better to strike. But the moment I lay her dead with one blow, the master will set to reciting the spell. As the old saying goes, 'A tiger, however fierce, won't eat its own cubs.' I'll rely on clever speech and a nimble tongue to coax him round, and then it should be well enough."

Good Great Sage — he recited a spell and summoned the local Earth-God of that ward and the Mountain-God of that place, saying: "This demon has come three times to make sport of my master, and this time I mean to beat her to death. Stand witness for me there in mid-air, and let her not escape." The gods heard the command — who would dare disobey?

— and stationed themselves in the clouds to watch. Then where the Great Sage's cudgel fell, he struck the demon down and at last severed her spirit-light.

Upon his horse the Tang monk again shook and trembled with fright and could not speak. Beside him Bajie laughed: "Fine Wukong! He's gone clean mad — only half a day on the road, and he's beaten three people to death!" The Tang monk was just about to recite the spell when Wukong rushed up before the horse and cried, "Master, stop, stop! Come and look at her shape." And there it was — a heap of powdery white bones lying at the side of the road. The Tang monk said in great astonishment, "Wukong, this person has only just died — how is it she's turned into a heap of bones?"

Said Wukong, "She was a stiff corpse, a lurking spirit working its mischief, beguiling men and ruining their root here in this place. I've beaten her dead, and she has shown her true form. There's a line of writing on her spine: she's called the Lady White Bone." Hearing this, the Tang monk was indeed inclined to believe. But that could not stop Bajie from prodding at his side: "Master, his hand is heavy and his cudgel fierce. He's beaten the person dead, and only because he fears that certain spell of yours, he's deliberately worked a change upon the body into this shape to blind your eyes." The Tang monk, soft-eared as ever, believed him again, and once more set to reciting. Wukong, unable to bear the pain, knelt by the roadside and could only cry, "Stop, stop! Whatever you have to say, say it quickly and be done."

Said the Tang monk, "Monkey-head — is there still more to say? A man who does good is like the grass in a spring garden: you do not see it grow, yet day by day it gains. A man who does evil is like a whetstone: you do not see it wear, yet day by day it wastes away. Here in this wild waste and open country you've beaten three people to death in a row —

and still no one denounces you, there's no one to answer for it. But should we come into a city, into a place thronged with people and the smoke of hearths, and you take that mourning-staff of yours and in some moment past all telling of good from ill fall to beating people about and bring down a great calamity — how am I then to save my own skin? Be gone with you!"

Said Wukong, "Master, you wrong me unjustly. This creature was plainly a demon who truly had it in her heart to harm you. I beat her dead and rid you of the menace — yet you cannot see it, but believe instead the slanders and cold whispers of that blockhead, and drive me off time and again. As the old saying goes, 'A thing not done past three.' If I do not go now, I'm truly a base and shameless wretch. I'll go, I'll go — go I will and go I shall — only you'll have no one left under your hand." The Tang monk flared into wrath: "This insolent ape grows more lawless still! By your account, only you are a person — are Wuneng and Wujing, then, not people too?"

When the Great Sage heard him call those two "people," he could not hold back his grief and bitter sorrow, and said to the Tang monk, "Alas! In those days, when you came out from Chang'an, you had Liu Boqin to see you on your road. When you reached the Mountain of Two Frontiers and saved me out, I bowed and took you for my master. I have wound through ancient caves, plunged into deep forests, seized fiends and caught monsters, won Bajie, gained Sha Monk, and tasted a thousand bitter toils and ten thousand hardships. And today, in muddled foolishness behind a wakeful face, you only bid me go back. This is just as it is said: 'When the birds are gone, the bow is hung away; when the hare is dead, the hound is boiled!' Well, well, well — only there's that troublesome Tight-Fillet spell." Said the Tang monk, "I'll recite it no more." Said Wukong, "That's hard to promise. If you come to some place

of cruel demons and bitter trials and cannot win free, and Bajie and Sha Monk cannot save you, then in that hour you'll think of me, and you won't be able to keep yourself from reciting it again. Even a hundred thousand miles off, my head would ache. Better, if I'm only to come back to you in the end, that I never form the intention of leaving at all."

Seeing him talk on and on, the Tang monk grew angrier still and rolled from his saddle to the ground. He bade Sha Monk fetch paper and brush from the bundle, and there by the ravine drew water, ground ink upon a stone, and wrote out a writ of dismissal. Handing it to Wukong, he said, "Monkey-head, take this as proof: I'll not have you for my disciple any longer. If ever I see you again, may I sink into the Avici Hell."

Wukong hastily took the writ and said, "Master, no need to swear oaths. Old Monkey will go." He folded the paper and tucked it in his sleeve, then once more pleaded softly with the Tang monk: "Master, I have followed you for a season, and had the Bodhisattva's instruction besides. Today I am dismissed halfway, my work unfinished, my merit unwon. I beg you, sit, and receive a bow from me, and then I can go with an easy heart." But the Tang monk turned his back and would not heed him, muttering under his breath, "I am a good monk; I will not receive a bad man's courtesies."

Seeing that he would not relent, the Great Sage worked an out-of-body art: he plucked three hairs from the back of his head, blew upon them a breath of immortal air, and cried, "Change!" At once they became three more Wukongs, who together with his own self made four, surrounding the master on all sides to bow. The elder dodged left and right as he might, but could not escape, and so willy-nilly received a bow.

The Great Sage sprang up, shook his body, drew the hairs back in, and then gave his charge to Sha Monk: "Worthy brother, you are a good man.

Only take heed — guard against Bajie's mischief-making chatter, and on the road be more careful still. Should a demon some time seize the master, you must say that old Monkey is his chief disciple, for the bristly fiends of the West, hearing of my powers, will not dare harm him." Said the Tang monk, "I am a good monk; I will not so much as name a bad man like you. Be gone."

When the Great Sage saw that the elder, thrice over and twice again, would not turn his heart or change his mind, there was no help for it, and he went at last. See him now:

With tears held back he knocks his head, taking leave of the elder; with grief within he lingers, charging Sha Monk to heart. One toss of his head, and he wipes it on the grass before the slope; with both feet he kicks and overturns the vines upon the ground. Up to the sky, down to the earth, he wheels like a turning wheel; across the seas, over the hills — first in all the world. In a moment his shadow is gone from sight; in a flash he speeds back to the road of old.

Swallowing his anger, he took leave of his master, called up the somersault cloud, and went straight back to the Water-Curtain Cave on the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit. All alone he was, in misery and desolation — when suddenly a roar of water broke upon his ears.

Looking out from mid-air, the Great Sage saw that it was the sound of the great tide of the Eastern Ocean at the flood. At the sight of it, he thought once more of the Tang monk, and could not stop the tears from spilling down his cheeks. He stayed his cloud, halted his steps, and only after a long while went on his way.

In the end there is no knowing how this parting and reunion would turn — so listen to the telling in the next chapter.

Chapter 28: The Demons Gather at the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit

Now, though the Great Sage had been driven away by the Tang Monk, still he brooded and sighed without end. Soon he sighted the great Eastern Ocean, and he said, "It has been five hundred years since last I traveled this road!" And he beheld the sea-water:

Smoke and waves rolling, vast billows surging on.
The smoke and waves roll out to meet the River of
Heaven; the vast billows surge down to thread the
veins of earth. When the tide comes raging, the
waters flood the curving bays — when the tide
comes raging it roars like thunder through three
months of spring; when the waters flood the
curving bays it howls like a mad wind through nine
days of summer. The blessed elder riding his dragon
must furrow his brow as he passes; the immortal
lad astride his crane is troubled, sure enough, again
and again. Near the shore there is no village, no
hamlet; beside the water, few fishing boats. The
waves roll up a thousand years of snow; the wind
breeds autumn in the sixth month. Wild fowl come
and go as they please; sand-birds sink and float at
will. No angler stands before the eye; only the gull
is heard beside the ear. Below, the sea-creatures
sport in joy; at the sky's edge, the passing wild
goose grieves.

The pilgrim gave a great leap and bounded across the Eastern Ocean, and soon he came to the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit. Lowering his cloud, he opened his eyes wide and looked about — and upon that mountain there were no flowers, no grass; mist and rosy haze were utterly gone; the peaks and crags had collapsed, the woods and trees were scorched and withered. How had it come to such a pass? When he had made his great uproar in the Palace of Heaven and been hauled up to the upper realm, the mountain had been set ablaze and ruined by the Illustrious Sage Erlang at the head of his seven sworn brothers of Mei Mountain. The Great Sage grew doubly miserable. There is an old-style poem bearing witness to the ruined mountain's fallen scene:

I look back on my immortal hill, and tears fall down
in twin streams; facing the mountain I grow
wretched, and grieve the more. Once I thought no
harm could come to this mountain; only today do I
learn that even the earth can be undone. How I hate
Erlang, who wiped me out; how I rage at the petty
god who bullied my people. In his fury he dug up
the graves of your ancient spirits; for no cause he
broke open your ancestors' tombs. The rosy mist
that filled the sky is all dispersed; the wind and
clouds across the ground are scattered thin. On the
eastern ridge no striped tiger roars; on the western
hill where now is the white gibbon's cry? In the
northern gully no fox or hare leaves a track; in the
southern valley the deer and roebuck have left no
shadow. The blue stones are burnt to a thousand
clods of dirt; the emerald sands are turned to a
single heap of mud. Outside the cave the tall pines
all lean and topple; before the cliffs the kingfisher-
green cypress grows sparse. Cedar, fir, sophora,

juniper, chestnut, sandalwood — all scorched;
peach, apricot, plum, prune, pear, jujube — all gone.
The cudrania is dead, the mulberry gone — how
raise the silkworms now? Willows are thin, bamboo
is scant — hard for the birds to roost. The clever
stones of the peaks are turned to dust; the springs
at the ravine-bottom are dry, all overgrown with
weeds. Before the cliffs the soil is black, no orchid,
no iris; beside the road the mud is red, with creeper
and vine clinging. Where do the flying birds of
former days take wing? To what mountain did the
running beasts of that time flee? The leopard scorns
this ruined place, the python loathes it; the crane
shuns it, the snake turns back from the spoiled
land. Surely it was some evil thought of days gone
by that brought down such hardship before my eyes
today.

While the Great Sage was in the very depth of his grief, he heard from
before a fragrant grassy slope, within a hollow of creeping vetch, a
rustling sound — and out leaped seven or eight little monkeys, who
swarmed forward in a crowd, surrounded him, and knocked their heads

upon the ground. They cried aloud, "Great Sage, Grandfather, have you come home today?" The Handsome Monkey King said, "Why do you not frolic and play, but each of you hides and skulks out of sight? I have been here some while, yet saw no trace of you. Why?"

The monkey host, hearing this, each let fall his tears and reported: "Ever since the Great Sage was seized and hauled to the upper realm, we have suffered cruelly at the hunters' hands — truly past enduring. How could we withstand their stiff crossbows and strong bows, their fierce yellow hawks and wicked hounds, their snares and traps, their spears and hooks? And so, each cherishing his own life, none dared show his head to frolic; we only burrowed deep into the caves and fled far to our nests. When hungry, we crept to the slope-front to steal grass to eat; when thirsty, we went down to the ravine to sip the clear spring. Just now we heard the Great Sage Grandfather's voice, and so we came especially to meet you — and humbly beg your help and protection." Hearing these words, the Great Sage grew more wretched still. He asked, "How many of you are left upon this mountain?" The monkeys said, "Old and young together, there are but a thousand or so." The Great Sage said, "In my day I had a host of forty-seven thousand demons. Where have they all gone now?"

The monkeys said, "After Grandfather left, this mountain was set alight by Bodhisattva Erlang, and more than half of us were burned to death. We crouched in the wells, we crept into the ravines, we hid beneath the iron-plate bridge, and so we kept our lives. By the time the fire was out and the smoke gone and we came forth, there were no flowers or fruit to feed us and we could scarcely stay alive, so half of us went off elsewhere. We, this remaining half, have lived upon the mountain enduring our hardships. And these two years, the hunters have carried off half of us again."

The pilgrim said, "What do they want with you, that they carry you off?" The monkeys said, "Speak of these hunters and you will loathe them! Those of us they shoot with arrows or pierce with spears, or poison and beat to death, they take away to skin and bone us — stewed in sauce, steamed in vinegar, fried in oil, parched in salt — and eat us as a relish with their rice. And some of us they catch in nets or snares, taking us alive, and they make us jump through hoops and perform tricks, turn somersaults, stand on our heads — and in the streets, to the beating of gongs and the thumping of drums, they make us do every kind of antic for sport."

When the Great Sage heard this, he grew the more enraged, and said, "Who is in charge of affairs in the cave now?" The demons said, "Marshals Ma and Liu, and Generals Beng and Ba, still hold it." The Great Sage said, "Go and let them know I have come." Those little imps rushed in at the gate and reported, "The Great Sage Grandfather has come home!" When Ma, Liu, Beng, and Ba heard the report, they hurried out the gate, knocked their heads, and welcomed him into the cave. The Great Sage took his seat in the center, and the host of monsters bowed in rows before him and asked, "Great Sage Grandfather, of late we heard you had kept your life and were guarding the Tang Monk on his journey to the Western Heaven to fetch scriptures. How is it you do not journey westward, but have come back to your own mountain?"

The Great Sage said, "Little ones, you do not know. That Tang Tripitaka could not tell the worthy from the worthless. All along the road I caught fiends and seized demons for him, spending the whole skill of my life — time and again I slew the monsters; yet he said I was committing violence and doing evil, and would not have me for a disciple. He drove me back home and wrote out a writ of dismissal as proof, vowing never to use me again."

The monkeys clapped their hands and laughed aloud. "What luck, what luck! Why be a monk? Just come home, and let us frolic together for a few years." They called, "Quick, set out the coconut wine to wash the dust from Grandfather's journey!" The Great Sage said, "Hold off the wine a moment. Let me ask you first — these hunters, how often do they come up my mountain?" Ma and Liu said, "Great Sage, no matter the season, they pester us here day after day." The Great Sage said, "Why have they not come today?" Ma and Liu said, "They should be coming presently." The Great Sage gave his orders: "Little ones, all of you go out and gather for me those crumbled stones on the mountain that the fire baked brittle, and pile them in heaps — twenty or thirty pushed into one pile, or fifty or sixty heaped together — I have a use for them." The little monkeys came on all at once, a whole swarm of them, and in wild confusion gathered many heaps. The Great Sage looked them over and said, "Little ones, all of you go hide inside the cave, and let me work my magic."

The Great Sage climbed to the mountain summit and watched. From the southern half of the slope came the boom-boom of drums and the clang-clang of gongs, and there flashed into view over a thousand men and horses, all bearing hawks and hounds, gripping swords and spears. The Monkey King looked closely at how fierce and dangerous these men came on — fine, valiant fellows, truly bold and brave. Behold:

Fox-fur covering shoulder and crown, brocade silk wrapping waist and breast. In their quivers, wolf-fang arrows; at their hips, jewel-carved bows hung. The men like mountain-searching tigers, their horses like ravine-leaping dragons. In packs they lead their hounds; on every arm a hawk is perched. Wicker baskets bearing fire-bombs, and Sea-East Falcons set in place. A hundred-odd loads of birdlime-poles, a thousand hare-forks besides. Ox-headed nets to bar the road, and Yama-knot nooses of cord. All at once they raise a wild halloo, scattering out like stars across the sky.

When the Great Sage saw these men spreading up his mountain, his heart filled with great wrath. With his hand he made a magic sign, in his mouth he muttered a spell, and toward the southeast he drew in a long breath of air; then, with a whoosh, he blew it out, and it became a furious gale. A fine wind! Behold:

Raising dust and flinging earth, toppling trees and snapping the woods. The sea-waves rose like mountains up; turbid billows piled ten thousand fold and overran. Heaven and earth went dim and reeling; sun and moon turned dark and sunk in gloom. One blast that shook the pines roared like a tiger; then, suddenly, into the bamboo, it sang like a dragon. Ten thousand crevices howled in rage — the sky's own breath let go — while flying sand and rolling stones wounded men at random.

The Great Sage raised this great wind, and on the wind he sent the crumbled stones flying and whirling in chaos. Pity those thousand-odd men and horses, every one of them —

Stones struck the crow-heads to powder; sand flew,
and the sea-horses were all hurt. The ginseng and
the cassia rushed before the ridge; their blood dyed
the cinnabar ground. The aconite could not return
to its native place; how should the betel-nut find its
way home? Their corpses, light as light-powder, lay
on the mountain field, while the rouge-girl at home
looked out and waited.

And there was a poem that said:

The men dead, the horses dead — how shall they go
home? Wild ghosts and lonely souls in confusion
thick as hemp. Pity these brave and bristling
captains, these valiant lords — who could not tell
the worthy from the worthless: their blood dyes the
sand.

The Great Sage lowered his cloud and clapped his hands, laughing aloud.
"What luck, what luck! Ever since I submitted to the Tang Monk and
took the tonsure, he was forever counseling me — 'A thousand days of
doing good, and the good is still not enough; a single day of doing evil,

and the evil is more than enough.' Truly there is such a saying. While I followed him I slew a few monsters, and he blamed me for committing violence. Yet today I come home, and I have finished off this whole crowd of hunters!" He called out, "Little ones, come out!" The monkey host, now that the gale had passed, heard the Great Sage's call and each came leaping forth. The Great Sage said, "Go to the foot of the south mountain and strip the clothes from the hunters who were killed; bring them home, wash off the bloodstains, and put them on against the cold. Push the dead men's corpses into the bottomless pool, ten thousand fathoms deep. Drag the fallen horses here, flay off their hides to make boots, and salt down the flesh to eat at leisure. Take those bows and arrows, spears and swords, and use them to drill yourselves in the martial arts. And gather up those many-colored banners and standards and bring them for my use." The monkeys each gave their assent.

The Great Sage took the banners apart, washed them, and pieced them into a single banner of mingled colors and flowers, on which he wrote fourteen characters: "Rebuilder of the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit, Restorer of the Water-Curtain Cave, Great Sage Equal to Heaven." He raised a pole and hung the banner outside the cave. Day by day he summoned fiends and gathered beasts, stored up fodder and hoarded grain, and never again spoke the two words "the monk." His fellowship was great and his arts were high; he went to the Dragon Kings of the Four Seas to borrow sweet, life-giving immortal water, and washed the mountain green again. In front he planted elm and willow; behind, pine and nan-wood; peach, plum, jujube, and prune — nothing was lacking. Carefree and at ease, joyful in his work and settled in his dwelling — but of this no more.

Now we tell of the Tang Monk. Having listened to crafty counsel and given free rein to the banishment of the Mind-Monkey, he climbed into

the saddle and urged his horse forward. Zhu Bajie opened the road ahead while Sha Monk shouldered the luggage and they went westward. They crossed the White Tiger Ridge and suddenly came upon a stretch of wooded hills — truly a place of clinging vines and twining creepers, of kingfisher cypress and green pine. Tripitaka called out, "Disciples, the mountain road is rugged and hard to travel, the pine forest thick and clustered, the trees dense and crowded. We must be very careful, for I fear there may be fiends and savage beasts." Look at that simpleton — he braced up his spirits, told Sha Monk to lead the horse, and himself used his nine-toothed rake to open the way, guiding the Tang Monk straight into the pine wood. As they were going along, the elder reined in his horse and said, "Bajie, I am truly hungry this day. Where can I find some vegetarian food to eat?" Bajie said, "Master, please dismount and wait here; let old Hog go and search." The elder got down from his horse, Sha Monk set down his load, took out the alms-bowl, and handed it to Bajie. Bajie said, "I'm off." The elder asked, "Where are you going?" Bajie said, "Never mind. This trip of mine — I'll bore through ice to fetch fire and find a vegetarian meal; I'll press snow to seek oil and beg up some rice."

Look at him: he came out of the pine wood and went westward more than ten li, yet never came upon a single house — truly a place where there were wolves and tigers but no curl of human smoke. The simpleton, footsore and weary, mused to himself, "In the years when pilgrim Sun was about, whatever the old monk wanted he had at once; today the burden has fallen to my lot. Truly, as the saying goes, 'Only the householder knows the price of firewood and rice; only the parent knows the grace of bearing a child.' And there is nowhere at all to beg." Then drowsiness came over him and he thought, "If I go straight back now and tell the old monk there was nowhere to beg, he won't believe I walked all this long way. I had better dawdle another hour or two, then go back and report. Well then — let me just have a sleep here in this thicket." So the

simpleton tucked his head down into the grass and lay down. He meant only to drowse a little and then get up — but how should one who is footsore from the road do otherwise? Once his head went down, he only snored on and on.

Let us say no more of Bajie sleeping there. We tell instead of the elder waiting in the wood, his ears growing hot and his eyes twitching, his body and mind ill at ease. He turned and called to Sha Monk: "Wukong went to beg for food — why has he not returned even at this late hour?" Sha Monk said, "Master, you still don't understand him. He saw that households hereabouts are generous to monks, and his belly is large besides — what does he care about you? He'll come back only when he has eaten his fill." Tripitaka said, "Just so. But if he is over there gorging on alms-food, where shall we find him? The day grows late and this is no place to stay the night. We must find lodging — that would be best." Sha Monk said, "No great matter, Master. You sit here, and let me go find him." Tripitaka said, "Just so, just so. Food or no food, let it be — only finding lodging is what matters." Sha Monk took up his treasure-staff and went straight out of the pine wood to look for Bajie.

The elder sat alone in the wood, utterly bored and weary. He could only force up his spirits, leap to his feet, gather the luggage into one place, and tie the horse to a tree. He took off his broad-brimmed hat, planted his pewter staff upright, smoothed his black monk's robe, and strolled at a slow pace through the secluded wood to dispel his gloom. He gazed over the wild grasses and mountain flowers, but could not bear the clamor of birds returning to roost. The forest was all deep grass and narrow paths, and because his thoughts were tangled and troubled, he took the wrong way. He had set out, first, to ease his cares, and second, to find Bajie and Sha Monk; but the two of them had gone by the straight westward road, while the elder, after wandering a while, drifted off

toward the south instead. Coming out of the pine wood, he suddenly raised his head and saw, off in that quarter, a golden light flashing and shimmering, brilliant vapors rising in clouds. Looking closely, he found it was a precious pagoda, its golden summit shining — the light of the setting sun glancing off that gilded roof and making it glow. He said, "Your disciple has no good fortune indeed. Ever since I left the land of the east, I made a vow: at every temple to burn incense, at the sight of every Buddha to bow, at every pagoda to sweep the stones. Is that shining thing not a precious pagoda of yellow gold? How is it I did not take that road? Below the pagoda there must be a monastery, and in the monastery there must be monks. Let me walk over. As for the luggage and the white horse — I reckon no one travels through this place, so all will be well. If there is a convenient lodging there, I'll wait for the disciples to come and we'll rest together."

Alas! The elder's ill luck had come upon him at last. Look at him: he strode off and came straight to the pagoda. But behold what he saw:

Stone cliffs ten thousand fathoms high, a mountain so vast it touches the blue empyrean. Its roots run deep into the thick earth, its peaks thrust up to the very height of heaven. On either side, some thousands of assorted trees; before and behind, a hundred li and more of twining vines. Flowers mirrored on the grass-tips, the wind casting shadows; water flowing in the cloudy hollow, the moon without root. Fallen timber lies across the deep ravine; withered creepers hang knotted upon the bright peak. Beneath the stone bridge, a clear spring rolls and rolls; upon the terrace-seat, white powder glows ever bright. Seen from afar, it is like the heavenly halls of the Three Isles; seen up close, it is like the fairy realm of Penglai. Fragrant pines and purple bamboo ring the mountain stream; crows and magpies, gibbons and monkeys, thread the steep ridges. Outside the cave-gate, running beasts come and go in rows; within the woods, flying birds emerge and enter in flocks. The green,

green fragrant grasses are fair; the bright, bright wild flowers are in bloom. This place is plainly an evil ground — and the elder, in his ill luck, came blundering up to it.

The elder stepped forward, and when he had come right beneath the pagoda gate, he saw a mottled-bamboo screen hanging within. He pressed in at the door, lifted the screen, and went inside. Lifting his head abruptly, he saw upon a stone couch a fiend lying asleep on his side. What manner of thing did he look like?

A face of indigo-blue, white fangs jutting, one great mouth gaping wide. On either side, tangled, bushy temple-locks, all of them dyed the color of rouge; three or four towering purple whiskers, like lychee-shoots standing in a row. A parrot-beak of a nose, arching upward; eyes like the dawn-star, glittering cold. His two fists like a monk's alms-bowls; his two blue feet like gnarled stumps on a cliff's edge. Slung aslant, a pale-yellow robe and curtain, finer than a brocaded cassock. The blade he carried gleamed with cold light; the stone he slept on was smooth and flawless. He had marshaled his little imps in their ant-ranks; he had sat as old fiend in his wasp-court. Look at him — awe-inspiring and stern, all crying out together, calling him "Lord." He had drunk wine with the moon, making three men of one; he had felt the breeze beneath both arms as he tipped his cup of tea. Look at him — his spirit-powers are vast indeed: with a single blink, he roams the ends of the earth. In the wild forest the

small birds clamor; in the deep thicket lodge the dragon and the snake. Where the immortal lads till the fields, white jade is born; where the Daoists tend the fire, cinnabar is nourished. His little cave-gate, though it cannot reach the Avici Hell, houses a hulking fiend — none other than an Ox-Headed Yaksha.

When the elder saw what manner of thing lay before him, he was so frightened that he started backward a full step. His whole body went numb and tingling, his legs went weak and soft, and he hastily turned to flee. But he had barely turned around when the fiend — whose spirit-sense was truly powerful — flung wide a pair of golden, gleaming demon-eyes and called out, "Little ones, look outside the door — who is that?" One of the little imps stuck out his head, peered beyond the door, and saw a bald-headed elder. He ran straight in to report: "Great King, there's a monk outside. Round-headed and full-faced, with two ears hanging to his shoulders, a body of tender smooth flesh and a fine delicate skin — a very fine monk indeed." Hearing this, the fiend gave a roar of laughter and said, "This is what's called 'a fly on a snake's head — food and clothing that comes of its own accord.' Little ones, hurry after him at once and seize him for me. There'll be a rich reward for you." Those little imps swarmed forward all at once, a whole nest of them. When Tripitaka saw them coming, though his heart was as frantic as an arrow and his feet ran as if flying, in the end his courage failed, his legs went weak and his feet went numb; and besides, the mountain road was

rugged, the forest deep, the day far gone — how could he move a step? The little imps hoisted him up bodily and carried him off. Truly it was:

When the dragon swims in shallow water, the
shrimps make sport of him; when the tiger comes
down to the level plain, the dogs do him insult.
Even though good deeds meet many a trial and
barrier — who ever met them as the Tang Monk did,
journeying toward the west?

Those little imps carried the elder up, set him down outside the bamboo screen, and reported in great delight, "Great King, we've caught the monk and brought him in." The old fiend stole a glance at him and saw that Tripitaka held his head erect, his bearing majestic — a fine monk indeed. He thought to himself, "So fine a monk as this must be a personage from the upper realm; he is no trifling sort. If I don't put on a show of power, he will never yield and submit." Then all at once, like a fox borrowing the tiger's might, he bristled his red whiskers upright, his blood-red hair stood toward the sky, his eyeballs nearly burst from their sockets, and with a great roar he cried, "Bring that monk in!" The fiends all answered with a ringing cry and shoved Tripitaka straight inside. This was a case of "Under another's low eaves, how dare one not bow the head?" Tripitaka could only press his palms together and pay his respects. The fiend said, "What place are you a monk of? Where do you come from? Where are you going? Speak plainly, and be quick!" Tripitaka said, "I am a monk of the Tang court. By the command of the Great Tang Emperor, I am going to the West to seek out the scriptures and gathas. Passing your

honorable mountain, I came especially to the pagoda to pay homage to the holy one, never thinking to disturb your majesty. I beg you to forgive my offense. When I have fetched the scriptures from the west and returned to the land of the east, your high name will be recorded forever." Hearing this, the fiend gave a great "Ho, ho, ho" of laughter and said, "I said you were a personage of the upper kingdom — and so you are. I was just wanting to eat someone, and you've come along most conveniently! Otherwise, wouldn't I have let you slip by for nothing? You're meant to be food in my mouth: naturally you'd come crashing in, and now, even if I'd wanted to let you go, you couldn't get away; even if you ran, you couldn't escape!" He called to the little imps, "Take that monk away and tie him up." Sure enough, those little imps swarmed forward, wound the elder round with rope and cord, and bound him to the Soul-Fixing Stake.

The old fiend, gripping his blade, asked again, "Monk, how many are there in your party? Surely you didn't dare go up to the Western Heaven all alone?" Seeing him holding the blade, Tripitaka spoke honestly: "Great King, I have two disciples, called Zhu Bajie and Sha Monk; they have both gone into the pine wood to beg for food. There is also a load of luggage and a white horse, both left in the pine wood." The old fiend said, "Better luck still! Two disciples and you — that's three — and the horse makes four: enough for a single meal." The little imps cried, "Let us go and catch them." The old fiend said, "Don't go out — shut the front gate. When those two have begged their food, they'll surely look for their master to eat with them; and not finding him, they'll surely come looking right up to my gate. As the saying goes, 'The trade that comes to your door is the easy trade to do.' We'll catch them at our leisure." So the little imps shut the front gate.

Let us say no more of Tripitaka meeting calamity. We tell rather of Sha Monk, who had come out of the wood to look for Bajie. He went a good ten li or more and never saw a hamlet or a village. He stood on a high mound, gazing about, when he heard the sound of a man's voice in the grass. Quickly he parted the deep growth with his staff and looked — and there was the simpleton, talking in his sleep. Sha Monk grabbed him by the ear and at last woke him, saying, "You fine simpleton! The master sent you to beg for food — did he give you leave to sleep here?" The simpleton woke in a fluster and said, "Brother, what time is it?" Sha Monk said, "Get up quick. The master says food or no food it is all one — he has told you and me to go and find lodging."

The simpleton, all dazed and muddled, hefted the alms-bowl, gripped his rake, and went straight back with Sha Monk. When they reached the wood and looked, the master was gone. Sha Monk grumbled, "It's all your fault, you simpleton — you failed to beg up any food, and now a fiend must have carried off the master!" Bajie laughed and said, "Brother, don't talk nonsense. That wood is a clean and elegant sort of place; there is certainly no fiend there. I expect the old monk couldn't sit still and went off somewhere to take the air. Let us go and look for him." So the two of them could only lead the horse, shoulder the load, gather up the broad hat and pewter staff, and go out of the pine wood to search for their master.

This time, too, it was not the Tang Monk's fate to die. When the two of them had searched a while without finding him, they suddenly saw, off to the south, a golden light flashing and shimmering. Bajie said, "Brother, the lucky are simply lucky. Look — the master has gone off to their house. That shining thing is a precious pagoda; who would dare neglect him there? They are surely setting out vegetarian food and keeping him to enjoy it. We had better get a move on and catch up to have a bit of the

meal." Sha Monk said, "Brother, there's no telling good fortune from ill. Let us just go and have a look."

The two of them, bold and bristling, came up to the gate. It was shut. Set crosswise above it was a slab of white jade, on which were carved six great characters: "Moon-Wave Cave of Bowl-Hill Mountain." Sha Monk said, "Brother, this is no temple — it is a fiend's cave-dwelling. If our master is here, he won't be a pretty sight." Bajie said, "Brother, don't be afraid. You tie up the horse and guard the luggage, and let me go and ask after him." The simpleton lifted his rake, went forward, and shouted, "Open the gate! Open the gate!" The little imp keeping the gate inside opened it, and at the sudden sight of the two monks he hastily drew back and ran to report, "Great King, trade has come to your door!" The old fiend said, "What trade?" The little imp said, "Outside the cave-gate there's a long-snouted, big-eared monk and an ill-luck-colored monk, come hammering away." The old fiend said in great delight, "That's Zhu Bajie and Sha Monk come searching for their master. So he can search, after all! How did he track me right to my gate? Their faces are fierce and unruly — take care not to slight them." He called, "Bring my armor!" The little imps brought it, he put it on, gripped his blade in his hand, and went straight out the gate.

Now we tell how Bajie and Sha Monk were waiting before the gate when they saw the fiend come on, fierce and dangerous. Do you ask how he was arrayed?

A green face, red whiskers, scarlet hair flying;
golden armor and mail, gleaming and bright. A
belly-wrap lining his waist, a stone-studded belt; a
chest-guard lashing his armor, a cloud-walking cord.
Idle, he stood before the mountain — the wind
howled and howled; moody, he roamed beyond the
sea — the waves surged and surged. A pair of
indigo-blue, scorched-sinewed hands gripping fast
the soul-chasing, life-taking blade. Would you know
this creature's name and surname? Sound out the
two words, and call him Yellow Robe.

The old fiend Yellow Robe came out the gate and demanded, "What region's monks are you, shouting at my door?" Bajie said, "My son, don't you know me? I am your venerable lord. I am sent by the Great Tang to the Western Heaven. My master is the imperial brother Tripitaka. If he is inside your house, send him out at once and spare yourself a raking!" The monster laughed and said, "Yes, yes, yes — there is a Tang Monk in my house, and I have not slighted him in the least; I laid out some buns of human flesh for him to eat. Why don't you come in and have one too — how about it?"

The simpleton actually meant to go in. Sha Monk grabbed him and pulled him back, saying, "Brother, he is tricking you. Since when do you eat human flesh?" Then the simpleton came to his senses, whipped out

his rake, and aimed a blow straight at the monster's face; the monster dodged aside and brought up his steel blade to parry and meet him. The two of them leaped onto cloud-heads and battled it out in mid-air, each displaying his spirit-powers. Sha Monk threw down the luggage and the white horse, raised his treasure-staff, and rushed in haste to join the attack. At that moment two fierce monks and one foul fiend fought a fine battle up in the clouds. Truly it was:

The staff rose, the blade met it; the rake came, the blade parried. One demon-general showed his might; two divine monks displayed their transformations. The nine-tooth rake was a hero indeed; the fiend-quelling staff was fierce and terrible too. Front and back, left and right, they came on all at once, yet Yellow Robe was plainly unafraid. Look at him — his dipped steel blade flashed bright as silver; truly his spirit-powers, too, were vast and wide. They fought till the whole sky was wreathed in fog and lost in cloud, and halfway up the mountain the cliffs crumbled and the ridges cracked. One fought for his fame, and would by no means give over; one fought for his master, and was utterly without fear.

The three of them went back and forth in mid-air, and after they had fought several tens of rounds, neither side could be told victor from vanquished. Each held his own life dear, and it was truly hard to disengage and hard to part.

In the end we know not how the Tang Monk was to be rescued; so listen to the next chapter for the explanation.

Chapter 29: A Letter Carried Out of Sorrow, and a Monk Who Plays the Tiger

A poem says:

Vain thoughts need no violent suppression; for the True Suchness, why must we strive and seek? The Buddha-nature, our own root, is cultivated before the Buddha — and how should delusion and awakening stand in any order of before and after? Awaken, and in an instant you are made upright; stay deluded, and through ten thousand kalpas you sink in the stream. If a single thought can join itself to true cultivation, the sins and stains as countless as the Ganges sands are wiped away.

Now then. Zhu Bajie and Sha Monk had fought the fiend for some thirty rounds, and still neither side had the better of it. Do you ask why neither could win? If it came to a true contest of skill, then never mind two monks — even twenty of them could not have stood against that demon. It was only because the Tang Monk's allotted span had not yet run out that in secret the Dharma-guarding spirits watched over him; and in the air above, the Six Dings and Six Jias, the Guardians of the Five Quarters,

the Four Sentinels of the Watches, and the eighteen Protectors of the Faith lent their strength to Bajie and Sha Monk.

But let us leave the three of them at their battle.

Inside the cave the elder wept and grieved, thinking of his disciples, tears running freely from his eyes. "Wuneng," he mourned, "in what village have you fallen in with good friends, lingering greedy over their offerings of food? And you, Wujing — you cannot know where to look for him; will you ever find each other? Little do you dream that I have met with a demon and suffer captivity here. When will I see you again, shake off this great peril, and reach the Spirit Mountain at last?"

In the very midst of his sorrow and distress, he saw a woman come out from within the cave. Steadying herself against the Soul-Fixing Post, she called, "Elder, where have you come from? Why has he bound you here?" Hearing her, the elder peered up through his tears and saw that she was a woman of perhaps thirty years. He answered, "Lady Bodhisattva, there is no need to ask. I am one already doomed to die — I walked in at your gate. If you mean to eat me, then eat me and have done; why ask anything more?"

"I am no eater of men," said the woman. "My home lies more than three hundred li to the west of this place. There stands a city called the Kingdom of Precious Image. I am that king's third princess; my milk-name is Hundred-Flowers Shame. Thirteen years ago, on the night of the fifteenth of the eighth month, while I was out enjoying the moon, this demon swept me up in a gust of wild wind and carried me here. For thirteen years I have been his wife, bearing his children in this place, and not a word of mine has ever gone back to the court. I think of my father and mother, and I cannot see them. From where have you come, that he should have seized you?"

"This poor monk," said Tripitaka, "was sent westward to fetch the scriptures. As I idled along the road I blundered in here by mistake. Now he means to capture my two disciples as well, and steam the whole lot of us to eat."

The princess gave a coaxing smile. "Be easy of heart, elder. Since you are one bound for the scriptures, I can save you. The Kingdom of Precious Image lies along the great road you must take to the West. Carry a letter there for me, and pay my respects to my father and mother — and I will see to it that he spares you."

Tripitaka nodded. "Lady Bodhisattva, if you will but save this poor monk's life, I will gladly be your bearer of letters."

The princess turned quickly to the inner rooms and wrote out a letter home, sealing it fast. Coming back to the post, she loosed the Tang Monk's bonds and put the letter into his hands. Freed at last, he held it up and said, "Lady Bodhisattva, I thank you a thousand times for the gift of my life. On my journey, when I pass through your honored land, I will surely deliver this to the king. But I fear that after so long a span of years your parents may refuse to believe me for what I am — what then? Do not blame this poor monk if he should have to tell a small untruth."

"Have no fear," said the princess. "My royal father has no son; he begot only us three sisters. If he sees this letter, he is bound to wish to look upon you."

Tripitaka tucked the letter snugly into his sleeve, thanked the princess, and made to leave by the front gate. But the princess caught hold of him. "You cannot go out the front way. All the fiends, great and small, are out before the gate waving banners and shouting their war-cries, beating drums and clashing gongs to back up their king against your disciples. Go out by the back gate instead. If the king himself seizes you, at least he

will question you first; but I fear the little fiends might catch you and, not knowing good from ill, snatch and tear at you and take your life. Let me go before him and put in a word to smooth the way. Once the king has let you go, wait for some sign from your disciples, then find them and the lot of you can make off together."

Hearing this, Tripitaka knocked his head to the ground in thanks, did exactly as he was bidden, took his leave of the princess, slipped out beyond the back gate, and dared not move on alone, but hid himself among the thorn-brakes.

Now the princess had hatched her clever scheme. She hurried out before the gate and pushed her way through the throng of fiends. From above came the clang and clatter of clashing weapons — for it was Bajie and Sha Monk still locked in combat with the fiend in mid-air. The princess cried out in a piercing voice: "Lord Yellow Robe!"

When the demon king heard the princess call, he flung Bajie and Sha Monk aside, dropped down upon his cloud, gripped his steel blade, and took the princess by the arm. "Wife, what is it you wish to say?"

"My lord," she said, "just now I lay asleep within my gauze curtains, and in a dream I suddenly saw a spirit in golden armor."

"What spirit in golden armor?" the demon asked. "And what did he want at our gate?"

"In my girlhood, while I was still in the palace," she said, "I privately made a certain vow in my heart: that if ever I were matched with a worthy son-in-law as my husband, I would climb the famous mountains, worship at the immortals' shrines, feed the monks and give alms. From the day I was wedded to you, in all our husband-and-wife happiness, I have never once spoken of it. That golden-armored spirit came to claim

the unkept vow and bawled at me till I woke — but it was only an idle dream after all. So I dressed myself in haste and came to tell my lord of it, and never thought to find a monk bound to that post. I beg my lord's mercy: out of regard for my poor wishes, spare that monk, and let it count as my feeding of the monks in fulfilment of the vow. Will my lord consent?"

"Wife," said the fiend, "you fret over nothing at all. What weighty matter is this? If I want to eat men, where can I not scoop up a few? What is a single monk worth? Let him go."

"My lord," said the princess, "let him out by the back gate."

"What a bother you make of it," said the demon. "If he is to be let go, then let him go — why fuss over back gate or front gate?" Then, taking up his steel blade, he called aloud, "You, Zhu Bajie — come here! It is not that I fear you, or will not fight you; but out of regard for my wife I spare your master. Go quickly to the back gate, find him there, and be off to the West. But if ever you come trespassing on my borders again, there will be no mercy at all."

When Bajie and Sha Monk heard these words, it was as though they had been turned back from the very gate of the dead. In all haste they led the horse, took up the luggage, and scurried off like rats. Rounding the back gate of the Wave-Moon Cave, they called, "Master!" The elder knew their voices and answered from among the thorns. Sha Monk cut a path through the grass, helped his master up, and hurriedly got him onto the horse. As it is said here:

Cruel and dire, he nearly fell to the blue-faced ghouls; but tender of heart, by good fortune, was Hundred-Flowers Shame. The great fish has slipped the golden hook and line — tail lashing, head tossing, it rides away upon the waves.

Bajie took the lead at the front, Sha Monk followed behind, and they came out of the pine forest onto the high road. You should have seen the two of them grumbling and grouching, complaining back and forth, while Tripitaka could only smooth things over between them. At nightfall they sought lodging; at cockcrow they were up to read the sky. Stage by stage, past long pavilions and short, before they knew it they had covered two hundred and ninety-nine li. Then, lifting their heads with a start, they saw a splendid city before them — and it was the Kingdom of Precious Image. Truly a fine place it was:

Clouds hang dim and far, the road stretches long;
though the land lies a thousand li off, its scenes are
bounty enough. Auspicious vapors and lucky mists
enfold it round, clear winds and a bright moon
beckon and sway. The towering, jagged far-off
mountains spread out like a painted scroll; the
babbling, gurgling running streams scatter their
crushed jade and gems. Land fit for the plow runs
ridge on ridge, furrow on furrow; grain enough for
the table—thick green sprouts and fresh young
shoots. Anglers at their lines, a few households
along the three winding ravines; woodcutters
gathering fuel, one load between two pepper-
crowned peaks. Outworks where outworks should
be, walls where walls should rise— its moat of
metal and water stands firm and unbreached; home
set beside home, household by household, each
contending only in carefree ease. Nine-tiered lofty
towers, grand as palace halls; terraces ten thousand
fathoms high, like banners of brocade. There are the

Supreme Ultimate Hall, the Flowery Canopy Hall, the Incense-Burning Hall, the Hall of Letters, the Hall of Proclaiming Government, the Hall of Prolonged Brilliance— hall after hall with jade steps and golden stairs, ranked with civil caps and martial helms. There are the Great Brightness Palace, the Bright-Sun Palace, the Palace of Lasting Joy, the Flowery Purity Palace, the Establishing-the-Calendar Palace, the Endless Palace— palace after palace with bells and drums, pipes and flutes, that wash away the boudoir's sorrows and the griefs of spring. In the forbidden gardens, dewy blossoms match against tender cheeks; along the royal moat, willows in the wind dance with slender waists. On the great thoroughfares ride men in coronet and girdle, stately of mien, mounted behind five horses; in the lonely byways stand men with bow and arrows, parting the clouds and mist to skewer a brace of eagles. Lanes of flowers and willows, towers of strings and pipes— the spring breeze

yields nothing to the Bridge of Luoyang. The scripture-seeking elder, looking back toward the Great Tang, felt his very liver and gall break with longing; the disciples who shared their master's road, resting their burdens at the little post-station, found their dreaming souls dissolve away.

The scenery of the Kingdom of Precious Image was more than the eye could take in. The three of them, master and disciples, put away their baggage and horse and settled to rest at the post-house.

Then the Tang Monk walked on foot to the gate of the court and said to the usher at the palace gate, "There is a monk of the Tang court who has come expressly to seek audience with His Majesty and to have his travel-document countersigned. I beg you to convey this request within."

The Yellow-Gate officer of audiences hurried to the foot of the white-jade steps and reported, "Your Majesty, there is an eminent monk of the Tang court who wishes to see Your Majesty and have his travel-document renewed." When the king learned that the man had come from the great country of Tang, and that he was moreover a holy monk from afar, he was greatly pleased and at once granted the audience. "Bid him enter," he commanded. So Tripitaka was ushered up to the golden steps, where he completed the rites of dancing obeisance and cried out the royal acclamations. The civil and military officers ranged on either side could not help sighing among themselves, "What manner of man comes from the upper realm—how easy and gracious his ceremony and decorum!"

"Elder," said the king, "on what business do you come into my kingdom?"

"This humble monk," said Tripitaka, "is a follower of Sakyamuni from the Tang court. By the sacred decree of my Son of Heaven I am bound for the West to fetch the scriptures. I carry a travel-document with me, and upon reaching Your Majesty's noble land it is only fitting that I have it countersigned. Not knowing how I ought to advance or withdraw, I have presumed to disturb the dragon countenance."

"Since you have a travel-document from the Tang Son of Heaven," said the king, "bring it up that I may see it."

Tripitaka raised it in both hands, unrolled it, and laid it upon the royal table. The document read:

The Tang Son of Heaven of the Great Tang Kingdom in the Southern Jambudvipa Continent, in obedience to Heaven and in keeping with the cycle of fortune, issues this passport for travel: We humbly consider that We, of meager virtue, have inherited the great foundation. In serving the spirits and governing the people, We have walked as on the edge of an abyss, as upon thin ice, dreading it morning and night. Some while ago, having failed to save the Old Dragon of the Jing River, We were reproached before Our August Sovereign of the Heavenly Court; Our three souls and seven spirits departed in a moment to the shades below, and We were already become a wanderer in the realm of impermanence. But because Our earthly span was not yet spent, We were moved by the lord of the underworld to be released and restored to life. Thereupon We spread abroad great assemblies of merit and built up a Mass for the deliverance of the dead. By grace there appeared the golden body of

the Bodhisattva Guanshiyin, Saviour from Suffering, who pointed out that in the West there is a Buddha and there are scriptures, able to ferry over the souls in darkness and release the lonely ghosts. We have therefore specially charged the Dharma-master Xuanzang to journey afar across a thousand mountains and seek out the scriptures and gathas. Should he come to the various kingdoms of the western lands, let them not cut off this bond of goodness, but pass him on according to this document. Such are its necessary contents. On an auspicious autumn day in the thirteenth year of the Zhenguan reign of the Great Tang. The travel-document of the Imperial Presence. (Above it were stamped nine precious seals.)

When the king had read it, he took out his own kingdom's jade seal, set his royal cipher to it, and handed it back to Tripitaka.

Tripitaka gave thanks for the favor, received his document, and then made a further request: "This poor monk comes, firstly, to have his document countersigned; and secondly, he bears a letter from home to Your Majesty."

The king was overjoyed. "What letter is this?"

"Your Majesty's third princess," said Tripitaka, "was carried off by the Yellow-Robe fiend of the Wave-Moon Cave on Bowl-Top Mountain. This poor monk chanced to meet her, and so she has sent a letter."

At these words the king's eyes brimmed over with tears. "For thirteen years," he said, "since the princess was lost, there is no counting how many civil and military officers I have demoted and dismissed, no counting how many maidservants and eunuchs, within the palace and without, great and small, I have had beaten to death. They could only say that she had walked out of the palace, lost her way, and that there was nowhere to seek her. We questioned the common households throughout the whole city without number, and still there was no trace. Who could have known a demon had carried her off? Hearing these words now, all at once, my heart is wrung, and I cannot hold back my tears."

Tripitaka drew the letter from his sleeve and presented it. The king took it, and seeing the two words "All is well" written upon the cover, felt his very hands go weak, so that he could not tear it open. He gave the order to summon a Grand Academician of the Hanlin Academy to the hall to read it aloud. The Academician came up at once. Before the hall stood the civil and military officers; behind it stood the consorts and palace women—all of them inclining their ears to listen. The Academician broke the seal and read aloud:

Your unfilial daughter, Hundred-Flowers Shame,
bows her head and makes a hundred obeisances
before the dragon-and-phoenix hall of her father the
king, of great virtue, ten thousand years to him; and
beneath the Bright-Sun Palace of her three royal
mothers; and before the worthy ministers, civil and
military, of the whole court. Your unworthy
daughter was fortunate to be entrusted to the
queen's palace, and is moved beyond all telling by a
thousand kinds of toil and care lavished upon her. I
could not exhaust my strength to gladden your
faces, nor give my whole heart to the duties of a
child. Thirteen years ago, on the fine night and fair
hour of the fifteenth of the eighth month, by my
royal father's gracious decree, the several palaces set
out their banquets to enjoy the splendor of the
moon and share together the great gathering of that
clear-skied night. In the very midst of our
merriment, all unawares a fragrant gust sprang up,
and out flashed a demon king with golden eyes,

indigo face, and dark-green hair, who seized your daughter, mounted upon an auspicious radiance, and bore me straight off to a wild and lonely place among the mountains, where there was no telling one thing from another. Relying on his strength, the fiend forced me to be his wife. And so, having no choice, I have endured thirteen years, and have borne him two demon sons—every one of them a demon's seed. This is in truth a ruin of all human bonds, a wound to decency and custom, not fit to be set down in a letter that only brings shame. But I feared that, after your daughter's death, the matter would never be made plain. Even as I sat nursing my grievance and yearning for my parents, all unlooked-for the holy monk of the Tang court was himself taken captive by the demon king. So your daughter, with falling tears, wrote this letter, and made bold to set him free, entrusting to him this scrap of paper to lay bare the inch of my heart. I humbly beg my royal father to take pity, and send a

great general with all speed to the Wave-Moon Cave on Bowl-Top Mountain to seize the Yellow-Robe fiend and bring your daughter back to court—this would be a deep and gracious mercy. Hastily and without due ceremony; the rest I cannot say in writing. Your rebel daughter, Hundred-Flowers Shame, bows her head again and again.

When the Academician had finished reading, the king wept aloud; the three palaces shed tears; the civil and military officers were moved to grief; and there was no one, before or behind, who did not mourn.

The king wept a long while, then asked the two ranks of officers, "Who dares to raise troops and lead an army to take this demon for me and rescue my princess Hundred-Flowers?" He asked it again and again, and not a single man dared answer. They were truly martial generals carved out of wood, civil officials molded out of clay. The king's heart was wrung with vexation, and his tears gushed like a fountain. Then the throng of officers all bowed low together and submitted: "Your Majesty, do not grieve so. The princess was lost, and to this day, thirteen years on, there has been no word of her. By chance a holy monk of the Tang court has met her and brought this letter here—yet whether the account be fully true we cannot be sure. Moreover, we are all of us mortal men on mortal horses; we have studied the books of war and the arts of arms, but we are fit only to draw up battle-lines and pitch camp, to guard the realm from invasion and trespass. That demon is of the kind that rides on clouds and travels in mist; we cannot so much as meet him face to face—

how then should we march out to the rescue? Now this scripture-seeker from the eastern land is a holy monk of the upper realm. His Way is lofty enough to make dragon and tiger crouch; his virtue is weighty enough to win the awe of ghosts and spirits; he must surely possess the arts of subduing demons. As the old saying goes: 'He who comes to tell of trouble is himself the man to resolve it.' Let us therefore ask this very elder to subdue the demon and rescue the princess—that would be the surest plan of all."

Hearing this, the king turned quickly and entreated Tripitaka: "Elder, if you have the skill, then loose your magic powers, capture the demon, and bring my child home—and you need not go on to the West to worship the Buddha at all. Let your hair grow out and keep your head of locks, and I will bind myself to you as a brother, share my dragon throne with you, and we will enjoy wealth and honor together. How would that be?"

Tripitaka hastily made his plea: "This poor monk knows a little of reciting the Buddha's name, but in truth he cannot subdue demons."

"If you cannot subdue demons," said the king, "how do you dare go to the Western Heaven to worship the Buddha?"

The elder found he could hold it back no longer, and so he brought forward his two disciples. "Your Majesty," he said, "this poor monk alone could hardly have come so far. I have two disciples, well able to open a road where they meet a mountain and to throw a bridge where they meet a river, and so they have brought me safely here."

The king said reproachfully, "You monk, this is most unreasonable. Since you have disciples, why did you not bring them in together to see Us? Had they come to court, even if there were no gift to their liking, there would surely have been a meal of monkish fare to share out."

"This poor monk's disciples are ugly of face," said Tripitaka, "and I dared not bring them unbidden into court, for fear of alarming Your Majesty's dragon person."

The king laughed. "Listen to this monk talk! Surely it cannot be that We should fear them?"

"I dare not say it," said Tripitaka. "My elder disciple is surnamed Zhu, named Wuneng, called Bajie. He has a long snout and protruding tusks, stiff bristles and fan-like ears, a coarse body and great belly, and a wind springs up wherever he walks. My second disciple is surnamed Sha, with the religious name Wujing. He stands twelve feet tall, his arms broad in three sections; his face is like indigo, his mouth like a basin of blood, his eyes flash and glitter, and his teeth are ranked like driven nails. Such are their two appearances, and that is why I dared not bring them into court of my own accord."

"Since you have described them so," said the king, "what have I to fear? Summon them in." And straightway he sent a golden tablet to the post-house to invite them.

When the idiot heard that they were summoned, he said to Sha Monk, "Brother, you would not have us deliver the letter—and now you see the good of having delivered it. The Master must have handed it over, and the king has said, 'The letter-bearer must not be slighted,' and is bound to lay out a banquet in his honor. But the Master has a poor appetite, and out of regard for you and me he has spoken our names and sent the golden tablet to invite us. We'll all have a good meal, and be the better fit to travel tomorrow."

"Brother," said Sha Monk, "whatever the reason may be, shall we go and see?" So they handed over the luggage and horse to the warden of the post-house, each took up his own weapon, and followed the golden

tablet into court. Coming before the white-jade steps, they took their stand to left and right, sang out a single salutation toward the throne, and then never stirred again.

The civil and military officers were every one of them taken aback, and all said among themselves, "These two monks may be ugly enough—but their coarseness is too gross by far. How is it that, seeing our king, they make no proper kowtow, but after one salutation stand bolt upright on their feet? Strange, strange!" Bajie heard them and said, "Sirs, do not pass judgment. We are just so: at first sight, true enough, we look a little ugly; but watch us a while longer, and we wear quite well to the eye."

The king, seeing how ugly they were, was already startled at heart; and when he heard the idiot speak out so boldly, his courage trembled the more, until he could not keep his seat and tumbled down off the dragon throne. Luckily the attendant officers raised him up. The Tang Monk, in a fluster, fell on his knees before the hall and kept knocking his head, crying, "Your Majesty, this poor monk deserves ten thousand deaths! I told you my disciples were ugly and dared not bring them to court, for fear of harming the dragon person—and now truly they have alarmed the royal presence."

Trembling and quaking, the king came forward and helped him up. "Elder, it is well you spoke of it beforehand; had you not, and had I seen them all at once without warning, I should surely have been frightened to death." After a long while the king steadied himself and asked, "Elder Zhu, Elder Sha—which of you is the master at subduing demons?"

The idiot, knowing no better, answered at once, "Old Zhu can subdue them."

"How will you subdue them?" asked the king.

"I am the Marshal of the Heavenly Reeds," said Bajie. "Only because I broke the laws of Heaven was I cast down into the world below; and now, by good fortune, I have turned to the right path and become a monk. From the time we set out from the eastern land, the foremost at subduing demons has always been I."

"Since you are a heavenly general come down among mortals," said the king, "you must surely be skilled in transformations."

"I dare not boast," said Bajie, "but I manage to know a few transformations or so."

"Then transform one for Us to see," said the king.

"Set the subject," said Bajie, "and I'll transform accordingly."

"Transform into something large," said the king.

Now Bajie possessed thirty-six transformations. There before the steps he showed off his skill: pinching his fingers in the magic sign and reciting a spell, he gave a shout—"Grow!"—arched his back, and at once stretched to a height of eight or nine zhang, for all the world like a Road-Opening Spirit. So terrified were the two ranks of civil and military officers that they shook and trembled, and the whole court, king and ministers alike, stood dumbstruck and dazed. Just then the Hall-Guarding General called out, "Elder, if you can grow your body to such a height, is there any limit to how tall you might become?"

The idiot let fall some idiot's words: "It depends on the wind. An east wind, well enough; a west wind, I can manage too; but if a south wind springs up, I'll poke a great hole clean through the blue sky itself."

The king, much alarmed, cried, "Put away your magic—we have seen enough of your transformations." Bajie shrank his body down, resumed

his true form, and stood in attendance before the steps.

The king asked again, "Elder, when you go this time, what weapon will you use against him?"

Bajie drew his rake from his waist. "Old Zhu uses a nine-toothed rake."

The king laughed. "That can only disgrace your appearance. Here I have whips, batons, melon-maces, hammers, sabers, spears, battle-axes, broadaxes, swords, halberds, lances, and sickles—take whichever suits your hand. What sort of weapon do you call that rake?"

"Your Majesty does not understand," said Bajie. "Coarse and clumsy as this rake may look, it has in truth been my own weapon since boyhood. When I was Marshal in the watery mansion of the Heavenly River, in command of eighty thousand water-troops, I relied wholly on the power of this rake. And now, come down to the mortal world to guard my master, when I meet a mountain I rake through the dens of tigers and wolves, and when I meet water I overturn the lairs of dragons and sea-serpents—all by this rake."

Hearing these words, the king was exceedingly pleased and thoroughly convinced. At once he commanded the nine ladies of the harem: "Bring out a full flask of the royal wine that We Ourselves drink, that We may give the elder a send-off." A goblet was filled to the brim and offered to Bajie. "Elder," said the king, "this cup of wine is but a token of the toil We lay upon you. When you have caught the demon and brought back Our daughter, there shall be a great banquet in your honor and a thousand pieces of gold in heartfelt thanks."

The idiot took the cup in his hands. Coarse and rough as the fellow was in his person, in his conduct he showed a touch of refinement: he bowed in a great salutation toward Tripitaka and said, "Master, by rights this

wine should be drunk beginning with you; but since the king has bestowed it upon me, I dare not refuse, so let old Zhu drink first to whet his spirits, the better to catch the demon." The idiot drained it at a draught, then poured another goblet and offered it to his master. "I do not drink wine," said Tripitaka; "you brothers may have it." Sha Monk came forward and took it. Then Bajie summoned a cloud beneath his feet and rose straight up into the air. Seeing this, the king exclaimed, "So Elder Zhu can ride the clouds as well!"

When the idiot had gone, Sha Monk drained his own wine and said, "Master, when the Yellow-Robe fiend held you captive, the two of us did battle with him and could only fight him to a draw. Now Second Brother goes alone, and I fear he is no match for the demon."

"Just so," said Tripitaka. "Disciple, you had best go and lend him your strength." Hearing this, Sha Monk leaped up upon a cloud and soared away. The king was thrown into a fluster and caught hold of the Tang Monk. "Elder, do stay and sit with Us a while—do not go riding off on a cloud as well!"

"Alas," said the Tang Monk, "I cannot go so much as half a step." And so the two of them stayed talking together in the hall—but of that no more.

Now Sha Monk caught up with Bajie and called out, "Brother, I've come!"

"Brother," said Bajie, "what have you come for?"

"The Master sent me to lend you a hand," said Sha Monk.

Bajie was delighted. "Well said—and well come. The two of us will put forth our strength together and go catch that monster. Even if it comes to little, we'll at least make a name for ourselves in this kingdom." Just look at them:

Wreathed in lucky radiance, they take their leave of the kingdom's bounds; shrouded in auspicious vapor, they set forth from the capital. Bearing the king's command, they come to the mountain cave, putting forth their strength with one heart to catch the fiendish thing.

Before long the two of them reached the mouth of the cave and dropped down from their clouds. Bajie drew his rake and, with all his might, struck once at the door of the Wave-Moon Cave, raking a hole in the stone gate as big as a dipper. The little fiends keeping the gate flung it open in terror and, seeing who it was, ran inside to report: "Great king, this is bad! That long-snouted, big-eared monk and that dark-faced, sour-visaged monk have come again, and have battered our gate to pieces!"

The fiend was startled. "This will be Zhu Bajie and Sha the Monk, the two of them. I spared their master—how do they dare come back and batter at my gate?"

"They must have forgotten some article," said the little fiends, "and have come to fetch it."

The old fiend snorted: "Nonsense! Forgotten some article, and dare batter at my gate for it? There must be another reason." In haste he buckled on his harness, gripped his steel blade, and came striding out. "You monks—since I spared your master, how do you dare come back and batter at my gate?"

"You filthy fiend," said Bajie, "you've done a fine piece of work."

"What work?" said the old demon.

"You tricked the third princess of the Kingdom of Precious Image into your cave," said Bajie, "and relying on your strength forced her to be your wife. Thirteen years you've kept her—it's high time you gave her back. I come by the king's command, on purpose to take you. Get inside, quick, tie yourself up, and come out trussed, and spare old Zhu the trouble of laying hands on you."

At these words the old fiend was filled with rage. Just look at him: gnashing his steel teeth till they ground and grated; glaring his great ring-eyes wide; valiant and fierce, he raised his blade and hacked straight at Bajie's head. Bajie dodged aside and met him face-on with the nine-toothed rake; and close behind came Sha Monk, lifting his treasure-staff and rushing up to strike alongside. This bout, fought on the mountaintop, was unlike the one before. Truly it was thus:

A word amiss, a phrase awry, brings on a man's wrath; malice of intent and wounded feeling kindle the fires of rage. This demon king with his great steel blade hacks straight at the head; that Bajie with his nine-toothed rake meets him face to face. Sha Wujing flourishes wide his treasure-staff, and the demon king fends off the soldiers of the spirits. One ferocious fiend, two holy monks, back and forth they go with never a pause. This one says, "You cheated the realm—you deserve a death sentence!" That one says, "You meddle in idle quarrels, crying injustice!" This one says, "By forced wedding of the princess you wronged the state!" That one says, "It's no concern of yours—stop your idle wrangling!" Reckon it up, and all because of a letter carried home, monk and fiend are both at peace no longer.

They had fought on the mountain slope some eight or nine rounds when Bajie began little by little to flag; his rake grew hard to lift and his strength gave out. Do you ask why he could not stand against the fiend

this time? When they first joined battle, the Dharma-guarding spirits, because the Tang Monk had been held in the cave, had secretly aided Bajie and Sha Monk, so that they could just hold their own to a draw; but this time all the spirits were back in the Kingdom of Precious Image guarding the Tang Monk, and so the two of them were no match for him.

Said the idiot, "Sha Monk, you go up and fight him a while, and let old Zhu step aside to ease himself." And with that, never minding Sha Monk at all, he bolted off into the wormwood and creeper, the thornbrakes and clinging vines, and, not caring good from ill, burrowed in all in a heap. Never minding that the thorns tore his scalp and the brambles cut his snout and face, he rolled himself down to sleep and dared come out no more—leaving only half an ear above ground to listen for the sound of the watchman's clapper.

When the fiend saw that Bajie had run off, he made straight for Sha Monk. Caught off guard, Sha Monk was seized in one grip and dragged into the cave, where the little fiends bound him hand and foot, all four limbs trussed together like a hog's.

And in the end there is no telling how his life fared—so listen to the explanation in the next chapter.

Chapter 30: The Demon Profanes the True Law; the Dragon-Horse Transforms

Now, the monster had Friar Sand bound fast, yet he neither killed him nor beat him, nor uttered a single word of abuse. He took up his steel sword and thought to himself, "This Tang Monk is a man of a great civilized realm—surely he knows propriety and right. He would never have spared his own life and then sent his disciples to seize me. This

must mean that my own wife somehow sent a letter back to her home country, and word has leaked out. Let me go and question her." And with that the monster, his cruelty rising, resolved to kill the princess.

The princess, all unknowing, had just finished her toilet and came stepping forward. There she found the monster glaring, his brows knotted, grinding his teeth in fury. Still she met him with a smiling face. "My lord, what troubles you so?" The monster spat out a curse: "You dog-hearted, base woman, utterly without human decency! When I first brought you here I never said one harsh word to you. The brocades you wear, the gold you put on—whatever you lacked I went and fetched. Through all four seasons you have had your comforts, every day my love deep upon you. How is it that you think only of your father and mother, and have not the least heart for husband and wife?"

Hearing this, the princess fell to her knees in terror. "My lord! How is it that today you speak of parting?" The monster said, "It is not I who would part—it is you who would part from me! I seized that Tang Monk, meaning to make a meal of him. How is it that, without first telling me, you set him free? It must be that you secretly wrote a letter and bade him carry it for you. Otherwise, how would these two monks come pounding at my gate demanding that I return you? Is this not your doing?" The princess said, "My lord, you wrong me. When did I ever send any letter?" The old monster said, "Still you talk back! I have one of your accomplices held captive here this very moment—is that not proof enough?" "Who is it?" she asked. "It is Friar Sand, the Tang Monk's second disciple," said the demon.

Now, when a person stands at the threshold of death, who will admit to something that brings death down upon them? She could only deny it to his face. The princess said, "My lord, calm your anger. Let you and me go and question him together. If there truly was a letter, then beat me to

death and I shall die content. But if there was no letter, would you not have slain me wrongly?"

The monster would hear no more of it. He thrust out one hand, broad as a winnowing-basket and indigo-blue, seized the ten thousand strands of her golden-leafed, jade-branch hair, dragged her forward, and flung her to the ground. Then, grasping his steel sword, he turned to interrogate Friar Sand. "Friar Sand!" he barked. "You two dared to come storming up to my gate. Was it because this woman sent a letter to her country, and the king sent you here?"

Friar Sand, bound as he was, saw how savage the demon looked—how he had flung the princess to the floor and now held the sword ready to kill her. And he thought to himself: "It is plain that she did send the letter and saved my master—that is a kindness beyond measure. If I speak the truth, he will kill the princess straightaway, and that would be repaying kindness with injury. Enough, enough! I have followed my master all this while and never rendered him an inch of useful service. Today I am already bound. Let me give this life of mine to repay my master's debt." So he cried aloud: "Monster, do not be so brutish! What letter? You wrong this woman and would take her life without cause! We came here to demand the princess for a reason. When you carried off my master to your cave, he saw the princess's face and bearing. Later, when we reached the Kingdom of Precious Image to have our travel-rescript stamped, the king showed us a painted portrait of the princess and went inquiring of her everywhere. He asked my master whether he had seen such a face along the road, and my master spoke of the princess. The king thus knew it was his own child, bestowed royal wine upon us, and sent us to seize you and bring the princess home. This is the whole truth—when was there ever any letter? If you mean to kill, then kill old Sand, but do not

wrongly harm an innocent woman, for that would grievously offend the law of Heaven."

Hearing Friar Sand speak so boldly and grandly, the monster threw down his sword and lifted the princess up in both arms. "It was my own rashness," he said. "I gave you much offense. Do not blame me, do not blame me." He smoothed her black tresses, propped up her jeweled coiffure, and with soft, gentle words and a pleasant smiling face cajoled her back inside, even inviting her to sit in the place of honor while he begged her pardon.

Now, the princess was a woman of yielding nature, and seeing him pay her such mistaken courtesies, she softened and her heart changed. "My lord," she said, "if you think on the love between husband and wife, you might at least loosen Friar Sand's ropes a little." The old demon, hearing this, at once ordered his underlings to untie Friar Sand and chain him up instead. When Friar Sand felt himself unbound and only chained, he rose up and rejoiced quietly in his heart: "The ancients said, 'Do another a kindness, and you do yourself a kindness.' Had I not done him that service, why would he have ordered me eased and loosened?"

The old demon then had a banquet laid out to make amends and soothe the princess's fright. When the drinking was half over, the old demon suddenly changed into a bright fresh suit of clothes, took up a precious sword and girt it at his waist, then turned and stroked the princess's arm. "Wife," he said, "stay home and drink your wine, mind the two children, and do not let Friar Sand go. While the Tang Monk is still in that kingdom, I shall go early to claim my kinship." "What kinship will you claim?" she asked. The old demon said, "I'll claim your royal father. I am his son-in-law, he is my father-in-law—how should I not go and acknowledge the bond?"

"You cannot go," said the princess. "Why can I not go?" he asked. The princess said, "My father's kingdom was not won by horse and battle — it is the altar of soil and grain handed down from his ancestors. From boyhood he ascended the throne as crown prince; he has never once gone far from the city gates, and has never laid eyes on such a fierce fellow as you. Your countenance and features are so hideous that if he sees you, I fear he will be frightened, and that would turn out badly. Far better that you do not go to claim the kinship at all." The old demon said, "If that is so, I'll simply change into a handsome young man and go." "Then change yourself," she said, "and let me see."

Excellent monster! There at the banquet table he shook his body and changed, and became a comely, dashing young man — and indeed he was born so:

His form refined and elegant, his frame tall and commanding; his speech all courtly grace, his bearing in the very flower of youth. In talent like Cao Zhi, who made verse with ease; in looks like Pan An, at whom maidens lightly threw their fruit. On his head a magpie-tail cap, his dark cloud-hair drawn smoothly up; on his body a robe of jade-white gauze, broad sleeves floating in the breeze. On his feet black flowered boots, at his waist a phoenix sash a gleam. Truly a man of marvelous spirit and grace — towering over the valleys, a splendid and handsome youth.

The princess, seeing him, was greatly delighted. The demon laughed. "Wife, is this not a fine transformation?" The princess said, "It is good, it is good. When you enter the court, my father, being your kin, will not slight you, but will surely have his civil and military officers keep you to feast. Yet while you drink, take a thousand cares and ten thousand cautions. Do not let your true face show, do not let your horse's hoof slip out, do not let a word of it leak — that would not be at all refined." "No need to instruct me," said the old demon. "I have my own way of managing."

Watch him now ride a cloud, and in a moment he reached the Kingdom of Precious Image. Setting down his cloud, he walked to the outside of the palace gate and said to the gate-keeper, "The Third Son-in-Law has come especially to see His Majesty. I beg you, pass word in." The yellow-gowned usher came before the white jade steps and announced, "Your Majesty, there is a Third Son-in-Law come to see you, now waiting outside the palace gate for your summons."

The king was just then conversing with the Tang Monk. Hearing "Third Son-in-Law," he asked his officials, "I have only two sons-in-law. How is it there is now a third?" The officials said, "This Third Son-in-Law must surely be a demon come." The king said, "Is it well to summon him in?" The elder, alarmed, said, "Your Majesty — a demon cunning enough to pass for human is a demon of no small power. He can know the past and the future; he can mount the clouds and ride the mists. Summon him, and he comes in; do not summon him, and still he comes in. Better to summon him in and spare ourselves a deal of trouble."

The king approved the suggestion and called for the demon to be admitted, and the demon was brought to the golden steps. Like any courtier he performed the rites — dancing and shouting "Long live the king." The officials, seeing how handsome and fair he was, dared not take him for a demon. They were all of fleshly eyes and common mold, and took him for a good man. The king, seeing him so towering and lofty, thought him a pillar fit to save the age, and asked, "Son-in-law, where does your household dwell? Of what region are you a native? When did you wed our princess? And how is it you only come today to claim the kinship?"

The old demon kowtowed. "Sire, your servant is a man of the Moon-Wave Cave on Bowl Mountain, east of the city." The king said, "How far is that mountain from here?" "Not far," said the demon, "only three

hundred li." The king said, "Three hundred li — how could my princess have come there to be matched with you?"

The demon, with cunning words and flowery phrases, false feeling and feigned sincerity, answered: "Sire, from my youth I have loved bow and horse, and lived by the hunt. Thirteen years ago, leading a few dozen of my household lads, loosing my hawks and chasing with hounds, I suddenly saw a fierce striped tiger bearing a woman upon its back and making down the mountain slope. Your servant drew his bow and with one arrow brought the tiger down, carried the woman home to my manor, revived her with warm water and broth, and saved her life. When I asked her of what household she was, she never once spoke the two words 'royal princess.' Had she told me at once that she was Your Majesty's Third Princess, how would I have dared so deceive my heart as to wed her on my own? I would surely have brought her up to the golden palace and, great office or small, sought some post to glorify my person. Only because she said she was a commoner's daughter did your servant keep her at his manor. The maiden was fair, the man was talented; both being willing, we were thus joined, and so have lived these many years.

"At the time of our wedding I wished to slaughter that tiger and invite all our kin, but it was the princess herself who told me not to kill it. The reason she gave for sparing it was put in a few words, and put so well — she said:

By Heaven and Earth alone are we made man and wife, matched without matchmaker, wedded without witness. In a former life the red cord once bound our feet — so let the tiger now serve as our go-between.

"On account of these words, I loosed the tiger from its bonds and spared its life. The tiger, carrying its arrow-wound, galloped off with drooping tail. I did not know that, having got its life, it dwelt in those mountains and cultivated itself these several years, refining its body into a spirit, and gave itself wholly to bewitching and harming men. I have heard that in years past there were several who went to fetch scriptures, all said to be the Tang Monk come from the Great Tang. I think this tiger must have harmed the true Tang Monk, seized his travel-papers, and changed into the very likeness of the scripture-seeker, and now stands in your court deceiving Your Majesty. Sire — the one seated there upon the embroidered stool is exactly that fierce tiger which thirteen years ago bore off the princess. He is no true scripture-seeker at all."

Now watch that yielding-natured king, his foolish and deluded fleshly eyes unable to know a demon: he turned that whole tissue of empty words into solid truth. "Worthy son-in-law," he said, "how do you know this monk to be the tiger that carried off the princess?" The demon said, "Sire, in the mountains I have eaten tiger and worn tiger; I have slept and risen alongside them. How should I not know one?" The king said, "Since you know him, have him show his true form, that I may look." The monster said, "Lend me half a cup of clean water, and I will make him

show his true form." The king ordered an officer to fetch water and hand it to the son-in-law.

The monster took the water in his hand, leaped up, stepped forward, and worked his Black-Eye Body-Fixing Spell. He recited the incantation and sprayed a mouthful of the water at the Tang Monk, crying, "Change!" The elder's true body was hidden upon the dais, and indeed he was changed into a fierce striped tiger. To the fleshly eyes of king and courtiers, that tiger appeared thus:

White brow, round head, a flowered body, eyes like lightning. Four hooves straight and towering; twenty claws hooked and keen. Saw-teeth ringed his mouth, sharp ears reaching to his brows. Ferocious and stout as a giant cat in shape, fierce and mighty as a tawny calf. Stiff whiskers stood straight like silver wires; his stabbing tongue, blood-red, breathed out a foul vapor. Truly a fierce and striped beast, gust upon gust of dread power blowing through the precious hall.

At one sight of it the king's soul scattered and his spirit fled. The officials, terrified, all fled and hid. A few bold military officers, leading their generals and lieutenants, rushed forward in a throng and hacked wildly with weapons of every kind. This time — had it not been that the Tang Monk was fated to keep his life and not die — even twenty monks

would have been beaten into a pulp. But by good fortune the Guardians of the Days and Hours, the Revealers of Truth, the Officers of Merit, and the Defenders of the Faith were all secretly protecting him from the air above, so that none of those soldiers' weapons could wound him. The officials shouted on until evening, and only then took the tiger alive, chained it with iron ropes, set it in an iron cage, and stored it away in the court chamber.

The king then issued a decree, bidding the Court of Imperial Entertainments lay out a grand banquet to thank the son-in-law for the kindness of his rescue — for otherwise, he said, they had nearly been done great harm by that monk. That evening, when the officials had withdrawn from court, the demon entered the Silver-Peace Hall. Eighteen palace maids and singing-girls were chosen to play and sing, to dance and urge the demon to drink and make merry. The monster sat alone at the head of the table, ranged left and right with beauties of lovely form. Watch him take his pleasure and drink until the second watch — when, growing drunk, he could no longer restrain his vile nature. He sprang up, laughed aloud, revealed his true form, and with his cruelty bursting out he reached out his winnowing-basket hand, snatched up one of the girls playing the lute, and with a crunch bit off her head at one mouthful. The other seventeen palace maids fled for their lives, scattering and hiding everywhere. Look at them:

The palace maids in dread, the singing-girls in alarm. The palace maids in dread, like lotus blooms cowering under night-rain; the singing-girls in alarm, like peony flowers tossing in the spring wind. They smashed their lutes to save their lives, tripped over their zithers as they fled. Out the door they could not tell north from south, leaving the hall they cared not east from west. Bruising their jade-fair faces, marring their tender beauty, every one ran for her life, each one fled to save the rest.

Those who got out dared not raise an outcry. The night was deep, and they dared not alarm His Majesty. They all huddled beneath the low walls and the eaves, trembling — but of that no more.

Now the monster sat above, pouring and drinking by himself. He would drain a cup, then drag a body over and gnaw two bloody mouthfuls. While he took his pleasure within, the word spread among the people without: "The Tang Monk is a tiger-spirit!" The rumor flew about wildly, until it reached the Golden Pavilion Post-Station. At that hour the station was empty of men; only the white horse stood at its trough, eating grass and fodder. Now this horse was in truth the young Dragon-King of the Western Sea, who for breaking Heaven's law had had his horns sawn off and his scales stripped, been changed into a white horse, and set to carry the Tang Monk westward to fetch the scriptures. Suddenly hearing men

say the Tang Monk was a tiger-spirit, he thought in his heart: "My master is plainly a good man — surely the demon has changed him into a tiger-spirit and brought him to ruin. What is to be done? What is to be done? My eldest brother has been gone a long time; of Pig and Friar Sand there is no news either." He waited only until the second watch, then sprang up. "If I do not save the Tang Monk now," he said, "this whole holy work is finished — finished!"

Unable to bear it longer, he snapped clean through his halter, shook off saddle and bridle, leaped up swiftly, and showed his power, becoming a dragon once more as of old. Riding a black cloud, he rose straight into the ninth heaven to look about. There is a poem to prove it:

Tripitaka came westward to bow to the Honored of the World; but on the road there lurked a vile and demon air. This night, changed to a tiger, in disaster he was caught — and the white horse, dropping his halter, came to save his lord.

The little Dragon-King, hovering in mid-air, saw the Silver-Peace Hall ablaze with lamps and candles — for eight tall candlesticks held eight burning tapers. He lowered his cloud and looked closely, and there was the demon, all alone upon the high seat, drinking by force of magic and eating human flesh. The little dragon laughed: "This wretch is no good. His horse's hoof has slipped, his secret is out, his scale is off the balance. Is eating men any path to advancement? Yet I do not know what has become of my master, and instead I have met this filthy monster. Let me

go and toy with him a while; if I get the upper hand and take the demon, it will not be too late to save my master after."

Good Dragon-King! He shook his body and changed, becoming a palace maid himself — her body light and slender, her bearing soft and charming. Quickly she stepped inside and saluted the demon with a blessing: "Son-in-law, do not harm my life. I have come to pour your wine for you." The demon said, "Pour, then." The little dragon took the flagon and poured the wine into his cup, and the wine rose three or five parts higher than the rim, yet never overflowed. This was the little dragon's Water-Pressing Spell. The monster, seeing it and not knowing what it was, rejoiced in his heart: "You have such a skill?" The little dragon said, "I can pour it higher still." "Pour again, pour again," said the monster. She raised the flagon and poured on as he pleased, and the wine rose on as it pleased, like a thirteen-storied pagoda, peaked and brimming, and not one drop spilled over. The monster stretched out his mouth and drank a cup; then he dragged over a corpse and ate a mouthful. "Can you sing?" he asked. The little dragon said, "I know a little." And she sang a small tune, true to its melody and rhyme, then offered another cup. "Can you dance?" the monster asked. "I know a little," said the little dragon, "but my hands are bare, and the dance is not pretty to see." The monster lifted his robe, unfastened the precious sword at his waist, drew it from the sheath, and handed it to the little dragon.

The little dragon took the sword, and with care, there before the banquet table — three up and four down, five left and six right — set going a flowery sword-play. The monster watched, his eyes agape. Then the little dragon cast off the flourishes and aimed a chop straight at the demon. Excellent monster! He twisted aside and dodged it, then in a flurry snatched up one of the tall candlesticks and parried the precious sword.

Now that candlestick was forged of wrought iron, and with its handle weighed eighty or ninety catties. The two of them went out of the Silver-Peace Hall, and the little dragon resumed his true form, rode up his cloud, and joined battle with the demon in mid-air. This was a fine fight in the dark. How was it seen?

The one a monster born of Bowl Mountain; the other a true dragon banished from the Western Sea. One loosed his radiance, like white lightning spat forth; one bred his fierce vigor, like red clouds bursting out. One was like a white-tusked old elephant come among men; one like a golden-clawed wildcat flown down to the mortal world. One a jade pillar propping up the sky; one a golden beam bridging the seas. The silver dragon flew and wheeled; the yellow fiend tumbled and rolled. Left and right the precious sword knew no rest; back and forth the tall candlestick never ceased.

The two of them battled in the clouds for eight or nine rounds. Then the little dragon's hands grew weak and his sinews went numb, while the old fiend remained strong of body and stout of power. The little dragon could hold out no longer, and flung his sword to cut the demon down. But the demon had a trick for catching swords: with one hand he snatched the

precious blade, and with the other hurled the candlestick down to strike. The little dragon could not parry in time, and took the blow on his hind leg. In panic he dropped out of the clouds, and only the Imperial Water River saved his life, for he plunged headlong into its depths. The demon pursued and searched but could not find him, and so, taking up both the precious sword and the candlestick, returned to the Silver-Peace Hall and went on drinking and sleeping as before — but of that no more.

Now the little dragon lay hidden at the bottom of the river. For half an hour he heard no sound, and only then, gritting his teeth against the pain in his leg, did he leap up. Treading a black cloud, he went straight back to the post-station, changed again into his old form as the horse, and crouched beneath the trough. Pitiful — his whole body was wet, and his leg bore an ugly wound. At that hour:

The Will-Horse and Mind-Monkey were both scattered and lost; the Metal-Sire and Wood-Mother both withered and fallen. The Yellow Dame was wounded, all parted and astray — with the Way and its virtue dwindling, how could the work be wrought?

Let us say no more of Tripitaka's calamity nor of the little dragon's defeat. Now Zhu Bajie, after parting from Friar Sand, had buried his head in a clump of grass and rooted himself out a pig's wallow. That nap lasted clean through to midnight before he woke. When he woke he could not tell where he was. He rubbed his eyes, steadied his wits, and cocked his ear to listen. The mountains were so deep no dog barked; the wilds so

empty few cocks crowed. He watched the stars shift and the Dipper turn — it must be about the third watch — and he thought: "If I want to go back and rescue Friar Sand, truly 'a single thread makes no cord, and one hand alone cannot clap.' Enough, enough — let me go into the city and see my master, get the king's leave, then pick out some bold men and horses to help old Pig come rescue Friar Sand tomorrow."

The blockhead hurriedly rode his cloud and went straight back into the city. In a moment he reached the post-station. By then men were still and the moon was bright. He searched both corridors but could not find his master; he saw only the white horse lying there, its whole body wet, with a spot the size of a plate — blue and bruised — on its hind leg. Bajie cried out in alarm: "Double bad luck! This beast hasn't even been traveling — how does he come by sweat on his body and a bruise on his leg? Some villains must have robbed my master and beaten the horse into the bargain."

The white horse recognized Bajie, and suddenly spoke with human speech, calling out, "Brother!" The blockhead was so startled he fell flat, then scrambled up and made to bolt outside. But the white horse stretched out its neck and caught his black robe in its teeth. "Brother," it said, "do not be afraid of me." Bajie, still trembling, said, "Younger brother, how is it you've taken to speaking today? When a horse speaks, there must surely be some great misfortune."

The little dragon said, "Do you know that our master is in trouble?" Bajie said, "I do not." The little dragon said, "You do not. You and Friar Sand showed off your powers before the king, thinking to overthrow the demon and earn merit and reward. But you never reckoned on the demon's skill being so great and your own arts so wanting that you could not master him. By rights, one of you should have come back to bring word — yet there was no news at all. The demon changed into a

handsome scholar, broke into the court, and claimed kinship with the king. He has changed our master into a fierce striped tiger, who was seized by the assembled officers and is now chained in an iron cage in the court chamber. When I heard of this misery, my heart was as if cut by knives. You two were gone these two days and knew nothing of it, and I feared for the master's life at any moment; so I had no choice but to change into my dragon's body and go to rescue him. But when I reached the court, I could not find my master. Coming round to the outside of the Silver-Peace Hall, I met the demon, and changed into the form of a palace maid to fool the monster. The monster bade me dance with a sword for his amusement, so I seized my chance and cut at him. But he dodged it at once and, lifting the tall candlestick in both hands, beat me back. I flung the sword at him again, but he caught it, then hurled down the candlestick and struck me once on the hind leg. So I dived into the Imperial Water River and escaped with my life. The bruise on my leg is from the blow of his candlestick."

Bajie said, "Is there truly such a thing?" The little dragon said, "Would I be fooling you?" Bajie said, "What's to be done? What's to be done? Are you able to move?" The little dragon said, "And if I can move, what of it?" Bajie said, "If you can move, then move on down to the sea! Let old Pig carry the baggage off to Gao Village, go back to the old furnace, and be a son-in-law again."

Hearing this, the little dragon bit fast onto his long gown and would not let go, and could not hold back the tears streaming from his eyes.

"Brother," he said, "do not, by any means, give way to sloth." Bajie said, "And if I'm not slothful, then what? Brother Sand has already been taken; I am no match for that demon in a fight. If I don't break up the company now, what am I waiting for?"

The little dragon brooded a long while, then said through fresh tears, "Brother, do not talk of breaking up the company. If you would save our master, you have only to go and fetch one person." Bajie said, "Whom would you have me fetch?" The little dragon said, "Make haste — ride your cloud back to the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit and invite our eldest brother, Sun the Pilgrim. He still has the great power to subdue demons. He will surely save our master and avenge both our defeats besides."

Bajie said, "Brother, let us fetch someone else. That monkey and I are a bit at odds. Back on White Tiger Ridge, when he killed that White-Bone Lady, he blamed me for egging the master on to recite the Tightening-Fillet Spell. I only meant it as a joke — I never thought the old monk would take it in earnest and start chanting, and so drive him away home. I do not know how angry he still is; he certainly won't be willing to come. And if even one word goes amiss between us, that mourning-staff of his is heavy — if I catch a few blows without knowing my place, how would I live through it?"

The little dragon said, "He will certainly not beat you. He is a Monkey-King of benevolence and righteousness. When you see him, do not say the master is in trouble — only say, 'The master is thinking of you.' Lure him along. When he comes here and sees the state of things, he is sure to feel indignant, and will certainly contend with that demon. He'll be sure to take the demon and rescue our master." Bajie said, "Very well, very well. Since you are so wholehearted about it, if I do not go I'd seem the heartless one. I'll go this once. If the Pilgrim truly will come, I'll bring him along; but if he won't come, then do not look for me — I shan't come back either." The little dragon said, "Go, go — he is sure to come."

So the blockhead truly gathered up his rake, hitched up his gown, leaped aloft, trod the cloud, and went straight eastward. And it was, in truth,

fated that the Tang Monk should live. The blockhead met a fair following wind, spread out his two great ears like a pair of sails, and was soon across the Eastern Ocean. He set down his cloud — and before he knew it the sun had risen — and entered the mountains to seek his way.

Just as he was going along, he suddenly heard voices. Looking closely, Bajie saw it was the Pilgrim, gathered together with a host of fellow spirits in a mountain hollow. He sat upon a great rocky cliff, and before him more than twelve hundred monkeys were ranked and arrayed, crying, "Long live the Great Sage, Grandfather!" Bajie said to himself, "What enjoyment, what enjoyment! No wonder he was unwilling to be a monk and only wanted to come home — so there were all these good things here: such a great estate, and so many little monkeys to wait on him. If old Pig had a mountain like this, I wouldn't be a monk either. Well, now that I'm here, what shall I do? I really must see him."

The blockhead was a little afraid of him and dared not show himself openly, so he slipped along by the grassy cliff-side, squeezing and sliding in among the twelve or thirteen hundred monkeys, and kowtowed along with them. But the Great Sage Sun sat high, and his eye was sharp and cunning; he saw him plainly and called out: "In that ranked company, the one bowing all out of order — that is some foreign fellow. Where has he come from? Bring him up." The words were scarcely out when the little monkeys swarmed like bees and pushed Bajie forward, pressing him down to the ground.

The Pilgrim said, "Where are you from, foreigner?" Bajie, hanging his head, said, "I wouldn't presume — thank you for asking. I'm no foreigner; I'm an old acquaintance, an old acquaintance." The Pilgrim said, "All the monkeys of my Great-Sage company are of the same look. Your face is shaped quite differently — your features rather lumpish — you must be a demon from somewhere else. If you wish to enlist under me, you must

first present a written application with your particulars and report your name, and then I'll keep you here to be mustered in with the ranks. Since I haven't enrolled you, how dare you bow here all out of order?"

Bajie, head down and snout puckered, said, "For shame — so you put on this face for me! You and I were brother disciples for several years, and now you make as if you don't know me, calling me some foreigner." The Pilgrim laughed: "Lift your head and let me look." The blockhead thrust his snout upward. "Look, then," he said. "You may not know me, but surely you know the snout." The Pilgrim could not help laughing: "Zhu Bajie." Hearing himself named, the blockhead bounced up in a single roll and cried, "That's right, that's right! I'm Zhu Bajie." And he thought to himself: "Since he knows me, it'll be easy to talk."

The Pilgrim said, "Why aren't you off fetching scriptures with the Tang Monk, but here instead? You must have offended the master, and he has banished you. If there's any letter of dismissal, hand it here and let me see." Bajie said, "I never offended him; there's no letter of dismissal, and he never drove me away." The Pilgrim said, "If there's no letter of dismissal and he never drove you off, then why have you come to me?" Bajie said, "The master is thinking of you, and sent me to fetch you." The Pilgrim said, "He neither invited me nor thinks of me. That day he swore an oath to Heaven and wrote a letter of dismissal in his own hand — how would he now be willing to think of me, or send you so far to invite me? I most certainly won't go."

Bajie made up a lie on the spot, saying quickly, "It's true he's thinking of you, truly he is." The Pilgrim said, "How was he thinking of me?" Bajie said, "The master was riding along on the horse and called out, 'Disciple!' I didn't hear, and Friar Sand pretended to be deaf. So the master thought of you, and said we were no good — said you were a clever, quick-witted fellow, that when he called you'd always answer, and ask one thing and

you'd answer ten. Because he thought of you so, he sent me especially to invite you. Pray go and make the journey: first, you'll not disappoint his longing hope; second, you'll not have made my coming all this way for nothing."

Hearing this, the Pilgrim leaped down from the cliff, took Bajie by the hand, and said, "Worthy brother, you have put yourself to trouble coming so far. Come and play a while with me." Bajie said, "Brother, the road is long; I fear the master is looking out for us and we'll be late. I'll not play." The Pilgrim said, "You've come all this way — will you not look over my mountain scenery?" The blockhead dared not stubbornly refuse and had to go along with him.

The two of them went hand in hand, the whole crowd of little monkeys following behind, up to the very summit of the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit. A fine mountain! Since the Great Sage had come home, in these few days he had set it all in order, restored fresh as new. There one saw:

Green as carved kingfisher-jade, high as if scraping the clouds. All around, tigers couched and dragons coiled; on every side, the crying of apes and the calling of cranes. At dawn the clouds sealed the mountaintop; at dusk the sun hung among the trees. The flowing water murmured, chiming like jade pendants; the ravine springs dripped, sounding like a jasper zither. Before the mountain, cliffs and crags and sheer walls; behind the mountain, flowers and trees in lush abundance. Above it joined the basin where the Jade Maidens wash their hair; below it linked the diverted waters of the River of Heaven. Heaven and Earth wrought its beauty to rival Penglai; the pure and turbid bred it into a true grotto-heaven. The cunning brush of the painter could scarcely depict it; the immortals' own deft minds could not draw it out. Exquisite the strange rocks; strange the exquisite rocks — exquisite their gathered hues upon the ridge and peak. When the sunlight stirred, a thousand strands of purple

splendor; when the auspicious vapor swayed, ten thousand shafts of rosy cloud. A grotto-heaven, a blessed land, existing among men — all over the mountain, new trees and new flowers.

Bajie looked his fill and could not exhaust it, and was filled with delight. "Brother," he said, "what a fine place! Truly it is the first famous mountain under heaven." The Pilgrim said, "Worthy brother, could one not pass one's days here?" Bajie laughed: "Listen to my brother talk! A treasure-mountain, a grotto-heaven, a blessed land — how can you speak of merely 'passing the days'?"

The two of them talked and laughed a good while, then went back down the mountain. There by the roadside several little monkeys knelt beside the path holding up purple-glistening grapes, sweet-scented pears and dates, golden loquats, and bright-red bayberries, crying, "Great-Sage Grandfather, please come to your morning meal." The Pilgrim laughed: "My brother Pig has a great stomach, and fruit won't do for his meal. Well, well — don't scorn the poor fare; make do and eat a few as a snack." Bajie said, "My stomach may be great, but when in the country, do as the country does. Hand them here, hand them here — I'll eat a few and taste the new ones."

The two of them ate the fruit, and gradually the sun climbed high. The blockhead, fearing he would delay the rescue of the Tang Monk, kept urging him on: "Brother, the master is yonder looking out for you and me. I beg you, let us go quickly." The Pilgrim said, "Worthy brother, pray come into the Water-Curtain Cave and play a while." Bajie firmly declined: "I am much obliged for your kind feeling, brother, but the

master has waited long; there is no need to trouble going into the cave." The Pilgrim said, "If that is so, I dare not detain you further. Let us part right here." Bajie said, "Brother — you're not coming?" The Pilgrim said, "Where would I go? Here, Heaven cannot constrain me and Earth cannot govern me; I am free and at ease. If I cannot play here, what is the good of being a monk? I'm not going — go along yourself. But pass word to the Tang Monk: since he has driven me off, let him think no more of me."

Hearing this, the blockhead dared not press him hard, fearing only that he might rouse his temper and earn a couple of strokes of the staff. With no choice, he muttered his farewell, found the road, and went off. When the Pilgrim saw him gone, he at once dispatched two nimble little monkeys to follow Bajie and listen to what he might say. Truly, no sooner had the blockhead got down the mountain, not three or four li along, than he turned his head, pointed back at the Pilgrim, and cursed aloud: "This monkey — won't be a monk, would rather be a demon! This baboon — I came in good faith to invite him, and he won't go. Well, if you won't, then you won't!" He walked a few steps and cursed a few more. The two little monkeys hurried back and reported: "Great-Sage Grandfather, that Zhu Bajie isn't very honest. He walks a bit, then curses a few times." The Pilgrim flew into a great rage and cried, "Bring him here!" The whole pack of monkeys came flying over the ground, overtook Bajie, knocked him sprawling, grabbed his bristles and pulled his ears, dragged his tail and tugged his hair, and hauled him back.

What treatment was in store for him, and whether his life would be spared or lost — listen to the explanation in the next chapter.

Chapter 31: The Brotherly Bond, and the Cunning Capture of the Golden Helmet

Demon

Bound in brotherhood, the heart is whole; the Dharma returns to its true nature. When metal yields and wood is tamed, the right fruit ripens; the Mind-Monkey and the Wood-Mother together compose the elixir's root. Together they climb toward the Land of Perfect Bliss; together they arrive at the Gateway of Non-Duality. The scriptures are the great road of cultivation; the Buddha is matched to one's own original spirit. Brother and brother meet to seal a threefold pact; demon and fiend in their hues answer to the Five Elements. Cut away the lures of the six gates, and at once you reach the Great Thunderclap Monastery.

Now, that idiot Zhu Bajie had been seized by the whole pack of monkeys — hoisted up, dragged about, hauled this way and that until his black cassock was ripped clean through. Muttering and grumbling to himself, he moaned, "It's finished, it's finished. This time I'm in for a beating that'll kill me."

Before long they reached the mouth of the cave. The Great Sage sat upon the stone cliff and cursed down at him: "You bran-stuffed, blockheaded oaf! You'd already gone on your way — so why did you curse me behind my back?"

Bajie knelt on the ground and said, "Brother, I never cursed you. If I cursed you, may I chew my own tongue out at the root. I only said that since you wouldn't come, I'd go report to Master myself. How would I dare curse you?"

Wukong said, "How can you fool me? When I tug my left ear upward, I can hear the talk of the gods in the Thirty-Three Heavens; when I tug my right ear downward, I can hear the Ten Kings of the Underworld and

their judges going over their ledgers. You cursed me as you walked along — do you think I didn't hear?"

Bajie said, "Brother, I know how sly and rat-witted you are. You surely changed yourself into some little thing and followed me to listen."

Wukong shouted, "Little ones! Pick out the big cudgels. First give him twenty whacks across the shins to greet him, then twenty across the back to send him off — and after that I'll see him on his way with my own iron rod."

Bajie, terrified, kowtowed and pleaded, "Brother — for Master's sake, I beg you, spare me!"

Wukong said, "I do recall that Master is a kind and righteous man."

Bajie went on, "Brother, if not for Master's sake, then for the sake of the Bodhisattva of the Southern Sea — spare me!"

When Wukong heard the Bodhisattva mentioned, three-tenths of his heart softened. He said, "Brother, since you put it that way, I'll not beat you. But speak the plain truth and don't lie to me. Where has Tang Monk run into trouble, that you've come here to trick me?"

Bajie said, "Brother, there's no trouble at all — I simply missed you."

Wukong cursed, "You beatable, worthless creature — still you try to bluff me! I, old Sun, returned in body to the Water-Curtain Cave, but my heart follows the scripture-seeking monk. That Master meets danger at every step, calamity at every turn. Tell me at once, and spare yourself the beating."

Hearing this, Bajie kowtowed and confessed, "Brother — I'll be honest. I came to fetch you, meaning to keep it hidden from you. I never expected

you'd be this uncanny. Spare me the beating, and let me up so I can speak."

Wukong said, "Very well — get up and talk." The monkeys let go their hold. The idiot sprang to his feet and kept glancing nervously to either side.

Wukong said, "What are you staring at?"

Bajie said, "Just checking that the road there is wide and open — good for running."

Wukong said, "And where would you run to? I'd give you three days' head start and still have the skill to fetch you back. Speak quickly — if this rouses my temper, I'll never spare you."

Bajie said, "I'll hold nothing back from you, brother. After you left, Sha Monk and I escorted Master onward. We came to a forest of black pines, where Master dismounted and bade me go beg for vegetarian food. I walked a long way and found not a single household; worn out, I lay down in the grass for a little nap. But Sha Monk, parting from Master, came looking for me. You know how restless Master is — he wandered alone through the trees, enjoying the scenery. Coming out of the wood, he saw a golden pagoda shining with light and took it for a monastery. He didn't expect that beneath the pagoda dwelt a fiend named Yellow Robe, who seized him.

"Later, when Sha Monk and I returned to search, we found only the white horse and the baggage — no Master. We followed the trail to the cave mouth and did battle with that monster. As it happened, Master had a savior within: the third princess of the Kingdom of Precious Image, whom the fiend had carried off. She wrote a letter to her family and entrusted it to Master to deliver, and so found a way to set him free.

When he reached the capital and handed over the letter, the king begged Master to subdue the fiend and bring back the princess. Brother — you know it well — can that old monk subdue any fiend? The two of us went back to fight it, but the monster's powers are vast and we never reckoned on them; it captured Sha Monk too. I fled in defeat and hid in the grass.

"Then the monster changed into a handsome scholar, entered the court, claimed kinship with the king, and turned Master into a tiger. By great good fortune the white dragon-horse revealed its dragon-body by night and went searching for Master. It never found him, but came upon the fiend drinking in the Silver-Peace Hall. The horse changed into a palace maid, poured the fiend's wine, and danced with a sword, meaning to seize the moment and cut him down — but instead the fiend struck its leg with the great Hall-Lamp and wounded it. It was the horse that sent me to fetch you, brother. It said: 'Your elder brother is a man of benevolence and honor, and an honorable man bears no grudge for old wrongs — he will surely come to save Master from this one trial.' So I beg you, brother, remember the old saying, *Once a man is your teacher for a day, he is your father for life* — and by all means, go and save him!"

Wukong said, "You idiot — when I took my leave, I charged you again and again: 'If any fiend should seize Master, you have only to say that old Sun is his eldest disciple.' Why did you not speak of me?"

Bajie thought to himself, "Begging him won't move him half so well as goading him. Let me prick his pride a little." So he said, "Brother — it would have been better not to mention you at all. It was only because I did mention you that the fiend grew utterly outrageous."

Wukong said, "What do you mean?"

Bajie said, "I told it: 'Fiend, don't be insolent — don't harm my master. I have an elder brother called Sun the Pilgrim. His powers are vast, and he

is a master at subduing demons. When he comes, he'll leave you without so much as a patch of earth to be buried in.' But the monster, hearing this, grew all the angrier and cursed: 'What sort of thing is this Sun the Pilgrim, that I should fear him? If he comes, I'll flay off his skin, draw out his sinews, gnaw his bones, and eat his heart. Lean as that monkey is, I'll still chop him to a hash and boil him in oil!'"

When Wukong heard this, he was so enraged he scratched his ears and rubbed his cheeks, leaping about in a fury. "Who dares curse me like this?"

Bajie said, "Calm your anger, brother — it was that Yellow-Robed Fiend who cursed so, and I'm only repeating it for you to hear."

Wukong said, "Worthy brother, get up. It isn't that I wouldn't have gone. But since the fiend dares curse me, I cannot but subdue him — I'll go with you. Five hundred years ago, when I made my great havoc in Heaven, every god and general across all the skies, seeing me, bowed and bent his back and called me Great Sage, every one of them. This insolent fiend dares curse me to my face and behind my back. I'll go and take him, hack his corpse into ten thousand pieces, and so repay the insult! That done, I'll come straight back."

Bajie said, "Just so, brother. Only go and take the fiend and avenge yourself — and whether you come back after or not is entirely as you please."

Then the Great Sage sprang down from the cliff, dashed into the cave, stripped off his fiend's garb, straightened his brocade cassock, cinched his tiger-skin kilt, took up his iron rod, and marched straight out the gate. The whole troop of monkeys, alarmed, barred his way and cried, "Grandfather Great Sage, where are you going? Take us along to romp for a few years — that would be fine, too."

Wukong said, "Little ones, what nonsense is this. In this matter of guarding Tang Monk, all Heaven above and Earth below know that Sun Wukong is Tang Monk's disciple. He did not drive me back at all — he sent me home to look in on you, sent me home to enjoy myself at ease. It is only because of this present affair that I must go now. You must all keep careful watch over our home and estate. Plant the willows and pines in their season, and let nothing fall to ruin. When I've gone back and seen Tang Monk safe and fetched the scriptures back to the Land of the East, my task complete, I'll return and share with you the joys of our natural state."

The monkeys, each and all, received his command.

Then the Great Sage joined hands with Bajie and mounted the clouds. They left the cave, crossed the Great Eastern Ocean, and reached the western shore, where they brought their cloud-light to rest. Wukong called, "Brother, walk slowly and wait here a while — let me go down into the sea and cleanse myself."

Bajie said, "We're hurrying along the road — what's all this washing about?"

Wukong said, "You wouldn't understand. Ever since I went home, these few days have left some smell of fiend-haunt about me. Master loves cleanliness, and I'm afraid he'll find me distasteful."

It was only now that Bajie understood Wukong was acting from a heart wholly sincere, with no other thought behind it.

In a moment the washing was done, and they mounted the clouds again to press westward. Soon they saw the golden pagoda shining in the distance. Bajie pointed and said, "Isn't that the home of the Yellow-Robed Fiend? Sha Monk is still inside."

Wukong said, "Stay in the air. Let me go down and see how things stand before the gate, the better to meet the fiend in battle."

Bajie said, "Don't bother — the fiend's not at home."

Wukong said, "I know."

Fine Monkey King! He brought his auspicious light down and went straight to the cave mouth to look about. There he saw two little boys at play, swinging crook-headed clubs to knock a fur ball, laughing and snatching at the hole in their sport. One looked about ten years old, the other eight or nine. While they were at their game, Wukong rushed up — never minding whose children they were — seized one by the topknot, and lifted him bodily off the ground. The child took such a fright that he raged and wept, cursing and crying all at once. This startled the little fiends of the Wave-Moon Cave, who hurried in to report to the princess: "Madam — some stranger has carried off the two young masters!" For those two children were the offspring the princess had borne to the fiend.

Hearing this, the princess rushed out the cave gate, and there she saw Wukong holding the two children, standing high upon the cliff and making as if to dash them down below. Terrified, she cried out shrilly, "You there! I have nothing to do with you — why have you carried off my sons? Their father is a fearsome creature, and should any harm come to them, he will never let it rest with you."

Wukong said, "Don't you know me? I am Sun Wukong the Pilgrim, eldest disciple of Tang Monk. I have a younger brother, Sha the Monk, held in your cave. Go and set him free, and I'll give you back these two children. Two for one — that's still a bargain for you."

Hearing this, the princess hurried inside, drove off the little fiends guarding the doors, and with her own hands untied Sha Monk. Sha Monk said, "Princess, do not untie me — for when the fiend comes home and demands his prisoner of you, you'll be dragged into trouble and suffer for it."

The princess said, "Reverend, you are my benefactor. You argued my family letter for me and saved my life — so I have taken care to set you free. And as it happens, outside the cave gate there is your elder brother, Sun Wukong, who has come and bids me release you."

Ah! The moment Sha Monk heard those three words — "Sun Wukong" — it was as if cool cream had been poured over his head, as if sweet dew had moistened his heart. At once a joy rose within him, his whole breast filled with spring; it was not like hearing that some man had come, but like picking up a slab of gold and jade. See him shake out his sleeves and stride out the gate! He saluted Wukong and said, "Brother, you truly have descended from Heaven. I beg you, save me!"

Wukong laughed and said, "You little Sha-monk — when Master chants the Tight-Fillet spell, would you ever speak a kind word for me? All your fine talk about guarding Master — why aren't you walking the westward road, but squatting here? What for?"

Sha Monk said, "Brother, no more of that. An honorable man does not reproach what is past. We are defeated generals — we cannot speak of valor. Save me, save me, I beg you."

Wukong said, "Come up here." And Sha Monk leapt up onto the stone cliff.

Now, Bajie, hovering in the air, saw Sha Monk come out of the cave and at once brought his cloud-head down, calling, "Brother Sha — bear up,

bear up!" Sha Monk looked round and said, "Second brother, where did you come from?"

Bajie said, "Yesterday I was beaten in the fight. By night I went into the city and met the white horse, and learned that Master was in danger — bewitched by the Yellow-Robed Fiend's magic into a tiger. The white horse and I took counsel together, and so I went to fetch elder brother."

Wukong said, "Idiot, never mind reunions now. Take these two children — each of you carry one — and go first into the city of Precious Image to goad that fiend out, while I deal with him here."

Sha Monk said, "Brother, how are we to goad him?"

Wukong said, "The two of you ride up on a cloud and stand above the Hall of Golden Bells. Without a word of warning, dash these children down before the white-jade steps. If anyone asks who you are, just say, 'We are the Yellow-Robed Fiend's children, carried off by the two of us.' When the fiend hears it, he's bound to come back — and then I won't have to enter the city to fight him. For if I battled him within the city walls, there'd be clouds spewed and mist breathed, dust flung and earth tossed, and the court, the officials, and the common folk would all be thrown into fear and disorder."

Bajie laughed and said, "Brother — whenever you plan a thing, you stick us with the worst of it."

Wukong said, "How have I stuck you with anything?"

Bajie said, "These two children you've snatched are already scared witless; in a moment their voices will be too hoarse to cry, and a little after that they'll surely die. If we take them and dash them down, smashing them into meat patties, will the fiend let us go once he catches up? He'll certainly demand we pay with our lives. And you'll come off

clean, with not even a witness against you — isn't that sticking us with it?"

Wukong said, "If he lays hold of you, then the two of you fight him back here. The battleground is broad and open, and here I'll be waiting to deal with him."

Sha Monk said, "Just so, just so — what elder brother says makes good sense. Let us go." And the two of them, steeling their bold spirits, took the children and departed.

Wukong leapt down from the cliff and went to stand beneath the pagoda gate. The princess said, "You monk — you have no faith or honor at all. You said that if I freed your brother you would give me back my children. Now your brother is freed, yet you keep my children still and come back to my gate — what for?"

Wukong said, smiling courteously, "Princess, don't take it ill. You've been here a great many years; I'm only taking your sons to go and meet their grandfather."

The princess said, "Monk, don't be rude. My Yellow-Robed lord is not like other folk. If you've frightened my children, you'll have to answer for it."

Wukong laughed and said, "Princess — born as we all are between Heaven and Earth, how can a man so easily be said to have committed a crime?"

The princess said, "I understand such things."

Wukong said, "You're a woman of the inner chambers — what would you understand?"

The princess said, "From childhood I was raised in the palace and taught by my parents. I recall the old books say: 'Of the five punishments and

their three thousand offenses, none is greater than unfilial conduct."

Wukong said, "Then you are precisely an unfilial person. For it is written: 'My father begot me, my mother nourished me. Alas, my father and mother — they bore me in toil and pain.' Filial piety is the source of all conduct, the root of every good. How is it, then, that you keep company with a fiend and never once think of your father and mother? If this is not the crime of being unfilial, what is?"

When the princess heard these upright words, her ears burned and her face flushed, and for a long while she could not speak. At last the words burst from her: "Reverend, you speak truly. How could I not think of my parents? But this fiend snatched me away and beguiled me here; his commandments are strict, my own steps are hindered, the road is long and the mountains far, and there was no one through whom to send word. I wished to take my own life, but feared my parents would suspect I had run off willingly, and the truth would never come to light. So, having no choice, I dragged out this poor remnant of life — truly the greatest sinner between Heaven and Earth." So saying, her tears welled up like a spring.

Wukong said, "Princess, you needn't grieve. Zhu Bajie told me you wrote a letter that saved my master's life, and that in your letter too you showed your longing for your parents. Old Sun, having come, will surely take the fiend for you, bring you back to court to see your sovereign, find you another fine match, and let you serve your parents into their old age. What do you say to that?"

The princess said, "Monk, don't go seeking your death. Yesterday those two fine champions, your fellow disciples, couldn't even prevail over my Yellow-Robed lord. And you — a scrawny ghost all sinew and little bone,

looking for all the world like a crab with all your bones grown on the outside — what skill have you, that you dare talk of taking a fiend?"

Wukong laughed and said, "You've no eye for people, and can't tell a man when you see one. As the common saying goes: 'A bladder, big as it is, weighs nothing; a steelyard-weight, small as it is, presses down a thousand catties.' Those two of mine are all bulk and no use: they brace against the wind when they walk, they waste cloth when they dress, hollow at the heart for kindling, soft at the loins beneath the crown, and no good at all once the meal's been eaten. As for old Sun — small I may be, but I'm tightly knit."

The princess said, "Have you truly such skill?"

Wukong said, "My skill you've never seen. I'm a perfect master at subduing fiends and supremely able to quell monsters."

The princess said, "Don't go misleading me, now."

Wukong said, "I'll certainly not mislead you."

The princess said, "Since you can subdue fiends and quell monsters — how will you take him?"

Wukong said, "Go off and hide yourself for now; don't stay here before my eyes. For when he comes, it'll be hard to move freely against him — I only fear that you, grown too fond of him, won't bear to see him harmed."

The princess said, "How should I be too fond of him? That I've lingered here so long is only because I had no choice."

Wukong said, "You've been husband and wife with him thirteen years — how should there be no feeling? When I see him, I'll not toy with him: every blow of the rod a real blow, every strike of the fist a real strike. I

must beat him down before you can return to court to see your sovereign."

The princess did indeed do as Wukong told her and went off to a quiet place to hide. And it was likewise that her marriage-bond was fated to end, and so she came to meet the Great Sage's coming.

The Monkey King, having hidden the princess away, gave his body a shake and changed himself into the very likeness of her, then went back into the cave to wait for the fiend.

Now, Bajie and Sha Monk carried the two children to the Kingdom of Precious Image and dashed them down before the white-jade steps. Pitiful — they were smashed flat as meat-pancakes, fresh blood spurting, bones shattered to powder. The whole court of officials was thrown into terror, and they cried out: "Disaster, disaster — two men have been hurled down from the sky!" Bajie then called out in a great voice: "Those children are the Yellow-Robed Fiend's sons — carried off and brought here by old Zhu and Brother Sha!"

The fiend was still in the Silver-Peace Hall, his wine-stupor not yet slept off. Dreaming there, he heard someone call his name, rolled over, raised his head, and looked — and there in the clouds were Zhu Bajie and Sha Monk, hooting and shouting. The fiend thought to himself: "Zhu Bajie I could expect — but Sha Monk I bound up at home. How did he get out? How would my wife consent to free him? And how could my children fall into his hands? This must be Zhu Bajie's trick, because he couldn't get me out to fight him, contriving this stratagem to snare me. If I own up to this bait, then I'm in for a brawl with him. And I'm still aching from the wine! Suppose he gets in a blow at me with his rake — wouldn't that wipe out all my prestige and let him see through my secret? Let me first go home and look — whether they're my children or not — and there'll

be time enough to talk with him after." The fine fiend, without even taking leave of the king's audience, turned toward the mountain forest and went straight to the cave to look into the matter.

By this time the court already knew he was a fiend. For that night he had eaten one of the palace maids, and seventeen others had escaped with their lives; at the fifth watch they had reported the whole affair to the king. Because he had now departed without taking his leave, all the more was it plain that he was a monster. The king set many officials to keep watch over the false tiger — but of that no more.

The fiend went straight back to the cave mouth. When Wukong saw him coming, he laid his snare at once: squeezing his eyes shut, he let the tears fall pattering down like rain, then stamped his feet and beat his breast, wailing to Heaven and earth, sobbing bitterly there in the cave. For the moment the fiend could not tell the difference, and came up and embraced him, saying, "Wife, what is the matter, that you grieve so?"

The Great Sage spun his ghost-tale and shaped his false words, and weeping streams of tears, lamented: "My lord — as the saying goes, 'A man with no wife has no master of his goods; a woman with no husband finds her life come to nothing.' Yesterday you went to court to claim kinship — why did you not come back? This morning Zhu Bajie carried off Sha Monk and snatched away our two children too. I pleaded bitterly, but he would not relent. He said he'd take them to court to meet their grandfather. Half a day now, and no sign of the children — I know not whether they live or die. And you not come home either — how could I bear to give them up? That is why I could not stop my heartbroken weeping."

Hearing this, the fiend flew into a great rage. "Were they truly my children?"

Wukong said, "They were indeed — carried off by Zhu Bajie."

The fiend, raging, leapt about. "It's finished, finished. My children have been dashed to death by him; they cannot be alive now. The only thing left is to fetch those monks and make them pay with their lives to avenge my sons. Wife, weep no more. How do you feel? Let me see to a cure."

Wukong said, "I'm not ill — it's only that I cannot bear to lose the children, and weeping so has left a pain in my heart."

The fiend said, "That's no great matter. Get up — I have here a treasure. Just rub it a little over the painful spot and the pain will stop. But be careful — don't flick it with your thumb; if you flick it with your thumb, it will reveal my true form."

When Wukong heard this, he laughed inwardly: "This vile fiend is honest enough — without any torture he's confessed of his own accord. Once he brings out the treasure, I'll give it a flick and see what manner of fiend he truly is." The fiend led Wukong by the hand deep into the cave's most hidden, sealed recess. Then from his mouth he spat out a treasure, about the size of an egg — a śarīra relic, an exquisite inner elixir. Wukong rejoiced in his heart: "What a fine thing! No telling how many sessions of sitting went into this, how many years of trial in the refining, how many turns of pairing male and female to forge this inner-elixir relic. Today, by great karmic fortune, it has met old Sun." The monkey took it in hand — but where was there any sore spot? He rubbed it about deliberately, and then flicked it once with his finger. The fiend, alarmed, snatched at it with both hands. But that monkey was wonderfully quick; he gulped the treasure down into his belly in one swallow. The fiend clenched his fist and struck. Wukong blocked it with one hand, wiped his face once over, and revealed his true form, crying out: "Fiend, no more of your insolence! Now look hard — do you know who I am?"

Seeing him, the fiend started back in great fright: "Yah! Wife — how is it you've put on this kind of face?"

Wukong cursed, "I'll smash you, you vile fiend! Who's your wife? You don't even know your own ancestor!"

The fiend suddenly began to recollect: "I seem to half-know you."

Wukong said, "I'll not strike you yet — look again."

The fiend said, "Your face does seem familiar, but for the moment I can't call up your name. Who are you, really, and where did you come from? Where have you knocked my wife flat and stowed her, that you come to my home to cheat me of my treasure by deceit? Truly insolent, truly hateful!"

Wukong said, "So you don't know me after all. I am Tang Monk's eldest disciple, Sun Wukong the Pilgrim. I am your old ancestor of five hundred years ago."

The fiend said, "There's no such thing. When I seized Tang Monk, I knew only that he had two disciples, called Zhu Bajie and Sha Monk — whoever spoke of anyone surnamed Sun? You're some monster come from who-knows-where, come here to swindle me."

Wukong said, "I did not travel with those two. My master, because old Sun was forever beating fiends and had killed a great many, and he being a man of mercy and goodness, drove me back — and so I was not on the road with them. It is you who don't know your ancestor's name and surname."

The fiend said, "You're a poor sort of fellow indeed. Driven off by your master as you were, what sort of face have you to come showing yourself before people again?"

Wukong said, "You vile fiend — how should you know that 'Once a man is your teacher for a day, he is your father for life'? That 'between father and son there is no grudge that outlasts a single night'? You harmed my master — how should I not come to save him? Harming him might be one thing — but you also cursed me behind my back and to my face. What do you say to that?"

The fiend said, "When did I ever curse you?"

Wukong said, "Zhu Bajie told me."

The fiend said, "Don't believe him. That Zhu Bajie has a sharp snout and a knack for old-wife gossip — how can you listen to him?"

Wukong said, "Enough of this idle talk. Just consider: today old Sun has come to your home, and you've treated your far-traveled guest poorly. Though you've no wine or feast to offer, you do have a head. Quick — stretch your head over here and let old Sun give it one blow of the rod by way of tea."

When the fiend heard talk of being struck, he laughed aloud: "Sun the Pilgrim, you've miscalculated. Since you mean to fight, you ought not to have followed me in here. I have a hundred and more fiends, big and small; though you were all hands, you'd never beat your way out my gate."

Wukong said, "No nonsense. Never mind a hundred-odd — were there thousands or tens of thousands, I'd only need to mark each one out clear and beat them one by one, no blow wasted, till I'd wipe out your root and leave not a trace."

Hearing this, the fiend hastily passed the order, and the fiends from before the mountain and behind it, the monsters inside the cave and out, were all mustered. Each gripped a weapon, and they packed themselves

three and four layers deep across every door, letting no one through. Seeing it, Wukong's heart filled with joy. With both hands he gripped his rod and shouted: "Change!" — and changed into three heads and six arms. He gave the golden-hooped rod a single flourish and made it three golden-hooped rods. See him wield three rods in six hands, beating his way through — just like a tiger loosed among sheep, a hawk dropped among the hens of the coop! Pitiful, those little fiends: those his rod touched had their heads smashed to powder; those it only grazed bled like running water. Back and forth, lengthwise and across, he went as into a place where no one could stand against him.

Only one old fiend was left. He chased out through the gate and cursed: "You vile ape, what an utter rogue you are! How dare you come to a man's door and bully his household?" Wukong quickly turned his head, beckoned with his hand, and said, "Come on, come on — to beat you down, that's the real achievement!" The fiend raised his precious sword and slashed straight at his head. Wukong drew his iron rod and met him face to face. This battle, upon the mountaintop, half in cloud and half in mist — they fought:

The Great Sage's powers were vast; the fiend's own arts ran high. This one leveled crosswise his rod of raw iron; that one held up aslant his sword of quenched steel. Lazily the sword rose, bright as a glowing dawn-cloud; lightly the rod parried, like a colored cloud adrift. To and fro they guarded their crowns, turning many a time; over and over their whole bodies wheeled round and round. One shifted his features with the wind; the other stood his ground and rocked his frame. That one opened wide his fiery eyes and stretched his ape-long arm; this one flashed bright his golden pupils and bent his tiger-waist. You come, I go, the weapons crossing in war, sword meeting rod, rod parrying sword, neither yielding. The Monkey King's iron staff followed the Three Stratagems; the monster's steel sword kept to the Six Secret Teachings. One, long skilled in his arts, was lord of fiends; the other, lavish in his powers, guarded Tang Monk. The fierce Monkey King grew fiercer still; the heroic monster

grew the more heroic. Heedless of life or death they fought in the air, all for Tang Monk's far-off worship of the Buddha.

The two of them battled some fifty or sixty bouts with neither victor nor vanquished. Wukong rejoiced inwardly: "This vile fiend — that sword of his can actually hold off old Sun's rod. Let old Sun feint an opening and see whether he can spot it." Fine Monkey King! With both hands he raised his rod and assumed the posture of "The Tall Probing Horse." The fiend, not knowing it was a ruse, saw the gap, brandished his sword, and rushed straight in to slash low; whereupon Wukong swiftly shifted to "The Great Centered Level," knocked the sword aside, and then with the move "Stealing Peaches Beneath the Leaves" brought the rod crashing down on the fiend's very crown — and beat him clean away into no shadow, no trace.

Quickly drawing back the rod to look, he saw no sign of the fiend. Wukong was greatly astonished: "Why, my lad — he couldn't even take a beating, and beaten he's vanished! If he were truly beaten dead, there'd at least be some pus and blood — how is there not the least trace of him? He must have fled." Hastily he sprang up into the clouds to look, but on every side there was neither stir nor sound. "These two eyes of old Sun's see everything everywhere at a single sweep — how could he have slipped off so nimbly? Now I see it. The fiend said he half-knew me; he must be no mere mortal monster, but very likely a spirit come down from Heaven."

In a fit of anger the Great Sage could no longer contain himself. Gripping his iron rod, he turned a somersault and leapt straight up to the Southern Gate of Heaven. This so alarmed the deities Pang, Liu, Gou,

and Bi, and Zhang, Tao, Deng, and Xin, and all the rest, that they bent their backs and bowed on either side, daring not to bar his way, and let him pass through the Heaven-gate straight to the foot of the Hall of Universal Brightness. There the Four Grand Preceptors — Zhang, Ge, Xu, and Qiu — asked, "Great Sage, what brings you here?"

Wukong said, "While guarding Tang Monk, I came to the Kingdom of Precious Image, where a fiend had deceived the king's daughter and harmed my master. Old Sun fought it in single combat, but in the midst of the battle the fiend vanished without a trace. I believe it is no mortal monster, but most likely a spirit from Heaven, and I have come to investigate — what fiend-deity has gone missing and slipped away?"

Hearing this, the Preceptors went into the Hall of Divine Mists and reported to the throne. By command an inquiry was made: the Nine Luminaries, the Twelve Branches, the Five Dippers of East, West, South, North, and Center, the host of stars of the Heavenly River, the Five Sacred Peaks and Four Great Rivers — all the gods and saints of Heaven were present in the skies, and not one had dared leave his post. Then they checked, outside the Palace of the Dipper and Ox, the Twenty-Eight Lunar Mansions — and, strange to tell, there were only twenty-seven; the Star of Kui alone was missing. The Preceptors reported back to the throne: "Kui, the Wood-Wolf, has gone down to the mortal world."

The Jade Emperor said, "How long has he been absent from Heaven?"

The Preceptors said, "He has missed four roll-calls. Roll is called once every three days; it has now been thirteen days."

The Jade Emperor said, "Thirteen days in Heaven is thirteen years in the world below." At once he ordered his own bureau to recall him to Heaven.

The twenty-seven mansion-officers received the decree, went out through the Heaven-gate, and each chanted spells to rouse the Star of Kui. Now where had he hidden himself? He was the very god-general whom the Great Sage had beaten and frightened during his great havoc in Heaven; terrified, he had darted into a mountain ravine to skulk from the calamity, and the water-vapor had veiled his fiend-cloud — which is why Wukong had been unable to find him. Hearing his own bureau's officers chant the summoning spells, he at last dared show his head and went up with them to Heaven. The Great Sage barred the Heaven-gate, meaning to strike him, but happily the other stars dissuaded him, and they brought the fiend before the Jade Emperor. From his waist the fiend drew out his golden tablet and, kneeling below the hall, kowtowed and confessed his crime.

The Jade Emperor said, "Kui, the Wood-Wolf — the upper realm holds boundless splendid sights, which you did not stay to enjoy, but stole away to a single quarter of the world below. Why?"

The Kui mansion kowtowed and reported: "Your Majesty, pardon your servant his crime worthy of death. The princess of the Kingdom of Precious Image is no ordinary mortal. She was once a jade maiden who tended the incense in the Hall of Spreading Fragrance. Because she wished to have a secret union with me — and I, fearing to defile the splendid precincts of the Heavenly Palace — she, longing for the mortal world, first descended below and was reborn within the royal palace. I, not failing our earlier tryst, changed into a fiend, claimed a famed mountain for my own, carried her off to my cave-dwelling, and was matched with her as husband and wife for thirteen years. 'Every sip and every peck — none but is fore-ordained.' Now, through the Great Sage's coming here, the matter is accomplished."

Hearing this, the Jade Emperor took back the golden tablet and demoted him to tend the fire for Lord Lao Zi in the Tushita Palace — kept on his stipend but set to labor; should he earn merit, his post would be restored, and should he earn none, his punishment would be the heavier.

When Wukong saw the Jade Emperor deal thus with him, his heart was glad. He made a great bow toward the throne and, turning to the assembled gods, said, "Gentlemen, I've put you to trouble." The Preceptors laughed among themselves: "That monkey is still such a country boor. We've rounded up his fiend-deity for him, and instead of giving thanks for Heaven's grace, he makes a bow and withdraws." The Jade Emperor said, "So long as he gives us no trouble and leaves Heaven in peace, that is our good fortune."

The Great Sage brought down his auspicious light and went straight back to the Wave-Moon Cave on Bowl Mountain. He sought out the princess and recounted to her, just as it had happened, the tale of the star who, longing for the mortal world, had descended — and of the fiend's capture. Just then he heard Bajie and Sha Monk calling loudly from mid-air: "Brother! If there are fiends, leave a few for us to beat!"

Wukong said, "The fiends are utterly wiped out."

Sha Monk said, "Since the fiends are all destroyed, there's nothing left to hinder us — let's bring the princess into the court. Don't open your eyes, brothers — let's use the earth-shrinking art."

The princess heard only a rushing of wind in her ears, and in an instant she was carried straight back into the city. The three of them brought the princess up onto the Hall of Golden Bells. She reverently saluted her royal father and mother, was reunited with her sisters, and all the officials came to pay their respects. Then the princess reported: "It is thanks to the boundless powers of the Reverend Sun that the Yellow-

Robed Fiend was subdued and your handmaid restored to her homeland."

The king asked, "What manner of fiend was Yellow Robe?"

Wukong said, "Your Majesty's son-in-law was the Star of Kui from the upper realm, and your beloved daughter was a jade maiden who tended the incense, who out of longing for the mortal world came down among men. This is no small matter — it was all karma from a former life, and these marriage-ties were destined to be. The fiend was taken when old Sun went up to the Heavenly Palace and reported to the Jade Emperor, who found that he had missed four roll-calls and been thirteen days in the world below — which is thirteen years, for one day in Heaven is a year below — and at once sent his own bureau's stars to recall him to Heaven and demoted him to do penance and earn merit in the Tushita Palace. And so old Sun has restored your beloved daughter."

The king thanked Wukong for his great kindness and bade them, "Go now and see to your master." The three of them went straight down from the hall and, with the officials, came to the audience-chamber, where they carried out the iron cage and loosed the false tiger from its chains. To everyone else he looked a tiger; to Wukong alone he looked a man — for the master had been bound fast by the fiend's sorcery and could not move, though his mind remained clear; only his mouth and eyes were hard to open.

Wukong laughed and said, "Master — you're such a fine monk; how have you got yourself up in this hideous shape? You blamed me for being violent and doing evil, and drove me away. You meant to be wholly bent on goodness — so how have you suddenly worked yourself into a face like this?"

Bajie said, "Brother — save him, save him; don't keep nettling him so."

Wukong said, "You instigated everything — you're his favorite, his fine disciple. If you won't save him, what do you come seeking old Sun for? I told you to begin with: once I'd subdued the fiend and avenged the curse against me, I'd go straight back."

Sha Monk came forward and knelt: "Brother — the ancients said, 'If you won't look at the monk's face, look at the Buddha's.' Since elder brother has come this far, I beg you, save him. If we could have saved him ourselves, we would never have dared come so far to invite you."

Wukong took him by the hand and raised him up: "How could I ever mean in my heart not to save him? Quick — fetch water." Bajie flew like a shooting star to the post-house, fetched the baggage and the horse, took out the purple-gold alms-bowl, filled it half with water, and handed it to Wukong. Wukong took the water in hand, chanted the true words, and spewed a mouthful straight over the tiger's head — and the sorcery withdrew, the tiger-shape dissolved.

The elder showed forth his original body. Steadying his spirit and opening his eyes, he recognized Wukong at last. He grasped him close and said, "Wukong — where have you come from?" Sha Monk, standing in attendance to one side, set forth the whole affair in order: how they had invited Wukong, how he subdued the fiend, saved the princess, dissolved the tiger-spell, and returned to court — all of it told through. Tripitaka thanked him without end: "Worthy disciple — it is thanks to you, thanks to you! On this journey, may we reach the West early and return straight to the Land of the East to report to the Tang Emperor; yours shall be the foremost merit."

Wukong laughed and said, "Say no more, say no more — only don't chant that certain thing, and I'll be deeply moved by your kind regard."

When the king heard these words, he again pressed his thanks upon all four of them. A vegetarian feast was prepared and the Eastern Pavilion thrown open wide. The master and disciples received the royal favor, took their leave of the king, and set out westward. The king, too, led his many officials to see them far on their way. Truly it was:

The sovereign returns to his precious hall and sets
his realm at peace; the monks depart for
Thunderclap to seek the Buddha-Patriarch.

And in the end, what further matters lay ahead, and when they would reach the Western Heaven — that you must hear told in the chapter to come.

Chapter 32: The Spirit of the Day Brings Warning on Flat-Top Mountain

Now that the Tang Monk had recovered Sun Wukong, master and disciples were once more of one heart and one body, and together they pressed on toward the West. Since rescuing the princess in the Kingdom of Precious Elephant, they had been escorted out through the western gate by king and ministers alike. Of the road there is no need to speak in full — hunger met with food and thirst with drink, lodging at night and traveling at dawn. And just then it happened to be the season of the third month of spring. At that time of year:

A light breeze stirs the willows, green as threads of silk,
A scene so fair it begs to be set down in verse.
The season hurries the birds to song, Warmth
coaxes the blossoms open, And fragrance spreads
across the earth. To the courtyard of flowering crab-
apple come paired swallows — Truly the time to
savor spring. Red dust and purple lanes, silken
robes and sounding strings, Plucking the
wildflowers, passing the wine-cup round.

As master and disciples journeyed on, drinking in the sights, a mountain rose up to block their way. Said the Tang Monk, "Disciples, be careful. There is a high mountain ahead, and I fear there may be tigers and wolves lying in wait." Wukong replied, "Master, a man who has left the household life should not speak as a householder does. Don't you recall what the Crow's-Nest Monk said in his *Heart Sutra* — 'The mind without hindrance: being without hindrance, there is no fear, and one is far removed from inverted dreams and delusions'? It comes down only to this: 'Sweep the grime from the mind, wash clean the dust from the ears. He who will not endure the bitterest of bitterness can never become the man above all men.' Don't trouble yourself with worry. As long as old Sun is here, even if the very sky should come crashing down, I can keep you safe — so what are a tiger or a wolf to us?" The Elder reined his horse back and said,

"In that year I took the imperial command and left Chang'an, Mindful only of going west to bow before the Buddha's face. In the land of the Sariras, golden images glow with color; Within the pagoda towers, the jade brow-mark gleams. I seek to the ends of the earth nameless waters, And cross every land to a mountain I never reach. On and on through layered mists and rolling waves — When will this body of mine ever find rest?"

When Wukong heard this, he laughed aloud and said, "If you want your body at rest, where is the difficulty in that? Once the work is accomplished, all ties will be cut and all phenomena will be empty. At that moment, naturally and of itself — won't your body be at rest then?" Hearing this, the Elder could only take joy and forget his cares. He loosened the rein, urged on the white horse, and pressed the jade dragon forward.

Master and disciples climbed up the mountain, and it was steep beyond measure — truly towering and craggy. A fine mountain:

Lofty, soaring ridges; sharp, whittled peaks. Below the winding deep ravines, beside the lonely sheer cliffs. Below the winding deep ravines you hear only the splash and gurgle of a water-python rolling its body over; Beside the lonely sheer cliffs you see only the steep-shouldered tiger lashing its tail as it bursts from the woods. Look up — the summits jut so high they pierce the blue heavens; Turn your eyes — the gorges sink so deep they border the green void. Climbing up, it is like ladders, like footstools; Going down low, it is like moats, like pits. Truly it is a strange and grotesque peak-and-ridge land, Truly a chain of jagged, whittled cliff-walls. On the peak-and-ridge heights, the herb-gatherer dreads to set foot; Before the whittled cliff-walls, the woodcutter can scarcely advance an inch. Wild rams and wild horses dart about like shuttles; Cunning hares and mountain oxen are drawn up as if in battle array. So high it screens the sun and blots out the stars, And here and there one meets monstrous beasts and

gray wolves. The grassy paths are tangled and dim,
hard for a horse to pass — How shall one ever reach
the Thunderclap and behold the Buddha-King?

The Elder reined in his horse and gazed at the mountain. Just where the going was hardest, he saw a woodcutter standing upon a slope of green sedge. And how was he got up? Listen:

On his head a battered old indigo felt hat; On his
body a coat of coarse black wool. The battered old
indigo felt hat, screening mist and shading sun — a
rare sight indeed; The coarse black wool coat, joy
enough to forget all care — a man seldom met with.
In his hand a sharp steel axe, ground bright; His
blade has felled the dry wood, bound tight in a
bundle. Spring colors hang at his eaves, serene
through all four seasons; The idle ease beyond his
body is calm as the three stars of evening. To his old
age he passes content with his lot — What glory or
disgrace has ever touched this mountain?

And that woodcutter:

Was felling rotten brushwood there before the slope, When suddenly he met the Elder coming from the east. He stilled his stroke and set down his axe and came out of the trees, Hurrying his steps up onto the rocky cliff.

In a sharp, loud voice he called out to the Elder: "You there, Elder, journeying west — hold a moment! I have a word to offer you. On this mountain there is a band of poisonous fiends and savage monsters who feed precisely on travelers like yourself, passing east and west." When the Elder heard this, his soul flew from him and his wits scattered; trembling, he could no longer sit steady in his carved saddle. He turned at once and hurriedly called to his disciples, "Did you hear what that woodcutter reports? He says this mountain harbors poisonous fiends and savage monsters! Who dares go and question him about the particulars?" Said Wukong, "Set your mind at ease, Master. Let old Sun go and get the whole story out of him."

What a fine Wukong! He strode out and made straight up the mountain. To the woodcutter he called "Elder Brother," and offered a respectful greeting. The woodcutter returned the courtesy and said, "Elder, what brings you all to this place?" Said Wukong, "I'll not hide it from you, Brother — we are sent from the Land of the East to fetch scriptures from the Western Heaven. The one on the horse is my master, and he's rather faint of heart. Just now you were good enough to warn us of some poisonous fiends and savage monsters, so I've come to ask you straight: how many years has this fiend been at his trade, and how long has this monster held the mountain? Is he an old hand, or a mere fledgling? Be so

kind, Brother, as to tell me honestly, so that I may have the mountain god and the local earth-spirit deliver him up and pack him off."

Hearing this, the woodcutter threw back his head and laughed at the sky: "So you're a mad monk after all!" Said Wukong, "I'm not mad — this is plain honest talk." The woodcutter said, "If it's honest talk, how do you dare speak of having him delivered up and packed off?" Said Wukong, "Since you stand here puffing up his fearsome power and talking such wild nonsense — blocking the road to bring us warning — surely you must be kin to him? If not kin, then a neighbor; if not a neighbor, then a friend." The woodcutter laughed. "You ruffian of a mad monk, you've no sense at all! Here I come out of pure good will, on purpose to warn you so you'll keep your guard up morning and night as you travel — and you turn it round and lay the blame on me! And never mind that I don't even know where the demons came from — suppose I did know: how would you dare have them 'delivered up'? Delivered up to where?"

Said Wukong, "If he's a Heaven-fiend, hand him to the Jade Emperor; if he's an Earth-fiend, hand him to the Earth Bureau. Those of the West belong to the Buddha, those of the East to the Sage; those of the North are handed to the True Warrior, those of the South to the Fire Virtue. If he's a flood-dragon spirit, hand him to the Lord of the Sea; if he's a ghostly haunt, hand him to King Yama. Each has his own quarter and direction. Old Sun is known to folk everywhere — I'll issue a single writ and have him packed off overnight at a run."

The woodcutter let out a cold, mocking laugh. "You ruffian of a mad monk! No doubt you've roamed the country and learned a few tricks of charms and water-spells, fit only to drive off goblins and bind ghosts — but you've never yet run up against monsters as vicious and venomous as these." Said Wukong, "How do you reckon they're so vicious and venomous?" The woodcutter said, "This mountain road runs some six

hundred *li* across, and its name is Flat-Top Mountain. In the mountain is a cave called Lotus Cave. In the cave are two demon chiefs. They have painted likenesses and drawn portraits, meaning to seize monks; they have copied out names and looked up surnames, meaning to eat the Tang Monk. If you'd come from anywhere else it might be well enough — but if you carry so much as the single word 'Tang,' you may give up all thought of getting through, of getting through at all." Said Wukong, "We are precisely from the Tang court." The woodcutter said, "Then he means to eat you, sure enough." Said Wukong, "What luck, what luck! Only I wonder — how does he go about eating us?" The woodcutter said, "How would you like him to eat you?" Said Wukong, "If he eats the head first, that's still some sport; but if he eats the feet first, then it's a wretched business." The woodcutter said, "What do you mean, head first? What do you mean, feet first?" Said Wukong, "You've never gone through it, that's clear. If he eats the head first, one bite and it's off — I'm already dead, and however he fries or stews or boils or simmers me, I'll feel no pain. But if he eats the feet first, gnawing the ankle-bones, chewing the leg-shanks, eating up to the waist-joint while I'm still in too much of a hurry to die — won't I be suffering bit by bit, piece by piece? That's why it's a wretched business." The woodcutter said, "Monk, he hasn't all that much leisure. He simply seizes you, ties you up in his steamer-basket, and steams you whole." Wukong laughed. "Better and better! At least the pain won't be unbearable — only a bit of stifling discomfort to put up with." The woodcutter said, "Monk, don't make light with your tongue. These demons carry five treasures about them, and their magic powers are vast beyond all measure. Even were you the jade pillar that props up the sky, the golden beam that spans the sea — if you meant to see the Tang Monk safely through, you'd still have to faint dead away a time or two." Said Wukong, "Faint how many times?" The woodcutter said, "Three or four times at least." Said Wukong, "No matter, no matter. In a single year we

faint seven or eight hundred times, so three or four are easily come by — we'll faint them off and be done."

What a great Sage — wholly without fear, his whole heart bent only on guarding the Tang Monk! He left the woodcutter behind, strode back down, and came straight to the front of the horse on the mountain slope. "Master," he said, "there's nothing much to it. There may be a little goblin or two, but it's only that the folk hereabouts are timid and let it weigh on their hearts. With me here, what is there to fear? On we go, on we go." Hearing this, the Elder set his heart at ease and followed on. But just then, the woodcutter was nowhere to be seen. Said the Elder, "How is it that the woodcutter who brought us warning has vanished?" Bajie said, "Our luck's run low — we've gone and met a ghost in broad daylight." Said Wukong, "I expect he's ducked into the woods to look for firewood. Let me go take a look."

What a great Sage! He opened wide his fiery eyes and golden pupils and scanned across the whole mountain and over every ridge — but there was no trace of the man. Suddenly he lifted his head and looked up into the clouds, and there he saw it was the Spirit of the Day on guard. At once he leaped upon his cloud to overtake him, cursed him a few times for a "hairy demon," and said, "Why didn't you come and speak your piece plainly, instead of changing yourself like that and putting on a show for old Sun?" In a fluster the Spirit made his bow and said, "Great Sage, I was late in bringing the warning — forgive me, forgive me. These monsters truly have vast powers and many transformations. Only by your own cunning and skill, by the working of your divine wit, can you carefully guard your master. Should you grow even a trifle slack, the road to the Western Heaven you may as well forget." Hearing this, Wukong dismissed the Spirit with a shout, fixed the matter firmly in his heart, pressed down his cloud-head, and came straight back up the mountain.

There he found the Elder with Bajie and Sha Monk clustered round him, pressing forward.

Now he thought to himself in secret: "If I tell my master the Spirit's words exactly as they were, he's no good for it — he'll start crying for certain. And if I don't tell him truly but lead him along blind, then, as the old saying goes, 'Newly into the reed marsh, one knows not its depth.' Should the demons carry him off, won't it be old Sun who has all the worry again? Let me make a little use of Bajie first. I'll send him out ahead to do a round with the monster. If he can beat him, that's one merit to his credit; and if he hasn't the skill and the monster seizes him, it'll be soon enough for old Sun to go and rescue him — and it'll let me show off my talents and make a name." So he reckoned with himself, consulting his own heart. "Only I fear Bajie is lazy and won't stick his neck out, and the master has a soft spot for him too. Let old Sun rein him in a little and bridle him."

What a great Sage! Watch him work a piece of trickery: he rubbed and rubbed at his eyes until he had squeezed out a few tears, then went straight up toward his master. When Bajie saw him coming, he called out at once, "Sha Monk! Set down the load, get out the baggage — let the two of us divide it up." Said Sha Monk, "Second Brother, divide it for what?" Bajie said, "Divide it up! You go back to the Flowing-Sands River and be a monster again, and old Hog will go back to Gao Village to look in on the wife. We'll sell the white horse, buy a coffin, and send the master off to his rest. Everyone scatters — who's still going to the Western Heaven?" The Elder, hearing this from horseback, said, "You blockhead! We're walking along well enough — why are you talking nonsense again?" Bajie said, "It's your son talking nonsense, is it? Don't you see Sun Wukong coming back over there crying? He's a hero who can bore through Heaven and dig into Earth, who fears neither the axe's blow

nor the fire's burn nor the cauldron of boiling oil — and now he's put on a cap of grief and comes blubbering, tears streaming down his face. That mountain must be sheer and steep, the monsters fierce and savage. Soft, feeble folk like us — how are we ever to get through?" The Elder said, "Stop your nonsense for now and let me ask him directly, to see what he says." So he asked, "Wukong, whatever there is to talk over, let's do it face to face — why are you fretting all by yourself? Putting on this weeping-bag face — are you trying to scare me with a paper tiger?"

Wukong said, "Master, just now the one who brought us warning was the Spirit of the Day on guard. He says the demons are fierce and savage, and the going here is hard. Sure enough, the mountain is high and the road is steep, and we cannot go forward — let's come back another day." Hearing this, the Elder was struck with dread and terror, and clutched at Wukong's tiger-skin kilt. "Disciple, of our three stages of road we've already walked a stage and a half — why do you speak of turning back and regret?" Wukong said, "It's not that I'm not giving my whole heart to it. I only fear the demons are many and our strength is slight, our company few and alone. As the saying goes, 'Even a lump of iron — once in the furnace, how many nails can it make?'" The Elder said, "Disciple, you have a point — truly one man alone is hard pressed. The art of war says, 'The few cannot withstand the many.' But here I still have Bajie and Sha Monk, both my disciples. Marshal and command them as you please — let them be your defending generals and helping hands, joining strength and uniting hearts to sweep the mountain paths clean and lead me over. Won't we all then attain the true fruit?"

<!-- context-overlap from prior window --> whole heart to it. I only fear the demons are many and our strength is slight, our company few and alone. As the saying goes, 'Even a lump of iron — once in the furnace, how many nails can it make?'" The Elder said, "Disciple, you have a point

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So all of Wukong's writhing and squirming had been only to coax these few words out of the Elder. He wiped away his tears and said, "Master, if we're to get over this mountain, then Zhu Bajie must agree to two things — only then do we have three parts in ten of getting through. But if he won't heed my words and take a turn in my place, there's not half a part of hope of passing." Bajie said, "Brother, if we're not going, let's just scatter — don't drag me into it!" The Elder said, "Disciple, ask your elder brother what it is he wants you to do." So the idiot duly turned to Wukong and said, "Brother, what is it you want of me?" Said Wukong, "The first task is to watch over the master; the second is to go and scout the mountain." Bajie said, "Watching the master means sitting still, and scouting the mountain means walking. You can't mean to have me sit a while, then walk, then walk a while, then sit again. How could I tend to both at once?" Wukong said, "I'm not telling you to do both together — just take on one and have done." Bajie laughed. "That can be arranged, then. But I don't know what watching the master is like, or what scouting the mountain is like. Explain them both to me first and let me pick the more suitable one." Said Wukong, "As for watching the master: when the master goes to relieve himself, you wait on him; when he wants to walk, you support him; when he wants his vegetarian meal, you go beg the alms. And if he has gone the least bit hungry, you're to be beaten; if his face has gone the least bit sallow, you're to be beaten; if his

frame has grown the least bit thin, you're to be beaten." Bajie took fright. "That's hard, hard, hard! Waiting on him and supporting him is no great matter — I could carry him on my back without ever setting him down and still count it easy. But suppose you send me into the villages to beg alms — on these western roads they won't know I'm a scripture-pilgrim monk. They'll only take me for a half-grown stout hog come out of the hills, and a whole crowd of them with pitchforks and brooms will surround old Hog and knock him down, haul him home and butcher him, salt him down to keep for the New Year — won't that be a plague of an end?" Said Wukong, "Go scout the mountain, then." Bajie said, "And what is scouting the mountain like?" Wukong said, "You go into this mountain and find out how many monsters there are, what mountain it is, what cave it is, so we can get safely past." Bajie said, "That's a small matter — old Hog will go scout the mountain." And the idiot hitched up his robe, leveled his nine-tooth rake, and, bold and bristling, strode straight into the deep mountains, full of swagger as he charged up the high road.

At his side Wukong could not hold back a snickering cold laugh. The Elder scolded him, "You wretched ape! Toward your brothers you've not the least tenderness or pity, but always nurse a jealous heart. You've put on this cunning show — all clever words and a fawning face — to dupe him into going off to scout the mountain, and now you stand here laughing at him." Said Wukong, "I'm not laughing at him — there's flavor in this laugh. You watch: Bajie, going off like this, will certainly not scout the mountain, nor dare to face a monster. There's no telling where he'll go to skulk and hide for a while before he makes up some lie to fool us with." The Elder said, "How can you know that about him?" Wukong said, "I reckon he's just so. If you don't believe it, let me follow him and see, and listen — first, to back up his hand in subduing demons; second, to see whether he has any sincere heart to bow before the Buddha." The

Elder said, "Good, good, good — only don't go playing tricks on him." Wukong promised, and went straight up the mountain slope. There he gave his body a shake and changed himself into a tiny gnat-moth. Truly he became light and deft — only look at him:

Wings thin, he dances on the wind without effort;
Waist tapering, fine and small as a needle.
Threading the cattails, brushing the grass, passing
through flower-shade, Swift as a shooting star, and
swifter still. Eyes bright and clear and gleaming,
Voice and breath faint and all but mute. Of all the
insect kind he is the smallest, Yet slender, graceful,
deep in his cunning. Many an idle day he rests in
the quiet woods — His whole body cannot be seen,
A thousand eyes could not find him out.

With a hum he flew off on his wings, overtook Bajie, and settled at the root of the bristles behind his ear. The idiot only kept trudging along, never dreaming there was someone riding on him. After seven or eight li of road, he flung down his rake, turned his head about, and, glaring back toward the Tang Monk, jabbed his fingers and waved his hands and railed: "You flabby old monk, you pinching Protector of the Horses, you weak-faced Sha Monk — there you all sit at your ease, having tricked old Hog into tramping the roads! We're all fetching scriptures, all hoping to win the true fruit — yet it's me alone they send off to scout some

mountain. Ha! Knowing there are monsters, you skirt round and away — and even that's not the half of it, but you send me to go looking for them! What rotten luck. I'll just find somewhere to sleep, sleep a good one, and go back and give them some muddled answer — just say I scouted the mountain, and that'll settle the account." And so the idiot, on a sudden stroke of cunning, shouldered his rake and walked on, until in a hollow of the mountain he came upon a bend of red grass on a slope. In he burrowed, spread out a flat bed on the ground with his rake, and rolled down to sleep. Stretching his back with a long, satisfied stretch, he said, "Pleasant! Even that Protector of the Horses can't be as easy and free as I am."

All the while, Wukong, clinging at the root of his ear, had heard every single word. He could not help flying up to play him another trick. He gave his body a shake and changed himself into a woodpecker. Only look:

An iron beak, sharp and pointed, glossy red;
Kingfisher plumage, gaudy bright and gleaming. A
pair of steel claws, keen as nails. What of a hungry
belly, when the woods are still? Best he loves the
dry rotten stumps, And most he scorns the bare,
lonely old trees. Round eyes, forked tail, a nimble,
capricious nature, And his rat-a-tat sound is fine to
hear.

This bird was neither large nor small — on a scale it would weigh but two or three ounces. Red-copper beak, black-iron feet: with a flick of his

wings he came swooping down. Bajie had toppled over and was sound asleep when the bird gave him a sharp jab — tchak! — right on the lip.

The idiot scrambled up in fright, bawling, "Monsters! Monsters! Something speared me and got away — my lip hurts something terrible!" He reached up to feel, and blood oozed out. He said, "Confound it — I've had no joyful event, so how have I come to hang out a red banner on my lip?" Looking at his bloody hand and muttering to himself, he peered all about on both sides, but there was no stir of anything. "No monster at all — so what speared me?" Then, lifting his head, he saw a woodpecker flying there in mid-air. The idiot ground his teeth and cursed, "You dead thing! It's bad enough the Protector of the Horses bullies me — now you come to bully me too! I see how it is. He surely doesn't take me for a man at all — he just takes my snout for a length of black rotten dead wood with worms breeding inside, and came hunting worms to eat, and so gave me that one peck. Let me tuck my snout into my breast and sleep." And the idiot rolled over and lay down to sleep again as before. Wukong flew over once more and gave him another peck behind the ear. The idiot scrambled up in alarm: "This dead thing — what a torment you are! This must be his nest, where he lays his eggs and broods his young, and he's afraid I'll take it over — that's why he keeps pestering me. Enough, enough, enough — I won't sleep here." Shouldering his rake, he made straight out of the red grass slope, found the road, and walked on. And wasn't Sun Wukong delighted to bits — the Handsome Monkey King was nearly toppled over with laughter. Said Wukong to himself, "That clod, with both eyes wide open, can't even recognize his own people."

What a great Sage! He gave his body another shake, changed back into a gnat-moth, and lit behind Bajie's ear, never leaving him. The idiot went deeper into the mountains, and after another four or five li, he saw in a

hollow of the hills three squarish slabs of blue-green stone, each as broad as a tabletop. The idiot set down his rake and made a great deep bow to the stones. Wukong laughed to himself in secret: "That idiot! The stones aren't people — they can't talk, can't return a courtesy. What's he bowing to them for? Isn't that a blind business?" But it turned out the idiot was treating the stones as the Tang Monk, Sha Monk, and Wukong — the three of them — and rehearsing before them. He said, "When I get back this time and see the master, if he asks whether there are monsters, I'll say there are monsters. If he asks what mountain it is — if I say it's made of mud, or made of earth, or beaten of tin, or cast of bronze, or steamed of dough, or pasted of paper, or drawn with a brush, they'll all say I'm being an idiot, and talk like that will only prove me more of one. I'll just say it's a stone mountain. If he asks what cave, I'll likewise say a stone cave. If he asks what gate, I'll say it's an iron-leaf gate studded with nails. If he asks how far it is inside, I'll just say there are three layers within. And if he searches it out thoroughly and asks how many nails are on the gate, I'll just say old Hog was in too much of a flurry to count them right. With all this made up neat and ready, I'll go fool that Protector of the Horses." And the idiot, having patched it all together, dragged his rake and set straight back along the road.

How was he to know that Wukong, behind his ear, had heard every bit of it clearly? When Wukong saw him turning back, he beat his two wings, got back ahead of him, resumed his true form, and presented himself to the master. The master said, "Wukong, you've come back — how is it Wuneng is not yet seen returning?" Wukong laughed, "He's over there making up his lies — he'll be along directly." The Elder said, "His two ears cover his eyes — he's a dull, stupid fellow. What lies could he make up? It's you cooking up some spook-tale again to slander him." Said Wukong, "Master, you do nothing but cover for him. This is talk with proof to match." And he told it all in advance — how Bajie had burrowed

into the grass to sleep, been woken by the woodpecker's peck, bowed to the stones, and concocted the whole story of a stone mountain, a stone cave, an iron-leaf gate, and monsters within.

He had scarcely finished when, before long, the idiot came walking up. Still afraid of forgetting his lies, he came with his head down, conning them over under his breath. Wukong gave a shout: "Idiot! What are you reciting there?" Bajie pushed up his ears and looked about: "Have I reached the place already?" He came forward and knelt down. The Elder lifted him up: "Disciple, you've had a hard time of it." Bajie said, "Just so. Of all men, the road-walker and the mountain-climber have the hardest time." The Elder said, "Are there monsters, then?" Bajie said, "There are monsters — a whole heap of monsters!" The Elder said, "And how did they come to send you back?" Bajie said, "They called me Grandfather Hog and Great-Uncle Hog, laid out some bean-curd soup and vegetarian fare and had me eat a good meal, and said they'd line up flags and drums and see us safely over the mountain." Said Wukong, "I expect he fell asleep in the grass and that's a bit of dream-talk." Hearing this, the idiot shrank two inches in fright: "Father! When I was sleeping, how would you know it?" Wukong stepped forward and seized him fast: "Come here and let me question you." The idiot panicked and, trembling all over, said, "Question away and have done — what's all the grabbing and pulling for?" Said Wukong, "What mountain is it?" Bajie said, "A stone mountain." "What cave?" "A stone cave." "What gate?" "An iron-leaf gate studded with nails." "How far inside?" "Three layers within." Wukong said, "You needn't say any more — the second half I remember exactly. But for fear the master won't believe it, let me say it in your stead." Bajie said, "The cheek of you! You never even went — what do you know of any of it, that you'd say it for me?" Wukong laughed. "'And if asked how many nails are on the gate, just say old Hog was in too much of a flurry to count them right.' Isn't that it?" Down went the idiot in a flustered

kneel. Wukong said, "And bowing to the stones as though they were the three of us, asking and answering yourself — isn't that it? And saying besides, 'Once I've got my lies made up neat, I'll go fool that Protector of the Horses' — isn't that it?" The idiot at once fell to knocking his head on the ground: "Brother, when I went to scout the mountain, you didn't go and follow me to listen, did you?"

Wukong railed at him: "You chaff-stuffed blockhead! At so crucial a spot I send you to scout the mountain, and off you go to sleep! If the woodpecker hadn't pecked you awake, you'd be there sleeping still. And the moment you were woken, you cook up a whopping great lie — won't that ruin the whole business? Stick out your ankle, quick — five strokes of the rod to fix it in your memory." Bajie took fright: "That mourning-staff of yours is heavy — a graze of it peels the skin, a brush of it bruises the sinew. Five strokes of it would be the death of me." Wukong said, "You're afraid of being beaten — then why did you tell lies?" Bajie said, "Brother, just this once — I'll never dare again." Wukong said, "One offense gets three strokes." Bajie said, "Father! I couldn't stand half a stroke." Helpless and out of all resource, the idiot clutched the master's sleeve: "Put in a good word for me." The Elder said, "When Wukong said you'd made up lies, I still didn't believe it; but now that it's turned out so, you really do deserve a beating. Yet just now, in crossing this mountain, we're short of hands to send about — Wukong, let him off for the present, and beat him once we're over the mountain." Said Wukong, "The ancients say, 'To go along with one's parents' wishes is called great filial piety.' Since the master says don't beat you, I'll let you off for now. But you go back and scout the mountain again — and if you tell one more lie and bungle the business, I'll not spare you so much as a single stroke."

So the idiot had to scramble up and go again. Watch him charge up the high road — but a suspicious heart breeds phantom devils, and at every

step he fancied it was Wukong transformed, dogging him; so at every thing he saw, he at once suspected it was Wukong. After seven or eight *li*, he saw a tiger come running across the mountain slope, and he wasn't even afraid, but raised his rake and said, "Brother, come to listen for lies again? This time I'm not making any up." Walking on, the mountain wind came on very fierce, and with a *whoosh* it blew down a withered tree that came rolling right up before him. He stamped his feet and beat his breast: "Brother! What's the meaning of this? The moment I say I dare not make up lies, you go and change into some tree to come hit a man?" Going on ahead, he saw a white-necked old crow cawing straight overhead, calling several times running, and he said again, "Brother, shame on you, shame on you! I said I won't make up lies and I won't — what are you forever changing into an old crow for? Have you come to listen?" Now this time, in fact, Wukong had not followed him at all; it was only that the idiot, frightening and bewildering himself, suspected and second-guessed at every turn, so that wherever he went he supposed it was Wukong on his trail. But of the idiot's fright and suspicions, no more for now.

Now to tell of that mountain, which was called Flat-Top Mountain, and that cave, which was called Lotus Cave. In the cave were two demons: one called the Great King Golden Horn, the other called the Great King Silver Horn. Golden Horn was seated in his place, and he said to Silver Horn, "Brother, how long is it since we last scouted the mountain?" Silver Horn said, "It's been half a month." Golden Horn said, "Brother, go today and scout it for me." Silver Horn said, "What's the scouting for today?" Golden Horn said, "You don't know. I've lately heard that the Tang court of the Land of the East has sent an imperial younger brother — the Tang Monk — west to bow before the Buddha. A party of four: Sun Wukong, Zhu Bajie, and Sha Monk, with the horse — five mouths in all. Find out whereabouts they are and catch them for me." Silver Horn said, "If we

want to eat men, there's nowhere we can't grab a few. If these monks have reached this far, let them go on by." Golden Horn said, "You don't understand. In the year I came out from the Heavenly Realm, I often heard people say that the Tang Monk is the Elder Golden Cicada come down to the mortal world — a good man of ten lifetimes' cultivation, his primal yang not once spilt. Whoever eats his flesh will have his years prolonged and live forever." Silver Horn said, "If eating his flesh can prolong our years and make us immortal, then why bother sitting in meditation, or building up merit, or refining the dragon and the tiger, or mating the female and the male? We ought simply to eat him. Let me go and catch him." Golden Horn said, "Brother, you're a bit hasty — don't be in such a hurry. If you go out the door and, never minding good or bad, drag in every monk you meet, suppose it's not the Tang Monk — that wouldn't be right at all. I remember what they look like; I once had their master and disciples painted in likeness and drawn in portrait. Take these with you, and whenever you meet a monk, check them against the portraits and verify." Then he recounted, one by one, which man bore which name. Silver Horn took the portraits and learned the names, then went out of the cave, mustered thirty little fiends, and came up the mountain to patrol.

Now to tell of Bajie, whose luck was out. Just as he was walking along, he ran head-on into the band of demons, who blocked his way and demanded, "What man comes there?" Only then did the idiot lift his head, push up his ears, and see they were monsters — and he panicked, thinking to himself, "If I say I'm a scripture-pilgrim monk, they'll snatch me up." So he said only that he was a traveler passing through. The little fiends reported back, "Great King, it's a passing traveler." Among the thirty little fiends, some knew him and some did not. One at the side, who had been listening closely to the descriptions, said, "Great King, this monk looks like the Zhu Bajie in the picture." He called for the spirit-

portrait to be hung up. When Bajie saw it, he started in great alarm: "No wonder I've felt so out of spirits all this while — it turns out they've carried off a likeness of my very soul!" A little fiend held it up on a spear-point, and Silver Horn pointed with his finger: "This one riding the white horse is the Tang Monk; this hairy-faced one is Sun Wukong —" Bajie heard and said, "City God! It's all the same to me if you leave me out of it — a hog's-head and the three sacrificial beasts, and twenty-four portions of pure offering!" Muttering away under his breath, he kept making vows. The monster went on, "This black tall one is Sha Monk, and this long-snouted, big-eared one is Zhu Bajie." Hearing himself named, the idiot took fright and tucked his snout into his breast to hide it. The monster called, "Monk, stick out your snout!" Bajie said, "I've a congenital ailment — it won't stick out." The monster ordered the little fiends to hook it out with a hook. Frightened, Bajie thrust out his snout and said, "What petty manners! There — isn't this it? If you want to look, just look — what's the hooking for?"

The monster knew it was Bajie, drew his treasure-sword, and came forward to hack. The idiot raised his nine-tooth rake to block it and said, "My boy, no insolence — mind the rake!" The monster laughed, "This monk took his orders halfway through life." Bajie said, "Good son, you've some wit about you. How did you ever know that your old man left the household life only midway?" The monster said, "Since you know how to use that rake, you must have been digging the ground in somebody's garden plot and stolen it away." Bajie said, "My boy, what would you know of this rake of your old man's? It's no common ground-digging rake. This is it:

Giant teeth cast like the claws of a dragon, Dressed in mottled gold to the shape of a tiger. Should it meet a foe, a cold wind scatters down; Should it grapple in combat, fire-flames spring up. It can rid the Tang Monk of obstacle and bar, And on the western road seize the demons and spirits. Swung about, its mist and haze blot out sun and moon; Raised up, its dusky clouds darken the Dipper and stars. It topples Mount Tai, and tigers take fright; It overturns the great sea, and old dragons quail. For all your tricks, you monster, One stroke of this rake leaves nine bloody holes."

Hearing this, the monster would by no means give way. He plied his Seven-Star sword, loosed his full repertoire of strokes, and went at it with Bajie back and forth — fighting on the mountain some twenty rounds without victory falling to either side. Bajie worked himself into a fury and met him at the risk of his life. The monster, seeing him flap his ears, spray sticky slobber, and brandish his rake, roaring and bellowing all the while, was after all a little daunted, and at once turned his head and called up the little fiends to set on all together. Had it been one against one, all might still have been well; but seeing the little fiends all rush in at once, Bajie lost his nerve, could not fend them off, broke ranks, turned tail, and ran. But the ground was uneven, and not having watched

it closely, he was all at once tripped by a tangle of trailing vine and went stumbling head over heels. He picked himself up and was just making off when another little fiend, lying flat on the ground, grabbed him by the heel, and *thump!* — down he went again, a dog gobbling muck. The whole pack caught up and pinned him, seizing his bristle-mane, hauling his ears, dragging his legs, pulling his tail, and lugging and heaving carried him off into the cave. Alas! It was just as the saying goes:

A body's demon-nature is hard to wipe out, And the
myriad disasters that breed are not easily cleared
away.

After all, there is no telling whether Zhu Bajie kept his life or no — so listen to the next chapter for the explanation.

Chapter 33: The False Way Beguiles the True Nature; the Princess Steals the Elixir

Now the demon carried Pigsy into the cave and announced, "Brother, I've caught one and brought him in." The old monster rejoiced. "Bring him here and let me see." The second monster said, "Is this not him?" The old monster replied, "Brother, you've grabbed the wrong one. This monk is good for nothing." At that Pigsy stuck out his snout and spoke up. "Great King, if the monk is good for nothing, then turn him loose and let him go. It's not fitting to mistreat a fellow." But the second monster said, "Brother, don't release him. Useless though he is, he still belongs to the Tang Monk's party — they call him Zhu Bajie. Let's soak him for now in

the clear-water pool out back. Once the bristles have soaked loose from his hide, we'll salt him down, dry him in the sun, and keep him to eat with our wine on a cloudy day." Hearing this, Pigsy groaned, "What rotten luck — I've blundered into a monster who deals in salted pork and cured ham!" The little fiends hauled Pigsy off and flung him into the water. Let us leave him there.

Now Tripitaka sat upon the slope, his ears burning and his eyelid twitching, his whole body ill at ease. He called out, "Wukong, why is it that Wuneng has gone off to scout this mountain and stayed away so long without returning?" Sun Wukong said, "Master, you still don't understand his heart." Tripitaka asked, "What heart has he?" Wukong answered, "Master, if there were a monster on this mountain, he could not advance half a step — he'd surely raise a great commotion and come running back to report to me. Since there's been no such alarm, I reckon the road is quiet and clear, and he has simply gone straight on ahead." Tripitaka said, "But if he has truly gone on, where shall we meet up with him again? This is wild, open mountain country — not like the streets and lanes of some town or market." Wukong said, "Don't fret, Master. Climb back on your horse. That idiot is somewhat lazy; he's bound to be plodding along slowly. Give the horse a touch of the whip and we'll certainly catch him, and all go on together." So indeed Tripitaka mounted, Sandy shouldered the luggage, and Wukong led the way up the mountain.

Meanwhile the old monster called again to the second. "Brother, since you've already caught Pigsy, the Tang Monk is surely near. Go scout the mountain once more, and mind you don't let him slip past." The second monster said, "At once, at once." And see how he hastily mustered fifty little fiends and went up the mountain to patrol. As they marched, they saw auspicious clouds drifting and a haze of good omen circling in the

air. The second monster said, "The Tang Monk is coming." The fiends asked, "Where is the Tang Monk?" The second monster said, "Over a good man's head, auspicious clouds cast their glow; over an evil man's head, black vapors surge to heaven. That Tang Monk was once the Elder Golden Cicada come down into the mortal world — a good man of ten lifetimes' cultivation — and so these auspicious clouds drift about him." But none of the fiends could see them. The second monster pointed with his finger. "Is that not he?" At that moment Tripitaka, upon his horse, gave a sudden shiver. The monster pointed again, and again the monk shivered. Three times in a row he pointed, and three times in a row the monk shivered. Uneasy in heart and spirit, Tripitaka said, "Disciples, why do I keep shivering so?" Sandy said, "Shivering like that is probably an attack of indigestion." Wukong said, "Nonsense. The Master is passing through deep mountains and steep ridges, so naturally he's cautious and starting at shadows. Don't be afraid, don't be afraid — let old Monkey clear the road ahead with my cudgel and steady your nerves."

Good Wukong! He whipped out his cudgel and before the horse spun through several flourishes — three up and four down, five left and six right — running through all the strategies of the Six Secret Teachings and the Three Strategies, and putting forth his full magic powers. The elder, watching from his horse, saw a display the like of which is rare in the whole realm and altogether absent from the world. Wukong cleaved open the road and pressed straight on — and very nearly frightened that monster to death. For the fiend, watching from the mountaintop, lost his soul and his wits, and cried out, "For years I've heard tell of Sun the Pilgrim, and only today do I learn the rumors weren't empty — it's all really true!" The fiends crowded forward. "Great King, why puff up another man's spirit and snuff out your own prestige? Whom are you praising?" The second monster said, "Sun the Pilgrim's magic powers are vast — that Tang Monk is not one he'll let be eaten." The fiends said,

"Great King, if you've no means to take him, let a few of us go report to the eldest king, summon all the soldiers great and small of our cave, deploy them in formation, and join hearts and strength as one — where could he run to then?" The second monster said, "You've never seen that iron cudgel of his — it carries a valor that ten thousand men could not withstand. Our cave has no more than four or five hundred soldiers; how could they endure a single blow of his?" The fiends said, "If that's how it stands and the Tang Monk can't be eaten, then haven't we grabbed Pigsy by mistake? Let's send him back, then." The second monster said, "Caught him we did, and not by mistake; but to send him back would not be wise either. The Tang Monk is to be eaten in the end — it's only that we can't manage it just yet." The fiends asked, "On this reckoning, must we wait several more years?" The second monster said, "It won't take years. As I see it, that Tang Monk can be plotted for only by gentle means, never seized by force. To try to lay hands on him by a show of strength — we'd not get so much as a whiff of him. He can only be moved by kindness; once we've coaxed his heart to chime with mine, then within that kindness we'll lay our scheme, and so we'll have him." The fiends said, "If the Great King has settled on a plan to take him, may we be of use?" The second monster said, "Go back, each of you, to your own stockades — but breathe not a word of this to the eldest king. If he's stirred up, word will surely leak and spoil my scheme. I have a magic of my own and shifting shapes by which I can take him." And the fiends dispersed.

Then alone he leapt down the mountain, and there beside the road shook himself and changed into an aged Daoist priest. And how was he got up? Behold:

A star-crown gleaming bright, hoary crane-white hair all tousled and loose; feathered robe girt with an embroidered sash, cloud-treading shoes trimmed with tawny brown. His spirit clear, his eyes bright as an immortal's, his frame hale, his body light as a man of great age. Speak not of the Azure-Ox Daoist — he outshone even the Plain-Tablet sage. A false image he fashioned, true as the true, a feigned feeling he molded, real as the real.

There by the great road he played a Daoist with a broken leg, his foot all running with blood, groaning and moaning, crying only, "Save me! Save me!"

Now Tripitaka, leaning on the strength of Sun the Great Sage and of Sandy, came joyfully forward. Just as they were traveling on, they heard the cry, "Master, save a man!" Hearing it, Tripitaka said, "Mercy! Mercy! In this lonely wilderness of mountains, with not a village or cottage on any side — who is it that cries out? It must be someone struck down with fright by tigers or leopards, wolves or vipers." The elder reined his fine horse about and called, "Whoever is in distress, come forth!" The monster came crawling out of the brush and knocked his head on the ground before the elder's horse, bang after bang. Seeing from his saddle that here was a Daoist — and one well on in years — Tripitaka could not bear it. He dismounted at once and lifted him up, saying, "Rise, please rise." The monster said, "It hurts, it hurts, it hurts." Letting go his hands

and looking closer, Tripitaka saw blood streaming from the man's foot. Alarmed, he asked, "Sir, where have you come from? And how did you come to injure your honorable foot?" The monster, with crafty words and honeyed speech, with feigned feeling and counterfeit sincerity, replied, "Master, west of this mountain there stands a pure and secluded abbey — I am a Daoist of that abbey." Tripitaka said, "If you do not stay in your own abbey, tending the incense fires and practicing the rites of the scriptures, why are you wandering idly out here?" The fiend said, "The day before yesterday a patron's household in the southern hills invited a company of Daoists to perform a star-quelling rite and scatter blessings, and we came away late — my disciple and I traveling along together. As we reached a deep defile, suddenly a mottled fierce tiger fell upon us and carried my disciple off in its jaws. Trembling, with nowhere to flee, I took a tumble on a slope of jumbled rocks, hurt my leg, and lost the way home. Today, by great heavenly fortune, I have met with you, Master. I beg you, of your boundless mercy, to save my life. If I can but reach the abbey, I would pawn my very body and sell my life to repay so deep a kindness." Hearing him, Tripitaka took it all for truth and said, "Sir, you and I are both men of a single life. I am a monk and you a Daoist; our robes and caps differ, but the principle of cultivation is one and the same. If I did not save you, I'd be no true member of the religious orders. Save you I will — but you cannot walk the road, can you?" The monster said, "I can't so much as stand up. How am I to walk?"

Tripitaka said, "Well then, well then — I can still walk; I'll yield you my horse to ride a stretch, and when we reach your abbey you can return it to me." The monster said, "Master, I am moved by your deep kindness, but my hip and thigh are broken in the fall, and I cannot ride a horse." Tripitaka said, "Quite right." He called to Sandy, "Lash the luggage onto my horse, and you carry him a stretch." Sandy said, "I'll carry him." But the monster hastily turned his head, threw Sandy a glance, and said,

"Master, I've been so frightened by that fierce tiger that the sight of this ill-omened, dark-faced master frightens me all the more — I dare not have him carry me." Tripitaka called, "Wukong, you carry him." Wukong answered briskly, "I'll carry him, I'll carry him." So the fiend fixed upon Wukong, contentedly insisting that he do the carrying, and would say no more. Sandy laughed and said, "What a blind old Daoist! Won't let me carry him — perversely wants the other one. The moment that one's out of the Master's sight, on some three-pointed crag he'll dash your guts clean out of you!"

Hearing this, Wukong laughed under his breath. "You filthy fiend, how dare you come and provoke me? Ask yourself how many years old Monkey has been in the world! These ghostly tales of yours might fool the Tang Monk — but do you think you can fool me too? I know you for a monster of this mountain, and I reckon you mean to eat my master. But my master is no common sort — is he yours to eat? If you would eat him, then at least you'd best hand over more than half the share to old Monkey." When the fiend heard Wukong muttering, he said, "Master, I am the son and grandson of a good family, who became a Daoist. Today, by misfortune, I have met with the peril of tigers and wolves — I am no monster." Wukong said, "If you fear tigers and wolves, why don't you recite the Northern Dipper Scripture?" Tripitaka, just then mounting his horse, heard these words and scolded, "You wretched ape! 'To save one life surpasses building a seven-storied pagoda.' Just carry him and have done — why all this talk of the Northern Dipper Scripture and the Southern Dipper Scripture?" Hearing this, Wukong said, "This rascal is in luck! My master is a kind and charitable man — fair without, yet somewhat thorny within. If I refuse to carry you, he'll blame me. Carry you I shall, but I must lay things straight with you first: if you need to make water or worse, tell me beforehand. If it comes dribbling down my spine, the stink is unbearable, and it'll foul my clothes — and there's no

one to wash them." The monster said, "A man of my age — don't I understand your meaning?" Then Wukong hauled him up, slung him onto his back, and together with the elder and Sandy made for the highroad westward. Over the uneven heights and hollows of the mountain Wukong walked slowly and with care, letting the Tang Monk go on ahead.

They had gone scarcely three or four miles when the Master and Sandy descended into a hollow of the hills, so that Wukong could no longer see them. In his heart he grumbled, "The Master, old as he is, still understands nothing of how things stand. On so long a road, even an empty load feels heavy in the hand — I could fling it down for spite — and yet he sets me to carrying this monster. Never mind that he's a monster; even were he an honest man, at his age he might well be dead already. I'll just dash him to death — why carry him?" Now just as the Great Sage was reckoning to dash him down, the monster knew it, and being skilled in spell-craft, he worked a magic to move mountains and overturn seas. Right there on Wukong's back he made the secret signs and pronounced the true words, and dispatched the whole of Mount Sumeru through the air to come crashing down upon Wukong's head. The Great Sage, startled, tilted his head aside, and the mountain pressed down upon his left shoulder and arm. He laughed and said, "My boy, what spell of heavy-bodies is this you've worked to crush old Monkey? This is nothing to fear — only that a balanced load is easy to bear, and a lopsided one hard to endure." The fiend said, "One mountain won't hold him down." So again he chanted the spell and dispatched Mount Emei through the air to press upon him. Wukong tilted his head aside once more, and it came to rest upon his right shoulder and arm. There he was then, bearing two great mountains, hurrying like a shooting star after the Master. The fiend, watching, was so terrified that his whole body broke out in sweat from head to foot. "He can actually carry mountains!"

Steeling himself again, he pronounced the true words and dispatched Mount Tai through the air to crash straight down upon Wukong's head. The Great Sage's strength went soft and his sinews went numb; meeting this spell of Mount Tai pressing upon his crown, he was so crushed that the Three Corpse-spirits within him shrieked and red blood spurted from his seven orifices.

Fine monster! Having used his magic to crush Wukong, he rode swiftly on the long wind to overtake the Tang Monk, and from amid the clouds reached down a hand to snatch the man off his horse. In a panic Sandy flung down the luggage, whipped out his demon-quelling staff, and met him head-on to block the way. The monster raised a seven-star sword and came on to meet him face to face. It was a fine combat:

The seven-star sword, the demon-quelling staff — ten thousand glints of golden light flashing like lightning. This one, with round eyes fierce as the Black God of Death; that one, with iron face, truly the Curtain-Rolling General. The monster, before the mountain, showed his full power, his whole heart bent on seizing Tripitaka of Tang; this one strove with all his might to guard the true monk, his whole heart resolved to die before he'd let go. The two of them spat clouds and belched fog up to the heavenly palace, tossed earth and raised dust to veil the very Dipper. They fought till the single red sun went pale and lost its light, and the whole wide world of heaven and earth grew dim and reeling. Back and forth they grappled eight or nine rounds — and beyond all expectation, Sandy was defeated.

The monster was exceedingly fierce. Wielding his precious sword, he sent its flourishes whirling down like shooting stars, until he had worn Sandy weak and unable to ward him off. Sandy turned to flee — but the fiend pressed in upon his staff at once, swung out his great hand, seized Sandy and clamped him under his left armpit; with his right hand he

took Tripitaka off the horse, hooked the luggage with his toes, opened his mouth and bit down on the horse's mane; then, working his fetching-magic, he carried the whole lot of them off in a gust of wind into the Lotus-Flower Cave, crying out in a piercing voice, "Brother! I've caught all the monks and brought them here!"

When the old monster heard this, he was overjoyed and said, "Bring them here and let me see." The second monster said, "Are these not they?" The old monster said, "Worthy brother — bah! You've grabbed the wrong ones again!" The second monster said, "You said to catch the Tang Monk." The old monster said, "That's so — this one is indeed the Tang Monk. But you still haven't caught that capable one, Sun the Pilgrim. We must catch him first — only then is it well to eat the Tang Monk. If we haven't caught him, don't lay a hand on his people. That Monkey King's magic powers are vast and his transformations are many; if we ate his master, would he take it lying down? He'd come kicking up a din at our gate, and we could forget all hope of peace and quiet." The second monster laughed. "Brother, you do overmuch to flatter the man! To hear you praise him, he's rare in heaven and altogether absent on earth. As I see it, he's only just so — no great prowess at all." The old monster said, "Have you caught him?" The second monster said, "I've already dispatched three great mountains to crush him beneath them, so that he can't shift an inch. That's how I came to fetch the Tang Monk and Sandy here, horse, luggage and all." Hearing this, the old monster's heart was filled with joy. "Fortune, fortune! With that fellow pinned down, the Tang Monk is at last the meat in our mouths." He called to the little fiends, "Quick, set out wine, and let me pour your Second Great King a cup for his merit." The second monster said, "Brother, don't drink yet. Tell the little ones to fish Pigsy up out of the water and hang him up." So they hung Pigsy in the eastern corridor, Sandy on the west side, and the Tang

Monk in the middle; the white horse they led to the trough, and the luggage they stowed away inside.

The old monster laughed. "Worthy brother, fine work — twice over you've caught three monks. But although Sun the Pilgrim is pinned under the mountains, we still need to contrive some means to bring him here as well, to add to the steamer — only then will it be well." The second monster said, "Elder brother, please be seated. To take Sun the Pilgrim, there's no need for us to stir ourselves — we need only send two little fiends with two of our treasures to pack him up and bring him in." The old monster said, "Which treasures shall we send?" The second monster said, "My purple-gold red gourd and your mutton-fat jade vase." The old monster brought out the treasures and said, "Which two shall we send?" The second monster said, "Send the two — Fine-Spirit and Clever-Bug." He gave them their orders: "You two take these treasures and go straight to the topmost peak of the high mountain. Turn the bottom toward heaven and the mouth toward earth, and call out once, 'Sun the Pilgrim.' If he answers, he's already packed inside. Straightaway paste on the slip that reads 'By order of the Most High Lord Lao, hurry, hurry, as the statute commands' — and in a single hour and a quarter he'll dissolve into pus." The two little fiends knocked their heads in obedience, took up the treasures, and set out to catch Wukong. Let us leave them.

Now the Great Sage, pinned by the monster's magic beneath the roots of the mountains, thought of Tripitaka in his suffering and yearned for the holy monk in his calamity. In a piercing voice he cried, "Master! Think back to when you came to the Mountain of Two Frontiers and peeled away the sealing slip — old Monkey escaped his great affliction and took up the gate of religion. Grateful for the Bodhisattva's bestowal of the holy decree, you and I dwelt together and cultivated together, shared the same karma and the same form, the same seeing and the same knowing. Little

did I think that, coming to this place, we'd meet such a demon-barrier, and I'd be crushed under his dispatched mountains. Pity, oh pity! My death is deserved enough — but it's hard on Sandy and Pigsy, and on the little dragon who turned himself into our horse. This is just the saying: 'A great tree calls down the wind, and the wind shakes the tree; a man strives for high fame, and fame is the death of the man.'" Having sighed, his tears fell like rain.

This soon startled the mountain god, the local earth-spirit, and the host of Guardian deities of the Five Quarters. The Golden-Headed Guardian gathered them and asked, "Whose mountain is this?" The earth-spirit said, "It's ours." "And who is it you've crushed beneath it?" The earth-spirit said, "We don't know who." The Guardian said, "So you don't know, after all. The one crushed here is the Great Sage Equal to Heaven, Sun Wukong the Pilgrim, who five hundred years ago raised his great uproar in the Palace of Heaven. He has now turned to the true fruit and become the Tang Monk's disciple. How could you lend your mountain to a demon to crush him? You're as good as dead. If one day he frees himself and gets out, will he spare you? At the very lightest, the earth-spirit would be charged with manning a relay post and the mountain god with banishment to the army — and we ourselves would draw a grave charge of dereliction." Then the mountain god and earth-spirit grew afraid and said, "We truly didn't know, didn't know. We only heard that demon chant his mountain-moving spell, and so we shifted the mountains over. Who would have guessed it was the Great Sage Sun?" The Guardian said, "Don't be afraid just yet. The statute says: 'He who acts in ignorance does not bear the guilt.' Let me work this out with you — release him, but don't let him fall to beating us." The earth-spirit said, "That'd be unreasonable — release him, and then he beats us?" The Guardian said, "You don't understand. He has an As-You-Will Gold-Banded Cudgel,

exceedingly fierce: whatever it strikes dies, whatever it grazes is wounded; one tap snaps the sinews, one brush flays the skin."

The earth-spirit and mountain god, fear in their hearts, conferred with the Guardians of the Five Quarters, then came to the gate of the triple-peaked mountain and called out, "Great Sage — the mountain god, the earth-spirit, and the Guardians of the Five Quarters come to pay their respects." Good Wukong! Though the tiger grows lean, the hero's heart does not diminish; his bearing was naturally lofty, his voice clear and ringing as he answered, "What do you want with me?" The earth-spirit said, "We report to the Great Sage: we will move the mountains aside and beg the Great Sage to come forth, and ask his pardon for our discourtesy." Wukong said, "Move the mountains, and I won't beat you." Then he barked, "Up and away!" — sharp as an official issuing a command. The deities chanted the true words and the spell, dispatched the mountains each back to its proper place, and set Wukong free. Wukong sprang up, shook off the dirt, tightened his skirts, and drew the cudgel from behind his ear. He called to the mountain god and the earth-spirit, "All of you stick out your ankle-bones — each take two strokes to start, and let old Monkey work off his vexation." The deities were aghast. "Just now the Great Sage promised to pardon our offense — how is it that the moment you're free you've changed your tune and mean to beat us?" Wukong said, "Fine earth-spirit, fine mountain god — you say you don't fear old Monkey, yet you fear a monster?" The earth-spirit said, "That demon's magic powers are vast, his sorcery high and strong; he chants the true words and the spell and presses us into service in his cave, each of us standing duty in turn."

When Wukong heard the words "standing duty," his own heart was shaken. He raised his face to heaven and cried aloud, "O blue Heaven, O blue Heaven! Ever since primal chaos first divided, since heaven opened

and earth was sundered, the Mountain of Flowers and Fruit gave birth to me. I sought out enlightened masters far and wide and was given the secret arts of long life. Think of me — shifting shapes upon the wind, subduing tigers and quelling dragons, raising my great uproar in the Palace of Heaven, styled the Great Sage Equal to Heaven — yet never once did I cow the mountain god and earth-spirit into servitude. And today this lawless demon — how does he dare summon the mountain god and earth-spirit to be his slaves and stand duty in turn? O Heaven! Since you gave birth to old Monkey, why did you give birth to such a creature as this?"

Just as the Great Sage was sighing thus, he saw a rosy glow come blazing toward him out of a hollow in the hills. Wukong said, "Mountain god, earth-spirit — since you stand duty at this cave, what is that thing giving off the light?" The earth-spirit said, "Those are the demons' treasures shining. Likely some fiend has come bearing treasures to subdue you." Wukong said, "Now this will be good sport! Tell me — who has dealings with that demon in the cave?" The earth-spirit said, "What he loves is to refine elixirs and decoct medicines; what he delights in is Complete-Reality Daoists." Wukong said, "No wonder, then, that he changed himself into an old Daoist and tricked my master away. Since that is how it stands — I'll mark you all down for a beating later, and you may go back for now. Let old Monkey catch him himself." And the host of deities all rose into the sky and dispersed.

Then the Great Sage shook himself and changed into the likeness of an old True Man. And how was he got up? Behold:

His hair done up in twin coiled knots, his body clad in a hundred-patch robe; in his hand he tapped fisher-drum and clappers, at his waist hung the Lü Patriarch's cord. Slantwise he lounged beside the great road, waiting on purpose for the little fiends. In a moment the fiends arrived — and the Monkey King slyly laid his trap.

Before long the two little fiends came up the path. Wukong stretched out the gold-banded cudgel, and the fiends, caught off their guard, tripped over it and went sprawling flat. Scrambling to their feet, they finally caught sight of Wukong and clamored, "Insolence! If it weren't that our Great King reveres religious folk, we'd settle accounts with you!" Wukong smiled and said, "Settle what accounts? Daoist meeting Daoist — we're all one family." The fiends said, "Why were you lying here, that you tripped us up?" Wukong said, "When little Daoist lads meet an old Daoist like me, they ought to offer a tumble as a meeting-gift." The fiend said, "Our Great King's meeting-gift runs to a few taels of silver at most — how is it that with you, a tumble serves as the meeting-gift? You must hail from some other district; you're certainly no Daoist of these parts." Wukong said, "Truly I'm not. I come from Mount Penglai." The fiend said, "Mount Penglai is the sea-isle realm of the immortals." Wukong said, "If I'm not an immortal, who is?" At that the fiends turned their anger to delight and pressed forward, saying, "Old immortal, old immortal — we are creatures of fleshly eyes and common mold who could not recognize you; our words gave offense — pardon us, pardon us." Wukong said, "I

don't blame you. As the old saying goes, 'An immortal's body treads not common ground.' How were you to know? Today I've come to your mountain to deliver some worthy soul to become an immortal and attain the Way. Which of you is willing to follow me?" Fine-Spirit said, "Master, I'll follow you." Clever-Bug said, "Master, I'll follow you."

Wukong, knowing well, asked as though he did not. "Where do you two come from?" The fiends said, "We've come from the Lotus-Flower Cave." "And where are you bound?" The fiends said, "By our Great King's command, we're off to catch Sun the Pilgrim." Wukong said, "To catch whom?" The fiends said again, "To catch Sun the Pilgrim." Wukong said, "Would that be the Sun the Pilgrim who follows the Tang Monk to fetch the scriptures?" The fiend said, "The very one — do you know him too?" Wukong said, "That monkey is rather rude. I know him, and I've a grudge against him myself. I'll go catch him along with you — that'll be lending you a hand." The fiend said, "Master, there's no need for your help. Our Second Great King has some sorcery — he's dispatched three great mountains to crush him beneath them so he can't shift a step, and sent us two to fetch treasures to pack him up." Wukong said, "What treasures?" Fine-Spirit said, "Mine is the red gourd; his is the jade vase." Wukong said, "How do you pack someone up with them?" The little fiend said, "We turn the bottom of the treasure toward heaven and the mouth toward earth, and call out to him once. If he answers, he's packed inside; then we paste on a slip reading 'By order of the Most High Lord Lao, hurry, hurry, as the statute commands,' and in a single hour and a quarter he dissolves into pus." Hearing this, Wukong was secretly alarmed. "How fearsome, how fearsome! When the Duty-God on watch brought word that day, he said there were five treasures — these are two of them. I wonder what the other three may be?" Wukong laughed and said, "You two — lend me those treasures to have a look." The little fiends, suspecting nothing, drew the two treasures from their sleeves and

handed them over to Wukong with both hands. Seeing them, Wukong rejoiced in secret. "Splendid things, splendid things! If I just give my tail a flick, I'll go whisking up and away — and count them a gift to old Monkey." But then he thought again, "No, no. To snatch and run would ruin old Monkey's good name. That would be nothing better than daylight robbery." So he handed them back, saying, "You still haven't seen my treasure." The fiend said, "What treasure has the master? Let us common folk have a look — it may ward off calamity."

Good Wukong! He reached down, plucked a hair from his tail, pinched it between his fingers, and called, "Change!" — and it changed into a great purple-gold red gourd a foot and seven inches long. He drew it out from his waist and said, "Behold my gourd!" Clever-Bug took it in hand, turned it over, and said, "Master, this gourd of yours is big and shapely, fine to look at — only it's of no use." Wukong said, "How of no use?" The fiend said, "Each of these two treasures of ours can hold a thousand people." Wukong said, "What's so rare about a thing that packs in people? My gourd packs in the whole of heaven itself." The fiend said, "It can pack in heaven?" Wukong said, "Truly it can." The fiend said, "I fear that's a lie. Pack heaven up and show us — then we'll believe; otherwise we'll never believe you." Wukong said, "If heaven vexes me, in a single month I often pack it up seven or eight times; if it doesn't vex me, half a year may pass and I won't pack it once." Clever-Bug said, "Brother, a treasure that packs up heaven — let's trade for it." Fine-Spirit said, "His packs up heaven; why would he be willing to swap it for ours that only pack up people?" Clever-Bug said, "If he won't, we can throw in the jade vase to boot." Wukong rejoiced in secret. "Gourd for gourd, and the jade vase thrown in besides — one of mine for two of theirs; that suits very well indeed." He stepped forward, took hold of Clever-Bug, and said, "Will you trade if it packs up heaven?" The fiend said, "If it packs up heaven, we'll trade; if I

won't trade, I'm your son." Wukong said, "Well then, well then — I'll pack it up for you two to see."

Good Great Sage! He bowed his head, made the secret signs, chanted a spell, and summoned the Day-Wandering Spirit, the Night-Wandering Spirit, and the Guardians of the Five Quarters. "Go at once and report on my behalf to the Jade Emperor. Say that old Monkey has turned to the true fruit and is guarding the Tang Monk on the road to the Western Heaven to fetch the scriptures; that the way is barred by a high mountain and the master has met with bitter affliction; that I mean to lure the demons into trading away their treasures. With a thousand and ten thousand prostrations, I beg that Heaven be lent to old Monkey to be packed up and shut away for half an hour, to help bring this off. And if there is so much as a single word of refusal, I'll come up to the Hall of Numinous Mists and set sword and spear to work."

The Day-Wandering Spirit went straight in through the Southern Gate of Heaven, descended below the Hall of Numinous Mists, and reported everything to the Jade Emperor. The Jade Emperor said, "This wretched ape-head — his words are without manners. Before, Guanyin came and pleaded that he be released to guard the Tang Monk, and We further dispatched the Guardians of the Five Quarters and the four Duty-Gods to protect him in turn. Now he wants to borrow Heaven and pack it up — can Heaven be packed up?" Just as He was saying it could not be done, out from the ranks stepped the Third Prince Nezha and reported, "Your Majesty, Heaven can be packed up." The Jade Emperor said, "How is Heaven to be packed up?" Nezha said, "From the first division of primal chaos, the light and pure rose to become Heaven, the heavy and turbid settled to become Earth. Heaven is a single mass of pure vapor sustaining the jasper palaces and celestial gates; reasoned out, it truly cannot be packed up. But Sun the Pilgrim is guarding the Tang Monk

westward to fetch the scriptures — this is indeed what is called a karmic blessing high as Mount Tai and a store of goodness deep as the sea — and today we ought to help him bring it off." The Jade Emperor said, "What help would you give?" Nezha said, "I pray a decree be handed down. Let me go to the Northern Gate of Heaven and borrow from the Patriarch Zhenwu his black-eagle banner; if I unfurl it once above the Southern Gate of Heaven, it will shut away sun, moon, and stars together. Face to face one will not see a man; clutch at white and one will not find black — and so we shall dupe the fiends into believing Heaven truly has been packed up, and help Wukong bring it off." Hearing this, the Jade Emperor said, "Let it be as you propose." Receiving the decree, the prince went to the Northern Gate of Heaven, saw the Patriarch Zhenwu, and reported it all. The Patriarch at once placed the banner in the prince's hands.

Quickly a Wandering Spirit descended to the Great Sage's ear and whispered, "Prince Nezha has come to lend his aid." Wukong raised his face and looked — and saw auspicious clouds curling through the sky, and there indeed was the deity. He turned back to the little fiends and said, "Watch closely now — I'm going to pack up heaven." The little fiends said, "If you're going to pack it, then pack it — why keep fiddling and dawdling like passing a stubborn stool?" Wukong said, "I was just now working my spirit and chanting the spell." The little fiends both opened their eyes wide to watch how he would manage it. Then Wukong flung the false gourd up into the air. Now consider — this was a thing made from a single hair; how much could it weigh? Caught by the wind on the mountaintop, it went drifting and tumbling about for a full half-hour before it came back down. And up at the Southern Gate of Heaven, Prince Nezha snapped the black banner open with a great rustle and shut away sun, moon, and stars together. Truly, heaven and earth seemed dyed in ink, the cosmos painted over with indigo. The two little fiends cried

out in alarm, "Just now when we were talking it was barely midday — how is it suddenly dusk?" Wukong said, "Once heaven's packed up, you can't tell the hours apart — why wouldn't it be dusk?" "But why so utterly black?" Wukong said, "Sun, moon, and stars are all packed inside — there's no light left without; how could it not be black?" The little fiends said, "Master, whereabouts are you speaking from?" Wukong said, "Am I not right here before you?" The little fiends reached out and felt for him in the dark, saying, "We only hear you speak — we cannot see your face at all. Master, what kind of place is this?" Wukong fooled them further. "Don't move your feet. This is the shore of the Bohai Sea. If you lose your footing and fall in, you won't reach the bottom for seven or eight days!" The little fiends cried out in alarm, "Stop, stop, stop — let heaven loose again! Now we understand it's packed up and that's quite enough. If you keep at it any longer and we tumble into the sea, we'll never find our way home."

Good Wukong! Seeing that they had taken it all for truth, he chanted the spell again, stirring the prince, who rolled up the banner — and at once bright sunlight stood at high noon. The little fiends laughed with delight. "Marvelous! Marvelous! Such a fine treasure — if we didn't trade for it, we'd truly be no sons fit to keep a household." Then Fine-Spirit handed over the red gourd, Clever-Bug brought out the jade vase, and together they passed both to Wukong; and Wukong handed the false gourd over to the little fiends in exchange. The treasures traded, he then carried the business through to the very end. He plucked a hair from below his navel, blew on it a breath of immortal air, and changed it into a copper coin. He called out, "Little lads, take this coin and go buy a sheet of paper." The little fiends said, "What for?" Wukong said, "I'll write you out a deed of contract. You've traded these two people-packing treasures for one heaven-packing treasure of mine; lest a man's heart prove uneven, and lest in the long years to come there be any going-back-on-it or

inconvenience, we'll write this out and each keep a copy as proof." The little fiends said, "There's neither brush nor ink hereabouts — what deed shall we write? Let's swear an oath to you instead." Wukong said, "How shall we swear?" The little fiends said, "We've swapped our two people-packing treasures for your one heaven-packing treasure; if we go back on it, may we be struck with plague through all four seasons of the year." Wukong laughed and said, "I'll certainly never go back on it either; and if I do, may I likewise be struck with plague through your four seasons."

Having sworn the oath, Wukong gave a leap, flicked his tail, and sprang up before the Southern Gate of Heaven, where he thanked Prince Nezha for the merit of his banner-waving aid. The prince returned to his palace to render his report and sent the banner back to Zhenwu — but of that no more. Wukong stood upright there amid the heavens and looked down at the two little fiends below.

After all, there is no knowing how things were to be settled; so listen to the next chapter told.